Anchor [up to me, my love]

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Anchor [up to me, my love]

by StarryNap

Summary

> “She is standing there, almost bright against the darkness of the house, the fireplace casting slight golden reflections over her skin and hair, just standing there, looking at Catra with an enigma inside her eyes”
>
> The sea can bring many things to the shore. Logs licked by the salt, smooth high rocks hit by the waves of the sea, tiny and beautiful shattered shells, bright sea glass. New, old and lost one. It can wash away memories and pains and also bring with it things one would have never thought about before. The sea can hide many secrets. For Catra, who has been alone for her entire life and it’s convinced she always will, moving to the lonely house next to the sea that her grandmother inherited her it’s almost ring fitted.
>
> Except, when a storm and destiny comes into her life
>
> or
>
> Siren AU! Now Complete! Full PDF available now

Notes

> Hello and welcome to the siren!au
> I’m so SO excited for this little story and I’m glad I was able to publish the first chapter before mermay was over! I hope you enjoy it as much as I’m enjoying writing it “)
>
> WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER: brief mentions of Catra owning a shotgun -she gets rid of it soon after, there are no shot scenes or people hurt by it-. I want to make very clear that I, by no means, approve the owning nor use of weapons on any kind of way, reason or form. I find them deplorable things that should never exist in the first place. The only reason I include it on this chapter was for literary purposes and motive to a certain scene and nothing else. Please know that by no means I wish to be insensitive or disrespectful to anyone. I’ve marked the scene with ***** if you wish to jump over it and no read it.
>
> With nothing else to say, I leave you with the very first chapter of this story. Ready? 3, 2, 1, see you at the end!

See the end of the work for more notes

What the sea tide brings

Chapter I. What the sea tide brings

She doesn’t say anything, so it’s just the two of us

looking at each other,

her fingers damp against my chin.

– Kacen Callender, *Hurricane Child*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x



Catra has been living in the only house on the hill for an entire year and it has been a major pain in the ass every single second of it.

Catra loves it.

It's the only house up there, halfway between the shore and the highest point of the hill, where the stone remains of a long ago crumbled lighthouse are still scattered around. The cliff it's almost absurdly high, with sharp rocks and the harsh hit of the waves against stone in the bottom.

It's an old thing, a two story house with worn out blue painting in the wood curtains and washed out white over the walls after years of rain and salty sea breeze and abandonment. The stairs creak when you step on them, the floors are dull and scratched, the furniture dusted and forgotten. Carta has climbed to the roof to fix the leaks in there in the middle of the rain way too many times already. She has caught a cold almost each time too.

The house it's, by all means, in the middle of fucking nowhere, easily around thirty minutes from the nearest village. It's lonely, nobody comes around here and for Catra it is everyone she could have asked for.

The inheritance mail arrived the day after she turned eighteen, right after she had her only two bags and backpack in the foster home's door with nothing but a stray kitten just rescued held to her chest and tightly grid teeth on her mouth, jumping into the cab and disappearing forever from the personal hell Mrs. Weaver had taken care to make for her for endless years.

If Catra had waited just a little bit more, just a couple of hours, if she had taken just a little longer to throw all the, limited, things she had managed to make her own; if she had stopped just for a second more to scream back at Weaver after so many years of pain, maybe Catra would have received the letter herself and things would have been different.

But then again, if she had waited just a little more, maybe she wouldn't have made it out of that house at all, so she doesn't really regret it.

The letter finds her again five years later, right after the publishing of her first novel and two weeks after being named an outstanding success for a young writer's career in the Etherian's reading market. Who would have known that, after years of scribbling down little over the top and gruesome fantasy stories on the frames of her notebooks would have brought her to this. Maybe it was the description of new twisted and beyond amazing worlds that caught the reader's attention, maybe it was the deep thriller and horror tangled on them too, or the lack of cheesy romance but for an afterthought, barely even there if you knew where to look at difference of all the other fantasy books out there, who knows. What she knows is that Ms. Spinerella, her publisher, loved it, that she had decided to give scrawny and in debt Catra a chance and suddenly her book was everywhere in the local market.

Catra didn't really care for the small local fame. She cared to tell her story, to pour out years of abuse into words, *coping for trauma* as her therapist would say. But the check that came with it wasn't unwanted, it allowed her to pay her bills and buy good food for Melog. It was enough.

The lawyer must have found her like this, from her name plastered in the hardcover of her book in the libraries, because when he managed to contact her, he was almost shaking with excitement.

Turns out Mrs. Weaver had actually contacted him all those years ago when the letter directed to Catra ended in her hands, claiming Catra was a runaway, a troublemaker, probably even dead in some ditch. And not happy with all those lies, she had tried to squeeze her way inside Catra's inheritance as payback for *bothering* on fostering her for eight years. Turns out too, the lawyer wasn't really that stupid and be windrawed the letter from Weaver almost as fast as it arrived.

Catra learns all of this, with her mismatched eyes glued to the yellow page of a testament, scanning the words like a foreign language inside her numb brain.

Catra had a grandmother and she loved her. The lawyer explained it to her, on the tiny table of the kitchen (having a successful book doesn't make you rich, but it allows you to live decently for most of the year), with several old looking documents and envelopes scattered over it. Razz had known the entire time about Catra and where she had ended up after her parents' sudden death, and had made sure to leave her everything she rightfully owned after she passed away. A considerable amount of money both from Razz and from her parents, a couple of boxes with personal objects and a house on the other side of the country.

Catra didn't touch the boxes. They are still tucked in one of the shelves of the house, collecting dust. But she looked through the photographs of the house, an abandoned old building in the middle of an empty cliff above the sea, straight out of your most eldritch nightmares. And then she blinked, eyes misted, mind far away, with her tongue heavy and strange for her own mouth.

"Why didn't she come for me?" asked Catra, still looking at the table, frowning so deep on her face her head hurted. "If she knew where I was, *who* I was with, why did she leave me

there?"

The lawyer sighed, giving her a kind look above the frame of his crooked glasses. He was a funny man, with a hat that almost looked like a mushroom stop on his head and a morse mustache on his face. "She was very old already when it happened. She always had a lot of energy but her memory was failing badly. The government didn't allow her to keep you. When she passed away, you were still too young, they didn't even allow us to tell you about it."

Catra pressed her lips together, fighting back the knot on her throat. "I don't want charities."

The lawyer gives her a gentle smile, leaving a worn out bronze key on the table between them. "It's not a charity Catra. She fought for you, Catra, all the time. And she made sure you had security when she wouldn't be here anymore. I'm sorry we didn't reach you on time, I'll make sure that Ms. Weaver answers for holding back legal information to you" Catra gulps, looking from the rusted key to him, a silent question on her eyes that he understands. "There wasn't a single day of your life where you weren't loved, Catra, even if you didn't know it."

Catra cried the entire night. It was ugly and heartbreaking and unbearable, knowing you had a family. That maybe, just maybe, you weren't as alone as you thought to begin with.

When the morning came, most of her stuff was already halfway in boxes, hanging on the phone with the airlines that would take her away from the unbearable sun of the country and towards the sea, much to the alarm of her publisher when she found out about ten minutes before Catra hopped in the plane.

The coast of Salineas was widely different from the dry plains of the Crimson Waste. Catra had grown up her entire life surrounded by terrains with dry trees, cactuses and heat waves coming out of the asphalt streets and sweat making her clothes stick to her back uncomfortably. She had never really been that fond of it. Salineas was the complete opposite. There were no high buildings or criss-crossed streets or honks of cars and angry drivers. Everything was calm here, almost too much, and if Catra didn't know different, she would have thought the village was abandoned. There were small, local markets everywhere, selling fruits and vegetables and fresh products from local farmers and fishermens. The light of the old looking lanterns illuminated the paths in golden light, with even older looking pretty houses painted in colorful tones in rows besides the port, almost matching the small boats tied up there. There weren't palm trees or golden soft sand or unbearable heat. The beach was cold and harsh, with mild sunny days on its best day and freezing cold winds most of the rest. The sand was harsh, more tiny rock smothered by the water and sea glass than actual sand, and tall and sharp dark rocks and green cliffs at either side you looked at.

It looked like your average seaside haunted village and Catra was in love with it in an instant.

As most days of October, it was pouring down heavily over Salineas, and as most days in Catra's life, her day hadn't gone at all like she thought it was going to be. Being a lonely siren , habitating an even lonelier house and writing as an author for a living was enough to make her the talk of the town but she didn't care for it even on her worst day. It had given her the quietness and space she needed to collect her thoughts and write and somehow also heal a

little some of the shit that had happened in her life. It wasn't a work from one day to the other, she was still snarky and grumpy, but being independent and managing her own life, away from the busy and loud city, and caring for Melog had helped her drop some of the worst habits she used to have, like pushing herself too much until unholy hours of the morning or slashing against herself with anger. It was something she was proud of.

So, living in the middle of nowhere had its perks, but it also had its lows, like for example, when the electric storm whipping the town blew out the fuses and she had no more firewood to avoid dying like a frozen ice cube on the floor of her bedroom. Or, another example, when she had to drive for forty minutes to the village under the increasing rain and another fifteen looking for the only open store that would be kind enough to sell her what she needed *and then* fifty minutes back because she had to stop at the side of the empty road to change a damned blown out tire on the back of her truck.

She had ended up selling her motorcycle for a beat up red pick up, because if all those years of driving in the dunes of the waste had taught her something was that a motorcycle and a too inclined cliff weren't really friends. Now, knees deep in mud, she wonders if it wasn't easier to just roll off the cliff and not go through this shit.

Catra mutters this to herself inside the car, holding the wheel with so much strength her knuckles are pink as she drives over the worst of the rocks. Her hair is soaked, sticking to the back of her neck and down her shoulder and making little frozen drips run down her back, making the thick red jacket she wears useless against the cold. She drives for about five minutes more until the now familiar silhouette of her house comes into view, the paint darkened by the pouring rain. Catra clicks her tongue, parking as close to the house as she can, before turning the engine off. She makes a tight knot on the plastic bag of the logs, holding it close to her chest before opening the door and making a run to the porch.

The door doesn’t have a lock -nobody comes here anyway- so it’s easy for her to push the exterior and inner door open with her hip, stepping inside the house and away from the cold air. She kicks her boots off, leaving wet spots in the floor anyway, water dripping from her hair and pants, soaking the fluffy carpet of the living room as she approaches the fireplace.

“Damn it”

Catra leaves the bag on the floor, peeling off her jacket and socks before tip-toeing quickly upstairs, leaving a trail of wet clothes behind.

“Melog,” calls out Catra softly, entering her bedroom. “Melog, I’m back”

The room is quiet and cold, not really that big but cozy enough to fit a big bed, a closet of white wood and a seat next to the floor to roof windows. That is her favorite part of the entire house. She likes to sit there with her computer on her lap and watch for endless hours through the window and into the open sea as she tries to write and fails. That, and the fact that the bedroom has the biggest bathroom she has ever seen, with enough space to fit a shower *and* a bathtub long enough for Catra and a second person to squeeze inside, if they cuddle. Not like Catra has someone else either.

Catra strips out of her wet bra with a wince, opting for just a loose old bad shirt and baggy pants as she towels her hair dry. There is a small meow beside her and she turns in time to look at Melog crawling from below her blankets, their black fur ruffled in funny places from sleeping on their side the entire day. Catra rolls her eyes at them, throwing the towel unceremoniously towards the dirty clothes basket and leaning to scratch them softly in the back of the ears.

“Comfy much, hm? I spoil you too much, I’m going to get another cat and you’ll see then” Melog purrs at her and then rolls away, mildly annoyed by Catra's empty threat before burying themself inside the pillows again, only their tail visible between the soft fabric.

Catra scoffs, turning around to grab another and walk down again. That's, until she hears them.

There is a shout in the distance followed by another one and then the distinct shout of distraught as the sea splashes for a very different reason than rain. Catra looks through the window with her teeth clenching, narrowing her eyes into the distance until she spots the deeply unwanted presence of a fishing boat close to the shore and three men over it, throwing nets and fishing spears to something definitely fighting for their life below the water.

"These motherfuckers," exclaims Catra under her breath, walking away from the window just so she roam in the side of her closet angrily.

Here is something Catra absolutely hates about this place. Because it's always cold and quiet, many marine species arrive to this side of the sea for the season. She has seen so many fishes and turtles, sometimes when she is lucky, seals, and even one rare golden evening, a whale very far away deep in the ocean. But with them, Catra has also seen the coming of illegal hunters that like to use this side of the shore, too recluses and away from the eagle eye of the marine authorities to stop them.

Catra encountered them for the first time about three week after she arrived it there and she got a good bruise on the side of her forehead after a thrown oar hit her when she shushed them again -or more like when she cursed then to death again-. ***** She remembers it well, because it was at the next day that she found in the basement the very same shotgun she now grabs from behind the dust of the wall and pulls out, marching out of the bedroom and down the stairs with furious resolution.

Now, even with a past or having problems dealing with her anger and her emotions, Catra doesn't like violence, much less guns. But she can and will totally shot at some illegal hunters' balls any time they dare to enter her shore and try to prey the animals there.

Downstairs is freezing for the lack of heat but for the first time in the entire day, Catra thanks that the storm blew the lights off and that she had to drive to unholy hours of the night out and to the house again. She probably wouldn't have heard them at all otherwise.

Catra puts her socks and boots in a rush, tapping a quick message to the chief of the protection marine area -there is no signal anyway, it will probably arrive until the storm passes- and storming out of the house with the same fierceness of someone that gives zero fucks about anything at all and that is probably ten times more dangerous than the lighting

crashing against the sea. She approaches the end of the shore, narrowing her eyes as she focuses on the single boat there and the men over it. It's a expensive thing, much more luxurious than the other ones she has seen. And bigger too, all pristine white and new. Even the men over it have white jackets and pants and boots, all of it it's so *pure* it gives Catra a headache immediately.

As she gets closer, splashing water everywhere while she gets inside the sea, Catra can make off the a logo carved in the wood of the side of the boat. Two bat-like wings with three eyes on the right side in neon green. Catra doesn't recognized but it doesn't matter, they are leaving either they do it for the good way or the bad way.

"Hey!" screams Catra at the top of her lungs, holding the shotgun with both hands and calling the three men's attention immediately. "Hey, you assholes! This is a protected area! You can't hunt here!"

Two of the men are leaning over the side of the boat, gripping with all their strength a couple of nets between their hands. From that very side, the trapped creature slams distraught and scared against the boat, whining and splashing water everywhere. The third men is standing up, holding something silvery and blue between his hands as he turns his attention to Catra.

"And who are you?! The protector of the land?! Do you speak for the fish or something like that?!" he mocks her back, yelling above the sound of the rain. The other two laugh, pulling from the nets and throwing blind ramming slashes with a knife inside of it, making the creature hiss in pain.

Catra bites de inside of her cheeks in anger. Not for the mocking but for the torture. She hates these people. "I'm not repeating myself again! Leave that creature and get the fuck out or you will regret it!"

The man scoffs, throwing his head back in a completely amused laugh before waving a hand condescendingly towards Catra's direction. "Go away, *pretty.* Don't put your nose on things that aren't your fucking business. What are you even goi going to do? Wave that thing you are carrying at us? Women don't even know how to hold that shit"

The bullet crosses the air in a clean arc, brushing the man's hair and barely missing his face at all. Catra moves way too fast, not even bothering in answering, still holding the smokimg gun up and aiming at him with cold determination. The man gasps, eyes wide and face pale as a sheet, looking between the empty air and Catra's hand like a lost puppy trying to understand.

"That- that was just luck," he says, stuttering still. Catra smirks, tightening her grip again.

"Wanna bet, dipshit?" Catra shots again, this time towards the other two, flying over their hands far enough that it doesn't actually hurts them but close euthat they feeling the burn of the lethal bullets brushing their skins.

It's not a mistake. The shoot achieves its goal because the men shout in surprised, throwing themselves back and letting go completely from the nets. The sea creature struggles with the loose nets and then speeds away as fast as they can. Catra can hear them swimming away

with difficulty and towards the sharp rocks on the base of the cliff, closer to the shore she is in, hiding among them.

"God fucking damn it!" shouts one of the men of the nets, bending towards the engine if the boat to bring back the machine to life and go behind them.

"Ah, ah, ah" denies Catra, clicking her tongue against her teeth and shaking her head from side to side, like a disappointed teacher that knows has the high ground above the rest. She points at them with the shotgun, shoulders straight, freezzing them in place. "Don't you dare, fucker"

The first man kicks against the floor, furious, dropping the thing in his hands inside a bucket and baring his teeth to Catra. "You whore! Just wait until we get there!"

He turns to the engine too, only to jump away with an scared yell when Catra shoots at the side of the boat, allowing for the sea water to starts slipping inside of it at alarming speed.

"Crazy bitch!" screams the man, panting in fear as he looks at her. The other two yell, standing up and running in circles like headless chickens, trying and failing to stop the water of getting in. Catra doesn't relent.

"You are in my property doing illegal hunting and I have the right of getting rid of you however I please!" She follows the panicked movements of the men with something closer to mirth, smirking pleasently. "Go on then. Sink. I'll be waiting for you right here."

The men hesitate, looking back at the *obviously* one in charge with urgent expressions. The last one stands up again after failing on his ass for Catra's shot, brushing water from his pants and straightening his jacket again. "Let's go."

One of the man hesitates while the other slips with the water and falls inside the boat with a heavy thud. "But-but the boss said-"

"I know what he said! We'll deal with it later, just go!" the other scatter over the surface of the boat, rushing to turn on the engine and direct it towards the opposite side, speeding away through the increased violent waves. The man in charge turns to Catra one last time before they dissapear between the ocean, pointing at her with one gloved finger and a wild smirk on his face. "I'll see you later, pretty."

Catra doesn't give him the satisfaction to answer, standing in place until she is sure they are completely and absolutely gone. She lowers the gun towards the sand, running a shivering hand over her soaked hair and sighing deeply. Besides her, on the rocks the sea creature has hidden into, a loud and heartbreaking yowl risies above the cry of the wind, snapping Catra's attention back to it.

"Fuck" Catra squints, precariously stepping in the sea rocks as she approaches the place where the whimpering is coming. "Fuck, oh shit, fuck. Hold on there, I'm coming."

Catra lowers the gunshot down and unceremoniously away in the sand, careful of not scaring the already frightened creature and making them hurt themself even more. It's probably going

to get washed away with the tide, that's alright, Catra hates the damn thing anyway. ***** Under the thick darkness of the storm and the scattered light that the lightning brings, she can barely see beyond her own nose. She can, however, hear the desperate splash of the wounded creature against the rocks and the menacing hissing as she gets closer and closer.

The water that crashes here is lower than the rest of the shore and it definitely wouldn't allow the creature to swim freely, much less as scared as they probably are right now. Catra grunts, climbing the rocks and scratching her palms against the rough surfaces. They sounded big when they got out off the nets. If it's a seal she might be able to guide it back to the ocean, but if it is wounded she will have to bring it with her until the storm passes and she can drive to the marine center in the village to get them check out. So far, all the illegal hunters she had encountered hadn't managed to hurt any animal, but these ones were clearly hurting them to get them inside the boat. A wounded animal will definitely not make it in the sea, no with so many predators and the waters violent like this. Catra isn't a marine biologist or a doctor but she has been alone most of her life, and she has learnt a lot on her own, she knows she can do this.

Catra jumps the last of the angular rocks, feet digging into wet sand below her, threatening her to knock her flat in the ground by the pull of the waves. Her shoes and socks and the bottom of her pants are soaked and she regrets deeply not bringing a flashlight with her too. Catra follows the distressed sound blindly, precariously following the shape of the rocks with her hands.

The virulent sky breaks into daylight with the whip of a lightning against the cliff, illuminating the unstable path with silver light. Catra’s breath dies in her throat and then yelps in surprise when the siren in the rocks growls at her loudly and horrifyingly, falling over the harsh sand with a strong hit. Catra crawls above the sand and the cold water, kneeling over the shingles and partially hiding behind the edge of the tallest rocks. Catra’s breath comes in puffs of steam against the icing mist, panting in shock and fear as her brain tries to make sense of the scene in front of her. Another lighting crashes against the sea, washing the shore in light once more.

There is a siren on the shore, struggling against the sharp rocks and seaweed, her back pressed against the harsh surface as she tries to make herself as small and invisible as she can against them. She is tall and pale as a pearl, probably around Catra’s age or a little bit older though she is pretty sure it doesn’t even begin to actually be accurate. There is a kind of wonder about her that makes it impossible for Catra to look away. Her hands are long, way longer than human hands, with deep blue and black sharp nails scratching the minerals of the rocks like butter and delicate iridescent membranes between each of her bone soft fingers that shimmer as crystals against the dim light. Her face is impossible, all sharp teeth and scales and fins instead of ears, colorful like sea glass and at the same time dark like the sea at night, long shouts like both screaming bells and the sweetest of songs leaving her mouth as she warns Catra to stay away, looking with stray golden and dark eyes to every side around her, trying to find a way to escape and leave this new confinement she has found herself into. Catra can't tear her eyes from her, she just can’t, she feels hypnotized under the splendor of her, heart beating so fast it almost blows out of her chest and pours into the salted water at their feet. There is a song inside her head, numbing her limbs and her brain, making Catra feel as if she could dance among stars or just walk into the depth of the oceans if she wanted

her to. Catra blinks at her, her eyes heavy and foggy, traveling from the depth of her eyes and the depths of her shoulders down her strong arms and the length of her legs, kicking angry and frustrated at the wet sand and the low tide in there. Something golden and bright drips down the curve of her calves and into the sea, forming rivulets of ichor in there. Catra follows the direction of the golden ichor, eyes finally finding the deep wound in the inner face of her right calf, wide enough to make Catra's stomach turn into knots.

Catra blinks again, shaking her head hard to the side and clearing the sudden fog in her mind completely, looking again at the siren with a cloudless mind. Like this, under the storm's Light, Catra can see she is covered in bruises, in the side of her temple, the curve of her left shoulder and arms, down her waist and in the soles of her feet, muscles twitching there painfully looking, making the siren sizzle in paint and wince. Besides the obvious cut in her leg, there are smaller ones on her upper arms and back, one of them crossing the arch of her strong eyebrows and down through her cheekbone, turning the skin there purple and golden and blue. She is trembling from head to toe, her eyes wide and obviously scared, she is visibly angry but above all, *she* is terrified *of* Catra. She is also looking way too green, even for the slight blue tones cradling her face and entire skin, her head tilted to the side as her head grows heavy for her strength and the struggle starts to wash away from her body, unconsciousness starting to claim her away.

"Oh crap, oh no," Catra darts out of the rocks, hovering closer to the siren 's legs with one hand held in front of her in a calming manner, the other one balancing herself over the moving sand and the water. The siren seems to shake herself awake slightly, alerted by Catra's change of position. The pushes her head back, baring her teeth completely in a dangerous warning but not moving further, probably too exhausted to do anything else. Catra tries to ignore the rows of fangs, gulping audibly and without making any other movement either.

"I know you are afraid," Catra starts, her voice barely audible beyond the thunder and the rain. "But I'm not like them, I'm not going to hurt you. Just let me help you, alright? I'm *going* to help you, you can't get out of there on your own" the siren looks at her extended hand and back to her face, her fins vibrating with a low hiss. Catra gives her a tiny, stressed but honest smile, exhaling. "I promise."

The siren considers her with half lidded eyes, growling at Catra one more time before her hiss turns into a painful wince and her dark eyes roll back, flopping forward blacked out. Catra meets her halfway, catching her inside her arms with a huff, dropping her pearl and gold arms around her own neck and shoulders so she can support her and not end up falling down the water too. Catra can feel the beating of her heart inside her ribs and chest, her skin slippery with ocean water and salt. Catra rests her palms above her shoulder blades, wincing when the sharp cartilage pricks on her bruised skin slightly. Catra exhales, shaken, eyes watering either with the ocean breeze or fear or confusion, she doesn't even know.

"I'm not going to freak out, I'm not going to freak out," she whispers to herself again and again, cradling the siren 's sharp face on her neck and pressing her hands on her arms so she can lever both above the water. Catra feels something like fragile paper or even the slimmest of crystals come apart on her hands and when she takes one away to look at it, she can see

that the beautiful blue scales on the siren 's skin had started to come off, leaving only purple and blue tones on the skin behind.

"Okay, I'm getting you out of here right now." Catra twists over herself to reach for the seaweed tangled on the siren 's legs, thanking the elasticity all those years of forced gymnastics brought her. She tears apart the slimy green ropes, pushing away pebbles and tiny cutting rocks brought by the, each second now, harsher storm. It's almost right over their heads, if Catra doesn't get them out of there now they will end up in roasted food for the sharks.

Catra brings one knee up, dragging the other too and holding her breath before pushing herself and the siren in her arms upwards in one difficult motion. Catra struggles on her feet a little bit, swinging from side to side slightly and dangerously close to falling several times. Another thunder cracks in the sky, the lightning following it close after, way too close to where they are standing.

Catra turns as best as she can, resting most of the siren 's body over her back and shoulders, holding her arms tight against her neck with her hands. The siren growls softly over Catra's neck but doesn't stir awake, her long legs and feet dragging behind her over the sharp pebbles.

"Please don't bite my head off." Catra grunts, squatting a little so she can lace her arms behind the siren 's trembling knees and lifting her up again, carrying her fully like a wet bag pack of blue scales and honey hair on her back.

Every single muscle in Catra's body screams at her as she makes her way above the rocks and across the shore, walking with wide steps the inclined path that leads back to her house. The siren whimpers against Catra's shoulder, tensing but still slack on Catra's hold as the rain washes mercilessly over them.

Catra climbs the three steps that lead to her porch, kicking open both doors with her boot and rushing inside without bothering to close them again. She is glad she managed to keep her college shape because walking the long staircases with a siren definitely taller than her on her back would have ended very badly otherwise. The house is chilling after Catra forgot to close the windows and actually lit the fireplace when she arrived from the village but she doesn't care about it right now. Catra walks inside her bedroom with wobbly legs, approaching the bed with a heavy sigh as she gently places the wounded siren over the sheets, stretching to grab a bunch of pillows and nestle them around her head and neck. Melog rises from their now moved nest, meowing at Catra with annoyance before jumping slightly in surprise as they take in the new presence beside them.

"Scooch aside a little, Melog," whispers Catra without even noticing it, making sure the siren is well placed on the bed and that she won't roll and fall suddenly. Melog approaches the side of the siren 's face, sniffing softly at her cheek with curiosity. Whatever they smell, salt or maybe even fish, Melog seems to like it because they rub their little nuzzle over her wide forehand twice, jumping down the bed and immediately out of the room right after with a judging look thrown to Catra behind their back.

"This cat-" mutters Catra, looking down at the siren again.

She naked. Like, very much so. Catra's face lights up in bright red, boiling heat on her ears and the top of her nose as she looks at every side of the room, picking up a clean blanket and placing it gently and respectfully over her chest and hips, mindful of not brushing too much over the open slashes there. Then she darts towards the bathroom, pushing open the cabinet of the mirror to grab the first aid kit her friend Scorpia had almost slammed on her hands before she moved away, claiming she would need it someday living in the middle of nothing. Catra notes to remind herself to send Scorpia a basket of cheese or something, later.

Catra steps out if the bathroom and into her small room again, placing the kit on the table at the foot of the bed before scrambling around to lit up the only candles she has inside the chandelier above the bed and roaming inside the bag to gather sterile gloves, disinfectant and gauzes on her hands. The siren has moved on the bed, probably struggling inside her unconsciousness for the pain, burying her head in the soft pillows below her as she pants.

Catra rolls the siren gently on her back again, pushing the blanket slightly to the side, assessing the scattered wounds over her torso and arms with clinical sight and a perpetual blush on her cheeks. She tries to not look too much beyond the open slashes but she is just mesmerizing, with turquoise and aquamarine scales over her shoulders and elbows and down her hands, above the delicate bones of her wrists and the back of her hands and long fingers. Scattered above the crests and valleys of her collarbones and down across the depths of her ribs and abdomen, all the way back up towards her neck and cradling her cheeks and temples like corals over sand. She is also breathing really hard, chest moving up and down with difficulty and if Catra looks just a little bit closer she can see the both soft and hard fluttering of gills on either side of the column of her neck, like silk embraces, struggling to understand that her lungs have to work now instead of them and not the other way around.

She is beautiful, on every part Catra's eyes lands on, she is absolutely beautiful. From the deep fall of her pronounced nose to the expanse of her forehead and the almond shape of her eyes, up to the honey color on her hair falling like rivers over the mattress and the slight point on her colored ears. She is also very pale, way too pale to be good, with golden ichor dripping from the wounds in drops and is that what focus Catra's attention back to the present, rushing to move and grasp the disinfectant solution and gauzes, soaking them in green liquid before pressing them gently, so very gently, over the slashes with clean tweezers.

Catra gets lucky for about three minutes, cleaning the wounds with feather touch until the siren grunts low on her throat with discomfort, her moonlight and lilac eyelids fluttering open just a little, taking in the sight of Catra sitting close and next to her, barely a few inches away from where she is leaning cleaning over her collarbones. Catra holds her breath, eyes wide and completely frozen in place, not daring to move a single muscle as she waits for her to react.

The siren considers her for the smallest of seconds, blinking slowly, and then her entire face shifts, melting from the iridescent deity into something much more of what Catra had seen back in the shore, just as beautiful but lethal and absolutely fucking terrifying. Her bright blue eyes turn on their sockets and drown into abysmal darkness, the black harsh against the paleness of her face. The corners of her mouth split and stretch all the way until they almost reach the start of her ears, wide mouth opening to rows and rows of shark like teeth, flashing

dangerously at Catra when the light of the lightinings whips against the ocean outside and the siren *screeches* at her, a sound so low and vibrating the very glasses of the windows shake. The siren scrambles around the bed and over the white headboard, making a mess of Catra's sheets and absolutely growling at her again before she raises a hand and claws at her, steel nails cutting in the air with knife sharpness towards her face.

Catra gasps and falls off the bed with a heavy thud, feeling the way the points of the siren 's nails catch her skin and scratches the entire side of her face, burning uncomfortably like a cat's claw. She covers her ears with her hands, wincing at the sound when the siren screams at her again, the delicate bones inside her ears vibrating and hurting with the sound so much Catra only wants to curl herself into a ball and cry. Instead, Catra crawls backwards towards the wall behind her until she doesn't have anywhere else to go, watching as the siren stumbles down the bed, knocking the crystal lamp in the side and tripping over her own feet until she crashes against the window, only to find it locked up with a frustrated yell.

Catra huffes against the pain on her cheek, taking in the way the little broken pieces of the lamp dig even more small wounds on the siren 's feet and ankles and, with crescent horror, how she starts slamming herself against the glass again and again.

"Hey," stutters out Catra, extending a hand uselessly in her direction to call her attention. She is getting a bad habit of doing this. "Hey, stop that. Hey! You are going to hurt yourself again, idiot, stop it!"

And oh dear, it does call her attention, because the siren snaps her head towards her again, baring her teeth in rabid rage before throwing herself again at full speed against Catra, mouth opening as wide as it can -which is, mind you, a *lot* as Catra realizes with increased panic-.

"Oh shit, oh shit," Catra shierks, scrambling on the hard floor and out of the way, throwing herself at the end of the bed and barely missing the crash at all.

The siren crashes this time against the wall, growling menacing and defined not happy, scratching the concrete of the wall in deep gashes with her nails. Catra stands, slips and stands again, reaching for the door as the siren charges against her again in all her fours, limbs tangling against themselves as if she wasn't used to them at all. Catra grabs the doorknob with her sweaty hands, swinging it open and bursting outside, into the corridor, and closing the door behind her with a slam, scarcely avoiding hurting the siren 's hand with the frame when she throws herself to the wood, aiming for Catra's back.

Catra leans over the closed door, feeling the way the siren claws and hits against it from the other side with absolute fury, growling and screaming like a bloody banshee behind the wall. Catra twists, just enough so she can turn the key of the bedroom and lock it out, stumbling back until she is leaning over the railing of the staircase, panting as if she just had run a whole marathon under the sun. Somewhere deep I side her she feels bad of locking the siren inside the bedroom, but after another series of screams that sound like steel nails scratching over metal or someone getting murdered, it just melts into annoyance, heart thundering on her chest wildly with shock and fear.

"Would you please calm the fuck down?! You are being a major pain in the ass!"

The siren just howls at her again, banging in the door before scattering inside the room with new found anger. Catra can hear her stumbling over the floor and her stomach turns, thinking in the way her legs were trembling with effort and her wounds pulsed at being torn open again for the fear outburst.

Catra sighs, running a hand through her hair, slightly brushing over the scratches on her skin with a hiss. She slumps against the railing, trying to recover her breath as she listens to the siren move around in distress around the room, occasionally banging in the door and the window. Catra looks down at her hands and realizes she is trembling too, all of her, and that her clothes are still soaked to the bone after her adventure on the beach. Catra scratches the side of her forehead, conflicted, opting to walk down the stairs and towards the first floor as quietly as she can so both the siren and her can calm down.

The house is drowned in darkness, the tiny candles she had lit before going to town long gone out after the storm started crashing against the shore with newfound force, the salty and cold breeze entering through the half open windows. There are drops of golden blood smudged on the floor where Catra carried the siren to her bedroom and the doors slam against the frames where she didn't lock them behind them. Catra closes the open frames around the first floor and strips out of her wet clothes, *again,* entering the downstairs bathroom. Melog jumps from a casket of clean clothes next to the door, dragging a white cotton shirt behind them as they follow Catra inside. Catra turns on the light of her phone, placing it face down in the sink so she can finish peeling off her pants and boxers, leaning to the casket to grab a fresh set.

"Thanks buddy," says Catra, taking the shirt from Melog's back and scratching their ears as she slips inside it. Catra squints to the barely illuminated mirror, wrinkling her nose at the sight of the three angry red scratches in her face that tickle her skin with a slightly uncomfortable burn. "Well- scratched by a pretty siren . Every lesbian's dream, am I right?"

Catra giggles nervously at her own reflection, looking down to see Melog watching back at her with an unimpressed look on their face.

"What?" she questions them, her voice hoarse and scratchy. It's very clear that the weight of the last hour of her life hasn't settled entirely and Melog knows it because they huff at her as much as a cat can do. Catra rests her hand at each side of her hips, narrowing her eyes at them. "Don't give me that look, Melog. What else was I supposed to do? Leave her there? She is wounded. Those fishermen may still be out there too, I mean, it was obvious what I had to do."

It 's not obvious. Nothing about this is obvious at all.

Catra went out ready to kick the ass of some fucking illegal hunters and look after a wounded seal or otter or anything else and came back with a siren with teeth like a shark and blue and golden scales and the scream of a freaking bloodthirst ghost, and Catra's heart was suddenly in shameless inside her ribcage.

Above their heads, on the second floor, the sound of furniture being moved around and things breaking rises up again, one more heavy thud and the unmistakable sound of a mirror breaking before falling into complete silence again.

"That's the bathroom, isn't it?" Catra murmurs to Melog, looking at the roof, sighing deeply. "Alright, round two."

Melog rubs their head on the back of Catra's hand, jumping down the sink and walking with silent steps to the stairs. Catra follows them close behind, trying to not step over the noiser spots until she reaches the end, her bare feet muted over the carpet that leads to her door. Melog is already sitting there, looking from the tall wood to Catra and back, scratching once with their paw over it to motion Catra in action.

Catra grabs the key and turns it to the opposite side, twisting the doorknob the quietest as she can muster, opening the door just a jar and peeking inside with her heart fluttering like a hummingbird.

The bedroom looks as if it had hosted a tornado inside. The sheets are merely shreds hanging from the headboard and the desk. The bedside lamps are smashed in the ground just as the blue curtains and even part of the closet, one door hanging sadly from its hinges. The chandelier has miraculously survived, some candles still lid and illuminating the room in gentle light. The siren it's not there and dread pools in Catra's belly when she looks at the windows, afraid that she had somehow broken them and thrown herself from there and two stories down to the ground. But besides some deeply concerning scratches in the glass, the windows are still intact.

A sound comes from the left side, in the way of the bathroom, quiet but just loud enough for Catra to hear it. She slips inside the room, hesitating before letting the door swing wide open, a free way out for any of them if any one wants it. The bathroom door is scratched and half opened**,** just enough that Catra can catch the bright blue of two eyes looking at her tensely from inside.

Catra walks to the bathroom, stopping just to grab an old emergency lantern from beside the vanity -also torn around-, the warm like from its light bulb casting funny shadows over the floor. Catra pushes the door open, stepping inside with her heart in her throat.

She is sitting on the furthest corner inside the huge tub, as far as the mosaic wall allows her, her feet slipping over the ceramic, both arms extended to the sides to try and balance herself. Her hair fails in a wet golden curtain over her face, making only her, now, bright blue eyes and dangerous scowl to be seen from between the honey strands. She looks more human now, if that is even possible, and there is a sad trail of iridescent scales on the floor and the tub that might just explain why.

"Hey" whispers Catra's, stepping over the fluffy carpet next to the sink without closing the door. The siren bares her teeth again, hissing low on her throat, but she doesn't lash out against Catra again. Catra hums in relief, approaching the tub hesitantly just to step back again when the siren sizzles, every nerve in her body in alert. "It's alright, it's alright. I'm not going to touch you, I promise"

Catra sits in the single seat inside the bathroom, some good feet away from the tub and closer to the sink and the small window over it. She rubs her hands over her numb legs, trying to heat herself as the tension inside the reduced space keeps growing, Catra sitting basically on

the floor and the siren born from a very folklore still in the tub, cradled in the ceramic like a scared spider.

"Look, I'm really sorry I locked you here. You just are really freaking beaten up and you also honestly scared the shit out of me. I won't do it again, okay?" Catra worries her bottom lip between her teeth, shoulders bend forward. "Listen, the door is open. The downstairs door is open too, you can leave whenever you want, I'm not holding you here against your will in any way."

Catra motions towards the open door, careful of not making any gesture that might trigger her again. The siren blinks, slowly, frowning at Catra. She makes Catra nervous, way more nervous than she has ever been in her entire life. And it has nothing to do with the fact that she isn't human or that her jaw and her skull didn't seem to be attached a few minutes ago. It's something else, something completely different about her that makes Catra stumble with her own words -something that she never, ever if her life she has done- and blush.

"I just- I just wanted you to check on your wounds first, you are really scratched up and there is a storm outside" Catra points at the window then just in time for another thunder to make the walls of the entire house vibrate with its force. Catra winces, hunching over herself even more. She doesn't like storms.

As the siren keeps looking at her in deep silence, another thought crosses Catra's mind and she almost slaps herself in the forehead in frustration. "I don't even know if you can understand me. Can you understand me?"

Silence.

Until the beautiful siren moves over the white ceramic, letting herself fall a little bit more comfortable inside the tub. The siren locks eyes with Catra, not emitting any sound until she nods, so infinitesimally small that if Catra had been anything else but completely enthralled with her she would have missed it. "Alright, I'm taking it as a default yes"

The siren huffs at her, irritated, slipping deeper inside the bathtub with a scoff. Her skin looks painfully dry and the tips of her long, elegant fingers -now void of the scaled edges and pointy nails- are slightly blue in the tips, the same tone as her chapped lips and the underside of her eyes. She is a sea creature, Catra remembers with a stab of guilt. Catra doesn't know what the hell is going on but she knows she must be suffering a lot so far away from the open sea.

"I have an idea just let me-" Catra trails off, reaching for the bronze pipeline at the feet of the tub. The siren slashes at her, very quickly, not enough to scratch Catra's face off but yes to make a clear warning."No touch, I promise okay? I'm just trying to open this thing." The siren frowns, looking deeply inside Catra's eyes. "I promise"

A few seconds go by but the siren backs up on th the end, pressing her back to the cold surface of the tub, keeping an eye on Catra the entire time. "Okay, there we go"

Fresh cold water starts to pour out from the pipes, filling the tub quickly. The siren gasps -a sound small and harmonious like a bell that runs goosebumps down Catra's spine- and sinks

inside the water.

"Better?" Catra asks with a relieved smile. The siren looks at the water just to start scowling at it and splash it out of the tub with a scoff. Catra's smile dissolves into a confused pout, closing the pipeline. "What? It's water"

The siren huffs again, this time to her, wrinkling her nose. Catra grunts, falling back into the small chair. Honestly, after everything that is happening, she doesn't have the mood or energy to be dealing with the pickiness of salt water fish-

Catra stops old in that thought, eyebrows rising with understanding. She stands up again, startling the siren , though Catra doesn't pay mind to it this time. She opens the cabinet behind the mirror, knocking into bottles and towels until she finds what she is looking for, a goodbye gift from Perfuma that has remained stored there for months, still sealed and perfectly usable. Catra grabs the "meditative sea salts for baths" between her hands, throwing a nervous look between the waiting siren and the bottle.

"How much- alright fuck it" Catra unscrews the bottle and empties the entire thing inside the tub, wrinkling her nose at the immediate sizzling sound of the salt against the water. The siren jumps back in surprise but it doesn't last long because her eyes widen as she takes the newly salted water between her hands, letting out a sound much like a sweet purr and sinking inside of it until the only parts of her body above the surface are her eyes and the top of her head.

Catra exhales, letting herself fall unceremoniously over the tilted floor, face between her hands. She is aware that the siren 's eyes are following her every move but she doesn't say anything, silence allow Catra to breathe deep in and out exactly as her therapist taught until she feels sane enough to rise her head again, locking her eyes with the siren 's bright ones.

"Let's make a truce, alright?" the siren frowns but otherwise remains silent. Listening. Catra takes it as a good sign. "Let me treat your wounds. You are seriously going to get eaten by something if you try to- to *leave* like this. Let me patch you up and then you can do and go wherever you want to. Sounds good?"

The siren wrinkles her nose, small bubbles popping in the surface when she sighs underwater. Catra is half waiting for her to throw her something or growl at her, but the siren moves slowly, taking one of her arms out of the water and extending it towards Catra, resting precariously over the edge of the tub with an impatient look.

Catra blinks at the pale limb and then back to the siren, shaking herself out of her stupor harshly. Catra stands up in a rush with an awkward squeak, slipping over the wet floor before scrambling for the knocked out first aid items in the floor and crawling back next to the tub.

The skin in the siren 's arm is scattered in small cuts, no longer bleeding, and light bruises. They aren't deep but the skin where her scales used to be is irritated and red, some of the pearlescent ones still falling off on their own. Catra tries not to wince but she can't avoid it, gulping loudly before taking the gauze and dabbing it over the cuts quickly.

The arms are relatively easy, Catra goes through the wounds fast, checking up no major damage, and going through one and then the other arm in a blink. She doesn't feel like trying her luck.

"Let me see your back," says Catra, bringing the lantern closer to see better. When she turns back, the siren is looking at her with an eyebrow raised, judging. Catra frowns and then rolls her eyes, clicking her tongue against her teeth with annoyance. " *Please"*

The siren scoffs but compiles, swimming close to the edge, wrapping both of her arms over it and hissing her face between the space between her eyebrows. Her hair fails in damp curtains over her shoulder and inside the water, floating in swirls above the salt. Catra holds her breath, bringing the chair close and leaning over her back. The gashes there a deeper, angry red over her skin but not bleeding anymore. A wave of anger washes over Catra, her mind spiraling towards the memories of the hunters as she cleans the open skin and places with trembling fingers surgical tape strips over them, keeping them closed. She can feel her own head hurting all the way to her teeth, unclenching her jaw when she realizes she has been biting the inside of her cheek the entire time.

The siren - *siren* , the thought, appears suddenly in Catra's mind, bringing small tears at the corners of her eyes because *what the hell*- is calm. Her fast breathing has lowered down but her shoulders are still shivering, with pain or shock or cold, Catra doesn't know. Her hair has slipped back a little, showing the side of her face, greenish and clamy. Her eyes are shut close tightly, eyebrows knitted together with her hands closed in fists over her elbows. There is a wound on the side of her face too, like the lighting parting the night sea outside the house. It's not bad, but it will definitely scar.

Catra reaches for her, hesitating. She shakes her head to the side, not getting closer but keeping her hand hovering in the space between them. "You have a wound, in your face, too" she starts, her voice too loud, even as a whisper, inside the heavy silence. "I need to touch your face, is that okay?"

The siren doesn't turn to look at her but her shoulders drop, giving Catra one single nod. Consent given, Catra moves further, taking the wet strands of hair stuck to her face and gently placing them behind her spiked ear, leaning again to clean over the wound. On these ones, she can only clean and place some healing ointment over them, the pads of her fingers touching the siren 's skin so softly it's almost a caress. Catra doesn't know how good itw going to act with all the salt water around it, but something is something.

Catra falls back into her ankles, dropping the used gauzes into the bin nearby, worrying her lip between her canines. She has gone through every wound except the bigger one, on her leg. The siren doesn't react at the silence or the lack of touch, still almost petrified over the edge of the tub, drops of water dripping in the fluffy carpet below.

"Hey," Catra calls softly for her. "I need to check your leg. I know there is a big one there, it must be hurting a lot."

The siren stays still for a few seconds, moving just enough so she can lock her eyes with Catra's, just a few inches away. She has such incredible bright blue eyes, Catra has never seen eyes like those before. Catra has never seen anyone as her before. She doesn't even know

what she is doing, she just knows that she feels weirdly and suddenly protective of this folklore come to life and that she needs to take care of her because she needs her.

"Come one, don't be stubborn" Catra gulps, voice hoarse and squeaky as she smiles, very tiny. "It's the last one, then you can go home."

The last comes shaken, to Catra's surprise, but reassuring and it calls the siren 's attention because her eyes sparkle with recognition, moving away from the edge until her back touches the opposite wall, taking her leg out of the water and resting it where her arms used to be. Catra gulps, feeling the way her ears and nose colors immediately in splotches of red. She kneels in front of the tub, rubbing her sweaty hands over her pants to stabilize them and taking the siren 's ankle between them, moving it slightly to the side so she can catch a better look to the wound. Just as the other, it's not bleeding anymore, and thanks to the water most of the smudges of golden ichor, sand and dirt are already washed away, allowing Catra to inspect clearly under the precarious light.

It's a clean cut, probably done by one of the knives of the hunters when the siren was fighting to get away from their nets. It will heal relatively quickly but it will scar too, and the skin surrounding it will be very sensitive for a while. Catra washes the wound with the disinfectant solution several times, making sure it's well clean before putting on the ointment and the strips over it, pulling the skin as quickly as she can muster and sticking it together. The siren hisses, shooting her arms to the sides to grab the edges of the tub and hold herself from them, face paling even further. Catra hums, low on her throat, absently reassuring her while she covers the wound with a sterile patch. Catra hovers over her just for a little longer, making sure the wound is safely patched and then letting go of her leg completely. So close, her skin smells, unsurprisingly, like salt but also as something much like rosemary and warm water, slightly rough in the soles of her feet and her ankles when Catra takes her hands back.

She finishes and moves away, putting the first aid things in the first place she looks at, just keeping them away. She sits over her ankles, lacing her fingers below her bent knees, just looking at the siren , who hasn't stopped following her with her eyes the entire time. Catra's heart is thundering inside her ears like water but she exhales, trying to keep her cool and her head above the surface of everything, shrugging with one shoulder as she points with her chin at the bandages.

"Perks of being alone your entire life, I guess. You learn plenty about taking care of yourself." The siren doesn't move, nor makes any other signs, looking at Catra with something heavy and undescribable. The corners of Catra's mouth drop and she sighs, standing up in wobbly feet, long asleep after being sat over them for so long.

Catra shifts on her feet, unsure even where to look. This is new to her, not knowing what to say or how to act, being so openly unsure. Somehow she feels the most vulnerable she has ever felt, here, in this bathroom on bare feet, standing in front of the most beautiful and terrifying person she has ever seen.

"Take as much time as you need," Catra hears herself saying, in the softest tone of voice she has ever used, ever. *Where is that even coming from?*

Catra backtracks towards the door, not even looking back, her shoulder bumping against the frame. The siren brings back her leg and sinks in the water completely again, watching Catra fumble and trip with herself with something that is almost mirth inside her eyes. Catra trips with the blankets on the floor, almost falling to the ground. On the tub, tiny bubbles pop into the surface and Catra is almost sure the siren is laughing *at* her.

This is ridiculous

"Fuck. I just- I'll be downstairs" Catra pouts - *again, what the hell*- and runs a hand over her already frizzy hair, suddenly very aware that she probably looks like puked by a tornado.

The bright eyes of the siren shimmer and she blinks, slowly, once, submerging completely under the water at the same time Catra storms out through the open door and down the stairs like a cat scared by thunder.



Catra grunts, making herself a tight ball in front of the fireplace, her knees pressed against her chest and her fingers holding the arcs of her feet. Her back hurts from being bent like this for so long but she doesn't mind it, watching the blue and green flames lick over the salt washed logs inside the chimney, it's smoke swirling and rising up the brick column and to the outside.

It's late, very late, two in the morning the last time Catra checked on her phone before the battery ran out and that had been a while back. Her eyes are tired from looking at the screen or the flames or for being awake at such an hour of the night -not her first rodeo at all, but definitely way more exhausting than sitting writing for hours to end.

Outside, the storm and the thunder have relented almost completely, but the breeze coming from the sea is freezing cold, chilling the entire house to its very bones. Not even like this, so close to the fire, helps Catra melt away the chill inside her body right now. She feels bad, leaving the siren upstairs alone, and she feels especially bad because she doesn't know what to do about this but this on the hard floor in her living room and wait for the time to wash away. Melog has come to cuddle next to her, their little face buried between the fur of the carpet and Catra's feet, purring in their sleep. At least someone is sleeping in the house.

The old house that never gives the right hour placed above the fireplace ticks, rhythmic, synchronized with Catra's hummingbird heartbeat. The woods creak, swollen by the rain. The house has been dead silent for hours to end, maybe that's why she doesn't hear her walk down the stairs. Melog snaps their head up suddenly, a low purr rising and calling Catra's attention, who turns her head around to look at the end of the stairs without moving any further.

She is standing there, almost bright against the darkness of the house, the fireplace casting slight golden reflections over her skin and hair, just standing there, looking at Catra with an enigma inside her eyes.

"Are you going home now?" asks Catra, in a thread of a voice. She is annoyed with herself, for how pathetically sad she sounds. "It's alright, the door is locked, as I promised you. You

can go."

Stay , whispers something inside Catra's heart.

Shut up, barks her mind back.

"Go," her mouth says instead, resting her cheek against her knees.

The insides of her body are at war with themselves, entropy inside her soul. Catra must have gone insane already, the sea tide and the loneliness creating vivid dreams in her mind, ghosts of seafoam and myths of flesh and bone that are walking barefoot around her house. That's the only way she has to explain it because none of this can be real otherwise, it just can't. These things don't happen to Catra, orphan and alone, angry, at war with herself all the time. People come into her life and then they leave, they leave her behind. These kind of things only happen inside her books, in fantastic worlds of magic and fighting and even then tragedy always tears it all apart. That's how things go, in Catra's life.

"I told you it’s fine. Just go"

The siren exhales, her breath cold against the warmth of the room, creating clouds of steam. She looks back, towards the slightly ajair door Catra had left unlocked and open and then back to Catra. Her expression has changed, intense, charged with a language Catra can't understand, her body swinging slightly from side to side, her mouth twitching, like she had just realized something she hadn't seen before. Catra frowns, jolted out of her numbness by the uneasiness that pours out of her body, her pupils dilating and eyes narrowing, fear drilling in her spine.

"What 's wrong?" Catra asks, rolling out of her tongue in automatic.

The siren moves, just a little to the side coaxed by Catra's questions, truly showing how badly she is trembling. It's worse than when Catra brought her in and vastly different from how Catra had last seen her inside the bathroom. This time, the shiver travels down her arms and legs and spine, making her muscles twitch involuntarily and her balance to swing on its axis. Her skin is basically translucent now, the beautiful blues and iridescents gone alongside the intricate swirls of her scales. Where there were pearls and corals and sea life carved on her skin now there are only red patches, smooth and wrong. Wrong.

Catra untangles from herself, scrambling to her feet, her stomach turning into knots. She doesn't understand but she knows something bad is going on, or maybe happened already. The siren perks up at Catra, still looking like she is about to pass out at any moment. Still, she turns around and reaches for the door in wide, unsure steps, looking behind her several times as if making sure that Catra is there. Her eyes are wide and alarmed, bloodshot against the white and the blue, silently screaming at Catra before storming out of the house and into the beach again, her long hair still heavily soaked snapping behind her back. Whatever it is, she is asking for Catra's help.

Catra fumbles on her feet, unsure, hands trembling at her sides, nails pressing against her palms so hard it leaves dents over her palms. The cold breeze is slipping through the open door and inside the house, making the flames of the fireplace hesitate over the logs. A sound

comes from the beach, low and strange, chilling the marrow in Catra's bones. It comes again, this time louder, vibrating as the sounds heard in the depth of the ocean, shaking the glass of the windows. And then again, even louder, a song and a scream at the same time, followed by another and another, each one louder and more distraught than the other that sets Catra in motion, rushing through the slippery floor, across the room and the dark corridor and into the porch, socks, shoes and jacket be damned.

The air bites in her skin merciless, blowing her hair behind her back and making her eyes sting with the sand and the salt. The beach is cold, the night sky thick and dark, the waves still washing against the shore violently.

She is walking from side to side of the shore, the sea crashing against her bare legs, salted hands that seem to grab onto her and want desperately to pull her inside, failing every single time. Her expression is terrible, desperate and suffering, maybe sea breeze, maybe silent tears or both running down her cheeks as she mouths at the sea, a sound like a yell and the most beautiful lullaby ripping out of her throat loudly, traveling inside the water and above the rocks and into the dark depths of the ocean. Her feet dig themselves into the wet sand and the pebbles and she looks at every side, scratching at the ground, above stone and below tiny broken pieces of shells, looking for something that Catra can't see or understand.

"Hey! Hey, what is going on?!" Catra steps into the sand, trying to ignore the cold and the sudden fear and sadness that has overtaken her heart with the sound waves. The siren circles the sand, her legs shaking and desperate, as if she was expecting something to happen, scratching at the length of her legs with blunt nails, angry, frustrated. She steps into the water, looks at herself, walks back and screams again. The sound *hurts,* ringing in the walls of Catra's skull, making her fight against the need to press her hands on her ears, drop to the ground and curl against herself. Catra gulps as she hugs herself tightly, her throat closing, icing realization digging through the haze. "You can't leave. Why can't you leave?"

The siren snaps and hisses at her, not really as a warning but as a shaken growl just to walk after purposely inside the water with stumbling steps. Catra watches her go, her hair and face soaked with the strong wind left by the storm, until the siren trips and falls in the sand, quite a few feet inside the sea, struggling to keep her head above the tide.

"Oh shit," Catra runs and throws herself to the water too, inhaling sharply when the freezing water crashes against her like a thousand swords. It's not too deep, just enough to reach Catra's chest if she stands straight, but the waves are strong, pulling her in as she tries to reach for the struggling siren . Like this, with adrenaline pumping inside her veins, Catra is almost able to forget she doesn't actually know how to swim and that drowning scares the shit out of her.

Catra kicks and impulses herself against the force of the water, reaching to her and wrapping her arms around the siren 's strong torso, one on the side of her waist, the other on her shoulder, Catra's chest against the siren 's own, pulling her backwards and keeping her from falling again, struggling to bring her out of the water as best as she can. The siren fights her but not for too long, letting herself be dragged away until they are both kneeling on the edge of the shore, cradled between Catra's arms with her nails dug in the rocks and the sand, facing the sea. She opens her mouth again, letting out a yell so distraught it brings tears to Catra's

eyes and makes her heart speed up so fast the only thing she can do is hold her tight against her chest and not let go. Catra looks at the shape of the house absently, embracing the siren . She doesn't know what else to do but hold her and let her cry.

It's heartbreaking and unbearable, tearing the cords inside Catra's heart, and it's only a fraction of what the siren is truly missing. She lets her body fall against Catra's, her scream slowly melting into high pitched whimpers, heart wrenching sobs that rival the sea in violent mourning. This is it. The realization. The fall.

"I'm sorry," Catra finds herself whispering into her ear, repeating it as an apologize or prayer or a mantra. Anything. Anything at all that may comfort her. "I'm so sorry, I'm sorry. This shouldn't have happened. I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry-"

Catra's voice trails off, mixed with the wind and the cry at the ocean. Catra pets the crown of her head, wet and cold, tiny spark of icing forming in there for the cold. Catra feels like boiling, a cord about to snap, angriest as she has ever been. She should have killed them, those hunters, they should be gone. Nobody that causes someone a pain like this should be allowed to do more harm. What would have been of her, if Catra wasn't there? She should have kill them, thinks and thinks the darkest part of herself, the one she has struggled to bury down and that now is screaming too alongside the heartbroken siren in her arms. But she didn't, because Catra it's not like them, but hell she *wishes* .

Catra gulps, stomping down over the dark thoughts, rocking the siren softly from side to side. She doesn't need Catra's anger right now.

"You are safe now, you are going to be alright," Catra closes her own eyes tightly, nestling the siren 's head further on her neck. The screams have slowly died down, replaced by deep heavy sighs and the occasional mourning hiccup. Catra hugs her closer. "Nothing is going to hurt you here. I'm not going to let them hurt you, alright? You are not alone on this."

The siren's shoulders slump forward, the outburst calmer now, leaving only the harsh wind and solitude of the shore around them as company. But she is still shivering so bad it makes Catra's teeth click against each other and her heart to shatter, cold tears running down her cheeks and into the siren 's shoulder. She hadn't noticed she was crying too. Catra rubs her back in circles, unconsciously nudging the side of her head against hers in some kind of comfort.

"Come on, let's go inside" Catra whispers, her finger pads against her goosebumped skin. The siren bend over herself and Catra even more, burying her head against Catra's neck and her hands into the sand. Catra's heart skyrockets and leaves the planet, struggling to even form a coherent sentence when she speaks next, only driven by worry and cold. " *Please* , you are freezing and soaked, you're going to get sick. *I'm* going to get sick and I'm insufferable when I get sick, so do us both a favor, alright?"

The siren exhales, unbothered by Catra's sad attempt of spirit lifting humor, still panting against Catra's neck, but she takes her hands from the rough sand, placing them against Catra's shoulder blades instead, and nods. Catra sighs, relieved as fuck, tightening her hold and motioning them both up a little, not really carrying her again. At this point, Catra's muscles are screaming with exhaustion and her head pulses a little with an imminent

headache, she doesn't think she will be able to carry her again all the way back. Thankfully she doesn't need to. She pushes herself up too, helping Catra as they stand up together.

"That's it" Catra coaxes her, bringing one of the siren 's arms behind her neck and getting a good hold of her waist, helping her maintain her balance as she guides her inside. "Let's go, princess"

Princess?

Catra pushes down the thought bouncing in her mind, chewing the inside of her cheek. She will deal with her own mental shit later. They walk together with careful steps towards the house, stopping every time the siren 's feet dig too deep in the sand, making her stumble with a frustrated grunt.

"I know, sand sucks. You'll get use to it," Catra cooes her in the softest of voices.

What's with this tone?

Catra bites her tongue, helping her as she limps through the last part of the beach and over the steps, rubbing her arms when the cold wood of the porch's floor makes her groan, uncomfortable.

"Come on, one feet after the other. That's good. You are really fucking brave, darling."

What. The fuck.

Catra pushes the door open with her shoulder, kicking it back closed with her feet and leading the siren to the comfiest couch next to the still warm and burning fireplace. It's Catra's favorite spot in the entire house, the couch soft, well worn and loved that makes you sink inside the multiple pillows Catra has thrown over it with time. The siren seems to think the same about it because she practically melts inside of it when Catra lowers her down gently over the seat, twisting on her spot in the carpet like headless chicken as she looks for the basket of clothes she has dropped somewhere after changing.

There is a muted meow and Melog's head appears from beneath the clothes of that very same basket, guiding Catra to it with a swirl if their tail, their eyes serious, almost too knowing for Catra's liking. She ignores them, shushing them to the side while she urgently picks up several clothes, rushing from one side to the other.

"Alright, let me help you," Catra says, not even thinking about it before blinking into reality, suddenly self aware that she might feel invaded by Catra's impulsives.

She doesn't look bothered by it at all, though, sitting up better, eyes heavy and sad but allowing Catra to slide a white thermal shirt over her head and arms, followed by a second one and a turtle neck, grey-wool sweater she got in the market and never wore. Then she helps the siren balance on her feet again, placing both of her hands over Catra's shoulders and halfway standing as Catra puts her the softest cotton pants she owns, a little more gray now than black after using them so many times, but just as comfortable. They are a bit short for her long legs, the cuffs barely brushing her ankles but it works, specially after Catra

throws too the thickest socks she has even seen before, those that have little cats on them and that Scorpia knitted for her birthday on their times as roommates in college and that Catra won't admit but she is deeply fond of.

The siren sits back on the couch, looking with clear curiosity at Catra leaning over the opposite couch to fetch her coat, a double layered flannel and fleece fabric mustard color thing, and a spare blanket thrown careless on the side. Catra is kind of a mess with her things but she is glad for that right now. Catra holds the coat to the siren, patiently waiting as she slides her arms through the sleeves, and, once she is well tucked and done, enveloping the blanket around her back, shoulders and damp hair until she looks like a siren burrito sitting in silence on her favorite couch.

Catra shuffles on her feet, unsure what to do next. She can feel the siren ’s gaze over her, as she has done the entire time since she is here, and it’s making her extra nervous. But she also looks for the worse, white as a sheet and tired as fuck and obviously shaken to her core, thought she has stopped trembling like a leaf and she doesn’t look like she is going to pass out in Catra again. Catra clears her throat, returning the siren’s sight with much more hesitation but not less intensity, blinking slowly at her a couple of times before daring to speak.

“Are you hungry?” The siren blinks back at her, seemingly surprised by the abrupt question. Catra beats herself up internally for it but doesn’t let it show or backtracks, trying to maintain some of that sharp pride and ever present sureness that characterizes her. Doesn’t last much. Catra doesn’t seem to be able to control herself around her or her puppy seal eyes looking at her like *that.* Catra grunts, taking her eyes off hers, anywhere else. “Look, this is not because I like you. I’m just tired too, I have plenty of food and, no offense, but you look like you need some iron. You in?”

Wow. Dick move, awesome. Catra is about to go bury herself in the sand or throw herself from the cliff, she fuckin hates herself. She can feel her entire face and ears turn bright red, the fine hair in her nape on point. All those bittersweet and unwanted signs of awkwardness, beginning to creep out, like a scrawny teenager speaking for the first time with a pretty girl.

After some good moments of absolute silence, Catra risks a quick glance at her, lips already pressed in an annoyed, apologetic pout. There is a gleam in the siren’s bright blue eyes, mixing in there with her sadness, and the corner of her mouth is twitching with something Catra can recognize as amusement, dancing under the mirth of an errand, tiny smile. She is smiling. Catra has a siren tucked in blankets in the couch of her house and she is patched up and probably traumatized for shit humans do -as usual- and yet, she is smiling. For Catra, *because* of Catra, Catra who is sharp and most of the time angry, though she is working in it, and who just doesn’t make people smile.

"I have tuna." Fucking hell. It keeps coming, the verbal vomit, Catra just can't stop it. "Do you - What do you eat? I'll check out"

Catra turns around in the direction of the kitchen, her own soaked pants sticking to her legs. Catra gives a step and stop, frozen in place by the feeling of a long hand wrapped around her wrist. She looks down, following the path of pale fingers laced over her skin up to the siren's eyes, silently questioning and mildly alarmed.

"I'm not going anywhere, just going to hop to the kitchen right there," Catra points at the other side of the house, the fridge and counter clear beyond the sofas. The siren gives her nothing but a black expression, not letting go from her hand. "Hey, I'm not leaving you."

The siren expression doesn't flicker, but her eyes soften a little bit in the edges and she let's go of Catra, burying her hands back inside the blanket with a shiver. Catra can feel the ghost of her touch on every fiber of her skin.

"Good." Catra turns her back to her, unable to hold her gaze anymore. She grabs a dry set of clothes off the basket and putting them on. She has showered many times in shared gym showers, she knows how to get out of dirty clothes and into clean ones with discretion. She gets to the fridge and opens it, thankfully still chill even without light in the house, roaming through the containers and plates there.

"Alright. Look, I don't want to guess, but I do have tuna and other fishes. I have some meat too, though no chicken, I hate it. Here they are. Salmon, carp, sardines-" there is a soft sound behind her. Catra turns, her eyebrows lifted, watching at the bright eyes from the couch that have sparkled back to life suddenly. Catra smirks in victory, taking the container from the fridge and a second one for herself and closing the door with her hip. "Sardines it is. I just have to warn you, I cook with a lot of condiments, and this one has spicy tomato sauce, so go at your own risk."

Catra turns on the stove, putting the sardine's stew on a pan and her own food in another pot, making sure to heat them both up well and good. The silence that falls inside the house is comfortable, easier than earlier. Catra is able to think clearly as she puts the food inside the plates, walking back to the fireplace in lighter but also sleepier steps. She hands the warm plate to the siren, making sure she has it well grasped in her fingers before sitting over the carpet cross legged, opposite to the couch where she is, with her back leaned in the bottom of the other sofa.

The siren looks at the plate, bringing it up to sniff at it before digging her entire hand inside the stew and taking a wide, messy bite from it, eyes wide in excitement as she not only devours but basically inhales the entire plate. Catra looks at her without blinking, her own plate halfway to her mouth in astonishment and mild horror too, laughing nervously when she takes an entire sardine and bites a huge chunk out of it, tiny crumbs falling to the couch and the floor. She looks so absolutely ridiculous and completely endearing that Catra doesn't even find it in herself to be the slightest mad about her things getting hot sauce in them.

"You like it. Siren's like spicy food, who would have known?" Catra grabs her plate again, taking a spoonful of noodles and eating it in a few chews, the warmth of the hot liquid and the condiments melting away the last of the cold the storm had brought inside her bones "Is that what you are? A siren?"

The siren looks at her without stopping from eating, dragging her eyes across the entire room and then back to Catra, shrugging with an indifferent huff. Maybe she doesn't know another human-given term for someone like her, maybe she doesn't really care how she is referred to. She doesn't seem bothered by it though, so Catra accepts it for now.

Another thought crosses Catra's mind, making her wrinkle her nose with another bite of her food.

"What is your name?" The siren snaps her attention back to her, her elegant, thick dark eyebrows raised. Catra imitates her movement, shrugging too and avoiding her eyes. "I can't go around calling you *Hey, you* "

She seems to consider it, her eyes thoughtful while she finishes the entire stew, handing the plate back to Catra with her face blank. She looks for Catra's eyes, locking them together until she is sure she has Catra's complete attention. The siren opens her mouth a little, not wide enough that it makes her wince in pain. Catra is about to tell her to not force herself when her voice comes out in gentle waves, filling the entire room in crystal bells. Her lips don't move with words but the beautiful sound keeps coming, spoken in a language Catra doesn't know or understands but that shakes the cores if her very heart and makes its home in there.

It's not long, almost immediate, the siren trailing off not long after starting, looking at Catra with expectation. But for the last it feels like hours, floating hypnotized inside the haze of her even as some part of her nudges how wildly ridiculous and absolutely dangerous it is to be so completely enthralled and devoted to someone so quickly.

Catra gulps, exhaling when she realizes she has been holding her breath the entire time, trying to blink away the bleary mist in her eyes.

" *Wow* , that was- beautiful." The siren smiles again, that tiny little self satisfied smirk, burying herself inside the fort of blankets and pillows. Catra wrinkles her nose, thinking in all the ways she can't replicate that sound, as beautiful as it is. "But I can't in a million years repeat that, I just don't have the pipes. Let's find another way, okay?" The siren rolls, *rolls* , her eyes at her, imitating her. Catra huffs, surprised. "Why are you giving me that look, you salty fish. Now wait there"

Catra puts her bowl on the side, scrambling through the books on the floor until she finds what she is looking for, a worn out white book with a cheap bend cover. She hands it to the siren, opening it to her in no page in particular.

"Here. It's a baby names book. I use it when I'm stuck on writing. Maybe you can find something here that gets close" Catra passes her finger through the rows of names and meanings, coaxing her to read through them. Catra then frowns, suddenly, taking her hand back and looking at the siren with a questioning look. "Wait, do you even know how to read?"

The siren shushes her away with her hand, not even looking at Catra, going through the pages of the book with a thoughtful and curious expression. Catra waits for her there, kind of losing herself in the golden reflection of the warm fire against the white of her eyelashes. She doesn't know how much time passes, but the siren makes a noise at some point, calling Catra's attention and pointing at a choice in the book. Catra leans next to her and towards the book, still on the floor, narrowing her eyes to the choice.

“Finn?” She is a bit confused until she notices the siren is pointing specifically to a column of meanings in the side. "Oh. Adorable? It's sweet but that's a meaning not a name," the siren gives her an unimpressed look and points at the word again, this time tapping with her nails on each letter until she stops midway. "Adora. Adora?" she nods, finally satisfied, closing the book and sinking inside the couch with a relieved sigh. Catra takes the book and drops it somewhere besides them, scooching back to her place on the carpet.

"It suits you," Catra says, raising her head to look back at her. Adora is looking down, at some point besides Catra's knee, where the bowl of food it's still smoking with warm food. Catra arches her eyebrow, smirking at Adora with mirth. "Still hungry?"

Adora crosses her arms and grumbles, looking away with a frown. So, she is proud and stubborn and Catra is in a big fucking trouble.

"Here, eat them" Catra basically pushes the bowl on her still cold hands, standing up just to let herself fall over the opposite sofa with a heavy thud. "It 's noodles. But the traditional ones, not that plastic crap that they sell in the stores."

Adora blinks at her without understanding but her face is grateful as she inhales out, too, the food in the bowl, barely breathing at all in between but with her eyes widening in delight. Catra sighs heavily, watching the side of her face against the fire's light. There are dry tear tracks in her skin and heavy lilac bags under her blue eyes. The occasional shiver born of anxiety instead of cold still shakes her limbs every once in a while but she seems to have taken comfort on that spot, tucking her legs below her and bringing the blanket closer to herself, trying to keep the warmth close and the sadness away.

There is a rush of movement to her side when Melog jumps to the couch Adora is in, approaching her with silent steps and curiosity. Catra's heartbeat picks up without her permission, afraid they may scratch Adora or the other way around, but Adora turns her head when she feels the soft fur of Melog's face against her face, surprise melting into fondness as Catra's cat starts nuzzling the side of her cheek with a reassuring, gentle purr. Adora smiles, small again, letting the empty bowl fall unceremoniously into the carpet and bringing her hand up, petting the side of Melog's face a little bit awkwardly, as if she didn't really know how to do it.

Catra deflates, something sticky and sweet and very, very dangerous crawling from the bottom of her heart to her lungs and cheeks at the sight of them, greeting each other like older friends. Adora is looking at her, again, almost without blinking, cradling Melog on her lap when they make themself a purring furry ball over her, slipping back into their spoiled child nap of the night.

Traitor.

"You should sleep, you need to rest" Catra whispers, a little bit drowsy herself, exhaustion taking its toll on her. Maybe the one that is going to fall asleep any minute now it's her. Adora hums, getting comfier, but doesn't seem to want to close her eyes either, her shoulders still tense. "You are safe here and free to stay as long as you want, and you are also free to leave if you want to. It's your choice at any moment," reassures her Catra, feeling her eyes heavy. The sofa is hard and very different from the couch but it's not too bad, definitely enough to lull

Catra to sleep. Catra yawns without being able to help it, rubbing the side of her face with her palm. It's cold down here, even next to the fire, without a blanket. Adora is still looking but she looks blurrier now, much more like a dream than a real person, cuddled suddenly in Catra's life.

"I'll help you get home, Adora. Promise" Catra hears herself say, very far away, slurred and slow as if she had stuck a bunch of cottons and honey inside her mouth. She is definitely falling asleep. "Just gotta take a quick power nap. Don't eat me while I'm asleep, alright?"

The hum inside her brain melts into a lullaby, sweet, incomprehensible, almost as if someone was singing to her from right inside her heart, turning Catra's inside into something soft and dragging her definitely into a deep sleep. Outside, the storm starts to dissipate, the thick clouds dissolving. It's still dark but the first lights of the dawn won't take long to shine through. The last thing Catra sees before falling asleep, it's a pair of blue eyes highlighted in gold looking at her.

Sleep comes.

End of chapter I

And whatever that may come [fog over my skin]

Chapter Summary

> It all comes back to her in a rush, expelling the air from her lungs harshly. Lights out, going for wood to the village, a storm. Horrible people doing horrible things, someone hurt and scared and angry hiding in the rocks. Long honey hair and golden and blue scales and sharp teeth.
>
> Adora.

Chapter Notes

> Hello hello! How's everybody doing? I'm so glad to e back with this story!
>
> Thank you so much to everyone that commented, liked and bookmarked the first chapter. It's really complicated for me to answer all your lovely messages but I read them all and I really really appreciate them! So thank you :")
>
> We've got ourselves a long boi (almost 30k words) so I hope you enjoy! Without anything else to say, I see ya downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter II. And whatever that may come [fog over my skin]

We had only just met, but this was an old love.

This was a love that ended in flames.

– Moïra Fowley-Doyle, *All the Bad Apples*

Music that inspired this chapter **x x x**



Three loud knocks in the door.

Catra wakes up with a jolt, sitting up on the seat of the sofa so fast her head swims with sudden dizziness. It's day, if the grey light that pours from the windows and into the living

room has anything to say about it. The fireplace has gone cold after the wood logs consumed completely at some point, making the temperature drop. The house is in silence.

Catra blinks, eyes bleary and confused. Her head hurts, the base pounding with stabs of pain. Catra groans inside her palms, trying to breathe in deeply and push away the waves of discomfort. There is something pulling in the side of her mind, something that she is supposed to be remembering but she really can't. Something about freezing water and a storm, and wounds and anger. Maybe a nightmare, then. Catra sighs, frustrated by the pain hazing her thoughts, swinging away mindlessly the blanket and coat placed carefully over her legs and chest.

Catra freezes, raising her head from her palms slowly to peak at the soft fabric between her fingers, the mustard of the flannel and the muted cream of the wool. Catra didn't fall asleep with them.

It all comes back to her in a rush, expelling the air from her lungs harshly. Lights out, going for wood to the village, a storm. Horrible people doing horrible things, someone hurt and scared and angry hiding in the rocks. Long honey hair and golden and blue scales and sharp teeth. Adora.

Catra snaps her head to the side -wincing when the headache stabs her in the side with the sudden movement- scanning the room with narrowed eyes, her heartbeat hitting against her ribcage harshly, closing her throat in a tight knot. The couch next to the fireplace is empty, the room void. Catra looks behind her, to the kitchen, just to find it exactly the same. Her house is deadly quiet, only the sea breeze hitting softly against the wood and the sea outside. There is nobody else there but her.

Maybe it was all a fever dream after all, thinks Catra, running a hand through her hair. Too many sleepless nights writing fantastic crazy stories and a violent storm mixing in her already messed up head. Still, Catra can't help the stab of disappointment that crosses her chest and heart. Or the prickle in the corners of her eyes with treacherous tears.

Catra rubs the back of her hand harshly against her eyes, angry at herself, grimacing when the knocks in the door comes again, this time with more urgency.

"I'm coming, I'm coming, goddamit!" yells back Catra, swaying her legs over the edge of the sofa, bare foot hitting the cold floor with a hiss. She stands up in wobbly feet, her entire body protesting in pain when she starts walking towards the door.

She doesn't make it far. Her feet kick against something in the floor that makes her lose her balance -that and the godforsaken migraine, mind you- and stumble unceremoniously to the ground. Catra groans, frustration boiling in the pit of her stomach, raising back in her forearms and turning around to see what exactly had made her fall. An empty bowl of noodles and a plate with red sauce smeared and dry on the bottom. Catra wheezes, adrenaline rushing on her ears as waterfalls. She drags herself on her knees, focusing on the dark floor in front of her. Dry golden spots mark a path from the main door to the staircase, losing themselves there, some tiny, almost invisible, others bigger. Somewhere next to them, a sunbeam shines over a round tiny object, not bigger than a penny, shimmering in golden

colors. Catra picks it up with shaky hands, bringing it up close with narrowed eyes. A golden scale, cold at the touch and beautiful as it can be and the only proof Catra needs.

Somewhere beyond her place on the floor, someone keeps bashing against the door. Catra rises on her feet again, turning around the rooms this time to be absolutely sure it's completely empty before approaching the space of the main door. Catra doesn't know where she has gone but it doesn't really matter right now. Catra reaches for the doorknob but stops, her fingers hovering just a little over it with hesitation. Catra inhales, holding her breath and frowning. The wood curtains in the windows at the sides of the door are closed tightly and she doesn't have another way to peek out and see who it is knocking. She could just swing the door open and hiss to however it is, as she usually does when some curious tourist gets lost and thinks it's funny knocking repeatedly at her door. But also, someone quite literally tried to kill Adora last knight. Those three men weren't your usual stinky, fortune hunters. They had expensive equipment, a shining new boat and thick clothes. They knew what they were doing. And they saw Catra. Catra and the only fucking house in miles where a hurt mythical sea creature may be hiding.

Catra snaps her hand back, straightening her back. She roams her eyes to the small table next to her and far away, towards the kitchen, looking for anything that may serve her as a defense. The knocking resumes, making the entire door vibrate with the force of it. Catra gulps and scowls, giving up in her search in order to press her ear against the door, trying to catch every single weird little sound she may hear.

"What?!" Catra yells. It comes raspy and tired and absolutely fucking horrid as it makes her head beat with uncomfortable pain. But the person at the other side of the door moves, just a little bit away, their feet heavy against the wood outside. Catra's heartbeat speeds up.

"Catra? It 's Bow!" the voice calls out and Catra can hear the grin in his voice even from the other side. Catra exhales, her chest and lungs deflating in one blow. Adrenaline is replaced by annoyance as she grabs the knob and pulls it open with as much strength as she can.

The cold breeze of the beach greets her with a full blow on the face, blowing her hair back and dissipating the last of the sleepy haze from her mind. Bow, phD Marine Biologist and leader of the Marine Protection Organization of the Salineas Investigation Center is standing in there, his thick tight curls floating too above his head with the wind. His gold and white raincoat protects his back and arms from the sea breeze but does nothing at all for his chest, clothes like this with a godforsaken lilac crop top and high jeans. Catra swears sometimes people's priorities are all over the place.

Catra crosses her arms and leans over the frame of the door, eyebrows lifted and a tight smirk plastered in her face, trying to sell the picture perfect pose of someone sure of themself and careless and definitely not hiding a siren somewhere inside the house.

"Yes, well, what can I help you with?" asks Catra with a hint of annoyance in her tone. She is a good liar, she had to learn to be one to hide many things, many emotions and feelings through her life. She can get rid of someone quickly if she wants. As predicted, Bow's big carefree smile trembles and washes away, replaced by a worrisome frown and a pout on his lips.

"I received your message when the lines came back. I drove here as fast as I could to check up on you," he offers her in return, his gentle smile climbing back into his mouth. Catra's head is pounding.

"Message, what message?" she asks, realization drawing over her at the same time she speaks. She remembers herself struggling at the bottom of the stairs to put on her boots, tapping an angry message at him before kicking the door open and going outside. Back when she still thought she was dealing with fishers and seals. Bow pulls out his phone out of his jeans as Catra remembers, dread running down her back though he thankfully doesn't seem to notice it. Or maybe he is courteous enough to not mention it which is totally not good for Catra, she knows he is smarter than he lets show, buried under all that tooth rotting kindness.

" *Motherfuckers at the sea again* " reads Bow out loud, barely containing a laugh. That's it, the entire message. Honestly, Catra didn't have time for more and Bow had received enough messages to know exactly what this was about. Which brings them to this particular predicament because Catra definitely *does not* want him here now. “I called you a few times in the morning to check on you but you didn't pick up so I just decided to come and see if you were okay.”

“My battery died,” explains Catra absently, trying not to show how badly she wants him to go. “And I obviously couldn’t recharge it with the electricity off, Arrows. You could have just called later, like, in the evening for example.”

Bow looks at her intently, giving her a tiny smile that Catra would consider condescending in anyone else but Bow. For Bow that expression on his face means he is thoughtful and, worst of all, worried. And that he is about to make her headache even worse with the pack of questions he is about to throw at her.

"Catra, it's four in the afternoon," he says, very gently. Catra gapes at him, speechless, snapping her eyes from his to look at the beach around them. The sun is definitely lower in the sky and opposite where it comes out every morning. The clouds are scattered in the sky after the storm, casting a grey shimmer over everything. Probably what made Catra get confused in the first place, that, or the pulsing headache. Whatever it was, it just means that she has been sleeping a little bit over twelve hours and that Bow's worry frown is definitely called for.

She has been out for twelve hours, which means Adora has been on her own for some of them. What if she needed something? Or her wounds reopened or she was in pain? What if the hunters had come back and Catra was passed out on the sofa and unable to help her out? Catra twitches her mouth, displeased and mildly alarmed and also quite angry at herself. This whole thing of caring about some else it's so weird.

Bow seems to feel the way Catra tenses up completely, though he doesn't understand the full length of why, but he drops the matter not pressing Catra more as he smiles. “Well, no worries, I’m here now. You can tell me what happened.” Catra wants to rip her hair out of her scalp with her bare hands, why did she have to send that godforsaken message?

“You know, the usual. Assholes thinking they are some kind of superior being and that for so, they have the right to hurt other creatures for fun, or money, or whatever shit show they use

as an excuse.” Catra bites the inside of her mouth, honest anger and hate boiling inside her throat and pouring out of her mouth. She has Adora’s screams craved inside her mind, the feeling of her body trembling against hers as she tried and failed to understand why she couldn’t go home. And Catra hadn’t known either, hadn’t known how to help her at all. Catra has spots of golden ichor dried in her floor, she stitched her flesh together after humans cut her up. Adora, who Catra has met for barely a few hours in the middle of a storm and that Catra doesn’t even know where she is right now, but who cried and mourned in her arms and who likes sardines and noodles and the couch next to the fire. She feels, just like any other sea or earth creature, and she suffers. She suffered at those hunters' hands and Catra wishes she could return them the favor. Catra doesn’t care about being the bigger person right now, as her therapist would try to recommend her, Catra couldn’t give less of a fuck, she *hates* them.

“Anyway, I hushed them away,” Catra’s voice cracks at the start miserably, though she masks it with a scowl. She knows Bow is looking at her. “You know I can be pretty convincing when I want to.”

Catra crosses her arms over her chest, looking far away into the ocean, stressing to appear indifferent to the whole situation. At the same time, she tries to force her hearing, weary if she can catch any sound that may rat them out. But there is nothing else in the house besides silence. In front of her, Bow sighs, conflicted, shaking his head from side to side as he put his phone back inside his jacket.

“Did they hurt you?” he asks, taking Catra by surprise. She frowns, returning her gaze to him with an offended scowl. He seems sincere, swinging on his feet slightly from side to side, considering Catra and the pace of her brain patiently. It makes Catra want to yowl and slam the door on his face. She definitely has better things to do than being psychoanalyzed.

“Of course not, they didn’t even got to put a foot off their boat.” Bow tilts his head to the side, seemingly considering something for a little bit and making Catra considerably more exasperated. Finally he looks like he drops whatever he is thinking about aside, at least for now. This time, it’s him who crosses his arms over his chest but not in a defensive manner, more like someone that 's trying to be understanding and concerned at the same time.

“Listen Catra, I know you care a lot about the animals, even if you try to act tough and cold all the time,” he says when she opens her mouth to protest. Catra closes it right back up, teeth clicking with each other in frustration. Somehow it makes Bow’s smile peek with a little bit more confidence. “Nobody would risk themselves so much if you didn't care for them. And we are all very thankful at the Center. *I* am really thankful for you and your heads up. You’ve really been the only reason why we’ve been able to rescue many hurt animals and bring them to their homes safely. But that's also my point, you are putting yourself at risk a lot and you know some of these people are very dangerous."

Catra huffs, leaning away from the door frame to poke a finger in the middle of Bow's forehead, who squeaks a little with indignation. "I'm a big girl, Arrows, you don't need to lecture me about safety measures. I live alone here, I know everything there is about it." Catra rolls her eyes, tapping on the floor with her feet impatiently. "It doesn't matter anyway, I was very clear and they left. End of the story."

Bow grimaces, unsure, but drops the ball. He knows he can't win against Catra in an argument and she doesn't have the patience or time to go into one right now. She exhales, though, dropping her arms to the side and frowning too, her thoughts swirling with each other. She is definitely not telling Bow anything of what happened with Adora last night, but he may be of use for something else, like tracking those men down.

"These hunters, they were different," she says to him. Bow seems to catch the sudden seriousness in her voice because his entire frame straightens up too, listening to her intently.

"Different how?"

"I don't know, Bow, just different. Richer. But also I don't think they were your usual selfish pricks, I think they are working for someone else." Bow raises his eyebrows at Catra. She called him by his actual name and that is proof enough that this is serious for her. "And they were- they were cruel. They all are, but they were even more. It wasn't only about capturing and getting a prey, they *hurted* her."

Bow frown deepens. "Her?"

Fuck

"The sea creature," adds Catra immediately, trying to tame down her increasing panic without him noticing. "She, them, that's not the point Bow."

"I know, I know." Bow raises his hands in defeat, trying to calm down the waters. "I'll let Micah know, I'm sure he will ask the lifeguard to watch over the port and the sea, in case they want to come back" he rubs his chin with his hand, deep in thought. Catra swears these people are so theatrical sometimes, but she feels slightly relieved by his idea. "Do you remember anything else about them?"

"Besides they shat their pants when I threatened them?" Catra scoffs. Bow doesn't laugh but he is also not bothered by it either. She swears he has the patience of a fucking saint. "They wore all white, like fucking cultists or something. And there was a green logo on their boat, two bat wings with three eyes in the space inside. That 's all."

Bow nods, taking his phone again to type a quick message and send it first hand most likely to the Micah, the village's apothecary and chief of the lifeguards vigilance. "Very well, we'll keep an eye out."

"Yeah, sure" Catra dismisses him, fighting for looking as indifferent to the entire thing as she can. Even so, she clicks her tongue against her teeth, wrinkling her nose when she asks. "If you know anything about them- let me know, alright?"

Bow looks at her in silence, gentle expression unreadable under his kind eyes but he nods nonetheless. "Of course" he shifts on his feet, unsure for a second as he studies Catra's face. "What happened to the animal? You said it was hurt" Catra narrows her eyes at him, even though he looks completely honest about his worry.

"Swam away," she answers him only, crossing her arms again. She is aware her entire posture screams defensiveness but there is nothing other way she can act again. "Is not like it was going to stay and drink the tea, Arrows."

Bow knits his eyebrows in disapproval, not because of her sarcasm, but for something else completely different. He knows Catra is keeping things from him and Catra just wants to slam the door on his face. "Catra, are you sure everything is alright?"

"Why are you insisting so freaking much, Arrows?" she finally snaps, basically growling at him.

"You have three huge scratches on your face, Catra"

Oh shit, god fucking damnit, fuck .

She forgot. It stung a little when she woke up and it was definitely itchy last night, but she was pretty busy with something else at that moment to worry about three lonely scratches that probably won't even scar. Catra exhales, she can avoid it, tensing up completely in the door. Bow seems to have realized he has struck a nerve but doesn't backtrack, waiting for Catra to offer some kind of explanation. It annoys the hell out of her.

"Melog scratched me" Catra deadpans, expression in blank.

"Melog"

"Yes, they are scared of storms." There is an indignant meow that comes from inside the house, most probably the offended mentioned cat, napping below some blanket and complaining at Catra's blatant lie. "New flash Arrows, cats scratch. Now if you excuse me I have a meeting with my publicist and a deadline to meet. So-"

“Yes, yes of course” Bow steps back, concern still etched on his eyes but he catches the sharpness in Catra’s voice and doesn’t push more. Catra watches him with a lifted eyebrow until he steps down the steps of the porch. If he also realizes about those lies he doesn’t comment on it.

Bow turns around halfway to his car, a beaten up red jeep with heart and moon stickers in the door, to look back at Catra with a serious but kind look, smiling at her as if she hadn't practically passive aggressively kicked him out. "If I know anything I'll text you, alright?"

"Yeah, yeah. Just go already. Aren't you late for a date with your girlfriend or something?" Bow turns seven bright shades of red, his eyes widening in alarm and, honestly, goddamn funny shame, tripping with his own big white boots awardly.

"Glimmer it's not my girlfriend," he stutters. Catra grins, a wide, cat-like smirk stretching on he face in victory.

"I didn't say Sparkle's name, but go off I guess." Bow gapes at her, basically making a run for the door of the jeep and slipping in the sand and pebbles several times before finally managing to get in. Catra drowns a laugh behind her palm as she watches him bring the car

back to life. Bow leans over the open window one more time hitting against his face with force.

"Call me if you need anything, alright?!" he yells, unnecessary, above the wind. Catra rolls her eyes, nervously holding her frame unt her knuckles turn white. *Go already,* she thinks.

"I'm twenty five, Arrows."

"And remember to not walk on the cliff when it's windy!" follows Bow, not listening to Catra or ignoring her completely, his ears still red in the tips. He turns the car around and drives away through the path towards the village, too slow -speeds limits at the shore or something- for Catra's liking, but leaving still. Catra's ability to make someone nervous enough to leave comes in handy sometimes.

She stays outside on the porch until she is sure Bow's car is long gone, and after that a little bit more still, paranoid that he may have remembered some question that he forgot to ask her and come back, or that anyone else may drive up to the house looking for something they shouldn't. Once she is sure nobody else is going to appear out of nowhere, Catra steps back into the house backwards, grabbing the doorknob to close the door. She needs to find Adora wherever she is in the house or at least make sure nothing has got to her when Catra was basically passed out with exhaustion. She hasn't heard any sound or creak that may suggest there is somewhere else in the house in all this time but she can't be sure. Not with this, wherever she is, Catra needs to find her and make sure she hasn't turned into fish nuggets or something like that.

Very sensitive, Catra scowls herself mentally, slamming the door closed with an annoyed swing.

Adora is standing right behind the door, deadly silent, just staring at her with those icy bright blue eyes. Catra screeches, jumping back several feet with a loud, indignant squeak in shock and surprise. Catra trips with her own feet and slips, barely holding herself up by grabbing the fabric of the curtain like a lifeline.

"Fffu-" Catra wheezes half curse out, bawling her shirt into her first to try and steady herself and her sped up heartbeat out of her embarrassing outburst, looking at Adora's still figure from below her eyelashes. Adora has given a step forward, her hand hovering hesitantly in Catra's direction, as if she weren't sure if to grab her or just let stand there motionless as she falls. The last is obviously the winning one. Catra chuckles nervously and awkwardly but without bite, running a shaky hand through her already messed up mane of hair in an attempt to mindlessly tame it down. She doesn't even want to look back at the irony of Bow's reaction and hers. She turns to look at Adora fully, straightening up and kicking at the floor with a hushed yell. "Do not creep on me like that, dude! Fucking hell, how long have you been standing there?"

Adora tilts her head to the side, taking her hand back to her sides. Her feet are bare, socks long gone somewhere in the house, shifting against each other as she considers Catra in silence. Under the daylight she looks less pale than last night, her hair falling in waves of honey over her shoulders and down her back, curling in the tips that brushes the lower of her back. Her scales are gone, smooth skin broken here and there with the bruises and scratches

left behind by the hunters and the sterile patches Catra had cured her with. She is not trembling anymore, only hovering from side to side every once in a while. And she is still wearing Catra's clothes, tight against the muscles of her arms and her chest. Now that she is standing, they are definitely small for her. Catra will have to find her new ones.

Catra gulps, shaking her shoulders. Adora is searching for her eyes, locking her eyes with hers and then back to the door, rinse and repeat. Catra chews in her bottom lip, frowning before understanding what she is trying to tell her.

"Did you listen to that?" Catra asks, voice cracking in the middle, referring to her conversation with Bow. Adora looks at her again, shoulders dropping though her gaze remains unfazed, stoic and cold, not once ashamed about listening as she awaits for Catra's answer. Catra's voice picks up in sudden anger, high pitched and trembling. "You can't just listen around without asking me, Adora. That's not how things work here. It's just- ugh."

Adora's expression drops, spots of red splashing over her cheeks. Catra feels the back of her neck rise in goosebumps, her tongue heavy with acid and sudden anger, defensiveness slashing immediately inside of her at the intrusion of someone eavesdropping on her conversation. It's a bad self protection mechanism she had learned during all those years with Weaver, when privacy was a luxury Catra did not possess and that now makes her want to lash out at Adora, makes her want to kick her out of the house and close the door behind. Instead, Catra inhales deeply, joining her hands in front of her face as she makes the effort to push down the anger and dark thoughts down, breathing and breathing until she feels like she is able to speak without breaking again. It's not Adora's fault. Any of it, nor Catra's past trauma nor being afraid or a sudden person knocking in the door. Not after everything she had gone through.

"Alright, listen, I'm sorry. I got angry. It's something I'm working on," Catra looks from behind her joined hands, catching Adora's eyes on hers. She also looks defensive, shoulders thrown back, neck tense, a frown on her mouth. But her blue eyes are softer in the corners, ashamed. It moves something very deep inside Catra's heart. She would usually not care about what others may feel when they wrong her and she lashes at them. But this is different, this is Adora. Adora is different for Catra's heart and she doesn't know the shit she has gone through. "I'm just- dealing with stuff, you couldn't have known. I know you are worried but you can't go around, quiet like a ghost and appear out of nowhere, okay? Just ask me or at least let me know next time."

Adora returns her sight intently, listening to her every word. Catra feels a tickle on the sole of her feet every time she looks at her. Nobody had ever listened to her this closely or with so much attention before. Adora exhales -and even that sounds sweet to Catra- and nods, twice, but still crossing her arms over her chest in waiting.

"Alright, thanks. And that's just Arro- Bow. He works protecting the shore of Salineas," explains Catra in the thread of a voice but better. Adora's eyes have changed again, from unmoving and soulless to something warmer, the hint of a worried frown diggin between her dark eyebrows. Somehow, it dissolves Catra's sudden barrier and allows her to speak better, less like she is getting strangled. "He doesn't know. About you, I'm not going to tell him. I'm not going to tell anyone about it or about what happened to you, alright? I told you, you are

safe here" Adora's eyebrows rise a little but she nods, slowly and still a little bit unsure. Catra sighs, rubbing the bridge of her nose between her fingers. "I did ask him, though, to keep an eye out for the hunters that attacked you. Alright?"

Adora swings on her ankles, front and back and she nods again, apprehension leaving her body like steam. It abandons Catra's body too, her muscles relaxing and with it, the pulsing headache coming back on full force. Catra winces, her nose wrinkling with the waves of sharp pain stabbing across her skull. She needs a painkiller, or smashing her head against the wall, whatever it is that will take the pain away and that is definitely not standing in the middle of the corridor.

"Are you hungry?" snaps Catra, grimacing immediately after, inhaling and exhaling several times as she tries to tame the irritability brought by the ache. "We missed breakfast but who gives a damn about meals names anyway. Come on."

Catra turns around, heading to the kitchen with wobbly steps. A cold hand wraps around the delicate bones of her wrist, the hold firm even as it is gentle, letting through the real extent of the strength behind it. Catra lowers her eyes in surprise to the strong fingers wrapped around her arm, warmth blooming on her cheeks and nose, trying to ignore the hammering of her heart as she catches Adora’s eyes with a questioning look. Adora presses her lips together thoughtfully in a -frankly- adorable pout. She is tall, Catra realizes with a hiccup of her heart, tall enough that she towers over her when she leans towards Catra’s face, bright eyes digging holes and stars on her face.

“What is it?” asks Catra in a whisper, unable to do anything else but stand there, unmoving. Her hand moves for itself, twisting to the side so she can take Adora’s hand fully in hers, lacing their fingers together. *Fuck, fuck.*

Adora lifts her other hand, bringing it too to Catra’s face, suspended just a few inches away until the pads of Adora’s finger brush gently, oh so very gently, across the entire length of the skin of her cheeks, up and down, so softly it brings tears to Catra’s eyes. It stings a little, following the reddish and slightly swollen paths of nails against butter skin. *The scars.* Adora runs her fingers over the bothered skin, her dark eyebrows knitted firmly together. Even the brightness of her eyes has dimmed a little, the guarded expression replaced for something sadder, more vulnerable. Regret. Worry. Tenderness.

Her face is mere inches away from Catra's, all sharp angles, square jaw and straight nose. She is beautiful like this just as she was beautiful yesterday, surrounded by iridescent scales, neon thorns and lethal fangs, like a dark, hypnotic nightmare sprouting from one of Catra's books, a haunting beauty ripped from the deepest pits of her writings, from a tale and from a warning. Her hands are soft over Catra's face, strong fingers and blunt nails. Her hair smells like salt -and a little bit like seaweed too- but her breath is sweet. She has a bruise on her left cheekbone and sterile patches on her jaw and she looks like a sharp angel bloomed out of the sea.

Catra is fucked. Royaly, completely, absolutely fucked.

“It’s alright," Catra hears someone, herself, say over the rush inside her ears. It's tiny but sure, not hesitant at all. Still, Adora’s frown twitches, doubt written all over her beautiful face.

Catra turns around to face Adora fully, resting her other palm over the pale hand that cradles her scratched cheek, entangling their fingers together. "Hey, you were attacked and scared. I would have scratched me too."

Adora huffs, shaking her head in disagreement. On her temples, Catra sees amazed how tiny golden scales bloom from her skin and shimmer for a second, just to fall out again like dandelion's seed. Catra smiles at her stubbornness, moving her hand from where is still nestling Adora's just so she can pull playfully from her earlobe, gaining a breathless gasp of surprise in return.

"It doesn't even hurt. I told you, I've gotten plenty of bruises and scratches, I know it's going to heal very quickly." She has, she knows, from falls off trees to accidents in the skateboard to belts against her legs at the hands of Weaver. But Adora doesn't need to know that, she might not even understand it. For many years, Catra didn't understand it either.

Catra feels a small nudge on her hand and snaps back into reality, blinking away errand tears before they can even begin to fall. Adora's eyes are concerned, her nose wrinkled adorably in deep thought. The back of her head is still pounding with pain, creeping down her eyes and nose. Catra doesn't know how long she is going to make it like this without starting to cry, and she definitely doesn't want to cry in front of Adora right now. It's already too much, too strong, all at the same time. Catra pulls from their joined hands at their sides, motioning them both away from the corridor and the conversation and towards the kitchen.

"Come one, I'll make you the best thing ever discovered on earth. Hot chocolate."

Adora follows her close behind without making a sound but also without letting go from their hold. She is limping a little, probably caused by the deep slash on her thigh. Catra will have to check that up later. Catra, on her side, grows increasingly aware of their hands tangled together, the sweaty skin of her palm brushing against the cool skin of Adora's, the difference in their temperatures somehow balancing each other. As Catra thought, too much, too fast, too sudden. They reach the countertop of the kitchen quickly, for Catra's both relief and dread. She lets go of Adora's hand with a strangled exhale, grabbing one of the kitchen' chair and pulling it out for Adora to sit in as she roams across the kitchen for the things she needs. Catra is panting, she realizes when she leans inside the fridge to grab the milk, heart hammering inside her chest. Her brain and her heart are fighting each other with this, the fact that this isn't just about a pretty girl Catra has brought home but a siren, a mythical creature that lives in the depths of the oceans and that has teeth of a predator and that could very much just change her mind and jump over Catra as she pours the food inside a pot and places it over the stove.

Catra turns to the counter, throwing Adora a quiet look. She is bent over the marble of the counter, a pout stuck on her lips, poking with her finger at the bag full of coffee grains Cara had left carelessly there with open curiosity. Like this she doesn't look like a sea predator but a lost golden retriever sniffing at the coffee and making a sour face to it.

Catra chuckles, half hysteric, half amused, crossing her arms over her chest. Now that she is actually watching her from a safe distance she can see Adora's hair is slightly wet, her clothes rumpled and a bit off. The thermal shirt inside out with the tag poking out of the neck and her sleeves very obviously wet in the cuffs, same as the ends of her pants.

"Where were you?" asks Catra, wincing at the loudness of her own voice. She leans to the drawer next to her hip, fetching a bottle of painkillers and a glass with water. When Catra turns again, Adora is already looking at her, head tilted to the side. "When I woke up" Catra explains, gulping down the pill, "you weren't on the first floor. For a second I-"

I- what? Thought you were just some kind of amazing dream? A nightmare? I was worried the hunters had come back for you when I was sleeping? I, what?

Catra scowls at herself, leaving the empty glass on the counter behind her with a loud ring. She lets the sentence trail off, not bothering to finish. Adora is still looking at her with a questioning look on her eyes. She seems to understand Catra is not saying anything else, though, because her eyes drawn from Catra's face up to the ceiling and back, answering with an intent look.

"Oh, you were in the bath again," Catra says, understanding the why of the wet clothes, and sighs, honestly relieved that she wasn't wandering around the shore on her own. "We are probably going to have to drain that tub soon or my poor pipes are going to suffer with the salt." Catra turns the stove to the minimum, careful that the milk is still cold enough that it is going to burn and set fire to the kitchen. "Come on, I'll get you dry clothes. You are going to get a cold if you stay in that."

Catra walks past Adora's chair and directly to the stairs, not even bothering to turn and check if she is actually following her. She gets to about the middle of the stairs before she feels cold fingers tangling against hers again and the sensation of Adora standing behind her, like a cold sea breeze, waiting for Catra to guide her upstairs. Catra releases all the air she didn't know was holding, chewing the inside of her cheek and walking the last steps that lead to her bedroom, still holding Adora's hand.

The room has definitely seen better days. There are evident scratches in the walls and the door but nothing can be done for that now. Someone has pulled the curtains closed tightly and the warm light of the bathroom is on after the light came back, letting show the crack on the sink's mirror and the mess of cotton and aid patches in the floor. But,the shredded sheets and pillows have been placed in a pile in the corner and the broken lamp and other decorations inside a basket next to it, a poor but honest attempt of cleaning the mess. Catra squeezes Adora's hand once, walking inside the room before turning to look at her with wide eyes.

"You cleaned." It's not a question. Adora's eyes roam across the bedroom and back to Catra, nodding once. Catra smiles at her, crooked, her canine catching in her bottom lip. "You didn't need to, but thanks."

Catra points at the mattress swiftly, letting go -hard- from Adora's hand and walking away from her -even harder- to open the closet. There is a ruffle in the blankets on the floor, calling Catra's attention. Melog's wild mane peaks out of the fabric, blinking slowly at Catra, still groggy from their third afternoon nap. Catra rolls her eyes at them and the motion, incredibly, doesn't spark waves of pain on her head.

"There you are," Catra greets them, rubbing the back of their ears. "Have you been keeping Adora safe for me?"

Melog meows, rubbing their little head against Catra's arm before jumping over the corner of the bed where Adora has sat, curling from below her arms and nuzzling her in the knee and ribs, happily purring next to her. Adora hums in return, petting their back with her long fingers in repeated motions. Melog doesn't let anyone else but Catra to pet them, ever, not even Scorpia or Perfuma and much less Entrapta. They were just like that. Scorpia had always joked that it was as if Melog reflected Catra's own emotions.

Catra kneels next to the closet in silence, looking at Adora cradle Melog with a tiny smile on her exhausted face. Catra gulps around the knot on her throat, returning to the closet and scattering clothes aside until she finds what she is looking for. A pair of sport tops, long shirts and joggers that Scorpia had forgotten after she moved out with Perfuma and Catra never bothered to return. Scorpia is about the same height as Adora, if maybe a little bit wider on the back. Catra also grabs some pairs of clean boxers and white joggers, balancing it all in her arms.

"Here," Catra leaves the items next to Adora's knee, running a hand through her hair in a nervous tick. "You can change with this. The thermostat should be working now but I'll grab you a sweater anyway"

Catra turns back and starts looking inside the closet again, vaguely catching the sound of fabric moving around and falling on the floor. Catra grabs the biggest sweater she has and pulls, knocking in her way a pile of books she had found scattered around the house and proceeded to stuff in the very bottom of the closet when she very first arrived. It's just your usual stuff, several cooking books, a telephone guide, a book about gardening in the forest and a hardcover ancient looking fairytale book. She blinks at it, frozen in place for a few seconds. It's obviously old, the edge of the pages worn and the spine broken in half. There is nothing in the cover besides a golden column of flowers etched there and a yellowed post-it note Catra hadn't seen before with a swirly handwriting that Catra recognizes as her grandma's and that reads *For when you need it.*

Catra leans to pick up the book with steady fingers, frowning deeply. She rests the sweater on her forearms, roaming around the old pages as she walks absently towards the bed. Catra reaches the bottom of the bed and raises her head to hand the sweater to Adora, letting the book drop loudly into the floor when she looks at her.

"Oh," Catra gasps out loud, blushing a furious red as she snaps her sight away, anywhere else in the room but to her.

Adora is standing in front of the long mirror placed in the opposite wall, staring at herself and very, very much naked from head to toes. She seems to be studying herself up close, the length of her legs, the fine hair over them and her arms. The mount of curly dark hair on her armpits and then down her navel, between the curves of her thighs. Adora frowns at herself, opening her mouth to inspect the rows of her teeth -blunt and tiny compared with their usual self-, the color of her eyes and skin, that she pinches once or twice, looking with raised eyebrows as it colors red and then fades away. She runs her hands through her skin, huffing in annoyance at the smooth surface of it, lack of sharp scales. Under the dim light that slips from the curtains, Catra can see pale and pinkish patches in Adora's skin, scattered down her shoulder blades and upper arms and waist, one with irregular edges as a star in the curve of

her ear and the side of her temple where a thick strand of silver and white hair is born, bouncing softly among the honey of the rest. In the darkness, Catra thought it was remains of the fallen scales, up close she can see they look more like characteristic patches of vitiligo, placed on Adora's body like gentle brushes over her skin. Catra thinks she is absolutely beautiful. Adora's nose is wrinkled in thought, unaware of Catra's dreaming eyes behind her, and she grimaces when she taps softly the patches that cover her wounds, letting out a low hiss to the mirror.

There is a kind of vulnerability in Adora's eyes, when she runs her hands over her chest, that Catra catches when she throws a swift look to Adora's face in the mirror. It's an expression inside her eyes that speaks of fear and shivering defenceless, like she had been stripped suddenly of all her armor and barriers and was now standing another kind of bare and open in front of Catra. And the last realizes that she isn't the only one that is feeling this way, too much, too fast, too important.

Adora turns, facing Catra completely. She is not trembling anymore but without all her clothes she looks awkward inside her own skin, like a baby giraffe giving her first steps. Catra looks at her too, locking their eyes together. Her face still feels warm and red because of Adora's seemingly absolute lack of decency, but that doesn't matter right now. Catra sighs, letting the sweater fall over the mattress without tearing her eyes from Adora's.

"They are weird, right? Human- limbs." Catra wrinkles her nose at herself. There it goes again, the feeling that she is an awkward teenager and not a grown ass adult.

Adora doesn't bat an eye, just staring at Catra, opening and closing her hands at her sides. Catra takes a breath and holds it, giving a careful step forward. Adora doesn't move away, quite the contrary, her eyebrows raise and she gives a step too, mirroring Catra, then another, this one more hesitant than the last. It's Catra who breaks the bridge, in wide steps until she reaches her, opening her arms at the same time Adora lets herself fall against her, wrapping her arms loosely over Catra's waist. Catra huffs a little against the weight but keeps them both steady, rubbing her palms over the skin of her shoulder blades and nestling Adora's face against her neck. Adora's breath tickles the skin of her nape and she is very cold, something Catra has started to take as something normal about her. It's fine, it cools the feverishness of her own skin, standing on point with goosebumps.

"You are- very clingy like this, aren't you?" whispers Catra against the silk of her hair. Adora doesn't move and neither does Catra, just rocking her gently from side to side. She doesn't know exactly what she did to have gained her trust, of this mythical creature, but she is definitely not against it. And she is definitely not going to break it. Catra just doesn't seem to have a filter when it comes to her.

Catra has never been like this with anyone else, definitely not with family, not with the scarce friends that she managed to keep, and much less with the very few relationships she tried to have and that didn't even got to this. She is not used to it, the physical affection, the tender touch. All the physical touch she ever got in the foster home was always harsh, most of the times painful. And now here she is with a woman that could very much kill her with a single blow if she wanted too, yet she is holding her so tenderly, curling around Catra as if this was the only place she felt safe in right now. After a little while, Catra's breathe starts to speed up

and her throat to close, the first signs of overwhelming anxiety starting to drown her out. Catra palms her softly in the upper arms, parting from Adora reluctantly but fully, putting some breathable space between them, inspecting the purple shade of her bruises and the red of the wound, less swollen now than yesterday but still angry and painful.

"Are you in pain?," asks Catra, frowning. Adora shakes her head in *no* . Catra grimaces, not believing her at all but Adora just shakes her head again, this time more fervently so Catra just rolls her eyes at her, taking her shaky hands away. Adora's arms, still wrapped loosely around her slip and fall to the sides, sadly. Catra can feel her own barriers building up again as she tears her eyes from Adora's, walking to the open door with muted steps.

"You can change into that. I need to check on the milk before it catches fire" Adora's eyebrows knit together in confused distraught that tears Catra's heart cords into shreds but she keeps walking away from her anyway, grabbing the frame of the door so hard her fingers hurt. She just needs to step out, just for a moment, and breathe. *Away* . "I'll see you downstairs. If you need help just- drop something in the floor or something."

Adora opens her mouth, as if she was going to say something, but Catra is already turning away, leaving Adora just standing there and speeding down the stairs without looking at her again. The sad hum of a song it's the only thing that follows her back.



Catra finishes serving the hot chocolate on her biggest mugs. Whipped cream, marshmallows and chocolate chips, a true bomb if you mind. Another perk of having to work several jobs during college, you get really good at making hot chocolate when you work in coffee shops, in the winter, until late at night.

The old fairytale book of her grandmother lays open in the counter, illustrated pages illuminated by the sunbeams that pour from the windows. Carvings on paper of beautiful people, surrounded by water and sea foam, born from coral and sand. Some of them turned into hauntingly beautiful forms, creatures of the depths with blind eyes and neon scales, others shimmering like the evening sun with poisonous thorns and fins like silks. Sharks, seals, dolphins, whales, octopus, Catra has lost count of how alike they look to some of those animals and how different they seem too. Other pages present yellowed sketches of these very same creatures changed into humans, scales falling from their skins, teeth shrinking. Stepping out of the waters bare and smooth, dragging behind them silks full of precious scales, pearls and sea glass.

No, not silks.

Skins

Catra taps on the surface of the counter in a grounding motion, waiting for Adora. She hasn't heard from her since she ran away from her. Guilt and shame is pooling in her stomach and yet she doesn't dare to walk back up and go for her. In the end, Catra doesn't need to.

Adora appears from the other side of the corridor in deadly silent steps, looking around her with her brows furrowed. Catra realized a while ago with a pang of guilt that she didn't even

stay to check if she knew how to put her clothes, but Adora seems to have figured it out on her own. Or maybe, Catra thinks, Adora knew quite a few more things that she gave her credit for.

Adora reaches the counter and flops into the chair, her long legs hanging from the edge and into the floor. Her straight nose is pointing to the sky and her shoulders are thrown back, almond eyes narrowed and serious, that cold expression she had when Catra found her first hidden inside her bathtub back into her handsome features.

Why is she angry now?

"Here," Catra pushes the steaming mug in Adora's direction, taking the other one between her hands. Adora huffs and rolls her eyes, not even looking at her, resting her chin over her closed fist with a scoff, ignoring the mug completely. Catra's shoulders tense, feeling the waves of offense starting to creep in her palms. That, until she catches the look inside Adora's eyes, the corners pulled a little bit down, shimmering in wet shine.

She is not angry, she is offended but she is also sad. Because I-

" I'm- sorry for leaving," Catra feels like she has been saying more I'm sorry's in the last twelve than the last twenty five years of her life. But Adora's eyes shot swiftly towards her and then away again, her head tilting a little to the side. She is listening. "You are just- a lot," admits Catra, wincing when Adora cringes a little, her back dropping. Catra leaves the mug back down with a clank, rushing to explain. "Not in a bad way, but- I'm not used to- not being alone. It's always been me against the world. But you are here now and I feel-"

- *like it's not only me anymore, like I care about you.*

Catra doesn't say it, letting her voice trail off, but her gaze remains strong in Adora's, hoping this sea foam creature somehow understands her better than all the people before in Catra's life.

She does. Adora drops her chin from her fist, resting both palms over the marble counter. The look in her eyes has changed again into something softer, the corner of her lips twitching into a barely visible smile. One of her arms extends towards Catra's, barely brushing the skin of her hand. Catra presses her lips together until they are nothing but a fine line, breathing hard, but Adora only nods, once. Catra turns her hand over, palm up, exhaling when Adora's rubs the cold pad of her finger over Catra's palm in tight circles, fixing her gaze against hers heavily, full of meaning. *I'm sorry, too.*

Catra gapes at her, trying and failing to wheeze any kind of sound, to tell her that she shouldn't be the one apologizing, but Adora is already taking her long hand away, taking the mug between them instead. She hasn't even said anything at all, but Catra doesn't feel pressured, relaxing against the furniture of the kitchen. It's a small truce and allows Catra to breathe and think clearly, even over the persistent tickle inside her hand.

Adora takes her eyes away from Catra's just so she can take a long sip of hot chocolate, not even grimacing against the heat of the liquid. Catra looks with raised eyebrows, expecting. Adora’s eyes shot like fireworks to the sky, her mouth falling open in a perfect “o”. Even her

skin seems to flicker and shimmer, delicate golden scales sprouting on her cheeks, reflecting the sunlight that slips from underneath the curtains. Catra giggles, so low Adora doesn't even hear her, and takes a sip of her hot chocolate too, feeling her bones melt with the delicious heat and sweetness.

"Okay," Catra sits down in the chair opposite to Adora, separated by the long counter between them. Catra runs a hand over her matted hair -she really needs a shower- and then brushes her fingers over the pages of the old book. "Adora, I'm going to ask you some questions. You can just nod or shake your head to answer, alright? This is important."

Catra puts emphasis on the last, fixing her mismatched eyes with Adora's. She is halfway through her mug, whipped cream smudged on her upper lip and the tip of her nose. Catra blows out the air of her lungs, the warmth of the chocolate -and definitely only the chocolate- crawling over her own cheeks. Adora rubs the back of her sleeve across her face, resting her forearms over the counter with a steady look on her eyes. Catra hums to herself, rubbing the corner of one of the book's pages between her fingers.

"Are you a human?" Adora's eyes harden just a little, eyebrows stoic on her forehead. There is a small moment and then a shake of the head. Fine, Catra already knew that, she just needed to ask any way. "Are you- from the sea?" Nod. Catra blows the air she is holding, running her fingers through the illustrated pages. It creeps her out a little, that her grandmother left her a book with the answers she is looking for. But yet again, it seems her grandma wasn't a conventional woman at all. "Do you have a name for it?"

Hesitation. Adora grimaces a little but nods, the silk of her hair slipping from behind her ears. Catra's fingers twitch, eager to learn forward and put it back into place.

"What is it?" Blank. Silence. Adora blinks at her slowly, unsure. Her mouth twitches in the corners, the pearl white of her blunt teeth peaking just below the skin on her lip when she opens her mouth just a little. Her chest constricts, air slipping from her lungs when she exhales and then wheezes. It's harsh and tiring and definitely exhausting, it *hurts* hearing it, like sandpaper against the rocks or nails in glass. Adora and Catra wince at the same time, Adora from the pain, Catra from hearing her hurted throat forcing itself trying to speak.

"Don't, Adora, don't" Adora shoots her a frustrated look, wheezing again, almost offended. The screaming from yesterday must have hurted her vocal cords pretty badly, or maybe she is not used to it all. After all, under the sea her breathing comes from the fine fins Catra saw on the shore, and her song comes from somewhere even deeper, like it is pouring out of her pores and not her mouth. Catra shakes her head to the sides frowning deeply and holding her ground at Adora's displeased snarl. "You don't need to hurt yourself to speak to me, Adora. I'm not letting you do that, so don't go and be a self-sacrificing stubborn ass with me, alright? "

Adora scoffs, wrinkling her nose. She looks away, peeking from the corner of her eye at Catra several times but her snarl gives up, dropping from her face as she nods. Catra smiles, victorious. "There, good siren" Catra flushes pink with her own words but Adora doesn't seem to notice her slip of the tongue, the endearment bouncing between them. Though, Adora's cheeks do color in a soft shade of peach. Catra clears her throat, looking away from Adora with her face burning. "Fine, then. Is this your first time in land- like this?"

Adora's expression sparks again, shaking her head to the sides firmly once. *I figured,* think Catra. Adora is curious and clumsy and she wears her clothes inside out but she also knows how to read and understands Catra and knows what some things are.

"Is this your longest time like this?" Adora's eyebrows furrow, her big eyes wrinkling in sorrow. She nods, a shadow of melancholy falling over her. Catra leans automatically towards her, absently, like a magnet.

"Adora, did you lose something?" Adora's eyes harden, that shadow still obscuring her pale eyelashes and making the bright blue of her eyes look almost silver. Catra grabs the books between her hands and spins it on the counter, pushing it softly in Adora's direction. She taps on the illustrations with her index, following the inked lines as Adora leans in and fixates her gaze on them too.

"Humans tell tales about sea creatures. Sirens, mermaids, selkies and so many other names, that's how you are called here. It's said that they would walk out of the seas and oceans and transform into beautiful people, capable of blending among humans. They became very famous for their beauty and songs, luring people with them to drag them to the depths and devour them," Adora's nose wrinkles adorably at that, huffing to the paper and then frowning at Catra, definitely offended. Catra shrugs, stocking her tongue out at her without a real bite behind it. "Hey, I didn't write it. Besides, most of those stories are written by men, so they are nothing to take seriously."

Catra changes the page, circling the drawing of a selkie, their face and torso human, their waist and legs blending with the smooth curves of a seal's body. Stepping out of the waters in swirls of seafoam. She rubs the paper over the skin's drawing almost ceremoniously, gently, careful of speaking softly but without losing the sudden urgency in her voice. "Is this it, Adora? Did you- did you lose your skin?" Adora's eyes flash, gripping the sides of the books so hard the cover protest on her hold. She drags her eyes from the book to Catra, silver against turquoise and gold. "Is that why you can't transform? Is that why you can't go back?

Adora breaks her eyes from Catra's, pressing her lips into a tight line. Her cheeks hollow a little and Catra knows she is chewing the inside of her cheek, like Catra sometimes does when she is overwhelmed, looking through the open window and towards the sea. The waves crash against the shore, they aren't as virulent as last night but their pull is still strong, mixing sand and pebbles. Her expression has melted into something sorrowful, lilac bags under her eyes. There are invisible dry tear tracks on her cheeks, glimmering under the evening light, proof of hours of silent crying and mourning. Her heartbroken face shatters Catra's heart in pieces. Adora goes still for a long time, until the sun is lower in the sky and Catra's mug has gone cold next to her elbow, the last not able to take her eyes apart as Adora's mind works itself. She can practically hear the gears inside her brain turn and twist. Finally, after what feels like a whole eternity later, Adora tilts her golden head to Catra and gives a final nod, just one. *Yes* .

Catra exhales, following Adora's sight and into the gray sea. She understands it, feeling alone in a place you don't know, being afraid, hopeless. Used for someone else's purposes. Feeling like the world has been ripped out from you without your permission. In Adora's case, it was quite literal.

"I'll help you out," Catra feels the way Adora's eyes turn to her but she doesn't return the look. She can't lose focus now. She knows what it feels like when everything is taken away from you, she knows the pain, and she doesn't want Adora to suffer it. Not her. She doesn't know why, she just knows this is how things are. Catra will help her find her skin and then she will be gone too, lost among the waves and the deep blue sea.

"Look, I know what it's like losing it all, it fucking sucks. And I've also spent a lot of time here on my own. I know the tides, *you* know the tides, and they sometimes bury things under the sands or among the rocks." Adora's gaze is still heavy on her face, making Catra stutter and trip miserably with her own words. Catra looks down at the book, in the illustration next to the selkies, a man ripping them out of their skins to keep them with him in land forever. She feels suddenly sick to her stomach. "Listen, I know you don't have any reason to trust me at all, much less after what you lived yesterday. And I'm- I'm difficult, to live with, to talk with. I've hurt many people and I ran with the wrong kind for a long time. I'm actually a horrible person. But you have to believe me when I say that I'm not doing this because I want to keep you here with me and only with me against your will or some bullshit like that, and I'm not expecting to get anything in return. I'll help you look for your skin and you can stay here until then- *if* you want to. You can sleep in my room, ruin my pipes, use my clothes. As long as you are somewhere safe in case those morons return and until we find your skin, it is good enough for me. Deal?"

Catra finally, *finally,* returns Adora's gaze, already brazed for whatever she may see there.

Adora is soft, Catra has come to the conclusion. She is gentle but she is also strong, really fucking strong and stubborn. She fought for her life and she was brave and, somehow, she trusted Catra to help her. She *trusts* her, present time. Adora smiles at Catra, all loopy and big and Catra can see the small gap on her front teeth, so incredibly endearing. Adora drops the edges of the book, stretching over the counter until she reaches Catra's hand, which she hadn't realized had balled at some point into a tight fist over the marble. Adora rubs her cold fingers over her knuckles, turning the fist around until Catra opens her hand, sweaty and pink like a flower. Just as before, Adora rubs the pads of her fingers over Catra's palm, feather touch, smiling at her wider when Catra looks from their touching hands to her silver eyes. Catra's fingers twitch and bend forward, tangling with Adora's into a loose hold.

"I'll look out for you" Catra hears herself say in a whisper. Adora's pupils shine in blue as she tightens their hold further, squeezing softly once before letting go completely, retracting her hand over the counter just slightly.

There is a pang in Catra's chest and she feels mildly hurt for a long second, sudden rejection and anger bubbling in her throat. That, until she catches the emotion in Adora's eyes, open and honest, her hand close enough to hers, still leaning slightly towards Catra. She is not walking away, she is giving Catra enough space to breath, just like she asked her to. Catra's chest constricts again, this time for a completely different reason.

Among the revolution inside her brain -and heart and guts-, an errand thought tugs to her vocal cords. "I'm Catra, by the way. Well, um, Catrina," Catra scowls at herself, both for the verbal vomit and the clear infatuation in her voice. Adora just blinks, the hint of amusement,

adorable dimples marking on her bruised cheeks. "Just Catra. Grayskull. Like the cliff outside."

Catra points loosely to the shape of the cliff outside the windows, beet red in the face. Adora tilts her head a little to the side, thinking hard until her eyes cross a little. Then she starts humming, a little tune that picks up and turns into a soft melody and then an even softer lullaby. It's short, just enough to make Catra's ears ring pleasantly and her breathing to calm down. The hum ends as quickly as it came, leaving the kitchen into a calm suspended moment. Catra gulps, rubbing her upper arm with her other hand.

"Is that-" *get a grip of yourself, Catra.* "Is that my name? On your language?"

Adora nods brightly, a self-sufficient smirk shimmering in her peach lips. Catra wonders if she knows exactly what she is doing to Catra. If she is doing it on purpose. If it has something to do with being a siren. If it means anything at all. In the foster home, Catra learned that everything good came always at a price. It was a business. Give and take, nothing was ever incondictional. Yet in the last day Catra has given more heartfelt apologizes than ever -Catra doesn't apologize-, and given back respect and space and gentleness by someone who is unaproachable, someone who is beyond Catra's reach. *Someone you don't deserve* , murmurs a dark voice on her mind, one that sounds too much like her foster carer.

Catra holds her breath, biting down in her tongue harsh, looking to chase the shadows that creep for her past away. Adora is still giving her those big does eyes, her brow furrowed a little in the middle. Wondering. From one instant to the other Catra gets pretty self aware that she hasn't showered since yesterday's morning and that she must look more like a drowned fish than anything else. Catra swift in motion -she is really good to bury her feelings into any kind of work- sprinting out of her chair and to the exit of the kitchen, on the complete opposite side of the counter from Adora.

"I really need to shower. Right this moment." Catra basically jumps over the chairs, heading to the first floor bathroom with wide steps. Adora doesn't raise from the chair but she does turn over the seat, following Catra with her eyes. "We'll go to the shore after. There is dry meat in the shelves if you are hungry." Adora's feet tap on the floor, distracting her from Catra. She tippy taps over the cold wood floor, huffing in amusement at her toes extending over the ground. She seems to be fasinated by human bodies having actual nails on their toes too.

"Okay," Catra flushes, murmuring to herself, spinning on the corner of the corridor and speeding towards the bathroom, slipping slightly with the small carpet in the floor. Adora's huff, that she has come to identify as a low laughter following behind. Catra doesn't notice it but her head has long stopped from aching.



"Fuck" Catra curses under her breathe, holding the raincoat closer to herself, water soaking her pants up to her thighs.

It's not raining per se, but the breeze coming from the sea is freezing, sticking on Catra's face and hair. The tide is high, not on its biggest point, but definitely enough to reach Catra's

knees if she stands as still as she can in the slippery sand, packed with pebbles and sea glass. The sun is lower in the sky, washing the water and rocks and house in golden light.

Catra pulls out her phone from the front pocket of her coat, lighting up the screen to watch the tides' map Bow had sent her once, when they very first met, so she would learn the highest tide hours and avoid them on her wonders through the shore -. Catra will never admit it, but that little colorful map had probably saved her ass from drowning quite a few times.

When they arrived at the shore, Adora had peered at the screen from behind Catra's shoulder, eyebrows raised and hands tucked inside the sleeves of the cardigan Catra had handed to her, her sweet breath against her neck making Catra almost lose her balance completely. They had a bit of a struggle about the phone before going out. Adora found the shiny thing when it started vibrating with Catra's medicines' alarm and proceeded to pick on the bright screen with a *bop bop bop* that sounded more like the wheezing of a half dying seagull than something else. And then, another thirty minutes of Catra trying to explain miserably and on the best of her possibilities what a phone and, worst of all, what internet was. As it turns out, Adora hates the strident sound of the alarms but she is really fond of the bright colors of videos, her pupils blown out in amaze at the moving figures in the tiny screen. It reminded Catra a little of those internet videos of cats playing with little fishes on the screens.

Now, Catra is halfway kneeling in the sand between the rocks she found Adora in, studying the map, comparing it with her clock and the setting sun in the sky. They don't have much to search for Adora's skin, probably just a half an hour more before the moon starts to rise and the tide grows impossibly high. It really is a miracle that neither of them drowned last night with the storm on top of it.

Catra clicks her tongue against her teeth, putting her phone back inside her coat with a grunt. Her other hand rises from inside the water, wet sand slipping through her empty fingers. Catra didn't even know how a skin was suppose to look like -armed with only an oldy fairytale book and Adora's fallen scales as a reference - but she knew it would be one chance in a hundred being able to find Adora's skin on the first look, but still, it makes Catra highly annoyed to come empty handed back to Adora. The last had stopped looking a little bit ago, after walking for the last three hours up and down the entire shore of Catra's land, barefoot and waist deep inside the sea.

She had almost thrown herself at the waves at the beginning, eyes sparkling, dragging the sand and pebbles from side to side, looking. It had scared Catra a little bit at the beginning, that she would want to swim too deep inside the water, too far from where Catra could reach her. Catra didn't know how any of this worked, didn't know if Adora could swim at all, much less breath too profound inside the water. But Adora has stayed in sight the entire time, mouth pressed in a progressively deeper frown as the hours went by, the spark in her eyes washing away first with annoyance and then with despair. It made Catra want to scream.

Catra stands from her place between the rocks, scanning the shore for Adora. She is sitting over the flat top of one of the dark rocks close to the path that leads to the house, her knees close to the chest, arms wrapped around them. Her hair floats around her face with the sea breeze, making her eyes look pensative and far as she looks over the ocean. Catra can see the way her muscles twitch and her skin itches to get inside the water.

Catra inhales, wobbling through the sand until she manages to reach Adora, standing hesitantly next to the rock. She worries her bottom lip between her teeth, looking at the side of Adora's beautiful face before exhaling, roaming inside her mind trying to find anything to say.

"Alright. I found you in those rocks down there. I guess it's a good start as any other" Catra points at the north, to the sharp stones near to the base of the cliff where she just was. The waves crash over them, reaching only half way of their height. It's taller than what Catra feels comfortable with but she can't complain, not with Adora looking expectantly and hopefully at the group of dark rocks, eyebrows raised. Catra shifts on her feet. "We'll probably have better luck in the morning, when the tide is lower and we can look deeper inside the shore."

Adora's shoulders and eyes fall and she looks away, resting her chin over her knees with a huff. The cold air makes her cheeks and nose to color in red and her golden hair whip behind her like a halo, ruffling in the top like a funny looking puff and sticking on her pale eyelashes. The baby curls at the sides of her face tremble gently with the wind. Even the fine hair on her cheeks is standing with goosebumps. She still looks for the worse, covered in sticky pads and bandages, clearly still fumbling with her long legs and feet, wobbling from side to side every time she takes a step. Catra tears her eyes from her, undoing the cords of her raincoat and taking it off completely just so she can place it over Adora's shoulders. Catra has to stretch a bit to reach her in all her height over the rock but at the end she is able to cover Adora with it, pulling the mustard fabric around Adora to shelter her from the cold.

Adora looks at her from the corner of her eyes, not moving from her position but bringing the warm raincoat closer to herself, her hair still whipping around her face. Catra catches one of the blonde strands between her fingers, absently running the silked hair over her skin. Catra sighs, the air leaving through her teeth with a low sizzle as she walks behind the rock Adora is in, running her fingers gently over Adora's long hair before start twisting it together into a loose, beautiful braid that falls over Adora's back into a more comfortable, organized honey mess. Catra can feel the way Adora's breathing shutters under Catra's fingers, still scrunched over herself, tension slowly but surely slipping off her shoulders. Catra secures the long braid with one of the errand bands she always has in her wrists, hands shivering unsure over Adora's shoulder blades before letting them fall still to her sides, walking precariously back to Adora's face.

"Let's go home, alright?" Catra asks in the gentlest of voices, offering her hand to her hesitantly, almost as if she wasn't sure if Adora would take it at all.

Adora looks at Catra's hand for a long moment, dragging her eyes to the sea, expression far away before blinking the silver mist from them, returning to Catra's face. The light of the sunset makes Adora look golden and ethereal to Catra's eyes as she slips her cold hand inside Catra's warm palm, tangling their fingers together tightly. Catra helps her down the rock, splashing water all around as they make their way through the beach and inside the house again.

Catra takes off her boots and soaked socks, tossing them aside unceremoniously next to the door. A problem for future Catra. Then she grabs the dry towel she had left by the stairs and

hands it to Adora, helping her keep her balance as she dabs it awkwardly over her wet feet and ankles.

Adora is quiet. Not in the speaking sense, of course, in another complete, different way. She is still gripping the sides of the raincoat close to her and her eyes are far away, thoughtful and mourning. Still, her strong jaw is set, teeth clenching with each other, nose up. She is scared but she hasn't given up yet, a blatant sense of rebellion pouring out of her as she approaches the living room, taking in all the items there with the kind of expression of someone that doesn't know what she is doing but that will do it regardless. It makes Catra smile behind her.

Catra follows her behind, dropping in the hard couch with a grunt, her hand falling between her hands as Adora inspects the books and trinkets in the bookcases opposite to the fireplace, running her fingers over the colorful spines. The corners of her lips are still pulled down and her eyes are sad but she is also curious, tapping over hard covers and tiny sea glass Catra had recollected with time.

There is just one picture in a frame in the bookcases, of Melog when they were five months old and still looked like a little spicy kitten. There were more, when she arrived, of Razz years younger and also years older, smiling, waving, picking up rocks from the sea. Others are of a woman that looks so much like Catra, holding a little baby on the shore in front of the house. She is also smiling in all of the photos, the tip of her canine catching on her bottom lip when she smiles like Catra does when she herself smiles. And many others. Catra couldn't bear having them there, looking at them every single day. Not yet. So she took them out and put them carefully inside a box on the bottom of the bookcase, hidden away for later, much later. Adora's foot brushes over the corner of the box when she rises on her tippy toes, taking one of the books between her hands.

Catra groans, taking her phone out again to continue her search. She doesn't know exactly what a siren's skin should look like. There are many pages on the internet talking about selkies and their seal-like skins, soft like silks and grey or white at the eyes. And many many blogs discussing what a siren's tail would look like. Maybe dark like those fishes from the deep sea, not really attractive at the eyes but strong and thick. Maybe neon, green and blue and many other colors, shimmering under the light. Maybe it's full of poisonous thorns or knife sharp scales. There are thousands of people hypothesizing, from the scholar to the fan to the weird guy writing weird things that makes Catra roll her eyes and want to throw her phone to the other side of the house.

There is a small bustle next to her feet and Catra rises her head in time to look at Adora, who has sat over the floor close to Catra with a curious expression in her eyes. She is holding a book in her hands, pushing it softly against her knee to call Catra's attention. The cover is dark, with swirls of gold and creepy but beautiful eldritch illustrations in the cover. Catra knows this book, she knows it by memory, she wrote passages of it under her blankets for twelve years.

"That's my book," says Catra, voice strained. Adora knits her eyebrows together, confused. "I mean, I created it, I *wrote* that." Adora's confusion melts into understanding and then excitement, grabbing the thick book with both hands with a sparkle in her blue eyes. She is

still tense in the shoulders but her sadness has washed away a little. She seems determined to make the best of what is happening to her. It makes Catra flush.

"It's horror and fantasy" Catra rushes out, chewing the inside of her cheek as Adora runs her fingers through the soft pages. "Not really- not really a happy ending. I'm not a romance writer."

Adora looks back at her with one elegant eyebrow lifted, an expression of incredulity in her eyes. There is a smirk in her mouth, popping the dimples in her cheeks as she looks at Catra with the kind of expression of someone that smells bullshit. Catra huffs at her, shoving her aside softly with her feet, making Adora fall into a small fit of wheezing laughter, out of breath and harsh.

Catra watches her get comfortable over the carpet, playing a little with the loose threads over the floor. The light of the night lamps makes her clear patches of skin look golden and cream, braid falling over one of her shoulders and brushing her waist, bruises still scattering her skin here and there. Catra presses her lips together and leans forwards a little, her hand hovering close to Adora's shoulders.

"Adora," Adora turns to her with lifted eyebrows, the book already open over her knees. Catra gulps, taking back her hand and placing it over her own knees, scratching the ripped fabric there nervously. The movement doesn't go unnoticed for Adora. "We *are* going to find your skin, Adora. You know that, right? I'm keeping my promise."

Adora blinks back at her, considering, before nodding slowly and hesitant at first and then firm and sure, rubbing the side of her face against Catra's knee just to return swiftly back to the book. It's too much. Catra wheezes, and absolutely inelegant sound that makes Adora snap back her attention towards Catra, eyebrows frunced in concern.

"Why are you trusting me so much?" bursts out Catra, voice trembling. Her hand balls into a fist over her knees, knuckles white with the effort. Adora's pretty eyes widen in surprise, mouth agape is seemingly confusion that only makes Catra feel even more on the edge.

"I'm not a big deal, Adora. I don't know about science or myths or geography. I don't even know how to swim. How am I supposed to help you like this?" Catra feels the words trilling with each other as they leave her mouth, sticky and self deprecating. They don't sound like her voice, they sounds like someone else completely, an older woman with dark hair and dark heart and dark words, poisoning Catra's heart from the inside out. Catra can't make them stop. "I don't know how to live with someone else, I don't even know how to live with myself. I've done bad things and hurt people that cared about me, pushed them away. I'm not *good* , Adora. I've never been anything good at all for anyone in my entire life. I- huff!"

Catra cuts herself short, words quiet against the large, pale hand pressed firmly over her mouth. Adora's upper body is stretched towards her, her torso halfway over Catra's knees, face almost at the same high as Catra's. Adora's eyes are dark and serious, pupils blown wide, black against bright blue like an eclipse. Her mouth is pulled down in the corners, face acid and stone cold as she keeps her fingers against Catra's lips, firmly.

Catra exhales against her palm, knitting her eyebrows together, confusion mixed with sharp offense. Adora looks at her intently, taking her hand away after some tense moments just so she can press her forehead against Catra's, humming low on her throat.

"I can't understand you, Adora," Catra says with a hint of exhasperation in her voice. She is trembling too, she notices when Adora's cold skin brushes against hers, her arms and hands twitching without her permission, blatant proof of her anxiety eating Catra alive. Adora's humming deepens, resting both of her hands at the sides of Catra's face, the book forgotten in the couch next to them. Catra gasps, clenching her teeth as she snaps her head to the side, trying and failing to escape Adora's sudden, gentle touch. "No, Adora, listen. This is not- I'm not good enough for you to trust me so- so *quick.* I'm not- *I'm* not enough for you to stay."

Wow, whispers some deep part inside Catra's mind. *Where is this all coming from?*

It came from the inexistent pictures in the bookcase. From the days and night in the foster home, yelled at, hit at, abandoned, always alone. It comes from years of self destruction, failing friendships, failing relationships, convincing herself that she wasn't worth the time or the effort, that she wasn't enough to be important for someone. Writing allow her to escape for a while but it was always there, in the shadows of her own monsters. Catra had come to learned to accept it. Lose it all before you can even have it. Win battles, losing the war. Catra was fine with that, living like this until it kills her.

Adora doesn't seem to agree.

Catra will never know what Adora saw inside her eyes that night, Adora will never tell her. Maybe it was desperation, loneliness. The craving of giving all the love she has tucked inse the depths of her heart and being loved in return just as strongly. Just as loyal. Maybe it was fear. Of failing Adora, who she has just met for a day. Of failing herself. Maybe it was something else completely. Whatever it is, it sets Adora in motion.

She drops her hands from Catra's face just so she can place them at the side on the couch, levering herself from the floor clumsily, still unsure of her limbs when she moves too fast too suddenly. Catra stares at her in silence, body tense as a cord about to snap and run away as she always has done. Adora doesn't even allow it to her. She climbs to the couch and then *over* Catra's lap, throwing her long legs -still mildly wet with seawater- over Catra's and wrapping her arms around her torso and upper arms, positively pinning Catra in the couch with her own body like a siren weighted blanket.

Catra struggles, automatically. She can't help it, Catra is not used to this, the gentle embrace. Even Scorpia learned, quite quickly in their times in college, that touching Catra was basically out of the table. Catra has been trying for years to make it better, but being alone all of those years too doesn't help it either. Nobody wants to hold on to someone that acts like a furious cat every time she is touched. Nobody but a sea creature, just as sharp and alone and scared.

"Adora" Catra mutters, teeth clenching, digging her nails in the skin of her own palms, anchoring her to the spark of pain there. "Adora, what are you doing?"

Adora notices. She takes her hands swiftly from around Catra's chest just so she can grab both of Catra's between them, bringing them up and nestling them between them. Then she presses her forehead against Catra again, looking at her with heavy meaning. Catra's bottom lip trembles and she can feel her nose getting red and damp with the first treacherous signs of burning tears. She bites them down, breathing hard from her nose.

"You don't even know me, Adora, I'm not worth it," Catra tries under her breath. Adora grunts, tightening her hold on Catra's hands and bumping her nose over Catra's jaw. Catra exhales, tensing once more before allowing herself to melt away. The dark thoughts start to wash away from her heart and mind, not disappearing completely -not yet, it will take months, years to really go away- but allowing Catra to breathe away, melting against Adora's cold body around her. "Okay, okay," murmurs Catra against Adora's cheek, shivering when she balls over her, tucking Catra's head under her chin. Adora likes to sleep like this, Catra thinks in an absent thought filled by drowsy memories of last night, curled over and tight.

"I'm going to be better," whispers Catra after a while. She doesn't know of she is talking to Adora or to herself anymore. Later she will stand with numb limbs and numb heart and make food for both and she will scowl herself the entire night because she doesn't know *what the fuck is going on* , heart and its hard armor cracking and opening in too, pouring all of into Adora's cold hands. Catra will scowl at herself and wonder why is she doing all of this with a woman -a siren- she literally just met. And she will try to ignore the tug inside her heart that drives her to Adora like a magnet, the same way it drive her to look out of the window and walk out of the house that stormy night. But that will be later and it will be a problem for future Catra.

For now, Adora hums against her head, a rumble that starts in her chest and vibrates on Catra's cheek where is resting over her collarbones. The rumble shifts and changes, turning into an otherworldly melody, soft enough that only Catra can hear it. Adora leans over Catra, reaching the abandoned book and tucking it open against one of her bend knees, reading and singing until Catra can't remember who was supposed to be comforting who.

Cares lets her eyes fall close, slipping into a deep sleep, quiet and calm as she has never sleep before, the sound of Adora's fast beating heart as her only anchor to the world.



Life goes on for them for the next couple of weeks, falling into a familiar rhythm easily, like puzzle pieces that fit perfectly together. Like an old song that you hear again after so many years and you still remember the lyrics. Like an old house that still feels familiar when you step inside it again after months away.

This is how their days go. Catra gives Adora her room, changing shredded sheets into comfortable blankets and pillows, broken lamps into bulbs in the chandelier -Catra doesn't trust Adora with candles after she almost burns her own eyebrows off getting too close too fast and too curious to the fire. The room still stinks a little like burn hair -. Bath always filed with cold water and salt, rinsed and changed every single day because Catra refuses having a seaweed plague growing inside her tube no matter how much Adora wrinkles her nose and pouts at her. Catra camps in the big couch of the living room and it sucks major ass, but she never let's Adora know. Her back and ribs hurt from the strained position and it's definitely

colder than upstairs but it was the best Catra came up with in a short amount of time, curled up on the bottom on the hard foam of the couch every night. She could have stayed in the room too, she thought many times grumbling to herself, with how clingy and soft Adora seemed to be around her. But Catra didn't think she could survive it, not so soon, not maybe at all. So, the couch it is. As it turns out, Adora also takes a little to get used to a human room. Catra can hear her walking around the bedroom's floor at unholy hours of the night, sometimes knocking things over -she is getting better at controlling her legs, which is an improvement, but she still is naturally, endearing clumsy- humming softly the same melody over and over that echoes across the entire house and that finally helps Catra fall asleep.

Catra starts waking up every day before dawn, tired as fuck. Catra hates waking up early. Being a writer had made her fall into a comfortable and a little bit unhealthy habit of falling asleep late and waking up even later. As many things since Adora came to her life, Catra was finding herself doing things she hadn't done before, ever. So there was that too.

It wasn't too bad, Catra discovered, still complaining all the way every day to the shore. She loves to watch the dawn from the beach -though maybe not the biting cold and freezing water-, and the pink and golden reflection of the sun over the water. The quiet, the calm. Catra walks until dawn across the sand, searching for anything that may resemble or lead her to Adora's skin, moving the sand and pebbles around with poles, climbing precariously the high, dark rocks and searching between the sharp corners, all of it without much luck. Catra scowls and grumbles, worry every day more and more that the sea had actually washed the skin away and buried her to the deep. And Catra would also shake her head and groan because it can't be that easy, it can be how this story goes, without noise, without a fight, without being something *more* like Adora's mere existence is. And if Catra is something that is resilient and stubborn.

After dawn Catra returns inside the house with her shoulders still fallen, just in time to wash her face and hair from the cold and the sand and prepare a charged coffee for herself and tea for Adora before she wakes up. The last rushes excitedly down the stairs, the first days like a newborn doe, slowly but surely, the next days steadier, ready to go out and search in the sand again, completely unaware of Catra's earlier stroll, or the smell of sea breeze in her hair. Catra knows Adora doesn't know she goes out every morning. That 's alright. Catra would follow her inside the sea every day for the rest of her life if Adora asked her too. Catra scowls to herself and serves Adora her tea and sardines, mumbling under her breath. Day after day.

In the evening Catra tries to write, sitting in front of her laptop with an everlasting frustrated snarl, words escaping her completely, trying to ignore the calls from Spinerella. Adora spends hours upstairs, holding her breath under the water of the bath until her lungs can do it anymore, just to rest her chin over the porcelain edge with heavy eyes when she has to take her head out and take a shivering, cold breath. It scared the shit out of Catra the first time she found her like that, completely submerged underwater. It's better now, Catra it's almost out of salt and the look in Adora's eyes every time she gets out of the water and walks back into the living room still breaks her heart but it's better.

Adora likes to make herself a tight ball on the comfortable couch near the fireplace, tucked below blankets with Catra's books in her hands, reading avidly, making small sounds every

time she reads something she likes. It runs a shiver down Catra's spine every day, rising goosebumps on her arms. Endearment, maybe. Pride, absolutely.

Catra is getting better at it, too, existing around Adora. The morning after her breakdown of that first day it was uncomfortable for Catra. She was on edge the entire morning, ashamed of her own feelings and vulnerability in front of a siren that probably didn't know better than getting stuck alone in the only house next to the shore with a traumatized woman. By the time Adora woke up, Catra was spiraling badly, until the last smiled at her, bright and calm, allowing Catra to breathe easily and without judgement. After all, Catra had also held Adora's shivering crying body in her arms.

All of it, every day, rinse and repeat.

It should worry Catra, how *calm* she is with all of this. She is surprising herself, actually. Finding a siren, saving her, letting her live under her roof, going out to search for her skin. Allowing herself to be- a little bit more of *herself* . Less sharp and angry.

She has been laughing more too, Catra notices about herself, one afternoon in the attic, roaming alongside Adora among the dusty boxes Razz had tucked in there with the years. Catra had been looking around the entire house for anything else besides the book Razz had left behind, anything at all that could help her find Adora's skin. Adora had found an old trunk behind some shredded curtains and distracted herself with it for a good half of an hour. Catra sniffed lightly, rubbing her stuffy nose for the dust with the back of her hand before looking towards Adora's direction, narrowing her eyes through the worn out fabric of the curtain.

"Are you good there, Adora?" asked Catra, arching an eyebrow in wonder.

There was a bit of a tussle behind the curtain and then Adora jumped out of it, falling in her ankles with a clumsy *tud* and swirling in circles with a huge, dopey grin. She was wearing the most absolutely godforsaken hideous costume Catra had ever seen. A huge white lace shirt with puffed sleeves and multicolored ribbons that look like kite's tails. Over it, Adora had thrown a long pink velvet vest, ripped on some places and patched with squares of other fabrics in others, making it look much more like a kids blanket than an actual piece of clothes, the seams sewed with golden thread and silver buttons halfway falling off their places. Adora was also wearing a turquoise pantaloon, the legs huge on the tights like lamp covers, and then narrowing at the knees, making her look like a french king and a harlequin had an unfortunate mixing accident. On top of it all, Adora put on a humongous yellow hat, the wing so big it covered almost Adora's entire face, with artificial wax flowers scattered all over the top, old and falling apart with the pass of time.

Catra chuckled, falling into a loud fit of laughter as she stared at Adora, tiny tears pricking in the corner of her eyes with mirth. "Where in hell's name did you pull that from?"

Adora grinned at her, crooked and cheeky, pointing behind her and towards the opened trunk, dozens of crazy colored clothes scattered all over the floor. It should have been a pretty unfortunate theater costume collection in its time. Catra could only imagine what her grandmother used to do with such eccentric things in her youth. Adora leaned to the trunk,

snatching another questionably bright and sparkling thing out of it and then turning back to Catra, leaning again in a wobbly try of a bow. Catra raised her eyebrows, smirking at Adora.

"A bow" said Catra, huffing. Adora only wobbled her eyebrows at her, straightening up. Catra followed up, ditching the dusty boxes and approaching Adora with her hands behind her back. "You are reading too much from my book, Adora. I'm not the best influence out there."

Adora rolled her eyes at her, swinging the clothes on her hands as she placed it over Catra's shoulders. It was a king-like coat, red and long, the edges brushing at her knees, the sleeves way too long to be actually functional, rimmed in white lace. Catra snorted, taking the corners of the flaps and twirling once, much more elegant than Adora, who just laughed in return, silent and breathless. Catra slipped below Adora's arm, taking a gnawed petticoat from the trunk and putting it over her leggings, making her look like a kaleidoscopic bell in the barely illuminated attic.

"Princess," said Catra in a fake french accent, doing a much more elegant curtsy than Adora's, extending her hand to her. Adora rolled her eyes and Catra thought she could see the peach flush of a blush on her pale cheek, bruises now more green and yellow than purple and red.

Adora took her hand, standing there, just swinging in her ankles at the rhythm of some invisible music that wasn't there. Catra smiled, tugging from her hand to bring her close with one swing, catching her from the waist when she stumbled with the sudden change of position only to give a quick step to the side and then another, bringing Adora with her on each one. Adora followed with an amused snort, tripping over her feet and crashing against Catra's side, her tall frame a little bit bent as she mirrored the steps as best as she could on her new limbs. Catra got a hold of her waist and swung her into a twirl, inelegant and clumsy, stepping in each other's toes and almost tripping down to the floor.

Adora laughed, strangled and still without a voice, and Catra followed her, twirling her again under her hand before separating, joined only by the hold of her hands as Catra gave a step forward, waiting for Adora to follow before dissolving into a series of uneven steps, jumping up and down in the floor, shaking her head and arms like crazy noodles and laughing. Adora looked at her with raised eyebrows and her mouth stretched into a wide grin before following her lead, stomping on the dusty floor like a baby elephant, both of the feet bare and slipping on the wood as they took each other's hands and circled each other, giggling all the way.

It was clear that Adora had no idea what she was doing, and even if Catra did she was more than happy to follow her along, locking their arms together and giving playful twirls around the entire attic, knocking over clothes and trinkets and other things on their way, jumping over and shoving each other as tiny ducks trying not really hard to give a refined dance. At some point, in between the inexistent music that played inside their heads, Adora had wrapped her arms around Catra's waist and lifted her in the air, giving only a quarter of a twirl before stumbling with the swirls of their clothes, both of them falling into the hard ground with a heavy thud. Catra left out a single *ouch* as she started laughing, splayed in her back with her arms open to the sides, Adora not much farther, smiling and red like a rose, even the paler patches on her skin flushed a soft tone of peach.

Catra felt alive, heart flying out of her chest after their impromptu dance, hair a mess, cheeks flushed, ridiculous clothes everywhere and breathless after jumping around like she had never done before, not even as a child, much less as an adult. By Adora's expression in her face that day, the feeling was mutual. Catra's eyes remained locked in the ceiling, still smiling, feeling tiny pieces of her barriers falling apart. With her face up, she couldn't see the way Adora's eyes were bright as she looked at her.

A few days later, when the weather got better and it finally stopped raining outside, Catra served Adora her first ice cream ever. It was *dulce de leche* flavored and traditionally made, something Catra had only ever found back in the village and that she absolutely loved. Adora had gotten so happy with it the skin of her temples started shimmering, golden and blue scales sprouting from her skin, making Catra smile. It was common, Catra had come to learn too. Every time Adora felt something strongly, tiny scales would appear on her face and the sides of her neck, making her look like a pearl or a pebble, depending on the hour of the day. Then they would fall off again, leaving a bright trail behind her. Catra had gotten the habit to put them all in glass vases with fairy lights.

At some point, Adora convinced Catra to walk around the top of the cliff before sunset, with her big doe eyes and mischievous smirk. They got the habit to sit on the very edge, looking at the sun as it sank inside the ocean, painting the sky red and the water golden, immense at their feet, just sitting there in comfortable shared silence, Adora humming for Catra.

Catra wasn't afraid of heights, used to spend long nights on the roofs of college, writing alone under the night sky. And neither was Adora. She liked to twirl around the grass of the hill, looking down to see the water crash against the dark and sharp rocks at the bottom.

At first, Catra had tried to make the effort of bringing her notebook and writing during their time there. She gave up on it quite quickly, instead, sketching Adora on the clear pages with her pencil. The movement of her feet as she tried her legs over the wet grass, the angles of her profile as she looked over at the sea below them, eyes nostalgic and bright; the curve of her smile when she grinned back at Catra, just staring at her with that kind of undecipherable expression Catra still couldn't comprehend, much less accept.

Catra taught Adora technology -without much interest or success-, books or art, poetry and music and the limited science and biology she was able to muster. Adora seemed to absorbed it all, like a sea sponge, looking at Catra teaching her with uncharacteristic patient and the glint of a smile in her lips. Catra checked out her wound, changing wet bandages and old sterile patches when needed, putting on smelly ointments that made Adora's nose wrinkle, and running her fingers delicately over fading bruises. Adora allowed her, relaxing further and further with time on Catra's hands, climbing up and curling on her embrace when storms lashed against shore and the sea and Catra had to make a huge effort to not sprint and run or cry in the spot.

Catra had also tried to teach Adora how to drive and cook. There wasn't a need to talk about it. The dent in the front of Catra's truck and the black ash stain ok the kitchen ceiling were enough testimony of it.

And Melog *loved* Adora. It was obvious from the very start. They langed in the couch next to Adora when she sits to read, nuzzling their tiny nose below her arm and curling into a tight

ball on her ball. They followed her everywhere around the house, Adora behind Catra, Melog behind Adora, acting like a furry and tiny bodyguard for the siren. They would sit besides the base of the bathtub, just waiting for hours until Adora would stand up and leave the bathroom dragging her feet across the floor, throwing herself into the blankets with her long hair soaking wet and her eyes misted in tears. Meg curled around her head or neck, purring against her skin until her heartbeat steadied. Catra knows this because it is how she would find them like this sometimes, peeking inside the bedroom after Adora missed dinner by a long shot.

Adora is heartbroken, Catra knows this. She tries to hide it away for whatever reason, burying it deep inside her chest with smiles and books in her hands, maps of the shore and the tide market up on the wall of the bedroom, always with her head on a plan. But Catra knows. She knows because she knows sadness like the palm of her hand, like an uncomfortable but familiar friend. She can see it in the way Adora's shoulders are tense, in the twitch in the corner of her mouth when she gazes at the sea. In the mornings, bare in front of the mirror while Catra empties the bath, inspecting the wound in the side of her face that has healed but has also scarred, a crooked line like a lightning crossing her face in a permanent reminder.

Catra didn't think sirens could be like this -but she honestly didn't think about sirens at all until weeks ago-, honest and caring and kind, wearing their heart on their sleeve, brave and stubborn. But also guarded and quiet and overthinkers, silently carrying the weight of their pain with them until it was too much, just for one night. Or maybe it was an Adora thing. Catra supposed it was the last.

On nights like that Catra didn't really know what to do, so she sat on the floor, her back against the frame of the door and read outloud to Adora from Razz's book. It was probably a shit attempt of comfort and Catra hated herself for it, but it helped. Adora's breathing would calm down, her anxiety would lower. It helped.

The morning of October 28th, a little bit over three weeks after Adora's arrival, Catra finds out Adora can play the piano.

"Yes," says Catra over the phone, tapping in over her notebook with the back of her pencil, looking at the empty page open in her laptop. Adora is walking by the corner of the living room, inspecting the furniture there, hidden below a dusty sheet. She is wearing grey joggers and one of Catra's sports shirts, white and way too tight against her chest. Catra grips the pencil on her fist, almost breaking it in half as she tries for dear life not to get distracted by her.

" *There is no need for you to feel pressured, Catrina, you have enough time until the deadline"* Catra's publisher, Spinerella, says on the other side of the line. Her voice is as calm and patient as always, walking Catra through her career anxiety as she has done since the first time they met each other. " *I saw you deleted a bunch of chapters from your last check up. Is everything alright, darling?"*

Catra bites her bottom lip, canines digging in delicate skin, looking over at Adora. She has gripped the sheet between her hand and pulled from it, revealing an abandoned, ancient piano below it. The expression on her face it's so bright it makes Catra's heart skip a beat.

"Everything is fine," answers Catra, maybe too quick and too harsh. There is silence on the other side of the line, not awkward, but waiting, with all the calm of a saint. Catra sighs against the phone, knocking her forehead against the smooth surface of the screen. "I'm just… having a fucking writer block, that's all. I'll get it done."

"Mmm," Spinerella wonders, making Catra sweat a little. In the living room, Adora sits in front of the piano, brushing her fingers over the keys softly. From this angle Catra can see the arch of her neck through the golden strands of her hair, soft and elegant. " *Just remember to write whatever you like, alright darling? Not what you think everyone wants you to write. You can even write something completely different to what you usually write!"*

"Like what?" mocks Catra without being able to stop, "A love story?"

Spinerella just hums into the phone, the hint of a smile clear even from the other side of Etheria. " *I mean, that is completely different to your alley."*

"I don't do love stories, you know that Spinerella. That's not my thing." Adora pushes one of the white keys, a bright sound echoing in the room, making Adora giggle.

" *Well, maybe it should be. After everything you've gone through I think that's what you deserve"*

"A romantic book?"

" *A love story,"* Spinerella corrects. Catra holds her breath, closing her eyes and tearing them away from Adora, scratching the surface of the kitchen table with her nails. Spinerella must catch the sudden tension because she adds, *"Of course, that's not all you can write, sweetie. As I said, do what feels best for you, and only for you. Romance is not the only thing on the planet. There are many other wonderful things that are worth it."*

Catra scowls at the table, nose wrinkling with her snarl. "I'm just not a romantic."

From Spinerella's side, a distant sneeze can be heard suddenly, followed by the echoing voice of her wife, Netossa, probably in the same room as her, speaking loudly. " *Oh, I'm sorry. I'm just allergic to bullsh-"*

"Alright! I'll call you at the end of the week, Catrina, darling," interrupts Spinerella in a rush, the sound of a cushion crashing against someone's head clear in the background.

"Fine, see you then." Adora has started to press more keys, first slowly, hesitantly, then a little bit faster, melodic, one after the other sure and rhythmic. Catra tilts her head to the side, mind already miles away from the conversation. "Tell Netossa to go fuck herself, too."

"This little brat-"

"Love you too, Catrina. See you!"

Catra hangs the phone, abandoning it carelessly over the table as she stands up, approaching Adora and sitting in the free space of the long, mushy bench in front of it, her arm brushing against Catra's slightly. Adora is playing the piano, actually playing it, long fingers brushing

and pressing over the monochromatic keys in a delicate melody, filling the entire house with music. Adora blushes when Catra sits besides her, stumbling just a little with the notes before picking it up again, this time faster, the melody changing into something beautiful and cheerful, keys following after keys, notes dancing around notes, circling Catra's head until all thought is numb and misted inside her mind, just the sound of Adora's piece and the low hum of her throat following the music. Catra gapes at her. She can help it. Her mouth falls open with shock and surprise and everything in between.

How was that song again?

Happiness hit her like a bullet in the back.

That was Catra, struck by lightning, by a thunderbolt, swept off her feet from the very first moment. That was Catra.

"Where did you even learn how to play?" asks Catra in a whisper, not higher than the sound of Adora's fingers flying over the keys, fast as a hummingbird's wings. "I'm pretty sure there aren't pianos in the bottom of the sea but please let me know if I'm wrong."

Adora tilts her head slightly towards her, smiling sideways only. Catra huffs, making herself more comfortable over the stiff couch and resting her cheek against Adora's shoulder, trying to ignore the flaring alarms inside her head. Adora's shoulders tense for one long second, relaxing almost immediately, her body melting and accommodating around Catra's, all of it without stopping playing once.

It brings a pang of uncertainty into Catra's, Adora playing the piano. It means she definitely learned somewhere on land. Sirens don't just walk out of the ocean knowing what keys go with what note. It means *somebody* taught her, somebody else Adora knew -or knows- in land. Someone that is not Catra.

Catra tries to suffocate the nasty wave of jealousy that rises inside her throat, bubbling and acid. It's not Adora's fault that she is strained with Catra, and it's not her fault Catra feels like shit at the thought she might not be the only human Adora knows, not even close to that. The way Adora wailed that first night, unable to dip back inside the sea and swim away. As far as Catra knows, Adora might have someone out there. Someone she misses, someone she desperately wants to go back too. Someone that is not Catra at all.

But. The soft melody reminds Catra of Adora's siren lullabies in the middle of the night, the ones that by now Catra knows to heart, that sometimes Catra thinks are for her. And the way Adora's chin brushes ever so lightly over the top of Catra's hair makes her heart skip a beat. It makes Catra feel like she is *important.* Like she isn't just a nuisance, or a distraction or a problem. Even if it's all just swift, even when Catra knows it will all come to an end sooner or later.

Catra breathes through her nose, focusing instead in Adora's hands over the piano. Even her long fingers are elegant, playing across the white keys lazyly, like a second -or third- breathing, sometimes stumbling with one or two keys but always keeping the cadence of the song. The piano is covered in a layer of dust, Catra never bothered to clean it up or even move it away from its original place. After all, Catra didn't play, not even a little.

The white of the keys and the coolness of Adora's skin against her cheek remind Catra of that first night. Rain against her face, hair whipping against her neck and soaked clothes, looking at the neat white of the boat and the horrid people on it that had tried to take Adora away. She could still see them vividly behind her eyelids, reviewing that night again and again in her dreams. The hunter's that were holding Adora between their nets, with their white clothes and green logos, dangling knives and harpoons at her, slashing her skin without remorse, trying to tame her down as she fighted for her life. The third one had blue hair and the thunderbolts crashing mercilessly against the surface of sea made his eyes look red, a furious snarl on his face as he looked at Catra with rage, gripping violently between his hand a pale fabric shimmering in blue-

Catra's heartbeat comes to a stop, acid and dread pooling in the bottom of her stomach, her soul dropping to her feet. She opens her eyes, snapping her head straight with sudden realization. She knows it, she has known it from the very beginning. She saw it but didn't understand it at the moment, and after, it had flown over her head completely, buried under Adora's bright and golden presence in her life. She let it pass because she hadn't comprehended it, she couldn't have possibly known the way her life was going to change drastically, the way the epicenter of her entire life was going to change and become something else. *Someone else.* If Catra had known, she would have thrown herself to that violent ocean in that very second, fight against the waves and her own fear of drowning and climb the boat. Tear the skin from that man's hands and snap their necks, claw at their faces and scream.

Adora has gone quiet, sensing Catra's drastic change of demeanor immediately. Her hands are still hovering slightly over the piano keys, her eyebrows knitted together in concern as she gazes at Catra with obvious worry in her silver eyes. She is beautiful and she wears her heart on her sleeve and Catra wants to slap herself because Catra saw it and she knows Adora is sad and scared and they have lost *three weeks* in nothing.

Some obscure part of her heart wonders if she actually knew the whole time and refused to see it just so she would have Adora a little longer in her life. The thought makes her feel sick.

Catra sprints out the bench, almost knocking herself over with the piano's legs after she uncharacteristically trips with her own feet, gaining a harsh hit on the knee on her way through the living room. Adora stands up too, her eyebrows frunced in confusion as she looks at Catra roaming through the blankets on the floor for her jacket and the keys of her car, muttering under her breath.

Melog comes from behind the couch, meowing wondering at Catra while she grabs her phone from the kitchen table and fumbles with it, groaning at the lack of battery. It must have died somewhere after her long call with Spinnerella and Catra's everlasting habit of not charging her damn things.

"I'm going to the town," says Catra, turning in her heels towards the door. Her head is a fuzzy mess, even her eyes are twitching, mind miles away. Somewhere behind her, she thinks she can hear the branch screeching against the floor and falling with a thud. "I won't be long, don't get out of the house. Melog will look after you and- *oye!"*

The word escapes from her mouth in her mother tongue, surprise evident in her tone as a hand wraps around her wrist and tugs back, not harsh but strong enough to make her fumble back a few feet. Catra turns to Adora, who is looking at her with that kind of fond and exasperated expression she seems to always wear around Catra.

"Adora" starts Catra, tapping with her feet on the floor. Her heart is jumping out of her chest with impatience but Adora's bright eyes keep her rooted in her place. "I told you, I won't be long. I promise. But we are two in this house now and we are running out of food"

The lie burns Catra's tongue. That's just who she is, isn't it? A liar. But she doesn't want to make Adora's hopes go up, not when the possibility of being crushed down after it is very palpable. Catra wouldn't be able to look inside her eyes and see more heartbreak on them.

Adora grunts, looking towards the door and back to Catra's face with determination clear on her face. Catra shifts on her feet, biting down on her lip nervously. "Do you want to come with me?"

Adora's entire demeanor brightens and she runs towards the door with a little sprint on her steps, grabbing the second coat there and throwing it carelessly over her own shoulders, opening the door and looking back at Catra with huge, waiting eyes. Catra gulps.

"You aren't even wearing shoes." Adora makes a sound with her throat, something very close to *are you serious?* and wrinkles her nose, already halfway through the door. Catra doesn't have much option but to give in. "Alright, alright! But you need to listen. Adora, *listen"* Catra approaches Adora next to the door, fixing the collar of her coat and handing her a pair of socks and boots, nudging her softly to put them on as she speaks. "We are going but you have to stay inside the car the entire time, you understand? Just for today. Adora, nod if you understand, this is important"

There is an underline in Catra's voice, something urgent that Adora must catch because her joyful expression sobers up completely as she nods, holding Catra's eyes the entire time. Catra finishes fixing the lashes of Adora's shoes and stands up, again, holding her dark hair into a bun.

"Okay, then" Catra fumbles with her keys, grabbing the doorknob with vice grip. Her mind is running in circles, heart beating fast and hard in the base of her throat. "Okay, so we are doing this then. You are a troublemaker, isn't it? What's next, are you stealing my car keys and driving to the woods?"

Adora snickers, grabbing Catra's keys from her hand playfully and rushing out, still stumbling over the pebbles with her boots. Catra exhales, turning back to look at Melog who has made themself a little ball on the couch, looking at her with blue eyes far too wise for a cat.

"Fuck," whispers Catra, anxiety coursing through her veins as she drops her shoulders in defeat. "Guard the forth, Melog."

Melog waves their tail at her, blinking slowly once. Besides the house, the sound the car's motor brought back to life startles Catra, who spins in her feet with eyes wide as plates,

rushing down the porch's stairs, almost forgetting to close the door behind.

"Adora, wait! I was joking!"



The familiar light of the antique street lamps greets them as they reach the gates that mark the entrance to the town. The black painted antique buildings shine in golden and orange reflections, enlightened by the candles and pumpkin lamps scattered over the porches, windows and stairs making it look all ethereal and mysterious at the same time. The people of the town have also started to harvest the marigolds, some of them placed in bouquets of orange and red and pink mixed with the velvet softness of others. The petals of others have been placed inside baskets, filled to the brim already in preparation for Candles Day, right at the beginning of November.

Catra grabs the steering wheel of the car so hard her knuckles turn a pale shade of pink, glimpsing swiftly towards Adora's seat next to her. She has her face pressed against the window, nose and forehead tight against the crystal as she looks outside with bright eyes. She makes a little cheerful sound in the base of her throat, pointing at a house *full* of pumpkins and looking back at Catra with a curious smile.

"They are pumpkin lamps, for All Hallows Eve," says Catra, returning the smile. "You know, that ancient festivity I told you about and that people turned into commercial shit?"

Adora giggles, nodding in understanding. She turns back to look through the window, smiling widening as she keeps looking at the town. There aren't many people outside but the shops are filled, people going in and around, dancing and eating, already resting after a hard day of work and excited for the incoming festivities. There are garlands and five pointed stars made of tiny branches, rosemary and rose blossoms, hanging from the doors and the windows. Candles placed over the steps, with their white and black wax dripping into the ground, and the roads of petals and salt placed over the streets and the doors in paths to guide the spirits home. Catra sighs heavily, relaxing her vice grip over the wheel just a little.

"People here still celebrate it the traditional way," Catra turns the car to the side, down through a quiet street with paths of rocks and wooden ceilings, slowly making their way towards the port. "I like Candle's Day better. It's more beautiful, there is food and music and dance and people making offerings and gifts to their dead loved ones. You would like it."

Adora is gazing at her again from the corner of her silver eyes, smiling sideways. She is so pretty. Catra could look at her forever.

Catra takes the turn outside the busy streets, down the path that leads them to the port. They are giving an entire circle around the town but Catra is doing it on purpose. She needs to look here first.

The boats of the town are quiet and still over the shore, moved from side to side gently by the waves, well held in place with ropes and lonely. Most of the people have already closed for the night and left to rest or enjoy the evening, so the boats are empty, a colorful contrato of the houses in the town beside them. Catra scans the rows of boats with narrowed eyes,

straining her eyes to look for any that resembles the one if that night. There are red ones and yellows, blues and greens and lilacs. So many of them but none are blue and none of them are definitely like the one she saw. These ones are old, well loved with use and work. The hunters' boat was too perfect, too shiny. Almost as if someone has placed it on the sea just for that night in specific. Catra bites into her tongue, tasting copper in the base of her mouth.

Adora shifts next to her, suddenly nervous at the sight of the boats and nets hanging from their decks, her cheeks pale and silver eyes dim under the light inside the car, looking at the calm port with hooded eyes. Catra catches her expression in the reflection of the glass, turning and outstretching her hand towards her so she can tangle their fingers together.

"Hey, it's okay," says Catra, voice strangled. The old pickup is going slowly through the road. The motor creaks a little as they cross over the loose pebbles and swollen wood of the port, complaining when Catra lowers the speed so she holds Adora's hand fully into hers, squeezing gently. "We are almost there."

Adora blinks at her in silence, grimacing a little, but nods nonetheless. Under the light of the street lamp outside Catra can see the silhouette of the crooked scar etched in the side of her face, skin tender and pink with healing. Catra tightens her hold, throwing a swift look back to the boats just to be sure the one she is looking for it's not there, and speeds up again, turning in the next exit and up, into the inclined street there.

This street is busier, open shops buzzing with people having dinner and chatting among themselves, music echoing through the stone paths and dark buildings. One of the shops at the center is shimmering with lights, purples and blues reflecting over the ground, fairy lights and tinted windows mixing with the old, mysterious structure of the building. The words *Dragon's Daughter III* are etched in the roof over the door with neon lights, a successor to Dragon's Daughter I and Dragon's Daughter II, signboards lost in an unfortunate and rather stupid fire everyone knew about, even Catra.

Catra parks on the side of the road, opposite to the shop. The lights inside the car go off, the soft music in the stereo quieting down too. They sit submerged in darkness, Catra looking at the store, Adora looking at Catra.

“Stay here, okay? I´m in and out” Catra slips her arms inside the sleeves of her jacket, closing all the windows and taking the key out. Adora fidgets on her seat, grimacing unsure. Catra brushes the pads of her fingers over her knuckles, smiling reassuringly. “If you need anything, just smash the horn in the steering wheel. I know you are good at that.” Adora rolls her eyes, apprehension replaced by mild annoyance. Her hair has slipped almost completely off the loose braid, falling like curtains around her face, creating a halo of light inside the shadows of the car. It would be so easy, lean in and press her face against Adora´s, share her warmth, finally give in to the vulnerability Adora has managed to dig out of her. Catra hasn't done anything else in those weeks but breathe and live inside Adora´s presence. And Adora is looking at her with those big doe eyes, curious as she reads Catra inside out, all her rough edges and sharp corners. Everything that Catra considers unlovable about herself -all of her-, Adora reaches to it without fear. She almost makes Catra feel wanted. *Loved.*

But it´s wrong. Catra now has a strong clue about Adora´s skin. They will find her skin and she will be gone. That's how it has always been, from the very beginning. Catra can't risk the

brief moments of her life with Adora just for a few seconds of selfish indulgence Adora might not even actually want at all, to begin with. Catra opens the door in a rush, slipping out of the car in one swift movement and closing it behind her a little too harshly. Adora looks at her from her seat, beyond the glass of the window, crestfallen and pensive as Catra crosses the street without looking at the sides at all.

Catra reaches for the door of the shop and enters the establishment, the damp night behind her as new sounds and smells surround her inside. The place is more illuminated than what it actually looks from the outside. Modern led lamps and posters hang from the ceilings and the walls, casting bluem lilac and golden light over the products in the front of the shop. Sea products of all classes are organized in white painted furniture. Sea salt, bath products, homemade soaps and others, and all kinds of food placed in the wood rows, tiny prices written in chalk next to them. Catra grabs one of the baskets made with worn out nets, filling it to the brim with huge bottles of sea salt and the first food she sees, not even bothering to stop and check what they are. She approaches the reception near the exit, throwing a swift look at the coffee and pastries corner placed at the bottom of the store. There are decorations already being placed there too, dry leaves and crowns of dry fruits in the walls and the roof. People are chatting and having dinner, the sound of silverware and glasses tingling against each other. Catra leaves the basket over the counter, taking her card out and dropping it carelessly next to them without stop looking inside the dinner room.

“My, my. But if it is our very own lonely writer,” the person behind the reception says, leaning over the counter to look closer to Catra´s face, calling her attention. “What brings you out of your fortress and into the land of the living, kitten?

"DT," Catra greets them, sucking on her teeth. DT smiles widens, throwing their long, neon blonde hair behind their exposed shoulder, the fabric of their tight shirt clinging to their collarbones, barely holding for dear life where it has been cut and ripped fashionably. They drums their fingers over the wood, throwing an sideways look at the items in the basket. "Some late night grocery shopping? I thought you liked the marked better"

"And I thought I told you to keep your nose out of my business," Catra bites back,almost hissing. She doesn't have the best kind of relationship with them. DT was interesting, during her first weeks in Salineas, but it reminded her a little too much about the people she used to run with. Slick. Never staying in place for too long. Always seeking for something. It would have appealed every single rebellious needs of a younger Catra, but this Catra was older, more tired, definitely more distrustful.

DT smile doesn't wave, instead, they rest their cheek over their closed fist, looking at Catra up and down, studying her. Her Saturday clothes and messy hair and angry frown, Catra knows she must look almost out of her mind, buying a bunch of salt and fish at almost eleven in the night instead of being partying with the rest of the young people of the town inside the dinner. It's not like she cares, it's not like she has ever cared what people thought of told her she should be doing. Still, DT seems to be reading her like an open book and Catra's stomach promptly packs its bags and walks away when DT turns their haze away and thought the glass of the front window, grinning like the cat that got the mouse when they catch the shade of Catra's pick up in the distance.

"Having company tonight, darling?"

"Alright, are you going to charge me for this or can I walk with my shit like this, then?" Catra growls, out of breathe, trying to not to think in the silhouette there of Adora still inside the car, her silver eyes following Catra wherever she goes. DT straightens up, the sly expression never once slipping of their face, but they start check out the items, putting them mindlessly inside a fabric bag.

"I doubt you are really here, at woe hours of the night, just to buy eight bottles of sea salt, soup and one can of sardines, darling"

Catra clicks her tongue against her teeth, digging her long nails over the polished wood. DT blinks, their long neon eyelashes brushing against their highlighted skin, waiting for Catra's come back. She doesn't give them the satisfaction of it. "Where is Mermista?"

DT chuckles, victorious as they start to pass the products through the machine, dinging like a bell with each one. "She is the back, having an argument with the distributors. What do you need her for?"

Catra bites the inside of her cheek, smiling as she imitates DT's sly tone of before. "I doubt that's any of your damn business, *darling.* "

DT laughs out loud, putting all the things inside a fabric bag and placing it over the counter, alongside Catra's card. From inside the dinner, a loud laugh echoes through the entire establishment, followed by a ringing tone and the start of a song that looks too much like a shanty. Catra turns towards the sound, where proud already pressed in annoyance.

"That'll work," she says, almost to herself, ignoring DT completely as she slips behind the dinner's counter and walks through the busy tables at the center and near the window, approaching the spacious cushions nestled in the very back, illuminated only by the neon led light in the ceiling and under the furniture.

There is a man standing over the table, dark worn out denim pants, ridiculous boots, a white loose shirt and a red handkerchief around his neck. His hair is stylish and polished like an actor that stumbled out of Grease, and his silly curled mustache moves as he ends his horrid singing, chest inflating when he gives the longest, most tortuous note. Catra rolls her eyes, crossing her arms over her chest and tapping on the floor, impatient.

"Sea Hawk. Sea Hawk!" she calls him, scowling. Sea Hawk lowers his eyes to her, smiling brightly at the sight of a new audience around his table.

"Yes! That is I! A song you would like to hear, my grumpy friend?" Sea Hawk makes a wide courtesy, grinning like an idiot without even looking at her. Catra huffs, grabbing him by the elbow and dragging him down the table and into the seat. She doesn't have time for whenever Shakespeare in the Park this is, she has already been away from Adora for longer than she would like.

"Listen, dude, this is important. I know Mermista sails with you. I need to know-"

"Yes! My beautiful muse! She is truly the greatest woman I have ever met!"

Catra looks at him with a blank expression, waiting more and more annoyed by the second. "Good for you. Would you shut up and listen? I need to know if you've seen a boat"

"Oh! I've seen plenty of boats!"

"A *white* boat," continues Catra, shaking him slightly by the flaps of his shirt. "With a green logo on the side. There were three men over it, all in white clothes. They were around the sea three weeks ago, I need to know if you've seen them recently."

Sea Hawk hums, resting his chin over his thumb, pensative. Catra doesn't let go of his shirt, waiting as the second tick by and Sea Hawk keeps thinking until his dark eyes sparkle with recognition and he smiles brightly, as if he had solved the greatest mystery on earth all on his own. Catra's stomach gives a twist. "Well, yes! Now that you mention it I did see a boat like that, my friend! It sailed right when we were closing for the night. My beautiful muse didn't want to spend the night singing to the stars so we came back to the port. The boat was speeding off through the bay when I saw it!"

"And after?" presses Catra, baring her teeth. Sea Hawk shrugs, shaking his head.

"We were in here after. Even though the night was *so* beautiful."

"It was raining hell, for starters," intercedes a third voice, annoyed. Catra leans back in time to watch Mermista circle her and lean over the edge of the table with her arms crossed, raising an eyebrow to Catra. "We didn't see when it came back. We did see, however, where it came from. A yacht, big thing, offensively expensive. It had the same logo on the side and the name *Velvet Glove* carved in the wood. It hasn't appeared in the sea or the port at all since then."

Catra exhales, cursing herself and her bad temper mentally. Maybe she had truly scared those dipshits away, taking their sorry asses and Adora's skin with them. Or maybe, in an even more terrifying thought than the last, they were waiting for things to cool down and we're going to come back to look for Adora. They knew what they were doing, after all, with the steel knife and the nets and the skin. They or whoever they were working for would know without the skin Adora was vulnerable, unable to transform. It boiled the blood inside Catra's veins, hot bile pooling in the back of her throat like a venom. Luckily, her face showed none of this but a blank, distant expression, broken only by Mermista's uninterested tone of voice when she speaks again.

"So, you are looking for those illegal hunters that went to your bay the other day." It's obviously not a question. Catra's voids expression shifts into a full scowl, her nail digging in her palms as she spits the words.

"Bow told you." Mermista rolls her eyes, taking a seat next to Sea Hawk.

"Bow tells everything to the entire town. Everyone knows." Catra breathes hard, loudly, holding a scream in. Damn her wonderful idea of calling people into this. Mermista looks at

her with something way too close to curiosity, wrinkling her nose. "To keep an eye up for them, of course."

"Of course," repeats Catra, exhaling like an angry dragon. Suddenly the lights are too bright and the loud music too overwhelming. She has gotten nothing out of this and she wants to go *now.*

Sea Hawk is humming a shanty softly next to Mermista, completely embellished by her face. She groans and pushes him aside, squishing his cheek and nose with her palm. "Look, I don't know what kind of personal beef you have with those people and honestly I don't care," she says, bearing her eyes into Catra's. "But I do know that if what they were going after is really precious for them, they will be coming back, and probably they'll be coming in a completely different way than before. So if you happen to see them around, let me know, I'm always down to harpoon some assholes."

Catra actually chuckles at this, smirking as some of the tension starts to wash away. "Noted that, seaweed girl."

Catra turns away to leave, not even saying goodbye. Mermista stops her in her tracks, calling for her. "Catra," Catra looks at her again, surprised she even remembers her name at all. Mermista has that bored expression as always but there is the shadow of a smile when she crosses her arms over her chest and huffes. "I read your book. It isn't as good as Mermisteries, *of course.* But it wasn't that bad or whatever."

Catra scoffs around a laugh, shaking her head from side to side. "Dick" Mermista smiles at her, just once, thight. Catra waves absently at Sea Hawk still sitting there, rising her eyes in sarcasm. "Good luck with whatever that is."

Catra can hear Mermista's lour groan as she exists the dinner room and approaches the shop's counter - *what a weord establishment*- grabbing her bag from the surface and turning to the door without a second thought.

"Are you this feisty for that pretty darling that is sitting inside your car? Or they are completely unrelated events?" DT asks from behind the counter, resting their chin over their folded hands. Catra freezes in front of the door, her hand still hovering above the doorknob when she looks at them with red rimmed eyes.

"What?" DT shrugs, smiling.

"They've been flicking the lights inside the car on and off for the last ten minutes." DT's fangs flash when they grin wider. "They seem nice."

"Stay away of her, DT," Catra snaps, poisonous. "I'm serious. I don't want you around her and I don't want you talking about her without any-fucking-body."

"Oh, darling, c'mon"

"I said no." For the first time since she's known them, DT seems to catch the dangerous, serious undertones in her voice because they stop on their noisiness, blinking at her as if they

were seeing Catra for the very first time. "Say it"

"Very well, darling. I won't talk."

Catra doesn't answer, just frowning at them before swinging the door open and bursting outside the shop, crestfallen and a mess but never with her shoulders fallen until she reaches the door of the car, unlocking it and slipping inside swiftly.

Adora is looking at her, Catra can feel her eyes on the side of her face, bright under the shadows. Catra sighs heavily, tuning to her to hand her the bag. "Here, I got you salt and food."

Adora takes the bag without even looking at it, still staring at her. Finally, after a few seconds, Catra collects enough bravery to look up, locking her eyes with hers. There are a hundred questions inside the silver of her eyes, loud even without a voice. She knows something is going on, Catra can't fool her, she is smart, she knows Catra it's upset about something. But Catra doesn't have the heart to tell her where her skin is, or that it is, for now, gone.

"Everything is fine," Catra lies, trying not to show her feelings blatantly on her face. Adora tilts her head to the side, leaning in until she bumps the bridge of her nose against Catra's temple. Catra exhales, closing her eyes, tears pricking on the corners without falling down. "Let's go home."

Catra fishes her keys on the bottom of her coat, barely managing to fit the hole next to the wheel. Adora leans back, resting the back of her head over the seat to inspect closer the bottles of salt inside the back. Catra turns on the lights and turns the key, bringing the pick-up back to life. She manages to advance about an inch when someone comes out from nothing, crossing the street in a rush without looking. Catra slams her feet in the pedal, cursing like an angry sailor as the car comes into an abrupt stop. Adora huffs next to her, clinging to the seat belt and the bag as Catra lowers the window of her own door and peeks outside, yelling.

"Would you fucking mind where are you going before crossing, you absolute idiot?!"

The person stops, tilting their head to the side and approaching the car. As the lights in the front illuminate her legs, Catra makes off the familiar fabric of a sparkling lilac raincoat, purple tights and silver plastic boots -that kind that look like pulled off from an alien convention or a kids alley but Channel-. Catra curses under her breath again, trying to turn the key again before she can fully make of Catra's face under the steering wheel.

"Catra?"

"Shit"

"Catra? It's me! Glimmer!" Catra doesn't want anyone in this godforsaken town to see Adora, but the very last person she wants to see her it's the daughter of the town's mayoress and the chief of the Biology Center. Glimmer reaches Catra's already pulled down window quickly, easing her face almost completely inside with a bright smile. Her neon eyeliner and sparkling eyeshadows shimmers under the light of the car, and her sweet perfume itches Catra's nose,

who grabs the steering wheel with both hands and tenses completely. "What are you- *oh* . Hello! Who are you?"

Adora looks from Glimmer to Catra, mildly alarmed as she clings to the shopping bag. She bites her bottom lip, grunting softly in a swift greeting. It doesn't discourage Glimmer at all. She jumps on her place up and down, almost draping herself through the window and over Catra to look at Adora better.

"I'm Glimmer Bright!" she presents herself, unfazed by Adora's lack of words. Glimmer inspects Adora's face, her eyes jumping from Catra to her and back. She smiles, tiny and devious, a mischievous tone overlapping the cheerful one as she points swiftly at Catra, joking with a wink. "Is she kidnapping you?"

"I'm going to run you over, Sparkles"

"I would like to see you try"

Adora chuckles, breathless, a soft hum coming out of her mouth almost like the hint of a voice. She looks at Glimmer's curious eyes and shakes her head to her question, once and sure, smirking brightly at her. Glimmer blinks, slightly mesmerized, her eyes unfocusing for a second.

Catra gulps, gripping the wheel somehow even tighter. She can feel sweat starting to cling to the skin of her forehead, sticky and nervous, fighting that no emotion shows through her face. "Well, this was all very interesting, Sparkles. Good bye"

"What- wait, wait! I was going to ask you how have you been doing" Catra stops trying to pull up the window, digging her eyes on Glimmer's. "Bow told me what happened."

"Is there *anyon*e that doesn't know what happened?" Glimmer smiles sideways, shrugging.

"He was worried about you. He said you looked pretty shaken." Adora fidges next to Glimmer, picking in the edges of her sleeve. Glimmer turns to look at her, tilting her head to the side. "We're you two together? Your- um, friend-?"

"Adora" corrects Catra, almost without thinking. She is getting defensive pretty hard and pretty quickly talking about that night and Adora in the same sentence. Any other day, Catra would have already snarled at Glimmer. But Adora's breathing is calm and her hand cool when she rests it over Catra's shoulder. Catra breath deep, looking at Glimmer directly in the eyes. "We are fine, Sparkles, *thanks*. Now, can you move?"

Glimmer looks at her as if she knew first hand Catra's weak affirmation is full of bullshit, but nods nonetheless, stepping back not without waving happily at Adora. "Bye, Adora!"

Adora barely has time to wave back before Catra is pushing the accelerator to the maximum, speeding away.

Catra opens the door with a huff, frustrated, turning on the lights on her way to the kitchen and leaving the shopping bag over the counter. Adora follows her close behind, her steps muted over the floor, leaving sand prints behind her where she got tired of the shoes in the car and took them off before getting inside the house.

The tiny red light of the voicemail tingles in the corner of the counter with a message. Catra pushes the play button, undoing the knot of her boots as the message starts playing loudly in the kitchen.

" *Wildcat* !" Scorpia's voice resounds, the echo of Perfuma's lighter tone in the background. Catra grimaces -she already knows why they are calling- taking the things out of the bag as Adora spins happily on the tall chair of the counter. " *Congratulations! You are officially twenty six years old now! Wohoo!"*

" *We've been trying to call you through the evening but couldn't find you,"* adds Perfuma, her voice a little bit distorted by the signal. " *However, we hope you had the most splendids of days, Catra"*

"I can't believe this is the second time we haven't celebrated your birthday!" Scorpia laments, sniffing softly. " *You need to let us visit you someday soon, alright? Oh! Entrapta is here! Entrapta! Come say happy birthday to Catra!"*

There is a bit of a shuffling noise and then Entrapta's squeaky voice comes into the message too. " *Hello there! Please let me know about the effects of self inflicted solitude in a new place! I must add them to my expedient of human interaction"*

"And, happy birthday," whispers Scorpia from some point, a smile in her voice.

"*And birth anniversary!"*

Catra chuckles, actually amused, turning on the small music box next to the microwave.

"*Call us when you feel comfortable, Catra"* says Perfuma, a smile clear in her face even from the other side of the phone.

"*And don't forget to eat chocolate chip cookies, Wildcat! It's tradition!"* Scorpia laughs, almost screaming to the phone

"The tiny ones!"

"Yes! Listen to Entrapta," there is a bit more of a fumble and then both Scorpia and Perfuma voices, saying goodbye cheerfully. *"Bye, bye!"*

The voicemail falls silent with one last beep, only the soft music from the speaker filling the space inside the kitchen. Catra pays no mind to it, roaming around the kitchen. It's already half past nine and completely dark outside, the soft and salty breeze of the sea slipping through the half opened windows above the sink, the sound of the cold waves crashing against the rocks.

The voicemail cracks and reproduces again, the sound calling Catra's attention. Adora is listening to the message intently, looking up and towards Catra when it arrives at the birthday mention, her eyebrow arched in a silent question. Catra shrugs, rubbing her palm against her nape.

"Some humans have this thing of celebrating each year the day they were born. It's not a big deal." Adora's elegant eyebrow somehow just rises further, an unimpressed look in her face. She *knows* what a birthday is, that's not what she is asking for. Catra rolls her eyes, putting the stew they are having for dinner in the stove. "Fine. Today it's my birthday. Happy?"

To nobody's surprise, Adora is not actually happy. She huffes, looking at Catra with something more like worried wonder than innocent annoyance. Catra doesn't need her to talk to know exactly what she is thinking. "Is not that I didn't want to tell you. I never celebrated it when I was younger. I barely even learned *when* it was because I filled my own school paperwork after primary school, and only when Scorpia found out they started *forcing* me to do at least some short of celebration." Catra crosses her arms over her chest. She can feel herself getting slightly defensive. "It's just a date, Adora, I told you, it's not important."

Adora pouts, resting her chin against the counter with a flop. Catra drops her arms to the sides, turning around to try and find anything else to do but look at Adora's sad puppy eyes.

The music is coming softly from the speakers, filling the room in calmness. The chair creaks when Adora stands from it, her soles tapping softly in the ground. Catra jumps slightly when she feels the cold touch of Adora's hands sliding over her elbows. She cups the angle of her arms, turning her around softly with a gentle pull.

"Adora, what are you-"

"Ca- tra" It's raspy, hoarse and a little bit squeaky. A melody from a rusty music box that hasn't been played in a while. Catra gapes at her, her mouth falling open slightly in surprise. Adora clears her throat, her frown twitching a little as she tries again with a little more confidence. "Catra"

"You are talking," Catra blinks, once, thrice, before her eyes sparkle in the sudden delight. She wraps her hands around Adora's upper arms, jumping up and down on her tippy toes in excitement. "You are talking, Adora! That 's awesome!"

Adora smiles back, untangling Catra's hands from her arms and resting them together, palm against palm. "Catra," she says again, she is not saying anything else, pulling from their hold and guiding Catra gently to the other side of the counter, into the side of the kitchen where the floor is bigger and there are less possibilities of knocking against something.

The music is just as gentle, soft instruments and soft voice, burying the entire house in calmness. The corner of her eyes wrinkle when she smiles. She looks to the speaker and back to Catra, starting to swing from side to side, abruptly and clumsy. Catra's eyes widen in surprise and then in mirth, laughing when she understands what she is trying to do.

"Adora, wait wait," Catra says around a squeaky giggle, shaking her head. Adora stops with a soft questioning look, her smile tiny and sideways, slightly embarrassed. "This one it's a little

different from the attic. Here, let me teach you."

Catra takes Adora's hands on hers, guiding it slowly, almost absently over her shoulders, resting them there softly. Then she wraps her hands around Adora's waist, stepping close to her until their chests are pressed together, cold against warmth.

"Alright, now swing from side to side, softly. That's it. Good, Adora, now to the other side," Catra smiles, looking from their feet to Adora's face, gulping loudly when she catches the look inside Adora's eyes. She is so close, Catra notices first, warmth flourishing on her cheeks, and so tall, literally towering over her head even without shoes on. Her hair falls like water around her face, brushing Catra's cheeks where it meets her in the middle, golden under the light. There are small golden and turquoise scales sprouting in the sides of her temples and the curve of her cheekbones, scattering the pale patches of her skin like tiny kisses or flower blooms, the brightness of its iridescence rivaling the peach flush over her nose. Graveness is attached in her features, the kind of solemnity of someone that is lost in her thoughts, but her eyes sparkle on the deepest of blues, watery and bright, reflecting Catra's own mismatched eyes. Catra exhales shaken, blinking quickly to try and wash again the sudden mist behind her eyelids. There are burning words boiling in the base of her tongue, acid and dreadful. Catra takes a breath, still swinging softly from side to side with Adora inside the circle of her arms.

"Adora, listen, what happened today at the town-" Catra's voice dies down at the sudden sparkle in Adora's eyes, the happy nods that encourages Catra to keep going. It would be so easy, wouldn't it? Tell her all the truth. She *needs* to tell her. About the boat and the yacht and the men with her skin. She would listen, Catra knows she would. This is not about Catra, this is about Adora, about who she is and what has been taken from her. *But.* She had been so happy in the town, her eyes sparkling, her smile wide as she looked at the candles and the flowers and the music. Even now, as she tilts her head to the side, her palms spreading over Catra's shoulder blades, the tenderest of touches between them, she looks happy. Happy to be there. Happy to be there *with Catra.*

"I- Don't worry about, Sparkles," Catra grimaces, mentally beating herself, but still keeps going. "She is really noisy but she is not a snitch. She is not going to go and tell everyone about you." Adora blinks, her curious expression melting into a comprehensive one. "She is just curious because I've always been alone up here. Everybody in this godforsaken town knows I'm an outcast. But you'll be safe."

Adora's eyes are fixed on hers, unwavering, absorbing every single word. She hasn't said anything else besides Catra's name but she doesn't need to. Somehow, Catra thinks that if she were to say something more right now or repeat Catra's name in that same tender, almost reverent tone as before, Catra would break and cry, so it's better this way.

Adora changes her hold, running her hands down the length of Catra's arms, gently, her cool finger pads raising goosebumps on the inner side of Catra's arm. Catra doesn't speak -she can't - only swinging at the rhythm of the music, eyes deep in Adora's as she drops her hands forward, circling her hands around Catra's waist, holding her close before spinning her around the kitchen floor in one smooth circle, stealing a surprised giggle from her.

"That was great" Catra says, in a thread of a voice "See? You are a very good dancer"

Adora is looking at her very intensely, unmoving and without saying a word. Her hands are still on Catra's waist, Catra's own hands have moved to rest above her shoulders. The music hasn't stopped playing, the soft lyrics echoing in Catra's brain without really making any sense at all.

Adora is shaking lightly, the movement barely tangible and of it wasn't because she is completely pressed against her, Catra would have missed it. Before she can even begin to question it, Adora leans towards Catra, her eyes never breaking contact, her face serious and determined -like a strategist about to do their most important plan of them all or a goddess, leaning towards the mortal world for just a secret moment of her time-, pressing their cheeks together and nuzzling her softly once, twice, her breath cold against Catra's bright red ear and her nose soft against her freckled skin. Catra giggles, she *giggles* , she can't avoid it, smiling honestly and wide for the first time in her entire life, all the dark thoughts inside her head melting and going away as she looks at the floor below their feet and the golden light of the chandelier above their heads.

"That tickles," whispers Catra, around a laugh, without bite or sarcasm at all.

Adora leans back, looking directly at her face as if studying her expression. Catra smiles at her, reassuring, catching an errand strand from Adora's hair and pricing it gently behind her ear, brushing the path of scales there gently.

Adora exhales heavily and leans towards her once more, nuzzling her again but this time deeply, with purpose. Her nose and lips travel from Catra's chin all the way up her cheek and the curve of her cheekbones, crossing the depths of the corners of her eye, across her temples and up to the beginning of her curls. She repeats it a few times, each one with a murmur in the base of her throat that sounds like a song and a lullaby and everything good. It's the gentlest touch Catra has ever felt, sweet and caring. Honest. Real. The lost tears in Catra's eyes start to fall almost slowly, with momentum, drawing paths of wetness down her cheeks. She can't stop them, she doesn't even try. And Adora doesn't stop. There is just a higher pitched him in her throat when she realizes Catra is crying, her nuzzling deepening. Her lips catch the errand tears like blooming roses to dew, breathe shaky and cold against Catra's damp skin. Catra sighs, her eyes fluttering almost close with the touch, blind behind the years and the tenderness.

"That's nice" she hears herself say, tiny. Adora hums again but doesn't speak, letting her cheek rest at the top of Catra's head, swinging at the sound of the music.

Catra doesn't have chocolate chip cookies for her birthday in the end, but this is better. Much better.



"Catra"

Catra opens her eyes to pitch darkness and Adora's bright blue eyes hovering mere inches from her face. There are like two lighthouses in the middle of the darkness, way too bright to be human. Human eyes don’t look this bright or this beautiful at wee hours of the night. It reminds Catra a little bit of Melog when they were much younger and used to wake up Catra

to feed them. Catra sighs, running her palm over her face, rubbing the mist of sleep out of her face.

"We really need to find another way for you to wake me up," whispers Catra, voice thick with sleep. Adora huffs with mirth, smiling. "Is everything okay?"

“Catra” Adora repeats and then, amazingly, adds with a smooth swirl of her fingers. " *Come with me* "

Catra blinks, puzzled as the words fit in place inside her sleepy mind. Adora’s human voice is low, a little bit scratchy in the edges, thick and strong. And she is *talking.* But- it's just Catra's name. Catra flushes pink, her cheeks warm, the print of the creases of her pillow marked on her cheek when the slow realization that Adora is also talking with *her hands,* starts to sink in.

"Are you hurt?" "Adora shakes her head. "Did you hear something?" One more shake. "Are they back?" Another shake.

" *Just come with me* " Adora signs, *signs holy shit,* outstretching her hand after, her fingers brushing over Catra’s knuckles.

Oh so she really is signing, fully. Where did she even learn that? Catra thinks, not with anger but with that same weird quick acceptance she has had through this entire thing. Catra sits up, stretching around a big yawn before taking Adora’s hand without hesitation. On any other day she would mock Adora or be sneaky and cool, or question since when the fuck she knows ASL and is able to form whole ass sentences. But not right now, she doesn’t have the strength or the want to put on a fight not even for the fun of it. And Adora is not saying anything else, in fact, the only thing she has said is Catra's name. A jolt of soft electricity arises between their skins when they touch, making even Catra’s teeth shake. Adora sighs, pulling from their joined hands as she helps Catra stand on her feet, watching over her as she trips lightly on her numb legs, much like Catra looked over her when Adora arrived at the house. Adora guides them through the bottom floor with ease, not even bothered by the darkness, knowing by now the path by heart. Or maybe she is just able to see extraordinarily well in the darkness, that wouldn't be a surprise.

Catra follows Adora up the stairs, rubbing her bleachy eyes as she tries not to trip with her own feet and making an absolute fool of herself. “So, are you finally luring me to eat me, pretty siren?” she asks, softly mocking Adora, her speech slurry with exhaustion. She doesn't even register what she is saying until it's fully out of her mouth, but when she does, Catra blushes a furious shade of red, looking at Adora sideways to make sure she interpreted it that way too.

Adora doesn't, she just rolls her eyes, her hold on Catra’s hand tightening a little before letting go just to sign quickly. " *I tried to nap on your couch today* ," Adora explains, reaching the top of the stairs. Her speech is a little bit slower, mindful, thinking over every word and signing them carefully, like someone who is remembering an old habit. There is an obvious edge that speaks of her own exhaustion. " *It sucks"*

"Be respectful with my couch" defends Catra as Adora pushes the door of her, previously Catra's, room. The bed is kind of a mess, blankets and sheets pushed in a ball at the foot of the bed, the soft pillows scattered in a half circle around the top on sides. The curtain of the huge window is pulled back, the glass slightly ajar so the sound of the sea enters the room gently, waves against the shore, the pebbles and sea glass making a sweet sound. Melog is sleeping on one of the pillows, their black fur strong against the pale blue of the cover. Their little ears shot up when the door opens, striking blue eyes opening to look straight at Catra with a soft wave of their tail, as if welcoming her before balling up again and falling right back to sleep.

Catra scans the room without understanding and then looks back at Adora who is watching her feet with a small frown in her eyebrows, worrying her bottom lip between her sharp teeth. "What?"

" *Sleep here"*

"Excuse me?" Catra almost shouts, a nervous laugh betraying her. Adora - sweet, kind, gorgeous Adora- just frowns deeper, throwing her shoulder back and repeating herself, this time looking directly at Catra.

" *Sleep here, with me* "

Catra looks at her, truly looks at her, her heart pounding painfully inside her chest, throat closing. Her mind is screaming inside her head, lashing like a hurricane against all her barriers. *Don't ruin it. Don't ruin it.* "Why?" she asks instead.

Adora's smile is kind, shy, her hands shaking just a little as they move through the air. " *I don't want you to sleep alone anymore."*

Catra exhales, already nodding. She is weak. She is weak and stupid and a liar and she can't say no to Adora. Maybe she really is enchanted now, maybe Adora had put a spell on her, by her music or her voice or the striking color of her eyes. She is a siren, after all. Maybe Catra is like one of Odysseus's sailors, fallen in the depths of Adora's sea. Or bed. Catra is fine with that, if Adora is going to drink her soul or her entire life, Catra is fine with that.

Adora doesn't, of course she doesn't. She is the gentlest creature Catra has ever known. Instead, Adora guides her again, this time towards the messed up bed, helping her under the tangled covers before slipping inside them too. They look at each other with half lidded eyes, noses brushing gently against each other. Adora smells strongly like salt, after being under the water of the bathtub for the last hours before going to sleep, and her breath smells a little bit like the coconut slices she had at dinner. Catra's breath shudders, a trembling exhale that doesn't go unnoticed between them, ruffling the baby hairs in her temples gently.

"How long have you been feeling better?" Catra asks. Her voice is a whisper, barely noticeable over the sound of the sea outside. Adora's eyes sparkle in recognition and she hovers closer, tucking her hands under the pillow.

" *Just- a little bit-"* Adora wrinkles her nose. Her hands hesitate in the space between them. " *We heal very fast* "

"Hmm"

Adora nuzzles against the soft pillow, sighing. This is so surreal for Catra, all of it, like a dream, but it also feels so normal. So- right. " *I liked being like that with you,"* Adora confesses. " *It made me feel* -" She stops, struggling with her words. Catra looks at her in silence, waiting, without pressuring her. She wouldn't even be able to speak even if she wanted to.

" *Vulnerable* " finally decides Adora, her cheeks pink, those trails of scales brightening her skin. *"In a good way. It made me feel that I could be myself. And that I would get to know you, really know you* "

Catra releases the air she didn't realize she was holding, nodding. Her eyes are wet, her heart tender. Adora must see it because she tangles blindly their fingers together, palm against palm, cradling them against her chest. " *We - you know what our voices do to mortals. Even in land, our voices aren't like yours. I- can't talk like you, you wouldn't understand me and it might drive you crazy. I didn't want that to get in the middle. I didn't want you to look at me like some- unapproachable being."*

"I don't," Catra assures automatically, "I didn't." Adora smiles and Catra's world shatters. "I thought that I was the- the unworthy one I guess? Things like this, they don't happen to me. Magic, myths, beautiful things." Adora's eyes sparkle and Catra tries to ignore the fact that she did just called her beautiful and magical. The fog inside her mind takes over instead. "I'm just- I'm nothing. I'm nothing, Adora, I'm just-" Catra gulps, wetting her dry lips. Adora looks at her with curiosity. Catra shivers, even under their shared warmth under the blankets.

" *You are grumpy"* Adora says, her eyes serious, honest, still clutching Catra's hand against her body. " *You are impulsive and stubborn and you have the mouth of a sailor* "

Catra grimaces, her shoulders rising. "Yeah, well, I don't make very good impressions anywhere-"

" *And you are kind* " continues Adora, cutting Catra's voice gently. Catra falls quiet, absorbing Adora's tiny smile inside her chest. " *You are benevolent and sweet and really brave. You have a good heart."* Adora exhale, voiceless but sweet. *"You saved my life"*

"Adora-"

" *You did* " Adora takes her other hand, this one placing it over her own cheek, just letting go of them so she can keep signing. Catra's hand is warm against Adora's cold face. " *You are* ."

You are nothing but a disgrace and a distraction, and none will ever want you the way you are.

The memory of the poisonous words slams against Catra so hard it makes her breathless. She locks her eyes in Adora's collarbone, in that secret space between her neck and the curve of her shoulder that Catra has dreamed about for countless nights now. Those words and many others alike repeat inside her head -they have never really gone away, in the first place-, reminding her that she doesn't get to have good things. That she doesn't deserve them. They

hurt and bite and tear apart until they start to die down, chased away by the soft rumble on Adora's throat and Catra hadn't noticed that she had begun singing, but it's working, the gentle sound making the memory of that woman extinguish like a candle held against the sea.

Catra closes her eyes tightly, washing away the tears and the knot in her throat. Adora's skin is soft under her fingers, the scales smooth. Maybe it is all a dream, just an hallucination of a mind that has been alone for too long. Maybe Entrapta is right and being isolated from the world is making her go mad and in the morning she will open her eyes and everything will be like three weeks ago. Maybe, *maybe* , so today, Catra can allow herself to be vulnerable and accept those words as true even if she knows they aren't. Her voice is thin and broken, still shaken, but she forces herself to talk anyway, falling into her usual bickering. It's safe, it's familiar. "Hell, does all this poetry and wisdom come with your newfound knowledge of sign language? Or what is happening here?"

For the split of a second, Catra thinks Adora might get offended or confused, but she only giggles, tucking her chin above Catra's head. " *Something like that"* Adora's hands change position, coming up to cradle Catra's shoulders and the lower of her back, tugging from her until her face is buried in that same forbidden space of before, breathing sea and sand from her skin. "Catra?"

"Hmm." Catra barely notices the last was a word voiced and high like the ring of a bell. In Adora's mouth, it almost sounds like a song, the only word Adora will ever speak.

" *I think- that I'm grateful to have lost my skin, if it meant knowing you."*

Catra digs her nails in Adora's sides, her pupils contracting until the black almost disappears completely among the bright colors. She can feel the sharp end of her nails catching in Adora's soft skin below the fabric of her white t-shirt, but Adora doesn't squirm away or make any signal that she minds it, or felt it at all. Outside, the first beams of the daw have started breaking through the thick darkness of the night, pink and lilac against deep blue.

"I'm still getting you home"

Adora smiles against her skin. She can feel her.

"I know "

End of chapter II

I love you—I do—but I am afraid of making that love too important. Because you're always going to leave me. We can't deny it. You're always going to leave.

– David Levithan , *Every Day*

MUSIC NOTES

The attic dance is inspired in this scene of the movie Little Women (2019) minute 1:30

Adora plays in the piano "Für Elise - reimagined" by Alexander Joseph x

The kitchen dance song is "Until I found her" (piano version) by Stephen Sanchez x

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed and thank you so much for reading!
Next chapter we are finally getting Adora's POV wohoo!
If you liked please consider bookmarking, commenting or sharing. See ya next chapter!
Be good :")

Beyond the marmoris and the cold breeze of her hips

Chapter Summary

All Adora has ever learned about love, is Catra.

Chapter Notes

ehehehe >:3

Warnings for this chapter: Mentions of depression, mentions of nudity at the end of the chapter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter III. Beyond the marmoris and the cold breeze of her hips

In the golden light of the sun on the water, I could see every freckle and blemish on her face, the flecks of light in her brown eyes.

– **Jane Healey** , *The Ophelia Girls*

Music that inspired this chapter x x x x x

" *Dawn* "

"Dawn?"

" *Is that weird?"* Adora nuzzles on their shared pillow, peach flush crawling in her cheeks.

"No it isn't" Catra's voice is squeaky and heavy with sleep, barely awake at all even though the sun has started pouring its light through the curtains for a while now. Catra squirms closer, her foreheads almost touching, just enough apart so Adora can sign between them. "I just didn't think your favorite part of the sea would be something that it's- not in the sea"

"Mmm" Adora hums sweetly under her breath, rubbing her cold cheek against Catra's. Catra's breath hitches for a second and for the hundred times in days, Adora wonders if Catra

actually knows what it means. " *That's because you haven't seen the dawn from below the surface."*

Adora pulls back in time to see Catra blink slowly at her, drowsy and soft as she only is during early hours of the morning or the quietest times at night. "Well, then tell me," Catra says, smirking.

Adora hums again, thinking as she catches a tangled strand of curly hair and brushes it behind Catra's flushed ear, her skin red and warm. Adora brushes the pads of her fingers over her forehead, considering her words.

" *It 's- pink.* " Catra snickers, pinching Adora in the side. Adora huffs, grabbing her hand away, tangling their fingers together so she can bring them to her lips brushing a tender kiss over the delicate skin of Catra's knuckles. " *Alright, alright. It's lilac and golden and pink, and other colors I swear humans can't see. And it's peaceful, the sea is calm without the moon. It helps me not to think.* "

Catra rumbles under her breath, a sweet sound almost like a purr, like Melog sleeping somewhere around their tangled feet under the blankets. She untangles her hand from the curve of Adora's neck, poking her in the middle of the forehead. "Didn't think you would need help with that."

Adora scoffs, without real offense behind it, waving Catra's hand away as she giggles, the corners of her eyes wrinkling softly.

Catra Grayskull is kind of an asshole and Adora absolutely adores her to pieces.

Catra rolls until she is resting on her back, looking at the ceiling with half lidded eyes. Adora marvels in her profile, softly illuminated by the light of the rising day, copper and gold under the sunbeams.

All of this is still so new for Adora. The feeling of things under her fingers, skin soft, too soft compared to the rough surface she is used to. The air is too crisp, the sand too warm. Her nails are blunt and her palms and arms so vulnerable. All of her seems different, lighter outside the water, quieter, less the sharp predator from the oceans and more something softer, gentler. Something made to hold Catra between her hands without hurting her. Even the colors seem dim with these eyes, missing the bright tones she is used to under the ocean that has been her home for so many years. The time itself seems to move slower up here, though that might be more of a Catra thing than a human one.

And Adora misses the sea devastatingly. Like a part of her that has been quite literally ripped off and taken away, keeping her from coming back to the waters she knows by heart. She misses the floor of the sea, full of life and colors, the sand darkened, the errand bones of animals, the jellyfish stinging in her fingers when they get too close. She misses the strong pull of the water around her body, the sound of animals humming to each other, the sun under the water. She even misses the hunt, the danger. Her sharp claws against a prey, swimming against mortal swirls of water, slashing against the steel stones. She thought she would die, those first moments after the hunters defiled her of what made her herself. She would die either by pain or by wounds or by the harpoons that almost slashed her face in half. Or by

sadness and rage. She thought she would die. And later and every single day since then, she mourned. Ripped out of her home, off her own skin and what she was before she was *Adora* . Wild. Free.

And still. *And still …*

"Were you with someone else? That day?" Catra asks, looking only at Adora's hands but not at her eyes, a blush climbing on her cheeks. Her frown is wrinkled and she is nibbling on her bottom lip -again- a sign that Adora has come to understand is a nervous habit. Adora knows she should be careful around humans, she has known it her entire life and it was just confirmed by those hunters, weeks ago. But Adora has never been very good at following rules, after all. And this is *Catra* . If there is something good in the world, that is Catra.

" *Nobody else comes to these waters. Only me* " answers Adora, shaking her head. Catra narrows her eyes, rolling her head to the side to look at Adora in the eyes.

"Why?"

Adora shrugs. " *Most First Ones don't like humans. They prefer to stay as far away as possible, for safety. The greed of humans is an old well known tale"*

Catra blinks, slowly, looking back at the ceiling with a nod. Adora told her the name they use for themselves the morning after her birthday. As with everything else, Catra took it calmly, normally, as if she had prepared her entire life to be thrown inside this world with the same elegance that Adora has come to know always characterizes her. She hadn't pressed Adora about anything, nor drowned her with questions, even if they burned behind the fire of her eyes. Catra seemed more worried about Adora letting her long healed wounds under the weird light of her weird thin block - *phone* -, than anything else. Catra had said something about preventing infections and a lot of things Adora didn't understand but she had been happy to comply with the weird thing, rushing at full speed with her hands about all the things she had been meaning to tell her for so long.

Adora stretches her hand, playing with the loose ends of Catra's curls against the sheets. She still has so many secrets to tell her, whispered among the lukewarm blankets and the honeyed shadows casted by the sun. She wants Catra to know everything, absolutely everything. All that Adora is and knows, all that she has seen and heard and learned. But first, there comes this. " *I used to come here all the time, though* ," Adora signs, gently. That calls Catra's attention. She rolls into her side again, locking her huge, owl eyes on Adora's. The turquoise and gold are so vibrant against the soft darkness of her face, it reminds Adora of the coral in the deep sea, precious. Adora gulps, suddenly nervous, unsure of how Catra is going to take it, even after everything. The last thing Adora wants, is to overwhelm her.

" *There was an old woman living here before you. She had round glasses and a pink dress and she was kind to me."* Adora watches Catra's throat, rising and falling when she gulps, and she has to hold back the need to bury her face in the angle of her neck with her entire strength, the lavender smell of her skin hitting Adora's nose delicately. Catra's eyes press tight but she nods, opening them again and cooing Adora to keep going. " *She saw me by accident once. I've never seen coral like the one that grows on the depths of this sea. I assured myself that I would be careful but then I saw a shadow casted right where I was and when I got to*

investigate I realized way too late it was one of those wood floaty things humans use at the sea "

"A boat" offers Catra, her voice thoughtful but soft.

" *Yes* ," Adora's hand taps over the mattress, her fingers so close to Catra's eyes she can feel the caress of her eyelashes over her skin every time she blinks. " *It was really scary, I had never been so close with a human before, at least not face to face, but I think she thought I was a seal. She even scolded me for being so curious"* Adora giggles, fond of the memories. " *With time, I saw her visit the shore more and more. She used to speak to the sea, the actual sea. I thought it was endearing. She was such a weird human. I got to trust her and- in the end I would take off my skin and actually meet with her too."*

Catra's eyes wide in surprise and mild alarm, her mouth falling open slightly. Adora rubs her hand against her own nape, apologetic. " *I never knew if she understood what was going on. I would come to the rocks you found me in and lean over there to talk with her. And she would say the most crazy things, it was nice, like hearing an old time storyteller* ." Adora breaks the breach between them, running her fingers under Catra's eyes, over the tiny dots that live in her skin there. Fifty nine. Fifty nine little dots. Adora has counted them. " *She taught me how to read and how to write. And she didn't mind getting soaked by the waves when it got too late on the day. She was a great human.* "

Catra sighs. Her lovely eyes turn watery and Adora can smell the light scent of salt on her cheeks. Adora's belly gives a sick spin, adrenaline shooting through her veins. *Did I say something wrong?* She panics for a second, looking at every side without knowing how to make it better. But Catra just holds out her hand, grabbing the hem of Adora's sleep shirt between her fingers, as if she only needed to anchor herself into something.

"She was my grandmother," Catra says, shaky. Adora's eyes are soft but she can't hide the confused frown out of her face. There are some words that still escape her and it makes her feel annoyed. Inadequate. But Catra is patient, searching for another term when she realizes Adora isn't understanding. "She was- the mother of my mother. My family. She was my family."

That's a word Adora knows. One that she holds close to her heart. She smiles, happy, and she thinks she can see the glint of something important in Catra's eyes. *"I supposed she was. You have the same eyes. And the same temper"*

That makes Catra smile too, but tiny, a little bit too tight on the edges. She looks like she is considering saying something, a fight going on inside herself before she speaks away. "She passed away" Catra explains and it almost sounds too apologetic, as if Adora was the one that belonged in the family and not Catra. " Years ago"

Adora breathes through her mouth, a sense of grief weighing over her heart even if it was a storm long ago foretold.

"I know " Adora signs, motions deliberated slowly, catching the sour expression in Catra's eyes, pained and nostalgic for someone she didn't get to know . *"I came one day but she*

wasn't there anymore. I came back every single day after day but the house always remained dark"

Catra remains quiet, just nodding, letting Adora know that she is listening. Her heartbeat is speeding up, Adora can hear it just as every time she is able to hear it speeding when Adora is close to her. It 's endearing. Catra bites into her lip, hard, the skin red. Adora's hand moves by itself, her thumb pressing against Catra's lip, rubbing off the sting from the blooming skin. Adora doesn't even realize what she is doing until their faces are most pressed together, nose brushing against each other. Catra's mouth has fallen open just slightly, the white of her teeth peeking, breath heavy. Adora gulps, the sides of her neck itching where her quills were once, her own heart beating inside her ribcage painfully.

Catra's body has gone tense, however, her nails grabbing into the bedsheets, almost tearing the fabric apart. Adora inhales, taking her hand away, keeping just enough distance between them over the rumpled pillows. Catra exhales between her teeth.

" *The day we met I came back out of habit only. I was on my way to migrate to warmer waters for the winter, but I wanted to swim in this waters before leaving"* Catra frowns, her face wrinkled in confusion. Maybe for a human, swimming under those weather conditions isn't that enjoyable. Adora shrugs. " *I like the rain over the sea. It makes the water dangerous."*

Catra's eyebrows shoot to her forehead, surprised, but a sly smirk starts to make her way on her lips, tension leaving her body little by little. She hooks her naked ankle behind the curve of Adora's calf, a silent signal to wiggle closer. If she wants.

"You really are a troublemaker" Catra says without any offense behind it. Adora chuckles, breathless, lowering her hand so she can run the back of her fingers over the skin of Catra's exposed shoulder. She starts gently, peeking at Catra's face for any sign of the touch being unwelcome. Catra hums, her skin rising in goosebump, but she doesn't move away, burying half of her face in the pillows, eye distant in thought.

"I am too. A troublemaker, I mean," Catra explains in a hushed voice, trembling on the edges. Adora doesn't comment on it, marking invisible circles over her skin. Catra seems almost to sink into herself as she speaks. "My foster mother, um, the woman I used to live with, she- used to say to me that nobody would ever love me for the way I am" Catra's voice hitches, Adora's fingers twitching over her, not stop its gentle movements. "Because of my temper and my character. She said it all the time. She said that it was to make me strong, to prepare me for the future that was to come for me, because I was just like her. I know how- how fucked up it is but I think it really managed to fuck up my brain in the end. To believe I'm not someone others can love"

Catra's voice thins and worn out, silence falling between them. Adora frowns, deeply, stopping her movements. She doesn't understand, she can't understand how humans can be so cruel to others, to themselves, to *Catra.* Adora is a predator, just like any other First One and merfolk alike. They hunt and tear and keep going. And even then, she can't begin to weigh how much the weight of words has wounded Catra. How she has been driven to believe *she* is the monster.

" *That's whaleshit* " Adora signs instead, frowning. It tears a chuckle out of Catra's throat, her eyes glimmering back to life.

"That bad?"

" *Yes* "

Catra nuzzles further in the pillows, following the waves of Adora's hands as she signs. "What part?"

" *All of it* " Adora frowns, straightening a bit so Catra can see the full movement of her hands in front of her. " *I've lived for a long time, Catra, I've seen humans for most of it, and I have never met someone more worthy of love than you"*

Something shifts in Catra's face, quick but important. Adora sees her inhale and exhale through her nose and mouth, her chest heavy over the sheets, and then the unmistakable shade of tears pooling inside her eyes without really falling at all. Adora's own heartbeat speeds up but she doesn't move or sign more, patiently waiting for Catra, allowing her to breathe even wiggling a little further away so she can have space. Catra catches Adora in the middle, her hand wrapping around Adora's elbow. Catra blinks quickly, washing the swift tears away and gives, nibbling at her bottom lip before smirking slightly.

"A long time? How old are you?" her voice is shaky and strained, the question guarded, meant to drive the attention away from her, but it's also sincere. Adora stares at her for a few seconds, studying her eyes and the angle of her mouth. Catra sees it because the muses of her face relax and she gives Adora an almost imperceptible nod.

Adora gives her a smile in return, softening too. *"Two hundred years? Years more, years less, I'm not sure."*

Catra makes a little strange sound, between a squeal and a strangle gasp. Her eyes widen like full moons and her mouth falls open just a gape. She recovers quickly, though, her stunned expression shifting into a wide grin, making her sharp canines flash when she smiles.

"I'm living with an elderly person," Catra says out loud, the edge of innocent bite clear in her voice. "Oh, I can't believe this, how are you looking like *this* while being so old? Is it the salt? "

Adora slaps Catra softly in the upper arm, the latter dissolving into a fit of loud, squeaky laughter, all tension and sadness forgotten.

Adora wonders if this is what love is. Something tender but also something cheerful. Something you work on because you know is worth it. Something you cherise and fight for. Something right.

Maybe this is what love *with Catra* is.

Catra nuzzles on the pillows, looking at her. Adora draws herself closer, pressing her cheek against Catra's, gently rubbing their noses and the side of their faces together on a lazy caress.

Catra's breath hitches, her hands curling over Adora's tank top, holding them close. When Adora drifts away, Catra's pupils are blown wide, black against the colors Adora has come to be so dearly fond of. She stretches her hand, running her fingers through Adora's hair, down the lines of the scar that stretches from Adora's eyebrow, across the corner of her eye and down the curve of her cheekbone. Adora doesn't mind scars, but there had been the slight fear inside her chest that Catra would. *She doesn't.*

"Tell me more, about the sea," she asks in a whisper, the morning sun shining in her eyelashes. Adora hums low in her throat, smiling.

" *Have you ever eaten a jellyfish?"*

"Ew"



Catra kicks on the pebbles at her feet, walking in the shore with slow steps. The air is chill, making her nose blush red and her hands to shake, even buried inside the pockets of her wool coat.

Adora is asleep, drifting off at some point in the morning after staying up for most of the night talking to Catra, her long hands elegant and memerizing as she signs in the space between them, her mouth brushing against Catra's cheek when she smiles at some dumb joke Catra had managed to blurt out.

Catra groans, pinching the bridge of her nose between her fingers. Being able to fully communicate with Adora had been incredible, not because it was better than their weeks before but because watching Adora describe things with that joyful playfulness that is completely hers had been the drop that had ended up to turn Catra's world completely upside down. She was a siren, a mythical creature of the sea, a predator -in Adora's own words, though Catra didn't agree-, and also the greatest creature Catra had ever met. She was proud and stubborn, playful and adventurous but quiet about her feelings, even as she slowly started to unfold around Catra's presence. She was kind even as she bit back when she was in pain -something Catra hated-, and selfless. And Catra is in love with her.

Catra growls, digging her boots inside the rough sand. Some part of her wants to run inside the sea and drown herself in it, the other part -the one that is absolutely terrified of water- just wants to sit in the sand and cry. Both parts agree that Catras has fucked up and that she has to suck it up and do her best to help until Adora decides to go. Like every single person before her.

The growl becomes a drowned whimper and into a quiet, sad sigh. Catra narrows her eyes to the sea, biting the inside of her cheek until she tastes copper in the base of her tongue. The shore narrows at the base of the cliff, close to the rocks she had found Adora in. There is a sound coming from behind them, a splash of water against the surface of the stones and something heavy dragging over the pebbles. Catra frowns, rushing close to the rocks without a second thought, peeking from behind them to see the origin of the turmoil. .

"Oh, hello," Catra greets, tilting her head to the side. "What are you doing there?"

The seal looks back at her, their huge eyes almost too intelligent, studying her. Catra gulps, shifting on her feet, unsure. She doesn't get closer, still shielded by the rocks. The seal is huge, way bigger than any seal she had ever seen before, their skin a light brown and gray, scattered with black spots. Catra drums her fingers over the rock, considering. So many incredible things have passed so maybe…

"Hey, um, do you know something about… skins?" Catra wheezes out, her ears red. She feels kind of ridiculous, if she is honest. The seal just looks at her, unmoving. "Look, I have a… a friend. She is like you. Well, not like you exactly, or maybe she is I'm not sure, but she lost her skin," Catra wets her lips, nervousness but also hate pooling in her mouth, throat clenching.

"Something happened and she… I can't find it. Do you know if there is another way? Can I get her another skin or…?" Catra's voice thins and dies down, the seal's expression stoic and unimpressed. Catra scoffs, laughing dryly at herself as she runs a hand over her face. "This is fucking ridiculous. I'm begging for help to a seal. What am I even doing?"

"Catra"

Adora's soft voice comes as it always does, in a sweet whisper that sounds like a song. Catra turns around, shoulders dropped as someone that has been caught in something. Adora is standing a few feet away from her, looking at Catra with something between amusement and softness. She is wearing one of Catra's old band shirts, the black fabric striking against her loose light hair, tucked inside the high waistband of a pair of worn out denim pants. Her feet are barefoot as always, and somehow the familiarity of it makes Catra's tension start to dissolve.

"Hey, you are awake." Adora smiles but there is obvious curiosity inside her eyes. Catra exhales. "I was just talking to… um, a seal"

Adora's eyebrows rise, curiosity written all over her face as she gets closer. Catra extends her hand almost without thinking, holding Adora's and helping her steady over the wet sand near the rocks. Adora smirks at Catra, squeezing her fingers together as she leans over the stones and peeks into the sea. Adora's eyes widen, a flash rushing through them when she sees the seal. Even her hold in Catra's hand tightens, her fingers crushing hers. Catra frowns, studying Adora's profile.

"I just thought that…" *fuck.* Catra damps her lips, kicking herself mentally to keep it together, "Maybe they would be able to help. Or know something. But I think they can't-"

" *He can understand you* " Adora signs, letting go from her hand without looking at Catra. " *But he doesn't trust you* "

"Oh." Catra chews on the inside of her cheek, unsure of what else to say. She looks sideways towards the seal, his dark eyes digging holes in the side of her face and for the first time Catra notices how actually charged and calculating that stare is. Catra shifts in her feet, uncomfortable, starting to walk away from the rocks.

Adora catches her midway, wrapping her hands around Catra's waist, stepping in front of her. They slip a bit over the sand and pebbles, barely missing a fall. Catra grunts, holding herself to Adora's ribcage. Adora doesn't miss a single look to her, lowering her hands but leaning at the same time until she can press her forehead against Catra's, pressing their noses together.

" *It's not…you"* Catra sees her sign through the corner of her eyes, slow enough so Catra can understand her without having to lean away. Catra gulps -for a very different reason than the disapproval of a seal-, her mind frustratingly slowly understanding.

"Is it because I'm a human?" Catra asks, her breath sharing its warmth with Adora's cold cheek. Adora nods.

" *Yes"*

Catra sighs, closing her eyes for a second. "Okay. That's fair." This Catra does lean away, searching Adora's eyes with hers. "Can you understand him?" A nod. *Okay then.* "Alright I'll leave you so you two can…speak?"

Adora smiles, nodding again, a little bit tighter than usual. Catra tightens her coat against herself, stomping over the spark of sudden anxiety on her chest. What exactly does she think is going to happen? The seal will eat Adora? Of course not. By the way Adora is throwing glances at the rocks, Catra understands she might even *know* the seal -another cold reminder to Catra that she is nobody to call Adora hers-

Catra steps away, slipping from Adora's light hold, walking back to the house without looking back.

Adora watches Catra skip over the dark pebbles and over the steps of the house, her shoulders dropped by the cold and freezing breeze, trembling until she finally walks inside the house.

There is rustle behind Adora, back into the rocks. Water splashing against the stone and something heavy dragging in the pebbles until all the sound stops altogether.

"Are you luring her out to eat her?" comes the voice, low and thick, raspy with little use and the evident drag of words that are not human. Adora exhales, turning to the stones with her back wound up tight.

Her brother leans over the sharp edges of the rocks, bare from waist up from his skin, deep blue and grey scales scattering all over the length of his arms and chest, his hair a shade closer to green than Adora's honey. His song is loud and clear for Adora, though his mouth doesn't open at all, stretched by the rows of his sharp teeth and Adora is glad Catra got inside the house because he has no regard about using his song in front of humans, or what it might cause to them.

Adora crosses her arms over her chest, the relief she feels at the sight of her brothers tampered by the alarms inside her head when he drags his black eyes towards the house.

"No, I'm not. She is not a prey." Adora answers back in her song, clear as a bell for both of them. Her brother's smile widens, obviously pleased to hear her speak in their own language.

"You could though. She is definitely in love with you already, it would be easy to drown her, way easy."

Adora digs her nails into her forearms, trying not to show on her face the way her entire world brightens completely at her brother's words. It doesn't work, she knows by the expression he is giving her, all deep gills and deadly teeth. Adora grinds her own teeth together, the tips chipping under the pressure.

"She's is my friend"

Her brother doesn't answer, nailing his eyes against hers. Both move at the same time. Adora rushes the last steps between the sand and the rocks, her brother leans impossibly further over them, wrapping their arms around each other into a tight hug. Adora nestles her head in the angle of her brother's neck, golden scales sprouting on her face and arms.

"I thought you were dead," mumbles her brothers against her hair, petting the back of her head with his long, sharp hand. Adora hums, leaning back so she can give him a sideways smile, treacherous tears hanging from her eyelashes.

"You should know better." He laughs, shaking his head at Adora's mirth.

They remain quiet, Adora as a human, her brother as a selkie, regarding each other until the gills around his neck start to shift and tremble with anger, a furious growl breaking through his chest, his calm and relieved expression breaking into something dark.

"I warned you not to come into these waters. I told what could happen" he says, song loud. For any human, it must sound like the moan of the winds or the cry of the sea against the shore. Frightening but familiar. Adora doesn't leave her guarded expression, lifting her chin in defiance.

"I've been safe"

"Safe? Look at you. I've been looking everywhere for you and here I find you, embracing a human that doesn't even touch the water," her brother snarls, furious before Adora's human appearance. Adora takes her arms away from him, fists her hands around Catra's shirt, anchoring to the soft fabric. It still smells like clean soap and her.

"I have," Adora repeats, anger starting to tighten quickly in the bottom of her mind. "Catra saved me. She is not like the humans you talk about."

"All humans are the same!" He lashes with the whip of the ocean against the cliff, cutting. "And *we* are not like the humans"

"I think you'd find we are more like humans than you think" Adora bites back, song high too but still remaining calm. The wind has started to shift, hitting harder against the shore and the sea.

"We don't hunt for pleasure or cruelness, they do."

"Catra is not like that"

Her brother clicks his teeth together, threatening. Adora doesn't care, she doesn't even flinch. She was like him too, sharp teeth and heart full of fear. She doesn't blame him. He studies Adora closely, the pattern of her scales, the look of her hair and skin, the wide scar on the side of her face. His eyes narrow, something cold and merciless washing over his demeanor.

"Where is your skin?"

The question hits Adora with the force of the water. Over their heads, the sky breaks into lightning.

"I-" Adora stutters, hesitates. "I don't know"

Her brother's expression breaks, mouth finally opening, letting see through the rows and rows of fangs and shark teeth there. His body turns to the side, leaning towards the house with newfound fire. "I will kill her"

" *yfílios* !" Adora's song breaks louder, scarier, a hundred times lethal. The lightning shakes and then ceases all together, the clouds retreat over themselves, the ocean quieting again. Deadly calm falls over the shore and them, heavy and sticky with Adora's sudden anger. "Don't touch her or I'll rip your throat off, *brother* "

Adam's eyes widen in clear surprise, the dark of his pupils bleeding back into blue. There is genuine surprise on his face, but he pushes it down, scowling deeply at Adora with incredulity in his eyes. Adora recoils on herself, the sudden anger that is boiling in her veins evaporating, leaving only shame behind. She had never raised her voice like that, much less *threatened* her own brother. What was wrong with her?

Adam narrows his eyes, studying her close. He doesn't seem angry or offended but his eyes are ice cold. " How do you know she doesn't have it?"

"She doesn't"

"Your skin is gone and she has you in her bed. You *reek* of her." The words are hurtful, cold, meant to hurt. But they don't. Adora doesn't allow them to. There is no shame in loving Catra.

"She doesn't" Adora repeats, pointing every word of her song with a snarl. It doesn't last much. Her face relaxes, anger going slack. She knows Adam would never hurt something that Adora cares about. He is angry and weary, but he is good, and he worries about her. Adora knows this. And she knows she should elaborate, explain to him what is happening. That Catra stitched her wounds together and put salt on her water, that she gave Adora space

and safety, that it was Adora who brought Catra inside her bed, not the other way around. But she doesn't want to, she doesn't want to talk about Catra's profile against the light of the sunset, about her eyes like sea glass, always carrying some kind of sadness that Adora wishes she could carry for her. She doesn't want to talk about the nights they've spent together, about Catra's sleepy breath against her cheeks and the long hours Adora has laid awake looking at her sleeping because when Catra is dreaming her face relaxes and she looks younger, happier. Adora doesn't want to talk about how much she loves her because that and all the rest belongs to her, to *them.* So instead, Adora says this, "I know you don't trust humans but I trust her and you need to trust me"

Adam considers her, weighs her words. His gills and scales are still ruffled with the jolt and anger, mouth set in a firm line, but he has calmed down. There is a curious hint in his eyes, something that looks almost like pride, buried beneath the doubt.

"You've never acted like this before," Adam says, smirking. It throws Adora a little bit off.

"Like what?"

"This" Adam waves his hand, signaling at Adora and the house Catra is in. Adora squirms, unconsciously leaning her body toward the house, interfering with Adam's gaze.

"Well, maybe it was about time for me to rebel from First One's prejudices"

Adam's eyes are still steel cold in the corners, doubt creeping in them. Adora knows him, he is her brother. They've been together when everything else was gone, when their parents left them as soon as they could hunt on their own, as every First One parent does. He is smart, he *knows* her. "You act as if she was your mate."

The words fall colder over Adora than rain. She scrunches over herself, her shoulders falling, wrapping her hands over her upper arms. Adam searches her eyes but she ignores him, looking away, into the water.

"You can't be serious, *latrévei* "

Adora curls over herself even further, biting into her lip, tasting her own blood when her teeth break skin.

"I miss the sea," Adora says, still not looking at him. "I miss swimming. I miss my skin and what I was with it. I miss what I am, Adam, it *hurts* . But-" her song trails off, drowned by her thoughts. Adam is right, she is acting like it. It's not the first time she has thought about it, it won't be the last. "You have a mate."

"Teela is a First One not a human."

"I don't care about that"

"Clearly," Adam rolls his eyes in a gesture that is such of her brother that makes her snicker, even over the tension of it all. "Humans don't have the same perception of mates as we do, Adora."

"This is different, Adam." Her brother growls, not convinced at all. "It is"

She doesn't elaborate, Adam doesn't ask more. He drags his eyes through the pebbles at Adora's feet, digging in her skin.

"I thought hunters had killed you," Adam confesses in a murmur. "When you didn't meet us in the usual spot. I've been looking for you in every place I could think of"

"I'm sorry," Adora apologizes, honest, shame and sadness falling over her before her brother's worry. She did disappear, after all. She was hunted, she was almost killed. Adam is not wrong. Just remembering that night makes Adora want to scream and cry. "Catra saved me."

Adam's growl deepens. He doesn't answer, not for a long time. When he does though, his song is calmer, easier for the mind and for the sea.

"Fine." He doesn't say more but Adora knows he is talking about Catra. Adora sighs, relieved. Far away in the sea, a high sound reaches them with the wind, the waves of another song, calling for him. Adam's face contorts, fighting with himself. "I can't stay. Teela doesn't do good in cold waters, we need to migrate"

Adora nods, pulling from the loose strands of Catra's pants. "I know"

Adam tilts his head, grinding his teeth. "I don't want to leave you *here* either"

"I'll be alright." Adam clicks his teeth together unsure. "I will be"

Adam leans against the stones again, wrapping his arms around Adora's neck. "I'll be back when the water is warmer." Adora smiles, even though he can't see her, palming him in the back. "Find your skin, Adora. Promise it"

Adora's eyes water with tears but she nods. "I promise"

When Adam leaves, Adora sees him pull his skin over him completely, turning him into what Catra called a seal. And for the first time in her life, Adora feels jealous, just a spark, just enough to make her feel bad. Jealous not because he is leaving, but because he is free to choose if he does it or not.

Adam lingers in the sea for a while more until a new call from Teela comes and then he is gone.



Catra is doodling in a loose piece of paper, trying not to lose her mind. She stressed cleaning the kitchen for a while. And then she opened and closed her laptop almost with anger, scolding herself. As if she was going to be able to get anything wrote down right now.

So now she is sitting here, in the kitchen's island, scribbling without thinking until she realizes it's actually Adora's profile. Catra groans, throwing the pencil halfway through the

counter, frustrated.

The door opens and closes a few minutes later and Adora enters back into the house, leaving a trail of sand behind her. Her shoulders are slumped forward and her hair damp with sea water. Her face is paler than usual and she smells like salt.

She's been crying, Catra thinks, her stomach clenching inside her.

"Is everything alright?" Catra asks, wrinkling her nose when her voice comes off shaky and unsure. Adora raises her eyes, locking her gaze with Catra's. She tries to smile but it flutters down, the corners of her lips pulling down.

Adora walks past Catra, sitting over the edge of the back of the couch, her long legs dangling over the floor. She looks at Catra again, her hands twitching. She seems to be considering something, hesitating before she starts signing.

"It was my brother"

Catra blinks, confused. She thinks the morning over, piecing the words together until she manages to understand. "The seal? The seal is your brother." The last part comes as an affirmation. "Your brother is a selkie."

Adora nods, smiling tiny at her. *"He came looking for me, he thought-"* She doesn't say more, she doesn't need to.

"He thought you had been captured," anger and shame pools in Catra's chest, closing her throat. She understands now, the distrust, the seemingly -totally- hostile looks. Can Catra blame him? Of course not. "Adora -"

" *Adam has never liked humans,"* Adora explains, hands moving quickly before her. She seems almost desperate to explain. *"I explained it to him, I told him you saved me. I don't… he can't understand it, but he is calm now. He was just-"*

"Scared," Catra ends, running her nails over the counter. She looks towards the door and back to Adora, digging the nails of her other hand into her palm. "Is he here?"

Adora is already shaking her head. " *He is gone. He is migrating to the south with his mate for the winter."*

"Okay," Catra says, but frowns, chewing in the word. *Mate.* Mate. "Is he… is there someone else looking for you, Adora?"

Adora tilts her head to the side, her eyebrows wrinkling without understanding. Catra flushes red, suddenly embarrassed. Who does she think she is to be asking that?

" *There is nobody else,"* Adora signs. Her eyes sparkle and for one too long second, Catra thinks Adora understands what she is truly asking. *"First One's parents leave when we are pretty young. It's only ever been Adam and I. And Adam found his mate recently. So it 's just me. Only me."*

Catra exhales, nodding. "Are you -" she stops again, reformulating in her head. Of course Adora is not okay. She has lost her skin, her brother, the sea. There is nothing Catra can offer her bigger than that. "What can I do?"

Adora's tiny smile finally stretches into one of her usual, soft grins, wide enough to make the corner of her eyes to wrinkle, her cheeks coloring pink. *"Nothing that you are not already doing, Catra"*

Catra wants to bang her head against the wall every time Adora talks to her like this because what is she supposed to understand out of it? What is she supposed to believe?

As Catra keeps having a full blown internal crisis, Adora leans to the other side of the couch, fetching something from the seat. When she turns back to Catra, there is a huge smile on her face. It's obvious that she had pushed down her sadness deep inside her again. Catra hates every time Adora does that, but the latter doesn't even let her comment on it. Adora stretches her arms, offering something to Catra, who takes it without thinking.

" *Finished* "

Catra blinks at the book, slowly registering it's *her* book, the one that Catra wrote and Adora has been reading avidly for the past weeks. "Oh, what did you think?"

"I liked it. I liked the horror "

"You did?" Catra asks, truly surprised, warmth pooling in her belly.

"I did. It scared me, it was great " Adora swings her feet over the floor, smiling from ear to ear. " *I don't agree with your heaters. If all it needs more horror* "

Readers, Catra thinks, but doesn't correct her, too speechless to even think about it. "More horror, for real?"

" *Yes and I disagree too that the protagonist should have a love interest* "

"Why?" Catra can barely hold back the squeak in her voice but Adora doesn't notice it.

" *She is her own person. She has enough dealing with her demons and her nightmares. She doesn't need a love plot to make her story interesting or great. She is awesome* "

Kiss me, Catra thinks, exploding in her mind like a grenade.

"Okay" she says instead, mentally beating herself.

Adora grins, looking back at the bookshelf in the living room. " *Is there another?"*

"No, I'm working on the second one but it's taking a while." Adora pouts -pouts- nodding in understanding. Catra can't deal with Adora's crestfallen expression. "But I still have some short horror stories that I wrote in college and high school. You could read those if you want" Adora's entire face brightens like a damn lightbulb. It's not fair, how can she be so bright and

curious all the time? She is exactly the type of person Catra can't stand and she is completely in love with her. "They are in one of the boxes at the bottom of the bookcase"

Adora practically jumps from the back of the couch, rushing forward so she can rub her cheek against Catra's and then jolting towards the living room, tripping with her own feet.

Catra chuckles, out of breath, letting herself fall over the back of the chair. She knows this is not going to end well for her, she knows it in her bones. And yet she couldn't fight the fear she felt of losing Adora, of her leaving, leaving with her *family.* Catra whimpers in the angle of her elbow, digging her nails over her upper arms.

A soft sound comes from the living room, a thud and a ruffle like something that has fallen over. Catra raises her head from her self-pity crisis, narrowing her eyes towards the other room. When no other sounds come, she stands up, legs wobbling, walking past the couch and towards the wall where most of her books are neatly organized.

"Adora? Are you okay?"

Adora is kneeling on the carpet of the floor, resting her weight over her ankles. A box is opened in front of her, several papers and more books pulled carefully aside. Adora is holding something between her hands, square shaped and small enough that Catra can't make sense of it from her spot behind Adora.

Adora turns when she hears Catra coming, resting the square over her knees so she can sign quickly at her.

" *Who is this?"*

"Who?"

" *This lady* " Adora points at the square that now Catra can see is a framed picture, worn out and old behind the crystal. " *She looks a lot like you* "

Catra kneels next to Adora, their shoulders and legs bumping against each other when she leans over. She can see the picture fully now, goosebumps rising over her entire body when she understands.

"Oh, that's not- that's not the box-" Adora is looking at her, her eyebrows knitted in worry. Catra clears her throat, tapping her finger over the picture. "Um, that's my mother"

Adora's eyebrows arch, looking at the picture. There is a woman there, standing over the surface of a white boat. Her smile is crooked and mischievous, wild curls flying around her head and face like a crown. The photo is old, yellowed with time and has long since washed away the colors, but Catra knows the eyes of the woman are blue. She knows them, it's the only thing she hasn't been able to forget of her. "She died. A long time ago"

Adora's eyes saddened, running her fingers over the frame of the picture. It's obvious it was well loved and cared for many years, up in some spot in the fireplace. " *Do you remember her* ?"

"I was very young when she died" Catra runs her fingers atop of Adora's, looking at the photograph without really seeing it. "But, I do remember some things. She smelled like vanilla and clean sheets, and she sang to me. I remember what her hands felt like against my cheek and her eyes" Adora turns her palm around, tangling their fingers together, her hold and eyes reassuring when Catra looks back at her. "I guess I always thought they were more my own inventions to not feel so alone in the orphanage."

Adora frunces her lips, taking her hand back to sign and Catra immediately misses the cold touch of her skin against hers. " *What happened to her?"*

"She drowned" Catra is blunt, told like someone would rip a bandage off a wound. Adora flinches. "At least that's what my lawyer said. She was a marine biologist or something like that. The ship she was in suffered an accident and sank. I was with my grandmother, um, with Razz." Catra looks around them, at the items of the house that still hang since her grandmother's time. "They took me away almost immediately after."

Catra looks back, biting on her cheek. Adora is staring at her, unmoving, blink very slowly. Almost shyly, her hand wraps around Catra's again, leaning to her until her forehead and nose is pressed on the side of Catra's face, her breath hovering just above Catra's lips. Catra tenses, relaxes, tenses again. She feels like she should be saying something, a joke maybe, a cold hearted comment to break the tension, probably, but it doesn't come. The only thing that comes is a broken exhale that she identifies as hers and the dreadfully familiar feeling of tears biting at the corner of her eyes. Catra doesn't want to cry, she doesn't want *Adora* watching her cry. Crying is a liability, a weakness, a deadaway that something is irreparably broken inside Catra and nobody wants to deal with something broken, nobody wants to risk cutting themselves with the sharp pieces, or bother trying to place the pieces together. Catra understood that very soon and very hard in life.

But Adora closes her eyes, resting her weight against Catra, breathing slow and calm over her skin and she is not trying to put the pieces together, she is cradling them as they are, sharp edges and all, and Catra can't right against it at all.

"I miss her. I've missed her my entire life," Catra confesses in a whisper, lost between both of them. She can feel the slow start of a rumble in Adora's chest but nothing more. Now that the words are out for the first time in Catra's life, she understands how true they are. Catra grids her teeth, bites in her tongue, but in the end she let's the tears fall, running down her chin and slashing tiny over her hands. She knows Adora can feel them over her skin and somehow it makes her cry harder. "I'm sorry you couldn't go with your family, Adora"

They are pressed to close together, she can feel when Adora's breathing comes to a stop, every patch of skin in her body shivering and shifting with the sprouting of scales and it lets Catra know how much and how deep she is *feeling* right now.

Catra wants to retreat, panics, thinks about starting to apologize for something, everything, but Adora doesn't let her. She just nuzzles further in Catra's, exhaling, and Catra can feel the start to another set of tears falling between them, this time from another set of eyes, brushing over Catra's skin and mixing with her own. The shakiness of Adora's breathing, the temple of her hands. It hurts. Catra thinks she can feel it like a pain of her own. It hurts.

They stay like this for a while, silently crying on each other's side. Soft steps made by soft paws approach them as Melog males themself tiny between their bodies, nuzzling them both on their arms. Their purr picks up as the roll over them, their little head stop of their joined hands, their tail lashing lazily over Adora's lap. It feels homely, familiar in a way Catra has never known. She opens her eyes just a slid, peeking at Adora's face against hers. Her eyes are closed and her nose is red with salted tears. The pink of her lips hovers just above Catra's mouth, far enough to make her miss her, close enough to turn her insane. There is so much tenderness and softness in the space between them, things Catra has only even know with Adora. Things she craves and wants and longers for and that are always just ablve her reach. Just far enough.

Lean in, Catra's mind hammers inside her brain, or maybe is her heart, sick of being in pain for so long. *Just lean in, just do it. Just go with her.*

She could. She wants to. Catra has never wanted anything else more than this.

"Do you want to come to the market?"

Adora leans back, blinking back the mist that had gathered inside her eyes. She is flushed pink, her nose, cheeks and even ears. It makes the golden of her hair to accentuate and the pale scales over her forehead to shines. She is so beautiful, Catra wants to cry again.

Adora seems to take a while to understand Catra's words -Catra herself takes a while to understand what she just said-, tilting her head to the side with curiosity.

"I mean- today is the Samhain" Catra scrambles inside her brain, trying to find anything brilliant to say. "I thought you may like it-"

Adora surges forward suddenly, squishing her nose against Catra's in a sweet but way too excited nuzzle, almost making both their heads bump in the way. She jumps from the carpet, carefully leaving the framed picture over the dinner table before leaning back down, grabbing Catra's forearm and dragging her upwards in one strong swing, basically dragging her to the door.

"Wait- wow, alright. Right now? Wait, Adora, you dumbass! My shoes!"



Adora *loves* the market -whatever a market might be, she is not sure yet- but she loves it.

By all starters, it smells crazy. There are so many smells coming from everywhere, some of them strange, some of them unpleasant, but most of them absolutely delicious. The town is buzzing with energy, humans going in and around, circling each other, talking, singing, laughing. Little humans -children- are running around the legs of the rest, chasing each other playfully, pushing the wheeling chairs of their friends around the streets, painted with flower petals and tinted powder, and holding the hand of those who can't see, guiding them around the several gifts and goodies shops.

Adora is chewing on an apple covered in caramel and burnt sugar that Catra had gotten for her at some point. It was, as every else she had been eating for the last hours, the most delicious thing she had ever tasted. It could even knock the jellyfishes off her chart, if she was honest.

Catra is walking next to her, carrying a bag full of fresh food on one shoulder, her hair bouncing behind her where it had spilled from her ponytail. Her face is serious but calm, taking in the town and its people around them with high alert. She had spent most of the drive to the town explaining to Adora that they needed to be careful. Not calling attention at all. Adora knows she is still scared -Adora is scared too- and that it worries her -even if she would never admit it out loud- about the hunters of that night or any other hunter around. Catra had even convinced Adora to change into a high neck gray sweater and to let her hair fall around her face freely, in case of any kind of sudden scale - sprouting. Just to be careful. Adora would usually be extremely capable of controlling her scales, but around Catra, she wasn't sure anymore. Just seeing her made every single nerve in Adora's body want to jump out and bounce in joy.

There is cheerful music echoing across every corner of the streets, reaching even the shore and rows of colorful boats. Adora got nervous at the beginning at the sight of the boats, but the joy that surrounded them had quickly washed it away. That and the fact that Catra had taken her hand the entire time, walking side by side around the town. Adora bites into the last of her apple and sighs, leaning her head so she can rest her cheek atop of Catra's head. Catra's curls tickle her in the nose and it makes her laugh.

They come to a stop in one of the stalls scattered across the street. There are dozens of fruits and candies displayed on the counter and the small bags behind it. Two persons are attending it, an elderly woman with silver hair and a round and sweet face and a elderly man, slightly shorter than the woman, his face a little bit red with the autumn sun and his eyes just as kind as the other.

Catra leans towards the items, asking several questions about them in a kind voice. Adora smiles at her, staring at the side of her face. The black of her turtleneck sweater makes her mismatched eyes pop and her hair curls tighter around her ears, held up only by a red hairband. Adora feels happy, she feels so happy every time she sees her.

A new smell calls her attention, something sweet but also savory coming right from the stall next to them. Adora turns to the place, eying the food there. There are long golden squares, small circles sprinkled with something white, tiny biscuits and bigger ones that Adora knows are called cupcakes. The entire stall is bursting from top to bottom with the food, still warm and delicious. Adora turns back to Catra who is already looking at her, eying the stall and back to Adora with a knowing smirk.

"It's bread," she says and then repeats the last word at the same time her hands move -the left one held in front of her sideways, palm towards her chest, fingers closed. The right one hovers over the back of the left, this one with the fingers curled inwards and the thumb held up, making the motion of slicing over the back of her other hand- signing it at the same time. " *Bread."*

Adora smiles, repeating the sign. " *Bread"*

"Yes," Catra grins, tilting her hip to the side with her hand resting over it. She gives Adora a smart look, pointing at the bread stall with her chin. "Go, dummy. I'll be here."

Adora beams at her, leaning so she can nuzzle their noses together and then skipping happily towards the bread stall with a wide smile on her face.

Inside the stall there are two women. The first one is tall, taller than Adora, with beautiful dark skin and a deep blue hijab around her head and neck. She is wearing a jumper of a clearer blue and a turtleneck orange sweater under it, the sleeves cuffing at her wrist with twinkling golden bracelets. Her expression is serious but kind, with black eyes sparkling with some kind of hidden wisdom and her full lips twitching in a small smile. The sound woman is slightly shorter than the first, with long, wavy hair held in a braid behind her and a lilac and blue shirt and jeans. She is looking at Adora with curiosity, a kind smile in her smile. When she tilts her head, Adora can see the shape of a small conch cradle behind her ear.

" *Hello* " Adora greets, smiling. The woman's smile widens impossible bigger, her eyes shimmering.

" *Hello, darling"* she signs right back, small breathy sounds accompanying her when she signs. " *I'm Mara and this is Hope. What can we get for you?"*

Adora grins, running her eyes through the bread. She doesn't know the name of most of them but they all look amazing. She grabs the small paper Catra had handed her at the beginning of the market -money, she called it, to trade for things- and hands it completely to the woman.

" *I want everything that is worth this paper, please"*

Mara blinks at her, surprised. Her smile softness and she pushes Adora's hand with the money gently back, shaking her head. *"What about this? I'll give you one of each so you can try them out and find which one you like. It's the Samhain anyway, it's time for giving."*

Adora nods, delighted, watching avidly as Mara and Hope start packing carefully every bread in paper bags and those inside a basket. At some point, Adora sees Hope lean towards Mara and press her lips against her cheek and forehead, signing something Adora can't understand.

Mara hands Adora the basket full of bread short after, grinning. Adora waves excitedly at Hope behind her, distracted with another customer.

" *Is she your mate?"*

Mara looks at her stunned, dissolving into a breathless laugh. *"I guess so. She is my wife"*

Adora wrinkles her nose, confused. She has heard that term before and knows its sign but nothing else. *"What is a wife?"*

Mara taps her own chin with her finger, thinking. "Um, *you'll see, a wife is the person I've chosen to love"* Mara nods to herself, grinning brightly to Adora. *"Hope is the person I've chosen to be with for the rest of my life, no matter the hardships or the joys, I will stand with her and love her, irrevocably. So a wife is someone you choose"*

Adora absorbs the words within herself, warm and fuzzy like an embrace, like swimming in a clean sea at dawn, resting over the sand of the bottom, swirling around the caves and the coral. She smiles, sure. Of course, she knows what a wife is as well as she knows what a mate is.

"What does it mean? That thing she told you?" Adora asks again, this time talking about the sign she didn't recognize. Mara's eyes are narrow, thoughtful. She leans over the counter, looking at the busy street around them until she spots Catra in the stall next to them. She is talking with the people there but her eyes dart every few seconds to Adora, cheeks pink, making sure she is well.

Mara smirk is pleased when she leans back. She fishes a paper and a single pen from the pockets of her jeans, scribbling something over it and passing it to Adora swiftly. Adora takes it, reading it avidly.

It means 'I love you'

Adora looks from the paper and meets Mara's eyes, grinning, who tilts her head and asks kindly, " *Do you want me to teach you how to say it?"*



"Catra! Hey, you!"

Catra turns from where she has been inspecting a jar of marmalade, searching and -sadly- finding the owner of the voice.

Glimmer - *wonderful, absolutely fantastic* - walks towards her, perched from the arm of Bow - *even fucking better* - smiling brightly at her, all silver dress and pink crop top and that multimillionaire smile that makes them both look like some kind of top model pulled out of a queer version of a fashion magazine.

Catra groans, rolling her eyes back and trying as hard as possible to not look towards Adora's direction. Of course she had to cross with Sparkles *and* Arrows today of all days. Brilliant. Fantastic idea Catra.

"Do you seriously have nothing better to do than bothering me?"

"We are happy to see you too, Catra," Bow says back, shaking his head in fond disapproval. He turns to greet the sellers behind the stall, smiling kindly at them. "Good morning Mr. and Mrs. Thaymor"

"Well, good morning Beauregard, darling. How are your fathers?" Mrs. Thaymor asks, handing Catra the last of her bags. "Here you go, darling, my best 'ate de guayaba' just for you. I know how much you love it."

"They are doing great, thank you. We'll meet at the festival later" answers Bow, grinning from ear to ear.

"Wonderful! Oh to be young again. Mr. Thaymor, darling, what happened to that bag of pumpkins?" Mrs. Thaymor trails off, lovingly scowling at her husband and completely distracted from the other three.

"What are you doing?" Glimmer asks, eyeing the bag of food hanging from Catra's shoulder with a curious look. Catra throws her the single most cold-hearted stare that she can, baring her canines at her in a mocking threat.

"Obviously buying ingredients so I can curse the town later"

"Obviously," Glimmer rolls her eyes, huffing. She gets distracted too, looking at something over Catra's shoulder that makes her entire face brighten like the cat that got the bird. Catra's stomach drops. "Adora! You are here too!"

Catra turns her head as Adora approaches. She is carrying a basket full of what it seems is pretty much half of the stall. And Adora looks so proud, dangling the basket over her elbow. She stops at Catra's side, looking at her with the softest expression ever. She doesn't even notice Glimmer and Bow standing there, looking at both of them with curious expressions.

" *Bread* ," Adora signs, beaming with pride. Catra smiles at her, all her barriers crumbling into dust in a matter of seconds.

"Yeah, I can see that," Catra chuckles, grinning.

They stare at each other in silence until the soft sound of a throat clearing jolts them awake. Catra looks at Bow and Glimmer with a sour expression while Adora waves at them brightly.

"Oh hello, sweetheart!" Mrs. Thaymor exclaims, surprised by Adora's sudden presence. The old woman seems to gape lightly at her, as well as Glimmer and Bow, without being able to stop it. Adora grins wider and the woman's wonder just increases with it, her tone friendly but full of wonder when she speaks to her. "I haven't seen you here before"

"Mrs. Thaymor, Bow, this is Adora" Glimmer exclaims before Catra can say anything at all. She doesn't even wave on her enthusiasm when Catra practically stabs her with her stare, ignoring her murderous gaze. "She is Catra's, um, friend-?"

Glimmer's question hangs in the air, unsure. Everyone, except Adora, stares at Catra, waiting for an answer. Catra opens her mouth and closes it back up, feeling like a goddamn dead fish between them. What is she supposed to say? Friend? The most obvious answer, it's easy, quick, she could just say it and be done with the matter. But Adora is not just a friend, is she. She is Catra's best friend, she is sure about this now, but she is also so much *more.*

Catra gulps, opening her mouth again to explain before the curious gaze of the rest. Adora completely beats her to it.

" *I'm her wife* !" Adora signs joyfully with a bright smile on her face, lacing her arm with Catra's and nuzzling on the side of her face gently. There is no sarcasm or sudden urge to lie there. Just the plain honesty of someone that is completely convinced that what they say it's true and that they are happy for it.

Catra gasps, turning every shade of red because *What the fuck? What the fuck?*

The package slips from her hands from how hard they are trembling, falling with a muted sound over the counter. Nobody notices, they are all focused on Catra's face and Adora's smile, a striking contrast of plain shock and beaming happiness. Catra's eyes are locked in Adora's face, wide as moons as she tries to say something, anything at all. But the words don't come and Adora keeps nuzzling the column of her neck with her nose, making Catra make the most embarrassing sound in front of everyone there, something between a squeal and a purr.

Oh she is never getting to live this down, ever.

Around them, the sound explodes back again with full force.

"Oh my, you are so sweet! Glimmer, are you looking at them?!" Bow squeals loudly, shaking Glimmer from side to side with excitement. The latter is looking at Catra as if she had grown a second and third head, gaping in shock. She looks at Catra, then at Adora, then back at Catra until her stunned expression turns into the most evil smirk she can muster in all her pink and silver being. Yes, she is definitely never letting Catra live it down.

"Well, that explains a lot," she mutters and doesn't elaborate more, an evil hint in her eyes when Catra's face turns an ever deeper shade of red. Adora bumps her nose against Catra's temple, calling her attention. Catra turns back, squeezing Adora's fingers between hers swiftly.

"Adora-"

"Oh! Oh! How wonderful!" Mrs. Thaymor exclaims, clapping her hands in joy. "It's such a pleasure to meet you!"

Adora grins at the woman, nodding. Catra feels lightheaded, like the ground had been pulled off her feet and she was just floating around the town. She can't even feel the weight of the bag on her shoulder or the heat of the autumn sun above their heads. The only thing that grounds her right now, is the cold brush of Adora's hand on hers, familiar and kind, her thumb running circles over Catra's knuckles.

"But darling," Mrs. Thaymor adds, narrowing her eyes as she eyes at Adora's face. "What in heaven's name happened to your face?" asks the old woman, pointing at the scar on the side of Adora's temple. She doesn't ask it with I'll intention, but her surprise and curiosity at the huge wound gets the best of her. Next to Adora, Catra visibly deflates, tightening her hold on Adora's hand. She can feel alarms going off inside her head, alerting her that they are reaching dangerously close to things they shouldn't talk about. Still, Adora shrugs, detangling her hand of Catra's so she can answer.

" *Some fishermen tried to kill me at the beach* " Adora answers, easily, almost resting on its importance. Catra stares alarmed at the shop lady and then at Glimmer and Bow, who's expressions of shock match each other. That's bad. " *Catra scared them off"*

That's really bad, tremendously bad. Maybe Catra could convince -snarl- at Bow and Glimmer to be quiet about this, but there is no way the lady is not going to tell someone else. And where one salinean knows something, all the rest know too before the day ends. Horrible indeed.

"Adora-" Catra basically growls under her breath, tugging from Adora's elbow. This time, when Adora looks at her, Catra knows she can see the wave of panic living in her eyes. Adora's shoulders fall forward, her cheeks paling in shame. Catra's heart gives a jump inside her chest and she squeezes their fingers tighter, trying to speak to Adora without words. *It's okay,* Catra tries to say, searching Adora's eyes with hers.

"Goodness. Oh darlings, I am so sorry that you still have to deal with all this stupidity, even now" Mrs. Thaymor exclaims, cradling her hands over her chest. Catra frowns, confused, until she understands where the woman's mind has led her too. Of course her first thought wouldn't be that Adora is a siren. *Of course.*

"Wait, it was that day that you called me? About the illegal hunters?" Bow interrupts. He is so smart it annoys the hell out of Catra, especially now when she doesn't want him to be smart. Bow detangles from Glimmer's arm, stretching his arm towards Catra. "I- I didn't know you two were together that day. Catra, why didn't you tell me?"

"We could have helped. I can have the paramedics at your house in a few minutes" adds Glimmer, cornering Catra between the stall and Adora.

"Yes, you just need to tell us. There is no need to confront them in your own-"

"If Adora was hurt you could just -"

"Well maybe I just didn't want your fucking help!" Catra explodes, out of breath. She realizes her outburst immediately, for the sore of her throat and the stunned expressions of Bow and Glimmer. Catra's shoulders fall forward, ashamed, rubbing her upper arm with her hand in a grounding motion.

She feels a hand on her shoulder, squeezing gently. Catra looks up, the corner of her eyes pulled down, to look at Adora, who is looking at her with that kind of patient kindness she always gives. There is a small smile in her lips, encouraging, and points to the other two still standing behind Catra, nodding reassuring.

"Um, I'm sorry-" Catra mutters, between her teeth, to Bow and Glimmer, still dragging her eyes across the ground. "I- I got angry. I'm working on it."

Bow shakes his head from side to side, standing just close enough to Catra to not be invasive. He has an apologetic, kind smile on his face, mirroring Glimmer's own, who had folded her hand in front of her with a small pout.

"No, we are sorry. We pushed too hard. You have the right to talk about it if you want and when you want to." Bow reassures her.

"Yes, we are sorry Catra. We shouldn't have cornered you both like that" Glimmer whispers and is void of any sarcasm or the usual banter she and Catra have going on in a normal day.

Catra scowls lightly, unused to being the one receiving the apology. Adora squeezes her again, this time on the low of her back, pressing her nose against the back of her head. Catra can feel all her anger and apprehension dissolving in an instant, evaporating into the fall air when she exhales.

"Yeah, okay," Catra says. "Okay. Let's just, not talk about it more"

Bow grins, nodding, Glimmer nodding with him. "Alright."

Mrs. Thaymor has gone silent too behind the stall, but she is back into grinning again, wide. "So! Any plans you four young fellas have for the Samhain evening?" she asks, probably wanting to ease the tension that had fallen over them.

It works like a charm. Glimmer's mouth falls open into a perfect 'o' and she starts jumping up and down over the ground, clapping her hands excitedly.

"You need to come to the festival! Both of you!" she grabs Bow's upper arms, shaking him from side to side in excitement.

"The festival," Catra repeats, slow and unimpressed. Next to her, Adora sprints with curiosity, wrapping the arm that isn't holding the basket around Catra's waist. Catra tries very hard to get distracted.

"Yes! There will be food, music, traditional rituals. Oh! And my mother convinced the council to let us light bonfires on the shore." Glimmer numbers, counting with her fingers. "And of course, the candle procession at midnight. I know you like that, Catra"

Catra growls, grimacing at Glimmer, but the last doesn't even wave on her excitement, throwing Catra a smile that says how much she knows she already won. Especially when Adora bumps her forehead against Catra's temple, calling for her attention. Catra turns to look at her, archi g her eyebrow.

Adora's face is bright with excitement, looking at Catra with something very close to a gentle plea that Catra can't deny her.

"You want to go?" Adora's face splits into a wide smile, nodding happily. "Very well, we are going then," Catra gives in with a sigh.

Behind them Glimmer and Bow basically squeal with delight, surrounding both Catra and Adora with bright expressions, almost sparkling in happiness.

"You can dress as whatever you like!" Glimmer exclaims, nodding at the several stalls with traditional and fun looking costumes. Bow nods, stops, thinks about it and then shakes his head, raising his pointing finger with a thoughtful, serious face.

"But not a mermaid "

Glimmer nods in agreement. "No, definitely not a mermaid "

"Mermista claimed the mermaid already and you know how she gets," Bow winks at Catra, who just rolls her eyes, packing the groceries inside her bag.

Adora, however, blinks at him and good-natured and painfully honest, says, " *But I'm a mermaid* "

Cares drops the jar into the ground, breaking in dozens of jelly and glass pieces around her feet. Glimmer, Bow and even Adora jump back, surprised by the crash, but Catra remains where she is, her eyes glued to the ground and the big pieces of broken glass without really seeing it at all, panic alarms going inside her head.

"Wow! Wait, let me help you," Bow offers immediately, smiling kindly at Catra as her takes a handkerchief from the pocket of his crop top and carefully starts to pick up the remains of the jar.

"Shaky hands," Catra hears herself lie through her teeth. Bow doesn't seem to notice because he rests its importance with a wave of his hand, smiling kindly at her. In the meantime, Glimmer starts talking to Adora, her eyes unavoidably big and sparkly -the slight squeeze of Adora's bicep doesn't go unnoticed- but Catra can't really blame her. If she wasn't absolutely speechless right now, she would even mock her for it.

"So you did have a costume already in mind!" Glimmer is saying, accusatory. Catra shakes back to life, sharp and cunning as always, catching the opportunity and going with it.

"Yes, a costume," Catra agrees, giving Adora a hard silent look when the second turns to her with a questioning twitch of her eyebrows. "I'm sure we can find another *costume* for you to wear, Adora."

Realization must fall over Adora because her eyes open wide and she gapes, grabbing the handle of the basket with renewed force, resolving to only nod in agreement. Catra sighs, chewing the inside of cheek. She leans towards Adora, blindly searching for her hand, tangling their fingers together and squeezing softly in reassurance. Adora's tense expression softens and she smiles at Catra, a small, apologetic glint that only them understand hidden inside her eyes.

"You are… so sweet, it's disgusting," Glimmer says out of the blue, lighthearted. Catra jumps, slightly taken aback by Glimmer's voice. Adora doesn't move, still staring at Catra's face with an adoring look. Catra snarls at Glimmer.

"Sparkles, please, do find it in your heart to shut the fuck up"

Glimmer scoffs, linking her arm with Bow. The pair starts walking up the street again, stopping next to Adora just enough so she can bump her hip softly with hers. Glimmer is still a little bit pink in the cheeks, though she can't help it. Most of the people walking by had either tripped over or just blatantly stared at Adora, eyes wide and mouth gaped. It's not like Catra hadn't noticed it before.

"See you at the festival!" Bow says -yells- goodbye, waving his hand with a huge grin on his face, calling the attention of half of the stalls.

Catra fights the urge of rolling her eyes, just waving her hand interestingly to him. Catra grabs Adora's hand between hers, the latter still waving goodbye happily and a tad *too* long. Catra pulls from their joined hands, almost dragging Adora behind her as they stomp out of the streets and towards the port.

"Let's get out of here," Catra mutters to Adora, clenching her teeth. "We have everything we need and I'm tired of the market."



Catra has been… awfully quiet the entire time they've been walking down the port.

They dropped the bags inside the car at some point so they wouldn't be carrying them around as they strolled around the shore. Adora took her chores off almost immediately, throwing them carelessly to the side in the wooden steps of that lead to the shore. Catra remained quiet, looking at Adora with an indescriptible look inside her beautiful eyes.

Now they are walking next to each other, Adora ankle deep inside the calm water, Catra feet away, just far enough so the waves don't get to touch her. Adora digs her feet inside the soft sand, sighing in relief at the rough touch. It's not the same -it will never be the same- than swimming in the depths of the sea, swirling over around subterranean caves and traveling alongside the wales through the tides. But it helps.

Adora glances at Catra, worry creeping in her chest. Catra's face is serious, far away from where they are, submerged in thought. Adora stops in her tracks, the water splashing over the fabric of her pants. Catra's must be still in high alert because she also stops, looking over Adora with arched eyebrows.

"*Are you upset?"* Adora asks, feeling her cheek burning with sudden shame. The corner if Catra's mouth twitches in surprise.

"What?"

"*Are you upset? For what happened?"*

Catra stares at her speechless for a few seconds. She clicks her tongue against her teeth, retreating on her steps to get closer to Adora, still avoiding the water.

"At the market? Of course not, it's not your fault. Sparkles is really fucking noisy by nature." Catra shrugs, digging her hands inside the pockets of her jeans.

Adora grunts, not convinced. " *Please be honest with me, Catra"*

It seems to take Catra aback. She shifts in her feet, unsure, glancing at the water, the boats around the port and back to Adora. "I am not upset, Adora. I'm just worried," she explains,

"There are a lot of people at these festivals and you- ugh. People *look* at you Adora. I'm just…"

She trails off, uncomfortableness dripping out of her in waves. Adora takes pity on her, softness extending in her chest. " *Scared?"*

Catra exhales, nodding. "Yeah, I guess so"

Adora hums, considering. She walks out of the water, stepping close to Catra slowly. *"Catra, nothing bad is going to happen,"* she signs, tapping Catra's chin with her fingers. Catra's eyebrows knit in sudden anguish, her true emotions clear as water. She hugs herself, leaning away from Adora's touch.

"Aren't you scared? Every time we are here? Every time someone approaches us?"

" *I am,"* Adora confesses. Of course she is. She is terrified to say the least, but she is also curious and excited to walk among humans and also- " *but you are here. We are together. So I know nothing bad is going to happen."*

Catra just looks more conflicted. She opens her mouth as if she wanted to say something but closes it again, chewing on whatever she was meaning to say. Adora doesn't like seeing her like this, unsure and scared. It's what Catra is. And Adora hates even more being the reason for it.

Catra sighs, running her hand through Adora's hair, brushing the locks back. The touch is tender and Adora leans towards it, exhaling in comfort and relief.

"Adora," Catra starts again and her eyes are glazed over, her voice shaking with the question, "why did you tell them you are my wife?"

Adora feels her own heart speeding up, excitement traveling down her veins. " *The bread lady explained to me what it was,"* Adora says as if it was enough explanation.

Catra frowns in front of her, taking her hand back from Adora's head. "She did?"

" *Yes* !" Adora signs, joyful. But Catra doesn't seem to be sharing the feeling, in fact, she looks even more confused than before. Adora's shoulders fall, swift disappointment falling over her chest. " *I'm sorry. Should I not call you that? I should have asked."*

Catra blinks, surprised, pulled out of whatever she was thinking about. "What? No. No, Adora don't apologize you didn't do anything wrong" Catra brushes her thumb over the curve of Adora's cheekbone, looking almost melancholic when she speaks. "I just… don't think you really understood what that word means"

" *I did understand,"* Adora defends herself. Catra's face is still cemented in doubt so Adora ads, " *I like calling us that, in front of other humans. Can I keep doing it?"*

Catra seems to think about it, searching something in Adora's eyes. Whatever it is, she also seems to find it because she relaxes. Maybe she realizes Adora *does* know, or maybe she

thinks Adora hasn't got a single clue about what that word means. Whatever it is, Catra gives up and lets it go, for now.

"Yeah, alright. I… like it too," and then almost to drown her last words, ads at full speed, "It's better, actually. So people don't ask questions."

Adora presses her lips into a thin line. She knows there is more to say about this conversation but she also senses it might just not be the time. So instead, Adora takes Catra's hands between hers, pulling gently off her and towards the water. Catra tenses up again, digging her heels in the pebbles.

"I don't know how to swim" Catra blurts out, looking between the sea and Adora with an increasingly alarmed face. Adora tilts her head to the side, frowning lightly.

" - *you live next to the sea"*

Catra grimaces, "And?"

Adora looks inside Catra's eyes, reading her like an open book. She is nervous - *I've always been alone-* and afraid - *my mother drowned* - and sad - *I'm scared-,* and Adora feels guilty. That this is her fault too, that she is part of the reason Catra is scared. But, over her sense of responsibility, there is more. Adora cares, she cares for Catra, she cares for her happiness and she cares for her fears. So, Adora turns Catra's palm over, drawing circles on her skin before leaning back.

" *Catra- the water won't hurt you while I'm here* " Adora signs, mouthing the words silently. A visible shiver runs down Catra's back. She looks at Adora, unsure. *"I promise* "

Adora stretches her hand towards her, letting her decide. The words seem to light something inside Catra because she exhales heavily, taking Adora's hand. Adora grins, walking back and into the water, leading Catra in with her.

They don't go deep, barely where the sea reaches their knees, mostly because Catra is still wearing her shoes and because she is trembling from head to toe, clenching to Adora's hand for dear life. Adora cradles her face and presses gentle kisses over her shut tight eyelids, smoothing the tense lines over her forehead with her thumb. Catra shivers again.

"Okay, okay," Catra muebles, opening her eyes just a slit, only so she can look around them and the water that surrounds them, seafoam bending and licking at her legs. Little by little, Catra starts to relax, watching the sea gently move around her with a newfound marveled expression. "Okay, this is not that bad."

Adora doesn't say anything, resting her jaw against the side of Catra's temple. She doesn't walk Catra deeper into the sea, so they remain standing over the sand, quiet. Around them, the sound of seagulls and the murmur of the market, already preparing for the festival, is the only thing filling the air, mixed with the brush of the waves against the shore.

Catra leans back, locking her eyes with Adora's for a moment so long Adora loses her breath. There is something heavy in Catra's eyes that makes Adora's entire body shiver and she has

to fight to keep down her scales to sprout. Adora remembers the words the bread lady taught her, repeats them in her head a few times, just to be sure she doesn't do them wrong. Slowly, deliberately, Adora starts raising her arm, almost imperceptibly pointing at herself. Catra blinks, hyperaware, her body temperature skyrocketing. Adora starts crossing her arms and then Catra's phone starts going off loudly.

"Oh shit," Catra mutters, out of breath. She fumbles with her pockets, her movements drowsy and uncharacteristically clumsy -she almost drops her phone into the sea *twice* -

Finally, Catra manages to take her phone off, looking at the screen with an annoyed face that quickly melts into a blank expression. Before Adora can ask, Catra is already pressing the little green circle, raising the phone so it's at her face height.

"This better be an emergency," Catra snaps, gentle enough that sounds more annoyed than angry. A high voice comes almost screaming from the phone and when Adora leans over Catra's shoulder to pick at the screen she can see the face of another woman, white hair, dark lipstick and definitely thick tears tracks on her cheeks.

"**Wildcat! You are alive!"** the woman is saying between loud sobs, the image freezing and coming back several times. Catra rolls her eyes, clicking her tongue.

"Of course I'm alive, what are you even talking about? And why are you *video* calling from Entrapta's phone?"

There is a bit of a rustle through the screen and another head pops out from the corner of the screen, uneven lilac bangs and purple eyes and a squeaky curious voice.

"**Scorpia has been convinced that you've been murdered!"** the second person, Entrapta, announces cheerfully. " **She also said if she used her phone to call you, you wouldn't pick up? Have you been subject of any murder attempt lately?"**

Catra sputters with incredulity, pinching the bridge of her nose. It's actually quite endearing, when Catra gets annoyed or frustrated. Or at least it is for Adora.

"No. I haven't. Are you two watching true crime documentaries again?"

"**Yes! It's been quite informative!"** Entrapta says, clapping her hands with excitement. Behind her, Scorpia's face comes into view again, barely pushing another sob away.

"But wildcat!" she exclaims, rubbing her eyes and with it smudging the black eyeliner everywhere. " **We haven't had news from you in weeks! Not even after your birthday! And you live so close to the sea I thought something had happened!"**

A swift spark of guilt crosses Catra's eyes before her friend's worry, but there is also endearment, the hint of a tiny smile appearing on her lips as her friends keep babbling in the screen and, there it is, Adora can see it clear as water under the sun, the shimmer of Catra's kind heart, leaking through the high walls she has built around herself.

Now, Adora has lived many, *many* years. Most of those years, she must admit, she has spend them carefully watching the humans on their travel through live. She has seen beautiful things and terrible ones and she knows there are so many others she must have missed, always too afraid to actually walk among them on her own. But she has learned this.

Humanity sucks. Adora knows this first hand. But it is in this darkness and awfulness that the true beauty and kindness of humanity gets to be born. After all, there can't be dawn without night before. And Adora has also learned that humans aren't necessarily completely good or completely bad -with its exceptions-. Humans are messy, complicated and, more often than not, always driven to mistakes or success by their own emotions. On this, humans and First Ones are quite similar, though no merfolk, like her brother, would ever admit it out loud.

It is this *messiness* that has always fascinated Adora. The drill that humans make mistakes most of their lives and, still, keep living. Keep laughing and playing and growing and, in the best of cases, learning and becoming better. Adora loves this. The freedom of choosing, of being wrong. The freedom of changing.

This is what Adora sees in Catra.

"Alright, I forgot to text you back. That's on me," Catra admits. Her tone has changed and instead of annoyed she sounds softer, apologetic. She looks at her friends through the strange crystal screen and drops her shoulders, apologizing. "Sorry. I've been really busy these weeks"

"It's alright, wildcat" white hair -Scorpia- beams at her. **"I'm just glad you are okay"**

"Though Perfuma did tell us to give you your space and not pressure you," Entrapta adds, scrolling through something that looks way too much to a notebook. Catra chuckles, unconsciously leaning her weight over Adora's chest, who just wraps her arms around her waist and holds her, listening to the exchange in curious silence.

"Why do you not listen to your girlfriend, Scorpia?"

"**Because!"** Scorpia throws her arms to the air in a quite dramatic gesture, barely missing hitting Entrapta in the face. Scorpia's arms shimmer in metal glow and Adora makes a mental note to ask about it later. " **We've been watching this true crime murder case and it just happens to take place near the sea, so obviously I just thought *oh!* Who are you?"** Scorpia absolutely changes the subject, noticing Adora rest her cheek over Catra's shoulder for the first time in the entire call. Between Adora's arms, Catra squirms, slightly anxious.

"This is Adora. She is- um, my friend," Catra presents them with a flick of her hand, stuttering a little with her words, a red flush tinting her cheeks adorably. "Adora, these are Scorpia and Entrapta, old annoyances of mine." Adora grins back at them, waving brightly.

" *Hello."* Scorpia blinks, suddenly baffled and out of words. Entrapta, however, just smiles ever brighter, bringing a small boxing towards her mouth

"This must be the cause of Catra's distraction these weeks," Entrapta mutters towards the box, studying Adora's face. Scorpia remains speechless **" *What a particular scar you have* "**

she asks, signing, signaling at the white scar on the side of Adora's face, extending from the root of her eyebrow, across her eyelid and down her cheekbone.

It's wide, crooked and burning painful when it was healing. It made Adora feel self-conscious and angry for a long time, staring at herself in the fogged mirror, a visible proof of what had been done to her, what had almost happened. For a long time, it had made her want to crawl at her own face and tear it apart so she wouldn't have to look at it. But then, there was Catra. She had sat next to Adora every day to care over the wound, and the many others in her body, gently and the entire time her face hadn't contorted in disgusting, or recoil or even pity. And when the wounds healed Catra still looked at her the same. Sometimes even, Adora has noticed, when Catra was drowsy with sleep or caught up on her own thoughts, she would run her fingers over the raised tissue of the scar, drawing tree roots and leaves instead of lighting in Adora's face, touch so delicate it felt like a feather. And, with time, Adora stopped hating the scars and started to accept them, to take them as a new part of herself, a proof that she had survived. And it helped.

Catra, however, is still especially protective about it.

"Entrapta-" Catra says, low and warning, but her friend doesn't even seem to hear her at all.

"***With what was it made of?"*** Entrapta inquires, wiggling her eyebrows. She is definitely straightforward but not ill meaning so she doesn't take offense to it just she didn't when the sparkling girl -Glimmer- and crop top -Bow- asked.

" *An harpoon* " Adora signs, shrugging. " *I can hear you"*

A gasp Scorpia's side, the mentioned bringing a hand towards her chest, eyes wide.

"**Oh boy, are you serious?"**

" *Yes. Some fishermen attacked me-"* Adora hesitates, glancing sideways to Catra. She is looking at Adora through the reflection of the screen, tense "- *for no particular reason at all"* Adora finishes with a satisfied nod. No suspicions, good job. " *Catra saved me* "

Adora feels Catra lowering the hand that isn't holding the phone, squeezing Adora's hands around her waist once. On the screen, Scorpia lets out a small cheer, nodding in agreement.

"**Of course she did, that's our wildcat"** she says, not asking more questions. Catra relaxes in Adora's arms, humming under her breath.

"**Interesting** " Entrapta mumbles, scribbling something quickly out of view, tucked in the small vision of the phone so she can throw an analytic look at them. " **Would you say your relationship is merely platonic or has rather a romantic nature?"**

"Alright, I'm hanging up right now" Catra snaps, her voice high pitched and strangled. So close to each other, Adora can feel the warm heat of her cheek as she blushes deeply, mortified by her friend's questions.

On the screen, Catra's friends sputter, rushing to say something that sounds a lot like 'wait, how is everything going' and 'goodbye, please send me your input later'. Catra basically smashes her finger over the screen, dropping the phone inside her pocket with a frustrated sigh. Carta looks down and flushes, actually realizing that Adora is still holding her by the waist for the first time.

She walks away, untangling herself from Adora's arms and the latter quietly hums in protest, missing her immediately.

"Sorry, they can be, well, a lot," Catra explains, rolling her eyes. Adora shrugs, taking it importance with a smile.

" *They seem sweet* "

"They are. It was Entrapta who taught me sign language, actually. And we met Scorpia later on. Entrapta designed her prosthetic arms, she is a biomedical engineer" Carta agrees, kicking her feet a little inside the water. By this point, her pants are soaked but she isn't trembling anymore and almost looks like she has forgotten her fear for water almost completely. Instead, her voice has dropped into something soft, fond as she talks about her friends. Adora is grinning brightly at her, hooking her fingers in the hoops of Catra's pants, brushing swirls with her thumb in the space above her hips. Carta hesitates in her words, looking up at Adora from between her long eyelashes. "By the way, you never told me who taught you sign language. Or to play the piano"

Adora considers her, not because she is unsure of the answer but because she gets distracted, lost in Catra's pretty eyes and the blush on her nose. Adora feels herself smile fondly at her, caressing the path of freckles on her cheeks before answering.

" *Razz taught me the language,"* Adora says and sees the spark of recognition on Catra's eyes but also, of pride. Adora's smile widens. *"She was very patient with me, I'm really grateful. And the piano-"* Adora hesitates, unsure about how to explain she just has a very fine ear. It's mostly how she hunts on dark waters. She just heard the difference in the notes and repeated them so they would fit some of the soft music Catra had played once for her. In the end, that's exactly how she explains it, blushing.

Catra rolls her eyes at her, smirking mischievously. "Of course you are some kind of musical genius. Well, I'll hand you my guitar later, miss siren, and we'll really see what's up"

Adora chuckles, grasping a curl of dark chestnut hair between her fingers, placing it gently behind Catra's reddened ear.

" *Are you sure you want to go to the festival?"* Adora asks, making sure. Catra shakes her head, crossing her arms over her chest.

"It's good, we'll be together anyway," she says, easily. Then her eyebrows flicker as if she had caught herself slipping. Catra clears her throat, waking back to the shore, skipping over the pebbles in her way. Adora follows her close behind. "You are *definitely* not going as a siren, but I've got Razz's vaults still in the attic. We are going to look smoking hot."

Adora doesn't know what 'smoking hot' means -maybe they are going to eat something-. But one thing is sure, if Catra's expression can suddenly get so bright and mischievous, she can't wait to find out.



They *do* look smoking hot.

Catra helps Adora get ready for the festival. She fishes a pearlescent white dress from one of her grandmother's trunks, and the silk fabric has no rights to hug itself to Adora's waist and long legs like it does, but what can one do? Catra tries to hide her blush the entire time, fixing the spaghetti straps over Adora's bare shoulders, dusting silver fairy powder over her cheeks and eyelids and helping her clip a single pair of small white wings on her back. Adora brushes all her hair back, letting it fall free between the wings and down her back in rivers of gold. And she looks beautiful, absolutely breathtaking, Catra can't barely talk as Adora swirls in front of the mirror, giggling at the skirt of the dress tangling in her legs.

Catra dresses up too, mumbling the entire time. She also pushes her hair back, letting it curl down her back with a bounce, held to the sides of her head only by a few hair pins. She knows she will regret it in the morning, with humidity of the air, but Adora likes to run her fingers through it, so she doesn't mind in the end.

Gosh .

Catra slips into a tight black bodice, throwing caressesly over it a floor length see-through black dress that, at some point, could have a perfectly widow-like robe. Or a curtain. The sleeves are cuffed around her wrists and it's too big on her, but a belt cinching it together at her waist does the trick. Catra can feel Adora's stare at the side of her face as she paints a thick black eyeliner around her eyes, accentuating the cat-like shape of her eyes. A blush clings in Catra's cheeks the entire time and Catra doesn't even tries to tamper it down.

The weather is unusually warm and humid for this time of the year, but it works for them, especially because Adora refuses to put on shoes. Her face gets all round and pouty everytime she gets like this and every time it makes Catra want to laugh, which she hides it pretty convincely -what she can't hide, though, is the gentle expression she has everytime she looks at Catra, the soft glimmer in her eyes, open and lovesick-. Maybe is good that Carta doesn't know the face she makes, not that she would be able to repress it at all.

" *Why do you even wear shoes?"* Adora signs, mildly annoyed. Carta chuckles, kneeling in front of her as she struggles with Adora's nervous bouncing foot and the shoes in her hands.

"Society complexity and sharp splinters. Now give me your foot, Cinderella" Carta deadpans with a blank expression. Reluctantly, definitely unhappy by it, Adora stretches her foot to Catra, who makes quick work of slipping it inside her elegant feet and tying the laces.

" *What's a cinder bell?"* Adora asks after a while, frowning. It just manages to make Carta *giggle.*

″ I'll tell you later"

By the time they make it to the town it's already well past ten and the festival is bursting with life. If the market was packed with people this is absolutely ridiculous, it looks like every single person in Salineas is here and most of them are already gathering in the entrance of the town, greeting each other as they arrive. With all, the mixture of people actually dressing up, little kids in funny costumes and people with normal clothes is pretty even.

Carta clasps her hand with Adora's, her skin sweaty against Adora's cool, soft one. But Adora laces their fingers together immediately, turning to nuzzle her nose in the angle of Catra's jaw before pulling impatiently from their joined hands. She is exuding excitement, Catra can see, there is a sprint on her step and a huge grin plastering in her face and like this, wrapped in silver and white, she does look like an angel. Carta doesn't know how she is going to survive tonight.

As they get closer to the people, Carta glances towards the port, distracted by the high columns of smoke coming from the bonfire near the shore. If Perfuma were to be here, she would be already freaking out about the smokes into the air or something.

Someone bumps against Catra, making her stumble. Carta turns with a scowl, hissing something very close to ' *watch where are you fuckin going'* before she realizes the girl that just crashed with her it's not even paying her attention. In fact, her mouth is opening and closing like a dead fish and her eyes are locked in the person in front of Catra. Adora.

When Catra turns around, she can see the girl it's not the only one staring at Adora. Wherever they go, as they make their way through the river of people, everybody turns their head to look at Adora. Some of them give her a quick glance, cheeks burning. Others gape and choke with whatever they are eating or drinking. Many other just plainly stare at her, frozen in place as Adora walks by.

Catra growls -she can't help it-, tightening her grip on Adora's hand, following behind her with her dark clothes like a shadow. Catra should feel bad about this, Adora is not her possession, but she can't stop the feeling of protectiveness that washes over her every time some man's eyes linger in Adora for longer than a second, for any second at all. So, Catra steps closer to Adora, wrapping her arm tightly around her waist and throwing menacing glances to the people around them.

Adora doesn't even seem to notice, glancing at the leaves and dry flowers hanging over their heads with a marveled look in her face. The golden and purple lights around them make the silver in her skin shimmer, almost mirroring the shape of her scales. At some point, as they approach the high entrance of the town, at voice calls to them, high pitched and increasingly closer.

"Catra! Adora! There you are!" Glimmer appears from behind a few people, dragging a very disheveled Bow behind her, a huge crown of dry leaves crooked over his head and the golden eyeliner around his eyes a little bit smudged. Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes because only an idiot wouldn't realize they were probably making out behind some pillar. Glimmer points at Cards with an accusatory expression, tilting her hip to the side. "You are late"

"Arriving early is for lame people" Catra shoots back, drumming her fingers over Adora's hip and trying to ignore the way the latter shivers at the touch.

"I got here early," Glimmer complains, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Point proven"

Bow and Adora snicker at Glimmer's dramatically offended face while Catra just smirks, grinning even wider when Glimmer pokes her tongue out with a pout.

"Hi, Catra. Hi, Adora," Bow greets them, smiling. Adora smiles back, all white teeth and link lips, and Catra nods, smirk turning into a softer smile. She wouldn't be caught dead saying it but she actually likes him.

"Arrows." Catra glances at his attire and then turns to Glimmer, taking in her flowy pink dress and crown of peonies braided in her cotton candy hair. "What are you supposed to be? Tinkerbell?"

"Really funny, Catra. I'm a fae!" Glimmer points at the swirls painted in her arms and the fake fangs glued to her teeth. Catra chuckles. She has a very different conception of what faes look like but it fits Sparkles. "And Bow is a spring spirit!" Glimmer adds, squeezing his biceps with zero to none discretion at all. Bow is sputtering and blushing furiously by the time Glimmer turns to study Catra's dress, arching her pink eyebrow in an already condescending look. "What about you, um?"

Catra pulls the most menacing look she can, which is a lot, flashing the sharp edges of her canines at her with a fick of her hair. "I'm death"

Glimmer sucks if her lip, narrowing her eyes as a slow cat-like smile starts to stretch in her mouth. "And Adora is life?" she questions, glancing at Adora's white dress and wings, her hair splayed down her back as she nuzzles in Catra's shoulder, still holding her hand. "How romantic"

"Fuck off" Catra spats, but it doesn't reach her eyes and it definitely doesn't make a lot for Glimmer because she just cackles, fumbling with Bow's satchel until she fetches two things from it.

"Ha! Here put these on" she says, dropping the things over Catra and Adora's hair before neither of them can protest. Catra sneezes and immediately knows what they are.

Adora's flower crown it's quite different from Glimmer's. A mesh of laurel leaves, forget me nots, golden wheat spikes and violets, braided together into a soft circle that rests over Adora's golden hair like a fae's crown, making her look like a Greek muse standing in the middle of a river of mortals.

Catra straight up wheezes, she can hear Glimmer's stuffed laughter next to her. But before Catra can turn and snap at them, Adora is already lifting her hand, smothering the soft leaves if Catra's own crown and giving a smile so tender Catra stays rooted on her place in the ground.

“We got the same crown for both of you, we figured you would like to match,” Bow explains, barley stiffing a goodhearted giggle. Glimmer, on her side, seems determined to keep the evil smirk in her mouth.

“Yeah, we supposed you were *that* kind of couple”

Catra turns her head towards Glimmer, all the softness of her face slipping and hardening into something a thousand times harder. Glimmer blinks, surprised, considering for a second that maybe the teasing got too far. Catra tilts her head and drags her multicolored eyes towards Bow, a sly grin spreading in her lips.

“Yes. I figured you were that kind of couple too,” Catra says, loud, voice husky. “Hey, Arrows? You are going to want to clean your chin. Pink lipstick doesn't really work with golden glitter.”

Bow´s eyes open almost comically and Glimmer goes through different phases of red, so bright in the face she almost looks like a lighthouse, making quick and clumsy work of whipping Bow´s chin with the sleeve of her dress and throwing curses at Catra at the same time. Catra only laughs, catching one of the fallen laurel leaves from Adora´s shoulder, brushing their skins together. Adora is already looking at her, mirth knitted in her expression. She looks like she is also getting a kick out of Catra making fun of Bow and Glimmer and warmth spreads in Catra´s chest.

Another person approaches them then, with a long coat made of dry orange leaves and a mask of some kind of spirit over their face.

“Kiddos, it's time for the procession.” When he takes it off Catra can see it is actually Micah, Glimmer´s father and the chief director of the Biology Center. He has a huge smile on his mouth that only widens when he sees Catra, rushing to take her hand and shake it excitedly.

“Catrina! It's so good to see you in town!” he says, greeting her like they were old friends. Then he looks towards Adora, who is distracted bouncing one of Catra´s curls on her finger, and rushes to greet her too. “ *And you must be dear Adora. It's so nice to meet you too* ,” he signs, finishing by also taking Adora´s hand and shaking it a couple of times.

Catra throws an exasperated look towards Glimmer, baring her teeth a little. Glimmer raises her hands, shaking her head in negative. “I didn't say anything”

“Oh no, *it was mrs. Erlandia who told me about the beautiful couple, who heard it from mrs. Thaymor during lunch.”* Micah says, making sure to be mindful of his hands so Adora can understand him. He doesn't seem to know Adora can actually hear him but it's a kind thought of him. Catra bites back a groan and gives up. Small town, big talk after all.

Adora looks a little lost by the handshake and the exchange but returns the greeting, signing right back at him, “ *Hi. Who are you?”*

“Me? I´m Glimmer´s dad! So proud of being the father of this beautiful princess.”

“Dad!” Glimmer complains behind him. “I'm twenty four!”

“And still my little sparkling warrior. But! *I´ve come to fetch you all, young ones. The Candle ´s procession is about to start. Here, pick your candles I´ll help you light them up”* Micah struggles with his coat and fetches a bag from it, opening so each one of them can take a single, long, black candle from it. As he is helping them lit them with a match, Adora turns towards Catra, her eyebrows frowned.

“ *What is a Candle Procession?”*

“It´s a tradition for the first, today, and second of november,” Catra takes a match from the pack Micah is holding, lighting it up with the sole of her boot and using it to light up Adora´s candle. “Here, put your hands on the base, don´t let the liquid wax touch you, it's hot. Anyway, it's a tradition where you are supposed to walk from some starting point towards a graveyard or an altar. The point is honoring your dead ones and guiding them to you. That's why the flowers and candles and stuff” Catra ends with a weak shrug, flustered under Adora ´s tender gaze.

“ *Is that the celebration you talked to me about?”* Adora asks, her hands elegant. She is wearing a few of Catra´s rings, silver against the pale of her skin. They look good on her.

“Yeah,” Catra answers, gripping her own candle a tad too strong. They turn towards the rest. Micah, Glimmer and Bow are looking at them, sharing a knowing look and not saying anything else, turning to join the procession.

There are drums and musicians already at the lead of the people, guiding their walk across the town with their music, some wrapped in elaborated and colorful costumes, others standing over tall pieces of wood, making them look like giants crawling over the streets, throwing petal flowers to the air and making acrobatics as the people of the town follow close behind, laughing and singing.

It's fun, full of life and colors. Catra had never actually participated in it, not here since she arrived and definitely not when she was younger. In those times, days like this were just another day, angry with life. Now here she is, surrounded by sparkling and crop top dumbasses, hand in hand with someone beautiful.

Just one night, Catra thinks, squeezing Adora's hand in hers. *Just tonight.*

Adora makes a soft sound next to her, calling for her attention. Catra understands quickly, gently taking the candle from Adora's hand to let her sign.

" *Where are we going?"*

Catra, frowns, looking in front and around them to give herself an idea to the oath they are taking. It's really loud right now, but she can see the procession making a slow way towards the port.

"I guess we are going to cross over the port and to the main square," Catra says, tilting her head towards Adora's shoulder and neck so she can hear her over the sound of the music and singing. "I think that's where they put the altars"

Adora nods, pensive. Her eyes are bright, taking every single detail with a kind of passion Catra has never seen in anyone else, ever. Some kind of passion to live every single moment that is happening now and it makes Catra wonder how Adora's life was in the ocean. Beautiful, yes. Free, yes. But sometimes, when Adora was telling Catra things about it, like her travels around the caves, swimming around icebergs, diving to the very depths where things were lethal, dangerous, they sounded amazing but also Adora sometimes made them sound… lonely.

" *What are we going to do when we get there?"* Adora asks, trying to catch errand petals falling from the buildings. Catra follows the movements, feeling a slow, sweet and sticky smile making its way in her lips.

"Put the candles there. Flowers. Some people also leave food and other things their loved ones used to like when they lived." Catra turns her haze away from Adora, feeling a knot starting to form in her throat, threatening to choke her. She had people she had lost, people that loved her. And yet Catra had been so disconnected to the things that connected her with her family that now she felt weird, here in this festival. Everyone looked happy and comfortable and yet Catra walked among them like a real ghost, unable to feel like she belonged here.

Catra snaps out of her thoughts at the feeling of Adora's fingers tracing circles over her cheeks. She is smiling but it's different, charged with some kind of unknown knowledge that tells Catra she might just know what was going through Catra's mind. They are still walking, almost mindlessly along the crowd, but Catra manages to pass back to Adora her candle just so she can bury her face on Adora's shoulder. Adora lets out a soft huff of breathe, mildly surprised, but tilts her head too, pressing a swift kiss in the hair that isn't being squished by the laurel leaves and Catra swears she can hear someone whispering an 'aw' somewhere behind them.

At some point, Glimmer separates from where her father is chatting happily with Bow to approach them again. And because she has no concept of boundaries she skips on her feet, lacing her arms around Adora's opposite, the one that isn't wrapped around Catra, leaning over Adora's middle so she can talk to them in basically a yell. "Having fun?"

Catra wants to say something smart and sarcastic but Adora is already nodding excitedly, joining ti Glimmer's little jumps as they walk over the wood of the port. Glimmer looks pleasantly surprised because she grins broadly.

"Do you celebrate Samhain where you come from?" Glimmer asks and Catra knows it is common courtesy but still manages to make her nervous. Adora passes her candle back to Catra, hissing just a little when the melted wax manages to splash over her hand.

" *No, we don't really have concepts like this,"* Adora ponders over it, her mind fogging as if she were trying to find the words. She glances quickly at Catra before continuing and the small gesture lets her know she is aware that she needs to be careful about things. Catra relaxes a little, grateful. " *But I really like this. It 's cheerful.* "

"It is!" Glimmer agrees. She narrows her eyes, considering Adora with a bright look. "What do you work on? Sorry for the questions but 'someone' has been really secretive about you."

"Have you thought maybe your snoopy nose is the reason?" Catra bites back, tightening her grip in Adora's candle. The latter lowers her hand and grips Catra's elbow gently, squeezing back, two gentle brushes. *It 's okay,* they say.

"I like sea creatures. I know a lot about them " Adora says, proud of herself and her answer. However, Glimmer's eyes open like plates and her already excited face exponents alarmingly, speaking at a thousand for hour.

"My dad too! He works at the aquarium! Or well, the 'fancy named Biology Center'. Have you been there? You should totally speak to my dad about it, he can give you and Catra special access. Actually, we can ask him right now. Catra, I'm stealing your wife for a moment, don't freak out."

"Wait, what?" Catra has barely time to ask by the time Glimmer is already dragging Adora a few meters forward, shouting Micah's name. Adora throws back a swift glance to Catra, mildly alarmed but curious, shrugging as she is basically wrapped completely in conversation with them.

Catra is left in the middle of the crowd, walking at a good distance behind them and carrying both candles. She huffs, more annoyed that Adora is gone than to be alone, almost tempted to drop the candles on some dumpster and stomp away. But then again, she isn't seventeen anymore.

"Honestly, if my partner were that beautiful, I would also lock myself with her and away from the people," a voice says out of nowhere next to Catra.

Catra barely manages to bite back an unflattering screech in time to see the person talking is Mermista and, goddess above, Bow wasn't kidding when he said she was 'the' mermaid of the festival. Everything in her screamed commercialized mermaid, from the fabric of her skirt with face scales swed to it, the neon blue makeup and even the seashells glued on her even bluer hair. If only she knew-

And also, *what the hell?*

"What did you say?" Catra hears herself say, already defensive. Mermista shrugs it off, pointing at where Adora is walking next to Micah, nodding politely as he talks even faster than his daughter.

"Her. I mean, I know you like all this 'mysterious writer in a lonely house' thing, but like, everybody is talking about you two." Mermista says in an almost unimpressed tone, though the flicker of her eyes when Adora laughs breathlessly in front of them doesn't go unnoticed.

Catra knows there are some sounds humans aren't capable of making certain sounds, but she is also pretty sure she just *growled* at Mermista, and to the people around them that still dare to shoot a glance at Adora.

"What the fuck? Adora is not a piece of fucking meat-" Catra starts to says, barely containing her want to start yelling it to the four winds. Mermista, however, still dares, *dares,* to roll her eyes, fixing a strand of her hair with completely uninterest to Catra's outburst.

"Relax, tiger, it's not like that. People are just surprised that's all," she says, waving her hand like nothing. Anger starts to calm down inside Catra's chest, though she is still pretty pissed off, enough to see Mermista's manners are actually trying to reassure her. In her own weird way. "Bow told me you are married, so chillax"

"He told you 'what' now?"

"Meh, it was only me and Sea Hawk. I'm pretty sure Mrs. Thaymor is the one you want to thank about the entire town knowing. She almost made an assembly for my dinner, she looked pretty pissed off. Kept nagging us all about being decent people."

"Oh, fucking hell," Catra groans. Suddenly throwing herself to the sea seems pretty enticing.

I wonder if Adora would follow after.

Please, for the love of anything, shut up.

"I wouldn't worry much," Mermista interferes on Catra's inner monologue -she is going insane-, inspecting her perfectly manicured nails up close. Catra looks at her with a questioning look, arching her eyebrow until Mermista rolls her eyes in a way that manages to rival Catra. "I don't think people thought you two were to make an appearance tonight, but I've heard the things they say in the dinner-"

"The things" *Dreadful. Wonderful.*

"- *and* they are all pretty much boring positive things. You are our local celebrity so give the town a week to exhaust it out and things will be like nothing pretty soon." Somehow, Catra knows that Mermista really *is* trying to comfort her. Maybe because Catra looks like a wild cat about to snap or because she thinks the reason Catra is so weary about Adora is because there are some pretty nasty humans out there who hate everything they don't understand. It a way, that's exactly what it is. "Besides a few easily excited young girls, of course. I mean, your wife *does* have biceps for miles."

A young woman walks towards the group in the front right at that moment, greeting Glimmer and Bow swiftly and then redirecting her complete attention into Adora, ignoring whatever Sparkles is saying like a champion. She is pretty, pink hair held in space buns, a flower like dress, pink face paint in her face, probably one or two years younger than Glimmer. *Fluterina,* some part in Catra's brain provides, until the mentioned pink girl fake laughs loudly and leans forward, brushing her palm down Adora's exposed arm. *Well, fuck Fluterina.*

"By the way, I have news about the yacht you asked me about" Mermista adds, crossing her arms over her chest, the candle balanced perfectly on her hands. Catra snaps her eyes towards her, suddenly complete tense. "It seems it was seen close to the coast of Drill. Same logo, same name. I asked my contacts in the bay but nobody has register of what it was doing there besides an 'exploratory look for the owner'. It left yesterday towards the south so by now it must be in the entire other side of the Etheria."

Catra exhales, almost blowing both candles at the same time. *Fuck.* In one hand, whoever asshole they are is pretty far away, maybe they've lost interest, maybe they are not ever coming back. But then again, they still have Adora's skin. Anger pools in Catra's stomach, bubbling in her throat like acid. Suddenly not the singing, the flowers, the colors or even the candles in her hands can warm her, suddenly she is mad.

"What Bow did told me is that your wife was there that night" Mermista seems to see right through Catra's anger but doesn't mind, shrugging. There is a strain in her voice, something very close to offense even for Mermista. "Listen, I'm not going to judge. I've seen the scar. I would also want the people who did it to pay"

Catra blinks, honestly surprised. Most people would tell her to calm, to be assertive and positive or some shit like that. It is nice to be validated in her anger for once.

"Thanks, mermaid girl. I owe you one"

Mermista shakes her shoulders, making the little bells in her sari to twinkle together. "Don't mention it," and the see adds with a roll of eyes and a groan. "Seriously, don't mention it. I have a reputation"

Catra scoff, looking back to the front. "Whatever you say"

Glimmer is approaching then with a little sprint in her step, followed by Bow and Adora, who's eyes are locked in Catra's face, a small smile stitched on her face. Catra's heart gives a leap for a reason very different to anger.

"Hey! What are you doing slacking back?" Glimmer accuses Catra without real mocking behind it. She looks at Mermista with lifted eyebrows, walking backwards as she talks. "Wow Mermista. You really are the best mermaid in town."

"Ugh, I know that, obviously," Mermista answers but her eyes are twinkling in pride.

Catra has lost interest in the conversation, watching as Adora approaches her with calm steps. She is oink in the face, from the walking and from laughter, and there is obvious happiness in her eyes. Something good flutters inside Catra's heart and she can't avoid to smile back.

"Hey, you"

" *Hey,"* Adora skips over the white stone of the ground, they are getting closer to the main square, leaning towards Catra just enough to nuzzle her cheek in hers. Adora opens her eyes to Mermista staring at them and smiles, waving. " *Hello* "

Mermista blinks, immediately tinting a few dark shades of red. "Well, wow." It's the only thing she says before turning away. "I need to go find Sea Hawk"

"Where is he?" Glimmer asks, apparently deeply amused by the whole interaction.

"Probably finding something to burn" Mermista groans.

"Come on, I'll help you look for him, my mom will freak out if anything beyond the bonfires burn. Let's leave the love birds to their own thing," Glimmer says, walking away before Catra can start insulting her. *Coward* .

"So, how are other humans doing?" Catra asks to Adora instead.

" *Good, I think. They talk a lot and I didn't understand half of it,"* Adora's eyebrows scrunch, lacing her arm with Catra's. *"Please don't leave me alone again."*

"Pff, no chance in hell. You are stuck with me now," Catra blurts out and it's until she finishes saying it that she realizes what she said. She glances at Adora from the corner of her eye to see if she has made her uncomfortable but quite the contrary she looks happy with it, resting her cheek over Catra's shoulder with a hum.

The crowd has stopped, one by one walking towards the huge altar placed in the middle of the square. There are orange and purple petals mixed with multicolored powders, creating colorful tapestries over the white stones of the floor. Over the steps of the altar there are photographs and various plates of food, candies and desserts, flowers, salt and incense burning in the corners with a sweet smell. As the people walk by, the altar starts to fill with the light of the candles and the things they bring for their dead ones.

Catra squirms, uncomfortable, stepping back from the moving crowd in silence. Adora turns to her when she feels Catra's hand slipping away from her arm, her eyebrows lifted in a silent question.

"I, um, I don't have anything to place up there," Catra says, handing her candle to Adora. Adora looks at her, her eyebrows twitching in worry. Catra grimaces, leaning over one of the street lamps and away from the rest of the people. "You go see."

Adora looks deeply conflicted. She looks towards the myriad of people and then back to Catra, pressing her lips together into a firm line. A firm expression falls in her face as she turns around and disappears between the people.

Okay then, Catra thinks, grumbling. Annoyance falls over her but is not like she can complain. She did tell her to go after all. But still.

Catra sulks for a grand total of five minutes until Adora makes her way back to where she is. Her golden hair is a little disheveled, stuck in the tiny branches of the floral crown on her hair, but she looks excited as she makes her way to Catra. Her candle is nowhere to be seen but she is carrying something else in her hands, orange and soft looking.

“What do you have there?” Catra asks, frowning. Adora shakes her head, passing both things into one hand.

“ *Come with me,”* she signs, stretching her hand towards Catra,

Catra looks at her with narrowed eyes, suspicious. She could say no, stay sulking here and watch Adora mingle among the people. But Adora´s face is bright, hopeful, patiently waiting for Catra to decide. Catra takes her hand.

Adora guides her through the sea of people like she had done it her entire life and this wasn´t her first time around so many humans. Catra looks at her, an eyebrow arched, wondering how Adora is not nervous. But then again, as they get near to the floral, colorful altar, she can feel Adora´s clammy hand around hers and see the light shimmer of sweat in her forehead, or the way she seems to cling to Catra´s hand like a safe line and Catra understands she is nervous, but she is pushing through it. For Catra.

Catra barely notices that they have stopped in front of the altar until the smells hit her. There are already a lot of candles up there. Adora´s candle nestled between two empty bronze plates, with enough space next to it to place a second candle there. Adora turns to take Catra ´s candle softly from her hands, placing it in the free space before leaning one more time to place the things on her hands over the plates. Under the light of the candles Catra can see they are marigold garlands, orange, yellow and red sprinkled in their petals, resting next to the candles in calm.

Catra stares at them, speechless, until Adora brushes her finger under Catra´s chin, tilting her face towards her so she can see her sign.

“ *For Razz,”* Adora signs, caressing one of the garlands. She stretches her hand and brushes her fingers over the second one. *“And for you mom”*

Catra feels something loosen in her chest and break. She doesn't even realize she is until Adora cups her jaw in her palm, thumbing off the small tears that had started to fall from her eyes. She doesn't say anything, neither does Catra, it's a silent mutual accord. Instead, Catra laces her arms around Adora´s waist, burying her face in the angle of her collarbones. She can wait until the morning to feel mortified about it. Adora wraps her arm around Catra´s shoulders and rest her chin over her hair, watching the candles together until they don't burn anymore.

–

Catra has been fifteen minutes picking from her plate of sweet pumpkin, watching Adora go through her four plates. She sits a few feet away, between Glimmer and Bow, making no attempt to even pretend to listen to what they are saying beyond a few errand nods here and there and smiles dusted in food crumbs. The other two don't seem to be bothered by it, in fact they just look even more fueled to keep talking, something about the decorations and the festival, Catra isn't making a try to actually listen.

It's actually kind of funny, watching Adora having fun in the festival. Except for the errand moments some random girl decides to saunter where they are to casually greet the mayor´s daughter and her new friend and, seriously, who does that? But Glimmer plays it alone just to see the look in Catra´s face every time, gloomy and dark like a shadow. Catra is very close to throwing her plate at her face.

“Another milkshake for your friend?” asks the stall owner next to Catra, pointing at the tall glass with caramel liquid and then Adora.

“Yeah, just take it to her, I´ll pay for everything she takes”

“Sure,” and Catra swears the owner is laughing internally at her.

“Still sulking?” Glimmer asks as she approaches Catra, leaving her empty glass on the counter as an excuse. Catra frowns at her, scoffing.

“I don´t sulk”

“Yeah, whatever you say” Glimmer leans her back over the counter, following Catra´s gaze to where Bow and Adora are chatting. Whatever he is saying is making Adora laugh, so Catra can't find it in herself to be annoyed at it.

“She is nice,” Glimmer says, still looking at Adora. “A little bit dense but she is smart and kind hearted. I like her”

Catra rolls her eyes, finally giving up and pushing her plate away. As with everything with Glimmer Brightmoon the words can´t help to annoy, but the compliment makes her feel somehow proud too. Catra has found about herself that she likes that people see Adora for who she truly is, beyond the beautiful eyes and selfless heart. “Didn't know I needed your approval”

“You are a fucking jerk, you knew that?” Glimmer returns, though there isn't actual offense on it. She is smirking, actually.

“My best quality,” Catra grins with a shrug.

“What I'm *trying* to say,”Glimmer presses further, “Is that she is good for you. She makes you happy.”

Catra grimaces, picking in the fragile fabric of her dress with her sharp nails. “What makes you think that?”

“Well, for starters, I´ve never seen you drop your grumpy ass face like when you are with her” Glimmer teases her. But there is a heavy hint of honesty in her voice too. “She makes you smile. And you are– soft, I guess.”

“Aw, Sparkles, are you saying you have a soft spot for me?” Catra mocks her, trying to distract herself from the bump in her throat.

“I'm saying *you* have a soft spot for Adora” Glimmer bumps her hip against Catra´s elbow. “I mean, she is your wife after all”

“Sure. I guess” Catra mumbles under her breath, without really feeling it. Glimmer must hear it because she sits down next to Catra, giving her an honest worried face that almost makes Catra bark or run away.

“Catra, listen, I know we don´t know each other very well,” *definitely running away, “* and I'm a bitch with you sometimes and you are a jerk, it works for us, you know? But I mean what I'm saying. When I saw you arrived to Salineas you were so- well, you looked pathetically miserable”

“Thank you Sparkles”

“Shut up and listen. You looked so sad, and I don't know in what moment between that and now Adora happened but I´m glad it did.” Catra stares at her sparkling face without knowing what to say. Glimmer scoffs and punches her gently in the arm. “Happiness looks good in your stupid face.”

That´s better. Insults are something Catra knows. “Oh, I knew you had a silly little crush on me. You can say that you find me hot, you know?”

Glimmer groans, crossing her arms over her chest. “Asshole”

“Jerk”

Both dissolve into an easy laughter, watching as Bow and Adora walk towards them, Bow pointing at the spotted paper hanging from the street lamps and Adora staring at Catra.

“Thank you,” Catra whispers under her breath to Glimmer and she better have heard it because Catra will die before repeating it.

She heard it. “Sure,” Glimmer whispers back, grinning.

"Let's go dance to the bonfires!" Bow calls to them, smiling brightly. Adora's eyes shine in recognition, signing quickly.

" *I know how to dance. Catra taught me"* she says, with a warm smile. Bow's eyes almost seem to sparkle with cuteness and Glimmer groans, fake gagging.

"Of course she did. Come on" she laces her arm with Catra's and stretches to tangle her free one with Adora's, smiling mischievously. "This is an experience I don't want your boring asses to miss"

Glimmer bullies them all out of their shoes and basically drags them across the festival, down the port and over the sand until they are in front of one of the tall bonfires, the town on one side, the sea on the other. There are a few people there already. Mermista and Bow and a few pretty girls that send curious and charged looks towards Adora.

Catra gulps, looking at Adora, standing opposite to her across the fire. She looks ethereal under the red and golden light of the flames, a beacon of white light among the darkness of the night sky. Her haze is nervous as she glances at the people dancing in the nearby bonfires, unsure I'm her bare feet.

" *Alright, maybe I don't know how to dance after all"* Adora signs, shoulders dropped. There are two girls next to Adora, their eyes locked on her. The one on the left is lean and elegant, beautiful dark skin and locks held with golden rings, she is already spinning softly in her feet, light as a feather, batting her eyelashes to Adora with no regards to everyone else. The girl on the right is taller, stronger, handsome with white hair held in a high ponytail and she is smirking at Adora, flexing her arms on purpose. Catra grimaces, all good mood running off her immediately.

"Nobody does!" Glimmer shouts to Adora over the sound of the burning wood. "Just move around the fire as you feel like!"

Glimmer grabs Bow's hand and starts swinging from side to side, giving quick, practiced steps with him in their places. Mermista and Sea Hawk next to her do- their own thing, Catra guesses. There are drums and fiddlers on the shore playing quick and cheerful music, echoing across the entire beach, the soft hum of sweet voices singing unintelligible words alongside them.

The pretty girl next to Adora starts to circle her over the sand, drawing swirls with her hands and doing pirouettes around. The taller woman is heavier in her steps, moving around Adora like a serpent, sharp and exact on every moment. Adora observes them in silence as they surround her and turn away multiple times, hugging her upper arm, embarrassed and nervous. Adora is swinging gently from side to side but it's clear she doesn't know what to do or how to proceed, throwing swift shy glances at Catra through the fire.

Catra clicks her tongue and relaxes her shoulders, digging her feet in the soft sand below her soles. She can deal with some women doing sad attempts of bird's mating dances. She has twelve years of forced ballet under her belt, after all.

Catra steps back, dragging the sand with her feet, stretching her arms to the sides. She feels kind of ridiculous, but as Adora's eyes focus on her and only in her, Catra can't help but think that maybe, this moment right now, belongs to something else, something ancient.

Catra gives a step to the side and then spins in a half circle, the translucent fabric of the dress swirling behind her like a river. Adora's pupils shrink and then blow completely, dark overcoming the silver when Catra repeats the step, running her hands through her messed up curls, tiny petals in leaves falling from the crown in rains of green and blue. Catra gives a step forward and then to the other side, circling herself with her arms as she spins in three circles in her spot, letting her feet fall down the sand as gracefully as humanly possible, lifting her own weight easily when she lifts her leg up and straight towards her head, twisting her torso to the other side and landing in the same foot with an elegant spin. Across the fire, Adora mirrors the direction of Catra's steps, almost without thinking. She doesn't imitate the swirls or pirouettes but every time Catra steps to the side, forwards or backwards, so does Adora, following her movements like a second shadow, always close, never reaching her.

Catra opens her arms again and turns with them into quick spirals, never taking her eyes away from Adora's darkened ones, swirls so effortlessly they almost look impossible slow. It isn't until Catra gives a small, elegant jump on her place, falling surely in her feet as she bends her back down almost in half, hair falling in cascades down her back, and raising back again with her arms stretched towards the sky that Adora realizes she is imitating the movement of the waves behind her, moving like flowing water surrounded by fire, and if that doesn't mirror everything Catra is then Adora doesn't know a thing about poetry or love.

Catra stands on one leg, the other one stretched in front of her and spins again, turning outwards until she can't turn anymore, stopping with a firm stomp in the ground with her body facing the fire. She is breathing hard, chest moving up and down with the same strength of her movements, carving patterns inside Adora's bright eyes. They don't notice it but the rest of the people around the bonfire have retreated a little, allowing them their own private

inner circle next to the burning logs. Everybody is looking now, everybody is looking at Catra now, flames reflecting golden light against her skin, luring Adora closer with each turn and bend.

Adora stretches her arm towards the fire. Catra mirrors her. The flames bite in the tip of her fingers, almost too close to hurt and too far away to bring her close, twirling over the sand. Adora stops, standing still in the ring of people dancing around her, eyes locked in Catra's. Catra stops too, stepping back, breaking their entrancing dance of light and shadow.

Adora walks around the fire, her feet leaving footprints of sand behind her until she is right in front of Catra. Adora's breathing is heavy, heart thundering inside her chest like a hummingbird, eyes black and cheeks pink. Catra purrs, something proud and slick wrappjng over her ribs and throat, delighted in the fact that she has this reaction from Adora, her entire attention, making her forget every single other person in the godforsaken town except Catra.

Catra watches as Adora gulps heavily, her throat long and enticing. Catra smiles at her, sideways and somehow evil, circling Adora once in long, elegant steps, twirling over the soles of her feet in an invisible choreography until she is placed at Adora's back, turning around too. Catra's shoulder blades are pressed with Adora's, back against back. Catra tilts her head to the sides, glancing at Adora's profile from the corner of her eyes so close to her face she can feel her breath over her eyelashes. Catra raises her arms away again this time she lifts Adora's with hers too, guiding her. Adora's upper arms and wrists rest over Catra's, side by side, tangled like a swan's wing.

Adora exhales, nervousness loud even in her silence, but Catra just smirks at her, taking a step to the left and guiding Adora with her. Slowly, back to back, eyes interlocked, they start giving graceful steps around the bonfire, sometimes swirls, sometimes broad circles. Catra guiding, Adora following.

Adora laces her fingers with Catra's and pulls from her hand, twirling Catra under her arms in a sudden burst of confidence. Catra chuckles, pleasantly surprised, balancing herself on her feet. Catra separates from Adora just enough so she can turn them both around, this time facing front to front. Catra wraps her arm around Adora's belly, taking Adora's opposite arm so she can wrap it around her waist, leading them into a new kind of circle. That's good, Adora can do circles and that's it because pretty much any other thought has flown away from her head completely, enthralled only in Catra's bright, multicolored eyes.

Catra's grin only grows, tightening her grip on Adora's hips. A gentle squeeze is the only warning Adora gets before Catra seizes her back and waist and tilts Adora into a low dip, making Adora's long hair brush the sand below them, ripping a surprised gasp from her throat.

It shouldn't be possible but Adora's eyes darken even further, black drowning the white completely, bright blue shimmering inside them instead of silver. Adora's jaw snaps with a click and her mouth settles into an indescribable expression, looking at Catra hovering over her with a completely new gaze.

She straightens up and reaches Catra quickly, pressing their chests against each other, lacing the fingers of both of their hands together, palm against palm. Catra opens her mouth to talk

but Adora stops her, shaking her head. Instead, Adora starts moving forward, walking Catra backwards until they are away from the bonfire and from the curious gazes of the rest, entering the darkness as they walk further away.

A chill shiver runs down Catra's spine under the weight of Adora's expression but doesn't speak, allowing her to guide Catra towards the sea, hands still holding, bodies still pressed close, breaths mingled of how close their faces hover over each other. It's so much, so overwhelming in such a wonderful, glorious way Catra barely reacts when the cold sea starts licking her feet and legs, seducing her deeper inside. The water is calm, the calmest Catra has ever seen them, cold when she steps barefoot inside the waves. The sand sinks a little under her feet, giving away the further they walk inside the sea.

Adora is swinging from side to side gently, following the echoes of the music far away, never taking her dark eyes away. She sinks alongside Catra until the water reaches their chest, lapping gently the exposed skin of their collarbones and making the fabric of Catra's dress stick to her shoulders.

Catra exhales, resting her hands over Adora's shoulders, letting her weight rest on Adora's hands wrapped in around her waist. The sky is scattering in stars tonight, shimmering and so close to the water that Catra almost feels that she can touch them.

Catra tilts her head back, her hair falling inside water, soaking completely. Adora leans alongside her, pressing her cheek against Catra's, down her damp temples and the angle of her jaw until she reaches down, pressing her lips against the column Catra's neck.

Catra's breath hitches, shaking for reasons very different to the cold of the sea as Adora drags her lips down the small depths and creases of her collarbones and in a spot right below her chin that makes her entire world switch off. Adora sighs against Catra's skin, resting her cheek over her chest, both of them floating gently above the water, drifting with the ocean waves and in that moment Catra doesn't feel afraid of the water anymore.

Adora locks her eyes with Catra's, blue against amber, and slowly, almost tenderly, sinks them both under the water.

–

"And did you see Sparkles face when you walked in?" Catra giggles, kicking her feet in the air. "She got all red in the face when she saw you. I never thought something would be able to make Glimmer Brightmoon lose her words, but I've been proven wrong."

Catra is draped over Adora's lap, the back of her head nestled between the couch's armrest and Adora's thighs, and her legs throw without care over the other side of the couch. Adora's face hovers over hers, smiling, slightly leaning forward as she runs the pad of her fingers over the bridge of Catra's nose, again and again in a quiet, gentle motion.

They've been like this for the last minutes, Catra mumbling without stopping, slumped over Adora's legs, Adora looking at her in silence, almost adoringly. The fire in the chimney cracks every once in a while, slipping warmth inside their chests and bones.

Catra feels drunk, even though she hasn't drunk a single drop of alcohol. Her mind is fuzzy, spinning over its axis, full of bonfire smoke, sand and the salt of the water that still clings to Catra's hair. She's been feeling like this since the sea, under the sea, floating around the waves and darkness that scare her so much, with the ghost of Adora's lips on her neck and her hands on her waist.

The water won't hurt you. I'm here, Adora said and she had meant it. The sea was at peace, washing over them and Catra didn't feel oppressed or suffocated by its weight, she felt light. Even though she couldn't see beyond her nose and the sea opened wide and deep below her feet, Adora was there. Catra could see the blue shimmer of her eyes beyond the darkness, the soft feeling of her ears between her fingers -long, silk like, different to the cartilage she is used to- and the scales adorning her face and shoulders. Adora's pale legs had tangled around Catra's, her arms around her waist, her face over her shoulder, embracing Catra completely. She could have drowned her, there and then. Catra wouldn't have been able to resist, she wouldn't even have wanted to. Adora could have dragged her to the bottom of the ocean and devoured her whole and Catra would have allowed her. Maybe this was how sailors felt, why they described that infernal wonder at the presence of sirens. Unable to look away, welcoming death like one that treats life for one second of ethereal beauty.

But Adora didn't drown her or devour her. She tore Catra apart in a different way because when the latter opened her eyes to the darkness she wasn't afraid of the water or of drowning, she was at peace because Adora was with her. And what lasted just the few second Catra could hold her breath seemed like hours, until Adora get tly pulled them both above the surface, floating between the water and the stars, Catra's cheek nestled in the curve of Adora's shoulders.

So yes, Catra feels drunk with Adora. She doesn't even remember how they made it back to the house. Did they drive? Did they walk? Did Adora carry her weight through the waves until they made it to their shore? She doesn't remember. She doesn't even *care.*

Why would she? Catra is selfish, she knows this. She wants this. She wants this with Adora. The stolen second with mingled breaths and cold skin against warm one. Catra feels as if she had stolen something precious from the sea, something not meant for humans and yet she has her and she likes and it makes her sick with shame at the same time because Adora didn't choose this, she is just stuck on this moment with Catra. Adora is not hers, she is not a thing and Catra hates herself.

Catra exhales, blinking back the tears that had suddenly gathered in her eyes. Adora has notice -of course she had, for the wetness in her eyelashes or the sudden silence- but she doesn't speak about it, just running her finger below Catra's eyes, caressing the fragile skin there with feather touch.

"Why do you only say my name?" Catra asks, out of nothing, not louder than a whisper. Adora tilts her head to the side, bringing her hands close to her chest so she can sign quickly.

" *What?"* She is adorable when she is confused. Her eyebrows twitch and knit together, her silver eyes flash quickly with intelligence and curiosity. Catra bites into her lip, shrugging.

"When you use your voice, the only thing you say is always my name," she explains. She can feel sweat in her forehead, heat coloring her cheeks immediately under Adora's gaze. "Why?"

There is still so much confusion in Adora's face it's starting to make Catra nervous she said something stupid. Adora squirms a little under Catra's weight, chewing on the inside of her cheek. " *Do you understand me when I call your name?"*

"Well, duh, it's my name," Catra halfheartedly jokes, chuckling awkwardly.

" *No, Catra,"* Adora shakes her head, her hands moving quicker, more urgently. She has nice hands, strong, with long fingers and soft palms. *"You aren't supposed to understand me. I always call your name in my mother tongue"*

"Oh" Catra frowns, distracted. She doesn't want to drive into that today but she needs to ask. "Why do you do that?"

Tensions easies from Adora's shoulders and this time she is the one that shrugs, a tender smile itching its way in her mouth. She has a nice mouth too, pink lips, long but full, still shimmering with the peach chapstick Catra had handed her earlier. " *It's easy, your name. It 's like music."*

"Hmm" is the only thing Catra can mutter, humming under her breath.

Adora is looking at her in that way again, the way that makes Catra want *everything* in the world and still throw it all into the sun just for a moment that she can share with Adora. That way that makes Catra know that she would die for her, right here and now, even after she has been so stubborn to survive life out of sheer spite. The look that makes Catra want to be better, kinder, softer. Is the look that Adora always gives her and Catra doesn't know how to ace it inside her chest, if she should cradle it inside her ribcage or stab herself in the heart with it.

Catra blinks at her from her place on Adora's lap, mouth suddenly going from dry to specially wet. She feels fussy all over, from her flushed face to her toes, bubbling inside like sparkling water and something else completely different.

Catra damps her lower lip with her tongue, not taking away her eyes from Adora's shimmering ones, open, waiting, the silver swimming in blue like the moon reflecting on the sea. Adora is beautiful under the soft light of the fireplace, the shadows dancing over her sharp features like waves. Her hands are now slowly making her way through Catra's curls, rubbing circles on her scalp and nape, tearing a hum from Catra's throat that almost sounds like a purr. And she smells amazing, a mixture of smoke and fresh water that Catra can't wash away from her skin.

She is so close too. Adora has leaned further towards Catra, her hair creating a curtain of gold around Catra's face, surrounding them inside a fragile, calm bubble. Catra can feel her heart beating inside her throat when she gulps, her breath hitching in her lungs. All thoughts leave her mind, hushed and locked away somewhere where her fear can't reach them and maybe that is what catalyzes Catra's doom but she doesn't stop it.

Adora's hands stop, tangled in Catra's curls, fingers pressing against her skull. Catra stretches her arm, wrapping her hand on the back of Adora's neck. Her thumb draws spirals over Adora's cheek, invisible letters that she hopes Adora doesn't understand, brushing past the golden freckles there. So close, Catra can count them one by one, she can see herself reflected in Adora's eyes, cheeks flushed, mouth agape, and can feel the beating of Adora's heart against her ribs. The tension that had built up between them finally reaches a critical point, like a candle burning down or the sun hiding behind the sea, and it snaps. Catra surges forward, Adora leans down, the sea and the stone meeting in the middle.

Catra has kissed people before. Under the neon lights of some colleague party, with a cheerleader draped on her lap and one too many beers in her system. In the weary back of an alley, quick, angry and unsatisfying, lips bitten, cigarette's smoke and sore throats. Swift and underwhelming. Quick and hurtful. Kisses for Catra were quick escapes that made her numb, rebellious. Meant to take a rise out of her stepmother and hurt herself in the process.

None of them ever felt right.

None of them were Adora.

Adora's mouth parts against hers with a sigh. She doesn't gasp in shock, or surprise. She doesn't recoil in disgust. Adora *melts* around Catra, her strong arms wrapping around her waist, supporting the base of Catra's head against herself.

Catra inhales, holds her breath, pressing her chapped lips against Adora's smooth, cold ones. Adora's lips open with Catra's, her sweet breath hitting the base of her throat like rain. She is soft around Catra, kissing her like a hurricane kisses the shore, washing it all away, holding her between her arms and wrapping around her sand and the inside of her heart around the shape of Adora's adoration. Catra hiccups against her mouth, her chest heavy, breath speeding up impossibly when Adora's tongue moves forward, the cool muscle brushing past Catra's tongue and over the roof of her mouth in one tender lick.

Something flares up inside Catra's chest, boiling hot like lava, exploding like a nova, washing down her back as a snow storm. Catra's heart opens and spills, barriers crumbling into pieces as sand castles, slipping through Adora's fingers as she wishes and Catra knows there is no coming back from this. No matter what, no matter the weight of the heart break after or how much it will destroy her once Adora is gone, she will always be Adora's.

Catra straightens up in Adora's lap, never once letting go from Adora's mouth. She shifts over her legs, hooking her knee over Adora's hip, her tights coming to wrap at each side of her waist, sitting over her legs, chests pressed tightly together. Catra cradles Adora's face between her palms, gently, as lovingly as she can, tilting her head to the side so she can kiss her back deeper. Adora doesn't even hesitate with the change. Her grip on Catra's back shifts, long fingers wrapped on her hips, holding her close with steel grip.

Catra's tongue shoots forward, running its tip over Adora's bottom lip, cooing her mouth back open. Adora lets her head drop against the back of the couch and whimpers around Catra's tongue, a strangled sound that hitches in her throat and makes Catra smile around her mouth. Catra drops her head into Adora's neck, trailing a path of kisses over the length of her jaw, up the angle of her ear, running the edge of her teeth in the soft cartilage that lives there. Adora

exhales underneath her and leans forward, latching her mouth against the shivering skin of Catra's neck, kissing, sucking, *biting* down, her fangs catching human skin, until Catra gasps with an electric wave running down her spine, returning to Adora's open lips with newfound fire. All around them, the only sounds in the house are the fire cracking behind them, the faraway crash of the waves against the shore and the soft murmur of the mouths brushing together, joining in a known dance like a sinner's prayer inside the sacred space that is their desire for each other's skin.

All Catra had ever learned about love is that it's transactional, directly proportional to what someone can do or be of use for someone else. Until now.

All Adora has ever learned about love, is Catra

Catra closes her eyes tighter, exhaling into Adora's mouth. Her hands grip around Adora's golden hair, fingers running through the strands like rocks in a river, past the curve of her neck and up the gentle skin of her nape. And then Adora makes a particular something with her tongue inside Catra's mouth and Catra's heart promptly packs its bags and leaves, her hands twitching without her permission, making her pull from Adora's hair *hard.*

Adora whimpers around Catra's tongue, her sharp teeth catching in the skin of her lip, biting into the soft surface, drawing the infinitesimal drop of blood. Adora smooths her tongue over the reddened lip, licking away the sudden sting and blood, replacing it with liquid heat. Adora's hands clench and close tighter around Catra's hip bones, bringing her closer, accidentally making her slide over her lap further. Catra holds her breath, her thighs twitch away and then forward, rocking over Adora's abdomen in one long line. A shiver runs down Catra's entire body as the middle of her body meets Adora's skin between the layers of her leggings and the silk fabric of Adora's dress. Sweat breaks in Catra's forehead, cradling the sides of Adora's head between her hands, and her mouth opens in Adora's again, a loud, vibrating sound born from her chest and rumbling through her vocal cords in a proper, deep, moan.

The sound breaks Catra's bubble like a hundred needles. Painfully. She parts from Adora reluctantly, opening her eyes slowly, fearful, not wanting to wake up from this dream ever again. But she does in the end, just a little, just enough. Her mouth hovers over Adora's lightly, lips basically still brushing together, puffy and wet, smudged with Catra's red lipstick. Adora's eyes are closed, her cheeks painted in deep pink, the entire skin of her temples, neck and jaw covered in beautiful scales, more than Catra has ever seen her before. Against her skin, her eyelashes cast errand shadows, fluttering as butterfly's wings. She chases behind Catra's mouth, opening her silver eyes only when she isn't able to catch her, searching for her. They sparkle with life and something else, completely different. Nobody has ever looked at Catra like this. It terrifies her.

But it terrifies her more when the realization of what she just did finally locks into place.

"Fuck," Catra whispers, broken with pleasure. It makes heat and shame wash over her. At the shaken sound of her voice, Adora's pupils blow, pools of darkness against silver. Catra untangles her hands from Adora's messed up hair, jolting backward like a firecracker just lightened up. "Fuck. Fuck"

Catra climbs down Adora's lap, tripping on her own legs and falling hard into the floor. Adora surges forward, standing up to help her. Her face is broken too, concern drawn all over her face, barely covering her disheveled expression. She looks wild and beautiful and Catra hates herself with all her heart.

"I'm so sorry. This- Fuck" Catra scrambles into her feet, ignoring Adora's helping hands. Catra walks back, stumbling several times, putting a considerable distance between them. Adora's hand is outstretched towards Catra, trying to reach her, hold her again. Catra hugs herself, shaking her head, trembling from head to toe. "This shouldn't have happened"

Adora lets her hand fall back to her sides, fingers twitching against the fabric and eyes break into pieces and it hurts. Catra's heart stops its tracks, robbing her of her breath, making tears gather in her eyes and a scream make its way of her throat because she is fucking this up. She *fucked* this up, as with everything she has ever had in her life. Bad friends, even worse companions, college opportunities, bad decisions, mistakes.

Impulsive, a voice adds, a voice too familiar. *Volatile, distrustful. A distraction, a mistake* .

She is fucking this up, fucking Adora up. Adora who belongs to another world, who is good and deserves good and Catra can't give it to her because one way or another she will ruin this and she knows it. Like right now. Sooner or later, Adora will find out what Catra truly is. Raw and unfiltered, cutting, broken. She's been lying to Adora about her skin and she's been lying to herself about what she deserves. She doesn't deserve this -Adora's lips in her neck, her hands on her hips- and she is not going to have this. Catra never gets what she wants and all that she loves always leaves. Why would Adora be different?

" Catra *"*

Adora's voice cuts into the darkness like the sun, warm and golden but also burning, biting in Catra's cold skin, so used to being under the shadows she doesn't know where she begins or ends anymore. She is so fucked up.

Adora's jaw sets, her back straightening. She can see Catra spiraling back into her head, Catra knows she can see it and it fills her with shame. Adora, though, seems to have come to a resolution of her own. She steps closer, towards Catra, grimacing when Catra recoils and steps away.

Adora stops her reaching, lowering her hands instead to sign where she knows Catra can see her. *"I'm not going to hurt you."*

The words hit Catra like a thousand bricks because that's what all is reduced to, isn't? Everyone Catra has ever loved her has hurt her, if they meant it or not it didn't matter. They had.

Catra shakes her head, sharp, once. She points with her chin towards Adora's blunt nails. "I know you won't."

But Adora is already shaking her golden hair, looking at Catra with all the love and patience and honesty she is capable of, which for Adora is a lot. " *That's not what I mean,"* she says

and yes, Adora would rather cut her own hands off than raise a single finger against Catra, but they both know that's not what this is about.

"I know," Catra's shoulders fall, finally giving in to the honesty that is boiling inside her mouth. "It's not you I'm afraid of."

It's me, Catra thinks, though she doesn't say. She doesn't need to, Adora hears her.

Adora scoots closer, until she is merely a breath away from Catra and the latter is still shivering and she feels gross and wrong all over but the pang of Adora's lips in her neck still lives in her skin. Adora leans, thumbs Catra's cheek with loving touch, presses a constellation of tiny kisses in the swell of her cheekbone, down the curve of her chin, tilting away just enough to sign.

" *Sweetheart, I'm not going to leave you."*

And it breaks Catra's heart.

"No" Catra says but it doesn't come out, lost in the sound and feeling of Adora's lips on the corner of her mouth. "No. You don't get to say that." This time it does come, echoing inside the quiet living room. Catra wants to say it angry, furious even that Adora's dares to make a promise she can't keep. But it comes different, quieter, more heartbroken than she intended. Scared. It just makes Catra angrier. She presses her palms over Adora's chest and pushes her away, snarling. "Not when you and I know you are going to fuck off as soon as you find your skin again. You don't get to lie to me like that just because I'm human. Just because I care."

Adora winces as if Catra had slapped her. Her eyes harden, mouth closing into a firm line and for one second a bigger panic crawls nasty in Catra's chest, mixed with regret and shame.

" *That's not fair,"* Adora says and it cuts worse than if Adora had stabbed her. Catra looks away, curling her hands into fists. She can feel her own nails cutting in the skin of her palms but she welcomes it. *Rude, insensitive.* Adora softness, releasing a breath slowly through her mouth. She brushes Catra's chin with her fingers, gently cooing her to look back at her. " *I'm not lying, Catra"*

Catra wants to look away again but she can't, not with Adora's eyes carving roots inside hers. "You don't even know any other human, Adora." Catra mutters, flinching at her own tone, annoyed by the almost desperate edge on it. "There is so much out there, so much for you to see and know. So much you already know. What can I give you that wins over that? You will leave, for another human more interesting, prettier" *less broken, less hard to love "* or for another First One, someone like you" *kinder, softer.* "You'll find your 'mate' like your brother and you won't look back."

"Why are you giving me so little choice about this?" Adora finally snaps, walking away from Catra in a furious shiver. Catra trembles with the absence. *"Why are you already deciding for me? You speak as if you know exactly what I'm going to do or choose. Leaving or not leaving, wanting you or not, that's my decision"*

"You are a siren, Adora!" Catra is screaming now, tearing her vocal chords apart. "You are a mythical creature, you live in a world I don't belong to"

" *I'm not mythical. I'm right here and you are here, with me"* Adora runs her hands through her hair exasperated, and the movement is so human it steals Catra's heartbeat. There is some kind of desperation in Adora's eyes when she looks back at her and for the first time Catra considers that maybe it's not only herself she is hurting by self sabotaging.

"Catra, I'm not perfect," and the way Adora says it is forceful, spoken between her teeth and a scowl, angry at the mere thought that Catra might be thinking about it. *"I'm not some ethereal unapproachable being. First Ones love to think about themselves like that, but I'm far from it. I lie too. I can be cruel too. I'm angry and stubborn and impulsive"*

Inadequate, a waste of time, a disappointment. That's wrong, that's what Catra is and they are not the same. But that's not true, is it? They are more alike than Catra dares to admit. Adora swam in the middle of a storm because she likes the rush of it, she runs head first into things without thinking if they might hurt her, she is feral and destructive but she is also cheerful, she trusts fast and loves faster and she is good and those are things that Catra was -is- before she forgot who she was at all. Things that Adora's presence made appear once again and isn't it love but cradling the good and bad things of each other? Embracing the ugly, broken part and accepting them?

Adora is looking at Catra with a kind of anguish and hurt that makes her heart tear itself in shreds. She is trembling from head to toe, crystal tears running down her cheeks, her face contorted into an expression that speaks of heavy resentment and barely content anger. Catra has seen her like this before, the day it happened, Adora with her knees sunk into the sand, screaming at the top of her lungs to the sea, begging it to take her back and having no answer in return.

" *I hate them"* Adora spats, her hands almost hitting against each other as they move. Catra stands still, frozen in place. *"I hate them. I hate them with all my heart. I hate what they've done to me, what they took from me. They abused me, hurted me, used me. Defiled me"* Adora's nails dig into the skin of her palms, much like Catra's did on her own. Catra flinches at the sight, shaking too. She wants to surge forward, wrap her arms around Adora's ribcage and embrace, absorb her inside her chest where the humans that hurt her can't find her, hurt her, use her ever again. Catra wishes she could scream and tear her hair and hunt those men down until they return what they have taken from Adora.

But she doesn't. Catra doesn't move or talks, she remains there, listening to Adora pour all the pain from inside her chest, letting her drop it between their feet so maybe the fire will get to reach it and consume it whole.

" *I pray every day to Kindly Ones that they die, that they get to feel what they did to me. I want them to suffer, I want to kill them. I want them dead"* Adora releases her breath, a wheezing, out of air sound pouring from her lungs, struggling to even pass through her nose. Adora's eyebrows twitch in despair, signaling to herself in anger. *"Do you think that makes me good? Kind? Catra, look at me"* Catra is looking. Adora steps back into the light of the fireplace and her face has changed. Her ears are long, pointed like Catra had felt them underwater, silk and golden fins. Scales cling to her face like pearls and her mouth is closed

but Catra can see the rows of shark-like like teeth, lethal and dangerous below the vulnerable skin of her cheeks. Even her eyes have changed, bright blue moons inside pools of darkness. *"Look at me. I'm not a goddess."*

"You are beautiful," Catra believes she thinks until she sees the way it disarms Adora completely and she realizes she said it outloud. Catra hopes Adora knows she is not talking about looks, that she is talking about something beyond. Adora knows, and still-

" *I'm a monster, Catra. I'm the one that doesn't deserves you. I'm broken beyond repair. I tear skin and feast in flesh. I'm what human's nightmares are made of."*

Adora gasps, breathless, almost crumbling into the wooden floor. Catra looks into her eyes, holding Adora's words inside her chest. But all Catra can see is *Adora,* sharp teeth and scales or golden hair and soft hands. It's still Adora. "You are not a nightmare to me"

Adora's eyes become impossible softer, tears rolling one after the other, mirroring Catra's. She gives Catra a tender, saddened smile. *"And you are still asking me not to love you?"*

Catra fall apart, pressing a hand to her mouth that barely contains the sob that breaks through her throat. Adora shoots forward, holds her, wrapping her arms around her neck, kissing the crown of her hair, nuzzling in the side of her face. Catra's lips wobble, rivers of tears streaming down her cheeks. She gets a hold of Adora's hands, lowering them down, resting her palms over Adora's. Long fingers against longer ones, blunt nails and sharp claws, freckles and scales.

"I'm a liar"

" *I trust you"*

"I've hurt everyone I've ever loved"

"I know you are working to be better"

"I'm not good for you"

"You make me happy"

"I'm not-" Catra's voice breaks. Adora waits. "I'm not enough. I don't deserve you"

" *You are everything, the only thing I've ever wanted"* Adora runs her hand through Catra's hair, pushing her curled bangs back, leaning to brush a featherlight kiss over Catra's lips. Catra sobs against her mouth, shaking her head infinitisemally small.

"I have nothing to give you"

Adora tilts her head to the side, smiles. Is tiny and shy, trembling in the corners with emotions. She is crying too.

"You don't need to"

The fire is warm on Catra's back and yet the cold touch of Adora's hands seems to burn Catra's skin when Adora bends once more, placing another kiss over Catra's open mouth. Catra kisses her back, sloppy and wet, tasting salt from their shared tears, shivering under the tingle of her fangs against her tongue.

"I'll wait" Adora signs when they finally part, tender and patient, making Catra's voice hitch on her lungs, *"I can wait for you. I've waited for you for two hundred years, Catra, I can wait until you are ready."*

Adora cradles Catra's cheek on her palm, drawing circles over her freckled skin. Catra nuzzles in her hand, closing her eyes for a second with a deep sigh. "Adora-"

"Catra" she opens her eyes again at Adora's call, missing her touch when she draws her hand away. *"You asked me if I knew what the meaning of wife was . Do you want me to tell you what the bread lady told me a wife was?"*

Catra bites into her bottom lip but nods, speechless. Adora's smile carves a dimple in her cheek.

" *She said a wife is someone you choose. That's why I said that in the market, Catra. I didn't got a word of what happened to me but I do choose to stay. Because you are who I choose* " she says it like a secret and like a hymn, spoken between them in whispers and caresses of hands, screamed to the sea in songs of rebellion. An eternal being begging a mortal to let them love her. " *I choose you* "

Catra cries. She cries when Adora wraps her hands around her face and neck, she cries when she gets near, cradling Catra's hands over her collarbones. Catra cries when Adora kisses her again, slow, thoughtful, catching the errand tears with her lips, running her tongue over the edge of her teeth, pressing her lips on the corner of Catra's mouth, on her temples, on the bridge of her nose.

Catra cries and falls and Adora catches her.

–

It's eight in the morning when Adora finally falls asleep. They've been quiet with each other since that moment in front of the fireplace, moving around each other in a known, familiar dance.

Catra stopped crying at some point, between the moment they climbed the stairs together and Adora, sitting Catra on the bed, ran a towel damp with warm water over her face, gently washing the tear tracks away. After, Adora laid next to Catra over the bed, watching her in silence. Catra looked at her back, until the dawn broke over the clouds and slipped inside the room like a candle.

Now Adora is on her side, sleeping deeply. Her hair is tousled to the side, golden over the blue of the sheets, one of her hands curled in front of her, as if she wanted to reach for something, even in her sleep. She looks so peaceful like this, all the lines of worry and sadness washed away from her face, her eyebrows relaxed, lips parted -lips that Catra has

tasted, cradled, surrendered herself to-, scales adorning her face like a crown, even in her sleep.

Catra is sitting next to her with her knees pressed against her chest, her chin resting over them, staring at the sunny sky outside as the sun makes its way over the sea. Her heart swells inside her chest, filled with something she never thought she would have and still, the dreadful feeling of guilt compresses her chest, makes the golden feeling turn into dark ooze, choking her from the inside out.

Catra slips out of the bed, tucking the cotton sheets over Adora's drowsy, sleepy body, fighting back the strong need of lean and brush a kiss over her forehead. Melog rises their head from their place in the loveseat by the window, waving their tail lazily at her as she makes her way silently across the bedroom and out of the door. The stairs are miraculously quiet when she tiptoes to the first floor, opening the curtains on her way outside.

Catra sits atop of the steps of the porch, fishing her phone from the pocket of her joggers. She has been awake the entire night, thinking. Catra hovers over her contacts, chewing over it for a few seconds until she finally decides to open the message bubble, tapping over the keyboard quickly.

To Scorpia

Catra: ***Hey, Scorp***

Sent

Seen 20 seconds ago

Catra's phone vibrates in her hand almost immediately after, Scorpia's profile photo shining on Catra's screen. Catra presses her lips in a tight line and sighs, tapping the answer button with just the smallest of hesitations. Scorpia's voice chimes through the phone as soon as the call comes through.

"**Hey, wildcat. Is everything okay?"** Scorpia sounds way too awake and alive to be so early, but then again she has always been more of a morning person opposite to Catra's late night slumbers. Catra grimaces, though Scorpia can't see it, wrinkling her nose in just the smallest of annoyances.

"How did you know?" she questions her friend. Catra can practically see Scorpia shrugging, her dark eyebrows knitted in concern.

"You never text first" Scorpia says in explanation, as simple as that. They remian silent on the line for a few seconds, quiet until Scorpia speaks again, this time worry clear in her tone. **"What happened?"**

Catra considers lying for one, good, considerable second but she gives it up soon after. Scirlia.woild know if she is lying anyway and Catra does want to talk about this, for the first. She wants for someone else to tell her if she has gone mad. "It's, um, about Adora"

"Okay" Scorpia agrees, not speeding her up but waiting, patient as Catra collects her thoughts.

"She- she said that she wants to be with me. That she chooses me. She said that I'm everything she has ever wanted" Catra's voice breaks and fades in the middle, choked up. There it is again, that feeling. Suddenly she feels dumb, inadequate, ridiculous for having caked Scorpia for this. What can Scorpia do anyway? She couldn't help Catra in college, she is not going to fix her fucked up head now. "This sounds so fucking stupid, doesn't it? I shouldn't have called for this-"

"It doesn't" Scorpia cuts her off and her voice is gentle to not drive Catra into panic but just firm enough to make her stop spiraling again. Scorpia sighs, the sounds distorted and unfazed by the static, but there. **"I kind of supposed it when we called yesterday, though I really thought you two had already gone through that "**

Catra's entire face shifts into a deep scowl. Was it really so obvious? Was Catra really, truly, so blind? "Why do you say that?"

Scorpia sighs into the phone and for one moment it shines through how fondly exasperated she is of Catra. "**You really don't realize the way she sees you, do you?"**

Catra gapes, speechless, looking at the sun painting the sea in red. "I'm not-"

"Did you reject her?" Scorpia cuts off. She is serious, uneasily serious.

"No." It's true, Catra didn't. But she also didn't say what she wanted. Adora had offered herself fully and embraced all that Catra was entirely, all the ugly, rotten parts that she had always thought of as unlovable, and yet Catra had said nothing. "I don't know. I- she said she was going to wait. For me"

"**Oh"**

Oh, indeed.

"No, no oh. I'm not- You don't understand. She is not like me," it sounds and tastes like bullshit even for Catra. Scorpia sees right through it too.

"**That's kind of a shitty thought, wildcat"**

"No, ugh. I don't mean it like that. I mean that- She has suffered so much, Scorpia. She's been hurt so badly and- and I'm not what Adora needs. I can't *give* her what she needs" Catra starts mumbling out, words tripping against each other, still alive and burning from the previous night, poisoning what is good in her life. Her throat is tight with treacherous tears, strangling her. "She would only end up being miserable if she stays with me," Catra ends, defeated.

"Umm" Scorpia says after a long second. **"You know that I adore you, right wildcat?"**

"But?"

"But you don't get to decide how much Adora needs you, or loves you. That's her decision" Scorpia's honesty slaps Catra, making her close her mouth with a very audible click. Scirpia must notice but she keep going. **"I know you've suffered in the past, wildcat, and I know you are scared. I saw you through it and, I think that after so many years of being told so, you started to believe that you actually deserved all the bad things that were happening to you. I think you still believe that. But that's not true, it was never true to begin with. You don't need to keep pushing away the good things that happen to you, Catra, not anymore. And Adora, I think, is a good thing."**

Catra exhales, rubbing her eyes with the palm of her hand. They feel puffy and charged, as if it hadn't been enough all the tears she had already shed.

"Catra, why do you think you are going to hurt Adora?" Scorpia questions. It's good natured, normal even to ask as a friend to another that is freaking out, but still manages to make Catra to spiral down.

Why, indeed? Maybe Scorpia was right. Maybe Catra was letting that *woman* win, ruin her life, allowing her to destroy her by destroying what made her happy. Poison her thoughts and her nights and her love. But it was all in Catra's hands after all, wasn't it? Weaver wasn't there anymore, it was just Catra, Catra and her fear to live. Things weren't bad anymore, Weaver was long gone, with her painful words and her abuse. Catra *survived.* She got out and made herself a successful career with something everyone told her she wasn't going to manage. She had a place to live, friends who wanted to help. Adora. Adora who last night had opened her ribcage and showed herself entirely to Catra as she was. All her hard edges and fears, her pain, her hate, her love.

"**Do you love her, wildcat?"** comes Scorpia's voice, sweet, understanding.

Catra wants to howl. Scream, run in circles, drown herself into the sea. "Scorpia, it's not that simple"

"**Do you?"**

Catra thinks about it. Adora sleeping, laughing breathlessly, dancing, swimming, basically inhaling food, smiling. Kissing, adoring. Her curiosity to live, to learn, to try. Her anger and fury, her stubbornness to survive, to hold herself above the abuse she had gone through. It should be obvious, tales tell about it, how easy it is to desire a siren, but this is completely different. Catra doesn't desire a siren, she loves one. She loves Adora.

Yes. Yes. Yes. Yes.

"Yes" Catra gives in, let's go, with the sand and the pebbles and the wind. "Yes, I do"

"Then let her try. Let both of you try" Scorpia states and she sounds *proud.* **"Trust Adora to love you and let her trust you to love her back"**

Tears gather and fall down again. Catra doesn't answer anymore but she is listening, in that little spot before the sea, Catra listens.

"Stop believing that you don't deserve to be happy, wildcat, and just *live* "

–

The sun is high above the sky when Catra hears the door opening and closing behind her. Adora's steps are muted over the white wood of the porch, silent as she approaches Catra and sits carefully next to her. Adora doesn't call Catra's name or try to start a conversation. She just sits there, looking at the sea in front of them, expanding like a second sky at their feet.

Catra shifts, slowly uncurling her hands from around her knees, lowering it down so she can take Adora's hands between hers, lacing their fingers together, still not looking at Adora.

She can feel Adora sigh next to her, the fine hair on her arms rising on point with a sudden shiver. Catra clenches her teeth, fighting to relax her jaw enough so she can speak, eyes locked in the soft waves of the sea.

"Do First Ones-? Umm" Catra struggles with her words, heat crawling on her cheeks, but keeps going. "Do First Ones kiss like humans do? Like- us?" Catra finally manages to say, dragging the words in her embarrassment.

Adora doesn't answer, Catra doesn't turn. The silence extends for a while, so long Catra starts to sweat, worried she has said something wrong, something that will inevitably push Adora away. *Trust Adora to love you* , Scorpia had said, so Catra does.

"Adora-? Oh" Adora is leaning towards her, searching for her eyes, looking at Catra through her white eyelashes with an indescribable expression on her face.

Adora closes the small inches that separates them, rubbing her cheek softly, tenderly but thoroughly against hers a couple of times, over her cheekbones and temples, her cold nose brushing the skin of her ear and neck.

Too soon, Adora turns away, looking back at Catra with eyes charged with the same feeling that was there yesterday.

"Is that-" *fuck* . Catra licks her lips, gulping. Her entire body is trembling, a cord about to snap. "Is that what a kiss is? For you?"

Adora smiles, lovingly, nodding at Catra.

"Oh" Catra mutters, biting on her lip. She can feel her skin tingling where Adora *kissed* her. "You- um. You greet me like this every day"

Adora takes her hand away and Catra almost regrets having said anything at all and the loss of her touch. " *I do* "

God. "Okay"

Adora smile widens. " *Alright* "

Catra knows she is blushing furiously but she can't help herself. Quite the contrary, Adora seems to be drawn by it, a snowflake driven to the fire when her cold hand cradles Catra's skin, chasing the heat of her blush as if it was the loveliest thing Adora had ever encountered, on this land or in the other.

"What is a 'mate'?" Catra asks again, this time, in a hoarse whisper. Adora's eyebrows flutter in swift confusion but she seems to understand what Catra is asking soon enough, nodding in understanding. After all, Catra wants, no, needs to be sure.

" *A mate is- a mate is a best friend"* Ador starts, her eyes reflecting the light of the sun. " *A companion, a lover"* both Catra and Adora flush a deep shade of red. Adora keeps going, " *but also much more"*

"How so?"

" *We believe our mates share our souls"* Adora states, face serious. Catra's heartbeat flares inside her chest. " *Mates, for us, are for forever. They are the anchor of our lives, what gives us a reason"*

Catra sucks on her bottom lip, "A reason for what?"

" *Living"* Adora's hands slow for a second, signing every word as if she wanted for them to carve themselves inside Catra's memory. They will no matter what. " *A reason to stay."*

Catra digs the nails of her left hand in the hard wood below her. Even after everything, she feels like they are reaching some kind of peak right now, the last drop of a rainstorm long ago prophesied. Adora raises her hand, points at herself, crosses her arms over her chest, points at Catra and steps into the rain.

"I love you " Catra inhales sharply, voice dying in her throat. " *In the way First Ones do, In the way you describe it on your pages. I love you that way. In every way* ."

Catra hiccups around a sob, new found tears sliding down her jaw. She doesn't clean them or fight them back, she lets them run free. Adora cradles her cheek, thumbing the errand tears away.

"How can you be so sure?" Catra questions in a voice barely above a whisper. "How can you know that I'm - *that* , for you?"

Adora's lips twitch into a melancholic smile. She takes Catra's hand, pulling from it gently, placing it over the skin of her own neck and collarbones. Here, Catra can feel the flutter of Adora's heart just below her fingertips, speeding up at her touch.

" *Because I can feel you, Catra. I can feel you in every cell of my body, in my blood. I felt you on my skin long before I found you. I think maybe that was the reason I was always so fascinated by the human world, because I was looking for you."*

And isn't that the truth? That maybe there was a reason beyond escaping for Catra to move into a house next to the sea, even when the water scares her. Maybe there is a reason why her

grandmother found Adora, years and years ago. Maybe there is a reason why Catra was awake that night.

Catra doesn't believe in destiny but, for one second, she dares to *hope* .

Adora stops, thinking something over, a sparkle of something beautiful shining in her eyes when she signs again. " *It doesn't really matter, if sharing our souls is true or not. I've already given you mine, completely.* "

And Catra believes her, she *believes* her, deep inside her bones and her heart and she knows her soul isn't inside her body anymore, that she also gave it to Adora, fully, from the very first moment they locked eyes in the rocks.

Catra exhales, broken and shaken, whispers in a hoarse murmur, and steps into the rain with Adora, "I love you, so much"

Adora melts around her and it's until then that Catra realizes how tense she was holding herself, nervous that Catra would, not reject her, but push her away, and still patient and caring above all.

Catra leans her forehead against Adora's jaw, sighing deeply, finally allowing herself to be cradled inside Adora's love. Around them, spots of sand float like fireflies, golden by the sun.



"You look happy"

Catra's voice is raspy, low and heavy with the weight of her emotions and the exhaustion. Adora knows she didn't sleep at all. She could see it in the dark circles around her precious eyes and the tired flop of her shoulders. But she is also almost vibrating in Adora's hands, her heartbeat running as fast as a storm against the ocean and there is a perpetual pink blush in her cheeks, making her freckles look like tiny sea glasses over dark sand.

"I am happy" Adora agrees because she is. Her chest feels like it can't contain the size of her heart anymore, barely managing to keep the beating organ inside her ribs. It's always been like this, since the first moment she saw Catra in the shore, soaked from head to toe and speechless, to now, with Catra sitting over the counter of the kitchen, her legs wrapped around Adora's waist, face red and eyes bright. She is running her fingers through Adora's hair, gently rubbing spirals down her scalp,

"Why?" Catra asks, her eyebrows twitching in that nervous habit Adora knows so well. She is a little bit more confident of touching Adora now than a few hours earlier, on that moment in front of the sea, but she still looks nervous, trembling just a little when Adora leans her cheek against the heel of her palm.

" *You are precious,* " Adora explains, simply. Loving Catra is so easy. Like swimming. " *And I love you* "

Adora loves saying it, loves Catra's expression when she does. Her pupils dilate completely, black overcoming the blue and amber, The dark skin of her cheeks heats up, reaching her neck and ears. All her body tenses and relaxes at the same time. Every time, Catra looks like she is about to cry and every time, she looks like she is about to laugh.

Adora admires this side of Catra, profoundly. This capacity she has to love so big, so honestly, so open and sincere and still, she thinks she doesn't love hard enough. Adora admires Catra's passion and stubbornness to survive, to want to live almost out of spite and also almost for herself too. She doesn't listen to anyone, and doesn't let anybody tell her what to do and Adora knows just how deep her hurt goes and she still keeps going.

Adora *loves* her.

" *It feels good, saying that. I love you* " Adora signs, staring at Catra's beautiful face. " *I love you* "

Catra lowers her head and catches Adora's lips between hers, exhaling in Adora's mouth, shaken by the honesty in her words. Adora sighs heavily, basking in the fire that lives in Catra's tongue. Catra kisses just as she loves, with everything she has.

Adora digs her hands on the divots of Catra's hips, tugging her closer to her from where she is nestled between Catra's legs. Catra's breathe hitches, leaning back just enough so she can whisper.

"I really need a- *oh,"* Catra's voice dies in her throat when Adora surges forward again, licking the roof of her mouth with her tongue.

This is something Adora loves about being a human, being able to *touch* Catra, to kiss her, run the flat of her tongue over the curve of her neck and nip into it, blooming violets into her skin. No sharp teeth that could rip her flesh, no steel claws that could tear her in too. Just softness and tenderness and heat against her cold skin, the drag of Catra's nails over the back of her neck, pulling Adora back into her mouth.

"I really need to take a shower," Catra is able to mumble between kisses, lips red and wet, swollen by the intensity of their kisses. Catra presses her thumb over Adora's kiss bitten lips, pupils blown wide. Adora grunts, aching to taste her in her mouth again which only earns a chuckle and a roll of Catra's eyes, fond. "I'm gross"

"Mmm," Adora hums. Taking Catra's chin between her fingers, gently rubbing her bottom lip from where she has bitten into it with her front teeth. Adora looks eyes with Catra's, purposefully bringing them slowly closer, giving Catra time in case she wants to pull away or speak again. She doesn't.

Adora is convinced her mouth has been made to cradle Catra's lips perfectly between hers. Catra sighs, the air from her lungs caressing gently into the skin of Adora's cheek. They curl against each other, Catra wraps her arms around Adora's neck as the master runs her hands under the hem of her shirt, roaming her hands across the warmth expanse of Catra's back, feeling the creases and depth of her spine with her fingers.

Somewhere deep inside her chest, Adora feels a rumble starting to pick up, expanding over her entire body. Catra gasps, smiling around Adora's lips, delighted. Adora presses herself closer to her, synchronized to the beating of Catra's heartbeat until another sound starts to echo inside the room. Adora frowns lightly, blinking in sudden confusion when she notices the rumble is actually herself. She is *singing,* her siren voice filling the house completely.

Panic flares inside Adora when she notices it. She turns back almost sharply so she can see Catra's face, studying it up close. But she doesn't seem bothered by it or in pain, and she definitely isn't going insane as a siren's voice can do to a human. Quite the contrary, Catra looks soft, the softest Adora has ever seen her, relaxed and free. Her eyes are still closed, smiling and giggling against Adora's mouth caressing the angle of her jaw with loving fingers.

"I can hear you singing, mi amor"

Mi amor.

My love.

Oh.

Adora's singing just grows louder, ringing like a thousand bells or ethereal trumpets, making every single glass and crystal tremble with its intensity. Catra doesn't even seem to notice it. She nuzzles her nose in the space between Adora's nose bridge and her cheek and Adora's heart swells when she understands Catra is giving her a siren's kiss, tiny and hesitant, almost as if Catra was nervous of somehow doing it wrong.

Adora keeps singing, completely unbothered by it. She presses tiny, butterfly-like kisses all over Catra's face, scattering over her skin like tiny worships, nuzzling in Catra's temples with the utmost tenderness. Catra's laughter grows louder, huffing against the side of Adora's cheek, palming her softly in the shoulder to call for her attention.

"Shower" Catra insists, not making a real effort to turn away.

" *Your sandwich first,"* Adora throws back, signaling at the sad turkey sandwich, long forgotten over the counter after Adora caught Catra in her arms, unable to *not* kiss her for more than a few minutes at a time.

Catra rolls her eyes fondly, stretching over the counter to grasp the plate, chewing on the sandwich with a proud little smile and a sneaky arched eyebrow towards Adora, bread crumbles smearing over her lips and cheeks.

Adora smiles and paints invisible spirals with her fingers over Catra's cheekbones, brushing her curls behind her ears, watching her eat in peace.

Adora is made of seafoam, sand and coral.

Adora is made of sea glass, cold water and salt.

Adora is made of sun and pearls and abyss's darkness.

Adora is made of Catra's breath and the heat of her skin and the wetness of her tears.

Adora is made of something holy.

Adora is made of love.

–

Catra steps out of the bathroom with muted steps, toweling the rest of the drops from her hair and leaving the towel over the chair of the desk with a shrug. Her hair almost looks bigger like this, thick curls bouncing over her shoulders and down her back, dripping over the fabric of her bathrobe. The latter is carelessly wrapped around her body, the lace that keeps it together knotted loosely over Catra's waist.

Adora stares at her from her spot in front of the unmade bed, frozen in the middle of preparing the room so they could go back to sleep. Adora gulps, gazing at her when Catra walks closer. The bathrobe is slightly open over Catra's chest, letting see through the delicate swell of the side of her breast, dark skin scattered with freckles even there.

Adora feels a buzz inside her ears and looks up, stumbling against the brightness of Catra's eyes, buried deep inside hers. Catra's cheeks are flushed in a dark shade of red and there is a glim inside the corner of eyes and the dimple on her mouth, but her expression is serious, pensive. Shame crawls down Adora's spine, stepping back from where she is only to trip against the edge of the bed behind her. Catra's mouth twitches into an almost displeased frown, stepping forward until she is almost pressed completely against Adora.

Adora searches in Catra's eyes for any sign that she might not want it at all, but the only thing she can find there is a soft determination, shadowed by a spark of shared shyness. Catra exhales, outstretching her hands until she can place them over Adora's, uncurling her fingers from the tight balls she had clenched them into. Catra rubs her fingertips over Adora's knuckles, pulling from their joined hands until she can place them over the knot of the bathrobe, letting her hands fall to the sides right after.

It's an open invitation, if Adora wants to.

Adora wants to.

Adora holds her breath, tangling the ribbon between her long fingers and pulling. Adora doesn't mind nudity, it's not something foreign to her. After all she never considered it from the same point humans do, clattered in her scales and her skin. But it is different for mortals. It's different for Catra. This is so much trust, this is all of Catra's trust handed on her inhuman hands, freely. So, Adora's hands don't tremble, even if her breath does, and she pulls until the ribbon falls away and the bathrobe opens wordlessly.

The silk fabric slips down Catra's right shoulder, opening almost slowly, revealing gentle skin and warmness. Catra's breasts are shaped like raindrops, small and perked up against the chill air inside the bedroom. Her nipples are brown, goosebumps raised on her skin under Adora's gaze. Adora gulps, running her own trembling hands over Catra's shoulders and down the sharp edges of her shoulder blades, letting the robe fall into the ground with a quiet flop.

Adora's hands lower even more, wrapping themselves around the curve of Catra's waist and making their home there. Adora sighs, giving the last step closer so she can rest her cheek over Catra's damp hair, closing her eyes as she feels the natural warmth of the woman she loves slipping into her cold skin and very bones.

She can feel Catra humming against the curve of her collarbones and the run of her calloused fingers when they fly over the skin of her chest, close but not enough to touch her, until she reaches the thin straps of the short silk nightgown Adora is using, hooking her thumbs on them and pulling down softly. The nightgown falls at Adora's feet in a pool of blue silk, forgotten into the wood tiles. Catra's fingers roam on Adora's body, gently, too gently, almost as if she was scared that if she touches Adora, she will disappear. Adora hums over the crown of her hair, running her cold lips over the curve of Catra's ears, encouraging. She can feel Catra shivering against her until her hands finally press against Adora's body, trembling but sure. Catra's palms cup the swell of Adora's breasts, almost kneading on them gently with her fingertips, brushing reverently across the skin under them. Her slightly sharp nails run down Adora's abdomen, rising pink lines in her pale skin until she reaches the sharp edge of her hip bones, pressing the heel of her hands in the skin there in gentle circles.

Adora shutters with the sudden feeling, warmth pooling from her naturally cold body like an explosion. Her skin pulls and breaks, dozens of tiny scales sprouting from the skin of her arms, back, face, neck and even the length of her legs, deep blue under the darkness of the room. Adora flushes, suddenly self conscious, but Catra just hums under her breath, a small smile spreading on her lips from where she has buried her face in the angle of Adora's neck. Catra runs her hands over the rows of scales, feeling their sharp edge with her finger, smothering them over Adora's skin with a caress. Then she lowers both of her hands back down, circling Adora so her palms are firmly pressed over the expansion of Adora's back, holding them both together inside their embrace, naked skin against each other.

They remain like this for long minutes, until the sun is lower in the sky and Catra's hair has started to dry. At some point they part from each other, reluctantly, just enough so they can kiss each other swiftly before climbing into the clean sheets of the bed. Catra crawls over the sheets first, resting her back over the crumpled pillows, legs wobbling. Her foot catches into one of the tangled blankets and she trips over the bed, stumbling over the mattress with an unflattering huff. Adora giggles and Catra chuckles with her, rolling her eyes and making an impatient sign with her hands. *Come closer. Adora* climbs after Catra, hovering over her ankles for a moment, pupils blown wide with the sudden view.

With the stumble, Catra's legs have fallen open over the mattress, revealing a mound of tightly curled dark hair right below her navel and the soft expanse of her tights. Adora's body moves out of sheer impulse, cooed forward by the pink dusted in Catra's cheeks and the golden light born from her own chest. She crawls over Catra's legs on her hands and knees, pulled by something invisible until she stops right over the point where Catra's hips meet her lean legs. Adora feels like the mortal now, trapped by a siren's song in the middle of a storm that is Catra's body and love. Adora has always loved storms.

Adora lowers down, nuzzling her nose past the soft curls, her scaled cheek brushing against the skin of Catra's tight. Catra is a little bit different to Adora's human body here, but she is beautiful. So beautiful here too, skin puffy and slightly pink, coated in the gentlest layer of

damp, shivering just a little under Adora's burning gaze and Adora can feel the way Catra's breath hitches in her throat, clinging to the bedsheets around them tight between her fists.

Adora looks at Catra through her white eyelashes, blindly pressing a fluttering kiss in the skin right between Catra's middle and her tight, silently seeking for Catra's permission. Catra sucks her breath, biting hard into her lip and gives a small, swift nod, her chest, face and neck painted in red.

Adora closes her eyes, smiling tiny and nervous at her, leaning until her lips press against Catra's closed soft labia in a, somehow, still chaste kiss.

Catra shivers from head to toe, eyes fogged for a second through the intimacy of it all, never looking away from Adora's face. Adora smiles, overjoyed, and dives again, peppering another small kiss this time right over the warm skin around Catra's entrance, in the closed lips that flutter just a little under her touch, and then another one, this time in the hooded pearl right above, small and almost invisible to the eyes. Adora sighs and straightens up again, resuming her travel above Catra's body with gentle eyes, scattering human and siren kisses over her warm skin.

Adora knows about sex, she knows what it is for First Ones and she supposes it can't be so different for humans. But this is not about that. Not tonight. This is about the feeling of Catra's lean body against hers, all her barriers down, and in return, Adora's bare body against her too, free of fear.

When Adora is close enough, Catra brings her hands at either side of her face, pulling her towards her until their mouths meet in the middle, opening against each other into a languid, heated kiss. Catra's heart is the fastest Adora has ever heard, so fast Adora curls the palm of her hand over Catra's chest, cradling the space right above the vital organ like petals to a flower. Adora licks the skin of Catra's upper lip swiftly, making a delighted sound with her throat. Adora loves kissing Catra, in any way or form.

She nestles her face into the angle of Catra's neck, Adora's long body accommodating around Catra's, wrapping her arms around her waist until she is laying face down over her heated body. Their breasts press together, hips meeting, the skin of Catra's tight brushing and resting between Adora's own intimacy. Adora hears Catra hold her breath and exhale a few times, chest tensing and relaxing immediately after until her arms come up, wrapping around Adora's back and shoulders, holding her close to her.

"I love you," Catra whispers over Adora's hair, like a secret. Her voice is thick, heavy with sleep and sweet like honey with emotions, her body drowsy and slack with exhaustion. Adora wants to answer back, but that would need for her to untangle from Catra's arms and that's just not acceptable for now. So, instead, she hums under her breath, a tender song without words that she knows lulls Catra into calm.

They don't sleep immediately, tangled with each other like this for hours to end until the cadence of Catra's breathing evens and Adora's singing drifts off into a peaceful dream. Like this, ear pressed against Catra's chest, her heartbeat on her cheek, it almost feels like the ocean cradling Adora back home.

It feels better.

End of chapter III

She just pulls me to her again, and eventually my thoughts stop their spinning, my breathing slows, and eventually I feel like myself again.

– **Misa Sugiura** , *Love and Other Natural Disasters*

Chapter End Notes

...and they were roommates

AND LOVERS

Thank you so much to all of you who have been following the story and being so patient with each chapter. I really hope you like this chapter. I know is a long one but didn't want to break it in two chapters so 35k words it is! Your constant support means the world to me, thank you to everyone that has read, commented, bookmarked, recommended and liked this little story so far. I love you all :)

Extras:

yfílios - earth, land
latrévei - adore, adoring
Adora's and Adam's name in First One is inspired by their rough translations in Greek

The Candles Procession, flower altars and all that involve is strongly based in Día de los Muertos (Day of the death) which takes place from the 1st to the 2nd of November

I carve a poem off her breath [sea foam against rain]

Chapter Summary

> "It feels good. It feels right" Catra thinks, who had never known this before. "It feels like love"

Chapter Notes

> The girls finally have the seggs.
> That's it.
> There is no lore on this chapter.
> They just make love and kiss
> Actually, it could be considered a bonus chapter, after the long hiatus. Like those beach episodes in animes just that this is winter and the have seggs.
> You can jump this chapter it you don't feel comfortable, lore with come back on the next :3
> Love u ♡

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter IV. I carve a poem off her breath [sea foam against rain]

Her mouth was warm and soft and sweet, and in the brief moment when her lips pressed against my own, my heart leaped with perfect understanding, perfect recognition. It melted with the heat of her, was sealed under a new covenant.

– **Hannah Kent** , *Devotion*



Intimacy with Adora is… a thing. A thing that is happening to Catra. One of the greatest things that has ever happened to her. That's it.

It's not sexual, even if there *is* nudity sometimes involved and every single nerve in Catra's body explodes when Adora touches her. It's *sweet,* caring, learning each other in the long nights and quiet mornings where they lay together in bed, blankets pulled aside, the weight of Adora's naked body nestled between her legs as the latter cradles Catra's breasts and hips and belly and skin in her palms, worshiping it with kisses and the cold skin of her lips. Catra breathes deep every time, eyes focused on the side of Adora's beautiful profile, running her

trembling fingers through her hair. This has never particularly turned her on, but the goddess above, Catra is, quite honestly, going a little bit insane.

It had been more nerve wracking for Catra, and even that was an understatement, given how nervous to let go Adora was at the beginning, letting herself be vulnerable under Catra´s touch after the abuse she had gone through. But they were learning together, Adora to let go, Catra to accept the love Adora was giving her, embrace it and give it in return. Running her fingers through the length of Adora's legs, adorned with scales that Catra liked to caress. Or pressing her lips over the paler spots of skin that lived in the back of Adora's neck and the low of her back, it was a revolution inside her chest. This was all so new to Catra, learning someone else like this. She had never had this with anyone before, not like this, much less the tenderness, the open flesh without waiting to advance into *something* else. But here she is and now Catra knows exactly how many golden freckles are scattered in Adora's nose, she know the mole that has make its home in the side of Adora's hip and the white stretch lines in her thighs, the curve of her feet and small swirl of baby hair right above her ears.

Somehow, it does feel like a preamble. A lesson for both of them before diving into something deeper. Giving each other the trust they need from the other before giving all of them to each other. Somehow, when Adora slips behind her in the shower, wrapping her arms around Catra's waist and resting her cheek on her back, or when Catra blinks awake by the feeling of her intimacy brushing the skin of Adora's belly from where the latter has tangled them into an embrace during the night, or when Adora looks the *entirety* of her with huge, warm eyes and peace in her heart, Catra thinks when they do step forward it will be as easy as breathing or coming home to an old friend. Tender, expected, fulfilling.

As Catra stated, she is going insane.

She isn't used to this, she doesn't know what to do with it. Cradle it in her arms and let her envelop her completely, washing all the pain and fear from the past away, letting her drown and also lifting her above her waves, merciless and caring and devastating like the ocean that washes at their door.

Catra didn't know love was supposed to be like this. All her life, she learned and thought that love was something that hurt, sharp and cutting, something that was supposed to make her bleed to be worth it, to deserve it. Catra didn't know love was supposed to be… peaceful.

And so, slowly, little bit little, Catra stops running and starts to heal.

The air is very cold as they hop off the pick-up. It's been over two months since the Samhain festival and their tearful confession in front of the fireplace. Winter has now rolled fully over Salineas, covering everything in a thick fog and a pale blue like tint. It rained the entire day yesterday so it shouldn't take long for snow to start falling over the town.

The parking lot of the Marine Biology Center is empty except for their own car. Bow had insisted for literal weeks until Catra gave up and accepted to finally go visit the place. It could be because she was tired of his constant nagging but the truth was that she couldn't deny anything to Adora when the latter looked at her with *those* eyes and asked her to go too.

Catra grunts against the freezing breeze, bumping her shoulder against Adora's who is busy staring at the huge buildings with wide, silver eyes. There is a blush in her nose and cheek from the cold and her mouth is agape with wonder, studying the glass windows with a new interest. She is so beautiful it tears Catra´s insides everytime she looks at her, guilt and love and want, messing with her emotions.

Adora hasn't asked or talked about her skin in months, and Catra hasn't got the guts to tell her she might never find it, might never be able to choose to go home.

Adora bumps her forehead against Catra´s temple, coaxing her back into reality softly. When Catra turns to look at her she is met with Adora´s patient blue eyes, staring at her with both tenderness and understanding. By this point, she has come to identify Catra´s sudden silences, when her head gets the best of herself and she goes quiet around Adora. Sometimes Adora lets her be, content in wrapping herself around Catra´s form and hum under her breath until Catra comes back. Other times, she looks for Catra inside her own head, bringing her back from the dark spirals of her mind. And even without a human voice, Adora has found a way to speak through the silence, finding Catra again.

Catra blinks up at Adora, slowly, a habit she thinks she got from being on her own with Melog for way too long. Adora beams at her, a bright and honest smile making its way on her mouth. Catra breathes through her teeth, looking away from Adora´s handsome face and to the huge building again. If she stares at her for long Catra might just cry.

Adora makes another sound with her throat, this time nuzzling her nose and cheek against the cold skin of Catra´s neck, rising goosebumps there. Catra tries to suppress a shiver without much luck, raising her hand to pat softly at Adora´s temples, lacing her fingers with the buttersoft strands of hair there.

“I´m here,” Catra assures her in a whisper, breathing the salt and coconut from her hair. Adora gives a pleased hum, placing a small kiss on the angle of Catra´s neck, tender enough that is almost a whisper. Catra wants to say something else, probably hurrying them both inside the building and away from the cold, but it's cut short by another swift kiss, this one higher over the column of her neck, open mouthed and cold. Catra sucks a breath, a shiver running from head to toe through her body. “Adora”

Adora answers with a low grunt, grave enough that makes Catra´s heart give a jump down her belly and then want to burst through her mouth. Adora can hear the increasing beating of Catra´s heart and just seems to fuel her further, running her sharp teeth above the creases of Catra´s throat until she reaches her jaw, nipping in the skin there purposely. Catra knows Adora is very aware of what she is doing, after months on land, she is not ignorant anymore towards certain things, especially things like this. They had a conversation about this already and yet here they are because even if Adora is aware she just doesn´t care, and honestly, Catra doesn´t care either.

One of Adora´s long hands roams up, cradling Catra´s face inside her palm. She grips Catra´s chin with her thumb and index, keeping her place when her mouth runs from her jaw to her lips, sliding them together. Adora kisses Catra long, wet and *hot* , all knowing tongue against the roof of her mouth and teeth in her lips. Catra feels lightheaded, almost dizzy when Adora

starts to walk them both backwards until Catra´s entire back and head is pressed against the closed door of the car, leaning over her in all her tall, mythic self.

Catra gives a small squeal, squeaky and quite frankly humiliating if it wasn´t for Adorás fingers on her waist and her other hand flat over Catra´s waist, sneaky fingers making their way under the fabric of Catra´s wool sweater. Catra gives a jolt at the touch of her fingers over her skin, accidentally biting down Adora´s tongue with her front teeth. She is about to lean apart and apologize when Adora straight up growls, leaning over Catra´s front body and kissing her deeper until all the air is basically gone from her lungs, replaced by Adora´s sweet breath.

This is another thing Catra has come to learn about Adora. She is bolder. Carefree. Rebellious. And so very hot.

Catra is almost about to pull from Adora´s arms and clothes and back into the car, completely forgetting that they are in a public, if empty, parking lot, when the sound of a throat hawking brings her back into reality suddenly. Catra tears herself away from Adora´s face, still searching for her and uncaring of the apparent presence of a third person besides them, turning to look into Bow´s frame.

“I´m sorry! I´m sorry!” He exclaims, wrinkling his nose. He has a hand covering his eyes and it's looking away, shaking his hand in front of him as he apologizes loudly, tripping with his own words as he tries very hard not to look. “I saw your car through the window and came looking for you when you didn´t walk inside.”

Catra makes a noise, between humiliation and anger, pushing Adora softly off her. Adora shakes her head, wrapping her arms around Catra´s lean waist tightly and hiding her face on the curve of her shoulder, purposely not moving. Bow risks a swift look towards them and then looks away quickly again, trying to hide an amused smile and failing miserably,

Catra grunts again, kicking Adora harshly on the shin and pushing her away until the latter huffs in annoyance and let´s her go, pouting the entire time. Catra would feel bad, but Adora is a siren and a big girl, she´ll survive.

“We were just about to walk inside,” Catra says, grimacing at the hoarse tone of her voice when she speaks. Her tongue tastes of the cherry chapstick Adora likes to apply and that she definitely tried to bite into when she didn´t know what it was in the first place.

“Sure, sure, sure,” Bow agrees quickly, turning on his ankles and towards the door of the building. He is still smirking, the bastard. “I´ll go ahead and turn on the lights for you. We are in maintenance so you´ll have the entire place for you two.” He starts walking and then another thought seems to cross his mind, turning his head back just enough that he is talking at them without seeing them yet. “Um, there are people working inside though, so, please try to not… you know… ? I mean, there are corners on the corridors …”

“Thank you, Arrows,” Catra cuts him, loud and sharp, her eye twitching. Bow is a good guy but he is also quite the runny mouth with his girlfriend and Catra is not looking up for that. Bow returns the smile, cheeky and a little bit mischievous and, oh, he is absolutely going to tell Sparkles and she will never let Catra live it down.

Catra snaps her eyes back at Adora the second he crosses the frame of the door, accusatory gaze met with Adora´s blown up pupils and devious smile. She knows what she did and doesn´t regret it a single bit. Catra gapes at her, both parts frustrated beyond mind and turned on under Adora´s mischievous eyes. She likes this side of Adora, Catra can´t deny it, this side that is free and uncaring and even challenging towards life, a force of nature lashing against the world. It makes Catra´s heart swell and her legs to cross.

“ *Come on,* ” Adora signs, all the bits smug but with the excitement of seeing the inside of the aquarium back in full force. She slips her arm across Catra´s, linking their elbows together. They walk towards the entrance with lifted spirits, eyeing the blue led lights framing it with curious eyes. Before the darkness can cover her movements, however, Adora nudges Catra again, signing in front of her face. “ *I´ll kiss you senseless when they don´t see us.”*

Catra´s outraged squeal is drowned by the recorded audio of a presenter, welcoming them inside the Biology´s Center aquarium. They cross through a relatively long dark corridor, lightened up only by the dim leds until it reaches the end and they walk inside the building finally, opening in front of them completely. All the air is expelled from Catra´s lungs, this time for a very different reason than before. For a second, she feels dizzy, the floor pulled off her feet, making her feel as if she was suspended inside water, too heavy and dark for her to move anywhere. Is a sentiment as strong as the pull of the ocean beyond her home and the pull of Adora´s arms above their bed. It is as beautiful as it is terrifying and now Catra understands why Sparkles was bothering so much on coming around and seeing the aquarium from the inside.

The building is built as a giant bubble, thick glass covering the walls, the nonexistent ceilings, even the floor which, even if they don´t have water below, have beautiful lights that make you feel as if you were walking over water or swimming inside of it. Catra gasps, she can´t avoid it, holding Adora´s hand between hers almost as a second nature, roaming her eyes up and down through the room. There is water above them, surrounding them, dark blue and natural light. Thousands of fishes swim all around them, from the littlest to the biggest, dull to bright colors, to small sharks and stingrays, stopping just for a second to throw a glance at them and then looking away, going on with their ways.

Catra blinks at the big space around them, only coming off her drowsiness when Adora's hand tightens around hers. Her eyes are locked to the glass ceiling, watching the fish and animals swim by calmingly. She looks wonderful and, under the violet light that shimmers through the water and against her face, she looks every bit what she is, ethereal and beautiful and almost, just almost untouchable. Catra wonders if this is what she looks like, underwater and free, wrapped in her skin and so, so alive. Somehow Catra knows this doesn't even come close to it, to what Adora truly is. Except in the parts where she isn't, in the skin that brushes against Catra's, palm against palm and the rise and fall of her shoulders under the white sweatshirt, and the cherry flavor of her lips where she kissed Catra all the way here.

Catra presses her lips together and, slowly, let's go off Adora's hand, letting hers fall loosely to her side. Adora shakes off her dreamy state immediately, turning her eyes wide and slightly alarmed to Catra's, confusion written all over her face at the lack of touch. It's kind of adorable, Catra thinks, smiling softly at her.

"Go see them," Catra assures her in a whisper. She doesn't dare to speak louder. When Adora doesn't move a muscle, Catra huffs, nudging her with her hip and pointing at the glass with her chin. "Go on. I'll be right behind you."

Adora blinks, slow almost in the way Melog blinks at both of them when they want to assure them they trust them, and then turns around on her place, unsure to even know where to go first. She finally starts walking forward, little by little, the soles of her shoes making no sound at all over the polished floor, making her way to the seawater around them and further away from Catra.

Adora walks around the aquarium like a spirit, sauntering from one side to the other, her hair golden over her shoulder and waist narrow. Somehow, Catra thinks the animals follow each of her movements, following her steps as she makes her way down the serpent corridors with her long hand pressed over the glass.

Catra follows her slowly during long minutes that turn into silent hours, hands tucked inside her pockets. Her palms prickle with the need to be holding Adora's again but she doesn't make a move to do it. In fact, Catra only stops walking when Adora does, her palm pressed firmly over the thick glass. There are a bunch of colorful big fishes right on the other side,staring at Adora with their big eyes. There is so much undescriptible beauty around them all that Catra is able to see is Adora.

“Are you okay?” Catra asks, rubbing her upper arm with her palm. Adora's eyes are very bright, not even blinking as she stares at the glass and dark as voids, black overcoming the white and making the blue shimmer like coral. She stares and stares until her shoulders rise again and Catra notices she wasn't even breathing at all.

“I'm just making sure they are happy” Adora signs loosely, still looking beyond the glass and far away from Catra. Catra gulps, her throat is dry like sandpaper and her lips feel chapped from where she has been biting on them but she can't keep her own curiosity at bay.

“You can undertand them?”

“ *Sensations”* Adora looks all around them, the walls and the crystal ceiling, following the free movement of the animals with her long fingers, barely even touching anything at all. *“They are recues, all of them. Some of them will be here for the rest of their life"* Adora's hands are slow when she signs, deliberated, lost inside her own head.

"It's not safe for them out there anymore. Humans' greed knows no limit"

Those last words make Catra's gut shrink inside themselves. She feels her stomach turn upside down and pull, a wave of nausea hitting her straight into the face. She is halfway towards Adora's spot but stops, cold on her feet.

Catra loves Adora so fucking much but she also knows her own guilt will swallow her, swallow them both, whole sooner or later. Catra doesn't know how much she will be able to live like this.

"I'm sorry" Catra blurts out beyond her own good judgment. Adora turns her beautiful eyes towards Catra, clearly surprised by the outburst. It's not the first - it won't be the last - Catra has had a breakdown in front of Adora . It still shames Catra every time and yet every time she isn't able to help herself, choking on her own undeserving guilt.

"I wish you weren't trapped in here, Adora. I'm so sorry, and-" Catra wets her bottom lip, knees shaking. The aquarium is suddenly too little to hold Catra, to close up around her. Suddenly, Catra is the one trapped inside a crystal box, head under the water. "Your skin-"

"Shh," Adora surges forward, pressing the pads of her fingers, the same she had just been pressing against the glass, over Catra's lips, shushing her softly. She waits, and waits, wrapped around Catra but never drowning her, until Catra's breath steadies and her heartbeat lowers into calm. " *I love you"*

Catra's breathing shutters, tiny like a leaf, a shiver running through her entire back. "I love you too, 'Dora, so much."

Adora's eyes soften, shimmering blue into gentle silver, the corners wrinkling kindly, staring at Catra in that way that makes the little hairs of her nape stand. Adora leans, slow enough that Catra could easily turn away if she felt like it - she doesn't - lowering in all her height until her cheek is pressed right above Catra's, cold skin against lukewarm, rubbing their faces together once, twice into what Catra has come to learn is another kind of kiss. Somehow, Catra kind of likes these kisses much better. Not because she doesn't love or crave *other* kinds of kisses, but, like their intimacy, these ones feel more private, more like a secret shared between them only. A meaning only them get to know in the entire little piece of their universe.

Adora's lips travel above her cheekbone, across the feather shift eyelashes of Catra's amber eye and over the arc of her eyebrows, pressing tiny kisses on her skin all the way until every nerve ending on Catra's body is singing. She is kind of aware that there are cameras around them, Bow *told* them there were, but she can't find it on herself to care much at all.

Adora's hand travel too, from being placed to either side of her neck, down to the collar of Catra's sweater, pushing past the fabric until her long finger run over heated freckled skin, drawing pink lines with her nails down Catra's upper back.

"Don't you want to see more?" Catra asks, half between a shiver and all the way in a long gasp, fighting hard to keep her eyes from rolling inside their sockets and melting into water between Adora's arms.

Adora snickers, too sweet and tender to be doing exactly what she knows she is doing, slowly and deliberately taking her hands away from Catra's body to sign.

" *I'd rather see you,"* she says, smirking, though the honesty is clear in her eyes. " *I only ever want to see you".*

Catra gulps, wetting her dry lips with the tip on her tongue. Adora follows the motion with her sharp eyes, pupils turning into slits in her eyes. There is something hanging over them today, heavy but not suffocating, sticky like honey and sharp and *hot.*

They've only been here for a couple of hours and they kind of promised Bow to have dinner with him and Sparkles later on the day but honestly, fuck it. Sparkles will never let her see the end of it but Bow will know to understand. Or at least Catra hopes so.

Adora nips suddenly on the side of Catra's neck, making her yelp in surprise. Adora is wearing a shit eating grin by the time she leans back, honey hair curling over the tip of her ears. She looks around them once more,glass walls, blue light and so much water it might just bend the building in half one day and, for the split of a.second, Catra thinks she can see something heavy cross Adora's eyes, like something overwhelming and exhausting. Like it's suddenly, too much for her too.

Healing is difficult, but they are getting there.

Catra laces their fingers together, long and perfect for each other, a movement made as a second thought, or even a second nature, cradling Adora inside her hold as much as she can. They are rushing across the corridors before any of them can realize they are doing it, feet mirroring each other as they pass room by room of water.

Somewhere in the end, Catra has the swift thought of sending Bow a message, quick and short and, hopefully, apologetic enough that he won't get offended for them leaving - he doesn't. He sends a little smiley face and a thumbs up and it kinds of feels like he was expecting it. Sometimes Catra wonders how much these people actually seem to know her. How much they actually seem to be friends and not just acquaintances -

Adora and Catra rush through the exit and back into the parking lot, into the cold breeze and the even colder concrete floor. It's raining, a quick and soft drizzle that doesn't even touch the floor. Small drops that are followed by even softer tears, white and unique and suddenly the drizzle turns into feather like snow. It almost doesn't look real, covering everything quickly as powdered sugar.

Adora looks up, into the sky, and smiles, stretching her hand upwards, almost as if she was trying to touch the heavy clouds with her finger. The snowflakes get stuck in her eyelashes and she giggles at the feeling of tiny kisses melting against her skin. She almost looks suspended in time, tan skin pink with the cold. She almost looks like a dream too, one of Catra's dreams brought to life by some god's breath.

They are walking under the drizzle and the snow and Catra will drive them back home and Adora will kiss her in the car. And the snow will fall. And life will go on.

Both have seen snow, Catra beyond the glass of her windows, crawled under the hardwood floor first and then sort blankets after. And Adora below the surface, a mist of cold.resting over her waters, making her claws go numb and her chest to burn with the cold burnt when she gets too close to the surface. But this is the first time Adora has seen it in her human form, so this is all new to her. It still numbs the tip of her fingers just as it did below the water but now it is different. Now she can actually touch it,.melting around her soft skin.

They sit in the front of the house, on the small steps that lead to the beach now covered in thick white snow, watching as the sea laps over the dark rocks and shimmers like a crystal

under the sun.

Adora is draped over Catra's lap, her back and head cradled over Catra's knees. Catra runs her fingers through Adora's loose hair, absently combing the ashed strands, brushing the slightly frozen strands from clogs of snow and ice. Her hair has gone darker the more she has spent on the surface, and her cheeks redder, slightly burnt by the cold the longer she refuses to spend outside in the winter.

Catra is hyper aware of Adora's eyes fixed on her face but her eyes stay towards the sea, freezing to the bone and, quite honestly, wishing she could go cuddle next to the fireplace, but too soft to move a single muscle.

"How long do First Ones live?" Catra asks at some point, lowering her eyes just so she can gaze at Adora's hands.

Adora's expression flickers for a moment from her enamored stare, regarding Catra carefully before answering. Her lips are a bit chapped by the sea breeze.

" *Way too long* "

The way she says it is somehow nostalgic, movements slow, like thinking and saying something one does not want to think about for too long. Catra runs her fingers over Adora's forehead this time, rubbing circles over the soft skin there. Adora stares at her from under her eyelashes, studying her face in the silence that stretches between them.

Adora loves her so much. It's ineffable and eternal and fated. Adora loves Catra so much it sometimes hurts because she doesn't know what to do with the amount of love pouring from her heart and into her ribcage and her bones. Adora loves her more than she has ever loved something else, more than the tide and the seafoam and the ocean depths. More than her skin. More than herself. She has never loved this way and never will again. She would gladly become seafoam for her.

Catra's expression is unreadable as she thinks and Adora loves every single line and freckle and mole and scar in her face. She has them all memorized by now because Adora loves each one of them.

"Will you come see me? When I'm old and gray?" Catra asks suddenly, frowning swiftly as if surprised by herself for asking in the first place. She sighs, white fog leaving her mouth and gives in, leaning against the wooded frame of the porch. "Will you come say goodbye?"

Adora frowns too, something heavy placing itself in her chest at the murmur of Catra's quietly unsure voice. She is trying to hide it but Adora can hear the tremble that lives there. Adora doesn't like this question, the meaning of it, so she tangles her hand with one of Catra's, bringing it close to her face to place a swift kiss over her cold palm before answering.
" *I'll always be with you, Catra"*

"And after? Where will you go after I'm-?" Catra cuts herself short, her nose wrinkling at her own words. "I want you to be happy"

"I'll go with you " Adora repeats, insisting, because she doesn't know how else to say it. How to explain it to Catra. Catra is smart, though, very smart, because her frown wrinkles and she looks down at Adora with an unsure look.

"What does that mean?" Adora presses her lips in a thin line, hesitating, which doesn't do wonders to Catra's crescent anxiety. "Adora?"

Adora straightens up from Catra's lap, which is a tremendous loss, shaking errand snowflakes from her hair with the movement. She searches for her lover's gaze, the pupils in her mismatched eyes tiny and alert. When she signs, Adora does it with purpose, making each movement deliberated slowly but sharp so Catra won't try and look away.

" *First Ones living hundreds of years- it's not a blessing Catra, at least not for me. It's a curse. We are alone, we are alone and see everything else die and rot and be reborn again but us* ." Catra's chest deflates, exhaling silently, but she nods, a tiny signal for Adora to keep going. " *But, things change when we find our mates, our lives mingle. Even the years we live are influenced by the life of our loved one. At least, that's what the few old First Ones I've met have told me, they live hundreds of lives together and then, when the time comes, leave together* "

Adora cradles Catra's face between her hands, pressing their foreheads together tight against each other. " *Firsts Ones die with their partners* " Adora signs when they part, *"If you die, I'll die with you, it's as simple as that"*

Catra's cheeks are spotted in red, either for the cold or for Adora's words, she is not sure, but the way her eyes swell into years leave no doubt at all.

"I don't want that" Catra says and it is broken, bien from within some kind of sadness Adora can't reach yet.

"I wouldn't want it any other way "

Catra leans before neither of them can say anything else, cradling Adora's face between her hands and kissing her, not swift nor playful like in the aquarium, but deep and slow and sugar heavy. Adora whimpers against Catra's mouth, breathing in the sweetness of her throat, cold breath and feverish skin.

Adora wraps her hands around either side of Catra's waist, pushing aside her sweater, just enough so she can touch the skin that lives there, shivering violently at the caress of her cold hand. Catra bites a whimper and then a moan, ripping her mouth off Adora's just so the last can latch into the skin of her cheeks and ear, drawing a line of kisses up and down her skin.

"Adora"

" **Catra** " Adora answers in kind, the only word in her mother tongue that she dares to speak out loud. Still, it always seems to turn something inside Catra because her entire body locks

and then melts, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck and then her fingers against the base of her nape and hair. Both somehow trying to bring her closer and also push both of them in some kind of way.

"Inside" Catra finally growls, slightly annoyed, because there it was, the intimacy they had so carefully built against each other, finally breaking free like ripe fruit. "Inside, right now"

Heat showers down Adora's spine, a hundred thoughts running on her mind wild and free like a tsunami. She growls instead against Catra's tongue, pressing herself closer to Catra's body, enveloping her inside her arms almost a tad too strong.

The house, she means the house, something whispers in Adora's mind, or maybe is Catra's drowned voice from the kisses, panting against Adora's earlobe when the last runs her mouth against her cheek and the angle of her jaw.

They tangle with each other's limbs for a bit as they stand up, tripping against their feet while crossing the threshold and inside the house, never once parting from each other's waist and mouth.

It's all a little bit chaotic and kind of violent, sea meeting the stone of the cliff, each other trying to take the lead, pulling from the other's clothes until something rips and fabric falls to the floor.

" *Ah* ," Catra huffs, pressed suddenly against the wall that leads to the fireplace where they have been camping for the last few days. Catra is barefoot, on her jeans and her bra, pressed between the hard wall and Adora's chest, her white shirt ripped open all the way to her belly button, golden scales already adorning her forearms and abdomen and Catra thanks silently whatever god that gave her lighting of showering right after coming home.

Adora leans back just a little, just so she can watch Catra's face, breathing heavily. They've kissed like this before, under the spray of the shower and tangled on damp sheets, but this one is different. It weighs and it makes every nerve on her human body to tingle. Catra looks at her right back, all deep red cheeks and wet lips, sweat pooling in her collarbones.

Adora's mind is roaming free, loose as sand as she absorbs herself in Catra's smell and warmth, the feeling of her skin like the curve of a pearl where her waist meets her ribcage, the sheer black lace covering the roundness of her breasts and barely hiding again the shade of her nipples.

Catra cradles Adora's face between her hands, roaming her thumbs over her ashes eyebrows, now covered almost completely by multicolored scales before leaning forward, pressing their foreheads together.

"Stay with me," Catra whispers against Adora's skin, closing her eyes. This close, Catra can feel the fast heartbeat of Adora's chest against her own ribs, faster than humanly possible. This way, she can even feel the way it jumps a little at her words, running free.

Adora nudges the side of Catra's face with her cheek, a tender kiss that calls back for her attention. Her watercolor eyes are less misted now, full of some kind of silent meaning. Catra

is unsure of what she is trying to say until Adora moves her hand around her back and then up, wrapping her fingers on the clip of her bra and then stopping completely, waiting for Catra.

"Oh," Catra whispers, biting hard on her bottom lip. She knows that, once she agrees, there won't be any turn back. There could, she knows, Catra knows any of them could stop it at any time, but she knows they won't. She doesn't want them to. "You can"

The first time Adora undressed her, lightheaded after their conversation and the night before, it was slow. So slow, like a fairytale, time passing by as in the stories of old, minutes into hours and hours into days. And all the times after it was the same, peeling each other's clothes like one would to a rose blossom, careful of not doing harm, tender and quiet, full of pauses and unsure looks and encouraging nudges.

But they've done all that already. This time is just as loving but it's more. Adora leans forward, burying her head on the angle of Catra's neck, who whimpers, half between a swell of tenderness and a whole lot in frustration, trying to push herself further into Adora's touch. She is almost about to complain when she feels a small prickle on the side of her neck and then a harder snap, not hard enough to hurt her but strong enough to turn her inside into water.

Adora bites the side of her neck, sharp teeth against warm skin, and rips off her bra in one movement, throwing it carelessly somewheres behind them. She feels the way Catra's entire body spasms against her hold and grins, she can't help it, deeply pleased.

Catra pants and grunt. Her jeans feel suddenly too tight against her skin, and he just knows her underwear is soaked, dripping on the inside of her thighs. And she can feel Adora *grinnin* g against her skin, the motherfucker.

Cates inhales and then latches her own mouth against Adora's skin, refusing to lose this one battle. She opens her mouth and let's her tongue fall free, licking a long line from the base of Adora's neck all the way to her jaw, licking and nipping with her fangs before lowering down, between her breasts, pushing back and away the last of her shirt, cradling one of their breasts with her hand and the low of Adora's back with the other, positively making Adora gasp in surprise and surrender.

Ha, Catra thinks, seemingly victorious, dipping her hand blindly, not letting go of Adora's neck and breasts for one second, for once happy of being the shortest of them both, just so she can fumble with the cords of Adora's cotton pants that fall into the floor immediately. Catra's breath hitches inside her throat, fingers brushing over soft, damp curls because Adora is wearing nothing under her clothes.

Catra doesn't dare to touch her, not yet, she doesn't even know what she might do once she does. Maybe cry a little. Instead Catra presses her palms at either side of Adora's tights, brushing her thumbs into circles just close enough to make Adora shiver but never touching her, massaging the muscle there, cooing her into relaxing. Adora let's the side of her face falls at the crown of Catra's head, breathing hard through her sharp teeth.

The smells all around them are crazy, heavy spices hitting Catra's nose and entire skin. Adora smells just a certain way like this. Like thunder, lashing against the salty sea, the kind of smell metallic but also completely natural when your hair stands up just before lightning releases and crashes against the bottom of the world.

Adora growls, deep on her throat and absolutely raw and feral, stealing Catra's breath, and she is sure Adora says something on her tongue but can't even piece the sounds together before Adora is moving. Adora pushes back, and twists, wrapping her long hand around both of Catra's wrists, pulling up from them so her arms are hovering above her hands. Catra gasps, surprised and aroused, standing in her tippy toes as Adora dips under Catra's armpit, licking and kissing the skin just besides Catra's right breast, still holding her in place with one hand while the other grabs the hem of Catra's jeans, pulling them hard and fast from her legs and then away, barely containing herself in ripping the fabric because she knows Catra loves those jeans.

Catra's eyes roll back into her sockets, her head falling backwards, hitting against the wall kind of hard. Her mind is blank, void of all thoughts while Adora's mouth works her up over her ribs and makes work of the rest of her clothes as Catras slowly comes to the realization that Adora is not only holding her still with one hand because it is hot but because she is *strong* , so unbelievably strong that she is holding Catra's whole weight above her head without breaking a sweat.

Cates doesn't even realize she is fully naked until Adora moves her around, releasing her wrists just so she can wrap her hands around her waist, basically carrying her the few steps left to their little spot next the fire, guiding Catra down to lay on her back over the blankets. There are no other lights on the house but the amber fire and it has long ago gone dark outside, leaving them secured on their own spot of the world for tonight.

There are a bunch of blankets and pillows on the floor, turned around carelessly from where they had made a makeshift nest and, even if there is no mattress, the floor isn't hard and uncomfortable but soft, where Catra now wriggles, breathless, trying to connect the wires of her brain back into her muscles as to not just lay there, heart and body and soul exposed for Adora to see.

Adora looks otherworldly like this, hovering above Catra as she starts to sink slowly on the floor, kneeling right between her legs. Her entire face has changed, ears long, soft and delicate, shimmering every color from blue to purple to green under the flickering light of the fire. Her eyes are huge, the white completely drowned by black, irises sticking blue against the warm darkness. She is panting and the human skin that still covers her chest is red with exercise and purple by Catra's kisses, little violet blooms that challenge the scales sprouting like crazy all over her shoulders and neck and cheeks and temples. It's been so few times that Catra has seen her like this, on the bare minimum of her true beauty without her skin, just slipping through when her emotions were so hard and so honest and bright, that makes Catra realize, just for this moment of theirs, Adora has stopped holding back.

" *You are driving me insane,"* Adora signs, deliberately slow, sinking further and further in the space between Catra's legs, lowering above Catra's body as a second skin as Adora slips her thigh between her thighs, pressing it against her again firmly though gently.

"Ah!" Catra gasps, seeking the touch between them almost automatically, rocking over her thigh slowly, absently. Suddenly she feels sleepy, completely relaxed, open and vulnerable under Adora's gaze. Adora nestles her face in her neck, petting the errand damp curls of her head gently, allowing Catra to rub against her, following the instinctual movements of her body, her spine flexing, curving, relaxing again, drowsy and also completely hyper aware that this is actually happening. That the inner face of her thighs is wet with arousal and Adora is in the middle of it all like a lighthouse, ignating alive something Catra didn't even know that existed inside herself, and she would be ashamed to be this vulnerable before but not now. Not with her.

Catra doesn't even know where Adora learnt this from and for a split of a second she is overwhelmed with jealousy and uneasiness, holding herself to the expanse of Adora's wide back with her nails, trying to push back the dark thoughts starting to clog her mind. That, until Adora shifts, pressing her foreheads back together so she can see the expression on Catra's face, making sure she is fine and contempt and that she wants to keep going, and Catra remembers Adora has spend weeks learning her carefully and maybe now that they are here she knows exactly what Catra needs, what she wants. The look on her bright eyes almost says it, screams it. *Tell me. Tell me how. Tell me.*

"That thing you do with your tongue… when you kiss me, " Catra dares, wetting her chapped and dry bottom lip with her tongue, a movement Adora's eyes follow with hunger. Catra's heart gives an almost painful squeeze inside her chest and she wraps her fingers with Adora's, lowering their joined hands, down, down, slippery sling and scales pressing against soft, curly hair, down until Catra places it where she is warmer, softer. Needer. "Here"

Adora's eyes flicker, confusion giving way to understandment and then to the most tender of smiles giving the situation. Adora snatches her scaled thigh away from Catra and the latter mourns the lost of it for a moment before Adora starts to retreat on her path, this time, resting her weight over the abdomen and forearms, staring at Catra's open folds with the kind of expression someone would make at finding a hidden treasure, wonder and care washing over her. Yes, Adora knows what sex is, and knows how important this is, not for humans or for first ones, but for them, right this second.

Adora brushes the lady of her finger against the pink flesh of Catra's entrance, just a brush, taking it back with a marveled look in her face

" *You are so wet,"* Adora marvels, staring at soaked finger, clear wetness dripping from her elegant fingers and into the scales of her wrist and somehow they almost seem to shine.

"Adora-" Catra says, a warning, hiding her face between both of her palms, watching the literal siren above her from in between her fingers. Adora licks her finger clean, tongue pink and long, eyes darkening even further at the taste, making Catra know she might be going to devour her whole after all.

"Fuck" Catra lets her head fall back, against the blankets, grabbing a fistful of fabric between her hands, anchoring herself to what is to come. "You are doing this in purpose"

Adora smiles at her, small, sweet and apologetic and so inherently *Adora* that it is enough to ground Catra into the now. Adora waits for Catra to catch into her head space, patiently

peppering reassuring kisses over her legs until Catra exhales, shaky, giving a swift nod.

Adora smiles and opens her mouth, letting her tongue fall just for a second, licking a sweet spot on Catra's navel. It's cold at the touch and wet and long, way long. Too long to be her human tongue at all. And it isn't smooth either, there are small bumps on its entire length, soft but also firm, and Catra wonders for the split of a second how would that tongue feel inside of her

Catra lets go of the blankets and whimpers behind her palm, sweat running down her temples.

She can feel Adora's breath above her, just a breath away from Catra's entrance. She inhales, holds her breath, grasping Adora's silk hair between her fingers for dear life. It doesn't matter, it doesn't prepare her at all. Adora's tongue circles her outer folds, gathering her musky scent on the back of her throat and slips inside in one swift thrust, deeper than anything Catra has ever felt before.

Catra's head slams against the pillows beneath with a deep groan, echoing on the walls of her house and barely challenging the scream of the snowstorm outside them.

Adora rubs the pads of her two fingers on Catra's entrance, massaging the muscle there and coaxing it to relax before entering her with them too, slowly, stretching her walls with gentle trusts, making her tongue press even closer to that spot that makes Catra's eyes roll back into white, mouth open, a myriad of high pitched moans and gasps leaving her throat in arrhythmic pass, her heels digging on the floor and blankets as shots of white pleasure spend all over her waist and legs.

She feels so full, she feels everything that Adora is in every single part of her body, slipping like sea water inside her cells, running salt and magic in her veins

"Adora, Adora-" Catra calls, again and again and again, a song just for Adora's ears, a true siren call, enveloping Adora in the haze of their bodies and the warmth of human flesh and the cold freshness of Catra's own ocean.

Adora can feel Catra chasing something, hunting for it full of hunger. She is panting over the damp blankets, sweat covering her entire precious body, her back arched off the floor. And she is singing, a myriad of small, staccato moans and whimpers, high pitched and raspy coming out from her kiss bitten mouth. She looks so beautiful, glistening under the fires light, Adora's greatest treasure.

Adora knows Catra is about to break down, she can feel it in her tongue, the way her walls are quivering with pleasure, soaking her legs, Adora's chin and her nose. Adora can feel herself building up too, a sea running down her own human legs, sticky and unstoppable. Her skin there is warm and sensitive, begging for touch.

Adora groans, between her own chase and Catra's, thumbing with her nose the hidden pearl above Catra's pink lips. Catra almost convulses at the touch, rolling her hips down, looking for the touch, *touch,* of Adora's nose and lips and tongue, wrapping her fist on the back of Adora's hair and pulling lightly.

Truth to be told, Adora has been reading, searching, trying to prepare herself as best as possible for Catra from the very few books around the house that talk about the matter. She has ideas but really, she doesn't know what she is doing. Whatever it is she must be doing something right because Catra's eyes are clouded, tears are falling down her beautiful cheeks and suddenly Adora is too far away from her.

Adora tales her mouth away immediately, lapping the last of that beautiful, heavy taste on her mouth before moving back up. Catra's eyes shot open, panting, looking at Adora without understanding.

"What- what, no-" Catra tries, voice completely gone and raspy, barely managing to speak at all. " 'dora"

" **Catra,"** Adora takes Catra's leg, coaxing it up and then to the side, opening her in a completely different way, one that makes heat and wetness pool between her folds in rivers. Catra can feel herself dripping over the curve of her tight and into the sheets, bright red with arousal and halfway shame.

Adora is looking at her again, in that very same way that makes Catra's belly to knot and her skin to shiver in fever, not one tearing her eyes from her face and her every expression. Her pupils are dilated so much, the dark almost drowns out the blue completely, almost golden under the light of the fire beside them and the darkness beyond the window.

Adora's folds brush against Catra's, wet and slippery, like a damp flower, making Catra gasp and whimper in pleasure, tears gathering in the corners of her eyes, feeling Adora pressed close as intimate as it can be against her.

Adora rises her hips a little and then lowers again, letting her folds brush and caress against Catra's again and again and again. There is something firm rubbing right against Catra's sensitive clit and the touch is making her go insane. Catra can feel Adora's wetness gush and drip all around her, down the skin of her thighs, through the depths of her folds and even inside of her, mixing with her own wetness and heat, slipping inside of her core.

"Faster" manages to exhale Catra, running her nails down Adora's shoulders and back, feeling with the pads of her fingers the gentle skin of her scars and the smooth yet hard surface of the iridescent scales that had grown there, born from Adora's wildness and passion. Adora grunts at the feeling, not uncomfortable but absolutely turned on, the blue if her eyes melting away into darkness, teeth sharpening just slightly again, just enough that when she bends to nibble and suck at Catra's neck they prick the fragile skin there, leaving blooming purple flowers behind them.

That's what makes it in the end. Catra yelps and convulses against Adora's arms, melting and snapping free, powerful enough that it makes her sight go dark and her mind to numb for several seconds.

Catra hadn't had sex in a long time, and the times she did it wasn't pleasure what she was looking for, much less love. It was all hard and painful. This is all the contrary, strong and overwhelmingly sweet, wrapping Catra in a skin of its own.

Catra comes back to herself with a little nudge, blinking from the haze on her eyes. The world is still a little blurry on the edges and she feels warm and sore everywhere. Everywhere. Except…

She can see Adora hovering above her, cradling Catra's face between her hands, a worry frow etched on her face, small, worried noises without words leaving her mouth.

"...fine …I'm fine," Catra manages to muster, resting her sweaty palm on Adora's cheek. The haze slowly lowers down, allowing her to look at Adora fully, concern still etched on her face. "That was… that was, fuck. That was amazing Adora. God."

Slowly Adora starts to relax, worried frown melting into a happy smile. Catra stares at her from between all the tenderness she feels right now, realizing that Adora's skin is still red in some patches, her breathing heavy, sweat glistening her forehead.

" 'dora, did you cum?" Cates wonders, now the one concerned. By the way Adora's cheeks paint red, Catra doesn't need any other answer. "Why? What happened? Was it not…"

Adora places her fingers over Catra's mouth, shaking her head before taking it away, signing.

"I'm a little bit different to you" Adora lowers her hand, pointing at her own navel, cheeks so pink they look like small suns. *"Here"*

Adora bites her lip, clearly nervous for the first time in the entire evening. Catra's heartbeat picks up, breath stopping in her throat.

"That's alright," she whispers sweetly, running her nails through Adoras scalp, tucking her damp honey hair behind her back, trying to make her feel safe. "You can show me, if you want"

Adora hesitates, just for a second, and then takes Catra's clammy hand between hers, bringing it down, between her pale legs, guiding Catra to cup her wam core on her palm, feeling the wetness of her folds twitching and then something else, a little bit above her dripping core, a little nub, firm and as warm as pulsing. Catra blushes deep red, breathing hard through her nose when Adora's fingers guide her along the, silk soft and hot that throbs when Catra caress it with her fingers, unfolding through her fingers and that makes her lose her brain

Catra exhales wrapping her fingers around it and bumping once, gently, across the length of Adora's member, amazed in the way her eyes rolls back with the pleasure and she loses the grip of reality by the overwhelmed heat, iridescent scales crawling on her forehead and the side of her face, making her look almost like a bird, a fenix sprouted from the flames of the fire and into Catra's arms, nestled still between her shivering legs.

"Ah," it escapes Adora's mouth, her spine arching with the shots of pleasure. Catra wriggles into a more sitting position, still feeling like her legs are going to give away in any second now.

"This is why you were nervous? You didn't know if I would like it?" Catra says, trying to sound smut and hot though her voice comes cracking in the middle. It would ashamed her

any other day but not now, not with Adora so completely vulnerable in her hands. Adora closes her eyes tightly, biting down on her lips they bruise, her hands locked at either side over the blankets. The scar on her face looks silver and she looks beautiful, a goddess that had just worshiped Catra with her mouth and her hands, finally letting herself be taken care of. "It's you, Adora, I love it"

Adora's eyes open a slit, swinging her arms around Catra's neck, pushing them both closer together. She is trying to push herself into Catra's moving hand, rubbing herself, chasing the touch, her breasts bouncing with the movement, covered in precious scales. Catra's ears are deep red and her mind is going everywhere, almost matching Adora's desperation.

Catra leans, pressing open mouthed kisses all along Adora's face, rubbing their cheeks together, breathing on her silk ears. Catra presses their cheeks together, calling gently for Adora's attention as she rubs her nose against her cheekbones.

"Are you alright, love?" Catra asks, genuine. Adora's eyes are still barely opened, watching Catra from behind a thick mist, but she nods, honest. “Good girl. Do you want to keep going?" Another nod. Catra smiles. "Adora, I love you,” she says and Adora smiles too, still hazy but definitely listening. “But if I don't have you inside me in the next minute I might have just have to do it on my own”

Adora straight up shivers, lust covering her expression, lust and also something almost dangerous. The look before a hunt, a predator chasing her prey.

Catra climbs over Adora, cradling her lap with her thighs and resting her arms around her shoulders and neck. She worries for a second that it may be tiresome for Adora, being sat on the floor, but Adora presses her hands on the low of Catra's waist and pulls her closer, the shift and pull of the powerful muscles of her back shifting and accommodating Catra's weight below her hands.

They cradle each other like this for a while, lips brushing against lips, chins, cheeks, the lilac of eyelids, down to the column of necks and into soft skin. Adora brushes the skin of Catra's side, her hand slipping upwards, cupping the roundness of her breast inside her cold hand. Adora leans forward, running her long, long siren tongue over the skin of her collarbones and then down, following the natural curve until she takes Catra's brown, perked up nipple inside her mouth, sucking in there with delight.

Catra moans, throwing her head back, her eyes locking with the wooden beams in the ceiling. She can feel wetness dripping down her slit again, soaking the inner face of her thighs with how turned on she is. She can also feel Adora, cradled between Catra's navel and Adora's abdomen, hot and twitching, responding to Catra's own heat in shocks of pleasure.

Catra runs her hand down Adora's chest, pointy nails leaving superficial red lines over her skin, following an invisible path until it reaches between them. Catra raises her hips a little, just enough that she can take Adora and guide her where she wants it the most. She has done this before, a few times, with her own fingers and toys, but this is different. This is about Adora. This is about Adora and her. It sends shivers of excitement but also nervous down her spine, raising the skin of her body in goosebumps.

Catra is not a prude. She knows sex doesn't mean being stuck with someone forever. This is not the medievo. But this is different. Somehow, inside of her chest, Catra knows that this is it, not turning backs, nobody else. She will be Adora's and somehow, incredibly, Adora will be hers too.

Mates, Adora had called it with a glint on her eyes.

Mates.

Wives.

Lovers.

Soulmates.

Catra’s hand trembles just a little at the end, suddenly overwhelmed. Not in a bad way, but she feels swift from one moment to the other, like she is suddenly alone in the room. Adora catches her, of course she does, guiding Catra’s hand between hers, lacing their fingers together and placing it softly over her shoulders. Then she holds her waist between her fingers firmly, making sure Catra's arms are steady around her neck before she lifts her hips from the floor, meeting Catra in the middle.

The head goes in easily, with no resistance at all. Catra is already open like a blooming flower and so wet, it slips inside of her all the way to the middle, where Adora stops to allow her to get used to it and breathe. Adora helps her through it, rubbing the base of her column in tight circles, staying still as Catra’s walls flutter and accommodate around her. Catra exhales, something that it's both a moan and a heavy sigh, pressing her forehead against Adora's firmly. Her eyes shut close without her permission, consciousness swimming in a haze of overwhelming pleasure and heat. It feels incredible. The studs along the length rub in her walls like nothing she has ever felt before, reaching places not even Adora's tongue could, that Catra didn't even know about to begin with but that makes her feel like her back has melted into boiling lava and her thighs to tremble around Adora's waist.

Adora sighs, a song already slipping all around them. Her face is calm and peaceful, still wrinkled with the lust and the pleasure but sweet, nudging a reassuring siren's kiss over Catra's neck.

“It’s okay” Catra gasps, smoothing down the baby hairs around Adora's forehead, damp with sweat, in an attempt to calm her erratic heart. “You can move”

For the first few seconds, Adora seems unsure on what to do. She is, after all, a sea creature and she has never done this before. All she has ever heard about this has been under water, stories that don't stray too far away from what they are doing right now. After a few tries, though, she gets it, finding the perfect angle that rubs just in a certain perfect way inside Catra. The swollen middle slips in and out of her, deliciously slow yet not enough to go all the way inside. Catra grunts, frustrated, brows frowned tight over her eyes. Tension running down her shoulders. That won’t do.

Adora gets a good hold of Catra’s waist and shifts their positions, flipping them down, resting Catra’s back softly over the blankets and pillows again. Catra stretches over their makeshift nest, accommodating Adora gently between her spread legs, laughing when Adora leans above her and her hair tickles her in the ribs.

“Come here, Princess” whispers Catra, her voice hoarse and thick with pleasure and heat.

Adora grabs her knee and bends it a little towards Catra’s chest, holding her leg up a little bit higher, hooking Catra’s elegant ankle over the low of her waist. The new angle allows her to slide inside Catra again with a single thrust. It goes completely, without resistance, suddenly, making Catra gasp loudly when Adora bottoms up to the hilt.

Catra’s other ankle also hooks below Adora’s butt cheek, digging on her slippery skin. Both of her knees and thighs cradle Adora’s waist, keeping her in place. Her fingers run down Adora’s powerful, sweaty palm, marking red lines as she holds herself to it. Adora presses her lips to hers, open mouthed, licking a line from the back of her palate, all the way behind her teeth and across the edge of her upper lip.

Then, she moves. It starts slow, dragging outside of Catra softly, letting her get used to the sensation before roaming back inside without warning, still absolutely careful. Catra tears her mouth from Adora’s in order to press her face over Adora’s collarbones and moan, loudly.

Adora finds a rhythm basically immediately. In and out, in and out. Catra can still feel the base of her folds brushing against hers with every stroke, fucking, making love.

There it is, the knot, coming loose. The wave, crashing against the shore, washing the sand away. There it is, as seconds turn to slow minutes of passion, strong, deep and lustful and slow, fast and sweet, wet like sea drizzle and warm as the sun.

Catra is beyond words, lost in the small universe that is Adora, feeling like she has been embraced by the very ocean. Adora is singing loudly, the siren's song filling every single corner of the room and the house and Catra's pores.

Adora looks at Catra, her hands wrapped on the strands of Adora's hair, mouth halfway open, all her freckles dark and deep like starts, small breasts like drops of dew pressing against Adora's, curls framing her face, and there is nothing that will come as close to be so beautiful to Adora, so dear. Not even the sea riff or the deepest of the seas or the dawn below the water will ever compare to this, to her, to the feeling of her hands against Adora's scales, the heat of her core against Adora's center, embracing her in all the ways possible. Her patience and acceptance, her love.

" I love you," Adora says, cradling Catra's cheek on her scaled palm. This way, she can see the way Catra's eyes swell into tears, spilling free almost immediately down her cheeks and losing themselves in the stands of her hair. This way she can see how her whole body starts to tremble, stripped and vulnerable. Adora doesn't understand why until she sees the flicker of Catra's eyes and feels her hand placing itself above the gills on her neck, caressing the soft tissue and that's when Adora realizes she has said it in her mother tongue, outloud.

"Say...say it" Catra stutters, already at the edge. Her eyes are blurry, from tears and from the unstoppable wave of pleasure washing over her, almost taking her over. "Please"

" **I love you,"** Adora concids, immediately, and she understands just what Catra is feeling, the vulnerability of being all that you are without holding back. ″ **Catra, I love you. I love you"**

Adora comes, Catra can feel her, she follows her and, for a second, she understands what is to be ethereal.

Adora falls over Catra, panting heavily against the angle of her neck and shoulder, feeling suspended in time and the universe, overwhelmed by emotions and love. Catra is panting too, eyes closed, her face ticked and hidden against Adora's hair, as close to Adora as she can manage with her limbs spent and sore and her heart heavy.

They stay like this for hours maybe, just listening to each other breathing and the fire cracking and the snow falling outside the house, turning it all white.

After a while, Adora pulls out, already smaller but throbbing still and Catra whimpers a little, highly sensitive. Who would have thought? Catra didn't know this about herself, how soft she would become after laying with her love.

Adora doesn't go far, cradling her against her chest, Catra's head under her chin. They will lay again, later, this time even slower, until the night breaks into dawn and neither of them can go anymore, but for now they embrace each other, no more words needed.

It feels good. It feels right. Catra thinks, who had never known this before. *It feels like love.*

End of chapter IV

(...) her fingers on my back were not so tentative, and our bodies pressed together under the water, warm skin on warm skin, and all the panic and fear and guilt and cold were nothing but distant memories of a passing storm. There was only this. There was only her.

– Sam Hawke

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed the fluff! (◜‿◝)♡

it won't last.

Held me into your benthic arms, daughter of the waves

Chapter Summary

"Stay with me"

"Always"

Chapter Notes

They go to a party
Catra wonders about marriage, Adora wonders about Catra
Mermista and Sea Hawks commit arson

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER: This story is about to go really dark really fast so please be sure to read the warnings and tags beforehand
- mentions of weapons
- mentions of illegal animal hunting
- descriptions of wounds (mild to severe)

As always, the spicy scenes are marked with ***** in case you would like to jump them over. If you read through, be away the spicy level went all the way to 5/5 habaneros. Drink some water.

Thank you so much for supporting me through this story and for being there for the girl and her siren. Hope you enjoy the chapter (I'm already 5k deep in the next)!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter V. Held me into your benthic arms, daughter of the waves

But a mermaid has no tears, and therefore she suffers so much more.

– Hans Christian Andersen , *The Little Mermaid*

☼

Two months goes by like rain through the rocks. Winter to spring

Catra wakes up next to Adora every day, either circled by her arms, or draped over her chest, Adora's hummingbird heartbeat quick under her ear, skin cold at the touch and yet so warm.

Catra loves it, the feeling of Adora's breath against her face, the long hours they spend making love to each other, Adora sweating and panting over the mattress, too far gone by Catra's mouth or fingers inside and around her, or until Catra's legs have given up, the muscles of her hips and abdomen exhausted as Adora trusts inside her with loving but strong strokes. Adora, sleeping before or after, all her hair loose, curled like locks of gold over the pillows. She always looks peaceful in her sleep, like all the doubts and fear have washed away from her body, like she is free from everything just letting herself float in peace over their shared sheets.

Sometimes they kiss for hours under the spray of the shower, lukewarm water washing over their backs, following the paths of fingers running down hips and thighs. Adora always looks the most beautiful like this, hair darken by the water, sticking to the naked skin of her arms and her back, her eyelashes casting shadows over the colorful scales on her cheeks when she lets herself get drowsy, naked and soaked from head to toe, embraced inside Catra's arms, just rocking together from side to side until the warm water turns cold.

Sometimes they spend entire evenings in bed, just laying next to each other, backs over the mattress and the cool sheets, noses touching, the room in silence, the curtains barely open to let the light pour inside.

Early in the morning, Adora likes to sit by the huge window of the first floor, the one that has the stained glass like waves and a huge cushioned seat and looks to the sea. She will just sit there in her silk nightgown, bare feet and long hair loose, humming until her song fills the entire house, a piece of the universe hidden away from the rest of the world.

Catra will join her when the sun is higher on the sky turning it all golden, only in her nightgown too, sitting in front of her in silence, content and smiling, until Adora moves forward and motions Catra to sit over her lap and her arms to wrap tight around her neck, making love to Catra against the now foggy stained glass without stop singing.

It is domestic, this folklore life of them. Wake up, sing, kiss, make love. Write, read, draw. Braid, seashell knots by siren hands that hang on the roof of the porch and twinkle with the wind. Eat and kiss and walk and swim and make love again.

Catra loves it, and she knows Adora too. For the first time in her life, they feel loved, openly. For the first time in their life's, both of them are, somehow, free.

✵

****

Light is pouring through the halfway shut curtains of the bedroom's window, painting it all in lilac light. Adora falls against Catra's sweaty forehead with a hoarse groan, gripping the sheets around Catra's face tightly, shivering, a breathy moan leaving her mouth. She is clearly unused to this, the attention, letting go, being selfish instead of selfless.

Catra helps her. Her hands are tight around Adora's waist, fingers digging in the curves of her body there, leaving purple and red blossoms like flowers. Her hips raise every time she meets Adora's thighs, helping her out as Adora rides the soul out of her, her pale thighs around Catra's waist, squeezing, holding down. Adora's folds are dripping with wetness, rubbing, fucking herself against the length of the strap and the curves of Catra's legs, bent to help Adora support her back against them.

"That's it, princess. That's it" Catra is saying, breathless, unable to look away from her. "You are doing amazing, 'Dora. So beautiful."

She is so fucking hot. Everything about her, even cold at the touch as she is. The bounce of her breasts, held gently on the strap shirt she didn't even bothered to take off completely, one of them slipping off from the fabric, flushed skin and pink nipple that drags Catra forward making her rest her cheek and lips against it, worshiping it with her breathe and tongue. The push and pull of her abdomen as she bounces over Catra, tightening, making the skin slippery with sweat and glistening golden. The messed up hair, honey colored and ruffled to one side, almost pink under this light, falling like a waterfall from one side of her face and against Catra's shoulder, soft, smelling like the shampoo they share.

"Let go, baby, you can let go" Catra chants, cupping Adora's firm breasts between her hands, thumbing on the dark pink of her nipples. Adora holds her breath and then lets loose, a deep moan ripping from her beautiful throat as she comes, heavily, spreading down her thighs, around the strap and across Catra's belly.

Catra exhales, tracing soothing circles on Adora's waist as the spams lower and call down, her muscles relaxing above her. She is still absolutely turned on but this is not about her right now.

Adora shifts her weight to the side, falling against Catra's side with a sigh, she collapses completely loose. Catra catches her in her arms, embracing her completely, helping her slip out of the strap gently, careful of not being too fast or rouge. The length is covered with crystalline release.

Adora rests the side of her temple against Catra's forehead, noses barely touching, breathes mixing. Her legs change positions, this time cradling only Catra's thigh, rubbing herself against her in one swift, delicious line, wetness spreading over Catra's skin divinely because, somehow, she is still not done.

Adora helps Catra unbuckle the snaps of the strap from her waist, just enough so Catra can wiggle out of them, taking the toy from it with one of her long hands, the other cradling the back of Catra's head. Catra makes an attempt to hold her hand to her to take the toy and rest it over the nightstand but Adora grunts, wrapping her long fingers on the silicone base.

"Adora? What are you-? Oh my- *fuck* "

Adora pushes Catra's lace bra up, culling her breast with her palm as she grabs the base of the strap, still wet and dripping with her own release, and presses it on Catra's entrance, dragging it inside her soaked opening in one, smooth swing.

They've done a lot of things in their months together. Sweet things, sharp things, heated things. But there is just something so incredibly desarming on Adora fucking Catra with the same toy she had just had inside herself, wetness mixing together, release and sweat.

Catra basically screams, moaning so loud it makes her deaf for a few seconds, no matter how hard she tries to contain it by slapping her hand over her mouth and covering her face with the mattress. Adora fucks her hard, trusting the strap inside of her without mercy and riding her thigh at the same time, bold after her first orgasm and already chasing the second.

Adora guides Catra through it when the waves hit them both at the same time, pressing a kiss to the side of Catra's temple, sweet lips and sharp teeth as her moans blent with Catra's.

Catra exhales at the end, spams ripping through her entire body. Adora takes away the strap, clear come coming off Catra's immediately after, letting it fall carelessly into the carpet just so she can return her fingers to Catra's slit, massaging and entering her with them until Catra comes a second time, swifter and twice as powerful and Catra barely manages with give a hoarse gasp, already too sensitive to move at all.

Catra feels like she is floating, far away from her mind, melted bone and sore heart. Adora takes her hand away, gently, lovingly, helping her out of the subspace her mind has fallen into until reality comes again and Catra can breathe.

After, Adora cradles her inside her arms, running her nails up and down Catra's back as the latter showers her collarbones with kisses, embracing each other until late hours of the morning and the dawn gives away to the day.

Wake up, sing and make love again.

****

✵

Catra finishes her book.

Spinerella is delighted, praising her and the new book and asking her how Catra managed to get her inspiration back after all. But what can Catra tell her? That she has spent most of the days of the last months either writing in bed or having wonderful sex with the love of her life and that, it turns out, that is all she needed. She can't say that, so instead, Catra just shrugs on the video call and says,

"A good burst of inspiration" looking towards the living room where her inspiration is sitting cross legged over the carpet, playing with Melog with a knitted ball.

Still, Catra must be a really shit liar, or maybe Spinerella is just a very good listener because she congratulates her at the end, smile bright even through the phone.

"I hope, whoever they are, they will help you find the peace you deserve, Catrina" she says and that 's all.

Little by little, the house starts looking like *them,* starts looking less like only a house and more like a home. They clean the attic together, some things going to the people of the town for free, others like Razz's books and trinkets displayed in bookcases around the house. They paint the walls a shell color and the room a dark blue, and the curtains remain open the entire day, letting the new warm sun and light pour inside.

Catra starts hanging pictures around the house. Over the walls of the stairs and above the fireplace. Most of them are of Catra and Adora, taken by instant cameras on the beach and the town and around the house. But some of them are old, from when Catra was a baby and even before that, of Razz and of her mom too, as young as Catra is now and just as beautiful. Adora doesn't mention it but she is proud. Catra knows anyway, though.

They even fix the old boat, with boards of multicolored wood and a lot of curses, on Catra's side. They might go sailing someday, maybe. But for now it's just there, waiting.

They've gotten bolder at going to the town, too. Adora likes to spend the evenings there, sitting on the bay at sunset or eating every single item of all the restaurants in the town. Catra is just happy to see her happy.

Surely, the entire town gets used to them pretty quickly. The writer and her beautiful wife. They see them sitting at the ice cream shop, or looking for seashells and trinkets on the flea market or buying bread and fruits or walking across the beach, hand in hand always. Quickly, the town learns to love them. The writer has always been serious, heart hard, always at arms away from everyone, except *her*. With her she melts, she becomes softer, with the world and with herself. She becomes more who she is and people love it. And her wife is so easy to love, bubbly and full of curiosity about the world, always laughing without a voice, always wrinkles on her eyes from smiling so much, unabashedly happy, incredibly kind.

The town doesn't really know where they came from, usually absent from every social life and then suddenly there, like sprouted out of the very sea. Sometimes, people of the town will think. They live in a town by the sea, after all, they are good acquaintances of the folks and tales. Sometimes, they will wonder if maybe, *maybe*...

It doesn't matter anyway. Every single person in the town would probably give their lives for them.

Sometimes, on quiet days, Adora likes to sit on the shore of their home until it's very late at night, letting the waves and foam wash over her naked feet and legs, just sitting there with her eyes fixed on the horizon beyond. Sometimes she even dares to go inside, floating above the water close enough that she doesn't drift away, salt in her ears and hair, just listening at all the sounds of her ocean again. On days like that, Catra lets her be. She looks at her through the window or seats on the porch, quiet, thinking. Searching.

But before the day ends Adora always comes back, smelling like salt and sun but right inside Catra's arms, the only other place beyond the water where she feels like herself.

There are seashell wind chimes hanging from the roof of the entrance, made by Adora with colorful ropes and knots and sea glass, twinkling with each other as they spin with the sea breeze. She likes doing that, she used to make them underwater and hang them on the roof of

the cave she used to sleep in or in her hair, and even her brother's hair much to his annoyance.

Sometimes she braids Catra's hair too, very careful of not tangling the soft curls, with small colorful beads and seashells and her own loose iridescent scales until Catra is basically asleep on her arms, a small treasure from the land to the sea.

Two days after their first time together, when the snowstorm tampers a little, they drive together to the town and end up staying for hours inside the warmth of something Catra called a coffee shop. There, Adora sees mates going in and around together, some of them with shining metal bands around their fingers, some of them bare, a human tradition she hadn't known yet.

When they return home, Adora quietly picks a few strands of thread and sits for hours on the shore until she finally manages to knot them together into the finests of braids, lacing it around Catra's delicate finger with a bounce and a proud beautiful smile before lacing another over her finger too, wriggling it before her face with the brightest of smiles. A thread ring, almost tender enough to be a childhood promise and honest enough to be a vow.

"Promise?" Catra had asked in a thread of a voice, whispered among moonlight and sweet kisses against her face.

"Promise"

They are still wearing them now, when they embrace each other inside the bath full of salt. When they dance slowly from side to side in the living room until dawn. When Catra is overwhelmed with love and pleasure as she cradles Adora inside her and runs her nails down her scaled back. When Adora wanders inside the waves of the ocean at midnight, helping Catra over the dark pebbles until the water is on their waists and she can sing freely, never going beyond the stones of the cliff and the edge of the shore.

Catra thinks she might just wear it forever, golden rings be damned.

Catra finishes her book and Adora sings and everything is good.

Micah and Angella invite them to their twenty-fifth wedding anniversary party. Catra is driving to the town alone today because Adora was too soft and too beautiful in the morning and too spent to even rise from bed and Catra didn't have the heart to wake her up. So today she is driving on her own, the window rolled down to let the wind slip in, radio at full volume as Catra sings with it and it's all anyone needs to know to understand Catra is happy.

Catra parks in front of Mermista's store, hopping off the car quickly and making her way inside. It's very early still, not even seven yet, and the square is mostly empty, clean and peaceful. The store is quiet too, with a bored employee at the other side of the counter that helps Catra ring for the bath salts and go.

It's a perfectly beautiful day when Catra steps outside the store and into the street carrying her bags, hair loose against the wind, twinkling with the small braids Adora braided last night, her clothes loose and clean and life good. It's a perfectly beautiful day because she has the mark of a hidden kiss on the back of her neck and tingle of strong hands on her waist and, maybe, if she had lasted a few minutes longer laying in bed with Adora in her arms instead of wanting to surprise her with a bath and breakfast nothing would have happened at all. But then again, if she had spent just five minutes more in the morning with the love of her life, who knows what would have happened at all.

It goes like this, like many things in life.

It's a perfectly beautiful day and as Catra takes the longer path through the square just to enjoy the morning she hears someone calling her name behind her.

It's a perfectly beautiful day so Catra turns around without stopping walking because the sun is just perfect and she thinks she might just ask Adora to marry her, properly.

It's a perfectly beautiful day when she sees Mermista rushing to her side, all blue hair and weirdly worried expression, saying something Catra can't quite place because she is just thinking how happy and lucky she is, how in love, life a selfish idiot.

It's a perfectly beautiful day when she doesn't watch where she is going so she crashes against the side of someone standing in the middle of the square and she turns around to apologize and the world comes to an end.

It's a perfectly beautiful day and suddenly the dream is over.

He is white. All about him. His clothes and shoes and even his hair, everything but the eyes, bright green and terrible. Not like the green of a forest in bloom or of grass at sunset. Artificial almost, void of life. He is wearing expensive clothes, a suit perfectly tailored with a white tie and the only spark of color there is an embroidery, two wings with three green eyes, a sigil that has been burned in Catra's brain for months, suddenly barely inches from her.

He is looking at Catra, quiet, face inexpressive. There is no recognition in his features but something lives on the back of his eyes, festering as rotten meat, and suddenly Catra is afraid. Deeply, terribly afraid.

It all happens very quickly because the next second Mermista has reached her, wrapping her hand around Catra's forearm and pulling from her slightly back, strangely protective of her actions to be who she is. The man moves too, facing Catra completely even as Mermista pulls her a little bit further away, and he looks like he is going to say something when a fourth person walks from behind the man, also staring at her.

"Catrina! Mermista! Sorry I didn't see you two there," Micah says, rushing at Catra's other side, seemingly to greet her except it is all wrong. His voice is too high pitched, almost controlled, and there is a sweat on his face even if Micah Moon has never broken into a sweat in his life. He is holding himself very tight, and when he wraps his hand around Catra's arm, he is a bit too harsh. He doesn't seem to realize how nervous he is.

"I was just- showing our visitor around town before he leaves, you know," Micah adds, a little bit too heavy on the last statement. The man isn't even paying attention to him or to Mermista, weighing Catra with his cold green eyes. "Oh, how silly of me. This is Mister Prime Kurr. He… arrived at the town earlier today."

For the first time, the man's face seems to twitch with emotion, tilting his head to the side, still not taking his sight away from Catra. He extends his hand, taking Catra's inside his without even waiting for her to react either, cold calculation on his stare.

"I don't think we have met before, Miss-?

"-Grayskull" Catra manages, fighting to not recoil at the touch of his hand against hers. His touch burns like steel and Catfa wants to break down and scream and cry into the floor.

"Grayskull" Prime repeats, tasting the word on his tongue, weighing it, studying it until his perfect face breaks into a perfect smile, all roads of white teeth and Catra can't help the feeling that, just with that, he *knows.* "Like the cliff"

Like the cliff

Catra says nothing, too overwhelmed by panic to even start to think any coherent thought. The only thing she knows is that she needs to go, she needs to go but she can't go and suddenly all the beauty and goodness that lives in her life, that lies asleep over their shared bed back in a home they have made theirs, is in danger.

Prime is still looking at her from head to toe, taking in her Sunday clothes and the bags in her hands. He seems to see something because his eyes flash with something sticky and nasty, eyebrows barely moving over his forehead with bemusement.

"Are you married, Miss Grayskull?" He asks and it's only then Catra realizes he has seen the thread on her finger, gentle and *there,* a tale tells that Catra loves someone and that someone loves her in return. That, on the house by the cliff that carries her name, Catra is not alone.

"Catrina and her wife are very dear to the people of the town," Micah says when Catra doesn't answer, his hold on her arm tightening a little bit more. Somewhere inside Catra's brain she understands they are trying to protect her, for very different reasons why she actually needs shelter.

"Wife" Prime repeats, clicking his tongue against his perfect teeth, smiling like the cat that got the bird. "How romantic"

That makes it click inside Catra's head because she is indeed absolutely terrified but this is also the first time she sees this man face to face and she hates him so much more than what she fears him, and it's him. It's him, it's him, it's him, it's *him* .

Catra grinds her teeth together so hard she thinks she might chip them, her nails digging inside her palms painfully. She straightens up, shaking off Mermista and Micah's hands from her just so she can return Prime's stare, blue and amber holding sickly green.

"And to what do we owe the *pleasure* of your visit, Prime?" Catra asks, stone cold, that edge of sarcasm that characterizes her clear on her tone. Prime's smile falls, clearly displeased.

"I'm looking for something" Prime answers, not once taking his eyes from Catra's face. "It escaped from me a while ago and I've come to reclaim it"

Catra feels as if acid has been poured inside her veins, rotting her from the inside out. And she hates, she hates so much because she kissed Adora's cheek this morning and ran her fingers down the freckles in her back. She hates, because Adora is alive and bright and beautiful and free and Catra might just have to kill him. She will kill him.

"I believe I must let you know that hunting is absolutely prohibited on these waters, Mister Prime," Micah is saying next to Catra, his tone usually warm and welcoming edging a sharp, cold edge. But it doesn't matter because the only thing Prime does is chuckle under his breath, crossing his arms behind his back with a condescending look.

"Don't worry. What I'm looking for has no rights neither on water or land, chief Moon, so what I'll do with it won't represent an inconvenient to you"

Catra slams her teeth together, biting the inside of her cheek in the process, filling her teeth and the back of her throat with blood.

"I'm afraid I must insist," Micah cuts him off, voice grave. He has straightened up, standing in front of Catra with a pull of his shoulders. He is kind and goofy and a little bit short but he is also the chief biologist and he *is* a strong man. He will do what he must and everybody knows it. That's why the people respect him. "You are free to keep your yacht on the bay and to visit the town as much as you like but the waters are off the limits. *All* the waters."

Prime remains quiet, still only staring at Catra. Catra bites down the venom on her throat, fighting back the sting of tears from her eyes. She is feeling too much too quickly. The world has spinned under her feet from one moment to the other and the only thing keeping her steady on her feet right now is Adora's smell in her shirt.

"What is exactly that you do?" Catra questions and she is aware just how rude she would be if this was anyone else but a monster. The corners of Prime's mouth twitch.

"I am a collector, Miss Grayskull. Of all beautiful things," Prime lifts an eyebrow, "but sometimes beautiful things are unholy. Dangerous, you see. So it's better to keep them where they can be contained, where they can't threaten the purity of this world." He smiles again, tight against the skin of his face, eyes sparkling with something insane and Catra has never been more afraid in her entire life. "Every creature has a place in my collection, Miss Grayskull, no matter what they are."

Catra is going to kill him.

Mermista wraps her hand around Catra's forearm again and pulls, not gently, hard, motioning her backwards insistently.

"Let's go," Mermista says, loud enough that is not even the try of a whisper. When Catra doesn't move, she pulls even harder, guiding Catra across the square and back to the store. "Let's get outta here."

"I appreciate that you showed me around the town, chief Moon. I believe I have seen now just what I needed," Prime starts saying, following Catra with his sight even as he talks to Micah, who is very clearly fuming on his side, the veins of his forehead popping.

Before Mermista can bring Catra completely back to the store, Prime snaps his green eyes to her face, raising his voice just enough that it's crystal clear across the square. "I believe we will be seeing each other another time, miss Grayskull. You might just be the person to enjoy the collection I keep in my yacht," he says, the sun catching on the white of his teeth. "Please, in the meantime, do send my regards to your lovely wife."

Catra opens her mouth to scream but Mermista drags her inside immediately, almost violently, closing the back door of the store tightly behind them. They enter a tiny backroom, painted in light blue with a few chairs and a small table, quiet and clean.

Mermista rests her hands against the closed door, leaning her forehead over the cold surface with a heavy sigh. "Motherfucker," she spits under her breath.

Catra swings on her feet, suddenly lightheaded, the reduced space spinning in front of her eyes and suddenly she feels very close to throwing up inside her mouth. Mermista turns to one of the boxes, roaming inside it until she fetches a long bottle of tequila from it.

"Sit," she says, sharp and fast. Catra would have snapped any other day but not now. She lets herself fall on the cracking chair as Mermista grabs a single shot glass, filling it to the brim and placing it in front of Catra. "Drink this"

"I don't like alcohol," Catra says, almost automatically, wrinkling her nose. Mermista narrows her eyes, shaking her head.

"I don't care. You look like you are going to pass out. Drink it."

Catra makes a face but gives up, grabbing the glass and drinking it all out in one swing. If she is honest, she does feel like she is going to black out any moment now. The burnt of the alcohol makes her throat tingle and it helps tamper down a little the feeling that she is falling down, an old familiar feeling of darker times in her life that she has never wanted to go back to.

Mermista makes a sound with her throat, refilling Catra´s glass before taking a long sip of the liquor directly from the bottle, letting herself fall over the second chair with a huff. They remain silent for a long while, drinking from the bottle until Catra feels slightly less like she is about to have a panic attack and the room stops spinning. Mermista doesn't look at her but to a point on the wall, eyes hard.

“He arrived very early this morning. At dawn,” Mermista starts saying, still without looking at Catra. There is a scowl on her dark painted lips. “Sea Hawk saw the yacht when he was coming home from fishing. And he saw the boats, they were looking for something on the sea

past the lighthouse. I called Micah, he has been with them since then, but you weren't picking your phone."

Catra says nothing, grabbing the empty shot glass like a lifeline. She wasn't picking up her phone because she was in Adora´s arms and there was no other holy space she wished to be. The thread ring in her finger feels tighter against her skin. Mermista clicks her tongue against her teeth, finally turning to look at Catra´s pale face.

"So, what do you want to do?" she asks, leaning against the chair with her feet propped over the table. Catra´s eyebrows twitch, returning Mermista´s stare without understanding.

"What?"

"Now that he is here, what do you want to do?" Mermista repeats, resting her elbows over the surface of the table so she can look at Catra´s face better. "He threatened you, it was obvious. He *knows* who you are. What do you want to do?"

Catra looks at her dark eyes, weighing the unspoken knowledge that lives in them. Dread starts running down Catra´s back, her muscles locking again tightly, heartbeat raising as she starts to get really defensive really quickly. Catra grinds her teeth together, snapping the glass away from her so she can rest both of her palms over the table, leaning over it and towards Mermista´s face like a lioness about to jump, prey already in her line of sight. Mermista must notice the change immediately because her shoulders drop as well as her feet and she raises her hands above her face in a try of a calming motion.

"Relax"

"What do you think you know?" Catra questions her between her teeth, knocking the chair behind her when she rises to her feet.

"I'm not your enemy here"

"Then fucking answer me!" Catra finally shouts, slamming her closed fist against the table. She looks all kinds of wild, with her hair loose around her face like a mane and the rim of her eyes red and damp. She hadn't even noticed when she had started crying. Maybe from the beginning, maybe at some point in the middle, rolling down her cheeks the little traitors, staining her face in weakness.

Mermista cringes but doesn´t move away, still holding Catra´s stare in hers. There is a grimace in her mouth when she tilts her head, considering Catra for a moment before answering.

"I think you love her," Mermista says, it's honest, "and I think you need to be very careful."

Catra lets out a harsh, shivering breath and falls down into the chair, letting her face fall between her hands over the table. Mermista hums, serving another round of shots for both of them.

“I´ll help you in whatever you want to do next. I told you at the festival, I won't ask questions and I won´t judge.” She drowns down another glass in a single gulp. “I'm still up to wreck them if you want.”

You might just be the person to enjoy the collection I keep in my yacht, Miss Grayskull

Catra raises her head, staring at her open palms. Catrina Grayskull has never been one to bend herself to what others want, has never followed what others say but what she wishes. She ain't going to start now. Not about this, not because of him, not when Adora is in the fine line of it all. Catra would rather burn the world into pieces than sacrifice Adora. This is why she is here, this is why the ocean gave her Adora, so she could return her safe and happy and bright. This is Catra´s sacrifice for love.

Catra looks around the small room and then at the door that leads towards the store, snapping her sight back to Mermista with new found, desperate emotion. She is already looking back at her, waiting.

“I need Sea Hawk.”

Adora watches Catra's car park on the side of the house and rushes outside with a spring in her feet. Catra is barely walking out of the car seat when Adora basically crashes against her, all long legs and arms wrapping around her into a tight hug.

And it's just that Adora can't help herself around Catra. She is soft and so dear to Adora´s heart. Adora presses their cheeks together into a siren's kiss and then presses several others with her lips across Catra's cheekbones and neck, worshiping the loveliness of her face with tenderness. It's only when Adora reaches to kiss Catra's eyelids that she realizes she tastes like salt and that the skin below her eyes is slightly damp and that as hard as she tried to hide it, she had been crying.

Adora has come to understand with time that sometimes Catra has bad days and sometimes she has very bad days. Adora has them too, when the weight of the ocean out of her skin is too heavy, when the scar in her face is too visible, when she understands what happened and things weigh a little too much. On those days Catra cradles her against her chest or sinks inside the freezing cold water with her, her cheek against the bare skin of Adora´s back and shoulder, holding her above the weight of the land and the water. As much as Adora sometimes is self destructive and sad, Catra won´t let her drown. And Adora won´t let her sink either.

Adora makes a soft sound with her throat, nudging the side of Catra´s face with her nose before tending to her sadness with kisses. Who would have known that sea foam could fall in love this hard, this much.

Catra sobs - she can't help it, there is too much love on this - wrapping her around Adora´s chest and letting her hold her close, her face tucked on the angle of Adora´s neck. Adora

sometimes wonders if Catra realizes just how special she is, that she is something others aren't. Sometimes Adora wonders if Catra understands that Adora is lucky to be alive. That without her Adora would be long gone. Without her, Adora wouldn't have learnt what it is to step in soft sand and hard pebbles or dance against the cold kitchen floor or feel the rain and the snow on soft skin. That without her, Adora wouldn't have known what it is to love.

Catra has suffered so much pain that Adora sometimes fails to understand, pain that she can't carry for her. So much violence for someone that has always been so beautiful. Catra has always been worthy of all things beautiful even if she never could see it. Always worthy of being loved. Adora wonders if Catra understands the ocean loves her, that the sea and the sand and the shells and the sea foam and everything that makes Adora´s world loves her. That Adora loves her, beyond the villages and the rivers and the seas and every horizon that embraces the water at dust. Beyond the tides that swirl inside the waters that saw her be born. Beyond the pearl and the gold and glass of a skin, unworthy when compared to the shelter of Catra´s skin against hers.

Falling in love with Catra happened quietly. Like a flower falling on a river or a leaf into grass, the moon alongside the tide. A kind of song Adora didn't know until she fell in love.

Catra presses a kiss on the back of Adora's neck and steps back, running a hand through her face to try and shy the tear tracks away. Adora raises her hands, frown furrowed. She wants to ask what has happened, what she can do to help, but Catra shakes her head very softly, grabbing Adora's hands between hers and lowering them down gently.

Catra's nose is pink from the crying and there are spots of red in her cheeks, beautiful eyes still swimming in sorrow. Catra extends her hand, grabbing a strand of Adora's hair between her fingers, rolling it carefully until it curls below Adora's ribs gently.

"Your hair is longer," Catra murmurs, her voice raspy and hoarse. Adora frowns deeper, chewing on the inside of her cheek nervously. Catra sees her because she rests her open palm against the side of Adora's face, stroking for a few minutes from the cheekbone to the shell of Adora's ear, gently washing the anxiety away. "Did you find something you want to wear to the party?"

Adora bites on her bottom lip, staring at Catra's beautiful face for a few seconds before nodding, hesitating still. Catra smiles, very little and very tired, nothing like the kind of smiles she had been giving Adora for the last weeks, so bright they shine on the room like the very sun. Adora watches as her gaze drifts from her face to the sea beyond their home, looking at the waters as if she was scared of something.

Adora's heartbeat picks up, quick inside her chest, and she wants to ask, *What has happened? My love, why are you sad?* But Catra just bumps their foreheads together , very gently guiding Adora inside the house, her hand firm on the base of Adora's back.

"Show me then, hermosa," Catra says, her voice slightly strangled. "I'll help you with your hair."

They walk barely a few feet before Adora digs her ankles on the boards of the porch and turns around, cradling Catra inside her arms again, tight against her chest as if that could keep

them away from being apart, her song rising in the base of her throat, reassuring and calming like the silence before a storm.

Catra sighs into the embrace, shivering when Adora presses a kiss on the base of her earlobe and the angle of her jaw. She still smells like salt and sorrow and Adora buries her face of her soft curls and tries to bite back the feeling that their world might be blurring a little bit on the edges.

Adora wears Catra´s mother's dress. It's the only belonging that remained in the house, besides books and pictures. A single piece of silk of a peach so tender it almost looks pink against Adora´s skin, held to her shoulders by thin straps, old fashioned enough to have a lace trail embroidered with pearls and which open neck doesn't have the right to cling to Adora´s collarbones in that way. Catra almost feels nervous because Adora looks like a bride herself and not like any other guest, but then again, Adora would look like a lotus flower with anything she had chosen anyway.

Adora asks if it's alright about ten times while Catra fights to follow the instructions of a video to pick up her honey hair into a pretty decent style. And Catra has to reassure her almost as many times as she asks, mouth full of hairpins with pearl ends until she finally manages to hold everything into gentle curls above Adora´s head, the baby hair of her temples curling gently above her ears.

“I´m not going to wear it and you look beautiful in it,” Catra says, ears bright red, tucking her own silk shirt inside her pants, feeling a little bit like a sack of potatoes next to Adora, who even sitting, barefoot over the kitchen counter, looks like an angel loose into earth. Adora smiles through the reflection of the living room´s mirror and Catra´s heart jumps into her chest and flutters outside her body in spots of red in her face.

Catra scratches Melog´s little head and tries to tame her hair before going outside, driving them both towards the Bright-Moon household before the sun sets. Catra takes the longer path, outside the town avoiding the bay and the streets, the windows shut down and the radio quiet. Adora does not mention it but she quietly wraps her arm around her elbow and rests her head over Catra´s shoulder, watching the meadows and green hills pass by in silence.

By the time they make it to the place it's almost night and there are already many people inside. Pretty much the entire town is there, if not that all of it actually. The entire manor is lightened up and the doors of the huge garden are open from side to side, illuminated by garden lights and paper lamps held in tall metal cords above their heads. Catra had always known Glimmer´s family was kind of over the top but after the third fountain she can count from her seat on the car she thinks it might just be disgustingly beyond that.

Catra scans the sea of people and exhales hard through her nose, gripping the wheel almost too tight. She knows what she is looking for, white uniforms, white suits, so bright they look like a mockery of a shell, with prying green eyes looking to rip Catra´s world apart. But she doesn't find any of that. Everyone is wearing clear colors, per request of the invitation it was more than obvious Glimmer had designed, but they are pinks, and blues and pale greens or

grays, like sea reefs of people Catra has come to know. There are no strangers or hunters there.

Adora brushes the tip of her fingers over her whitened knuckles, calling for her attention gently. Her face is peaceful and bright when Catra turns to look at her, completely relaxed, unaware of the dark shadow that looms over her, just sitting there waiting for Catra to come back into herself. Catra lets go of the wheel and laces her hand with Adora´s instead, studying the people coming inside the garden before sighing heavily.

“Alright, let's go.” Catra helps Adora clip her shoes and they walk towards the entrance side by side, Catra´s arm thrown around Adora´s waist, keeping her close. Catra is wearing boots and yet Adora keeps being taller, watching marveled at the fairy lights hanging from the bushes.

The gardens are dressed to impress, long roads of cypress circled by bushes of hydrangeas in full blooms, blue and yellow and lilac. The fountains are lightened up with their own light but the stream of water is turned off, letting the candles propped over the surface of the water float calmly. The dance floor is of gray marble, polished so perfectly that it almost looks like a mirror reflecting the lamps and the stars above. Close to the stairs that lead to the manor there is a platform with musicians already playing and on the opposite side a large table filled to the rim with desserts all perfectly placed, a huge wedding cake as the centerpiece decorated witg even more flowers and unnecessary gold sheets.

It is, in all, a perfect display of wealth. Catra would be kind of sick of the richness of it all if it wasn't for the fact that she knows the Bright-Moon family are actually pretty decent people, and because the moment Catra and Adora step inside the gardens, every single person turns their heads to look at them. To look at Adora. Some people widen their eyes, following their steps as they make their way to the main garden. Others even have the nerve to gape, mouths wide open, marveled murmurs following them like shadows, every other sound of chattering and even the music lowering down as everyone turns to watch Adora walk by.

At first, Catra thinks Adora doesn´t notice, but when the latter shifts softly on her feet and gets just slightly closer to Catra´s side, she realizes it´s not true. Her shoulders and cheeks are tinted in shy pink and she is fidgeting with the skirt of her dress, looking everywhere but to the people around them. So Catra tightens her hold on her waist and guides her gently across the garden, fighting the urge to growl at everyone on her way. There is no ill meant intention behind any of them after all.

They manage to make it to the dance floor exactly by the time the band starts a new piece, old fashioned romantic music filling the entire place, barely above the happy chattering of the people. Most are already eating, carrying little plates with tiny desserts that would have Entrapta delighted if they were there.

“Do you want to eat something?” Catra asks to Adora´s ear, making herself hear over the noise. Adora´s ear turns red immediately but she nods eagerly, her eyes already fixed on the food. Catra chuckles under her breath, trying to find the best path to walk around the dance floor and not across. It doesn´t help them much because she must have seen them walk in, as everyone else did, exclaiming loudly.

“Finally!” Glimmer rushes down the stone stairs, tapping on the marble floor with her silver heels. She is wearing a lilac dress that brushes the floor and she has cut her hair even shorter, bright pink and held to the side of her face with star pings. She kind of looks like the hydrangeas she is carrying on her hands too, the pearl earrings catching on the fairy lights. “Late as always!”

Catra arches her eyebrow, staring at Glimmer´s face with sharp eyes. Her makeup is impeccable and her hair is nearly plastic perfect and she always kind of looks like she is going to lose her shit any second now. “Stressed much, Sparkles? You look kind of… pink” Catra asks, grinning. Glimmer drags her eyes towards Catra almost like one of those serial killers of the movies, just slightly too open and wide to be normal at all. She definitely looks like she is going to scream.

“I´m going to kick your ass so hard you are going to get expelled from the garden, Catra, shut the fuck up.”

Catra covers her mouth with her free hand and snorts, eyebrows shot up on her forehead with the impression. Even Adora next to her huffs with surprise, her mouth stretching into a smile.

“Wow, I didn't think it would actually get a rise of you”

“I said shut up”

“ *Are you alright?”* Adora asks. The thin rings she is wearing on her long fingers twinkle a little when she signs, one on each finger except the one that carries Catra's ring.

“I am, Thank you very much for asking, Adora,” Glimmer answers with a deep breath, making a point on the thank you as she throws a sideways look at Catra. Catra just pokes her tongue out to her, rolling her eyes when Glimmer returns the gesture. “I´m just in charge of the entire party tonight, the banquet people arrived late, all of them, and there is a leak on the main pipes of the fountains so I had them turn down and pray they don't blow up, so I´m a little tiny bit on the edge right now.” Glimmer says, so quick the words trip with each other, her voice tone slightly too high, like a bird getting strangled.

“Ah, I see,” Catra murmurs around a laugh, quiet only by Glimmer´s sharp finger towards her face.

“I told you, don´t start,” Glimmer runs her hands down the skirt of her dress, closing her eyes and breathing deeply several times before looking up again. “How do I look?”

Catra is about to say something witty but Adora beats her to it. “ *Like a distressed seal?”*

Catra bursts into laughter, bending on herself with her cackles when she turns around and sees Adora is wearing the biggest shit eating grin she has ever seen her before. Glimmer looks between them with a progressively more unimpressed stare, between Catra's ugly snort and Adora's fake innocent eyes, her mouth twitching into a grimace.

"You two are insufferable together, why did I invite you?"

"Because you can't have a good party without us, Sparkles," Catra says, wriggling her eyebrows. Glimmer groans, rolling her eyes, but it's clear that even her is trying not to stare too hard at Adora.

"I beg to differ," Glimmer looks around them, catching her parents walking through the garden next to them, already greeting the guests. "Mom, dad! Over here!"

Glimmer catches their attention, swings her arms above her head overly excited. Angela and Micah hear her immediately, faces slipping into huge smiles when they see Catra and Adora standing in front of their daughter.

"Girls! So glad you could make it to our little celebration!" Micah says, obviously completely joyful. He smiles at them but doesn't rush to shake their hands or hug them and Catra silently thanks him. She already feels too much on the edge.

Angella is more quiet, looking at both of them with a gentle, pleased smile. She is tall, really tall, beating even Adora's height by a couple of inches, posture strong and straight but also gentle. Her gaze lingers a little longer on Adora but not too much as to feel invasive, and her small, classy grin widens into a full smile when she sees the rope rings in her fingers, the corners of her eyes wrinkling with softness.

"Thank you so much for coming, both of you look beautiful," Angella says, her accent thick. Adora blushes a little, squeezing Catra softly to her side.

" *We like parties,"* Adora signs, completely honest and cheerful. " *And food"*

Micah and Angella huff a wholehearted laugh. Micah has his arm around Angella's, matching pearl earrings and matching lilac suits, hydrangeas also clipped on Micah's pocket and Angella's hair. They look extremely elegant, both of them, every inch like this party is for them.

Micah is also looking at them very gently, weighing his words carefully. "If you ever decide to have a party of.your own we would be most delighted to assist, and to help you with anything you need. Isn't it, darling?"

"Of course yes," Angella agrees immediately, sharing the same tender stare full of silent meaning.

Adora tilts her head against Catra's and smiles, blinking curiously and obviously a bit lost with the theme here but happy to listen anyway. Catra, however, feels her stomach sink to her feet, the corner of her eyes itching with tears already threatening to slip down. Maybe it is the romantic old fashioned music, or the loving and honest stare of their friends, or the fact that Adora already looks like a bride in her arms. Or maybe that the world is fucked up and has suddenly get even more fucked up now, but Catra has to gulp down a knot on her throat, snapping her eyes away from the people around her and back into the crowded gardens.

Angella must feel Catra's anxiety because she clears her throat, turning to Adora. "We'll be cutting the cake until after the dance but I would love to share some desserts with you if you like."

Adora's face brightens even more, jumping a little on her feet and nodding. Catra let's go off her reluctantly, brushing her hips nervously and looking at the gardens and back at her Adora catches Catra's nervous stare and grins, leaning to press a reassuring kiss on her cheek before walking with Angella and Micah, tripping just once on the shoes.

Glimmer squeezes closer to Catra when the rest leave, getting a hang of two glasses of champagne and offering her one. Carts takes a small sip, feeling the small bubbles popping against her cheeks. She sees as Adora approaches the table alongside Angela and Micah, taking a bite of every single dessert she lies her eyes on, giggling under her breath at some occurrence Micah says. The low cut of the dress shows the expanse of her back, glittering a little under the purple and blue lights.

Glimmer takes two long sips of her drink, staring at Catra over the rim of the glass. "My dad … he told about your encounter in the morning with that man"

Catra freezes in the middle of drinking, holding her breath.

"He is not here, don't worry. My dad made sure that he stayed away," Glimmer bumps her shoulder against Catra's, trying to rest the whole thing of importance. "He was very tense too but it seems that man has stayed on his stupid fucking yacht for now."

Catra closes her mouth, breathing hard through her nose. Her mind is spiraling again. She doesn't want to think about it, doesn't want to duel. Her mind and her chest is already crushed with the weight. She just wants to have this moment with Adora, just this one.

"Does she know?" Glimmer asks and it's low and kind enough that it is barely above a whisper.

"Glimmer," Catra snaps, also low, not a growl but *pleading.*

Glimmer's eyes widen in surprise at Catra's tone, watching her for the first time. Catra's cheeks are pale, almost sickening so, and her eyes, usual bright when around Adora, are sunken and tired, slightly red in the rim. Glimmer gulps, stepping back a little so she can look at Catra fully, the sheer sweat on her forehead and the way her usual upright and proud stand is slightly bent forward, like she could barely hold herself straight.

Glimmer worries her bottom lip against her teeth, suddenly at a loss of words. She has never seen Catra like this before, so lost beyond the usual well collected and self confident facade of hers, barely holding herself around Adora for her sake. It's heartbreaking to see.

"Listen, I know you don't like talking about that night with me, or with anyone. I get it, alright? But whether you like it or not, we are your friends and we worry about you. Both of you." Catra narrows her eyes, tears spilling softly down the corners, and looks away, back to Adora. Glimmer softens her voice, stretching her hand towards Catra without actually touching her, hesitating. When Catra doesn't flinch, she places her hand over her forearm, just laying there, a calming touch.

"None of us could ever know what happened that night and I'm not going to push it, but you are scared and Adora got hurt that day. I … I just think she deserves to know what is going

on, for both of your sakes," Glimmer tries to look for Catra's eyes but she avoids her, dragging the back of her hand almost angrily across her tearful eyes. "She adores you, it's disgustingly obvious for anyone watching. I don't think she would want you to carry all of it on your own."

"You don't understand what you are talking about, Sparkles," Catra differs but her voice is defeated instead of annoyed, leaning her head against one of the pillars of the garden.

Glimmer frowns sadly, following Catra's line of sight towards Adora. She kind of looks like a tulip's bloom, tall and handsome, the free curls of her hair that fall around her face framing it perfectly. She isn't even wearing any makeup, naturally breathtaking on her own. But there is also a small nervous jump of her feet as she stands next to Glimmer's parents, she bites the inside of her cheek quite often and her nose wrinkles when she doesn't understand something, watercolor eyes drawn to Catra every once in a while, when she thinks she isn't looking at her, anxious to come back to her side.

"I understand love is about sharing the weight." Glimmer says in the end. Catra grunts, crossing her arms over her middle in a self reassuring embrace. "Catra…"

"No," Catra snaps, cutting, shivering but sure. Her hands are in fists but they are trembling considerably by her sides. "No. I promised I would look out for her, and no matter what happens that's what I'm going to do. *I'm* going to fix it. Alright? Just… if you want to help, help me keep her safe, *please."* Catra runs her hands over her hair, trying to calm herself. "She is too kind and too fucking gentle for her own good, she is going to end up doing something stupid to try and take the fall and is going to end up hurting herself. So please, do this one thing for me, Sparkles, and help me protect her."

Glimmer has never seen Catra like this, not once, not even when she first arrived in town and she looked broken, hurt by life beyond her control. Quickly, Glimmer realizes this is something that goes beyond her reach too, and it both makes her incredibly tender and abismal sad. Glimmer loves Bow, she is going to marry that man sooner or later, but this is some kind of love that runs deeper. Pretty quickly Glimmer realizes this is the love she used to read about in her fairytale books when she was little, the kind that carries sacrifice and loyalty and happiness beyond world and profound sadness. The kind of love that transcends. This is a kind of love Glimmer can't understand, but that she can help protect, even just a little, for the sake of love itself, so that's exactly what she will do.

Glimmer sighs, eyes hard, her own chest heavy with Catra's words but nods anyway, squeezing Catra's elbow gently before letting go. They stay still for a few seconds and then Glimmer surges forward, wrapping Catra into a tight hug. She kind of embraces for a lick on the shin or a loud, offended groan, but none of them ever come. Catra tenses for a good long second and then breaks down, sinking into Glimmer's embrace with a defeated exhale.

They remain like this for a long while until a soft clear of the throat calls back for their attention again. Angella, Micah and Adora are back, enjoying the last bites of some kind of glittering silver cupcake, giggling lightheartedly between them. Glimmer and Catra step apart, the latter cleaning her eyes quickly with the sleeve of her shirt.

Adora is already looking at her too, all soft eyes and no sense of decorum, ignoring the others as she walks to Catra immediately, cradling her jaw between her slightly sugar sticky hands, pressing her nose against Catra's into a kiss.

"Hey you," Catra murmurs, a little muffled, resting her palms over Adora's cold elbows. "You smell like bread"

Adora hums and smiles, wrapping her arms under Catra's ribs and lifting her on her tippy toes, ignoring shamelessly Catra's protests as she starts pressing a myriad of loud kisses all over Catra's face, jaw and neck, frustratingly sweet until Adora is smothering her in them and Catra is giggling out loud, face red by the kisses and the laughter.

Micah and Angella share a knowing look and a smile, Glimmer bites the inside of her cheeks and tries to hide her rising anxiety with a roll of her eyes, looking around in time to see Bow by the band's platform, motioning a signal with a huge smile.

"Oh, oh! It's time for the dance!" Glimmer announces brightly, leaving her glass by a small table so she can spin her parents around and guide them towards the floor swiftly, barely giving them time to react at all. "Mom, dad, you open! We'll follow after. Come on, come on! Now! And I want to see you two in there too!" Glimmer adds with no space for fight, pointing at Adora and Catra, still tangled inside Adora's arms and kisses on her ear.

"Sure, Sparkles," Catra says, out of breath by the sudden attack but with her tone back to her usual self. She seems to consider something for a few quick seconds, absently running her fingers in the nape of Adora's neck as she thinks. "I think… maybe we should meet tomorrow at Mermista's. You and Arrows and us, like, you know."

Glimmer gasps, covering her mouth with her hands in an exaggerated motion to Catra's proposal. "You mean what I think you mean?!"

"Don't. Ugh, forget it"

"Like a double date?!"

"Yeah, yeah, like a double date, whatever you want to call it." Catra says, rolling her eyes. Her hold on Adora tightness. "I have run an errand about the book in the evening but I think you three might like some time to meet each other or whatever."

"Aw, Catra, we really are friends now, aren't we?"

"Don't you have some musicians to bother or something?"

"Fine, then. You are off the hook for now," Glimmer says with a cheeky smile before running at full force through the floor and actually to the musicians, an honestly impressive endeavor on those shoes.

People are starting to gather around the limits of the dance floor, some with a few glasses of champagne others eating or chattering, all of them watching excited as the music starts to

play Micah and Angella's wedding song, both of them walking to the center of the scene between a shower of soft petals and people clapping cheerfully.

Micah wraps his arms around Angella's waist and Angela over his shoulder, dancing through never forgotten steps of the first dance they had years ago at their actual wedding. It's kind of precious and lighthearted, a nice display of love after so many years and endeavors together.

With the guest's attention pulled towards the dance floor, Catra and Adora stay back, lingering by the bushes full of flowers. Adors keeps pretty much ignoring the whole thing, party forgotten in order to embrace Catra tight inside her arms. Catra rests her chin over Adora's bare shoulder with a huff, feeling ridiculously tiny inside Adora's embrace.

"Are you playing starfish today, dummy?" Catra asks, praying that her voice doesn't sound as shaky as she feels. Adora hums and nods a little in answer and dives her face deeper into Catra's shoulder, without letting go.

Catra sighs, defeated, running the tip of her fingers down the expanse of Adora's back. They are a bit further inside the garden, here, the music is slightly muffled but Catra can still see the dance floor through the branches of the cypresses. Catra's eyes roam around them, catching on a tall bush next to them, where the flowers have started to crawl over the trees. Still held by Adora, Catra stretches her arm, managing to pick a few of the prettiest flowers, lilac and blue, just so she can start placing them above the pins on Adora's hair.

Catra is almost done with the flowers when Adora steps back slightly, enough so she can search Catra's face with her silver eyes, thousands of unasked questions clear inside them. Catra's heart makes a jump and sinks, suddenly extremely nervous.

She has the right to know, Glimmer has said, even if she didn't understand the actual depth to which that truth ran. Adora blinks down at Catra, tall and beautiful as a goddess statue, all peach colors and pearls and pink blush over her cheeks and Catra can't do it, she just can't.

"I needed that, thank you princess" Catra whispers instead, and she is not lying. Every time Adora touches her Catra thinks she is going to cry.

Adora raises her hands and sings quickly, placing one of Catra's curls behind her ear right after. *"I'm here with you"*

"I know," Catra places her palm over Adora's hand, cradling it against her cheek. She does know, that's why she is so scared. Catra points towards the dance floor, mustering a smile. "Want to dance, princess? You are too pretty to be hiding in the bushes here with me"

Adora rolls her eyes, placing her other hand in Catra's opposite cheek and then pinching them both swiftly, making Catra squeak.

" *Have you seen yourself?"* Adora signs, pointing at Catra's shirt, open to her ribs, and the hem of her pants. Catra knows those pants make her ass look incredible that's exactly why she wore them. Catra grins, shit eating, shaking her hips a little to riddle Adora further. She likes this better, the easy banter between them. At least for now it lets her breathe a little bit easier.

Adora huffs and grabs Catra's hand, spinning her in her place suddenly. Catra laughs, surprised, tumbling towards the main garden behind Adora. The dance floor is already full of people dancing with each other, following the rhythm of the music around them.

Catra guides them towards the center, close to where Glimmer is spinning around already in Bow's hand. Glimmer sees them finally joining in and grins from ear to ear, shaking her head.

Catra grabs Adora's right hand between hers, wrapping her other arm around her waist to bring her closer, starting to swing from side to side as she follows the music. Adora's bright eyes flicker for a moment there, looking to the floor with a frown.

"What 's wrong?" Catra asks, following her eyes without understanding what she is seeing. Adora stops their dancing and slips her hand away to sign.

" *I hear water"* Adora wrinkles her nose, looking around them.

"Water?"

A heartbeat passes and then every single pipe of the fountains around them gives up and blows. Water shoots strongly towards the sky, bursting like a geyser, and then falls down immediately, raining over the entire gardens and soaking it everything immediately.

Some guests yelp, other's gasp, soaked from head to toe by the water. The paper lamps survive miraculously but the dance floor starts to flow pretty quickly, slipping inside everyone's shoes. Someone has the good thought of covering the food and musicians barely make it out of the water, laughing the entire way as they place their instruments in the stairs instead of the now wet platform.

Glimmer kind of screams and kind of curses like a sailor out loud, gripping Bow's forearm to try and not fall spectacularly. She doesn't even have it in herself to get mad because Now ends up slipping anyway and falling down over the water, dragging Glimmer down with him in a fit of laughter. Micah and Angella stand still in the middle of the main garden, their hairs sticking to their faces, makeup running down a little, still in the middle.of a dance step. They look at each other and then at Glimmer and Bow and then back at each other, breaking down immediately into loud snorts of laughter. Everything is kind of ridiculous, mind blowing ridiculous and their clothes are ruined and the water is fresh, reflecting rainbows over their head where the dew touches the fairy lights.

There is nothing wrong in something ridiculous, on something going wrong, on something imperfect. Life isn't about being perfect, it's about being imperfect with the right people.

Catra sputters, running her hands across her face to get out some of the water from her eyes. Around her some people are rushing to find some shelter in the patio, though it is a lost battle already, dresses and suits already beyond salvation from the water. Others remain standing in the dance floor, joining the laughter, holding to each other as they watch incredulous the sudden rain falling over their heads.

For a couple of scary seconds, Catra looks around her and can't find Adora among the spray of the water and the rest of the guests. She turns around, heart on her throat, already beating herself up for having taken her eyes from her for just a second, until she sees her, barely a few feet away in front of her. Her shoes are long gone, lost somewhere in the party. All her hair has come undone, falling heavily down her back, her temples and shoulders, petals of lilacs soaked hanging from the strands like little bells of colors. Her dress is soaked through, clinging to the skin of her waist and thighs as she picks up the hem of the skirt, stepping over the overflown floor where the water brushes her ankles, obviously delighted by the whole thing, the most beautiful smile painted on her face. Standing like this in the middle of the dance floor she looks like a nymph, smiling down at the flowers of the ruined decorations floating above the water before looking up, directly at Catra's face, Adora's smile bright and beautiful, completely sincere.

Catra feels robbed from her breath, clenching to her chest when a pang of emotion almost stabs her in the heart, knowing that, if it had been any other moment, it would have been this. This is the moment where Catra would have asked Adora to marry her.

So, instead, she is going to let her go.

Adora seems to always be able to read her from the inside out, without words, even when she doesn't know, even when she doesn't understand. She approaches Catra with slow steps, her legs breaking on the fresh water easily, quick, until she is right in front of Catra, slipping her cold hands in hers so she can bring them towards her face, placing a kiss in the skin there.

Catra gasps, and it's almost a sob. She must look like a wet cat right now and yet Adora touches her so gently, so lovingly, eyes never leaving hers, as if Adora couldn't find anything more beautiful than Catra - she can't - anything she could adore more.

Catra takes her hands away from Adora's hold, just enough so she can wash away the swiftly disappointed look on Adora's eyes by cradling her face inside her hands instead. Catra holds Adora's face between her palms, carrying her watercolor eyes with hers so she knows Adora is listening intently to what Catra wants to say. And she wants to say so much and yet she can't bring herself to because Catra Grayskull is a liar and a selfish fool and she fell in love.

"I love you, Adora," Catra says instead of all the other words she *needs* to say. She can feel the way Adora goes soft in her embrace so Catra holds her tighter, eyes locked together. Catra needs to say this, Catra needs to make sure Adora knows she is wanted, that she is adored too. That Catra would die for her. That Catra adores her. "I love you, alright? No matter what"

Adora smiles, very tiny, almost shy, and under the lights of the garden her eyes look damp for a very different reason than the fountains breaking down. Adora caresses Catra's chin with the tips of her fingers for a long second before surging forward, pressing a kiss on her open mouth, right there in the middle of everything and everyone, open and honest and full of silent meaning, and maybe for a second on this celebration they are brides here, on this sacred space below the spray of water.

Catra shivers inside the kiss, wrapping her hands on Adora's wet hair, bringing her as close as she possibly can.

There is still fountain water pouring into the dance floor and the guests are pretty much soaked completely as they make their way back into the floor, dancing under the night rain. The musicians start to play again, slow and old fashioned, delightfully romantic. Familiarity, friendship. Joy and laughter and love are present everywhere right now but specially on the young women holding each other at the center of the garden. Everybody sees them, everybody smiles for them.

There are flowers precariously hanging from Adora's hair and Catra runs her hands to place them over Adora's lower back as the latter rests her arms over Catra's shoulders, foreheads leaned against each other, nose brushing, clothes sticking to their bodies and dripping wet while they swing from side to side gently, following their own kind of music.

And if scales sprout in Adora's cheeks and shoulders and shimmer with the paper lamps and the people of the town see them nobody says anything at all.

There is some kind of holy secrecy about love, after all.



Their last day together is beautiful, but neither of them know that yet.

Adora wakes up and she is happy. The sky is clear and the weather is candid, pink and lilac from dawn, with the sound of the waves washing their shore calmly.

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Adora wakes up and she is happy and because she is happy she turns around and awakes Catra with kisses, between her eyebrows and down the bridge of her nose and across her freckles and around her ribs and between her legs, until Catra is awake and is happy too, giggling though still drowsy and then full alert and shivering and panting as Adora thrust her long fingers in and out of her, exquisitely slow, making love to her until the pink turns into midday golden and her eyes are sea glasses.

And because the day is perfectly beautiful and Adora's nose has always been fine and she is deeply in love, Adora lowers Catra into the edge of the bed, following a trial of musky smell, running her teeth over Catra's feverish skin until she presses her mouth against her wetness for minutes or hours more, drinking in Catra's excitement and release. Adora's opens against her slit and her tingue rolls out, watering, licking, lapping at Catra's damp lips, pressing the flat and cold surface against the shivering skin and then inside, until the Catra is gripping at the soft sheets, arching from the bed with her legs shaking over Adora's shoulders and gasp in her throat.

Adora turns Catra around, gently, with tender hands and even more tender kisses on the curves of her hips, careful not to overwhelm her, she is already trembling like a leaf, lowering Catra's chest down over the mattress so she is laying over her belly, making sure her face nestled in pillows and she is loose and soft like a flower bloom before rising up her bottom from the sheets, knees digging in the bed.

It's the first time Adora has taken Catra like this, in such a vulnerable and open position, with her breasts against Catra's back and her lips behind her neck, but it does something for both of them. Adora can barely contain herself at the sight of her because without words Catra is trusting her with something so vulnerable, trusting her blindly with the most delicate, sacred part of her body, no restrains, no fears, open to let Adora do as she wishes because she trusts her this much and Adora feels like she is going to cry and giggle at just how much she loves her.

Like this, Adora can embrace Catra completely, left arm around her naked waist, cold lips against the low of her back. This way she can run her fingers and the heel of her hand, coated in clear release, over her damp slit, already wet with excitement, gently prepping her up, caressing her pink, soft lips and then past them the tender, warm walls of her body, until Catra is kneading the sheets, whimpering loudly over the pillows in protest and silent plead.

Adora lines up and gently starts thrusting inside Catra while cradling her against her chest, careful the entire time, barely holding back the need inside her body. Adora is soft at first - frustratingly slow, making sure nothing hurts, that is nothing is too much. The position, the penetration, the hold - and then hard, when they are as close as possible and Catra's hips are making little impatient circles. Relentless, unstoppable as the sea.

Exhale. Inhale. In. Out. In, in.

Kissing Catra's cheeks again and again when sweat and tears start to spill from her eyes and her nose goes stuffy and red by the sheer intimacy of what they are doing.

Adora makes reassuring sounds to check on her love and Catra answers them in kind, beyond words, long gone inside the pleasure and the fog inside her mind. Her voice is long gone, moans tiny and high pitched, little songs for Adora filling the entire room.

At some point Catra turns her head to the opposite wall of the window and makes a sound that shakes Adora's entire body, a song beautiful enough to rival a siren's song. She follows Catra's misted sight and finds her own reflection looking back, clear on the wall length mirror they had placed there, with the golden frame and the polished surface. Adora can see herself but her sight drives immediately to Catra, covered in a light sweat, her face, shoulders, neck and collarbones red. The bare expression in her face - mouth open slightly agape, the edge of her teeth visible under her kiss bitten dark lips, cheeks rosy, hair tousled to the side, gasping and panting over the pillows, looking back at Adora, the scales coating her shoulders, her long ears, the hair loose across her back, like she was the very sun above her - makes Adora lose her mind a little bit, trusting deeper and harder, hitting a point inside Catra she had never reached before and that almost makes Adora tether and fall.

Catra makes a small, surprised sound, hiccups of pleasure leaving her mouth with each deep thrust. Catra loses the grip of her tired knees and falls softly on her left side, her arms cradled against her own red chest, still facing the mirror completely. Adora follows her, never leaving her side, covering Catra's body with hers as their hips slap with each dive. Catra is so wet already Adora might as well be swimming inside of her, an entire ocean for her to cherish. The sounds would be obscene if the whole thing wasn't driven by sheer love, and she smells so good, salt and love making gripping into her dark golden skin.

Adora presses a kiss between Catra's shoulder blades and runs her cold hand through Catra's forehead, slicking her dark curls, damp with sweat, back and off her face. She can feel the heat building up there and thinks Catra might be getting a little bit of a fever but she doesn't stop, Catra would hate her, pressing her lips against her jaw instead into a tender kiss, up and down the base of her ear and then into the secret spot right below her chin. Catra whimpers with the touch and Adora realizes she is fighting to keep her eyes open, fixed on the point where their bodies meet through the mirror. The turquoise and gold of her eyes, usually sharp and quick, are completely misted over, way beyond her limit. It's then that Adora realizes Catra is giving her everything, all of it, completely.

Adora lets out a loud gasp, followed by a grunt. She presses her lips and sharp teeth hard against Catra's cheekbone, her hand still gripping her forehead, the other one brushing past Catra's goosebump raised breasts and her fluttering belly, diving into the triangle between her legs and then around the hidden pearl Adora loves. The motion makes Catra gasp and jump into the perfect angle, perfectly beautiful, just enough that Adora slips even deeper until there is nowhere else to go.

Catra feels it and Adora does too because they come undone together, melting around each other so much and so hard they drip into the sheets, wet like the sea. Catra buries her head against the mattress and whimpers, exhaling a moan, voice raspy and hiccuping as her release peaks and follows Adora's, up, up and then down, into the most perfect drift, like diving into a perfectly calm sea. Adora dives her mouth tight against Catra's ear and sings, about how much she loves her, her name, her love again, a siren song that should drive humans mad but that makes Catra and only her feel safe as she comes down from the soul crushing ecstasy of it all.

Adora slips out, still perfectly gently, absolutely tender, almost shy of the way slick and release drips out of her love and down her freckled thighs and it makes Catra shiver from head to toe. Adora rolls on her side until she is resting over the mattress in front of Catra, cradling her tight against her chest, covering her line of sight towards the mirror because she knows. She knows just how deep Catra's subspace can run, a whole world of sensations, of free roaming thoughts, of secret feelings. Knows how quickly touching, feeling, *seeing* herself like this can become too much too quick. Vulnerability is something very important and very sacred to Catra. Seeing herself like this, so openly vulnerable, raw, given, *taken,* can scare her so Adora shields her from it, always singing, always holding her and what she has given her close.

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They lay next to each other like this for a while, until Catra's breathing finally settles down, still warm from head to toe. Yet she doesn't speak yet, still a little bit out of herself, still too raw in the edges. She feels perfectly fine in her silence. Loved, taken care of, and Adora complies to it happily, joyful in being able to tend to her love when she needs her, completely devoted to her in every way possible. She has come to understand about herself that she finds more joy and comfort in giving and taking care of than in receiving. Sometimes or most times it frustrates Catra, Adora knows, but not today. Today, this just as it is, is important for both of them.

Adora stares at Catra the whole time, eyes soft, wrinkling in the corners with tenderness, running the back of her temples against her temples and cheekbones, whispering sweet reassurances and love words on her mother tongue and caressing the warm skin of her hips and sides as Catra's eyes flutter closed, slowly coming back into her body.

After a while, Adora carries Catra in her arms and towards the bathroom, running a cool towel over Catra's flushed face before stepping inside the bath. They take a shower together, the mostly cold spray tampering down Catra's love making fever. Adora helps her wash her hair and brush out the tangles, Catra's arms wrapped around her neck, her face nestled over Adora's collarbones. Adora rubs Catra's shoulders and waist, tampering down the sore pull of the muscles there, pressing closed lips kisses over the love bruises and red spots, fluttering, barely touching her at all, caressing her legs and tampering down the puffy and pink skin of her core as she helps her feel clean and fresh again.

They dry and then dress each other. Perfectly domestic, perfectly happy. Adora still refuses to wear shoes and she envelopes Catra in her favorite robe, made with patches of mismatched blue fabrics that Adora sewed herself because she knew Catra liked to feel embraced by something, even if she never said it out loud, especially after something so strongly intimate like they had just done. Adora can still feel the aftershocks running through Catra's body when she embraces her close.

If Adora had known, she would have never let them leave the safe embrace of their bedroom. If Adora had known, she would have laid with her love the entire day, her entire life, here, happy to live inside this dream, inside this life. Making love and kissing and singing. If she had known she would have refused to go to town to meet their friends. If Adora had known, she would have nailed the windows shut and wrapped herself around Catra's limbs and refused to leave her ever again.

But she doesn't know. Not even Catra knows. Nobody could have known so Adora joyfully kisses Catra's sweet mouth in the kitchen, under the golden light of the midday sun, and lets her go.

"You laugh now, but it's been an absolute nightmare to clean everything today. At least we managed to fix the problem so there is no more water leaking but seriously," Glimmer makes a motion of cleaning her ear with her pinky, grimacing. "I think I still have water on my ears."

Bow snickers around a bite of his food, the cuffs of his jeans still wet after working too on picking up the wreck that the fountains incident had left behind. In all, the party had been an absolute unique success, so besides a stuffy nose, Glimmer is not one to complain.

Adora hums a laugh and keeps devouring her second plate of food, cheeks stuffed, the fish and fried potatoes long gone as she excitedly eats. Catra is sitting next to her, her arm around Adora's waist, cleaning the breadcrumbs stuck on her cheeks every once in a while in an almost unconsciously tender motion. There is a glass of iced water in front of her and nothing else. She doesn't have the stomach to eat right now.

Catra feels shivering everywhere right now, frail, almost on the edge, like she is about to cry her soul out or just laugh until tears fall down off her eyes. Her skin is too sensitive, covered in kisses under her clothes, and her heart is somewhere else, wrapped safely inside Adora's beating chest as she laughs with their friends and eats lemon ice cream without wrinkling her nose.

Catra wishes with all her heart she could have stayed in bed until night time, her bones turned to jelly, heart soft, weather warm and Adora's touch even warmer against her back. Something had shifted between again this morning, something precarious, something delicate and important. As if Catra, who didn't know that had more to give, had let loose completely, had gifted Adora of everything she had left, of her heart and her trust and her soul and even her body. And Adora had met her in the middle and returned the same in kind, worshiping like one would do to the ocean, like Catra was everything to Adora. Beyond words and secrets .

Today, everything is beautiful and tender. Today Adora is not making it easier. She has been frustratingly lovely with Catra, devastatingly sweet, from the early hours of the dawn, kissing every inch of Catra's skin in every way possible, over the damp sheets and under the cold water and below the sunlight through the window. The image of Adora's reflection through the mirror, behind her, above her, all around her, inside her, is forever carved deep inside Catra's memory and skin. She will never see anything or anyone else as beautiful. For Catra, who wouldn't let anybody even touch her ever, this is how deep her trust in Adora runs.

Adora didn't even make it easier on the journey to the town. She kissed the inner face of Catra's wrists and then kissed her senseless in the car after they parked, tongue wrapping against hers, her hands on Catra's neck and hair. It was as if she couldn't get just enough of Catra, as if today Adora loved her a little bit more. As if this way Adora could absorb her completely inside her heart and never be parted from her again.

It's breaking Catra's heart.

Catra rests her head against Adora's shoulder and silently looks through the window, at the day slowly coming to an end as the sun sets on the horizon. The street lights start to illuminate the calm streets, a fine drizzle from an errand cloud falling over the town. There are a few people going in and around, running last time errands or meeting to spend the evening together, mostly smiling or going on with their days without sorrows. Without being chased by shadows.

Catra’s phone chimes in her pocket.

It takes her a second longer for her to answer, a second long enough for the phone to chime again, calling the attention of everybody else at the table. She ignores their curious stares, unlocking the screen so she can look at the small message bubble twinkling.

M~ *We are ready for you*

"Book stuff?" Glimmer asks, taking a huge bite of her dessert.

"Mhmm" Catra hums as the only explanation, tucking her phone back inside the pocket of her pants. "Gotta make a run home, I won't take long, one or two hours max," she says instead, leaning forward a little, kissing Adora's temple quickly, already standing up.

Before she can completely walk out of the seat, Adora shoots forward, grabbing her hand tightly in her. Her blue eyes are wide open, mild alarm swimming inside. Catra bites down on her bottom lip, squeezing Adora's fingers softly, trying to smile reassuringly at her.

"It's alright, it's just technical stuff. I'll be back soon. Wait for me with these two dingus, alright? I know you like them" Catra brings Adora's hand close to her face, kissing her knuckles. "Please stay"

She is lying, she is lying, she is lying to Adora and everything feels wrong.

Adora hesitates for a little but nods, looking at Glimmer and Bow who meet them with matching bright smiles. Catra stares at the three of them for a few seconds and walks out of the table, waving her hand at them before turning towards the door of the diner.

"Your jacket, idiot!" Glimmer calls behind her, rushing to her side to hand her the black leather. Catra takes it but Glimmer doesn't let go, making sure they are both with their backs towards their table before muttering between her teeth. "What 's going on?"

Of course she is not stupid, Catra should have known, as much as they call names to each other, Glimmer is pretty sharp with things and people. Catra sighs, putting on her jacket as she talks.

"Please take care of her," Catra whispers, not looking at Glimmer but at the dark night that has now completely fallen over the town. There are storm clouds in the distance. "I'll be back in an hour "

"Catra, whatever you are going to do-" Glimmer grabs the hem of Catra's sleeve, worry actually etched on her face. "Be careful, scum"

Catra looks at Glimmer's worried lilac eyes and then sideways towards Adora, her shoulders shaking a little where she is laughing for something Bow said to her, dimples on her cheeks. "Always am, sparkles"

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"Are you sure they are all here?" Catra murmurs, holding all her hair into a braid and covering it with the hood of her black sweatshirt.

"I told you, Sea Hawk made sure. He has been watching them for two days like you asked. All the hunting boats are here right now" Mermista answers between her teeth, grabbing the wheel of her car tightly.

"That I did, my beautiful muse!" Sea Hawk chants suddenly from the back of Mermista's expensive black car. Like them, he is also dressed in full black, not even his ridiculous handkerchief around his neck, as much as he tried to smuggle it on his clothes.

"Shut it," both Mermista and Catra snap at the same time, wishing him back into his seat as they look back at the bay.

The huge white yacht is quiet against the darkness of the bay, enormous in comparison, the only one on the bay right now alongside the rest of the smaller boats around it, just as white with the green logo on the side of the wood. Just as Catra remembers them.

There are green lights turned on inside the yacht and a few guards clothed in white circle the side of the bay every once in a while, vigilant of both the water and the land.

"There are always boats sent to the sea, always. Day and fucking night, it's been a nightmare. But Sea Hawk managed to sabotage the motors of most of them so we should have a few minutes before they manage to fix it."

"That I did-!"

"Shut up!"

"Good," Catra says, putting on the black face mask over her face. "I need them distracted, all of them."

"I know you planned this whole thing for a reason but are you sure you want to go inside?" Mermista questions her, frowning, already putting on her backpack where a few glass bottles clink with each other. She hands Catra one too, small enough that fits on the side pocket of her pants, the rag tightly shutting the mouth of the bottle strong smelling of gas.

"Yes," Catra says, zipping the pocket closed, no other explanation offered.

"Very well then," Mermista turns to unlock the doors of her car, slipping into the cold night quickly. "Let 's do this."

Sea Hawk walks out too, followed by Catra. He is jumping a little on his feet, two bottles already on his hands, with the kind of face a child would make on the morning of Christmas and not a man about to commit arson. Whatever makes him happy, Catra guesses.

"By the way," Catra says, wrinkling her nose against the lash of the wind before each one of them separate to their positions. "Thanks for helping me with this or whatever. In case we get killed."

Mermista rolls her eyes so hard Catra thinks they might pop right off her face, but her expression is honest when she looks at Catra. "Yes, yes. You're welcome or whatever"

They share a long look and nod, scrambling over the deck of the bay, covered by darkness.

Catra tucks behind one of the wide posts of the port, waiting in silence, her eyes never leaving the myriad of small boats around the yacht. It's not one, or two, but almost a dozen, all of them the same, all of them brought for the same purpose. Catra gulps back the acid on her throat and narrows her eyes, holding her breath when one of the guards roams his eyes over the spot she is hiding in and then looks away, not seeing her at all.

A second passes and then another, a glass crashes somewhere and then one of the boats, at the very corner, burst into flames violently. The fire consumes the flammable paint and the woods almost immediately, jumping from that one to the next, raising a wall of fire tall enough to start smoking heavily. The guards shout to each other in alarm, rushing to the edge of the port when another bottle crashes against the deck of one of the boats in the middle and joins the fire of the rest, followed by another, and another, pieces of glass jumping everywhere where the fire follows.

It doesn't take long for all the hunters and guards to rush out of the lower levels of the yacht, all of them in different levels of alarm, screaming at each other as Catra sees them run out and towards the boats, trying to kill down the fire. Catra grids her teeth, makes sure the guards are completely gone from the back side of the yacht and makes a run for it, jumping over the thick chain that separates the port from the sea and then jumping again without even thinking it into the open backside of the yacht, where the boats are usually poured out and into the sea.

Catra falls in her hands and knees, silently thanking all those years of gymnastics, quickly squeezing herself against the wall as she addresses the open space. She can see a few men making a run on the level above her head but they don't see her at all, too busy with the outside as the bottles keep raining over the boats and the fire rises in height, almost rivaling the yacht itself.

Catra grunts and pushes forward, finding a door open immediately and slipping inside. The place is disgustingly expensive, all fine wood and even finer metal, pouring out wealth in every corner. And it looks sterile, like a hospital that has never been actually used before, long corridors filled with nothing but bare white walls and fortunately dim lights above Catra's head.

Catra tries to make herself as small as possible against the wall, rushing across corridors and corridors full of silence and the occasional far away shout of someone outside, until she reaches the start of the highest level.

There is a heavy door there, of green crystal. Catra lowers herself behind a metal pillar, holding her breath as she studies the place quickly. One guard comes running from the opposite direction to Catra, also not seeing her at all, rushing inside the room when the door slides open. This way, Catra can see the inside of the room, a huge space also painted in all white. There is huge furniture around the wall, with glass separations, full of things Catra can't make out of the shape from so far away. There are several monitors placed on the wall opposite to the door, all of the turned on and focusing in the chaos that had unleashed in the port outside, and a desk in the middle of it all with a carpet in the floor in front of it placed in such a weird position that it takes Catra several minutes to understand it's actually a polar bear's skin, draped like any piece of rag over the polished floor.

Catra presses her palm tight against her mouth and tries not to throw up.

"What is happening?" Prime's voice comes from the desk, pointing each word with a grind of his teeth, obviously furious. He is standing up from his white leather chair, staring at the monitors with his hands in fists at either side of his body. He doesn't even look at the guard that has just come in, gushing and out of breath. When the guard doesn't answer immediately,

Prime slams his fist against the surface of the desk, cracking the thick crystal. Catra cringes and lowers herself smaller in her place. "Answer!"

"The boats! They are burning, all of them!" The guard finally manages out. He is covered in a light gray from the ashes of the boats, staining his white uniform completely. The guard searches on the pockets of his vest, taking out an almost complete piece of one of the bottles, the rag still held from the end though clearly burnt through. "We found this floating next to one of them."

Prime snaps his face to the man and that's when Catra finally sees his face, distorted in complete fury. His hair is slightly undone from his perfect style and the veins on his eyes pop out, red and angry, a contrast of color against the oh so white of everything else. He looks dangerous, still holding himself perfectly straight as he snatches the rest of the bottle from the guard's hold, studying it quickly and then smashing it against the ground loudly, breaking the rest of the little piece with the heel of his shoe.

"Show me," Prime orders to the guard, who rushes out of the room and towards the exterior of the yacht followed close behind by Prime.

Only when he gets out of sight, the heavy door that leads outside the yacht completely closing behind him, is when Catra lets herself breathe, tears picking at the edge of her eyes. She allows herself from some quick seconds of panic before walking from behind the pillar, running inside the room swiftly. There is a panel next to the door that Catra clicks quickly, shutting the green door tightly. She is aware that anything happens it won't save her much but is as much privacy as she can manage as she looks around her.

The shelves she had seen from the outside are actually full of awards and prizes. From fishing and hunting both in land as in waters, as well as a shooting contest. Catra bites down in her tongue when she watches that the things inside the glasses are actually animals, stuffed over, dead, forever held captive inside the artificially white walls of this monster. There are so many, both complete and in carefully picked apart pieces, that Catra loses count of them, at the edge of a nervous breakdown. Yet, none of them are close to what she is looking for, the shire of a psychopath yes but not what he had implied to Catra that day.

Catra makes her way towards the desk, pushing away several sheets full of money accounts, none of them important to her. Through the monitors Catra can see Prime is in the very deck, shouting something to several guards that are trying to put down the flames of his boats. Whatever Sea Hawk put on those things Catra has to admit is impressively stubborn.

Catra is looking at the monitors when she sees it, hiding between the white panels of the wall, a door shut closed. Catra approaches it carefully, throwing swift looks at the monitors next to her, making sure her face mask and hood is well placed over her face before stepping in front of the door completely.

She thinks she might find some kind of lock or monitor, anything that might open the door remotely. Instead, the heavy door simply slides open, wide for Catra to look as she pleases. Catra grabs the gram with her hand and gives just one step inside, just one, just enough to leave her frozen in her place.

There is a control for the door in the immediate wall next to the frame, so it's probably that Prime was inside when Catra's plan started to take motion and he left it open in his anger. There is a window on the opposite side of the door, triangular and fragile looking. The walls are bright, so bright it burns Catra's eyes, white from top to the bottom and so tall it almost looks impossible inside the space of the yacht. As well as the other room, this one is covered in objects, framed with white gold and placed inside boxes of thick glass. There are weapons and torture devices of all kinds hanging over the walls, like a butcher's shop, long and curved swords, axes covered in gems, as well as plates of gold and jewels, tapestries of rich colors and paintings, expensive and old, precious and irreplaceable. The kind of things one would find inside a museum and, just like one, this place is a shrine for stolen treasures.

It's not that what makes Catra's blood to turn into ice and her body to start tingling with both rage and fear, adrenaline running through her veins. It's not even the fact that every single item held here has a theme. Every single weapon is carved with images of the same thing, every single tapestry has scenes of the same folklore, all the books in the metal furniture have the same theme written on their covers and drawn over their pages, of different cultures and places each but all reunited in one single myth. Sirens painted in red over the frames, mermaids and selkies, the evidence of a lifelong obsession.

And yet, *yet,* all of this is not what scares Catra to her bones and makes her want to scream her throat raw in rage, tear her nails against her face and bend down in grief. It's the glass box placed in the middle of the room, thin and long, the highest prize, the favorite one. It's the chains inside of it, burning steel, crossed light a cross against each other, holding in place the treasure inside. It's the artificial light on the bottom, showing it off, an inside pleasure for the monster that has ripped it from where it belongs.

Pearls and sea glass, paths of coral, liquid silver, golden scales. Skin.

Skin, skin. Adora's skin.

So close and yet so far away from Adora's reach. So close to Catra's that it makes her head spin.

It's that, beauty prisoner inside a crystal jail. It's that and the fact that, behind the beautiful skin there is a huge glass coffin, big enough to fit two people inside, all the edges and corners adorned in intricate ivory spikes, another display of cruelty. The kind of coffin you would find inside a church, morbidly holding inside a saint's corpse. The kind of coffin filled with seawater and chains for wrists and a tail, just standing there. Waiting for the ultimate hunt, waiting for Prime's greatest greed. Waiting for what Catra loves the most.

There are tears rolling down Catra's eyes, slipping in the fabric of her mask, tears she doesn't even notice falling as she stares at the horror chamber in front of her. In fact, she is so lost inside her thoughts that her usual sharp instincts fail her and she doesn't realize when an errand running guard walks inside the main room behind Catra.

"Who the fuck are you? How did you get here?" The man yells, startling Catra. She turns around, searching quickly around her to find anything that serves her to defend herself but she is a fraction of a second too late.

The guard charges inside with all his speed and strength, managing to grab her by her braid when she tries to jump out of his path and her hood slips down. Catra yells for the pull, struggling to push him away, but the hold has given the guard advantage because he swings Catra around like a rag doll, slamming her back against the wall closer to them.

Catra gasps, blinded white for a few seconds by the sudden pain. Several objects come falling down from the walls, falling over both of them and crashing on the ground loudly. Catra manages to shake away the first grasp of unconsciousness quickly, stretching her arm to grab the lowest thing she has, the handle of a staff wrapped in leather and heavy metal.

She swings in down with a yell, managing to hit the guard on the back of the head, taking it down immediately. The man falls unconscious on the floor, letting go of Catra's hair who also falls in the ground harshly. She groans, standing up in unsure feet, kicking the man's side to push him out of the second room.

"Fuck this," Catra grumbles under her breath, reaching for the pockets of her pants to grab the lighter and the bottle Mermista had handle her, miraculously not shattered from the struggle.

Catra looks up and sees Prime standing outside of the main room, the green door wide open, just standing there staring at Catra. Her heartbeat almost lowers to a stop, every single sound running down until there is only silence between both of them. There are several feet separating them yet Catra can see clear as day the way Prime's eyes harden when he sees her, the flames outside reflecting on his pale irises in bright red.

Prime looks from her face, still partially covered by the face mask, to the room behind her, directly at the skin inside the glass and then back to her face, eyes narrowing, baring his teeth at her like some kind of insane maniac, something nasty and rotten flashing on his eyes.

It all happens rather quickly. Catra switches the lighter and lights the damp rag of the bottle. Prime launches himself in her direction, blinded by rage, and Catra throws the entire bottle against the floor, catching right above the polar's skin. The thing with morbid prizes like his is that, most of the time, they are extremely flammable.

The bottle explodes into pieces, fire catching instantly across the floor and the walls, bursting almost unnaturally violently. It is so strong, the heatwave pushes Catra back a few feet inside the second chamber, making her cover her face with her forearms. She looks up in time to see when the fire reaches Prime in the middle of his run towards Catra, grasping the side of his face into its flames, burning the skin immediately.

Catra watches in horror as Prime howls in pain, falling into the ground, trying to drown the flames away from his face with his hand just for the fire to extend into the sleeve of his suit, eating the fabric and trying to reach his arm and side too, as if the fire itself had taken a conscience and was trying to burn out the evil too.

The rooms start to fill with smoke immediately and the smells are crazy as the fire starts to rapidly devour the animals' remains, the carpet and the desk, monitors bending and melting away by the heat. The smell of burnt leather and hair expanding rapidly through the entire place, making Catra gag.

Prime's followers start to arrive pretty fast, some of them immediately rolling Prime to his side, hitting him with their smoked jackets to suffocate the fire from their boss' body. The violent wall of fire is the only thing separating them from Catra in the second room right now.

Catra lowers to the ground quickly, grabbing the same staff from before and turning to the glass box, not even really thinking when she swings it against it, quickly and strong, shattering the front glass wall in thousands of little pieces. Alarms start to go off everywhere inside the yacht, red lights blinking on and off, alerting everyone else outside. Catra is running out of time. She throws the staff to the side, grabbing the sharp edges of glass that still cling to the corners and tearing them off harshly, barely saving herself from cutting her palms open because of the thick gloves Mermista had handed her earlier.

Catra grabs the chains too, pushing them apart until she finds the rather fragile clips that keep them digging into the precious skin, holding it suspended in place. So close to it, Catra can immediately smell the sea clinging on it, something much like warm sun and fresh air, a perfume Catra has smelled a thousand times before on the back of Adora's neck and the inside of her wrists and the low of her back.

Catra bites the inner side of her cheeks until she bleeds and holds the skin softly between her hands, trying to be as gentle and careful as she possibly can when she unhooks it from the chains. This is a part of Adora and Catra loves every single part that makes Adora who she is, so even with the strong fire on her back and smoke filling her lungs painfully, Catra is tender when she lowers it down into her hands, sheltering in her hold after all the violence and humiliation it had gone through.

Absently, Catra expects the skin to be heavy, embroidered in pearls and scales as it is, so long that it brushes the polished floor when Catra pulls it out of the broken glass box completely. But the skin is actually light as a feather, basically a veil in Catra's fingers when she cradles it close to her chest with a deep sigh. And it is the most beautiful thing she has ever seen in her entire life, a star pulled out of the sky and poured inside Catra's palms, bright and shimmering when Catra touches it, finally safe after so long. The moonlight seen through stained glass. The most beautiful thing Catra has ever seen, except for the one the skin belongs to in the first place.

Catra bites back the need to cry and wraps the skin carefully but quickly over itself, opening her jacket and guarding it inside between the leather and the fabric of her sweatshirt so she can save it from the heat of the fire and the chaos around her. She then rushes past the wrecked box, kicking down the coffin in her way towards the window, slightly proud of the way it shatters loudly over the ground.

The fire is starting to catch inside this room too, devouring deviously every single thing hanging from the walls and over the floor. Catra faces the huge window, peeking through it. The room is placed exactly in the far end of the yacht and most of Prime's men are either still on the port or behind the fire at her back, so she only needs to manage it open and crawl outside. Easy.

Catra taps on the window once and the glass cracks slightly almost immediately, weakened by the strong heat coming from the fire. There is a bit of the struggle coming from the men at

Catra's back as Prime, finally turned off from the flames, starts pushing his men aside when they try to help him incorporate, spitting loud curses and orders here and there. Catra tries not to look too much but even from so far away she can make the shape of burnt skin on the right side of his face and the sight turns her belly in a nasty way.

"Get off me! Get off me!" Prime is yelling, hair in complete disarray, insane by both the rage and the wounds. Some of the guards try to grab him by the forearms just to be met by a strong hit.

"Sir, we need to go," one of his men is saying, voice basically drowned by the noise coming from the alarms and the windows of the yacht giving up under the heat. There is a strong sound that comes from the main room from where the desk finally gives up and all the monitors blow up, wires snapping and throwing sparks everywhere.

Catra tears down a tapestry from the wall next to her, ripping it in half quickly so she can wrap.her elbow with it before running back to the window. She steps back a little bit and then slams her foot flat against the surface, again and again until it cracks from side to side under the pressure, spider-like webs extending on the glass where it is the weakest. Catra stands firm in her feet and hit her wrapped up elbow against that same spot, the glass finally giving away and shattering down just enough for Catra to fit through and make a run for it.

The sea breeze slips inside the shattered window, making the fire surge almost comically bigger. Catra coughs harshly, smoke clinging to her lungs. She is pretty sure it is going to extend to other places on the yacht pretty quickly.

She is halfway climbing through the sharp pieces of the glass when Prime's voice raises again, past the walls of fire that separate them and the alarms and the turmoil, loud enough that Catra hears it clearly but also so unnaturally calm for the situation and his wounds that it sends a shiver down Catra's back with the sheer threat that his tone carries.

"I am going to break her" he says and when Catra turns he is looking directly at her, through the dangerous flames of the fire, face eaten by the same and oozing. Catra freezes, unable to look away in her fear. Adora's skin is cold where it meets the skin that's not covered up near her neck. "There is no place where my sight can't reach, no place where I won't look, and you won't be able to hide her from me forever." Prime's teeth click together when he speaks, spit and blood staining his face. "I know you, child, you are not different from me. I know what you will do with that skin to keep her with you, to make her stay. But I've searched for her kind my entire life, I've made my holy mission to purify this world from their presence. She belongs to *me.* "

Prime's advances, one steps closer, another, barely a few inches from the fire, unmoving when the pain should be making him convulse, so lost in his obsession and greed he feels nothing at all but anger and desire.

"I am going to take her for myself and I am going to tear her apart, so much, piece by piece. I'll bring her into my light until there is nothing left of her to take and what remains I will hang from these walls for the rest of her unholy life to do as I please with her so all those demonic creatures know they are not above us, above me."

Catra crosses the broken window, standing precariously on the small piece of deck there between the glass and the rail. Out of the corner of her eye Catra thinks she sees an emergency stair that comes all the way down to the first floor of the yacht, right next to the port, but her sight is swimming with tears that she doesn't even bother to wipe out, blurry the world around her.

Instead she smooths out her hand tight against her chest, making sure the skin is safely held against her heart and tries to drown out Prime's words chasing her as a shadow all the way when she climbs down the yacht, miraculously far away from the guard's grasp. When she reaches the port and when she slips on her own feet and falls hard over her hands and knees, scrapping her chin against the wood, and when she makes the run of her life past the port engulfed in flames and to the meadow where Mermista and Sea Hawk are already waiting for her inside the car, jumping into the back seat and crying the whole time as Mermista drives them all away like the fucking devil.

Catra pushes her back against the slick leather of Mermista's car and presses her fist against her mouth to bite down the scream that threatens to rip its way out of her chest. Catra sobs in silence on that car, curled around the skin as if it would make any difference, as if this way she could actually protect Adora from him, his words weighing over Catra's head as a guillotine about to pull off.

"I will find her. And I will break her, and it will be all thanks to you. Catrina."

Catra tears out her clothes, throwing them all on the back of her pick up without care, movements tight and robotic, barely registering she is doing it at all. The chill of the sea breeze bites on the naked skin of her back when she slips back into the clothes she was wearing barely an hour earlier, and she lets her hair fall down free over her back, hoping she can hide the purple bruises already forming on the dimples of her spine.

She is aware that Mermista must be watching her from the car, keeping an eye on her and their surroundings even after Catra told her to fuck off back to the store before her to avoid any suspicious. Mermista didn't say anything on the rush back, but Catra saw her looking at her with charged eyes through the rear mirror, a million questions never voiced, just driving through the town until they were far away from the bay. Nothing if it matters at all anyway, he knows who Catra is, so it just doesn't fucking matter.

Catra jumps inside the back seat of her car, shutting the door tightly behind her to avoid any curious looks before pulling out her jacket from where she had placed it, carefully picking it open. The skin shimmers when the dim light of the moon illuminates it, reflecting iridescent rainbows where Catra's tears fall over the pearls. Catra folds her jackets around the skin gently and then places it below the seat, as far away as she can. She feels guilty the entire time, tucking it away as if it were a mere rag and not Adora's heart, but she does it anyway, paranoid of anybody that could look inside the truck while she fetches Adora back.

Catra rubs her face clean with a water bottle she finds somewhere in the back of the truck and then hops inside, making the long drive around the limits of the town before entering through

the usual path, still sticking to her plan of making it look as if she had just come from the direction of her home, a complete opposite direction from where she was actually coming from. But anyway, as Catra thinks again and again until her heart feels sore and tired, nothing of it matters anyway.

She parks in front of Mermista's diner and ignores the fact that all of this feels surreal, putting on another coat, longer and warmer, as she steps out and crosses the street towards the door of the store.

She has barely made it fully on the street when the glass door painted with glass markets opens from side to side, the hinges protesting a little by the outburst, and a golden hair like sunlight rushes out of the place in a heartbeat.

Catra catches Adora inside her arms by instinct alone, wrapping them around Adora's back when the latter throws hers around Catra's neck, squeezing Catra close to her. Adora's red dress is tangled around her legs and the pores of her arms rise with the sudden change of temperature from the diner to the outside but still Adora just giggles, rubbing her cheek insistently against Catra's.

Catra pulls her back a little, staring at Adora's face, alarm running down her entire body from the surprise. Adora's eyes are wide open, bright and beautiful, and she is flushed, from the tip of her maybe too pointy ears to her round cheeks and all over her collarbones. Catra even worries for a second she might have a fever, even though that's not really possible, but Adora is jumping on her tippy toes as she stares at Catra, biting down in her bottom lip.

" *Pretty* !" Adora signs excitedly only to dissolve into a fit of silent giggles.

"Adora-? Huff!" Catra tries, failing when Adora places her palms behind Catra's ears, nuzzling their noses together, firm and lovely, and then leaning back just as quickly. She is barefoot, again, and trips a little when she tries to stand straight and still on a flat surface, like the floor, barely managing to sight with overly joyful but clumsy movements. A tall and very strong and beautiful looking baby deer in the middle of the empty street.

" *Pretty, pretty Catra. Hi kitty* "

The door opens again and out walks Glimmer and Bow, clearly rushing after Adora slipped away from their sight after the smallest of seconds. They huff, out of breath, but Catra turns to them before they can even start to talk, frowning deeply as she tries to steady Adora in her feet, who is leaning just a little bit too dangerous to the side.

"What did you do to her?" Catra questions, accusatory,. narrowing her eyes at the other two. Bow has his hand against his mouth, obviously tryin very hard not to laugh, and Glimmer is clearly just coming down from a fit of laughter, still cleaning swift tears from her eyes.

"Nothing!" Glimmer exclaims, face red too. Adora shakes her hands in front of Catra's face, calling back for her attention with a bright smile. She is signing still, rocking back and front on her ankles and giggling all at the same time

" *You are so pretty. With your cute little hands and your cute little freckles* "

"Does this look like nothing to you?!" Catra exclaims, steading Adora with one hand in her waist as she wiggles out of her coat, placing it quickly over Adora's bare shoulders and back. The black of the fabric makes Adora's eyes look even more silver.

Glimmer chuckles behind her hand. Bow's eyes are sparkling with cuteness. "We gave her one glass of beer, one! It wasn't even real beer, it was root beer!" Glimmer makes a poor attempt at defending themselves, eyes full of.mirth when she looks at Catra. "But I do think it's adorable"

" *You are cute* "

"I am not cute! Adora!"

" *Mean pretty. You are,* " Adora signs, making a fun little movement as if she were dragging the A's with her hands. " *with your cute little nose, and your cute little ears"* Adora grins, from ear to ear, bright as a sun. " *And your cute little noises and your cute little moans and-"*

"Adora!"

"Why do you smell like a barbecue?" Glimmer says out of nowhere, wrinkling her nose when she comes close and sniffs Catra's hair. Catra pushes her away without real force, not answering at all, instead tucking the coat closer to Adora's body and helping her untangle the knots of her soft hair with her fingers, holding it all into a low ponytail. Her cheeks are deep red and she is clearly out of it, still snorting lightly.

" *Oh, oh! The farmers! They are having a baby, y'know? A little itty bitty tiny person!"*

"Yes, I know what a baby is, 'Dora," Catra mutters, placing the baby hairs in Adora's temple behind her ear. Adora beams at Catra when she says that, smiling so wide every single tooth in her mouth peeks out.

" *Let's have one* "

Catra chokes on air, coughing lightly with the sudden surprise. "Uh- wha-"

" *Yes! With cute chubby cheeks and cute curls-"*

"What's with everything being cute today?"

"- *and cute toesies wooesies, and cute little fins* -"

"Fins?" Glimmer asks around a laugh, obviously extremely pleased by the whole thing.

Adora turns to Glimmer, eyes bright and mouth open, the picture perfect of someone that is absolutely delighted by what someone else just said. " *Yes! Fin* !"

Now Catra starts freaking out - as if she wasn't freaking out already to begin with - "Finn. A name, you know? Alright, let's go"

Adora grins with a joyful gasp, batting her eyelashes like butterfly wings towards Catra, a funky try of a flirtatious grin stretching in her lips. " *Are we making a baby?"*

Catra flushes bright red but shakes her head, kissing Adora's lilac eyelid softly. "Not tonight, princess."

Catra crosses her arm behind Adora's knees and sweeps her up into her arms, huffing when every single sore muscle on her body protests by the movement, tethering dangerously to the side before settling in her feet. Adora giggles, drunkenly delighted by the whole thing, throwing her arms around Catra's neck and burying her face against her ear.

"Do you need help?" Bow asks kindly, shaking his arms around them as if he was preparing to catch them if they fall. Catra points at her car with her chin, still holding Adora tightly against her chest.

"Help me open the door." There is a nasty pull on her belly and her heart is hammering inside her chest, anxiety rising on her throat like acid with the feeling of *get out, just get out of here,* paranoid to even look around her before crossing the street, feeling as if any second now Prime or his men will appear to take Adora away.

Bow helps Catra open the copilot's door and place Adora inside, which is a bit of a struggle considering she wraps herself around Catra like an octopus, finally managing to click her seat belt around her chest.

Catra is barely closing Adora's door when the loud sound of firefighters and ambulance alarms and honks start to fill the town into chaos, rushing down the street at full speed and into the path that leads to the port. One of the paramedics cars at the end slows down when they see them standing at the side of the street, a woman peeking from the rolled down window to speak with Glimmer loudly.

"Glimmer!" Tallstar yells over the sound of the siren's, "Do you mind getting a hold of your parents and telling them to meet us at the port?! Quick!"

"What is going on?!" Glimmer yells back, frowning deeply. Dread starts to bite on Catra's fingertips.

"That ridiculously huge yacht in the port is on fire!" Tallstar points at the sky behind them. The darkness of the night had managed to hide it for a little but the huge column of smoke coming from the port is now clear as a tornado, rising over the sky black and huge. "The owner was taken into a private hospital all the way back to Eternia but the fire is still going on!"

Catra steps around the car and tries to slip inside but Glimmer seizes her immediately by the wrist, not looking at her but keeping her in place with steel grip.

"I'll call my mom, you go ahead," Glimmer says, looking at Tallstar the entire time but still not letting go from Catra's hand.

"Great, thanks!"

Bow leans over Tallstar's window before she leaves to exchange a few quick medical words with her, his expression before lighthearted now completely serious. Glimmer snaps back her head towards Catra, looking at her with the most grave look she has ever seen her before. It even takes her aback a little.

"Glimmer-"

"Get out, get out of here right fucking now," Glimmer snarls under her breath, practically dragging Catra all the way to the pilot's seat. Her tone is strong but she doesn't sound angry. Actually she sounds kind of hysterical and absolutely terrified. "Take Adora and go home, alright? Don't do anything else more stupid. I'll deal with this. If it gets ugly we'll go for you, okay? Are you listening?" Catra stares at her in silence and nods, almost knocking her head on the frame of the door when Glimmer tucks her inside. "Fucking hell, Catra, I'm seriously going to kick your ass if something happens to you. Get out!"

Catra turns on the car and rushes through the street and out of the town, Glimmer and Bow reflecting on the rear mirror, every second more and more tiny until they are gone completely.

The journey home is quiet, Adora is fast asleep on the copilot's seat, snoring lightly and completely unaware of what is going on around her. As Catra crosses the meadows she thinks she is able to see the column of fire and smoke far away in the distance.

Their piece of the ocean is quiet when they arrive home, calm and peaceful as Catra parks the pick up on the back of the house and walks out, shaking Adora awake softly from her side of the seat.

"Come here, princess, let's get you to bed." Catra murmurs, helping a very sleepy Adora out of the vehicle and inside the house, closing the door tightly behind them.

The house is just as they left it, warm inside and cozy. Melog jumps out of the blankets they have next to the fireplace, reaching quickly their feet to rub their tiny nuzzle against their legs, meowing happily the entire time. Catra and Adora climb the stairs to their room together, walking inside with slow steps.

"Can you change yourself?" Catra asks in a low voice, trying to hide the fact her voice is completely raw from the smoke and the crying, and still, being soft with Adora in every moment. She doesn't know how to touch Adora in any other way right now but softly.

Adora nods with a little smile, scratching Melog's ears gently. Catra stands still for a few minutes, just watching her strip from her red dress and into her nightgown before rushing down the stairs again, crashing through the backdoor and back to the pickup, fetching her jacket with the skin tightly wrapped inside before rushing inside the house once more.

Catra closes the door and stays still over the floor, only with the jacket pressed close to her chest and the tranquility of her home around her. Suddenly she doesn't know what to do next, how to act. She knows, *she knows* what she needs to do. She knows she should be running up the stairs and into the room, knows she should be handing the holy veil in her hands to Adora, eyes casted down, unworthy of its beauty. Knows she should be apologizing to Adora.

Knows she should be letting her go, right now, before the consequences of Catra's actions reach her, before greed and rotten desire can touch her. Catra knows all of this.

But then again, the house is warm and Adora is singing upstairs, happy and free, calling Catra back to her side with her sweet siren's song. Right now, everything inside her home is gentle and good and the shadows haven't reached them yet. Right now everything is at should, everything except -

You are just like me, child. I know what you are going to do with it

Catra bangs her head against the wall, staring out to the sea beyond the stained glass of her favorite window. It's slightly open - Adora must have forgotten to close it before they went to town - allowing Cayra to see the seafoam against the stones and the peaceful shore, even with the storm clouds gathering above.

Just let me have this moment, Catra prays to whatever might want to listen to her, sinking into her ankles against the wall, the skin held against her cheek soft as a bride's veil, because she is human and she is selfish and she loves and that will be her fall. Because her body hurts everywhere and there's smoke in her lungs and she hopes with all her heart she had killed him when she could have. Because she knows what she has to do and Adora is singing in their room and Catra doesn't have the strength to do it. Not tonight. *Just for tonight. Let me say goodbye to her.*

Catra lifts the cushioned seat of the loveseat next to the stained glass, opening the small compartment where she usually keeps the blankets, placing very gently the skin inside. It almost seems to tremble when Catra lets go of it.

" **Catra** " Adora's voice calls from their room, making Catra jump in surprise, letting go from the lid suddenly. Catra rises to her feet quickly, rushing to the stairs without looking back.

She forgets to close the window and doesn't notice the small pearls fallen on the ground.

By the time Catra walks inside their room Adora is sitting cross legged over the bed, watching outside the window with a peaceful expression on her face. She turns to look at Catra walking in, her entire face shifting into the most tender of smiles.

She rises to her feet, approaching Catra in quick steps. She looks less dizzy and giggly than before but her eyes are still a little bit unfocused, maybe for sleepiness or for softness, Catra is not sure. Adora cradles Catra's hands inside her palms and presses their foreheads together, rubbing her nose against Catra's cheek a few times and then moving slightly away, just enough to make her sign clear between them. Catra misses her immediately.

" *Are you alright? Where were you?"* Adora says.

"I-" Catra stutters, unable.to even come up with some kind of explanation.

Adora just smiles, slipping her hand inside Catra's and pulling from her, gently guiding them both inside the safety of their bed, newly changed sheets fresh against their skin. Adora helps

Catra unzip her jeans and Catra refuses to take off the white shirt she is wearing, one of Adora's, afraid that Adora might realize she is bruised all over.

Adora doesn't notice, sitting on the far end of the bed with her legs at either side of Catra's hips, face to face. When Catra doesn't move, Adora huffs, rolling her eyes with a smile. She places her hands at either side of Catra's waist, just above the hem of Catra's black underwear, and pulls gently from her, bringing her closer. Adora sits comfortably against the pillows over the bed and cradles Catra inside her arms, right against her chest and beating heart, running her lips and the tip of her nose across Catra's face, painting kisses both sweet and swift and open mouthed and slow against her warm skin.

Catra whimpers under the touch, holding her breath and trying to think clearly when Adora dips her face under her jaw and bites lovingly at the space there, pressing her damp tongue over the skin immediately after to tamper the sudden sting. Catra shivers, finding the solace she so much needs right in Adora's arms and being unable to accept it.

Instead she pushes Adora's face slightly away from her, her fingers pressing over Adora's cheek to call for her attention, away from the sweet adorations she tries to give her.

" 'Dora, wait. Wait" Catra whispers and Adora stops immediately, listening intently to what she has to say. She respects Catra so quickly, being attentive so quickly and without fear that Catra's mind goes blank and her body goes numb, unable to keep going. "I need to talk with you about something. Something important. I- I just-"

What? I think we need to go. You need to go, Catra thinks, shutting her mouth painfully closed. *Please, you are not safe here. Leave, far away, leave before he finds you because of me.*

But also-

Stay, stay with me. I don't know how to ask you this and I don't know how to make you understand. I love you too much and I'm so scared. You need to leave me behind but it is going to kill me.

Adora bumps her nose softly against Catra's temple, gently bringing her back from her own head. Catra looks at her with pressed lips, begging her to understand what she so desperately wants to say without actually saying it. Adora doesn't understand, of course, making an encouraging sound with the base of her throat. Catra exhales, trembling and a little bit damp with treacherous tears, running her fingers over Adora's pale eyelashes. The images of Prime's second room are carved inside her head.

"Hey, Adora" Catra whispers and as always it makes Adora smile. "I think we should go sailing for a while. Tomorrow. I mean, you know, maybe you could show me your waters after all."

Adora stares at Catra's face, eyes slightly crossed and wide as a doe with the surprise and then snorts, giggling as she tucks her face in the angle of Catra's neck.

"What? Don't laugh at me. I'm serious," Catra says weakly, running her fingers on Adora's nape. Adora shakes her head against her collarbones, leaning back to catch Catra's eyes on hers. She looks pretty much completely awake now.

" *Well , I would like you to meet the whales I talked to you about, and the stingrays and maybe even my brother if he feels less of an ass,"* Adora starts signing excitedly, a new light in her eyes. It makes Catra's heart swell painfully. " *But what about the open ocean? I don't want you to be afraid,"* Adora frunces her eyebrows, completely honest, and Catra wishes she wasn't a liar and she didn't hate herself this much.

"I won't be afraid, not if it is with you," Catra runs her thumb over Adora's bottom lip, fighting back the tears. "As long as we are together"

Adora smiles against Catra's fingers, kissing the tips with all the benevolence and loveliness of someone that is not afraid.

" **I love you** *"* Adora says, and it's in her mother tongue, honey sweet on Catra's ears, cupping Catra's face on her hands.

"I love you too, Adora," Catra whispers on a thread of a voice, face terribly sad, scared and unable to understand what Adora feels, that Adora is already holding her entire world inside her palms. That she has no need for anything else, not fear, no harm, no sacrifice.

But this is not how this story goes.

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Adora pushes Catra delicately over the mattress, leaving kisses over her cheekbones as she presses her against the sheets with her body. Adora leans back, running her hands over Catra's shivering knees, gently cooing her legs open.

Adora hooks her thumbs on the sides of Catra's underwear and drags it down her legs, letting it fall to the side of the bed blindly. She is now clearly completely out of the laziness the root beer had made her go through, still a little bit drowsy, soft and gentle, but with her entire attention focused now in Catra and Catra alone. Adora runs her blunt nails below Catra's white shirt, sweet but firm, respectful of not taking it off if she doesn't want it, resting her cold palm against Catra's hip bone. Adora kind of feels fragile right now, touching Catra like one would caress a crystal flower, too precious and delicate to ever be harsh.

Adora lowers herself down over Catra's body again, kissing Catra's cheek, exhaling against her ear. Adora's other hand wanders down, feeling with just the tip of her fingers over the skin of her slit, barely even touching her at all. After this morning, Catra barely needs preparation at all.

Catra arches her back inside Adora's hold and whimpers, waves of pleasure and the protest of her sore muscles fighting a war for her nerves, sending sparks of electricity across her entire body. But Adora doesn't know, and yet she kisses the corner of Catra's mouth sweetly, reassuring her with tender hums and her lips against her forehead.

Catra lets go of her grip in the sheets to cup Adora's face in her hands, guiding her until they are face to face, looking at each other. Tears are falling free from Catra's eyes, warm one after the other. Catra doesn't stop them, falling free down her temples and losing themselves like pearls against her hair. Adora makes a try to wipe them away but Catra shakes her head, rubbing small circles under Adora's eyes with a feather touch.

"Stay with me," Catra whispers to Adora and to the night, a plea, an apology, a vow, and she means every single word, tainted in hidden sorrow.

Adora's beautiful eyes flash with something, some hidden knowledge that she and only she has about Catra, and yet worlds away from the grief that is truly going inside her heart. Adora rests her hand over Catra's, still against Adora's cheek, and holds it close to her skin. Adora draws her face closer to Catra, until her lips brush over her forehead purposely and the down, across her eyelids and over the gentle curves of her cheeks, mapping all the freckles of her face like she used to do with the stars, swimming alone in the middle of the ocean, until she reaches Catra's red mouth, speaking the round vowels of her language against her tongue.

" **Always** "

Adora rests her open mouth over Catra's, pink against red lips, the flat of their tongues meeting in the middle, pouring the sweetness of their breaths over each other's throat.

A high pitched *Ah* escapes Catra's mouth when Adora lines herself with her entrance, and then another and one more, a thread of her voice followed by a sweet exhale, hoarse and exquisite for Adora's ears, barely drowned down by their kiss.

Catra welcomes Adora inside easily, swift and lovely as water through sand. Her whimpers and moans are received by Adora's tongue against the roof of her mouth and the back of her teeth, echoing like marine caves, high and nearly desperate as Catra feels every single inch entering her with devout care. She can't help herself when her nails dig in the expanse of Adora's back, running red lines on her skin, or when she moans sweetly away from Adora's mouth, hiding her face on her golden silk hair instead.

Adora cups the back of Catra's head with her hands and kisses the shell of her ear, waiting until Catra relaxes around her, her legs falling wider at either side of Adora's hips, trembling with the sensations, skin feverish, soaked as a river. Adora waits, drowsy, a little sleepy, and when she is sure everything is well she moves forward, thrusting Catra into the sheets with equally gentle chase.

Adora loves her so much. She adores her and worships her. Is completely devoted to her. Adora had no idea she could find so much pleasure in undoing the person she loved until Catra was melting for the first time around her, blending their bodies together until none of them know where one ends and the other begins.

Catra comes with a hiccup, almost immediately, too softly that it's basically a caress and yet Adora follows her, letting herself be dragged by the tide that is Catra's heat. They shiver against each other, kissing sweet and deep for long minutes but Adora doesn't pull away, caressing the bruises in Catra's spine that she doesn't even know exist, and Catra doesn't drift

away, brushing golden hair behind silk ears, and they keep going, forever embroidered in this lovely dance that is theirs and theirs alone.

Catra rolls her head to the side, looking through the window and towards the sea, sigh fogged, misted with passion. She is breathless, with Adora beautiful and ethereal between her legs, hovering above her, around her, inside her, one soul in two bodies, heart to heart. Adora presses their cheeks together, rubs them into a kind kiss, holding Catra lovingly in her unwavering fond embrace.

She cradles Catra softly, following with the motions of her thrusts, in and out of her until it's a lullaby. Until it makes Catra's eyelids puffy and her sorrowful heart tender. Until Adora kisses the corners of her mouth and whispers sweet promises in her ear and Catra sighs, holding her close one more time. Until one last merciful strand of peace falls over her as she gives Adora all her trust, over her body and her soul, and she finally allows herself to sleep between her arms.

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It happens quiet.

Catra wakes up in pain, her head hammering, her body sore. Her head is not over her pillow or above the beating chest she has come to know as home, but over the cold mattress and she definitely pulled a muscle sometime during the night.

Her entire body tingles, worshiped by kisses where Adora made love to her until they were both asleep in each other's arms, and for so the cold now bites without mercy on Catra's exposed skin, a sharp slap that tears her from a sweet dream.

Catra straightness, keeping herself up with her arms, looking through the window that has the curtain pulled back, letting through the view of the sea, violent against the shore. The sky is deeply dark, black and gray, thunderous on the horizon with lightning that paints the clouds in purples and reds. The shore is illuminated by the light of the storm and the lightning. And, even beyond the glass, Catra can feel the very air heavy, metallic in her tongue, rising her hair and running a dreadful shiver down her back.

Something is wrong, Catra thinks, rushing to her feet so quickly that her head spins, making her stumble and fall off the bed painfully. Something, whatever it is, has gone terribly wrong and Adora is not in Catra's arms and not in the bed and not even in the room.

Catra pulls on her sweatpant and rushes through their bedroom, trying to turn on the lights only to be greeted by darkness. There is no electricity and all the candles in the chandelier on the roof have blown up. Catra grunts and pushes the door open, making her way down the stairs with her heart in her throat.

" 'dora?" Catra whispers when she reaches the end, looking around the living room and the kitchen drowned in the night's darkness. There is no response, not a sound that comes back to Catra's call. Catra feels like she is about to faint, tears itching in the corner of her eyes, barely holding back to fall down.

What if they found them? Found her? Catra thinks again and again, thoughts rushing through her head so quickly it makes her want to bend in half and throw up. *What if they followed Catra? What if they are here? What if they have taken her, hurt her? Tear her apart before Cagra could do anything to try to protect her as she promised.* Catra should have never fallen asleep. She should have never allowed herself to be selfish, to let herself be taken by the person she loved the most without thinking about the consequences. Not that night, not after what she had done. She had messed with the devil and fallen asleep. How stupid, stupid, stupid, *stupid, stupid. ..*

Catra turns around the arched pillars of the living room and stays still, a sob trying to make it through Catra's throat. Adora is standing in front of the stained glass window, halfway open, the hinges slightly creaking with the cold breeze that slips inside.

She has her back towards Catra, facing the window and the shore beyond. This way, Catra can't see her face, just the tips of her hair that curls on the low of her back and the lace end of her short nightgown against the silver light of the night. She is standing so still and quiet, so unmoving at Catra's call, that the sudden relief in Catra's chest quickly rips itself away into dread. Into fear.

"Adora?" Catra asks, quiet and shivering, hesitant to even speak louder. Catra takes a step forward and stops, “Mi amor?” Catra calls softly, breaking in the middle. "What is it? Are you hurt?"

"Catra," Adora says and the world stops. It's different, completely different to the way Adora usually says it. Before it was like music, a song only for Catra to hear, a display of trust and emotion and magic. This one is clearer, just as beautiful but completely different. It's not a song but the inflection of a voice, well spoken, clear, as quiet as the night around them.

Adora turns around to see Catra, ever so slightly, until she is facing her, her profile illuminated in the blues and purple light that comes through the glass.

"I left the window open," Adora says, *says,* out loud, mouth opening, lips curving around every word like an enchantment, like a curse. "I didn't want you to get cold."

She is speaking. She is speaking and she is barefoot and wearing her favorite nightgown, thin straps falling down her mouth kissed shoulder, her hair tousled where Catra had run her fingers and held herself to her nape. She is speaking and absolutely beautiful and the thread ring in her finger is a delicate promise and she is holding her skin between her hands.

Catra says nothing, absolutely nothing, eyes fixed in the precious skin held between Adora's fingers, long and completely breathtaking, a river of pearls and iridescent scales in the middle of their home, bright as the moon itself now hiding behind the gray clouds. Under Adora's touch it looks otherworldly, hanging from her forearms light moonlight, like sea foam at the edge of a wave. It almost seems to recognize her, recognize the place where it should have

never been ripped from. With her skin between her hands, Adora looks like the watercolor painting of a goddess or the marble statue of a mártir, forever captured into a single second of beauty.

"I-" Adora looks down, at the seat of the window where the skin was, where Catra *left* it, and then back to Catra. Her bottom lip is trembling terribly. "I don't understand" and she sounds so honest, so *lost,* so sorrowful and confused that Catra wants nothing else but to throw herself in her knees and sob an explanation, beg for forgiveness, cry out the truth before it tears them apart.

But she doesn't, Catra stands still over the cold wood of the floor, hands at either side of her body, just staring at Adora without making a sound or blinking at all.

Here it is, the decision, the sacrifice, the point of no return. Catra knows Adora, as well as she knows her own heart. She knows Adora will stay and that she will want to protect Catra, shelter her. Catra knows Adora is going to try and carry the weight for herself, give herself away to them, to *him,* so Catra can be safe. So here it is. Here is where Catra gets to make a choice, of keeping Adora or letting her go. Of saying the truth or being a liar to save her love.

I just think she deserves to know what is happening

"Catra," Adora repeats, voice breaking in the middle. When she moves, her hair brushes her face, soft as a feather, and Catra realizes Adora is crying, tears falling down her beautiful face as rivers.

He knows who you are

Adora steps forward, one step after the other, raising her hands towards Catra's face carefully slow, like reaching for a dove, like she was trying to not scare her even if she herself is terrified, the tip of her fingers brushing over Catra's chin and closed lips - lips Adora had kissed - into a caress so gentle it almost disarms Catra's resolution completely, the touch cold, *pleading* and so dear. The movement makes Adora's skin slip from her arms and down to the floor, a piece of the sea between them.

I will find her

Catra is numb, staring at Adora's silver and blue eyes like one would stare at something too sacred to be touched. Adora is pale, her usually rosy cheeks are almost white and she is trembling from head to toe. Yet, she somehow looks even more beautiful than Catra has ever seen her, as if just holding her skin for a moment had returned to her something vital she was missing.

I'll take her for myself. I will tear her apart.

"Catra." Her voice is so beautiful, a gift from her skin that had been held from her. Catra loves her so much. "Catra, say something! Anything at all! Just-" Adora's skin lays sadly on the floor between them, liquid silver under the moonlight, iridescent pearls, sea glass and scales like gold held from it, like a tapestry embroidered by a god.

She belongs to me

"Please" Adora cradles Catra's face between her hands, thumbing her cheekbones in circles, a motions she has done a thousand times. It had never hurt not like this, not before. Catra remains quiet, eyes fixed on a point above Adora's shoulder and the silence makes Adora go insane, her voice shivering and shattering completely. "You are breaking my heart "

I will break her.

"You know what it is," Catra hears herself saying, hollow, numb. She doesn't even feel like herself, she doesn't dare to, because if Catra allows herself to *feel* anything at all she is not going to be able to do this. She is not going to be able to turn her eyes to Adora's, like she is doing right now, and say without a tremble, "You know what it means, you are not stupid."

Catra sees the exact second the words hit Adora,, because the light dies inside her precious eyes, silver to gray like the cloudy sky. A stab on the heart, a bleeding knife held by Catra's hand. Adora's hands tremble terribly around Catra's face and she shakes her golden head strongly, betrayal and incredulity falling over her, cold and merciless.

"No," Adora whispers and it's so broken the sound almost doesn't come out at all. All the worlds and the skies and the oceans fall apart around them like broken glass. "No, Catra-"

"I have nothing else to say to you, Adora," Catra says, because she is a liar and she loves Adora too much, slapping her hands away from her face harshly. The way Adora's face shifts into unfiltered grief makes Catra want to scream and curse herself, makes her want to wrap her arms around Adora's chest and beg for her forgiveness and cry and *cry.*

I'm sorry, I'm so sorry. Please, please stay with me. Please stay.

But she doesn't. She can't. If Catra wants to protect Adora she must let her go. She doesn't and so she sees the way Adora steps back, her bare feet like sun against sand, another and another, an entire world apart from Catra with each one. The expression on Adora's face is undescribable and it's tearing apart every single cord of Catra's heart because she doesn't even look angry. She doesn't lash out or scream or yell at Catra. Doesn't push her apart or attack her as she could, as she has the right after the pain Catra is making her go through. Instead Adora looks so, so sad, sorrow and treason and absolute despair storming in her beautiful factions as a tempest over the ocean when the full weight of Catra's words settle in.

Betrayal, betrayal.

The only way to make Adora leave is by breaking her heart.

"You are just like them, then. You lied to me, *used* me. You-" Adora chokes on her words, ringing like the sorrowful bell of a funeral. Catra knows what she must be thinking, remembering. Every single word, every dance around the kitchen's floor, every whisper, every kiss, every caress, every touch. Golden memories burn into ashes by Catra's betrayal, tainting Adora's heart with dark ashes. "You are a monster"

The word burns in Adora´s tongue like acid and shatters Catra in the ghost of her hands. Adora doesn't mean it but she says it anyway, a curse in her mother tongue, a sharp glass against skin, a rotting flower on a grave, a lie painted by pain.

Catra almost falls apart by it, devastated, the world tearing itself apart between her fingers, barely managing to hold herself up by the sheer despair of it all. Her feet are so cold, her skin feels clammy and how is it possible that a few hours ago Adora was pressing kisses on the shell of Catra's ear and the bridge of her nose and now she is grabbing her ethereal skin in her hands, nightgown fallen in the floor, enveloping herself inside it until she looks like a star, bright as the sun, or a nova, devastatingly lovely, a devourer of all things inside the beauty of her desolation. Adora holds her skin tightly close to her, covering her shoulders and legs and honey hair, the image of a holy saint that has wrapped the moonlight around her bare frame and has the sun crowning her head.

Adora looks at Catra one last time, eyes like the ocean, bright against the dark, a midnight sun on her eyes. Cold. Freezing as the depth of the ocean that now reclaims her back. She has never looked at Catra this way before. "You've made your decisions, now live with them."

Adora wants to touch her but she doesn't. Adora wants to scream but she can't. Adora wants to kiss her but she turns around and leaves, leaves, leaves *her* . In all worlds, in all lives, in all stories, Adora always leaves first. Seafoam against wind, cold mist into waves. A piece of a fairytale over.

Adora runs through the house and out of the open door swiftly, a strand of moonlight set free, cradled by nothing but her skin and the ring in her finger, so frail right now she feels like it might snap her in half. She runs and runs and runs, through the sand and the dark pebbles, past the rocks where she had hidden that first night and then she had been rescued and then she had been betrayed. Adora runs and hates herself and doesn't dare to look back until she is meeting the sea and her tears are pearls inside the waves and she is gone.

Gone. Adora is gone.

Catra has followed. She didn't know when she started walking, didn't know if she ran or if she stepped out of the home - *their* home - slow, like a trance, like bleeding out of an open wound, lethal, letting it run until the pain washes her and everything she feels away. Silent. Like a nightmare, Catra follows Adora and doesn't stop her. Catra stays there and watches her go.

Catra remains on the shore for minutes or hours, just standing there, watching over the line in the sea where the water meets the sky. It's freezing - she doesn't feel it - and the pebbles cut the skin of her feet - she doesn't even flinch - the wind wailing on her hair - she wants to tear it out from the root - She doesn't feel anything besides that deep, agonizing hurt.

Sooner or later, the fall down comes, and with it, the realization. Catra's breathing speeds impossibly quickly, panting and then fully hyperventilating. She walks from one side to the other across the shore, grabbing at her chest feeling as the emotions start to tear her apart from the inside out. And then, Catra screams. She screams and screams, so loud it rivals the lash of the ocean against the cliff and the thunder above her head. Catra pulls from her hair and scratches her own neck and screams.

"Give her back," she thinks, again and again until her throat starts to burn and she realizes she is actually saying it out loud, yelling, howling, ripping her vocal cords from her throat. "I'm sorry! I'm so sorry, for everything! Give her back to me, please, give her back!"

Catra is not really thinking when she throws herself against the sea, so blinded by grief that she absently hopes it kills her. She doesn't think that she can't swim or that the water afraids her, she just sprints against the sharp slam of the water, devoured by the waves in seconds and yet Catra keeps fighting, over the dark pebbles and against the strong lash of the water until her feet aren't touching the ground anymore and she is fighting the very ocean to try and keep going, to try and find her.

The sea rises and slams her back into the shore like a wall of stones, too easy and too violent. Catra gasps, breathless by the hit, her back against the hard ground, soaked from head to toe and trembling.

"Fuck, fuck, FUCK!" Catra sputters, in pain. She is scratched all over, nose bleeding where it slammed her against the rocks, bruises already painting on her skin from rolling against the pebbles. It's a miracle she doesn't break her neck. Catra curses, tears falling rageful across her cheeks the entire time, and raises to her feet, barely managing to hold herself straight before going behind the water again.

The sea returns her back to the ground again and again and again, each time more violent until Catra is sure she has bruises all over her ribs and back, purple and deserved and yet she tries. She will cry until her throat is raw and dawn is breaking red over the dark clouds and she will drag herself back to the house and cry breathless on the end of the stairs, holding herself from the wood of the floor and the walls just enough so she can try and throw herself to the water again, just to fail again.

No matter how much she tries, Catra can't reach her again. The sea won't let her. It won't let her follow and it won't let her drown. Despising her and loving her all at the same time.

I guess it was love, after all . Catra thinks, hysterical after hours, slowly sinking to her knees with a hoarse sigh, her arms around her head, silently begging the sea to kill her between its weaves. It doesn't. *It wouldn't hurt like this if it hadn't.*

It all happened so quietly. Dawn breaks above her head, smoke rises on the bay of the town and Adora is gone.

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x x

End of chapter V

"Leave me, [...]" I wanted to say. "Walk out of this place and run far away and never think of me again, not once, let me die in your dreams, find someone whose skin isn't a suit sewn over barbed wire and broken glass.'

– Max Gladstone , *Last Exit*

Chapter End Notes

I started doing it

Had a mental breakdown

Bon appetit

Tear my heart open [flow it with your tears]

Chapter Summary

"Te adoro"

Chapter Notes

Catra gets a haircut
Adora meets a whale
Adam is done
There is a storm
Also, I'm sorry :D

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
- Descriptions of depression
- Descriptions of grief
- Descriptions of panic attacks
- Descriptions of blood, injuries and severe violence
- Descriptions of death
- Extremely delicate chapter, please proceed with caution, drink some water and take as much breaks as you need

I love you all, everything will be alright ♡
P.S. Also before the hakos come back, please download it for safe keeping!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter VI. Tear my heart open [flow it with your tears]

you realize that grief is perhaps the last and final translation of love. and i think this is the last act of loving someone. you realize that it will never end, you get to do this, to translate this last act of love for the rest of your life. And so her absence is felt every day

- Ocean Vuong , *NPR*

❍

"Adora"

Adora gasps, jolting on her own body. It's dark.

She looks around her, teeth bare, heart hammering. It's just darkness, deep and merciless, her hair floating around her head, powerful tail disobeying gravity, marble against obsidian. She is underwater.

Adora looks down, at her hands, long fingers, even longer nails, made to hunt and kill and feast off it. Claws. She knows them, they are hers, scales and thorns and blood. Blood. Red, dripping down the delicate membranes between them, from the nails to her knuckles to her wrist. Bright red as blood moons. This isn't her blood. Who is it?

"Do you regret it?"

Adora snaps her head up, panting. The voice comes from right in front of her. Is deep, hollow and also uneasily familiar. Void of all emotion but also full of sick curiosity.

Mocking.

Adora frowns, snarling, scanning the darkness beyond. Even with her sharp eyes, she can't make sense of the shadows.

"What?" Adora asks. She can feel the stickiness of the blood on her skin, even below the water. It's not washing away. It's stuck, dry over her scales, incapable of ever coming off.

"It's alright, if you don't" the shadows move forwards, towards her and suddenly they take shape, like thick ink against oil. Powerful tail, silver and marble, long ears, gills like silk. White and golden. Silver and pearls. It's Adora, watching herself from the other side, a mirror that stares back at her with eyes full of seawater and light hair soaked in red when she tilts her head to the side.

Adora exhales in shock, trying to move away. She can't. She is also stuck here, at this moment.

Her reflection, her other her, whatever it is looks at her with cold eyes, staring at her with curiosity. She looks like a nightmare, like a hunter. A monster . *Covered in blood as if she had just slashed something. There is not a trace of true regret or compassion in those eyes, she doesn't care, and for a fraction of a second Adora wonders if that's what she looked like. If that's how she looked at* her.

When? *Adora questions herself, dizzy, confused. The reflection hums, considering her. The sharp rows of teeth inside her mouth stretch when she smiles, speaking again.*

"I'm telling you, it's alright if you don't. They are monsters, after all," the smiles grow impossibly wider, narrowing the corner of her eyes, black as the depths of the waters around them. The flection moves forward - Adora can't - swimming around Adora swiftly, circling her a few times into a rotten kind of dance until she is behind Adora - the reflection's silver-like tail is coated with blood - placing her cold hands over Adora's shoulders and lowering her dangerous mouth until she can press it against Adora's ears and whisper.. " ***She*** *is a monster, remember?"*

“Who-?” Adora’s voice dies in her throat, the waters moving around her heavily again, a strand of moonlight in the middle of the darkness.

Catra.

Catra. Beautiful and precious, so loved, so lost. Catra sinks slowly in the water, eyes closed, arms stretched forward, pulled down by a force beyond her strength. She isn't swimming. She isn't moving. She isn’t breathing, Adora isn’t even sure if she is alive at all.

“She lied to you”

She is thin and frail like a flower against a storm, a treasure of stained glass broken into pieces. There are tears on her precious face, sunken and bruised from nights of sorrow.

That 's wrong .

Adora can see them, even underwater - that shouldn't be possible - slipping off her closed eyes as pearls. Lilac skin, deep, exhausted lines under her beautiful eyes, pale cheeks, all the beautiful freckles Adora knows by heart tinted in red.

Wrong, wrong.

There are three scratches in her face, wide open, skin worn out and raw, red liquid coming out of it in rivulets and Adora knows now exactly where the stains in her hands came from.

Wrong

Adora slams herself against the invisible hold that keeps her in place, kicking, lashing, tearing, fighting against the ocean in rage when whatever force that keeps her here doesn't allow her to go with her. She opens her mouth and tries to scream but nothing comes out of it. Catra keeps sinking, devoured by the dark water below and away. So far away, beyond Adora's reach.

“She lied to you" the reflection repeats her hold on Adora's shoulder tightening painfully, licking off Catra's blood from her front teeth. Her touch in Adora's skin is staining her too and suddenly all Adora can see is red. Red. White and red.

*“She **lied** to you” the reflection chants, a song that speaks of sorrow and betrayal, once and a thousand voices hammering inside Adora's mind again and again until every single sound is drowned out. “You **know** she lied to you”*

Catra disappears into the water, devoured by the darkness, just her tears leaving behind a path of bubbles like flowers. Adora screams, panic and terror threatening to blow out everything around her, digging her claws into her scalp and covering her ears. “Shut up! Shut! Up!”

"She lied to you" her own voice whispers against her cheek, the mock a kiss. "And yet, you left"

The water is red, heavy, clouding Adora's sight, drowning everything into darkness and this is a nightmare from which she cannot wake up.

“Do you blame yourself? Adora?”



"Catra?" There is a second of silence and then the knocking comes again, insistent against the blue wood of the door. "Catra? Adora? Are you two in there? It 's Glimmer!"

"And Bow!" adds a second voice, a try of cheerfulness overcomed by worry.

"Please, open the door! We've come to see you!"

Silence.

Catra is lying on the floor.

She doesn't know how long she's been here. Hours, days, years maybe. Entire lives slipping through her fingers as she lies on her side over the cold wood floor. Her cheek is numb and her eyes are raw, red from crying until she physically couldn't do it anymore. Her body hurts and her knuckles are bruised, worn off after hitting them against the pebbles of the shore and against herself.

She is mourning.

Catra doesn't remember how she got here either. There is sea salt and sand sticking to her cheeks and hair, she hasn't changed or showered, she hasn't eaten anything. She is barefoot.

Absently, Catra thinks she remembers collapsing here at some point, worn to the bone, gasping for air when lungs have out, trying to hold herself to the small pieces of a life she loved still scattered around their home. *Her* home, nobody else's, not anymore.

There are still small traces of her in the very foundations of the house, on the marrow of Catra's bone. If she stretches her hand, just a little, she might grasp a golden scale between her fingers, small and precious like a sun, sharp like a knife that draws blood. Catra doesn't dare to move. If she does, the scale might just dissolve into sand and seafoam and Catra wouldn't be able to bear more.

There is a path of pearls that leads to the seat of the stained glass. The window is still open.

Melog called for her for a while, in the beginning, sad and confused from the bedroom upstairs. They approached her gently at some point, sniffing her tear stained face, meowing gently and rubbing her face with their nuzzle, almost as if they were asking her to stand up. Catra didn't. So, instead, Melog ended up curling against Catra's ribs, next to her chest, and purred the entire night. They haven't moved either in all this time and Catra hates herself for forsaking them but she just can't do it.

Catra just stays there, staring at the door without seeing it at all, her left arm in front of her, palm up, waiting for nothing to come. Part of Catra awaits for her, all that makes Catra's heart and soul, waits for the door to get open or the oceans to part in the middle so Catra can look for her, so she has a way to come back if she wants to. But the ocean doesn't part and the door remains closed, blue paint and curtains closed, with just the unstoppable sound of knocking on the other side.

“Catra! I´m serious, open the fucking door!” Glimmer is screaming now, banging in the wood harshly. Her tone of voice is high, almost wheezing, concern in every word even as she curses like a sailor. Somewhere behind her, Bow, tries to calm her down but Glimmer grunts, forcing the doorknob and groaning frustrated when it doesn´t give up. “Catra!”

Catra closes her eyes and silently begs them to go away, an errand tear running down her cheek, warm against her freezing skin. Melog rises their head from the space below Catra´s elbow they have nestled into, looking at the banging door with wide eyes, They turn to look at Catra and when she doesn´t make an attempt to move, Melog sprints into their tiny feet, making their way to the door and purposely sitting in front of it, looking directly at Catra´s face. A new knock comes and Melog quite literally wails loudly, scratching the bottom of the door with their little sharp nails.

“I think that´s Melog,” Bow´s voice murmurs, mirroring Glimmer´s concern.

“Catrina Greyskull, if you don´t open this door right now I´m going to break it down, do you understand?!” Glimmer yells, walking back a few steps over the porch to give herself impulse. She is serious. “One!”

Melog screeches again, finally managing to get Catra´s attention. She looks at them from her spot in the floor, blue eyes against multicolored and the look Melog gives her it´s almost pleading. It makes something painful to squeeze in her chest.

“Two!”

Catra drags herself in her hands and her feet, standing up precariously. Every single muscle in her body screams with the change of posture. She ignores the way the delicate bones of her spine crack and pull horribly from her skin and makes her way to the door, switching the safe and grabbing the knob. Melog jumps into their feet again, rubbing themself against Catra´s legs happily.

“Three!”

Glimmer doesn´t get to charge against the door but she is damn close to it. Catra swings the door and stares at both of them without an expression in her face. Her eyes burn against the light of the day after spending so long in the darkness, drifting in and out of a merciful unconsciousness several times. The day is gray, silver clouds clotting the sky above their heads, cold breeze, and the sea is violent against the shore, crashing over the stones and the dark pebbles and against the bottom of the cliff, sorrowful.

Glimmer and Bow stand without moving, just looking at her barely standing up against the frame of the door. She doesn't know how she looks to them - feet bare, scratched in the soles,

hair wild, face pale and thin, bruised from crying and from fighting against the sea - and she doesn't care, waiting for any of them to say something before closing the door on their faces. Glimmer and Bow share an alarmed look.

“Um, Catra-” Bow starts but does not manage to keep going, shifting uncomfortably on his feet.

“What do you want?” Catra´s voice is terrible, broken into splinters and barely even there, the aftermath of screaming her heart out. Bow cringes softly, wrinkling his nose but the sound just fuels Glimmer further, shaking the shock away as she straightens up her shoulder, getting into motion immediately.

“I´ve been calling you for days and you won´t answer! And after that stunt in port I just- I thought- Ugh! We´ve been worried sick! ” Glimmer scolds her loudly, stretching her arms to rest her hands over Catra´s shoulders. Catra recoils away from the touch as if it had burnt her, crossing her arms over her middle and avoiding Glimmer´s eyes, biting on the inside of her cheek until it bleeds. Glimmer widens her eyes in surprise but doesn't try it again, looking inside the house instead. “What happened? Where is Adora?”

The words stab into Catra's heart, slashing her open again, pouring all of her blood into the ground. It feels so real, so painful, that Catra has to look down at her own chest, just to see if she is not actually bleeding out, slipping into the fabric of her shirt - Adora's shirt - and down her arms and wrists.

She is breathless and voiceless when Glimmer doesn't wait another second and charges inside the house immediately, Bow following quickly. Catra stays in the corridor, back against the wall, barely holding herself on her feet. The room is spinning slightly, blurring dark in the edges.

"Adora? Are you here?" Glimmer calls, looking at the kitchen and the empty living room. The piano in the corner is already collecting dust. Her voice sounds far away, drowned out, as if Catra was submerged underwater, ears full of salt.

"Catra? I'm going to check your pulse alright?" Bow is saying, gently taking Catra's wrist between his fingers. He also sounds so far away, even when he is barely a few inches from Catra, delicately running his fingers over her arm and then across her cold sweaty forehead, frowning deeply.

Glimmer steps into the bottom of the stairs, looking up with narrowed eyes. "Adora?"

Catra has never been one of poetry. She found solace in the horror of her stories, the darkness and the loneliness as her comfort. She would never understand the kind of words that would transform simple organs into flowers and feelings into strands of breeze. Never. Not until Adora. But now she knows, Catra knows, and she hates and adores every single second of it. She knows what it is to feel her lungs filled with seafoam, she knows what it is to spill tears into the sand like dew against dry leaves.

She knows what it is to feel her ribcage as the frail cage that once held Adora's skin in the grasp of a monster. She knows what it is to look inside for her heart and find nothing.

Nothing at all. Her heart is gone and everything inside is hollow as a mausoleum made for two where only one lies. And the crystal brittle strength she has left starts to fissure in the edges.

Crack

"She is gone" Catra says, thin and fragile, so small none of them hear her at all. She doesn't hear herself either. Maybe her voice and words have left her too.

Crack, crack.

"Is she upstairs? What is going on?" Glimmer insists, her hair undone, looking around the corridor as if Adora was going to sprout from the drawings of the staining glass and step in front of her, with her legs of marble and her golden hair. But Glimmer doesn't understand, she will never understand, that a siren did come and stole Catra's heart and now she will never step into these wooden floors ever again.

Crack .

"She is gone"

"What-"

"She is gone!" The glass breaks down and Catra comes undone with it. The screams bubble inside her chest and out of her throat, choking her, strangling her, holding her down. Glimmer and Bow both jump in surprise but it is already too late, too far gone. Gone. Catra is past it all and there is nothing else within herself but regret and anger and loss. "She is gone, she is gone!"

Catra grabs whatever is next to her, a glass, a vase, a mirror, she doesn't know, and slams it into the ground, the sharp pieces scattering everywhere. Catra grunts, screaming at the broken fragments and tearing of her hair until her scalp hurts, digging her nails into her temples as she tries to feel anything, pain or ache, whatever that is different to the abysmal brutality and emptiness in her soul. But none come, just guilt and regret and grief. Just that. No more.

"She is gone, don't you get it?! She left! She left, she- she-" Catra gasps, her throat burns, suffocating in her own lament. All the fury comes and goes swift as a wave, leaving her aflame to the bone. She doesn't know where to go, where to look, eyes roaming everywhere in the ground from broken glass to pearls to tears. "She left. She left- left *me* . I *made* her leave me- She is gone and she is never coming back and I- I- "

Words fail her, she is not even talking anymore. The world shakes and Catra thinks she might fall into the ground again from the way she is trembling, from head to toe, her teeth grinding against each other by the force of the spasms. Her own words echo inside the home and inside her head.

Gone. Gone.

"Oh no," Bow whispers, looking back at Glimmer as he starts placing Catra's words together, his eyes narrowed in sorrow when he understands this is not about someone attacked - as they feared -but someone that has lost something.

"Oh, Catra." Glimmer moves very softly, like approaching a wounded and terrified lion. Understandment has finally and somehow fallen over her too and her lilac eyes are full of tears too, reflecting just the tiniest fraction of Catra's pain. "Oh, darling, come here"

"She is gone and it's all my fault but I couldn't - I couldn't -" Catra is saying without sense, lost inside herself. "She is gone and I-"

"Shh, I know" Glimmer wraps her fully inside her arms, trying to reassure her. She can feel her, shivering uncontrollably. "I know, it's alright. We're going to fix it,. alright? We'll figure it out-"

Catra doesn't even notice she is crying again until she is inside her embrace, tears staining her face, sticking to her dark eyelashes and drowning her eyes. Glimmer's voice crosses through the mental mist of Catra's mind. She starts shaking her head violently, shifting inside Glimmer's hold until she is kicking and lashing again, pushing Glimmer away.

"No. No no. Don't touch me! Don't touch me, don't fucking touch me!" Catra howls, pushing herself back with so much force that she trips with something on the ground and falls hard against the wall, her shoulder connecting painfully with the concrete. She rests her forehead against the surface, hiccuping around a sob.

Time stills inside the house, Bow next to the door, Glimmer next to the stairs, Catra against the wall. In her outburst she knocked one of the pictures down, the glass cracked in the very middle. It's a picture of Adora, sitting on the edge of the stones next to the shore. The red and golden light of the sunset makes her hair look like pink quartz, falling over her naked shoulder and chest in loops. She is staring at the water and the sun, a smile hidden on the corner of her mouth, a secret kiss with an owner living in that sweet space. Her skin is golden and her eyes are ambers and, even here, she was already loved.

Catra took it, long before that night of the candles, before she knew what Adora's mouth tasted like, before she knew how her skin felt against her hands and how her spine felt under her nails. Long before she ever thought she would get to know what was to have her and what was to lose her, a fragment of a memory Catra kept between the pages of her books to make her company until she finally hanged in the lounge, like a prayer whispered in a solstice.

Catra has broken it in half, just like everything, just like her. Tearing all things good and gentle from the root because that's what Catra does, that's all she knows how to do. Have beautiful things and ruin them. Break them. Taint them.

"Get out," Catra leans and picks up the broken frame as she says it, placing the picture against the small table next to her carefully, very gently, unnervely and suddenly calm.

Glimmer rushes next to Bow's side, holding his sleeve as she shakes her head purposely, trying to keep her voice under control before she talks. "Cat-"

"Get out! OUT" Catra spins in her ankles, grabbing them both by the necks of their shirts and dragging them across the corridor and out the door, shoving them back into the porch with surprisingly harsh strength. Both of them trip, barely managing not to fall flat in their faces by grabbing into one another. They turn around to look at Catra but before any of them can say anything at all, she slams the door shut right in on their face, the hinges protesting loudly.

Catra rests her back against the closed door, exhaling heavily. Her legs are trembling terribly, so much that when her knees finally give up below her she falls hard against the floor.

Inhale. Exhale. Sob.

A sob breaks through her voice, high and painful, heartbreaking, echoing inside the empty house like a war horn. Catra closes her eyes tightly and bangs her head against the hardwood behind her, once, twice, until she is seeing spots of white in front of her eyes and her nape hurts.

"Catra. Catra open the door" Glimmer calls softly from the other side of the door, at the level of Catra's head. She has probably sank into her knees too "Sweetheart, let us help you, please"

"Leave me," Catra's voice is drowned out, so, so tired, so angry and so defeated at the same time until it sounds like she is begging. She lets her face fall over her bend knees, hugging her legs close to her chest. "Just leave me alone"

Melog comes walking towards her, ears pressed against their head, meowing softly. Catra doesn't move, doesn't even raise her face, hugging herself as if this way she could make herself a small particle and fly away. Melog meows one more time and curls around her feet, purring gently and comforting.

Somewhere beyond the door, Glimmer and Bow are still talking, reassuring Catra, trying to convince her to open the door again. She doesn't. Their voices go on until they are echoes alongside the waves that crash against the shore, calling her away from home. Catra doesn't stand up.

○

Humans like to think the depths of the ocean are some kind of mystical place, unknown to their eyes, unexplored and untamed, a place they haven't been able to get their hands into to do as they please. So they will buy their machines, construct their radars and sonars, destroy so they can satisfy they curiosity and their greed and yet, yet, when they manage to scratch just the surface the ocean meets them with darkness, wild, sometimes violent, of a silence so terrifying and lethal it shakes then to their cores and makes them look away, unable to look beyond the suffocating blackness.

What humans don't get to know, to understand, is that they are right. The sea beyond their reach is of a beauty beyond their comprehension. It's brutal, unfiltered, free. Unstained still by the hands of men. Adora has seen it all, from the tiniest organism that illuminates the floor

of the ocean in purples and blues, to the big animals, several times bigger than her. She has swam under their bellies and across the seagrass that grew over the floor. She has dived into the infinite depths of the oceans pits until there was nothing around her but particles and then, beyond the darkness, peaceful silence. She has seen the reds and the pinks and bright blues with her eyes, and colors no human could ever see in their entire lives. She has curled herself around coral reefs and destroyed with her hands and her powerful tail the remains of the humans´ print, left over the sea life and the floor.

Adora has seen it all. She has lived dozens of years on the ocean, knows it as the claws in her hands and the skin in her body. She has chased the danger and the adrenaline, swam against the violent ties, hunting the most dangerous animals knowing she is the apex predator, that she could bend the sea life in her hands if she wanted to.

Adora has missed the ocean deeply, missed it as breath, missed all of what made her what she was and yet now that she is here, curled around roots forever encased in salt and stones like knives with nothing but deep, deep blue all around her, so thick and huge she can't even see the sunlight, for the first time in her long life she is drowning in the dark.

For the first time her eyes, sharp, meant for the underseas and the hunt, are blind. She can't see the lights of the algae around her, she can't hear the singing of the animals swimming peacefully somewhere, miles above her. She can't feel the cold or the warmth of the tides as they change and cross courses. She doesn't feel the thrill of the ocean, she doesn't feel the freedom. Instead she feels caged, she feels like a prisoner, pressed down by the weight of the waters she once called home.

Adora knows it's not possible, it mustn't because she is, somehow, still alive, but she can't feel the oxygen running through her body from her gills, she can't feel the blood running through her veins. Her chest rises and falls but she doesn't feel anything inside. She is as she was before everything, a pearl, a sea shell, white and golden like daylight, so bright she almost looks lilac and blue among the shadows. Her gills are the same, over her neck and her ribs. Her fins are as they always were, fine membranes like silk, all colors changers, poisonous thorns in the edges, crawling over her back and her arms like armor. Her tail is as she remembers, powerful muscle that defies the strength of the ocean, long enough to surround her completely, embroidered in scales like gems, a strand of moonlight against the blues of the ocean.

She is as she was and yet nothing is the same, the world has shifted from its axis. The ocean welcomes her and she embraces it in return because it is a part of her but something is missing, heavier than being ripped from her skin, more painful, terribly more sorrowful.

She lies there, in the freezing cold depths of the ocean, curled in her side, and feels herself bleed to death into the sand even if she isn't. She lies there, throat and chest and back exposed, taunting the other predators, taunting the very ocean, as if saying *come here, come here for me, there is nothing else.* Adora looks inside herself and doesn't find anything else.

Adora lies halfway buried in the white sand, a ghost of a tale drifting away with the tide. Her arm is extended to the side, almost like a second nature, almost as if she was trying to reach something, to cradle it. Something. *Someone* .

Her palm is up, claws long and as dark as everything inside her, even longer fingers strong and covered in sharp escales and thorns. And then, there, in the second to last finger of her hand, a rope like a braid, delicate yet stubborn, refusing to give up under the pressure and the salt, held around Adora´s fingers as a second beating heart. It remains there because Adora can´t take it off, it remains there because ripping it off would feel like ripping her skin from her muscles, her lungs from her ribcage, her blood of her aorta.

Absently she knows she is singing, grave but loud, or she was, she doesn't know if the ringing in her ears it's her song anymore. She doesn´t recognize it. Under the water, her voice sounds different, high as it must be echoing through miles and miles of blue space, a call and a mourning until it's not a sound at all, so different from the sweet tones she had come used to sing, whispered at night like sweet promises as the ring in her hand.

Adora lies in the merciless cold of the ocean floor, closes her eyes and hopes the ocean devours her whole.

Catra steps out of the shower, dripping water across the floor. She doesn´t even think about what she is doing, going through the movements without thinking, probably pushed forward by some kind of self preservation or dignity, still refusing to die. Catra let it be. She doesn't care if she does it or not. She would lie if she said she knew when she stood up from the floor, how much time did it pass, how she dragged herself up the stairs and into the bedroom. She would lie if she said that, when she opened the door, the smell of Adora hit her with so much force she bent over the rail of the stairs, gasping, hyperventilating, somehow not throwing herself from it and into the floor.

Many hours must have passed after that because by the time Catra manages to drag herself inside the room it's dark outside the window. The curtain is still pulled back, letting moonlight shower the inside. The navy blue sheets on the bed are still undone, wrinkled and tossed aside alongside the pillows from where they had been sleeping before everything would come undone between her fingers. Adora´s red dress is draped over the chair next to the vanity, the pearl pins she used to hold her hair over the surface next to it.

Catra walks past it all without blinking, charging against the bathroom without closing the door behind her. The water is freezing cold when it falls over her but Catra doesn't even flinch, standing below the stream that hits her skin and face, soaking her hair to the root, just there, unmoving, until the water starts to fill her ears and she feels like she is going to scream.

Catra slips inside Adora´s nightgown, placing the thin straps over her shoulders. Somehow, it still feels warm.

Catra looks at herself in the mirror. Her eyes are hollow, bruised after crying so much every day. Her skin is pale, almost green under the light. She has scratches in her cheeks and a purple bruise on her chin where she fell at the port. She looks almost too thin inside the nightgown, swimming inside the silk fabric. Peach is not her color.

Her hair is knotted in places. Catra runs her fingers through the strands and gets tangled in the gentle embroidery of a loose braid, right behind her ear, made by Adora's gentle hands when Catra was sleeping, that night. A testament of tenderness and care even when she wasn't aware of it at all. There is the shadow of a kiss still painted on the angle of Catra's neck, partially hidden by the unattended curls and just the sight of it makes Catra spiral down

Catra grabs the handle of the scissors she keeps in the sink and snaps away. A huge strand of hair falls into the sink, curling over the marble sadly. Catra stands still, staring at it for a long second before swinging the scissors again. Snap, snap, snap, until the entire floor and the sink are filled with her hair.

Her short hair curls around her ears and over her temples, uneven, still damp. It's meant to get shorter once it dries.

She stares back at her and doesn't recognize herself.

Catra slams her fist against the mirror, cracking the surface from side to side. It makes a loud sound, louder in the silence of the house. Catra looks at her broken reflection, the expression in her eyes as broken as the surface, despair and desperation and heartbreak clear in every single of her factions. There are tiny and sharp pieces of the mirror digging on the skin of her knuckles, making her bleed slightly, pooling on her palm and dripping over the tiles.

She wonders when did herself, when did Catra, always proud and stubborn and dignified, allowed herself to reach this point. She wonders when did she let herself break apart for someone like this. But this is not just anyone, this is Adora, *Adora* . Catra´s Adora who has never belonged to her in the first place. Catra´s Adora who always leaves. This is Catra´s true love, only love, in every life and every universe, as painful or beautiful as it may be, and Catra is always, always, going to undo herself for Adora.

Catra sinks into her knees and weeps.

•

The sun rises in land and sets at the ocean and the moon follows, two mirrors of each other's sorrow, following the other's shadow, unable to ever touch again.

They run around each other and time runs with them.

The piano is left untouched, dust gathering over the surface, sorrowful and silent. There is nobody there to play it.

The fireplace is cold. There are still half burn logs inside and old ashes from even older fires, resting one over the other like gray graves. Even during the coldest nights of this freezing spring, it is never lit again.

The bed is undone, she can't bring herself to make it. Instead, she grabs all the sheets and blankets and drags them inside the eventually dry and huge bathtub of the room, curled around them inside the cold marble every night until sleep manages to take her away from some fake merciful minutes. The fabric still smells like them, like *her,* sea salt and sweetness and sex. She should wash them. She doesn't.

She barely eats, bread crumbs and some kind of breakfast protein bars. The rest of the spoiled food is thrown away. Melog is fed diligently every day but that's all.

She takes cold showers in the first floor bathroom and never looks at herself in the mirror.

She doesn't write again. She doesn't draw or paint. The notebooks where she used to scribble little notes and sketch Adora's precious face lay forgotten in the desk and the floor.

The phones are either uncharged or unplugged, the cable of the land line ripped from the wall after the voice message machine reached a limit. Glimmer calls, several times, and leaves voice messages on all of them. Bow calls too, leaving little notes as messages in the chat. She opens them and reads them and hears them but never answers, until the battery finally dies and never bothers to plug it again. She knows they take loops around her bay every day to see if she is alive.

She turns on a lamp when she sees them but doesn't come out, a silent signal. They don't knock, the house remains quiet. For a while, it's alright.

Spinerella sends her an email congratulating her for the book sales but she doesn't answer back. Instead she manages to email Scorpia, manages to fool her that everything is well and asks her to take care of that for a while.

She doesn't sing again, or dance. She can't.

The stained glass window remains open, even when it rains, pouring soft droplets over the loveseat and the floor. She sits over the seat until the day turns into night, her temple against the cold glass, knees against her chest, looking at the waves without speaking. This way, she thinks, *she* might have a way to come back if she wants.

Nobody comes. The window remains open, always.

When she is not next to the window she is the shore, sitting over the slippery pebbles or next to the sharp stones where she had found her that night. She sits there and waits, under rain or under warmth until she physically can't do it anymore and the thought of Melog makes her go back inside.

She doesn't think that she cries until she realizes she has been doing it as a second nature now. She cries and doesn't feel it run down her cheeks anymore, eyes red and raw.

The ocean is full of her tears.

Somewhere inside her head she knows she can't go like this forever. She knows she should be worrying about other things, worrying about herself, about consequences to her actions. She

knows she should get herself together and go back to the life she had almost a year ago, when she was alone and thought she didn't need anyone to live.

But living and surviving are two very different things, and existing once the axis of your world is gone is like leaving a planet drifting away without its star, forever condemned to fall apart.

Catra didn't know love could be so devastating, but then again, all myths end the same. Falling in love with a siren will always, always, break your heart.

○

Adam swims down the depths, powerful tail breaking easily against the pressure of the water. He has the prey between his claws, still a little bit warm, fresh from the hunt. He knows the blood slipping through the ocean current around him calls the curiosity from various predators nearby, just to swim away quickly when they take in Adam's presence.

He has never liked to refer to himself with a human name, he has even recoiled at the even sound. He doesn't need it, he never has. The ocean has given him his name, unpronounceable, a song only heard by the ocean and its creatures, a sound that belongs to the sea and never to the land.

He belongs to the oceans, to the depths, to the hunt and the blood and the prey. He belongs to the ocean animals and to the currents and to the darkness that is filled with earth shattering colors. He has always belonged here, where there are no limits, no cages. Where he can swim under the orcas and sink his teeth over preys when he is hungry. Here is where Teela is and where he is and he has never needed anything else, neither crave it.

But his sister is different, she always has been different.

They've been together their entire lives, hundreds of years living across the oceans, from the freezing cold waters to warmths. Their parents, as any merfolk, had left them very young and so they had always had each other's back, hunting together and on their own. Siren's didn't need more.

And yet, his sister has always been full of curiosity, always swimming around sunk constructions, always floating too close to the surface, always marveled by the things the land has to offer, both beautiful and terrible. She had always been attracted by it, called by the shimmer of the stars on the dark blue sky, mirror of the oceans, like songs coming from the sea.

She has always been free in her own way, reckless, chasing stormed oceans like chasing sunlight. Swimming in dangerous waters with mirth in her smile and across sharp shipwrecks as knives without fear. And no matter how much he has tried to convince her otherwise, she has never been one to listen, stubborn and mischievous, too strong-headed to understand the danger she might come upon.

She has always been like this, tethering between two worlds, driven by something beyond herself until, suddenly, she was gone. And he would never admit it out loud but he has never been more afraid before, searching for her on every ocean and sea, thinking she was gone, *gone,* until he found her on land, cradled by a human hand instead of her own skin. And he also never would admit it, but as much rage and raw instinct was fighting inside him, as much hatred he had for the mortal breathing inside the human house by the shore, he had never seen his sister that happy, that bright.

She was so… weird. An absolute opposite to the sister he knew, with clumsy human legs instead of her strong marble tail and soft sun kissed skin instead of thorns and scales. But she was smiling and there was something earth shattering more different in her than her appearance, something intangible, living in her eyes and in the corner of her mouth like a secret. Like a bruise, but tender. Like an embrace.

It took him a lot of time, many many moons and he could never understand. But.. the way she was smiling, the way she was singing that day, he knew she had found what she had unknowingly searched for so desperately for so many years. And little by little, from afar, he thought he could accept it after all, even if it meant never seeing her again.

And then…

Adam makes his way through deep stone formations and across narrow passages until he manages to enter the underwater caverns his sister is in. Here, the roof of the cave forms an air pocket between the edge of the water and the stone, creating a suspended space neither on land nor on ocean, unreachable for anything else but them.

Adam peeks his head from the calm surface of the water, wrinkling his nose at the first breath of air, his gills shivering uncomfortably. Here the small bioluminescent creatures dimly illuminate the fake floor. He sharpens his eyes, looking around the cavern. It doesn't take him long to find her.

Adora is halfway propped on a tall rock inside the cave, her tail on the water. Her arms are crossed over the surface of the rock, head nestled over them, looking at some point of the darkness of the water without blinking. Her eyes are narrowed, so sad and raw that the fragile skin under it looks almost bruised, lilac and red, looking without really seeing anything at all.

Everything about her looks shrunk and toned down. From her hair, falling over her shoulder in damp silk almost green under the shadows of the cavern, to her skin, purple and lilac with spots of deep blue over the soft fins of her tail. Everything about her had always been so bright, like a raw pearl golden in the middle of the deep black. But now she has turned dim and sorrowful, almost too sad to even touch. A dying star.

Adam grimaces, pulling out of the water until it reaches his elbows, carrying the fresh prey out of the water and over the lower rocks.

"I brought you prey" he sings, echoing in the reduced space.

"I'm not hungry," Adora sings back, broken and low, turning her head to the opposite side, away from Adam, hiding it between the angle of her arms.

Adam snaps his teeth together, quick anger and frustration overcoming him. He bares his teeth at her, balling his hands into fists at his sides, tail snapping angrily under the water. "You haven't eaten in weeks, you can't starve to death that's not how this works"

"Then how does it work, brother?" She sounds so far away, song hollow, uninterested. Adam grinds his teeth, unable to hide the sharp edge of his song.

"I found you mourning in the depths of the ocean, shredding your own voice, you scared every single animal in miles."

She wasn't even singing. It was the kind of lament that made the oceans tremble and the animals to hide away. The kind of lament heard in sorrowful moments from the mouth of someone that has met death and wasn't given the mercy of the peace that comes after. The kind of lament of someone that has lost everything. When Adam arrived at the place where it was coming he found Adora lying over the deep floor of the ocean, unmoving, like a piece of coral reef dead and drifting away. She didn't react when he called for her, didn't move when he pulled from her arms and carried her away. There was nothing there but sadness, the ghost of what his sister was, what she had become.

Adam deflates a little by the memory, softening his song. "I thought you were dying, sister"

Adora doesn't answer, doesn't even turn around, her shoulders shivering where her hair falls over her arms. There is a scar on the high of her back, long ago healed, crossing from her shoulder to the low of her ribs. The fins in her powerful back are dim and thin, thorns like lighting barely there at all. Some of the dark scales of her skin and her tail are falling down on their own, leaving sad paths over the cave's floor.

Maybe she is dying, after all, in some kind of way Adam cannot understand.

"I've been going to your shore, where your human is"

It does the trick. Adora snaps her head back to Adam, eyes wide, song dangerously slow. "What?"

He hesitates for a second but keeps going.

"The first time I went because I wanted to kill her. I was going to do it. I was going to drown her and tear her into pieces, for what she has done to you."

Adam watches as Adora raises her weight on her arms, nails digging inside the stone, scratching deep lines into the powerful mineral easily, with no resistance at all. Her entire face shifts, eyes narrowing in black, the blue of her irises bleeding into bright red. Her mouth stretches into a grimace, like a silent scream, in panic and rage, and every single scale on her body, of a muted copper and marble and purple since she came back, shivers and blends to pitch black, until she is a shadow around the dim brightness of the cavern, a creature pulled from the very ends of the ocean, where nothing beautiful ever grows. Deadly.

The cavern starts to shake, debris falling into the dark waters, filled with a low song coming from the back of Adora's throat, a scream knotted in every single note of her voice, threatening to turn it all to pieces. Adam swims back a little, shaking his head. This is his sister but, for one second there and for the first time of their long lives, he is afraid of her.

"I didn't, I couldn't. I didn't even go close to her, I swear."

They stay like this for a long suspended moment, Adora unmoving, Adam tense in every muscle, that hurtful song ripping through the cavern until it finally lowers and dies down. It comes back to normal slowly, black back to the dim colors, red washing away until Adora is back as she was, lowering back over the rock like a mourning spirit, sad and frail.

Even in her betrayal and her grief, the idea of harm falling over her human almost breaks his sister into pieces.

"Stay away from her," Adora says, muffled as she hides her face between her arms, but heavy and brusque and Adam fails to understand if it's a threat towards him or a warning for his sake. He suspects it's the first.

Adam presses his mouth into a tight line and swims closer, to the edge of the lower rocks, trying to search for his sister's eyes but failing. He looks away, at the calm water and past it, to the deep blue. Where his seal-like tail draws lazy swirls, his sister's tail, long and powerful, is curled tightly on itself inside the water as if it didn't even wanted to be there in the first place

"You looked happier. Before" Adam says, as a matter of fact. He can't help himself, so he just puts it out like that, unfiltered on his worry. In the rock next to him Adora bares her teeth, eyes tightly closed.

"You don't need to tell me about my life here, brother. I know it"

Adam falls quiet for a second after she snaps at him, letting the water quiet around them before singing again.

"I don't mean in the ocean."

He can almost physically feel the way Adora stops breathing, frozen in her place.

"Brother" It's a warning. He ignores it.

"She is waiting for you"

Adora's entire body shivers with the words. Her eyes swell with tears, sticking to her dark eyelashes, her entire face shifting with grief.

"I-" Adora's song trembles, confusion and guilt fighting in her face before she looks down at Adam, wrinkling her nose and snarling. "You told me, alright? You told me what they do and why, you tried to warn me. Well, you were right, fine? You. We're. Right. I was wrong with all of it, I thought it would be different, that it would be an exception but no. She- she- I trusted her and she-"

Adora chokes, digging her claws so hard against her upper arms the otherwise impenetrable scales start to give away, points of golden ichor starting to bleed very lightly from them. Pain distracts her, it helps her not to think.

"She'll keep waiting, what, every once in a while when she feels guilty about it? When she remembers me?" The words burn on Adora's tongue because she knows they aren't true and saying them out loud feels like a betrayal all on their own. It seems as if the only thing Adora has managed to do for three weeks is duel on her own pain and lie to herself.

"No" Adam cuts her short. His song has changed too, turned hard and short. Because even after everything he knows his sister. "She waits for you every day for hours. She just… sits on the shore and waits"

"I-"

"She cries every day too"

"Oh"

"I've never seen a human cry like that. It's - devastating" Adam squirms uncomfortable on the water, wrinkling his nose. "It makes *me* feel bad"

The words turn Adora's blood into ice because there has never been a world where Adora had ever wanted to make Catra cry. Because, betrayed or not, Catra is rooted inside Adora's bones, breath of her lungs, blood of her blood. And sometimes she thinks she can feel her there too, on the marrow and inside every cell and below her very skin, the ghost of her touch in Adora's chest like an open wound. Sometimes she thinks the pain she feels it's not only her own.

But she can't think about it. She can't allow herself to think about it because if she does, if she imagines Catra's dear face as she dreamt it, as she sees it every time she closes her eyes, bruised with sorrow and alone, Adora might just rip her own throat open and pull out all of her bones off her body and tear her heart from her chest with her bare hands.

"Do you really think she stole your skin?" Adam asks, softly but firm, looking now directly at Adora's eyes even when she avoids him.

"She had it"

"That's not what I asked"

"I-" Adora hesitates, her heartbeat speeding up. "I don't know"

Because, beyond her grief and the pain in her heart and the thought that Catra had been the one that had stolen her skin, that she had lied to Adora for so long, what hurts Adora the most is that she doesn't understand. She doesn't understand why, why if everything that Adora is was already Catra's, why, why, why. She doesn't even understand how. She doesn't understand.

"You'll never know unless you listen to her" Adam chews on his claws, licking off the blood from the prey forgotten on the rocks. "It's very easy, lash out and leave when things hurt you and confuse you," Adam stares at the side of Adora's face, sees the way her expression falls, the way her heart and her mind are fighting inside of her, forever torn apart. "But you love her"

"What does that matter anymore?" Adora asks even though her song breaks miserably, pain flaring on her chest.

"It matters because she needs you" Adam never thought he could come in some kind of defense for a human but here he is after all, trying to convince his sister to listen to her heart for once. "And she needs to trust that you will listen to her, that you won't run."

Adora feels like she's been slapped because, isn't that the truth? She ran away. She ran away at the first opportunity she had, pulled by her fear and her confusion. Ran away back to the ocean's arms without looking back, just as she promised Catra she wouldn't do.

"Human lives are very short, Adora, and they are very, very fragile" Adam places his hand over his sister's elbow, long claws and translucent membranes almost shimmering against the sickly pale of her skin. "You know, when mates are far away from each other, they don't always leave this world together. Sometimes, if one is gone, the other remains, existing. They become hollow things, full of regret, forever parted, and you will face all the ages of the world alone in your grief, without her." Adam's gaze softens as much as it can below the predator facade, squeezing from her arm gently. "You are my sister, I don't want that to happen to you"

Adora is visibly trembling now, creating waves in the spot of the water where she is.

"Why are you saying all this? You hate humans." It's not reproach but Adora just can't wrap her head around it. "You don't care that she had my skin?" And the way she says that, it's almost as if she was asking herself.

"I care about you. And you care about her" Adam finally climbs over the opposite side of the rock, leaning close to Adora's face until she presses their foreheads together, a small gesture between them that has always reassured them, always letting them know the other is there. Adora closes her eyes tightly, pressing her mouth into a line. This close, Adam can see the way she looks sick, too pale, too fragile, too heartbroken. He has seen this face before, in a human sitting close to the shore. "I couldn't touch her because she smells like you. And you smell like her. We only mate once in our lives, sister, and losing a mate can break you. And you *chose* her"

Adam squeezes from her arm once more before slipping back into the water. Before he leaves he turns to look at his sister´s broken expression once more, singing quietly before swimming away, back into the dark waters where he belongs and where his sister is lost. "Think about it, *Adora* "

Adam doesn't say it, but he had a dream. Sirens and selkies sometimes have dreams, when something important is going to happen. He had a dream the night Adora went missing. He had a dream last night. It was red and angry, like a scream made images on his head. He

doesn't care about humans, but he knows that what is about to happen to the human his sister adores, it might break them both completely.



Catra drags herself inside the house. There are footprints of sand where she walks but she doesn't bother to clean them away.

Catra walks into the kitchen, takes Melog's plate and serves them food. Practiced motions, the same steps again and again. Turn, change water, leave them on the floor. Done. A repetition that keeps her from driving insane.

She strips from her seawater soaked clothes and leaves them somewhere on the floor, slipping inside Adora's white shirt - warm, smelling of her - and sleep shorts. There are grains of sand in her hair that fall sadly over her shoulders when she moves.

Sometimes, she likes to walk into the sea. Just walk and walk and walk, until she physically can't do it anymore, water reaching her waist. Until the strength of the sea locks her in place and doesn't let her go further, even when the ocean is calm. She just walks inside the water until it won't let her anymore.

The house, as always, is quiet.

There are storm clouds on the horizon, dark and heavy, electric. Yet the calm on the shore is almost unnerving, so still that it looks suspended in time. There is not even a breeze, not for now, and the waves are too quiet, too still, barely even seafoam at all. The water is so blue it looks almost black, like ink poured onto the sea, and there are no animals around, not even birds. Just quiet.

Catra hears the wheels of a car roll on the further end of the meadow behind the house. It's far away enough that she knows it's trying to go unnoticed, lowering down when it gets to the sight of the house before stopping. Catra can still hear the motor running.

Catra sighs, rubbing her eye with the heel of her hand, distractedly wiping tears away. Glimmer and Bow drove by early in the morning, she heard them, and she found the bag full of fresh groceries on the door as she walked out to the shore. Absently, Catra supposes they are checking on her before the storm hits. Absently also, Catra wishes it will blow her away, as if she cares.

Catra hears the car get just a little bit closer, scrutinizing the darkness of the house. Catra doesn't bother to look through the window, she never does, reaching closer to the side table and turning on the only lamp there without a second thought.

The dim golden light pours out of the window and into the start to the meadow, bright enough to reach the tinted windows of the car.

The motor comes back to life and immediately drives away.

○

Adora swims close to the surface and almost doesn't recognize the sun. It's too golden, too bright against her skin, long ago painted in dark colors after spending so much time hiding in the shadows. She comes because she heard it, the song of a friend of long ago, echoing through the immense expanse of the ocean, calling for her.

Swimming hurts. It feels as natural as existing but it hurts just as much, on every single of her scales and every inch of her body, it hurts. Adora had never felt like this before. It had always been natural, easy, it had turned her cocky against the danger and careless. Now, every time her tail and her fins and her hands break through the water as flying it makes her want to cry. It doesn't feel right.

Adora is almost on the surface when she sees her, huge and beautiful as only creatures like this can be, swimming slowly, without hurry. The entire ocean is theirs.

Adora makes a small sound, not even a word, but the blue whale hears her because she turns her huge eye towards her, singing happily when she takes in Adora´s presence. She has known Adora since she was a cub, too curious of the land world for her own good, mischievous and sharp as a shark and since then the mother whale has taken on herself to keep an eye on her. They have been each other´s companions in countless migrations and Adoras has met her cubs and the cubs of her cubs because, contrary to what humans may think, whales can be as old as time, existing in their own world, under their own rules. Adora thinks that´s part of what excited her so much about them, the liberty of choosing how to live, up or down, kind in the middle, sometimes, of war. And the mother whale has known plenty of war. She is pretty old, after all.

“ *There you are,”* mother whale greets her, only to stop on her slow and peaceful pass to scrutinize Adora completely with her eye. “ *Oh darling, what happened?”*

Mother whale is very old, and so she is also very wise, she can see through Adora clearly, completely, from the inside out.

Adora swims to her immediately, hugging as much of mother whale as she can reach, curling around the side of her huge face with a sob, making herself as small as she possibly can. Mother whale hums, her song sweet and reassuring as it always is, crossing the ocean with its calmness. Adora mourns, crying against her. Here, the ocean washes her tears away.

Mother whale lulls Adora for a while, swimming them both across a few miles of the ocean, until Adora calms down, silent as she curls herself over the angle mother whale's pectoral fin, right next to her face.

“ *I went to land”* Adora sings in a whisper, barely heard above the overwhelming quiet of the ocean.

“Finally” Mother whale sings back, truly happy for Adora. She has known of her curiosity for decades, always pushing her forward when doubt overcame her. She knew something had happened when Adora disappeared suddenly from the ocean and yet something in mother

whale told her it was not all so bad, that it was for a reason and she hoped it was a good one. “ *Tell me more”*

“I fell in love” Adora´s song is sweet when she says it, the sweetest mother whale has ever heard it, and yet is soaked in sorrow, so much that it almost breaks mother whale´s own heart. “ *I fell in love. I am in love”*

Adora falls quiet, watching the water breaking through their bodies. Here, on this part of the ocean everything is empty, there is nobody else but them, the ocean and the golden sunlight reflecting over the surface.

“ *What happened?”*

“ *She broke my heart”* Adora doesn't even sound angry, she just sounds tired. She is tired. She is tired of feeling worn out, she is tired of being confused, she is tired of being heartbroken. She is tired of dwelling in her own frustration, in her own pain. She is tired of trying to hate Catra because she can´t, she just can´t, she could never no matter what, because Catra is rooted in the very foundations of her heart. She is Adora's soul. “ *And I don't understand why”*

Mother whale hums, mindful of the despair in Adora's song. It takes her a few minutes but she turns her eye back to Adora, calm as ever but groundbreaking when she asks.

“Do you think she did it on purpose?”

Adora freezes, cheeks paling even underwater.

“I-” her song trembles and breaks, mind and heart coming to a sudden stop . *“What?”*

“My darling” Mother whale chants, very, very gently *“Tell me about her”*

Adora closes her mouth tightly, narrowing her eyes in sorrow. So close to the surface, the sunlight crosses the water in golden lines, illuminating Adora's hand when she turns her palm up, as if she could cradle the light in her bare hand.

“She is- she is like the sun” Adora finally sings, sweet, like a secret, like the dearest thing inside her heart. “ *I lived in darkness for so long, always looking for something. For a- for a purpose for a life so- endless. And then there was she and I- I. There was she and suddenly there was light and I've never felt so happy, so alive. She makes me want to be alive."*

Adora feels herself so small, so big but also so little, a predator brought to her knees by such a gentle creature and maybe this is what angels were to humans, written on the books and manuscripts that Adora read avidly. Maybe this is what an angel was, something so beautiful and so devastatingly lovely. Something too holy to touch. Something that can break you if you love them. Something worth being broken for. Maybe that's what Catra was to Adora. An angel, a sin, a sun. A blessing, never a curse. Salvation.

“I was attacked by hunters, near her shore, they tried to capture me and she saved me” Adora rests her temples against mother whale's side, looking at her hands. *“She saved me in*

so many ways."

I have nothing else to say to you, Adora, Catra had said and she sounded so far away, so beyond herself, big and unapproachable by Adora's touch. She didn't even sound like herself at all and the memory just leaves a hollow void inside Adora's chest because behind all of the pain, behind all what she thinks she knows right now, she knows something is wrong.

"When I was attacked, I lost my skin. And I thought it was gone, that it had been sold in the human world or just torn apart by predators or by the deep sea" It's not possible underwater but Adora takes a shaky breath. She feels cold. The ocean water had never bothered, never made a difference if it was warm or freezing but now Adora feels locked in a shiver. She feels so much she doesn't even know where to start. *"I found it, with her, in our home. In the- in the place I started calling home.* Our *home. And I don't know- I don't know where she got it. I don't know how. It was- it was there. We had been there so many time and I never saw it before and when I found it I- I-"*

I left, Adora thinks though she doesn't say it. It stings. She doesn't need to, mother whale understands anyway, humming a low reassuring song without a real meaning as she listens to Adora.

And even as she sings the words into the ocean Adora still can't believe it, still can't understand it. They were happy, Adora was happy, so happy. She had given Catra her entire heart, openly, without fears. And Catra- Catra had cradled Adora's heart inside her chest. She had embraced it with a feather touch and wrapped it around herself. And she had given her heart to Adora in return.

If she had asked, Adora would have given her the skin too. *Here, take it,* Adora would have said, without thought, without regret. *Take all of it. It's yours. All that I am is yours.*

So many promises, pressed against each other's skin. So much love, in red lips and sweet words and sweat, fingers over hips. So much happiness and laughter in each other's arms, raw honesty painted by swears.

So it doesn't make sense, it doesn't make sense-

"Why didn't she tell me?" Adora wonders, begging for clarity, begging for the truth. Mother whale sings and gives her that.

"Maybe she was afraid you wouldn't love her anymore once you knew"

And oh, isn't that just the truth? Catra might have lied but Adora ended up lying too.

Sweetheart, I'm not going to leave you

I choose you. I'm staying with you

Promise?

Promise

Adora broke them all, the promises she whispered to her, all the tender words, all the sweet touches. Adora betrayed them. Adora betrayed her too.

Adora did what every myth and folklore expected her to do, Adora did what every tale tells. She took her skin and drifted away from the human world, drifted away from her. And Catra hadn't even said anything. She had stood there, quiet and pale like a ghost. Catra had just let her go…

Adora's heart stops, pupils shrinking in pinpoints.

I'm not going to let them hurt you , Catra had said, that very first night, cradling Adora inside her arms with the wind against their hairs and the sand and pebbles digging on their knees, when neither even knew this was where love started.

She had said then after saving Adora, after tending her wounds, after opening the door for her, after saving Adora again and again and again. Because she wasn't a monster, she was kind and loving and compassionate, beauty surrounding her like sunlight, and there wasn't a day where Adora hadn't felt loved after that.

And Catra had *let her go.*

Mother whale stops, turning on her entire might so she can see Adora fully. She must sense that something has changed inside Adora because when she sings to her is kind but firm, a mother's gentle shake.

“Do you believe that she loves you?”

“Yes," Adora answers immediately, because she knows it's true, because she feels it in her heart. As she is, so is Catra. As the sun is to the sea. As sweet as a rope ring. Because no matter what, there could never be doubt about Catra's love inside Adora's heart. It is the best part of Adora's life.

“Do you think she stole your skin from you?”

I love you Adora, so much

“No,” Adora song shakes, almost choking her with the true meaning of the words, mighty as it is, crumbling her heart and all that she thought she knew.

Whales aren't supposed to be able to smile but mother whale does, bumping the side of her head softly against Adora's hands

“Darling, what are you doing here?”

Adora opens her mouth but no song comes out, voice suddenly drained completely.

"You've spent so long wandering the ocean alone, always asking yourself if this was it. An endless life without a purpose. And now that you are here again, you are lost." Mother whale rubs Adora's face gently before pulling back. " *The ocean will always love you and you will*

always be a part of it," she sings to her instead, pushing her in the right direction once again, *"but I think you need to go home"*

Mother whale swims away after a while. She sings for a few minutes more to Adora, no more words, lulling her when she loses herself inside her head, and then swims across the ocean, letting Adora float just below the surface of the water.

So close, Adora can feel the tension of the surface with her fingertips, almost breaking free, too close and too far away.

She has always been the kind of acting first and think later, it was a part of her instinct. But, all alone in the middle of the ocean, Adora finally lets everything fall down on her.

She thinks and she thinks. About Catra, smart and beautiful. Adora's soul living outside her body. Freckles as stars, small hands against Adora's palm. They had laughed, and they had danced around their kitchen floor and a dance floor flooded with water. They had shared secrets like songs whispered at dawn, had lay with each other, *loved* each other.

Catra, Catra who wouldn't let anyone touch her, had opened herself to Adora's touch. Had let Adora hold her hand and kiss her cheek and share the most intimate part of herself. Sex was such a vulnerable thing to do between them, a shared secret, holy intimacy, skin over skin, and Catra had bare herself as she was for Adora to take, trusting her she would look after her body and her heart.

Adors thinks about that night. Adora had kissed her, had run her hands down her waist and the curve of her legs, had made love to her until she fell asleep in Adora's arms. So much blind trust, so much love.

She needs to trust that you will listen to her.

It had been a perfectly beautiful day of a perfectly beautiful life and Adora was perfectly happy.

She had failed to see that not everything was perfectly fine.

I'm going to get you home

Catra had been so sad, the days before that night. Adora knew it, she had seen it, smelled the salt on her cheeks, felt the sorrowful sadness in her limbs. And Adora had tried to reassure her, had cradled her lips and wrapped her limbs with hers and made love to her in the most vulnerable way, but she never stopped to think that maybe there was something else going on, that maybe Catra's heart was breaking for a completely reason at all, slipping through Adora's fingers like sand.

You know she lied to you

Do you really think she took the skin from you?

No. No no no no no no no. No

Then why?

Maybe she was afraid you wouldn't love her anymore once you knew

You are a monster

Adora covers her face with her hands and screams.

It echoes all around her, bubbles of air rising to the surface like boiling water, drowning the very silence.

I love you Adora, no matter what

She is waiting for you

Adora is so far away, she is almost an entire day away and yet she is not far enough. There is not a corner of the earth where Adora wouldn't feel Catra.

The echoes of her scream die down and Adora closes her eyes, listening to the sounds the ocean carries around her, from the surface of the water to deep into the abyss, looking for something, anything.

In the end it's a whisper, a sob, shivering and tiny and scared, heartbroken, pronounced by who Adora loves the most, born from deep inside her soul, brought by the current, tears dropped on a sea, traveling until they can reach Adora. Begging her to stay.

Adora

Adora snaps her eyes open and swims as fast as she can back home.



Catra sits in front of the stained glass, chin over her knees, blinking very slowly. Her eyes feel so dry, itching from where she has been rubbing her fingers to wipe them away. The tears tracks must be carved in her cheeks by now.

The storm clouds are so much closer now, almost hovering over her and the shore completely. The temperature has dropped terribly, freezing cold and harsh against the exposed skin of Catra´s arm from where it slips inside the house through the open window. The wind is alive now and fully lashing against the house drowning every other sound, loud, terrifying. It almost sounds like a scream.

Her mind is numb, her body cold, locked in this place as she always does, every day of every single day until she feels she can´t hold on anymore. Every single day until the days started to blend into weeks and realization started to fall over Catra that she was, truly, not going to come back.

And yet here she is, watching as the glass trembles with a thunder so powerful it shakes all the windows of the house, unable to tear her eyes away from the waves.

It was a night like this when Adora arrived.

Melog meows from his spot on the floor, loud and screeching, distracting Catra from the window to look at them with knitted eyebrows. She turns to look at them and misses the movement on the shore, misses the unmistakable sound, drowned by another violent thunder in the sky. She misses it all

By the time she looks back outside, everything is quiet again.

There is a knock in the door

Catra stills on her place in the loveseat, digging her nails over the soft skin of her upper arms, unmoving. She waits for a heartbeat, then another, holding her breath. She can't allow herself to hope, *hope* , but she can't help herself. Her heart swells and wishes so much.

Knock, knock

Catra rises to her feet, tripping with the flat floor and almost falling in her face, rushing across the corridor with her heart in her throat. She reaches the door and pulls back the lock.

Knock, knock. Knock

Catra opens the door, eyes bright, not even bothering to look through the curtains.

"Adora?"

❍ ☙

Many, many years ago, in the times of Razz's grandparents, there was a lighthouse on the top of the cliff. For many years, it helped the boats and ships of the town to reach their destiny safely, to navigate across the violent oceans and to greet them back home, a beacon of light in the middle of the darkness.

Adora was still young on her immortality when she followed its light all the way to the surface for the first time.

She had always wanted to explore the surface world, always curious by their sounds, by their smells, by their colors, always pulled by something within her chest. Something that bloomed like a flower made of sun the moment she saw that light circling itself above the surface.

The first time, she hid behind one of the tallest rocks in the ocean, still far away from the humans shore, staring curiously with her sharp eyes. Her skin was young, her tail hadn't even reached its full leng, softly white against the night ocean. On the shore, there was a very small house, for the light keeper and her family. Before Adora could swim closer, Adam found her and basically dragged her down back in the water. Adora managed, however, to catch sight of the eyes of the light keeper. Amber and blue.

After that, she would come back several times across the decades, further apart each one as the world grew older and she didn't. Adora would see from far away as the small house

changed into a bigger one, as people came and went by, as the lighthouse became older and worn out until finally it was just rock in an empty cliff. Things raising, things falling, things changing and Adora remained the same.

Years went by and Adora never grew old, stuck, into a moment, into a place, always the immortal hunter, destined to watch things be born and rot. Always alone. She was free in the ocean and she was so lost, she had no place to return to.

Except that shore.

After many years, there was an old lady that taught Adora how to speak with her hands and then there was silence and emptiness inside the house.

And then, the sun. Turquoise and gold. It's her light what guides Adora back home.

It's night when Adora arrives, thick black clouds swirling in the sky above her head, menacing and dangerous. The wind is wild, lashing and screaming against the land. The ocean is violent, pulling back and then crashing against the rocks again and again, pause and repeat, a morbid dance that speaks of some kind of bad omen.

Adora peeks her head out of the water about half a mile away from the shore, looking from behind the same rock she had hidden that first time. The surface has long ago gone smooth by the water and the salts. This time, it's different though. This time Adora's ribs hurt from how hard her heart beats, her arms tingle from swimming without stopping, the fins of her back and tail are raised, anxious, waiting. Every single cell inside Adora's body is screaming, pulling her forward, trying to make her hurry up, starved.

Adora exhales and looks at the shore, heart thundering, narrowing her eyes. She can see and hear perfectly, even from so far away.

Suddenly, the wind comes to a stop, as if ordered by some god far beyond reach, submerging everything into thick calmness, the eye of a storm that is about to fall down.

The shore is empty, quiet, dark pebbles and sand. And then, several feet behind, is her home.

The house is drowned in darkness, the curtains are pulled back. It still has the same washed out shell color in the wall, the window frames are the blue Adora knows, there are pillows on the porch's seat.

On the right side, Adora can see the tinted glass window. It 's halfway open. Something swells in Adora's chest at the sight of it.

The curtain of their bedroom is pulled open but it's dark inside, Adora can't see past the reflection of the sea against the glass. Adora's wind chimes are still hanging from the roof of the porch, quiet as the wind dies. The door is open, hanging broken from its hinges …

Everything stops.

Adora's pupils dilate and then shrink into slits, nails digging into the hard surface of the rock. Absently, she is aware the sea is turning more violent around her, crashing against her back

and her tail with more violence. But Adora can't feel any of it.

Adora looks to the side, past the porch and the wind chimes and the broken door. She looks at the cars next to their home, one, two, three, white, white as light after an explosion. And green, a crooked logo carefully and perfectly painted on the side of the car doors. She has seen that painting before, across lashing rain and hooks against her skin, when she was fighting for her life. She saw it when the knives cut into her face and her back and she saw it turn around and disappear when met with tender lovely hands protecting her from them. Adora had seen that color, that figure, it was burnt into her memory, and she had not thought about it in so long, too busy learning to dance, too busy falling in love, too naive to think it wouldn't go back for her.

Adora can't feel her chest, she can't feel the freezing water or the movement of the waves. The door is open, the air smells like copper and salt, the pebbles that lead to the cliff are torn apart, and there is sand and sea glass everywhere, as if someone had been dragged up the hill harshly, violently. As if someone had fought back.

Fighting, hurting, running, dragging.

Someone is yelling. Adora knows that voice, she has heard it a thousand times before, laughing and singing. Exhaling against her ear and smiling against her mouth. Is such a dear voice, the only song Adora ever needed. She would tear from her own vocal cords and never sing again just so that voice could laugh forever.

The voice is screaming, angrily, and someone is slapping a face back, hard. And suddenly, every single piece falls into place in Adora's mind.

Here it is. The answer. The why.

Suddenly she understands why she had been pushed away. It was on purpose, *it was on purpose,* it was to protect Adora from *them.*

Brave, beautiful creature, soul of Adora's soul, heart of Adora's heart.

Suddenly, as she looks horrified at the top of the cliff, at the ruins of what one day had guided her to what later would become her home, far away from where she can reach on time, Adora realizes she has made a terrible, terrible mistake.

Because Adora is not *there* , she is away because she left and she left her heart behind and now she is too far away to protect her from the predators chasing her down. She is not there, she is away, away, away, and she can see and hear everything, carved in her mind like boiling steel.

She is away and, suddenly, Adora has never felt so much fear in her entire life as she does now.

There is a man on the very top of the cliff, his clothes white, white, white. He has his back turned at the house, arms crossed behind him, looking directly at the sea. He is waiting. His

human's eyes could never see it. could never see the siren that hides so far away, beyond the reef, but he is waiting. Extatic.

The four men that accompany him finally make their way to the cliff too, just a few feet behind this man, dropping the weight of the person still struggling violently on their hands. They have seized her arms, so hard there are fingerprints painted in her upper arms, and they push her down harshly against the sharp rocks of the cliff, keeping her in place with steel grip.

Catra exhales as the rocks dig into the skin of her legs, trying to snap her arms away from the men holding her down without success. Her entire body is screaming, protesting under the painful pull of her muscles.

They had taken her by surprise, too wrapped inside her heart to catch them earlier. They had burst inside the ajar open door and chased Catra around her home like wolves thirsty for blood.

Her scalp burns from where one of the men grabbed her by the hair and slammed her into the wall as if she weighed nothing, knocking all the pictures down. Her ribs hurt horribly and her ankle is screaming after she tried to run upstairs and they teased her in the side and tackled her down with so much force she bit into her mouth, dragging her across the floor by her ankles. There are prints of her nails over the wood, scratches deep and desperate enough that it chipped and bled all of her nails.

And yet, it took all of them to hold Catra down because she fought back. Nail and tooth. Biting, scratching, kicking in their faces and their nuts. She fought until her knuckles were in raw skin and bleeding, until her throat was sore from yelling curses at them and screaming so loud her own ears ringed, even if she knew it was useless because she was alone here. Nobody is coming for her - and that's how she thinks it must be because being here tonight is a death sentence and she knows it, Catra knows it - She made a number of them just as they made a number of her and only then they managed to keep her from fighting them back.

She saw them burst into her home and tear everything apart as they looked for her, for the so desired prize, Catra's heart, stepping their blood-stained feet on the only place that had once been safe for Catra - that had been safe once for Adora- A refugee in ruins. Forced to watch at everything was tossed and torn apart before being dragged like some kind of fucking, sick doll outside and towards the huge cliff past the meadow.

Catra grinds her teeth and sniffles her nose, straightening her face to look directly at the white man standing with his back towards her. She's got a heavy nosebleed, blood dripping into her lip and chin, made after one of the men slapped across the face when she kicked him on the balls so hard she heard a crack.

Catra looks at Prime in front of her, breath speeding up, balling her hands into fists even if her arms are going numb from how hard she is being held down. It doesn't matter, she feels so much hate and rage right now it doesn't matter to her being the fact that stops her from jumping into Prime's neck and killing him with her own hands.

"We've searched everywhere, Sir. The creature is gone," one of the men says, back straight.

Catra doesn't even bother to look at him, eyes fixed on Prime. They all look the same to her, perfect versions of each other, trained to hurt and fulfill their masters wishes. These are murderers, cold blooded, no regrets. These are the men that attacked Adora that night. Catra remembers them as well as the back of her palm.

"And the ocean?" Prime asks, voice monotone.

"We scouted but didn't find anything. The waves are too violent to keep looking without our boats."

Prime sighs, shoulders raising and falling, shaking his head softly as he makes a twitching sound with his mouth, almost as if he was a scolding teacher and not a monster.

"That is very disappointing," Prime says, finally turning around. Catra's breath stops in her lungs, staring back at Prime's face fully for the first time since that night. "Whatever shall we do about that, Miss Catrina?"

The right side of Prime's face has melted, there is no other way Catra can describe it. From the line of the hair - three inches deep where hair doesn't grow anymore - all the way down his temple, eyebrow, cheek and chin and a portion of his neck, the skin is red and gaping, folded over itself like some kind of sick mock of fabric. His eye is narrowed, almost shut close, and it doesn't see anymore, iris gray, eyelid fallen and melted off too, almost a gaping hole.

It's horrid, absolutely violent. This is Catra's doing. The skin of Prime's face is not oozing anymore and it's obviously been expensively treated, he shouldn't even be on his feet this quickly after an injury like that, and this is Catra's doing and now she knows she is absolutely going to die.

Prime looks at her from above his nose - burn and scarred too, the tip is almost gone - making a displeased sound.

"Little fool creature, it was very brave of you to steal the skin off my boat, and so, so disappointing. For a moment I thought you out of all people would understand me, that you would see what I see about them. About their beauty and their bestiality. About the sin of their existence," Prime is red. Everything about him is so white but the burnt in his face is red, staining everything about him forever. No longer perfect, no longer pure. And Catra knows he is furious about it. "If you had understood that you would have been beloved in my sight, but I see you've been bewitched by the demon. You have betrayed your own kind for it and you've done it for nothing."

Below them, so far away in the water, Adora is fighting the tide, swimming as fast as she can to reach them, breaking the strong waves with her claws and her tail and her teeth. Desperate, she is driving insane with desperation.

But the ocean is fighting her back, out of its mind with the storm hovering above them and with something else completely, charged with energy, like a lighting about to crash on earth. The ocean is lashing against her and dragging her back with all its might.

Up in the cliff, Catra is breathing hard, her heart hammering inside her chest. Adora can hear it, all the way where she is, she can feel her heart beating fast and scared as a bird inside her own chest, next to her own heart, a second beating like a second skin. Adora can feel her everywhere and she is *too far away.*

"You know, I'm a collector. I don't *hunt.* That's distasteful. I take beautiful things and make them last forever, even beyond their time to rot. Isn't that mercy? Isn't that what we should do with treasures? Preserve them." Prime leans towards Catra a little, narrowing his other eye, still as bright green and vile as the first she saw it. "So tell me, Miss. Grayskull, where exactly is your lovely, lovely *wife* ?"

Silence falls over the cliff, nobody moves. Prime stares at Catra's still face with crescent exasperation.

There is a low hum coming from Catra that starts slow and then picks up, higher and higher until she is laughing fully, a mocking cackle echoing across the entire cliff and towards the water. It's not even a real laugh, too high pitched, too shaky and watery. It makes Adora's heart shrink inside her body.

One of the men grabs her by the back of Catra's head and forces her face up so she is face to face with Prime, pulling from the hair in her nape so hard tears roll down Catra's cheeks without her permission. Her bottom lip is busted and she has a wound right above the bridge of her nose all the way to her eyebrow, splitting the skin open, done after one of them pushed her against the kitchen's counter.

Prime narrows his eye even more at Catra, tilting his head to the side, waiting for her to answer.

"Fuck you," Catra snarls, baring her teeth at him.

Prime's face falls and he straightens again, sighing deeply again and looking briefly at the black sky above them before he uncrosses his arms from his back, stretching his hand towards one of the men who gives him a square piece of paper swiftly. Prime raises the paper to his eyes and inspects it with unnerving attention. There is a pleased sound at the back of his throat, almost like a delighted him, and a sly smile stretching in the corner of his lip as he turns the paper towards Catra so she can see it fully too.

It's a photograph, it's Adora's photograph, the one Catra took on the shore where she looked like a star against the sun, clasped on Prime's fingers and eyes.

Catra rises to her feet so quick and hard that the men holding her tether and trip on their feet with the strength of the pull and the surprise. They barely manage to catch her on time before she launches herself to Prime's face, holding her in place, her face just a few inches from his.

Catra bares her teeth at him, eye to eye, clenching her jaw so hard it hurts. Prime looks at her unimpressed, lowering his eyes back to the photograph still in his hands.

"She really is a beauty to behold, isn't she?" He says, very slowly, tasting every word on the back of his tongue as he saves the picture on the inner pocket of his suit. "Satisfy my

curiosity, please, Miss Grayskull. How does it feel to be between her legs? Or was it the other way around?"

Catra spits into his face. Blood and saliva drip from his healthy eye and down his cheek, quickly staining the neck of his jacket in red.

“Pig," Catra snarls at him, full of rage.

Prime´s men grab her from the arms and shoulders, forcing her back into her knees harshly. Prime basically hisses, cleaning his face with the back of his sleeve, a spark of something red and furious flaming inside his eye, the one Catra had not taken. Catra looks at him, frustrated in front of her and even when she is the one on her knees she laughs again, shaking her head as if she couldn't believe her eyes.

"Oh, you are just pathetic, aren't you?" Catra says, loudly, spitting each word as a curse. "She is gone. She is gone far beyond you or your assholes fucking grasp and she is not coming back. You will never, ever, get your hands on Adora"

Prime´s eyes sparkle, satisfaction washing over his face all over again.

" *Adora* . How sweet" he drags the name on his mouth and just the sound of it makes Catra´s skin crawl with disgust. "I'm sure she will be back for you"

"She won't, " Catra growls, grinding her teeth until it hurts, until her heart hurts. "I made sure of that"

Prime looks at her curiously, comprehension making his way into his mind as he starts to understand exactly what Catra had done to push Adora away. Away from the house, away from the shore, away from her. Prime looks at her from head to toe, beyond the bruises and scratches in her body, directly to the purple that lives below her eyes and the hollow of her cheeks, and past all of that, into the pain inside her heart. Catra squirms, uncomfortable and cornered, feeling herself stripped from her barriers under this man´s calculating gaze.

"Beautiful. The bittersweet taste of sacrificing for the one we love" Prime lowers down, grasping Catra´s chin between his huge hand, so hard that Catra is unable to snap her head away, the bone of her jaw protesting with the cruel hold. "Look at you, poor thing. Your Adora has caused you nothing but suffering. Wouldn't you like to be free of that pain?"

“Don´t touch me,” Catra grunts, but her voice comes broken in the edges, shivering without her permission, suddenly overwhelmed by the weight inside her chest.

"But you know what she is, Ms. Grayskull. You know what they do. They lure their victims, make them believe they love them, that they care about them."

"Shut the fuck up"

"Fill their heads with numbing songs and sweet words"

"No"

"And gentle touches"

"No" Catra exhales, choking with air. "You are wrong.

"If she loved you, why did she abandon you?"

Catra cries.

Every word, every sob. Adora can hear it all. She is never going to forgive herself.

Catra, listen to me, Adora thinks, Adora wants to scream, mouth and gills full of salt water, rushing across the ocean. She swims and rises her head above the water, making a swift and sweet sound with her throat - Catra´s name - a sound only for Catra, calling for her. But the wind is too loud and the waves too wild and without mercy they drown the sound until it's nothing. *Listen to me, I´m here. Don´t cry, my love, don´t cry. I´m sorry.*

Adora rips the water apart with her arms and in the cliff her heart cries.

Catra's tears drip silently on the ground below her bruised feet, painting clear tracks over her cheeks, among the dirt and blood and the sweat. Prime smiles widely, triumphant. He grabs the end of a short strand of Catra´s hair between the fingers of his other hand and sighs again, voice fakely sweet when he speaks, smiling as if he knew he had won. .

"So tell me, miss Grayskull, was it worth it?"

Catra hiccups around a silent sob and then takes a shaky breath, returning Prime's gaze firmly.

"Yes." And her voice echoes across the cliff and into the very sea. "All of it"

Do you believe she loves you?

Prime's face falls, darkening heavily. He straightens up, wrapping his hand completely around Catra's neck, bringing her up with him. Catra gasps, choking, her eyes widening as the air fails her. Prime's nails dig into the back of her neck, breaking skin, she can feel thin drops of blood running down her spine.

The men holding her let go of her arms finally but it is useless in the end. Prime lifts Catra a few inches from the ground and away from his body, unnervingly strong. Catra kicks and claws at his arm, gasping for air, but he doesn't even flinch, turning around on his ankles.

"We humans are so very emotional" Prime starts saying, calmly, as if it was something that pained him deeply. Slowly, he starts to walk further to the very top of the cliff. Catra can feel the lash of the sea wind hitting against her back, fear washing over her. "You are so brave, risking yourself for your Adora, but it will make no difference "

On the sea below the cliff, Adora panics. She is so much closer now, she is almost there, but still so far away, she is not going to make it to the shore in time, she is not going to be able to reach the top of the cliff on time, even if she ripped her skin from her body right now and ran as fast as she can.

Adora pulls her head out of the water and sings Catra's name, hysterical, not even a word, the sound of seafoam against smooth pebbles in the ground, the sound of the sun cradling the sea at dawn. An intimate sound only they know, a whisper against an ear during a heated night, the murmur of a kiss over the palm of a hand.

Adora sings and the wind carries it with it, tangled among the sound of the breeze against the cliff's grass. The men there don't hear it, Prime doesn't hear it, because neither of them have heard this sound before. It's not meant for them.

At the edge of the cliff, Catra's pupils widen and her eyes swell with tears, heart stopping inside her chest.

She hears it.

"Tell me, Miss. Grayskull, did you know that sharks can smell blood up to around a quarter of a mile away?" Prime lowers Catra down slightly, inches away from the edge, letting go of her throat just to seize her wrist so painfully between his hand Catra's delicate bones scream in pain. "I guess I'll just have to leave *Adora* a greeting then, on my behalf. Thank you very much for your cooperation and goodbye, Catrina"

Prime swings his arm forward and throws Catra off the cliff.

She doesn't even scream. It's an exhale and then she is gone.

The ocean is violent. Adora sees it all.

She has to throw herself alongside the waves and catch Catra on her arms before she can hit the rocks below. Adora has to be there. Now.

She swims, she swims and swims, arms extended below the water, empty, her tail cutting through the water like a sword, watching as her heart falls from the cliff like an angel falls from the sky.

Adora will reach her.

She will reach her.

She will reach her.

She will reach her.

Adora can't reach her on time.

Catra falls against the water with a hit so loud the waves vibrate with the force and violence of it. Adora can see - she sees it all, every single second of it - how her side connects and drags against the sharp face of rocks, crude, raw, slowly, almost in slow motion, sinking inside the fierce waters like a treasure buried and erased by the ocean. She is there for a moment and the next one she is gone.

The sea is screaming.

No.

Adora is screaming. Yowling, crying, howling.

Is the kind of wail that makes men fall to their knees with bloody ears and brain blow from the insides, the kind of shriek that makes entire seas tremble on part, that makes storms crash against the earth and winds to rip trees and buildings lift and fall apart.

She throws herself after her, sinking to the depths of the ocean, following her silhouette inside the darkness, the wind echoing her cries. She doesn't care if the men above see her or hear her. She doesn't care about anything at all. Her love is sinking, *Catra* is sinking inside the waters. The waters, Adora's *waters* , they are eating her alive. And she doesn't know how to swim and she is afraid of darkness, of water in her lungs. She is suffering and it's all Adora's *fault.*

It's a nightmare brought to life.

Adora sees her immediately, how could she not? She is spinning inside the water, thrown brutally from side to side by the force of the ocean, like a ragdoll or a mere cloth. The water is heavier, salty, it tastes like copper, Adora's sight is obscured by dense matter mixing on it.

Adora is a predator, she knows fatal wounds when she sees them, when she smells them. Catra is dying. She who writes stories, she who sings beautifully under her breath in the morning. She who taught Adora how to dance around the living room. She who stares at Adora with soft eyes when she thinks she isn't looking. She, who saved Adora and cured her wounds and braided her hair and protected her more than Adora ever knew. Stubborn and sharp and sarcastic and soft and kind and happy. There wasn't a beginning or an end, a purpose, a why to live. Not until her. She, who is dying. Adora's entire world is dying in the very same waters she promised would never hurt her.

The ocean pulls back again, getting ready to slam against the rock and earth once more. There is a second there, a momentum held in time where everything is calm, where Adora finally catches her. Catra is floating inside the, suddenly, still water, her short hair cradling her face, mouth in a slit. She is breathing and drinking water, she must have accidentally tried to take a breath when she crashed against the water, by the surprise or the pain. It burns. Her eyes are half way open, looking at the dim light that shines through the surface, silver, a fragment of moonlight that escapes the thick weight of the clouds. Here, underwater, everything is silent, just quietness, heavy and overwhelming, huge as the darkness that spreads everywhere around her, endless, almost slow. Like this she almost looks like flying instead of falling. Maybe it's not such a bad way to die, thinks Catra in a haze, overwhelmed by fear and pain and water. She has never been more afraid in her entire life, but, even among all the violence, the sea seems to still give Catra a few moments of gentleness, as if it recognized her even beyond its own instinct. It's not so bad.

Adora crashes against her, cradling her between her strong arms in one swift hold before the ocean shakes awake again and slams them both around with its entire might. Adora nestles Catra's head and neck against her collarbones, her arms held tightly around Catra's and her torso. Adora's powerful tail wraps around her knees and legs, bending over her into a tight ball looking to absorb most of the hit so it doesn't reach *her* again.

They spin inside the sea together, water inside their ears, pieces of rocks, rotten logs of trees and sand all around them, quickly throwing them against the cliff.

Adora braces for the hit, cradling Catra´s head tightly between her arms, and then the sea rises and launches them against the sharp rocks. Adora clenches her teeth, her back connecting against the wall of the cliff violently. It hurts, a lot, but Adora is feeling so much pain everywhere right now that she doesn't even pay attention to it, holding Catra´s limp body against her with one hand, the other stretching forward, trying to find a rock tall enough from where to hold on to. The waves wash over them again and again, freezing cold and merciless.

Adora needs to get out of the water right now, she needs to pull Catra's head out of the sea, let her breathe. She can't breathe. Adora can feel the struggle of her chest against the water below the skin of her hands

Adora manages to hold them behind one of the tallest rocks at the bottom of the cliff, arched as a halfmoon, hiding them both away from preying looks above their heads. Adora digs her steel nails inside the mineral to keep them afloat, clenching her jaw strongly. Here the pull of the water is still strong but Adora's tail is stronger and the waves don't crash so violently against them.

Adora´s body is out of control. All her fins are long and raised, end points as poisonous crowns of thorns shimmering dangerously under the water. Her claws have grown terribly, knives in her fingers able to cut the rock like fabric if she wanted, tinted in black. Her tail is still wrapped tightly around Catra´s legs, smooth golden scales everywhere where their skins touch but dark everywhere else. Adora´s face has shifted, soft gills like silk still but the corners of her mouth are stretched as far as it can, long rows of lethal sharp teeth inside it, grinding so hard against each other that several of them chip under the pressure.

Adora is absolutely terrifying and dangerous right now yet she holds Catra with complete devotion, nestling her delicate head over her shoulder gently, running her claws very carefully over her soaked bangs, pushing them softly behind her ears. Catra is unnervingly pale, purple bruises and scratches scattered around her cheekbones, her jaw and her temples. Her eyes are almost closed, struggling to breathe, her chest audibly screeching.

Adora kisses her, all sharp teeth and salt water, pulling the water out of her lungs and nose. It's the only thing she can think of, all that she can do until they get out. It tastes like salt and blood. Adora is never going to be able to forget it, it's carved in her mind and every cell of her body for eternity. She will always know how much is *enough.*

Catra shakes awake, her body jolting, coughing harshly around a mouthful of salt water. She looks around her, gaze fogged, confused and scared as she stares at the water all around them. Catra´s head rolls to the side, against Adora´s shoulder, taking in her presence fully for the first time. Her eyes are clouded, eyelids heavy, and she looks in so much pain and sorrow Adora´s chest sinks.

Adora can't help herself, Catra looks so confused and lost that Adora can't help herself when she leans closer to her face, still pressed chest to chest, tenderly cradling the side of her dear face with her huge, dangerous hand. Adora leans down until she presses her cold, siren mouth over the bridge of Catra´s nose, a gentle kiss, a sea creature and the human she loves. It

seems to be the only thing Catra needs to understand that this is real, Adora is real, she is here.

Catra squirms in Adora´s arms, whimpering miserably when the pain overcomes her. She raises her hands from under the water, placing them gently just below Adora´s gills. She is frighteningly cold.

"-dora, A- Adora" Catra says, voice barely above a whisper, raw after drinking so much salt water. Adora´s eyes soften, even in this form, staring at Catra with so much tenderness that Catra´s fragile heart breaks just a little bit more.

"I'm here, I'm here. We are going home, alright?" Adora begs, voice shivering so bad her teeth click together. She doesn't even notice she is singing instead of talking. "Just hold on a little bit more, love"

"-no, no, why did you come back?" Catra shakes her head, pulling softly from Adora´s marble and gold shimmering shoulders. There are tears running down her cheeks, one after the other, unstoppable as desperation starts to eat Catra alive. "Go- you need- go. Prime-"

"Catra"

"Go"

"No"

"Adora"

"No"

Catra sobs, pulling from Adora's soaked hair weakly, trying to make her dip inside the water again, to hide away from the prying red eyes of Prime still somewhere in the cliff above them. Adora's heart swells in fondness and sinks inside her chest with grief. Catra is bleeding out in the water around them and yet she is still trying to protect her. Catra has been protecting her the entire time.

"I don't matter, I don't matter" Catra repeats again and again, biting angrily into her split lip when Adora doesn't move, doesn't even flinch away. "For fucking- go, I don't *want* you here - go away. Go!" if her voice wasn't shaking so much Catra would sound furious, and maybe her lie would be as believable as last time, but she looks exhausted, practically limp in Adora ´s arms, so frail she might just break apart. It's a miracle she is still alive at all.

Adora presses her mouth strongly against Catra's forehead, breathing her in deeply. Adora is full of scales, sharp and cutting; her mouth stretched as far as it can be, from ear to ear, rows and rows of knife cutting fangs and teeth; hair like spines. She is a nightmare, pulled out of the darkest tales, a predator, a killer in the water. And here is Catra, nestling her face against her collarbones, holding to her as a lifeline, uncaring of all of Adora's sharp edges. Trembling like a leaf but not afraid, not of Adora.

"Shh, shh," Adora tries to reassure her, but it's hard when she can't even reassure herself, "don't cry, don't cry, my love."

"Don't hate me, don't hate me," Catra is muttering, tangling her fingers around the soaked silk of Adora´s hair.

"Catra" Adora has never heard Catra plead like that, so scared and sad. Something nasty starts to pull on Adora´s chest, covering it all in black. "I never hated you, I could never"

"I didn't - didn't t-took it" Catra says, running her fingertips as softly as she can down Adora ´s scaled upper arm. Adora sobs without tears, gently thumbing Catra´s cheekbone.

"I know. I know you didn't, sweetheart, please don't cry." Adora takes her hand, kissing her bruised knuckles with trembling lips, right below the ring rope still lovingly placed on her finger. She is so beautiful and Adora missed her so much and she is never going to forgive herself.

Adora´s nails dig deeper into the rock, biting back a scream only for Catra´s sake.

Adora looks above the surface of the rocks they are hidden in, carrying Catra's entire weight with one arm, the other still holding them to the hard surface to stop the tide from pulling them away. Here the waves almost seem benevolent, washing over them without so much cruelty as before, as if the very same water was afraid to keep touching Catra. Adora feels it, something that has always connected her deeply with the sea, like a second heart inside her chest, the way the water seems to tremble every time it touches Catra's skin, guilty, *guilty.*

On the edge of the cliff a strong light turns on suddenly and illuminates the rocky bottom. Adora presses herself closer to the rock they are hiding in, lowering as much as she can on the water, careful of keeping Catra's face nestled against her face and away from the water at all times.

Adora presses her free hand against Catra's wound, trying to lower down the lossblood as much as she can, tethering into losing her mind herself. Catra gasps at the movement, tears endless in her cheeks as she bites back a pained whimper.

The light above their heads moves insistently, trying and failing to find anything at all on the sea without success. The sky is growing more and more vile, violet and ill blue, broken in the horizon by the incoming virulent lighting the storm brings with it. From their spot, Adora hears the men yelling to each other, half of them rushing down the cliff and starting the cars, cowarded by the imminent storm.

"Sir! I don't think the creature is going to appear!" One of the men is saying, the wind lashing against them as they stand still on the top of the cliff, the light still held by the second men accompany them.

Prime - *Prime, white and green and red. Adora is going to kill him, she is going to fucking kill him, she is going to tear him apart from the inside out and she is going to enjoy every single second of it* - grunts, eyes fixed in the water without being able to see what he wanted.

"Did you see her fall?" He asks, voice barely contained in his fury.

"I did sir! The whore hit the rocks and sank!" The wall of the rock gives up a little where Adors clenches her hand, the waters trembling around them with her growl. "She must have hit the bottom or some shark got into her first!"

"She will come," Prime murmurs between clenched teeth, furious beyond comprehension, "She must."

"The storm is almost here, sir! If we don't go now we'll get trapped in the meadows!"

Prime stays still for several minutes, scanning the progressively higher waters. He knows, he knows, he saw Catra and he knew she would be of use to catch his prize again. He knew the creature would come back, if she had left at all, either by anger or by vengeance. And yet, as with many humans, he couldn't see beyond his own beliefs and thoughts. He couldn't see what was exactly below his nose.

"Fine. She'll be back sooner or later. Let her find her rotten remains then," Prime turns around, walking down the cliff with no rush at all.

Adora watches at his men surrounding him as he walks across the shore - Catra and Adora's shore - rushing to open the car for him and then closing the door quickly behind. Another lighting breaks into the sky, so loud and powerful it makes the windows of the house tremble. The cars turn on and drive away at horrid speed, leaving clear wheel marks in the ground behind.

"Adora," Catra whispers against Adora's fin ear, curling her hand over Adora's neck. Adora turns her eyes at her, bright blue in the middle of darkness.

"I'm here, *mi amor,"* Adora answers, saying the tender endearment in Catra's mother language. It sends a small shiver down Catra's body, the faintest of blushes covering her pale cheeks.

"I- I want to go home," Catra murmurs, narrowing her eyes at Adora sadly. "I wanna go home."

"I know. I'm taking you there, don't worry." Adora rubs the side of her face gently against Catra's damp temple into a sweet siren's kiss, shushing her gently and lovingly.

Adora waits with her heart in her throat, desperate as she feels the water get thicker around them with Catra's blood. She waits until she sees the lights of the cars disappointing completely, finally letting go of the rock just so she can wrap her arms around Catra's back, holding her against her chest.

Adora swims to the shore swiftly, pulling from her skin before she can reach the edge just so she can wrap it around Catra's shoulders instead, like a blanket or a shield, walking out of the water with her heart in her arms. Like this, with Catra surrounded by silver and sea glass and otherworldly beauty, Adora can almost understand the greed, the violence, the need. Looking like a pearl inside her arms, Adora would also kill for Catra.

She will.

"Get her!"

They ambush them at the shore, falling over them like prey birds starving for rot. Three of the men have stayed behind, hidding behing their own rocks - the same Adora had hidden in so long ago - by an order from Prime that Adora had failed to hear.

Two of them pounce against Adora, grabbing her by the soaked hair and waist, pulling her painfully to the side. Adora shrieks in rage, clawing at one of them on the thigh, barely missing him at all. She is not wearing her skin, long legs and body naked from just walking out of the water, but she is still covered in scales and teeth and claws, still as dangerous as she was seconds ago.

She elbows one of them in the nose, hearing the satisfying crunch of cartilage under the pressure. The man screams, blood pouring from his nostrils. He has green hair and he looks like a big baby, a small version of the man next to him, who has deep blue hair and is obviously older and who stabs Adora in the back of her shoulder with a hunting knife.

"Careful! Lord Prime wants it alive!" one of them screams.

Adora lets out a drowned yell, throwing a blind bite towards him without managing to reach him. She struggles on her feet over the sharp sand and pebbles, stubbornly holding Catra close to her, her arms tightly wrapped around Adora's neck. But the two men seize Adora by the upper arms and pull back from them so hard her shoulders almost pop, already trying to throw a net over her head.

The shortest and third one grabs Catra by the back of the hair and pulls, successfully ripping her from Adora and slamming her into the hard pebbles of the shore with violent crude force. Catra whimpers in pain, too far gone to scream anymore. Instead she curls around Adora's iridescent skin like a human shield, holding it against her chest and baring her teeth as she tries to protect it from the hands of the man trying to take it from her.

Her blood soaks the pearls into red.

Adora sees it all again and the last string of her self control snaps in half.

She screeches, a sound so loud and high pitched the men holding her bend in half when the it crosses their heads, slapping their hands away so hard they yowl in pain, ripping through their net restraints like nothing. She jumps over the shortest man, jaw unhinged imposible open, snatching him away from Catra's side in one single blow. The flesh feels like butter when she sinks her claws against the man's chest, slashing it open like a butcher, from the collarbones to the start of the abdomen, the roads of her teeth sinking against the point of the neck where the man's pulse is stronger, shredding jugular and carotid away. Blood sprays over Adora and across the shore, painting the dark into bright red.

Here is the thing you forget about Adora inside the shelter of her beauty.

She is a predator, she is the original hunter. She is not human, not once bound to their morals. She just watched the love of her life fall and almost drown in the waters she once called home. She is unbelievably angry and she is losing Catra. Catra, love of her life, angel, sun and salvation, Catra is dying and these men are still trying to hurt her.

Monster . Demon. Adora is going to become into the creature they believe she is for the person she loves, for Catra. Adora is going to become a murderer to save her soul if that's what she needs to do. There is no bargain in killing a killer, after all.

She is not a savior in this story, she is the tale monster. And she is full of *rage.*

Adora snaps and bites down, tearing and chewing, ripping apart, ignoring the wet gurgling around her until it slowly dies down and the mangled man stills between her claws. She hasn't eaten in weeks but this isn't about hunger, this is about starving for something else, a hunt for revenge, guilt and anger mixing inside her chest.

Adora tosses him into the water like an old rag and straightens up, tall and strong, bringing her hand back to grab the handle of the knife still dug in her shoulder, pulling it out without even flinching. She looks at the smooth surface of the blade, stained in golden ichor from the wound, and then tosses it aside, uninterested. The wound has already started to heal up.

The two remaining men stare at her with wide, angry eyes, fear living boiling red beyond their gaze and Adora knows what they must see, she can see it in the reflection of their pupils. A specter, a ghost from the sea, white and golden and as terrible as death itself. Temptingly naked and covered in scales as gold coins, her impossibly long mouth opened slightly, inviting, covered in fresh blood that drips heavily from her teeth and chin and down her neck and chest, staining her in crimson rage. They see the fallen angel from heaven written on their men's written bibles. The falsely accused witch burned into red ignorance. The pagan goddess of buried shrines and crumbled statues.

Temptress. Sinner. Priestess

Muse. Miracle. Murderer

Siren. Devourer of men

They see many things in Adora and they are all true and false at the same time. Adora is all of this and more because she is also Catra's. That's the only thing Adora knows she is, Catra's, only and ever hers, and Adora will be whatever she needs.

Adora throws herself over Catra, covering her body with hers, knees digging on the sand and long honey hair dripping in red falling in curtains at either side of Catra's face where Adora lowers herself further, hiding Catra away from the eyes of the other two men in front of them. Adora opens her mouth from side to side and hisses, a warning, a threat, cradling Catra's head between her clawed hands without tearing her sight away from the hunters.

Catra exhales, looking at Adora hovering above her, all shimmering scales and fins and covered in blood. She rests her hand against Adora's sharp cheek, cradling her jaw with her palm, uncaring of the sharp edges of her teeth or the fact that she looks like a fucking

nightmare. Instead she reassures Adora with her touch, running her thumb under Adora's completely black eyes, whipping off errand splashes of blood from her skin, staring at Adora from under her eyelashes because even though she is covered in blood and she looks absolutely terrifying she is also absolutely *mesmerizing* to Catra, free of the restrains of a human body. This is Adora as she really is and Catra loves her all the same.

Adora lowers her eyes towards her immediately, searching her face avidly. Under Catra's touch Adora's rage tames down almost completely, soft in all her sharp edges for her. Adora's heart gives a jump inside her chest at the sight of Catra looking up at Adora like she was the moon and suddenly Adora can't find in her body anything else but tenderness and sorrow and overwhelming adoration, tampering the anger like a blue flame.

Catra tries to speak but fails, coughing blood into Adora's arms as her hand falls back against her chest, where she is still holding Adora's skin like a lifeline - it's probably the only thing keeping her alive right now - Adora's pupils shrink into pinpoints at the sight, horror washing over her. She can hear Catra's heartbeat slowing even more, barely the beat of a bird's wings inside Adora's fine ears.

Adora grabs Catra's arm as gently as she possibly can, wrapping it around her own neck as she holds Catra close to her chest, cradling the back of her hair with her palm, crossing her other hand under her knees, standing up carefully with Catra in her arms. Catra gasps with the movement and Adora rocks her gently from side to side in a sad try to reassure her. She is so frail right now, crystal fragile against the touch of Adora's claws. Her skin is pale and her freckles are tinted with blood.

Adora is a siren and her hands are covered in knife sharp scales, but she is still wearing her ring, the thread dyed in red.

The two men in front of them pant, blood dripping slightly from their ears. The smaller one turns towards the older, growling under his breath.

"Do something, Hordak!"

"Shut up, Imp" the second grunts, staring directly at Adora's dark eyes, scleras inked in black, irises bright red, midnight suns watching at them mercilessly. The man, Hordak, grimaces, twitching his tongue against his teeth. "Fuck this"

He brings his hand back, grasping something from his belt. Adora watches as he lifts a gun in front of him, the cannon pointed directly at Adora's face. Adora wrinkles her nose, eyes hardening. Men are so disgusting, with their powder weapons and their greed and their cowardice.

"I'm going to shoot your whore and then I'm going to shoot you and you'll come with us even if I have to drag you from the hair. Sea slut"

He lowers the gun, just a little, just enough that this time it is hovering in the direction of Catra's head, nestled against Adora's shoulder, moving his finger towards the trigger.

Adora sucks a breath and *screams.*

All the windows inside the house blow up

There has never and there will never be a sound so horrifying, so absolutely terrifying, as the scream of a siren.

It's like a thousand voices screaming, a million crystals cracking and breaking into sand, hundreds of deadly sharp swords slicing against the air and cutting the very sound until there is nothing on the suspended space but its ring. It goes on and on until the very sea reacts to it, rising like a tsunami and crashing against the cliff and the rocks and the shore, seafoam like ocean horses breaking against the pebbles and the stones.

Catra nuzzles her nose against Adora's gills, breathing deeply through her nose. She can hear Adora's scream but for her is tamed, low, like a murmur in her ears. It doesn't hurt her or scare her but it makes her sad because beyond all that rage Catra can hear Adora's grief, shivering and heartbreaking.

For the men on the shore, however, it hurts as if someone was ripping their scalps, opening their skulls hollow and tearing their brains apart. It forces them to drop into their knees over the sand and scream as they feel every ounce of self will leaving them, drowned in Adora's voice, bound to her command, insanity slipping inside their bones as their scratch in their own faces and ears, desperate to make it all stop. The waves of the ocean wash the gun away.

Adora's scream quiets down suddenly, covering everything in jarring silence, the kind that remains hanging in the air, like an empty church after the ring of the bells.

Adora can feel Catra's chest against hers. Her lungs are burning, struggling to breathe, her body hurts, her throat is screaming in pain. Adora can feel it to the last cell of her body

Adora watches the men kneeling in the ground, chests heavy with their pants. Their ears are bleeding profusely now, dripping over their shoulders. Their eyes are misted, looking at the sand and pebbles without moving, gazes lost. Like this they look like mere puppets, fallen on the ground after their strings have been cut off, just waiting there for the master puppeteer to pick them up again.

They smell like Catra, they have her blood under their nails.

Adora bares her teeth, frowning deeply, eyes hooded as she stares at both of them from above the bridge of her nose. Her expression is hollow, almost bored, eyes set firm and mouth in a firm line.

"Look at me," Adora orders without speaking at all, voice overlapping, from the sweetest tone to the most obscure one, a sound pulled from the very abyss of the ocean, terrifying and impossible to ignore.

The men obey immediately, limbs pulled like dolls as they snap their eyes towards her, stripped of all will over their bodies, just as they had stripped from their will and freedom to hundreds of animals before. Just as they had tried to do with Adora and her skin, and then with Catra and her life, like they were worth nothing. And even inside their hypnotized state, Adora can see the consciousness beyond their eyes, hatred and anger storming on their

expressions as they are aware of every single thing happening, furious as Adora's song and voice commands them at her will.

Good , Adora thinks. She wants them to know it was her, she wants them to know they are nothing above her. She wants them to know that they are going to die and that it will be because of *her*.

" **Take your brother** " Adora commands, staring directly at the man with blue hair, and her voice echoes across the shore and the cliff, a thousand voices talking at the same time, the only sound in miles around. Adora watches as the man stands up from among the sand, slowly turning around to grab the collar of his younger brother on his fist. When his shirt moves, Adora can see the red lines of a scratch, done by Catra's nails when she tried to run away. Adora growls, low and so dangerous both men tremble from head to toe, just waiting there for her to drop the final judgement over their heads. " **Drown him"**

Both men's eyes widen, conscious, absorbing every word of the command, but none of them can do anything about it to stop it. The older brother tightens his fist over his brother's neck and starts dragging him into the water, walking and walking until the water soaks on his waist and back, deep enough that Adora knows it will suffice.

Adora kisses Catra's temple, gently tucking her head over the angle of her neck.

"Don't watch" Adora whispers in her ear, and it's only in her song, tender and sweet for her, drowning out for Catra the sound of violent splashing and cruel gurgling coming from the shore. She can feel the way Catra's eyelashes flutter when she closes her eyes very softly, nodding, cradling her hands over Adora's chest.

Drowning a human takes time, Adora finds out pretty quickly, but eventually the struggling and grunting also dies down, water still as the body drifts away with the strong waves, into the water and towards the depths.

The last man standing straightens up from his place on the water and turns on his ankles to look at Adora. He is grinding his teeth so hard, the bone of his jaw pops, his scleras are completely red, veins thick with pressure in his forehead, his hands into fists as he stares at Adora with murderous intent but completely unable to do anything about it at all.

Adora considers him, tilting her head to the side lightly, her hair falling like a dark golden curtain over her shoulder. She allows herself one second to enjoy this, to look at this man standing waist deep in *her* waters, unable to move or speak if she doesn't allow him first. Because she remembers him, she knows who he is. She saw his eyes when he slashed her face and ripped her skin off her body, months and months ago on these very same waters. Adora sees him and she remembers the anger and sorrow she felt, and she carries Catra in her arms and she feels the fear and pain he made her go through. On the water, the hunting knife with which he had attacked Adora floats close to him, still stained in gold.

Adora's face falls, eyes hardening even further, twin guillotines on her irises and her teeth.

"Pick it up" The man leans down over the water, grabbing the handle of the knife tightly between his shaking hands. His eyes talk of a thousand curses, roaming between Adora's and

Catra's face. Adora hisses on the back of her throat, hunting like a shark, sizzling as a lighting, eyes as cold as glaciers. He is trembling. He knows he is going to die. " **Cut your throat"**

Blood spills over the white sand, dark red and thick, and the sea washes the rest away.

Adora turns towards the house, not even bothering to look back, walking with firm steps over the sharp pebbles and sand. Her ears shrink, soft fins into cartilage. Her mouth closes in the cheeks and her teeth turn blunt, fangs, gums and tongue still stained in red. All her body softens, scales falling in the ground as she walks by, like a makeshift path towards the house, gone are the thorns and fins and membranes in her fingers, nails blunt. Still covered is blood but softer around Catra's form.

Forcing the transformation hurts but it doesn't hurt as much as the feeling of Catra, almost limp on her arms. She is a feather, she weighs nothing, her skin is tight against her cheekbones and the underside of her eyes is hollow and purple.

Losing a mate can break you

The house is wrecked. The door is blown open, doorknob rolled to the side over the floor. There are sharp pieces of glass everywhere on the floor - the stained glass window is blown up, Catra loved that window. Adora left her next to that window. Pictures are broken and tossed aside - of Catra of Adora, of *them* - and chairs knocked over. There are drops of blood on the corner of the kitchen counter and long scratches done by nails on the floor.

This is their home, sacred ground, holy space. Defiled.

Adora rushes across the remains of their home and towards the kitchen, knocking everything misplaced over the wide counter, very, very gently sitting Catra over the smooth black granite, her legs covered in small cuts and bruises at either side of Adora's waist, still holding Adora's neck like an anchor. Adora's skin falls mournfully between their bodies, like a bride's veil stained in red.

Catra is drenched from head to toe and her clothes are soaked with blood and she is so cold her lips are turning a scary shade of violet and blue. Adora grabs the fabric of Catra's white shirt - once Adora's, she was wearing it the day before she left - now tinted in red and pulls from it quickly, grinding her teeth when the movement makes Catra gasp in pain.

With her skin bare like this, Adora can see the full extent of the wound under the darkness of the house. The wound is wide and jarrying, three deep irregular lines that go from the middle and bottom of her ribs and her belly button, across her entire side and joining down the low on her back. The skin is raw and bleeding, the muscle compromised yet still stubbornly trying to protect itself. There is no human medicine that can fix this. And even if it were, Catra is already slipping away between Adora's fingers.

She doesn't even hesitate. Adora takes a hold of her own skin and *rips,* pearlescent scales coming off easily in shreds between her hands, like liquid, dripping into the floor in rivers of marble and gold. Catra sobs against her neck, trying to fight Adora's hands off her skin, stop her from what she is doing, push her hands away. But she is dying and she is too tired. Adora

shakes her head wordlessly and cradles her back, tearing from the skin again and again until the shreds hang loosely from her fingers. And it *hurts* , deep within Adora's chest and her own muscles and bones and organs. It aches like a broken bone, like a stab, like a rip on her flesh, it hurts so much she could scream from the pain and Adora will bear scars from this for the rest of her life, but it doesn't matter. It doesn't matter, it never mattered as much as Catra. It doesn't hurt as much as her dying in her arms. It wasn't worth leaving her for it.

Adora rests Catra's front against her bare chest, stained with the men's blood and Catra's, and places the shredded pieces of her skin above Catra's, directly over the wound. The skin shimmers for a second, almost with a mind of its own, tightening above the damaged flesh and then lays still, sticking to Catra's body like a quite literally second skin, like it knows who she is and that in any form, it always belonged to her, trying to shelter her, trying to protect her.

Catra gasps, tears slipping from her eyes as Adora keeps working relentlessly. Adora knotted wind chimes that now lie broken in the floor and braided Catra a ring that still rests in her finger and now she will embroider Catra's body to try to save her.

Adora cries the entire time, silently, tears dropping from her eyelashes and into the wounds as she tends to Catra's injuries with the utmost care, so tender Catra shivers every time she places the scaled skin over her, on her side, on her shoulder, on her upper arms, on her legs. Months ago, Catra tended to her injuries too, gently. Adora remembers because that was the first time she felt the tug on her chest, the quick beat inside her heart under Catra's touch. It was the first time she saw Catra's kindness and compassion, the first time she found herself unable to look away from a human, the first time she felt safe, the first time that Adora stopped feeling so desperately lost. It was the first time Adora felt loved, openly and vulnerably loved.

The greatest gift life had given her and she had left her.

Adora clenches her jaw as she works and wishes she could absorb Catra's wounds in her body. She wishes there was a way they could switch places, where Catra wouldn't feel pain or anguish. Adora bites on the inside of her cheek until she tastes her own blood and tries not to be consumed by despair.

"Adora" Catra whispers against her ear. Her voice is dry and thin with exhaustion. She is not bleeding out anymore but her body is going limp on Adora's arms, too tired to hold herself anymore.

"Shh, shh. It 's alright. It's alright I've got you hold on" Adora whispers back, furiously wiping her eyes with the heel of her hand when the tears make her sight blur, smudging blood against her own cheeks. Her hands are soaked in Catra's blood.

"Adora" Catra repeats, a little bit stronger, taking a shaky breath. "You need to leave. He is going to- he is going to hurt you. I-" Catra shivers when a wave of pain suddenly overtakes her, digging her fingers on Adora's shoulder. Adora holds her closer. "I- if I don't surv- Adora, I want you to choose yourself" she finally says, voice breaking but still firm. Her fingers press harder on Adora's skin, strong even as she is obviously terrified and she feels she might just drift away. "Promise me, Adora. Choose yourself first."

Adora holds her breath, running her fingers on the back of Catra's neck, stitching a scale like a flower over the nail marks there.

"I'm staying with you," Adora says against Catra's temple, not a drop of doubt or regret in her voice. She is strong and her resolution is stronger and it breaks Catra's heart.

"Adora-"

"You are beautiful." Adora cradles Catra's pale face between her hands, gentle but firm in her hold, just so she is sure Catra is looking into her eyes. Silver against sea glass. Adora rubs circles on her skin, brushing stains of blood off her cheeks. Adora's voice starts falling apart, finally undoing her. "You are so beautiful in so many ways and stubborn and smart and you don't listen to anyone ever. So you are not dying just because of him. You are going to live" Tears keep gathering in her eyelashes and they keep falling over Catra's skin, leaving silver marks like kisses there. Under their touch, the scratches and bruises start to fade away. "No matter what happens I'm staying with you. You are my *wife* " and the last word comes completely broken with a sob, almost bending Adora in half.

Catra is crying too, endlessly, looking at her from below her hooded eyelids, quiet. There are galaxies, universes, dying and being reborn inside her sea glass eyes, a thousand and more feelings and thoughts that cross her mind. Adora can see them because she knows Catra as well as she knows the ocean and better than she knows herself. There, in those beautiful eyes, is sorrow and anguish and pain, terrible, dug so deep Adora will have to dive inside Catra's heart to dig it out from root and as many times she needs to, for the rest of her life, until the skies burn out and the oceans dry.

But in those eyes Adora can also see the golden light of something that has become her own sun, so bright that speaks of unspeakable peace, of tender purpose and solace. Of nights of laughter and dance steps in front of the fire. There also lives Catra's love and Adora can see it even though her heart is breaking in two.

Catra nestles her head back into Adora's neck, murmuring very softly, and yet Adora thinks she can hear the hint of mirth on her thread of a voice. "You are so cheesy"

"Yes" Adora agrees with a tiny smile full of tears. "I know"

"Those men," Catra presses her hand over Adora's bloodied chest, right above her heart. Her fingers are scraped and bruised. "Are they dead?" .

Adora's stomach sinks into her feet as it starts to fall on her that she just murdered three men on cold blood - *pretty violent, no regrets, she would do it again* - and that she did it in front of Catra - *not ideal, probably traumatizing* -

"Yes," Adora wheezes, caressing the small bumps of Catra's spine. "Catra, I - "

"D- Don't be sorry," Catra tries to chuckle but it sounds more like a weak exhale against Adora's neck. "It was kind of hot"

Adora snorts a laugh, all kinds of watery and surprised and hysterical.

Catra is trembling, badly. Adora runs her hands up and down her body, her own fingers trembling as she brushes the wounds and the pearlescent skin placed over them. The scales shimmer, even under the shadows of their home, stitching tissue together slowly, but the skin is too dry, struggling to heal as it should.

Adora needs to get to salt water, right now, but the ocean outside is too cold and too violent and Catra almost died on it. Adora doesn't know if she is ever going to be able to step into it again.

"I'm so tired," Catra whispers, her cold lips against Adora's bare shoulder, dragging the words a little as unconsciousness starts to drag her away. Adora panics, all the fragile mirth between them breaking immediately, frantic again.

"Don't fall asleep" Adora wraps her arms tightly around Catra's shoulder blades and her waist, carrying her off the counter and over her chest. Adora tilts her head to the side a little, pressing her cheek over the crown of Catra's head. "Stay awake, my love, just a little more"

Adora makes her way to the stairs, trying to reach the - *their* - bedroom as quickly as she can. Somewhere among the knocked chairs, a small sound comes, like something very little dragging through a reduced space, flaring Adora's senses all over again. Melog peeks their little head from below a bunch of blankets tossed everywhere, fur disheveled, looking at Adora as if they didn't recognized at all and then at Catra in her arms, then back to Adora. Then Melog meows loudly, a little bit desperate too, rushing towards Adora's bare legs until their head bumps with her ankles, meowing and purring all at the same time, delighted to smell her back. She abandoned them too, didn't she?

Adora sobs, tears rolling from the corner of her eyes and over Catra's forehead, dripping down the bridge of Catra's nose and against the corner of her closed eyes too. Tears of one soul.

Sometimes, if one is gone, the other remains, and you will face all the ages of the world alone in your grief.

Adora prays. To the Kindly Ones and whatever goddess or devil or spirit or power that may be hearing her, whatever divine intervention or accident that made her, Adora prays.

Not her, not her. Adora begs, holding Catra unconscious against her chest because it's the only thing she can do without breaking down. *Please, don't take her away from me. Whatever you have given me, take it and give it to her instead.* Adora doesn't even realize she is talking, singing it to the dark, climbing the stairs and wailing in frustration and pain when her legs give up several times, almost tumbling them both into the ground. *She is a gift. Please. I'll never forsake her again.*

There are so many things Adora wants to say to Catra, so many apologies, so many secrets. She wants to throw herself into her knees and beg for her forgiveness, beg to be worthy of holding her trembling hand in hers, Like a devotee to a saint, like a demon that has fallen in love with an angel. Adora stops praying to the gods and she holds Catra close, heart against heart, praying this time to her, sun and goddess and angel and everything Adora wishes to adore for the rest of her life.

My love. My love

In the room, their bed is undone. Adora’s red dress is still over the chair. The air smells like tears, old, flooded in secrecy.

One day, I will explain to you

Adora walks over the sharp glass of the blown out window, uncaring if they dig in the tender flesh of her human body, uncaring if they make her bleed, uncaring if they break her in half.

Why sometimes I wake up screaming for you

Adora’s hair is almost white under the light of the virulent night that slips through the broken window. It falls over her eyes and down her back like the tail of a comet, soft, curling in the ends. She never cut it, even if she did get curious a few times. She knew just how much Catra liked to run her fingers through it, sun against stardust.

One day I will tell you why I hold your hand in mine a little bit tighter

Catra's hair is very short, uneven in places, curling around her jaw and ears like a crown. She loved her hair. Adora wishes she could crawl in her hands and nails across the sea floor for the rest of her life as a penitence if that meant she could somehow give it back to Catra.

One day I'll tell you why I cry when I caress the freckles on your cheeks

The bathroom is cold. There are blankets inside the huge tub that smell like them both, that smells like Catra's sleeping body and smells like the tears trapped in her face.

One day I tell you why I need to hear your heartbeat every night while you sleep

Living under the ocean, for Adora, was dark, isolated, beautiful is a kind of way that aches. For many years she didn't know there was more until she broke her head from the water and looked at the starry sky, filled with life and brightness, tiny dots as immense as being created in the first place could be, little fragments of gods scattered across the sky. Science and poetry and magic.

One day I'll explain to you why I kiss you slower, longer. Gentler.

That's how it felt looking at Catra's beautiful face that first night, a world being born again under the embrace of a star. Looking at her beautiful face right now, wrinkling with pain everytime she moves, it feels like a supernova, devourer of life, all things beautiful, all things sorrowful, all things loved.

That it is because seeing you it's seeing my soul living outside my body.

Adora's skin is smaller after being shredded by Adora's hands, bearing deep marks from her claws, dripping ichor dew over the floor. Adora will carry the scars, they are her sacrifice for Catra, just as Catra did for Adora. Even if it meant to never transform again, even if it meant to never return to the ocean again, Adora would do it over and over again.

That is because you carry my entire heart in your heart.

The skin still shimmers with a light of its own, clinging to Catra's chest where Adora has placed it, holding onto her like it knows her, like it knows what she did for it, for Adora. Like it knows the pain and the anguish and the love. Adora's heart aches painfully at the thought that Catra believed Adora wanted her skin more than she wanted Catra. There is nothing Adora has ever wanted or needed or loved more than her.

That is because I tasted the blood from your mouth, because I know exactly what is to see my soul ripped out of my chest

Adora pulls the blankets off and turns on the pipes, water filling the marble tub immediately. Adora dips her fingers inside and winces, it's freezing cold, but she doesn't have another option. She grabs an errand towel and damps it inside the water, running it over Catra's pale face, cleaning blood and tears away. She doesn't even realize her tears are dripping over Catra's face too.

Because I felt you slip away from my reach

Adora kneels over the floor, carrying Catra in her lap, waiting as the water fills the tub completely and overflows over the tiles, soaking Adora's soles and knees. She caresses the dips and creases of Catra's beautiful, pained face, wrapping her hand in hers and kissing her bruised knuckles. Melog curls inside the sink and meows sadly, their tiny body shivering.

That it is because I failed you to stay

Adora thinks of the day before she left, when she was enjoying the evening with Glimmer and Bow, when Catra was risking her life and Adora didn't even know it. She remembers laughing and missing Catra and wanting her back. Remembers Bow making a comment about their braided rings and Glimmer about her parents party-night. Adora remembers asking something to them because she still has human traditions to know and she loves Catra so much and she's been thinking about it from the moment she knew it was a possibility, to ask her to be with her and join her in all the ways someone can join somebody else.

Adora holds Catra tight against her chest and watches the water sizzle with salt and remembers she was going to ask her to marry her that night. And she cries.

My love, my brave love, that it is because I love you and I almost lost you and I'll never forgive myself for that

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○

… a night like this moons ago…

Catra has fallen asleep.

Adora sighs, gaze enamored, pressing a kiss on the pink shell of her ear and the corner of her closed eyes. She runs the tip of her fingers over her fluttering eyelashes, like swan feathers,

and caresses her cheek softly, marveling in the freckles that live there.

Catra is panting slightly, even in her sleep, her cheeks are dusted pink and there are tender tears like silver coins stuck on her eyelashes. Adora leans to kiss them away, pulling out so gently Catra sighs in her sleep, relaxing below Adora completely.

Adora lays over her, slightly leaning her weight to the side and resting her head against her hand so she can see Catra's face completely. The moonlight coming from the open window illuminates her face, stardust sleeping in Adora's arms.

Catra's eyelids are lilac and her eyelashes flutter every once in a while, little butterflies like dawn kisses. Her lips are kiss bitten red and damp and her breath is sweet as she sleeps. There is a small bruise in Catra's chin and it makes Adora frown, running her fingertips very gently over the red skin. Catra exhales with the touch, still sleeping, nuzzling closer to Adora.

Catra's arms are raised at either side of her head, resting over the soft mattress, palms up, elegant fingers relaxed. Her hair is long and soft below her, surrounding her head like a halo.

Adora drops her head from her hand and lowers back into the sheets, gently grabbing Catra's arms and wrapping them around her neck. She rolls Catra's sleeping body to the side, so gently Catra doesn't even stir, breathe even. Adora wraps her own arms around Catra's waist and nestles her face against the angle of Catra's neck where her pulse point is warmer and stronger.

Adora loves to hear Catra's heartbeat, her ear pressed against her skin, feeling the tremor of life and warmth running through her veins and heart. For Adora, it is like listening to the ocean, serene and magnificent, silence but also song, a lullaby Adora gets to know. It makes her feel so lucky, blessed by some god, finally having her entire soul inside her arms.

She doesn't need anything else, just this, just Catra. Catra and the question Adora will ask her when she wakes up, under the moonlight or at dawn. That's all Adora has ever wanted.

A rush of cold breeze calls Adora's attention, hitting softly on her back. They left the door of their room open from where the cold is slipping through, making the warm room a little bit chill. Just now, Adora remembers she forgot to close the window downstairs, like every night.

She'll go in a moment.

Right now, Adora wraps her arms around Catra's sleeping form, holding her so close they might just fuse into one being, heart against heart. The ocean is dangerously beautiful outside of the window, but Adora has no eyes for it, pressing open mouthed kisses on the column of Catra's neck, damp and warmth brushes of her lips against the angle of her jaw and her chin and and the point where her shoulder meets her neck, feather touch and infinitely tender.

Catra shivers under Adora's touch, still asleep, unconsciously seeking Adora's warmth further. Adora leans her head back a little, just enough do she can press her cheek over Catra's, breathing deeply against her skin.

Adora loves her so much, she would die for her, she would do anything for her

For now, Adora wraps her limbs with Catra's, nestling Catra's sleepy head against her shoulder, holding her close. Adora caresses gently the low of Catra's back, drawing swirls and circles until they turn into letters, carefully spelled over Catra's lovely back. And *I* and a *L* and a *O* and a *V* and every single letter left.

When she had her skin, Adora could speak every single language on land with ease, voiced instead of singing. She never used it, though. There was nobody she wanted to speak to. Now she doesn't have her skin and she doesn't have a human voice, but she knows the words, Catra's mother tongue in Adora's mother song, just a little bit different in the edges and just as lovely.

Adora doesn't know if Catra could understand them - she could - but she sings them anyway, her mouth against the tender curve of Catra's ear, over her closed eyelids, down the arch of her cheek where her skin is cold with the sea breeze from the stained window.

Adora's song is drowsy and sleepy and sweet. A song like a prayer, like a promise, that she is here.

That she will stay.

"Te adoro"

○

Adora holds Catra inside the salted bath the entire night. The water is cold and the minerals sizzle against the iridescent scales placed carefully over Catra's wound, stitching and lacing the skin together slowly, too slowly, painfully.

Adora rests her cheek against Catra's damp forehead, feeling the way heat builds up there with fever. She has drapped her shredded skin against herself again, so her powerful tail can wrap around Catra's back and legs, keeping her softly in place under the water when her muscles twitch and spasm in burning pain.

It's a horrifying sight. The wounds on Adora's tail match Catra's, deep and shearing, bleeding inchor on the water, but she bears them, doesn't care about them because if Catra dies tonight, Adora is going to throw herself from the cliff behind her. Because Adora is going to follow her, she is not letting her drift alone in the dark ever again.

Catra whimpers, in and out of consciousness several times across the night, holding herself to Adora's arms wrapped around her chest tightly, her lungs burning with salt water and anguish. Her short hair is soft against her scaled skin and Adora mourns the loss of it, gone with a grief that wasn't Catra's to endure and yet she did.

And Adora hates. There is nothing in her heart but her love for Catra and her hate for everything else. She hates Prime and his people. She hates the cliff beyond the house. She

hates the sea, the ocean and the sharp rocks. She hates the violent waves. She hates the wind and the storm and moon. She hates having taken so long. She hates herself.

Adora's rage is loud, her grief is silent.

The water of the bath is heavy with the salt and pink with Catra's blood and Adora hates.

End of chapter VI

Do you know I could break beneath the weight of the goodness, love, I still carry for you?

That I'd walk so far just to take the injury of finally knowing you

– Hozier, *Unknown/Nth*

Chapter End Notes

You really saw me putting a cliff next to the house and didn't think I was going to throw Catra from it? Shame.On.You

Also full eldrich horror Adora, my beloved

TRAUMA for character development

PS2. I swear everything will be alright don't be mad at me
PS3. Comments (screams), kudos and bookmarks are highly appreciated. Remember to download your fav works!

See you soon, love you!!

Pour my love into the sea [breath safe and adored from it]

Chapter Summary

"Do you know how much I love you?”

Chapter Notes

Repentance

Hello and welcome!! Guys, you are literally troopers and I absolutely love you to pieces thank you so much for sticking with me through the hardest parts of this story ;.;
I really hope you enjoy this freakishly long chapter, you deserve it (◜‿◝)♡

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter VII. Pour my love into the sea [breath safe and adored from it]

I’d weather storms and gales to return to her, my soul, my only.

– **Julia Drake** , *The Last True Poets of the Sea*

♡

A hurricane crashes against Salineas.

It's violent and it's long and it keeps people away.

It's an unnatural occurrence for the town, a storm pulled from the very depths of hell. The wind that swirls across the meadows and shores screams, voices of the sea devouring the usual peace of the town completely, raising trees from root and crashing against roofs and walls, full of rage.

The waves mirror it, raising and raising and raising with all their might until it almost consumes the ports completely. Sea water and salt crawling over the buildings, over the shores with dark pebbles and white sand, washing dirt and blood away.

The people of the town remain safe inside their homes and shelters but there is not a single soul that dares to walk out, that dares to challenge the rage the ocean has unleashed against

them, called by the cry of its daughter, aflamed by the tears of her lover. The sea swirls on itself and screams and nothing stops it.

The storm lashes against their shore too and against their home, dripping over the roofs like fallen stars and drums, and yet it doesn't feel threatening. It's like the eye of a storm, frighteningly quiet sometimes, freezingly calm, rain that keeps their home safe, guarded from anyone that might want to come in and defile it - *them* - again.

For seven days, it surrounds their home. For seven days it allows them to tend wounds in skin and soul. For seven days, just for seven days, it keeps them safe and sound.

♡

On the first day, Adora fixes the windows and closes all the heavy wooden curtains shut, nailing them until neither the wind or the water of the shadow of men can reach the inside. She picks up the broken glass and carefully fixes the pictures on the wall. She straightens the chairs and folds the blankets and saves them in the loveseat of a broken stained window. Pieces of stained glass scatter the ground.

There are nail scratches on the wood floor, there are pearls stuck on the jarring holes.

Adora doesn't dare look up. The lock of the window remains tightly shut.

She gets on her hands and knees and washes away the blood from the walls and the floor until her fingers and palms are raw and bloodied too. Until there are pieces of glass digging on her skin. Until the stains leave and the copper and salt smell that lingers with them. Until it hurts.

She is hurting herself, on purpose, trying to absorb a fraction of the pain lingering in the corners of their home. It's not good and it's not healthy and her love would be furious if she knew. Except she doesn’t.

Adora washes the blood and she hears the echoes of screams crawling in the walls and empties the bucket full of scarlet water down the drain and tries not to break down on the floor.

The lights go out and she turns on the fireplace, blue and green flames warming their home.

Catra sleeps.

When Catra sleeps, Adora stays with her, veiling for her dreams. Adora fixes the bed and the sheets and curls around Catra's thin body and doesn't sleep.

Catra has nightmares, Adora realizes fast, too fast. She doesn't trash in the bed or sleep fights. It's different, quiet. Her face scrunches in pain, frunced eyebrows, lips in an anguished scowl. There is sweat on her forehead and tears slipping from the corner of her eyes, hand balling into fists over the blankets. It's devastating, the kind of dreams Adora can't pull her out of no matter how tender or desperate she calls her name, not until she awakes by herself, with a

gasp, burying her face in the pillows with a deep sigh, holding herself to Adora's hand like a lifeline. The only thing Adora can do is hold her through it and make sure she is there when Catra opens her eyes.

"I'm not leaving," says Adora every time, silver against turquoise and gold. "I'm not leaving you, not again, not ever."

And the words hang between them like a vow, like an apology, like a plea, like tears in an ocean and blood in fingers and the broken pieces of a heart Adora is trying to put back together.

"I know," whispers Catra back, hoarse, hopeful, devastated, sweet, tired, honest.

Adora wonders if she really does know. Wonders if she really comprehends just how much Adora feels for her, how much she has missed her, how much her sorrow it's murdering her, slowly, like a poisonous dagger Adora has stabbed into her own heart. Adora wonders if Catra knows just how much she loves her and how sorry she is.

Adora wonders if this is the part tales don't tell you, the part between heartbreak and slay the dragon. That secret, nasty part where trust has been defiled and promises have been broken, where sobs break the night into nothing and where pain weighs like a world over your neck.

She wonders if this is what all those myths hide between prose and hubris. The laments of Psyche left alone by Eros, the tears of Andromache over Hector's body, the pleas of Eurydice behind Orpheus' shadow, the mourn of Patroclus for the crimson path of Achilles. The tragic destiny of tragic heroes and the infinite sorrow of those who loved them.

Catra falls asleep again and Adora cleans her tear tracks with her lips, drawing sad circles over her cheeks, tangling her fingers over the short strands of her hair. Adora does it all as if this way she could erase the pain away, like one brushes a feather off to the wind.

Catra sleeps and Adora stays.

The moments when Catra is awake Adora runs warm towels over Catra's face, washing tears and sweat away. She dresses the scratches in her arms and hands with clean gauzes and thinks how Catra did this for her, so long ago, tending to wounds made by men, out of compassion and kindness because that is who she was, who she is, just a fraction of her bravery and a whole part of her beauty.

Catra's fever lowers down and her wounds stitch together, still extremely fragile, still extremely painful. Adora tends to them with gentle care, every hour, every minute, gauzes coated in blood gathering around her bare feet, running the pads of her fingers over the tender skin, watching as the scales that were once her own and now are Catra's bend with her freckled skin, like patches of dawn holding onto her, refusing to let her slip away again. It's slow, quicker than any remedy in the world, and yet too slow. But, it's there and it's healing.

When she needs it, Adora helps Catra on her feet, wrapping Catra's arms around her own neck and supporting her back with her hands as she helps her into her tippy toes, rubbing circles on her bruised skin when she gasps and sobs with the pull on her delicate side. The

wounds are fragile and the skin is still vulnerable and sensitive. Adora can heal the damaged flesh but she can't take away the scars from it. Or the pain.

Every time, Catra presses her cold cheek on Adora's neck, rubbing their skins together as softly as she can, a gentle siren kiss filled with tenderness and sadness and silent pleas to stay. It brings tears to Adora's eyes every single time.

Catra almost doesn't speak, voice too dry and abused, body worn out and exhausted, heart too sore and heavy. She doesn't want to, she can't. Catra doesn't speak so Adora does it for her.

She reads from Razz's poetry books, sitting on the floor next to the bed. Catra curls on her side over the pillows, almost at the edge of the mattress, her eyelids hooded as she listens and stares at Adora's profile, almost as if she couldn't yet believe she was actually there. Tears gather in her eyes and fall down, trembling hand and trembling heart, held to Adora's fingers like a lifeline.

Adora reads and when her sight is too blurry to read she sings, sweet words of even sweeter songs she learnt on land, whispered broken and watery among the shadows of the room, with the rain outside almost like orchestras playing on their own, mournful and quiet, sad for the sadness that pours out of the house.

And when her human voice gets too shaky to speak, Adora hums reassurances in her mother tongue against Catra's cheeks, kneeling on the cold floor next to the side of the bed. She rests her cheek in Catra's pillows and presses their noses together and runs her fingers behind tears and hums. She hums for hours until she physically can't do it anymore, until Catra cradles her face between her cold, scratched up hands and pulls Adora towards her. Up and up, from the hard floor to the soft mattress and inside her embrace. And Adora follows her because she doesn't know what else to do, because she doesn want to be anywhere else but here, with her face pressed against Catra's chest, listening to her breathing and the gentle run of her bruised heart.

That first day, they hold tight onto each other and allow themselves to hurt, to be frightened, to be in love, devastatingly in love. They hold onto each other tightly and wait for wounds to heal under the other's touch and hope they don't become a tragic myth themselves. There is, after all, not elysium or tartarus, heaven or hell, rain or ashes where the love they've built here has a place but inside their own souls.

♡

On the second day, Adora finds a spare portable battery and manages to charge Catra's phone. There is no reception but the small thing vibrates violently and the light of voice messages twinkles insistently with the sea of messages in there, sent before it died down completely at some point.

Adora hesitates, just for a second, her fingers hovering over the button before finally pressing it down. She shouldn't be doing this but she has missed three weeks of Catra's life and she is so thin, she has barely eaten anything and Adora is scared.

The kind voices of the messages slip inside the staircase where Adora is sitting, on the very last step, echoing across her ears and the walls and the outside raging rain.

This is Catra, I'm probably not going to answer calls so leave a message like a decent person.

Beep |

| *Catra, this is Glimmer. I know you said to leave you alone but I'm going to be buggering your ass until you let me come in, I don't care what you said. Just to let you know.*

| *Catra, it's me again. It's been hours and I know you are listening to this, I can see the blue dots. Get up from the floor and have a shower, I… please.*

| *Catra, are you eating anything?*

| *Hey wildcat, it's me. I mean, it's Scorpia, well you already must have guessed right? Em, I talked to Spinerella like you asked me, she says the book is doing amazing! I don't know what you are doing but you should be proud! Tell Adora I said hi!*

| *Catra?*

| *This is your daily reminder to get up your ass* - rustle - *Please, Catra*

| *Just say something, anything, let me know you are alive at least.*

| *Just checking in, wildcat! Is Adora there? ... Entrapta put that down! Oh dear ... have to go! Listen quickly, I just wanted to say I hope you are happy, wildcat. I really, really do. I know how happy Adora makes you and I'm so glad for you. You deserve it, after everything. Alright now I gotta go for real! Gimme a call later!*

| *It's Glimmer, again . Don't do anything stupid, Catra, or I swear to fucking god ...*

| *Cat?*

| *Catra, it's been a week. I'm really worried about you*

| *Are you eating anything? You haven't come to the market so I thought… you need to eat"*

| *Catra? This is Bow. I know you don't want to talk or see anybody but I'm going to leave some groceries on your door, alright? You don't have to come out if you don't want to, I'll just leave them there… ... Catra, I know it's not my place and I know I have no business in here but.. if it's worth something, I think Adora truly loves you. I ... the last time we saw her, she asked us ... um ... I- I don't believe she could've stopped loving you, not… not for anything. Not like that. I don't know what happened but I need you to know that you are loved, Catra, and that you are needed, alright? ... ... Alright, I'm going to drive by. We got you.*

Adora shuts the phone, covers her face with her hands and sobs silently until she can't breath.

She carries Catra where she needs it, near the fireplaces to warm up her bones when then temperature inside the house drops further, to the restroom and the kitchen or inside the shower, Catra curled against her chest closely, her hands wrapped in the fabric of Adora's shirt so tightly her nails pick little holes there. There is no shame on this. She is sick and she needs her. That is a part of what love is.

Adora helps her undress gently, pulling from each cloth with care until she is bare in front of her, until all her scars and the red and purple and green patches in her body come into view and Catra curls into herself, ears red in embarrassment, hugging herself as if she could hide it all away from Adora's sight. She still doesn't understand she is the most beautiful thing Adora has ever seen, even beyond the beauty of her underwater world, beyond the light of the stars or the warmth of the sun. She is as beautiful as the day Adora saw her for the first time, as the day they lost each other, as every single day. She is beautiful with all her scars and all her pain, rooted inside her body like a kind of skin too. Tender and bright or dimmed and hurt like this, she will always be the most beautiful for Adora.

Adora helps her inside the shower and stands in front of her so the spray doesn't hit her directly, dripping from Adora's soaked hair and face and into Catra's like gentle kisses. The first time they tried this, she saw the way panic locked her over when the water rushed over her too fast, how scared she looked for a second before Adora rushed forward and pulled her out. Adora has learned her lesson, she is not letting it hurt Catra again.

In the evening, Adora cradles Catra's body over hers, holding them both into a sitting position over the bed. Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist and holds one of Catra's hands delicately between hers, opening the bottle of black nail polish with the other, working softly over her.

Catra's nails are mostly busted, broken in places and cracked in the tips. Adora doesn't want to think about what made them reach this point, on the nail marks in the floor below, on the amount of desperation she must have felt. Instead Adora files them as much as she can and paints them with delicate care, closing bloodied fissures with the painting and blowing them dry with her breath.

Catra rolls her head to the side at some point, tucking it below Adora's chin. She opens her eyes just a slit, chuckling under her breath when she catches sight of what Adora is doing.

"Are you painting my nails?" she asks in a whisper, good-natured, soft. Vulnerable. Adora nods besides her head, just humming in return. She can't bring herself to talk, not now. She will cry if she does and if Adora cries, Catra will follow her and it will be damned the day Adora makes Catra cry again. "You are so sweet"

You are a monster

It's the fragment of a memory, resounding inside Adora's head like a violent bell. It's acid, slashing words, sorrowful and unfair. Adora said them. She said them to Catra. Because Adora was hurting and she knew it would hurt Catra too.

Adora wonders if Catra remembers them.

She does. It’s in her eyes, when she wakes up from her exhausted sleep, blinking back tears and sorrow. When her eyes unfocus just a little, thinking she is still alone on their bed, lonely, lost. Abandoned.

"What time is it?"

"Late" answers Adora back, softly, merely above a broken murmur, pressing a trail of kisses above her temples and cheeks.

"I'm tired"

"I know" Adora tangles their fingers together, holding their joined hands against Catra's chest, feeling the rise and fall of her shoulders and the softness of her back against her. "You can go back to sleep. I'll look after you" Adora rests her lips on the crown of Catra's short hair, closing her eyes tightly, letting tears fall tiny and silently down her cheeks, there, where Catra can't see her. There where Adora can keep her pain hidden, where it can’t hurt Catra again. “I’ll always look after you”

Catra remembers those cruel, unfair, untruthful words yet she curls around Adora, chasing her warmth, trusting her completely as she also closes her eyes. Because, even if she remembers them, she knows Adora much better. Even if Adora can't understand it yet over the guilt, or the pain.

"Promise?" Catra whispers, already dozing off.

"Yes" Adora swears, "I promise"

♡

On the third day Adora tells Catra that she loves her and Catra shatters.

It's a whisper, a song, true as love can be. It shreds Catra in half.

Catra cries, she cries and cries and can't stop, rain against ice, sea foam over sand. It starts as a shaking breath, her eyes widening then softening, then filling with cold tears, falling down her cheeks like fallen stars.

She cries because she didn't think she would get to hear those words again, not in Adora's song, not from Adora's mouth, not in any form. She cries because she didn't believe she was worthy of them, because she didn't think she deserved them. She cries because they lost each other and all the tender love they had built carefully around each other is so fragile right now, so tender and painful.

She cries because Adora left her, Adora left her behind. Adora took her skin and begged her and Catra pushed her away and Adora left her. She cries because she had never felt so much suffering before, not even from the wounds she carries on her body now, and she has been crying for so long and for so much that feeling the tender touch of love again manages to

shatter her into pieces. Like the pieces of Adora's skin now clinging to her own skin, like the opals in Adora's eyes, full of tears and regret and guilt and pain.

This is who they are, dancing around each other's stardust, tangling around each other, drifting apart, meeting again like crashing galaxies. She cries for herself, she cries for Adora, she cries for the love that lingers and strengthens, cries for the adoration in Adora's touch and the regret in her voice and the silent plea in her silver eyes for Catra to forgive her. Cries because it broke them both and yet Catra knows she would do it all again, exactly the same, all the pain and the loneliness and the tears that have made their way into her marrow, all of it just for Adora's sake.

She cries because she knows Adora is suffering too, always mirrors of each other, light and dark, sun and sea, sand and sky.

She cries around Adora's hands when the latter cradles Catra's face between her palms. Cries when Adora repeats the words, cries when she rests their foreheads together and presses a fluttering kiss over Catra's broken lips, drowned in sorrow and overwhelming love, so hesitant it hurts, as if Adora didn't know how to touch her anymore, as if she didn't know that Catra is made of her love. Catra cries when she returns the kiss, vulnerable, open and regretful too and baring like a sword inside a soul. And then they kiss again and again, lips against lips, tongue against teeth, fingertips over cheekbones, tears across skin. Sour and sweet and painfully honest, full of desperate love, full of layered desire, filled with all the things Adora wants to say and all the love Catra can give, pouring each other's adoration on the other's throat, whimpering and gasping, fingertips against necks. And sighing and singing, open lips against feverish skin. And kissing again.

Catra cries because she can feel the weight of Adora's love around her bones, the embrace of her feelings across Catra's soul. She cries because she understands, without words. She understands Adora's pain is a parallel of her own. She cries because she realizes Adora *loves* her, actually, truly, fully, completely, loves her. And she cries because she was wrong, Adora never wanted something else, something more, but her. Being the recipient of this kind of love can bend anyone.

Catra cries until her tears are full blown sobs, loud and heart wrenching, too painful to ignore, sorrow that had been carried for so long opening free, an open wound pouring out all the venom, finally allowing itself to heal.

Adora cradles Catra against her chest, sitting in their bed with her front pressed tight against Catra's back, her face against her thin shoulder blades, her arms strongly crossed around Catra's chest, feeling the way the sobs rip through her lungs and her voice and almost breaks her in pieces with the force of it. Adora curls herself around Catra's small form and lets her cry and doesn't let go.

Catra cries and cries and Adora holds her through it all, her own quiet tears dripping over Catra's skin, repeating the words like a prayer against her ears.

I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you, I love you

I love you -

Catra cries and Adora follows her and they love each other and neither of them let go.

–

When Catra is sleeping, Adora covers her with her skin like a blanket, a soft veil wrapped over her gently, shelter and shield. There is not a place where Catra goes where Adora doesn't make sure she has her skin.

Catra tries to give it back but Adora denies it every time, shaking her head hard with lips pressed into a tight line as she makes sure it covers Catra's scarred nape and shoulders completely. Until she looks like a bride and a saint and an angel.

It's unusual, for a merfolk, for a first one. Skins are sacred to them, holy grails that allow them to live in their seafoam and coral world. Gods' gifts that have granted them immortality and violence and beauty and strength. Without them, they are nothing. This is why the safekeeping of their skins is so important, this is why the defile of it is so unholy. They won't even give it to their mate and, even if mates join for life, there will never be anything more important for a first one than their skin. Anything at all.

Except for Adora.

She shredded her skin into pieces for Catra and she would do it again until there wasn't anymore of it to take from just so she could live, just so she could breathe.

Catra is quiet and she is so careful, carrying the edges off the floor and against her chest when she is walking, hesitantly and slowly, holding it very tenderly against her body. The opals and scales blend into liquid gold when Catra touches them. The pearls darken until they look like starry skies and they never come back to the silver of before. New scales and sea glass bloom everywhere except where the scars live, like paths of the flowers Catra so much loves. Where there was starlight before now there is an aurora borealis, blues as gems and ambers as suns and it takes Adora a heartbeat to understand her skin is mirroring Catra's eyes, moon and sun.

Adora thinks it might just be shifting completely, molding itself around Catra's body, her elegant hands, her soft hips, the short silk of her hair, her gentle touch. Adora didn't know a siren's skin could change like this, as if it was making itself completely anew, but it doesn't matter. If it's Catra, it doesn't matter.

Catra is, after all, not only her mate. She is her best friend and her lover and her anchor and her entire world. She is Adora’s immortality and her purpose. She is the reason the Fates placed Adora on this world.

She thinks it's fitting because Catra is her entire soul and heart. Catra is her entire life. There is nothing Adora wants more than to carry her in her skin.

This way maybe Adora can also mold herself around everything that makes Catra what she is. Maybe this way she can fuse herself with her bones and make her nightmares stop. Maybe this way Catra can know that leaving her almost destroyed her and losing her almost killed her, that Catra has always been more sacred to Adora than the skin she cradles so carefully

against her heart or the sea that wails sadly outside the windows of their room. That Adora is holding her promise as a vow in the cords of her heart.

Maybe this way Adora can make Catra understand she is going to stay.

♡

On the fourth day, Catra gets a nosebleed and Adora pretty much loses her mind.

It comes out of nowhere. Catra has been sleeping a lot and her scars are almost, miraculously, completely closed. Adora convinced her to eat last night and then again in the morning, one turkey sandwich and then another and one more, pressing kisses on her cheeks when Catra weeps around the bites of her food. She is so thin and she is starving but her breathing is stronger, her face more colorful, red spots in her cheekbones when Adora leans to kiss the corner of her mouth. She looks a little bit better and it makes Adora a little bit happier.

So yes, it comes out of nowhere, except that Catra still has a little bit of fever and she is still tender in her wounds and she is quite exhausted, so Adora is helping her reach the bed, her hands on the low of her back and her waist, tender touches and even more tender whispers.

Catra is walking slowly across the wooden floor of their bedroom when she suddenly holds her breath, letting out a small *oh* and covering her nose with her hand. Adora is there immediately, eyes wide and alarmed, spinning around on her ankles so she is in front of Catra, almost falling on her knees as she searches for her face and takes Catra's wrist gently on her hand, lowering it back down.

Small drops of red drip from her nose and down her upper lip, falling against the floor in silence. It's small and very very little, probably caused by the errand fever. It drips for a few seconds and then it's over but it turns Adora's world around and it seizes her heart and her breath with steel grip, shutting down her brain completely.

Adora goes into overdrive, Catra can see it, like a sickness spreading between them, impeding like a storm in front of her. Adora´s precious eyes widen in sudden terror and then fall, casting jarrying shadows over her skin like thunderbolts over the dark sky. Catra holds her breath, dread falling over her cold and frightening, watching as Adora´s entire demeanor changes, from soft and open around her to guarded, almost robotic, shutting her pink mouth so quickly and hard her teeth clash painfully.

Catra extends her arm, hand searching for Adora´s blindly. She wants to tell her that everything is alright, that it is over, that she is not bleeding anymore, but suddenly all her words have left her and she is left speechless, just hovering like a spirit with her voice stuck on her throat. And she knows it's because she doesn´t mean just the nosebleed, and she knows Adora´s reaction isn't completely about it either.

Before Catra can find herself again, Adora is already rising to her feet, roaming across the room like a weeping angel. Her eyes are casted down, looking everywhere as she seems to be searching for something, and she is muttering to herself, so quick and low her voice sounds almost hoarse and even if Catra tries to pay attention she can´t make out of the words,

whispered in Adora´s mother tongue, crashing against each other until they are not a sound anymore.

Catra stands still in the middle of the room, watching as Adora makes her way to the bathroom and fetches a clean towel, dipping it inside the stream of water from the sink. Melog is curled tightly over the pillows of the bed, watching Adora moving around with smart, precarious eyes, meowing softly, mirroring Catra´s concern.

Catra stands still, gripping Adora´s skin tightly against her body. It's soft, it's the softest thing Catra has ever felt, a feather brushing over her body everywhere where it touches her. It's cold at the touch and tampers down the pain in Catra´s body, now almost gone completely. The first day it was unbearable, threatening to push her down the edge again, too cruel and violent to bear it. But, she could also feel the brush of the skin against her, so tender she would sometimes confuse it with Adora´s even gentler touch. And it would lull her into sleep as she felt her skin tingle and knit back together, healing her in the weirdest, most marvelous way. Catra can´t remember much more but besides that feeling and the sight of Adora´s face next to her, always, a little bit blurred by pain and tears but there. She could feel her there. Love, after all, is blind.

Now its touch feels just as reassuring but equally as sad, holding her up as Adora rushes back to her side, Adora is different too, than before. She is soft and gentle and loving still, devastating raw, opening herself bare for Catra. But she is also quieter now, moving around like a mourning spirit, slow and sharp and dimmed down.

And she is fiercely protective of Catra, almost feral, orbiting around her like a planet to the sun, like a dragon to a treasure, all sharp teeth and brave heart. Catra sees it, she does, on the way Adoras holds her hand when nightmares of water and green eyes choke her at night. She sees it in the way she nailed the windows and washed those men's blood from under her nails. She sees it in the way she cares for Catra's wounds as if they were going to open again and bleed all over the bed and the floor.

Adora presses the damp towel below Catra´s nose, cleaning the errand drops of blood from her face with a feather touch. Up close, Catra can see Adora´s face fully, hovering below her face, her knees on the hard floor, running the soft cloth again and again until there is no more blood to clean anymore. So close to each other, Catra can see the way Adora´s hands are trembling violently. All of her is shaking, from head to toe, strong spasms that threaten to knock her over and fall into the floor.

Her face is sunken and so tired, so impossible tired, eyes lined in red from hours and days and weeks of tears, hooded by exhaustion. And she looks pained, she looks like she is feeling the worst pain possible, like something is tearing her up from the inside out, bleeding her out, leaving her worn out and agonizing on the floor of their shared room.

She is looking at Catra as if she didn't know if she was actually real, as if she was a dream and Adora was trapped inside of it, too far away to reach her in time. Adora is roaming her eyes through the planes of her face, almost hysterical, from her forehead down the bridge of her nose and the curve of her lips, eyes swimming in tears, face pale. There are bruises under her eyes like lilac blooms and she is breathing hard, scales sprouting on her temples and falling on the ground immediately after, obsidian and sad.

It's the kind of expression of someone that is terrified, Adora looks *terrified.* The kind of expression of someone that has lived her own personal hell in a loop and that doesn't know how not to drown inside of it. Doesn't know how to wake up again from it. It's the expression of someone that isn't allowing herself to make any more mistakes, as if it was a tragic destiny to rip herself in pieces for someone else.

She hasn't eaten, she hasn't slept. Her face is too pale and there is a perpetual cold sweat in her forehead. She looks through the cracks of the wood to the hurricane outside for hours, holding Catra's hand inside her as if it was the only thing anchoring to reality, waiting with her heart on her throat for the monsters to appear again, paranoid and scared. She is gentle around Catra, loving and sweet, but there is a perpetual sadness that surrounds her, a weight that wasn't there the last time Catra saw her, so heavy that it crushes her, dimming her light until it almost extinguishes itself completely. A weight that pushes her down with all it's might, almost cracking her into pieces

Catra is still in pain and her heart is broken but so is Adora's. Adora is hurting herself, carrying with a guilt that doesn't belong to her, quietly carrying it all for Catra's sake and Catra hates it, hates her, hates herself because this is not how it is supposed to be. This is not what Adora is supposed to feel. This fear and distress and anguish. Catra is supposed to look after her and shelter her but she can't even walk without failing to breathe.

Adora is in pain because, even if she is immortal, she is not indestructible. She is mythical and beautiful but she is also real, she is *alive* . She is kind and soft, curious and loyal. She wears her heart on her sleeve and loves everything she can give. And she hurts too and her heart breaks too. And it makes Catra curl over herself in shame because all of this pain and suffering it's because of her, she caused it thinking it would save her and she doesn't know what to do to make it better.

Adora stands up in a swing, towel forgotten in the vanity, walking from side to side inside the quiet room, barely illuminated by the light coming from the outside. She looks like a lion, like a shark, chasing herself inside the enclosure of her own mind, closing around the blue walls of the room that saw them love each other and then lose each other.

Adora runs her nails through her hair and hisses in the places where her claws scratch her skin, unfolded as she slowly loses control. She has gotten a habit these days of holding all her hair into a ponytail over her head, falling on loops behind her back. It helps her move around freely around their house, it helps her not to pull from it from the root.

On the myth, Achilles tears off all of his golden hair with his own hands and burns it on a funeral pyle, merging that way with the corpse of his love, too worn out to keep living beyond the destruction of his own existence, too burdened by grief and sorrow, buried alive by regret and guilt. In the myth he tries to become death himself, covered in dirt and gods's blood, ashamed and filled with rage.

On the tales, the gods enchant mortals and lay with them and then they go away, to absorbed on their own endless immortality to care about anything else, wrapped in their ichor and their ambrosia, watching kingdoms rise and fall and mortals love and die and rot because of that, crawling on their knees for the gods to spare them one more time.

In this story, Adora pulls from her hair but doesn't rip it off, holding to the strands like lifelines, looking everywhere in the room and then at Catra, too lost inside her own head, too consumed by grief. In this story, it is the god that has crawled to her knees for a mortal, overwhelmed with so much love and grief and rage she doesn't know what to do with them. Self destructive and chaotic. A lunar moth that has fallen in love with the sun.

Adora sucks a breath, holds it, grips herself over her upper arms, breathes again. She doesn't even realize she is hyperventilating until her body starts to shake, violently, shocked by the strongest of tremors. She is going hysterical. Adora opens her mouth, tries to speak, but nothing comes out, nothing but the loudest, most heartbreaking sob, breaking down through her chest and across her entire body, finally bending her in half.

This time it is Adora the one who cries. Her tears fall down her cheeks relentlessly, rivers and waterfalls, pooling on her chin and dripping on the floor. She can't breathe, for the first in her life, she can't breathe and absently Adora wonders if this is how drowning feels like, the absence of air, the light head, the spinning room, the lungs constricting painfully inside her chest. She wonders if this is a fraction of what Catra felt when she drowned. *Adora watched Catra die.* Adora gasps and claws at her neck, leaving red lines there without actually breaking skin, looking for an air that fails her.

She is aware that she is opening and closing her mouth, vocal cords closing tightly on her throat, song strangled and raw. And she knows that, between the sudden, oppressing, fear, she is trying to call Catra's name, calling for her, desperately and lost in the dark. Adora doesn't seem to be able to find herself, to find her way back home.

Her knees are trembling like crazy, buckling under her and she knows it won't take very long for them to finally give up and tumble harshly into the ground. There are spots of black crawling on the edges of her vision, obscuring everything around her, in front of her, behind her, an eclipse hiding the sun from her reach and Adora *cannot breathe*

" … 'dora … Adora," Catra's voice pierces through the darkness, raw after so much silence, but *oh* so dear, a strand of sun chasing away the poisonous shadows. Adora blinks, her sight completely blurred by endless tears. It takes her so much, so, so much, but finally she can see Catra's precious face in front of her, her sea glass eyes locked in hers, wide and worried, swimming in her own tears, swimming in sadness. She has rushed out of the side of the bed, reaching Adora as a second nature, her hands cradling the sides of her face. "Adora."

Adora is falling, she has been falling since she saw Catra fall down that cliff, she has been falling since she left her, *abandoned* her. Abandoned her own soul, her heart and their love. She has been falling since she chose fear over love.

Adora is falling and Catra catches her.

Catra wraps her arms around Adora's chest, holding her before Adora can collapse completely into the floor, pulling from her until they are chest to chest, heart to heart, embracing each other so close they are one. Adora clings to her, like a lifetime, like an anchor, mindful of the scars that are her fault, mindful of the bones and the skin and the delicacy that holds the love of her life, but also desperate, fingers tight against freckled skin,

lips against Catra's neck, crying so hard and so loud Adora feels like her body is not going to be able to hold it up.

She is so tall she towers over Catra completely, yet she looks so frail right, like if Catra let's go she might break completely. And she holds onto Catra with so much desperation, sobs wrecking her, terrified to let go or to even look up because if she does Catra might just slip through her fingers again and disappear below storm waters and blood again, and Adora cannot exist in a world where she is not in.

"Adora" Catra exhales, and it comes all broken and wrong but it's the best she can do. She is breaking too. "I'm here"

“Catra,” Adora is chanting like a prayer, kneeling in the ground and holding Catra against her like a saint holding onto a rosary. She is gasping, struggling to breath so bad she is frighteningly pale, cries tearing at the cords of her soul and her heart. “Catra”

Catra digs her fingers on Adora's back and the nape of her head and presses her impossibly closer too. They've hurt each other so much for things that weren’t even their fault and they've missed each other even worse. And Catra knows, she knows that if they don't hold onto each other right now neither of them will survive.

"Look at me, look at me," Catra begs, grasping Adora's trembling hand between hers and bringing it towards her own cheek, cold against warm skin. "I'm here, I'm *alive* and I'm here."

Adora's eyes are on her but she is not looking at her, not really, misted over by panic and memories, overflowed in their pain with tears like diamonds that roll between Catra's fingers, fragile as crystals.

“It’s alright. You can cry, Adora, it’s alright," Catra mumbles, wet, and it's then when she notices she is crying too, dripping down her face and onto Adora’s face in tear stains. She wonders if one day they'll stop falling from her eyes.

Adora is shaking her head, grinding her teeth so hard her jaw settles and almost pops. She takes her hand away from Catra's and rubs the heel of her hand against her tearful eyes so hard it reddens the skin immediately, scraping the fragile skin there with her nails. This is the first time Catra has ever seen her like this, so sad and *angry* , so burdened by pain and guilt.

She is clawing at the floor with one hand - leaving deep marks over the wood parallels of the ones downstairs - and holding Catra's shivering shoulders against her and her face looks terrible, so much like that night on the shore when blood was staining her face and her hands. Her face is clustered with scales, dark as obsidian and bleeding rubies,covering her temples and cheekbones and the angle of her jaw and neck and falling immediately after, as soon as they sprout.

Adora is messy and chaotic and rageful right now, against life, against what happened, against herself, undoing herself in the seams, pushing herself far too much. Catra still doesn't know what happened to Adora during those violent days apart. She still doesn't know about the depths of the ocean and the cold sand and the darkness and the desolation, so much alike

to her own, reflections of each other. She'll find out, eventually. She'll know because Adora will tell her, but for now she can only feel it, the weight of it all, stabbing through Adora's body and into her own like a sword, like shared poison and one graveyard for two young lovers.

Catra loves her through it all.

"It's okay," Catra runs her fingers through Adora's hair, flinching at the touch of the bloodied scratches there, staining gold into copper. She grabs the tie that holds all her hair and snaps it in half, freeing Adora's hair as it falls gently down her back, rubbing circles from the crown of her head to her nape, speaking softly. “You’ve been through so much and I’m so sorry, Adora.” Catra’s throat closes tightly, tears burning in her eyes. “It's okay to cry"

"No,” Adora growls, so loud and firm it startles Catra for a second. Adora´s human voice is beautiful, even as overwhelmed by emotions as it is right now. She has been talking to Catra with so much tenderness the past few days but it still catches Catra by surprise from time to time, like hearing a swan speak for the first time

“No, no. I- no," Adora denies her again, balling her hands in fists over Catra´s shirt. Catra knew she would try to fight her but Adora loses the grip of her voice and dissolves into another heartbreaking sob again. Catra has never heard Adora cry like this, not even that night on the shore when she first arrived home, when she lost her skin and her voice. Never. Not until … not until the cliff. Adora shakes her head firmly again, lips brushing against Catra's neck. " You- you are the one hur-"

Catra knows what she is going to say, and she cuts her short, as gently as she can but firmly too, cradling the back of Adora's head on her palm.

“You are hurting too, Adora. Let yourself be hurt," she whispers to her, shaking but honest and she can feel the way Adora undoes herself around her, falling completely against Catra's hold.

"I'm scared" Adora finally confesses, tangling her fingers with the front of Catra's shirt, damp with her tears. "I'm scared, Catra"

"I know, I know." Catra's voice fails her and she hates herself a little for it, but she can't stop crying either. "I'm scared too."

And it's true, she is so scared. She feels like their home is going to break any second now, crushed under the greed of one man. And Adora is here, again, for Catra, for love, and Catra is scared.

Catra runs her fingers through Adora's bangs and pulls from her face gently, just so she can see her eyes. They are silver and bloodshot, exhausted and impossibly sad, yet they look up at Catra with so much adoration it makes her tremble and cry harder, almost choking in her words when she speaks again. "We'll figure it out, alright? We'll do it together"

Instead of reassuring her, Catra's tears only seem to fuel Adora's sadness further. Adora falls from Catra's sweet hold, pressing her tear stained face against Catra's belly, right under her

ribs, breathing her in deeply. Catra feels Adora running her cold palms under her shirt, resting them just below the crooked edges of her scars. Scars of wounds that bleed. Blood that should have drained her over the sand. Catra shivers and gasps because she should be dead. She would be dead if Adora hadn't been there, if she hadn't come back then. *Adora came back for her.*

Adora came back for her and yet Adora is trembling from head to toe because she thinks she *failed* .

"I've hurt you so much," Adora manages between a hiccup and a sob, burying her face as far as she can against Catra's body.

"No, Adora," Catra says and it breaks her heart. She tangled Adora's golden hair between her fingers, holding to the silk strands, cradling Adora's head gently around her palms. "Adora, it's not your fault. It wasn't your fault, none of it"

Adora's strong back arches with the strength of another sob, ripping through her throat. Catra thumbs the black fabric of Adora's sleeveless turtleneck, smothering it over her shoulder blades gently, waiting patiently. Adora is covered in scars too, on her shoulder and on her exposed bicep, long and wide, made by hunting knives. On her hands and down the length of her shoulder blades, jarring and new from where the sea slammed them both against the cliff and the thought makes Catra sink into herself. Pale and raised like opals. Painful but healed.

And there are scars on her skin, her *skin,* draped carefully by Catra over the bed before she rushed to catch Adora. It glimmers under the light of the few candles they have inside the room, golden and blue and *different.* Beautiful as a comet, scratched over and uneven where Adora sank her claws and tore it apart as if it was nothing, as if it wasn't the only thing that could return her to the sea.

They've sacrificed so much for each other, so much for this love.

"I'm sorry, I- I'm s-so sorry" Adora whispers, agonizing inside her pleas, inside her apologies, brushing her fingers over the delicate scars and Catra knows what she means. Adora saw her fall.

It's blurry for Catra, drowned by adrenaline and fear, but she knows it was terrifying and so, so painful. It's going to scar her body and soul for life and Adora saw it all, so close and so far away and she is blaming herself. Catra doesn´t even know what would have been of her if it was Adora in her place. Catra sinks her hands around her hair and exhales, trembling.

"I'm not sorry." Catra states, firm, strong. She doesn't know if she is ever going to forgive herself for breaking Adora's heart, for pushing her away, for causing her pain. But she is not sorry for the scars or her blood in the sand. Not for trading her life for Adora's life. She is not sorry to break herself for that. It might not be healthy and it might be terrifying, this amount of love, but this is who they are, the lengths they go for love, and she doesn´t want Adora carrying with that. "I'm not, Adora" and then with the sweetest and strongest voice she can she adds. "You are worth it"

Adora breaks around the words, nestling her face on the angle of Catra´s neck. She is warm, tears rolling down her cheeks and into Catra´s shoulder, her breath sweet, and she is holding Catra so tightly their hearts are beating as one. Their room smells like tears but it also smells like something else. Like forgiveness, like repent.

"I don't - I don't know w- what to do"

"I've got you" Catra buries her face on the crown of Adora´s head, holding her over her lap, letting herself cry too. "We've got each other. You don't need to do anything. I *love* you and I'm not letting go, not again."

They hold onto each other and cry until it's all out, until sadness and regret and grief washes off their bones and drips down their cheeks and out of their bodies. They cry until they are tired to the bone and the rain outside has picked up again, drowning the world into darkness. Until they don´t know if it is early or late and they don't bother to think about it. This is a moment for them, for their bruised skins and their bruised hearts. Let them hold each other's hands and heal.

Catra holds onto Adora and Adora holds onto Catra for minutes that blend into hours until their tears start to thin and finally dim down, still there but not acid anymore. Cold as a morning kiss.

Adora takes a shaky breath, exhaling slowly. Her chest still hurts but she doesn't feel like her lungs are trying to suffocate her anymore. She can feel her own cheeks bright red from crying so much, from the tip of the ears and down her neck and shoulders.Every single muscle in her body is trembling and her skin feels too sensitive, but she is also warm, surrounded by Catra ´s smell and hands, the cadence of her breathing next to Adora´s ear and her heartbeat inside her chest.

There is a low hum there, tender, filling Adora´s ears and head and entire body, covering it all in calmness. It takes Adora a while until she realizes it's Catra. Catra is singing. A sweet song, barely just a murmur without words of some song they used to hear on the radio before everything came crashing down..

Catra runs her fingers over Adora's shoulder, across her biceps and down her arm all the way to her wrist, a gentle caress full of warmth. She turns Adora's palm around gently, running her fingers over the skin full of glass cuts halfway healed, resting her palm in hers. Adora exhales, leaning her entire self on the pressure of their palms resting together, sharing touch and warmth.

Catra sighs, lacing their fingers together. Her humming remains steady as she pulls from Adora, very, very softly, guiding her patiently back to their feet. Adora follows her along, she will always follow Catra wherever she goes.

They make it up slowly, holding onto each other to not lose their balance. Adora´s legs wobble a little, numb after laying on the cold floor for so long, but Catra is there to catch her, still not letting go. Catra is going very slowly too, careful of not moving too fast.

To be honest, both of them feel like shit. Her body is still sore, phantom pain lingering in her bones, but Adora is there too to catch her, resting her free hand on her waist, right above scars and scales. She is always going to be there from now on.

Catra doesn't stop singing. She slips her arm around Adora´s back, placing her open palm over Adora´s shoulder blades, her other hand still tangled with Adora´s. Catra leans her head towards Adora´s chest, resting her cheek over her collarbones. Adora´s neck and shoulders are covered in scales, blues and ambers, but they are soft against Catra´s skin, like feathers. Catra starts to swing, very slowly from side to side, feet bare over the floor, tippy toeing to reach Adora.

Adora inhales and holds her breath, trying to keep Catra´s smell inside her lungs as much as can. Then she relaxes, finally, absolutely, leaning her cheek over Catra´s forehead, letting herself be lulled into this small, tender dance across their room. This moment is so fragile and yet so strong, so important, muted steps over wood, hand in hand, following the tender and silent movements of a waltz only they know.

They smell like tears and like sadness still, but they also smell sweet and caring, following each other carefully and tenderly, together. Catra sings and Adora loves her. Adora dances with her and Catra loves her back.

They are beginning again.

♡

On the fifth day, they talk.

But first, they sleep. They curl around each other like shells to a pearl, limbs and hands and lips tangled together, skin against skin. They hold each other and sleep for sixteen hours and nothing disturbs them meanwhile.

The sky outside is still virulently dark and the rain from the hurricane swirls and wails against the roof tiles and the shut doors, but the storm is a little bit quieter, a hesitant promise that this too will pass.

The house is calm, silent too and covered in some other kind of darkness, less oppressive, less mournful. It shelters them as they allow themselves to close their eyes, after spending so much time torn apart.

They are exhausted to the bone and so they sleep. Adora rests, for the first time in weeks, and Catra doesn't have nightmares, so drunk from each other's presence it is enough to allow them from some long craved hours of sleep. Of peace.

They wake up soft and warm against each other, surrounded by clean sheets that smell like them and tenderness. Catra blinks up at Adora, eyes gentle and drowsy with sleep, still heavy but brighter, less weary, less full of sadness. Adora watches her in silence for a long while, breathing quietly through her nose, painting all the creases and depths of her face inside her mind like starry maps, making herself anew around her.

Then she leans forward, very slowly, letting Catra lean away if she wants to - *she doesn't* - before pressing a kiss on Catra's lips, close mouthed and sweet. Catra sighs and lets herself be dragged with Adora's tide, nuzzling in the hand that has come to cradle her cheek during the kiss, infinitely tender and a hundred more times gentler.

Adora opens her eyes just a slit, silver shimmering as she looks swiftly at Catra's pink face, carefully studying her before daring to open her mouth the tiniest of fractions. The tip of Adora's tongue peeks out, wet and cold and pink too, licking a deliciously slow spot over Catra's bottom lip before retreating again, unsure for a second.

Catra shivers and gasps, her arms tightening on their hold around Adora's neck as she pulls from Adora soft hair, closer to her body until they are pressed firmly against the other. Catra's breath is sweet and it trembles a little as she opens her lips too, welcoming the sweetness of Adora's damp kiss inside her mouth again. It's still careful, still slow, learning each other and this new side of them hand in hand. Absolutely tender and completely patient.

They kiss each other, arms around the other, wet and slow, tongue against fangs and against tongue, and against lips. Long and free until they can't breathe. And when they can't breathe, Adora presses her mouth over Catra's face and runs her lips across her nose and cheeks and chin, worshiping her as much as she can without leaning away from their embrace. Kissing as if it was confession and solace and shelter, because it is

They rise from bed together and walk the precarious steps of the stairs hand in hand, in silence. They know what their silence means, they have never been uncomfortable inside of it. It has meant many things through their story, patience and acceptance and desire and decorum and understandment and wait. For now they know it means peace, quiet reassurance before speaking because they know there are things they need to talk about, that they need to settle before they can keep going.

Adora makes warm oatmeal for both of them - a gift from Bow's groceries - and both wrinkle their noses all the way, but they eat it whole. Catra rests her head over Adora's shoulder and Adora nuzzles on the short strands of her hair, locking tightly together the hands that are not holding spoons, hearing the rain falling outside.

Adora helps Catra fix her hair, cutting errand and uneven strands until it curls softly around her face, softer and young and kind. Catra braids Adora's hair, long honey strands held gently behind her head and down her back, brushing her waist when she moves. It feels lighter, for both. The best they can do with what has been given to them.

They light up the fireplace and Melog strolls down the room and into the comfiest couch, meowing happily against Adora's hand when she leans down to pet their little ears. She has missed them dearly and Melog has missed her back, if the way they nuzzle against her neck has anything to say about it.

Adora turns around, looking behind her. Catra is already sitting on the carpet, closer to the corridor than to the couch, comfortable on having an open exit at hand. She has her legs against her chest, hugging herself as she rests her chin over her bent knees. She looks younger like this, softer in all edges, staring at Adora´s face patiently.

Adora makes her way in front of her, sitting with her legs at either side of Catra´s waist, facing her completely. Catra relaxes around her, scooting closer to Adora´s lap, still staring at her from below her long eyelashes. The scar over the bridge of her nose is now completely healed, shimmering in delicate lilacs and purples between her freckles, there where Adora´s skin had healed her.

Catra must catch the intense expression in Adora´s eyes because she chuckles under her breath, smirking as she presses the pad of her index on the middle of Adora´s forehead.

“What are you thinking about, dummy?” Catra asks, her fangs flashing when she smiles. Adora crosses her eyes, reaching her hand up to grab Catra´s extended arm between hers. She huffs a little at Catra´s nickname but smiles back, tiny, playing with Catra´s elegant fingers.

“Can you tell me about it?” Adora whispers in return, drawing invisible circles over Catra´s palm, still not meeting her eyes.

Catra inhales, deeply, bracing herself softly for what is to come. She feels completely vulnerable right now, but she also feels open and less in pain than the days before. And the weeks before that.

“What part?” Catra answers gently, looking at the side of Adora´s face, right where the silver scar crosses her eyebrow and cheekbone.

“When did you know that he- that *Prime* had my skin?” It is still so strange to hear her talk, really talk, after so many months of sweet songs and sweet hands. Catra kind of misses her signs, misses the comfort of it, and yet Adora´s human voice feels so- natural. As if Catra had heard it for years and years before this life. It´s a voice she knows better than anything.

“I- I supposed he, the hunters, that they had it a few weeks after you arrived, when we were still looking for it on the shore. I saw one of them, the one with the blue hair. He was holding something in his hands that night. I didn't know what it was at that moment but then I understood,” Catra starts, fighting the urge to look away in shame. “I never knew for sure until much later but I asked Mermista to keep an eye on them, just in case. The rich fucker is not that hard to miss around the ports.”

Adora remains silent, listening intently. The golden of her hair lightened during her time away, and it almost looks like sunlight now, errand strands falling around her face softly.

“I thought- I thought maybe they had sold your skin or- or that they had kept it as a trophy and were done with it. It was stupid of me but so much time passed I really started to believe they weren't going to come back.” Catra´s voice is trembling but she holds herself, trying to convey all the sincerity and truthfulness she can in her words. She licks her lips, feeling herself paling as she keeps going. "And it made me so mad but- but I was also so fucking relieved and so fucking sick of myself because this was your skin in the line but I just wanted them far away."

Catra's voice breaks for a moment but Adora waits, without speaking, not even breathing.

“The morning of Angella and Micah´s party I- crashed against him, against Prime. Literally. Micah was trying to shush him away but Prime saw me. I recognized the logo on his tie and I *knew* .” Adora closes Catra´s fingers gently, leaning until her forehead is resting against Catra ´s knuckles. Adora closes her eyes and nods, a small sign to keep going.”He knew who I was, too. He recognized me.”

“How?” Adora´s voice is haunted.

“The cliff has my last name,´Dora.” Catra smiles without mirth, brushing tears from her eyes swiftly. “I don't know why he was away for so long, but he must have been doing some research. I´m the only one living here, after all. The house and the land are in my name.” Catra gulps around the lump on her throat, wrinkling her nose. “He *threatened* me, Adora. Micah accidentally told him about my- my wife, and Prime must have guessed. He is a smart asshole, he knew what he had come looking for. He knew that you didn't have your skin and that you were stuck on this form and he knew I helped you. His idiots must have told him. It wasn´t hard for him to guess and I-I should have get you out of here so much sooner-”

Catra is spiraling again. Adora notices immediately because she starts brushing kisses over the back of her hand, around the heel and all the way to the inner face of Catra´s wrist, lips brushing on the fragile skin there. Catra inhales and exhales several times, calming herself.

“Mermista got me out of there and I convinced her to help me burn Prime´s boats while I broke into the yacht,” saying it outloud, Catra realizes just how completely insane it sounds. She really wasn´t thinking back then. “I panicked. I just wanted him to go away and I thought that if I managed to destroy his toys I could buy us some time. And it- it kind of worked. I burned everything, even, um, his face.”

Catra can feel Adora tensing around her and she flushes, tangling their fingers together.

“Did they hurt you?” Adora´s voice is muffled but firm. Catra squirms in her place, chewing the inner side of her cheek nervously. “Catra-”

“One of them, some big bad gorilla idiot. He- um, he slammed me against a wall but I managed to take him out. That 's all.” Catra grumbles, a little bit defensive. She is not made of glass and she is not some damsel in distress, she can manage pretty well on her own. Adora snaps her eyes towards hers, liquid silver burying in her soul, burning like white fires, and suddenly all of Catra´s defense mechanisms dissolve into nothing.

Adora stretches her other arm, brushing the tip of her finger below Catra´s jaw, very gentle.“You had a bruise on your chin, that night”

Catra´s shoulders fall forward, all the fight leaving her completely. She can't get defensive with Adora about this, she doesn't have the heart. Not after what Adora had seen, not after saving Catra from bleeding out in the sea. She understands why Adora looks like she is about to cry. “I tripped and fell in the port. They didn't touch me”

It doesn't help the miserable expression on Adora´s face but she sniffles and tears don´t fall. Catra´s heartbeat is suddenly picking up, though, memories of that night haunting her like ghosts.

“He had your skin in a fucking glass box, Adora. He had a room full of- of siren´s shit and in the middle he had your skin hanging like a fucking trophy, And there was a coffin too. For you. It was filled with sea water and it was just laying there, waiting. I- I was furious. I just wanted to kill him, I wanted him to *hurt* , no matter the consequences."

Adora holds her stare, hard, breathing very slowly through her nose. Her eyes are aflame but the factions of her face say nothing to Catra, just raw, unfiltered nothing, like a storm about to crash against land. It makes Catra nervous.

“Why didn't you tell me anything?” Adora finally asks. Her voice is low, grave as a tumb. It sends cold shivers down Catra's back.

“I- “

"We could have figured out something together. Why didn't you trust me with this?" Adora's breath is starting to speed up but her expression remains blank as she leans away from Catra. It's just a few inches but Catra misses her immediately, the distance hitting her in the chest like a war hammer.

"You said it yourself." Adora's tone is straining at the edges, harsh and cutting, a cold sweat covering her forehead and the skin of her shoulders. Catra's body seizes immediately, locking into tension again. "This was about my skin, about me. I wasn't useless, I could have helped you. I could have protected you."

Catra fights against every fiber of her body and mind screaming at her, words and phrases she hasn't heard inside her mind in months - *words of that woman's voice* - telling her how little she means, reminding her how weak she is, beating her down, making her rageful and resentful and scared. She blinks back the black mist in her eyes, trying to focus on the now, in Adora, so tense in front of her she looks like an archer's bow about to snap.

Catra breathes deeply through her nose and mouth, chewing down acid boiling in the back of her tongue, trying to keep her voice under control.

“You are so- so good, Adora. You are so fucking good and so terribly kind and I knew you were going to do something so absolutely fucking stupid like going after them to keep me out of their reach. And you were going to get yourself hurt because of me. I knew you were going to sacrifice yourself.”

“So you sacrificed yourself instead?” Adora snaps, and to Catra´s surprise, she doesn't only sound upset. She sounds completely on edge, tethering on the edge of something sharp and cutting like a sword, poisonous as a deadly flower, venomous as a viper. Frightening.

Catra throws her shoulders back, straightening up in her place. She returns Adora's eyes with her own, unbending.

“I'm not worth your life”

“ **Catra** *,”* Adora sounds *angry.*

Good. Catra is angry too. Let them be angry.

Catra snaps her hand away, still cradled in Adora's lap, and stands up from the floor, a tad too quickly because it makes her head spin dangerously for a second. Adora follows her up as a second nature, hovering her hands around Catra's body, guarding her from a fall. Catra steps back, shaking her head firmly, her hands into fists at her sides.

“What would you have done then? Um? If you knew he was threatening me, that he was hunting me, what would you have done?” the words fall down her mouth like acid rain, quiet and angry. She can't help them, they echo around the walls.

Adora flinches, clenching her jaw tightly. Her nostrils are flaring from how hard she is breathing, every single nerve on her body screaming and overwhelmed. "You know- "

"No," Catra cuts her off immediately, choking around the knot on her throat. "You didn't hear what he said about you, what he planned for you. You didn't see that place or his face! I did!"

“Because you didn't give me a choice!" Adora finally blows up, yelling between her teeth, voice and song overlapping over each other, cracking completely. She doesn't want to scream, not to Catra, never to Catra, but she can't hold it back anymore, frustration and rage and pain overflowing from her tongue and chest and heart, burning cold and painful . "You didn't even let me try!”

"I was trying to save you!" Catra shouts back, tears gathering in the corners of her eyes. Her head is pounding in the temples and her side flares with the sudden outburst but she pushes forwards, anger also spilling from her body. “They would have killed me anyway! You didn't had your skin back then and Prime would have- he would- he would have taken you and locked you away for him, he would have- fuck- be would-" Catra stumbles with her words, drowning in the thoughts, on the images of what Prime wanted to do with Adora, what he *would* have done. She can't bear to even say it out loud. "Or he would have killed you altogether. I couldn't let him do that. I *love* you, don't you get it? I couldn't let him get near you!”

“I would've rather died with you!" Adora screams, shaking the entire house to its foundations, echoing loud as a bell in her song. She marches towards Catra, wrapping her long hands around her upper arms, softly but firm enough so Catra doesn't look away from her eyes. Adora's hair is in disarray but her eyes are settled, speaking every single of her words with passionate conviction. "A thousand times! I would have rather let them rip me apart than seeing you suffer, than leaving you alone!"

Catra closes her mouth so fast she bites her tongue by accident. They are closer to the corridor now, where the light is a little bit dimmer and the steady sound of rain is louder. Catra looks around them with the corner of her eyes, biting back the dreadful sense of deja vu. They were here too when Adora left. Adora was hurting too, Catra was hurting also.

"It was my choice," Catra mutters, softening her tone just a little, but Adora is already far gone.

"You almost died, Catra!" Adora chokes on air, grasping at her chest with her hands before pointing around them, to the walls and the closed windows and the ground. Adora looks at Catra with such terribly sad eyes Catra skips a breath, feeling Adora's pain as her own. "You almost died in my hands. You bled all over this floor."

"I know," is all Catra can whisper, flinching.

"Do you think that would've saved me?" Adora is not yelling anymore, her voice pleading, drowned in grief, shattered completely as she looks at Catra like she is the entire sun. "Did you really think I cared about my skin more than I care about you? That I loved it more than I love you?"

Adora feels completely desperate but she needs to say this, she needs for Catra to listen to it, from her mouth. Her skin is still hanging from Catra's shoulders, falling down her back like starlight. She is so beautiful, Adora is so in love with her and she needs to say this.

"I wouldn't have stayed because I'm *good* or *kind* , I would have done it because I *love you* , Catra. I came back because I love you more than anything."

"But-"

"Catra, you are not a monster." Adora blurts and the words hurt as much as the horrible moment she said them. Adora can see the way they rip through Catra's heart like a knife and she knows they are causing her so much pain still, crawling over her like earth to a grave. "I'm so sorry, I should have never said that and I'm so sorry. You are good. You are so fundamentally good."

Catra is shivering from head to toe, Adora can see it in the tremble of her shoulders and the light shimmer of her beautiful eyes with tears and Adora wants nothing more but to surge forward and wrap her inside her arms and never let her go again. But she can't, not right now with so much poison pouring out of herself. Adora is not going to touch her until it is all out.

"I promised you I would stay, that I wouldn't run and that's exactly what I did. I- I *promised* it and I broke those promises and you almost died because of it." Adora's voice breaks in the last words, shattering like the windows of their house. "You asked me not to hate you, but I could never, Catra, you're my entire heart. I'm angry at myself, I hate myself" Adora's bottom lip quivers dangerously, the first sign of incoming tears. “It's my fault”

"No- Adora-"

“Catra, it's my fault, don't you see? I- fuck. Fuck!” Adora curses loudly when her voice cracks again, digging her nails against her palms when she closes her hands into fists. They cut small wounds where her claws get out of control, ichor pooling between her fingers. “I left you and you almost died. For me. I promised you I was going to stay and I left”

"Adora"

"I abandoned you and you suffered so much and they hurt you" Adora looks towards the window but the stained glass is not there anymore. It lays in pieces on the porch outside.

"They hurt our home, they hurt *you.* If I hadn't- you would be dead, Catra, I would have come home and I would've found you dead. I can't- Catra, I can't live without you-"

Adora finally loses the grip of her legs, lowering back into the ground until she is sitting on the floor, her back against the corridor's wall. The house falls into a suspended silence, only broken by the cracking of the fire and the rain outside.

It doesn't last much, barely a few seconds. Adora covers her face with her hands and feels cold tears falling down her face, from sadness, from anger. They are not the same as yesterday but they are heavy too, aching in her soul. Catra's steps are muted when she walks the small space that keeps them apart.

“Adora” Catra says and her voice is terrible, broken like glass and trembling. “None of us got a say in what they did to us. That’s- it wasn’t our fault.” She takes a breath, gulps, holding onto herself like, if she lets go, she might break too. “It’s not *our* fault. *Don't* carry with that”

She says every word punctuating all that she means to say, honest and caring, firm in every sentence. Adora is still not looking at her.

"Adora, my decisions are my own and nobody else's and it was up to me to carry with the consequences. I knew that and I accepted it. But I never wanted you to suffer this much for it." Catra nibbles on her bottom lip, letting her own tears fall silently down her face. "I failed you too"

"No-"

"Yes, I did"

Catra kneels into the ground, next to Adora, cradling her face firmly between her hands. Adora's hands fall limp into her lap and she looks at Catra with completely vulnerable eyes, eyelashes coated in crystal drops. Catra's gentle hold grows firmer.

" *Nobody* has rights over your skin or your body. Not Prime, not his men, not me. Nobody." Catra holds her breath, the corner of her eyes narrowing in sorrow and regret. "You are right, Adora. I should have given you your skin the moment I found it, I should have spoken to you about this."

"Catra-"

"I should have, and I'm sorry for that," Catra shakes her head, holding Adora's stare. She needs to settle this, she needs for Adora to know she understands and how sorry she is. "I hid things from you, I betrayed your trust and you are in pain for it and I'm sorry." Catra tilts her head sadly, smiling without mirth, just sad and tired. "Let me ask for your forgiveness too."

Adora exhales, Catra's words settling inside her heart and mind. She raises her hand and places it over Catra's, keeping her close, nuzzling on the touch of her palm

"I knew you were lying to me, when- when I found my skin. You looked so sad-" Adora's frown twitches with anguish. "I knew but I let my fear control me. I- I didn´t know what else

to think-"

"I didn't give you another choice, Adora," Catra's cheeks are pink with the emotions, little rose blooms damp with tears. “You asked me to explain it to you and I pushed you away. I used your fear to push you away on purpose, to hurt you, I shouldn't have." Catra's chest deflates, her hands trembling. "I was afraid too, I thought I could protect you. I thought it was the only way. I- I don't know if I was wrong yet. I don't know if I would do it any other way, Adora. But I am so sorry it hurted you like this. I'm sorry you had to watch it happen. You didn't deserve that."

"Neither did you," Adora says immediately, tangling their fingers together, still held against her cheeks. "I left you"

"You did." And the way Catra says it, it's like it hurts her deeply but also like she *knows* . "But you came back"

Adora sobs at the words and so does Catra, weeping around the other like brides come back from war, condemned to tragedy and that still, somehow, have managed to survive.

"Thank you for saving my life, Adora," Catra's shoulders fall forward with the memory of that night. Screaming wind and violent waves and blood all around her. Cruel and painful, full of desperation, full of an intimate call Catra heard before falling into nothing. Shortness of breath and water in her lungs and salt in her ears. The strand of moon when she thought that this was it, violent ends to violent life and then warmth between the coldness and sharp scales and soft lips soaked in blood. A nightmare, a true nightmare. It's going to take them a long time to heal from it completely. "I- it was really fucked up, wasn´t it?"

“My love-”

“I was really afraid and it *hurted,* Adora”

“I know, sweetheart," Adora wraps her arms tightly around Catra's shoulders, cradling her against her chest. “I should have come sooner," she whispers, pressing a kiss on Catra's temple.

"You came when I needed you most. And I- thank you," Catra wrinkles the fabric of Adora's shirt around her fingers, holding her close. "Thank you for not giving up on me."

"Never," Adora says, so quickly it comes as a gasp. "Catra, I'm not leaving you. Please know that, I´m not leaving you again."

"I know- I know it now." Catra closes her eyes, nuzzling into Adora's collarbones. She smells nice, she smells like them again. "I understand now"

It's going to take them a long time to heal, yes, but they are starting here.

They don't spend long on the floor. It's cold and uncomfortable so they pull each other back onto their feet, still not letting go. Adora runs her hands below Catra's shirt, caressing Catra's

spine with her knuckles again and again. Catra trembles, thumbing the hem of Adora's turtle neck. A new thought crosses her mind,making her frown deeply.

"Adora-" she pauses, wetting her dry lips. "They are going to come back. You know that, right? Prime is obsessed with you. He is not going to stop until he has you or until he kills us both for good"

"Yes, I know." Adora rests her chin over Catra's head, looking at a blank spot on the wall. Her nerves are still completely on point, another kind of fire starting to wash over her. "But I am here with you and I'm not going to let him touch you, *us* , again. We are together now." The fire is rising, out of control inside of her, white and electric as thunder. "This is our home. I'm tired of running away, I'm tired of letting him win. I'm so tired of being afraid of them." The fire reaches her throat and she hisses, so low that if Catra's ear wasn't pressed against her plexus she probably wouldn't have heard it at all. "I can kill him, I *am* going to kill him."

It's a statement, true and undoubtedly honest. It's not even a threat, it's a promise.

Catra gulps, pressing her palm flat over the point where Adora's heartbeat is stronger, bearing fast as a hummingbird. "He's dangerous, like, really fucking dangerous"

"I am more," Adora growls. "I love you more than anything, more than fear itself and unless you ask me to, I'm not leaving you." Her hold around Catra's arms tightens, the points of her sharp nails digging a little bit in her skin where they get out of control. "I failed you once, I will not do it again"

Catra exhales sharply through her mouth, feeling the weight of Adora's confession falling over her shoulders like a world to Atlas.

"Fuck," Catra dips her nose on Adora's pulse point, brushing her lips and teeth tenderly there. "Why are you so fucking frustrating?" She thinks Adora might chuckle, even scoff, but instead Adora tenses up completely again, overflowing. " 'dora? Ah!"

Adora gets a hold of Catra's waist and spins her around, backing up immediately until she presses Catra's back flat against the wall, all blue wallpaper and pictures hanging from their frames. Catra inhales sharply and bares her teeth in annoyance, craning her neck to look at Adora's face.

"Adora, what the fuc- ?" Catra's questioning dies cold in her throat when her eyes meet Adora's, all coherent thoughts abandoning her at the same time.

Adora is faced towards her, her forearms resting over the wall at either side of Catra's face, holding her weight completely as she leans into Catra's space, their noses brushing together. And she is looking at Catra *prettily* - Catra has no other way to describe it - all red cheeks cradled in scales and shimmering eyes looking at her disheveled ass from below pale white eyelashes. Her breathing is fast, almost a panting, and there is a light sweat in her forehead, hot instead of cold at the touch, gathering in the roots of her hair where the braid has given up and let all the loose strands bounce over her face.

Adora is full of some kind of hunger Catra can't understand yet but that she seems to be the only one being able to satiate it. Hunger for vengeance, hunger for love. For Catra.

She still leans towards Catra with complete gentleness, carefully of not putting too much pressure on her side as to hurt her or to scare her. But she is a wasp out of control too, too beautiful to be touched, too lethal to be denied.

"Catra" Adora says, against her mouth, lips barely touching "Tell me you don't want me"

"What?" Catra croaks out, too dizzy to say anything coherent at all.

"Tell me. Look at me and tell me that you don't want me, tell me that you don't love me, tell me that you *want* me to go. Not like last time. Tell me, because only like that I will leave you, only like that will I agree to turn back and even then I will watch over you where you don't see me, every single day and every single night until we both rot or the world rot around us" Adora drags her mouth across Catra's cheek until it is right next to her ear, hot breath against shivering skin. "Tell me "

Catra feels like she can't breathe for a very different reason than water in her chest. "I can't do that," she gasps, closing her eyes against her will. "I can't. I'm too selfish."

"Be selfish" Three weeks. Adora has spent three weeks away from Catra and she already feels like there is not enough room in her heart for the length of her love and her desire and her want. How would a year have felt? How would a lifetime? Punishment, condemnation. Hell. "Catra, do you not understand? I want you, I only ever want you"

"Adora"

"There is no ocean, no land where you can cast me far away enough to make me stop thinking of you, make me stop feeling you in me" Adora rests the palms of her hands against Catra's, raising their hands together, skin against skin "I feel you, can't you see? I feel you in the marrow of my bones, I feel you in every inch of my skin, I feel you like I feel water in my veins. Whenever I look inside of me there you are." Adora's lips brush Catra's lilac eyelids, cooing them back open with their touch. "If you ask me to tear myself away from you, you are asking me to tear myself apart. There is no me without you, I don't want to be something of me if you are not there."

Catra is hyperventilating, Adora can feel it in the breath that hits her open lips but she doesn't stop, doesn't lower down. Her touch on Catra is loose enough that, if she wanted, she could walk away. Except that she doesn't, Catra stays and doesn't move at all, staring at Adora's face from below hooded eyes.

"I must have done something terrible in my last life for whatever that created me to make me exist for so long without you. I must have been cursed to wander without you and yet they still blessed me because I was made for you, all of me. My hands, my mouth, my eyes, they were made to worship you and care for you. They were made to destroy to defend you, Catra."

"Ah.” Catra is fighting to keep up, mind clouded. She has spent so long in darkness that stepping into Adora’s love again feels like falling into the sun after a long night. “I- I'm not- "

"What? Enough?" Adora drags every single one of her words, thumbing Catra’s bottom lip, softly freeing it from her front teeth. "I could kill you right now for saying those words. I could bend you with my thumb, it would be so easy." Adora dips her face into the crook of Catra’s neck, speaking against her skin. "You are so fragile, you are so strong Catra but you are also so delicate, like a pearl's shell on my hands. I could hold you hard enough and turn you into sand. It 's maddening, you are maddening, this trust you have granted me over you.”

Catra is beyond words now, arching her back from the wall, her fingers tangling on Adora’s long hair. She feels terribly selfish but she needs this right now, this fuel, this fire, this reassurance. Adora must be able to read her completely because she gives it completely. She brushes Catra’s short bangs from her forehead, perpetually mindful of now healed scars and tender bruises, this time speaking all her words across her cheekbones.

“You've consumed me completely. I am a predator, a murderer, Catra The monster in the human's tale and I’ve been brought to my knees by such a gentle creature, by you. I am undone without you. And you still dared to think you weren’t important? That you weren’t enough?" Adora blows the phantom of a kiss above the bridge of Catra’s nose, below scar and freckled skin. "I told you not to think for me, to not take that control from me. I told you to let me make the decisions about my heart"

Catra can’t resist, she is too weak, too selfish, too in love. What is love but drinking from fire after all? Adora’s inferno has spread all over their home, setting Catra aflame once again, a phoenix rising from ashes never meant to die.

She curls her hand over Adora's chest, cold skin against warm. "It is your heart I'm trying to protect, Adora."

"What do I have to do so you see that you are my heart?" Adora cradles Catra’s head between her hands, sliding between her hair like strokes of ink against paper. "If I am to have you, to love you, I will do so completely, Catra, with all the parts you think are dark or unlovable or unworthy. With all the parts that make you, you. I need *you.* "

Catra is shivering completely, held between the wall and Adora’s ethereal body, surrounded by her smell, her skin, the shimmer of her eyes, the touch of her arms around her body. She is all Catra can think about, her entire reason for living, she would destroy herself and the world for her, she who never thought she would need someone this much. And Adora would live for her, *live,* she who was so lost in an endless life, would live for her. In a world where they would choose each other every single time, no matter what.

Love makes us more human than heartbreak.

"Goddess,” Catra hiccups, unable to place all of these feelings into words, into songs.

"Don't call them now, they do not have a place between us," Adora drags her just slightly sharp teeth over Catra’s chin, nibbling on the delicate skin there, voice overcome by fervor. "I

don't need to speak the gods' name when I have you in my arms"

Adora leans her mouth against Catra's, opening her lips alongside hers, cooing her mouth open with her warm breath. Catra exhales around Adora's tongue, allowing herself to sink into the embrace, melting all around her hands.

Adora kisses her like the sea kisses the sand, powerful and strong and sure of itself, devastatingly beautiful and a hundred times more disarming. It spreads warmth across Catra's veins and makes blue fire to light on her belly and the length of her legs. Her skin is feverish for a whole other reason than sickness.

Adora runs her nails down Catra's ribs, wrapping her narrow waist inside her arms, flushing them both together. Their hips meet together like pieces of a puzzle and Catra can't help the moan that hitches off her breath, almost silent, sweet across the roof of Adora's mouth, sending shivers down both of their spines.

They part away slowly, gravitating towards each other's mouths again and again, stars circling each other, lips wet and heartbeats hammering inside their chests, following the other's rhythm like drums. Catra doesn't want to let go, too drunk in Adora's heat, but Adora nuzzles her gently with her cheek, breathing cool air on her ear until they are looking at each other again.

Their cheeks are flushed, marching reds, and if they are not careful enough they are going to fall into fire again. But Adora still has one last thing she wants to say, for now.

"I'm sorry for leaving you, I'm so sorry for running away. I'm so sorry for leaving you behind. It killed me, I swear" Adora takes Catra's hand in hers, bringing it up so she can kiss the palm with shivering lips. "I will never forsake you again"

"Neither of us," Catra leans until she places a kiss over Adora's forehead, right where her silk hair meets golden scales, the drag of lips over tender flesh. "This is about us, Adora, you and me. I swear it too"

Adora smiles around her hold, nodding against Catra's wrist. "I'll hold you to it."

Catra rests the pads of her fingers over Adora's chin, pressing the red in her lips from the kisses and the words and the embrace, marveling in the way they seem to bend around her touch like rose petals around dew. Adora looks at her with eyes full of moonlight, speaking so soft it sounds like her song. Maybe it is, Catra can't tell them apart anymore.

“I´m sorry,” and it's full of all of Adora's remorse and devoted love.

"I forgive you, Adora." Catra's voice is raspy, overflowing. “I'm sorry too, for everything” and so, it is cradled in her love too.

"I forgive you too, Catra"

It's not perfect and it's going to take them a lot still, but that is alright. They trust each other and they are together.

"I am yours," Adora sings, nestling her words around Catra's lips. "I am yours, Catrina, to do our undo as you please." She looks at her through her eyelashes, beauty cradled in lovely pain. "Tell me to walk away"

"I can't "

"Tell me to leave "

"Stay"

"Tell me to stop"

"Don't" Catra brushes the edge of her teeth above Adora's ear. "Please"

"I'm here" Adora leans her forehead against Catra's, holding her tight. "With you"

Eros comes back for Psyche.

Hector reunites with Andromache on the Elysium.

Orpheus lives and dies and embraces Eurydice again.

Achilles finds Patroclus in the dark.

Love prevails.

♡

On the dawn of the six day, they make love

Their room is warmer now even though the rain keeps pouring outside, window tightly shut by wood curtains.

Catra's hair is damp after a shower, dripping lightly over her shoulders. Adora helped her wash it and rinse, gentle fingers, patient every time Catra tensed up at the touch of the water. She can't handle the spray hitting her on the face or her ears, clouding her mind and blurring her hearing and vision. Not right now, it's still too much, it's still too violent. So Adora helps her.

It's very, very early, barely even morning, but there is no sleep on their bodies, not right now. They are awake for another reason completely different, overpowering the need of anything else.

The mirror next to the bed it's still there but Catra covered it with a sheet on the long days before this, so there is nothing around them but the soft bed and the warmth of the room.

They stand next to the bed, quiet in perfect harmony, just looking at each other in silence until any of them dare to move first. Adora is completely naked, chest moving with every breath, her hair falling long and free below her ribs and down the low of her back. Catra is

wearing Adora's skin and nothing but the skin, falling over her shoulders and across her chest and legs like a saint's veil, cradling her in golden and turquoise and opal.

This is not new for them, bare bodies, long legs, the secret triangle that lives between them. They know each other completely, from the most superfluous to the most intimate way. In a way, it's just like stepping back home.

Adora exhales and steps in, eyes heavily sweet. She wraps her fingers around the edges of her own skin, pushing them aside just enough so she can finally touch Catra again, wrapping her hands at either side of her waist. The iridescent opals of the skin shimmer as marble against the dark of her skin. Adora holds her breath and barely manages to stop herself from surging forward, digging her fingertips over the curve of Catra´s hips.

Catra´s breath stops inside her lungs, filling her with dizziness. All of this feels so preciously fragile right now, a bubble frozen during winter, painting snowflakes over it´s surface, an empty space behind the fire of the raging sun, ice over a thunderstorm ocean.

Adora runs her fingers over the healed scars over her ribs, gentle as ever, and then down following the errand paths of pink skin and multicolored scales until the very end. It is so completely incredible, so terribly ironic, how these paths almost bled Catra to death just a few days ago, how they can be so beautiful when they almost tore her apart. But this is Catra, so maybe that is why they are so precious, carrying the pain like one would carry a queen's honor, tears like jewels over her skin.

“Are you in pain?” Adora asks, and she doesn't only mean from the wounds.

Catra smiles, tiny, taking Adora´s hand between her fingers before nuzzling her cheek into her cold palm. “Not anymore”

Adora returns the smile, just as small and sincere, and lowers herself into the ground until she is kneeling in front of Catra, her hands at the sides of her waist. Adora looks up, towards her precious flushed face, eyes hooded below her light eyelashes. Adora´s eyes are so blue right now they look like oceans on their own and her legs and ribs and arms are coated in beautiful scales that twinkle when she kneels, showing her as she is, bare and completely exposed to Catra's eyes.

"Tell me what to do for you" Adora whispers, leaning to press a fluttering kiss over the skin of Catra's exposed belly, across the curve of her ribs, next to her belly button, close to her navel. "Tell me how to touch you"

Catra sucks her breath under the touch, shivering. She is aware her legs are trembling. Adora's claws are there, picking just a little on the skin of her hips, deliciously sweet. It steals the air off Catra´s lungs, the fact that this otherworldly creature, capable of bending men's free will with the pad of her finger and crush flesh and bone under her red lips like mere paper is kneeling in front of her, completely vulnerable under Catra´s hands, open and soft.

Catra lowers her hand, grabbing Adora's sharp chin between her fingers, tilting her head up so she can see her eyes.

"Kiss me," Catra whispers, low and hungry.

***

Adora smiles and presses a kiss in the space between Catra's tight and the soft hair that lives there, peppering the skin with tender caresses before diving where the smell of salt and heat is stronger, guided in by desire alone. Adora loves kissing Catra, in every way and place possible. She loves kissing the corner of her mouth and lips, she loves kissing the hidden pearl and the entrance of her slit, lips against lips and the tip of her tongue against release.

Adora rests her palms across Catra´s waist and the low of her abdomen and pulls her close, opening her eyes to look at Catra´s, hovering above her like an angel's halo. She is already looking back, sea glass eyes clouded with the warm mist of tears, brought back by desire alone. Her mouth is slightly open with silent moans, hips hitching with each wet stroke of Adora´s mouth. One of her hands is tangled on the crown of Adora´s head, gripping soft strands of light hair. The other is cradled against her own chest, holding herself to Adora´s skin like a muse to a golden fleece.

They look at each other and Adora kisses her until she feels rivers dripping from her lips and into her tongue, all the way down her chin, dripping over her bare chest as rain. Catra convulses against a shiver and releases Adora´s hair from her grip, bending on herself just so she can cradle Adora´s face between her palms, pulling from her insistently back up. Adora releases her mouth with a wet gasp, licking her lips at the thin ribbon of clear release still connecting them together, red mouth to pulsing heat.

Catra pulls from her face again, much more insistent than before, digging her front teeth over her bottom lip, passion coloring her cheeks in rose blooms. Adora follows her quiet petition slowly, taking her time to place open mouthed kisses over Catra´s abdomen, the narrow of her waist – *her scars, each single one of them* – the curve of her breasts and the raised brown of her nipples, all the way to her neck, covered in warm sweat, an back to Catra´s open lips. Catra kisses Adora open mouthed, groaning at the taste of herself around Adora´s lips, bringing her back to her feet.

****

Catra licks a soft line on Adora´s bottom lip, crossing her front teeth and towards her upper lip, drinking her in completely before leaning back, safe inside Adora´s arms around her back. Catra grips the soft skin still hanging from her shoulders and pulls from it softly, letting it fall over their heads like a bride's veil, covering from the darkness inside their room. The candle light still slips inside their little nest, letting Adora see Catra's factions fully.

Catra raises her hands, brushing the top of her fingertips over Adora's flushed face, across her forehead and down her cheeks, pressing her thumb over Adora's slightly open lips.

"Let me see you," Catra murmurs inside their little holy space. Adora places a kiss over Catra's thumb, cradling her palm against her cheek and, spirits above, Adora missed her so much.

"You are seeing me, my love," Adora whispers. Catra's cheeks and ears paint in precious pink but she shakes her head stubbornly. The short strands of her hair curl around her temples like waves. It makes her look so young and so beautiful, but the sight, soft as silk and barely touching her nape and the curve of her cheekbones, still makes Adora want to sob.

"That's not what I mean"

Oh

Adora squirms a little around Catra’s touch, eyebrows twitching."I don't want to scare you,"

"You won't." Catra waits for a second, studying Adora's tense face and shoulders before whispering again. "Nothing about you could ever scare me, Adora"

Adora's ears feel suddenly red with shame. She grips her own upper arm, looking at the floor. Catra doesn't let go of her face. "I'm- not pretty. Like that"

Catra makes a disgruntling noise in obvious disagreement, elegant eyebrows skyrocketing in her forehead. Adora rubs her thumb over the wrinkles that dip on her frown, exhaling when Catra whispers, "You are lovely." When Adora doesn't answer Catra searches back for her eyes, holding them in hers firmly. "Adora, I don't want you to pretend to be something you are not just because of my sake. You are not dangerous or ugly or scary, not to me."

Adora returns her gaze, cheeks flushing pink, but she still hesitates, breathing slowly against Catra's palm. The last thing Catra wants to do is push her to do something she doesn't want, but she knows Adora is hesitating for a whole different reason than want. Catra *knows* her. So she leans her forehead against Adora's cheeks and murmurs softly in the skin there.

"Please"

Adora relaxes all around Catra, exhaling as she nods, finally giving in. She knows Catra means no harm and that she will not push if Adora doesn't really want it, and there is nobody else Adora would show this part of herself but to Catra. Adora steps back, just enough that she can face her fully, pulling from her skin off its place above their heads and letting it fall gently against her shoulders. It melts all around her like water, sticking to her limbs slowly and completely, a second skin, a first shelter, a pearl´s shell.

Adora's face shifts like moon cycles. Her ears elongate, from round and pale cartilage to soft membrane that curls behind her head as wings of a dragonfly, across her head like a crown and down until it brushes the angle of her jaw fluttering a little when the warm air touches them. She can feel the way her mouth stretches, slits covered in fine membranes appearing from the corner of her mouth to her temples. Like this Adora could unhinge her entire jaw if she wanted, a mouth made to hunt big prey, to rip tissue and bone and muscle all the same. But Adora keeps it shut, so close to Catra's delicate fingers she doesn't even dare to breathe. A sword against a rose petal.

Her entire body shudders, tremors running down every single of her limbs as her skin opens and sprouts, scales as tiny flowers and gems covering her completely. Opals in her arms and elbows, golden coins in her wrists and waist, sea glasses down the curve of her thighs and

breasts, iridescent under the dim light and as soft as a tapestry hung on a church´s shrine. Lethal for everyone except for the one they are meant to be shown to.

Fins and gills cradle her neck and ribs, fluttering curiously at the lack of water around them, making her lungs tickle for a moment. It's alright, Adora does not need them to breathe right now. She thinks she might not even need the oxygen at all. Her legs remain there, long and covered in sapphire and plumb and merigold. She doesn't call for her tail nor needs it, she wants to remain here, with Catra in her arms looking at Adora like the sand looks at the stars. This is who Adora is, free, *free,* with her skin on its rightful place and her beauty and her danger. She is trusting Catra, with this part of herself she has been kept from for so long, even after everything and after all the horror and all the pain, Adora is trusting Catra. This is who Adora truly, really is and Catra has never been more in love with her but that in this second.

"You are different," Catra says under her breath, marveled, soft, in love, cheeks flushed completely. Her eyes are open in awe, shimmering as runs her fingers down the silk length of Adora´s hair, silver as starlight.

"How so?" Adora asks, running her knuckles down Catra´s belly, curling her claws to the inside of her palm to keep them away from her shivering skin as much as she can, fingers tinted in black ink. She can feel the weight of Catra´s precious face in hers and Adora never thought anybody would look at her like this, so openly tenderly that it costs to breathe.

"That night, at the sea. You were different, looked different. Like, um, like the moon.” Catra ´s ears turn impossible red but she keeps talking, placing her hands on Adora´s ribs, right below where the gills tremble at her touch. “Your skin is different too, I've noticed"

"I've noticed too,” Adora pushes Catra´s short bangs off her eyes, curls bouncing around her claws when she does. Catra follows the movement with a quiet hum. “I think it's because of you.”

Catra sighs, quivering. Yes, she has realized that too, Adora knows she could. “Is that– is that good?”

“Yes,” Adora answers immediately, smiling as tiny as she can,careful not to show the rows of her teeth. Catra sees this too because her eyes lock into Adora´s again, multicolored against black and bright blue.

“You are so beautiful.” Adora´s breath stops, looking to the ground and away from Catra for a second. Catra cradles Adora´s jaw between her palms, voice firmer this time. “Adora, you are the most beautiful person I've ever seen”

“I'm not a person,” it's all that comes as an answer, shy.

Catra´s face falls, rolling her eyes so hard they might just strain on their sockets. She tries to alleviate the pain in Adora´s voice, mirth falling softly on her tone. “Dummy– ”

"I'm a murderer,” Adora cuts her “, softly but just as burdened, shoulders dropping forward. Catra knows what she is thinking, remembering. That it is not about the hunters but about

herself, someone born in lonely immortality destiny to become a weapon for the rest of her life. “I´m a monst– "

Catra presses her fingers over Adora´s lethal mouth, stepping so close they melt around each other, softness and warmth. "You'll always be Adora to me, no matter what"

Catra raises a little in her toes, placing a kiss right over the membranes in Adora's cheek, and then another over the delicate fins in her eyebrows and one more in the curve of her mouth, gentler around the tip of the fangs there. Her hands whisper a touch over the sides of Adora's neck, gills flickering when her fingertips brush them, calling for her like calling for the sea, little traitor of what Adora truly feels. Catra seems to feel the pick up of Adora´s heart against her palm because she smiles, embracing every single sharp edge of Adora´s body inside her arms.

“Bed?” Catra whispers next to Adora's ear, barely a whisper away.

“Yes” it's all Adora can say without breaking apart.

Catra guides Adora to their bed with soft steps, a dove against the sky, blind steps guided by familiarity and the sanctity that lives still inside their room. She doesn't uncover the mirror on their way there. there is no need for reflections right now, just for their skins together and their breaths mingled.

Adora wraps her hands on Catra´s waist and hesitates at the foot of the bed, unsure for a moment. Catra seizes the second, turning them around and walking until the back of Adora's knees hit the edge of the mattress. Adora takes the hint and sits down over the rumpled sheets, not once letting go from Catra's hips as she looks up to her, waiting with her heart on her sleeve.

“Let me,” Catra asks, pleads, quiet as a murmur. “Please”

Adora blinks, once, and nods, smiling around the words. “Of course”

Catra pushes Adora gently on her back until she is falling over the feather pillows of the bed, completely leaning over them. Like this Catra can see her completely, from every single strand of silver hair to the scales like wings that wrap themselves around her ankles, a beautiful reminder that this is Adora's true form *on land.*

Adora rests her back on the pillows and the back of the bed and waits with breath held, arms raised at either side of her head and legs slightly parted, watching Catra in silence, the tiniest of smirks in the corner of her lips, mixed with cockiness but also full of shyness.

Catra huffs a heartwarming smile and moves forward, climbing over the bed in deliciously slow steps, basking in the way Adoras eyes drag from her body and back to her face, ethereal siren face beautiful beyond duty. Adora tilts her chin up and watches holding her breath as Catra wraps her legs around her waist, cradling herself over Adora's lap, longingly and sweetly.

Adora holds her steady in her place, palms resting flat over the expanse of Catra's back as the latter wraps her fingers over Adora's jaw, looking at her with so much intensity Adora feels herself shivering over the bed.

“Adora, do you know how much I love you?”

Adora smiles so tenderly it breaks and makes Catra's heart anew all over again, speaking in such a fit voice it's almost a bird's humming and not a word. "I do."

"No, you don't." Catra's grip tightens, her chest squeezing almost painfully. She holds Adora's silver gaze in hers tenderly but also full of some new kind.of energy, warmth passing between their bodies in waves. "I- I'm not a poet, I've never been one, Adora but I'm going to try right now, so don't laugh."

Catra feels suddenly dizzy but she gets a hold of herself and gulps around the knot on her throat. She needs to say this. She needs to tell Adora how loved she is, how worthy of goodness she is. How much Catra wants her, needs her, *loves* her. How sorry she is to have made her feel used, even for the smallest of seconds. Catra needs to say this now, in this holy space between them. In the middle of a hurricane like Francesca and Paolo, destined to circle each other on this storm until the end of the centuries.

"You– you are a wish," Catra shivers, gasps, keeps going. "You are a wish, you are a promise and you're a– Adora, you are a reason. You are *my* reason." Adora is starting to cry, Catra lets her. "You're incredible. You're smart and brave and strong and selfless. You're so beautiful. You're so full of light and life, Adora, and you are also so full of darkness and sadness and anger and that's so beautiful too. Everything in you. You deserve so much. You deserve a happy life even if it lasts all the years of the world or a single second."

Catra leans her mouth against the bridge of Adora's nose, speaking the words over the teardrops there. "You are not a murderer or a monster and even if you are it's all the same to me. I love you all the same, Adora," Catra feels herself breaking into pieces for a very different reason than sorrow, fear leaving her bones like sun cast shadows away. "You're my best friend and I love you"

"I was afraid for so long, Adora," Catra confesses in the space between both. "I– I was afraid of doing to you the same things that had been done to me. I was afraid of hurting you, I was afraid of cageing you, I was afraid. I was afraid of loving you so much that your departure would bury me. I was afraid of letting you love me thinking you would still turn your back when you saw how broken I am." Catra can feel and see the way Adora tenses under her words and how her eyes break into a million pieces, pain washing over both of them. It hurts, it pains to their cores but they bare it together, Adora's hands coming to rest over Catra's hummingbird heart, Catra wrapping her own over hers, keeping her there. "But, Adora, I understood. I understand now and I don't regret a single thing, a single moment. I never believed in destiny, I always believed in free will. But with you – with you I dare to believe. I want to believe it's real. I– want to believe that we found each other when we most needed the other. That you found me again. You didn't give up on me and I always waited for you to come back. Here. I would have done it until the end of time, Adora. I´m not afraid anymore."

Adora is openly sobbing now, beautiful, deadly face coated in dew that tastes that salt under Catra's mouth. Adora is being shaken to her core, undone below Catra's hands and she lets her. She will always let her, she will always come back to her no matter what.

"I wish I could put together all the words I want to say," Catra grumbles, slightly frustrated, but Adora just chuckles, wet with tears and sweet with a smile, leaning her forehead against Catra's nose. "I want to hold you, Adora. I want to touch you in every single way possible. Nothing makes sense to me without you. I want to love you with every– every cell, every wave inside of me." Catra opens her eyes, just a slit, looking at Adora´s through her eyelashes, breathing her in, tasting her in. "Let me love you, all of you, all that you think is too dangerous or terrible to even touch."

"Yes," Adora doesn't even hesitate and she doesn't even realize her song slips in there too. **"I love you too–** "

"Shh" Catra dances a quick, passionate kiss over Adora´s mouth, running her pink tongue under sharp fangs, drinking on the gasp from Adora´s mouth before turning apart, lips against the corner of mouths. "Be quiet, my love, let *me* love *you* right now"

Adora is losing her reason but she remains quiet, lapping on the taste of Catra´s mouth behind her teeth.

"I love you, beyond measure, Adora. I adore you, so much it hurts."

"No-"

"Let it hurt," Catra is letting kisses fall over Adora´s face, down her chin and across her jaw, teeth grasping on the angle of her neck and the arch of her mouth "Let me become a grave for the both of us, wound me and let me bleed, I'll love you through death too. Let me die and rest next to your heart. Let our bed become a mausoleum for us to nest."

"I have no other way to measure my love, Adora, but in words," Catra is feeling herself worn out, completely open and ravaged and vulnerable as she had never felt before. "And in sacrifice," Adora´s head falls forward, over Catra´s chest, "and in touch," Adora is touching her now, hands over her shoulders, palms down her thighs, fingers inside her heat. " *Ah*– It was all an act of love, don't you see Adora? All of it. Even the horror"

"My love– "

"My life, my love," Catra gasps over her mouth, eyes barely open now. "Dear Adora,my dearest Adora"

"Oh, Catra"

"These are my wedding vows," Catra whispers, undone, devastated, held together by love and kindness and choice. "I'll never say them out loud again"

"You don't need to, they are in my memory forever," Adora takes her hands away just su she can wrap them around Catra´s neck, rushing the scar that lived there. "I will guard them

forever" – *I will guard you forever* – she doesn´t say but Catra understands.

"I know. That's why I'm giving them to you," Catra can´t even smile right now, even if she wants to, too overwhelmed to move at all, "it's going to live here, between us. Even after I'm gone"

"We"

"We," Catra takes Adora´s cold hands just so she can rest their palms together, big and sharp against soft and small. "Should I write you love letters?"

"They are already written, here in your palms"

Where Catra is lean and resilient, Adora is wide and strong. And this body, warm and tender, Adora knows better than anything, better than the sea, better than herself.

Adora surges forward, wrapping her arms tightly around Catra's waist, shivering when the skin of her arms brushes against the soft, shimmering scars there. She meets Catra in the middle, cradling her mouth into a kiss, long, wet and slow, full of meaning like ink to a blank page. Catra whimpers against her touch full of some kind of quiet desperation. The touch of Adora´s scales against her bare skin is driving her delirious, frantic with want.

Catra parts herself from Adora´s mouth with a gasp but Adora doesn´t stop. Now that all the knots have come undone she cannot be contained anymore, latching her siren mouth to Catra ´s collarbones, worshiping the freckled flesh there. She has become another kind of hunter, one that craves the taste of Catra´s sweat and the sweetness of her breast.

"Will you tell me about the ocean? About your days there?" it's whispered from Catra´s hoarse voice to Adora´s tongue. "I've been so jealous of her"

"I will but you don't need to be jealous"

"She had you," and the way Catra says it is almost a growl, her fingers digging on Adora´s scalp.

"She is nothing compared to you, Catra. Nothing"

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Catra wanders her hand down, between the point where their heats are caressing like a kiss, carefully wrapping her fingers around Adora's, unfolding her like a flower´s bloom around her touch. Adora rests her mouth against Catra's ear, exhaling a long moan, wet and deep, on the cartilage there, scales crawling in her temples like a crown. Catra presses sweet kisses around Adora's cheeks, cradling Adora´s core between her wet lips, pink and warm. She rolls her hips in tight circles, rocking them together in a melting dance. She can feel the way Adora's abdomen tenses and relaxes with the movement, meeting Catra's caress relentlessly.

“I want you, Adora” and it’s the way she says it, dragging every single word, rolling the vowels between her white teeth, whispering in Adora´s ear, “I'm tired of missing you, I *need*

you. Your smell, your skin, your touch. I desire you, with every inch of my skin and every part of my soul“ Catra licks a line over Adora´s mouth, "I've missed you so much"

"You already have me. You´ve always had me, Catra."

"I've missed you. Every day, every fucking second"

"I missed you with every breath."

Adora opens her eyes, just a slit, looking at Catra prettily from between her eyelashes searching for any kind of sign of discomfort or pain she might be feeling, running her fingers over the scars. But Catra just shakes her head, a silent answer, thumbing Adora's red lips with her warm fingers before surging forward, kissing her slow and hot, ripping a whimper from Adora's throat and into her tongue.

Catra lays her palms on Adora's sweat-dampened shoulders and pushes her softly until she is resting back into the pillows below her, maneuvering until they are carefully placed below Adora´s waist.. Catra hovers above Adora's face, mouths open but not touching completely. Catra rubs Adora with her pink lips, dripping against each other, deliciously slow. Tears start to gather on the corners of Adora's eyes and spill down her cheeks and jaw. Catra lets them flow, catching them all with her lips, licking paths of love over Adora's uncharacteristically warm skin.

They move like this, pieces of an orchestra, for a few minutes, embracing each other. Adora´s arms are at either side of her head, fingers and claws curled towards the sheets, gripping them tightly. Her mouth is slightly parted, panting fog into the room with her moans, and her eyes are clouded in tears and wonder, never taking her eyes from Catra´s. Catra is above her, her legs tightly wrapped around Adora´s lap. Her face is a precious shade of red and she is gasping for air too, staring at Adora´s face and the bounce of her throat and breasts with each motion. She can feel the way Adora´s heat brushes against her entrance, so close it is overwhelming, so far away still that it's unbearable.

Catra holds her breath and lowers her mouth into Adora´s, lifting herself on her knees at the same time, just a little, just enough that she can line herself where both need it the most, sinking in as water down the rocks. Adora's breath hitches and she moans, her head falling into the feather touch of the pillows, her back arching without her permission off the mattress and into Catra's mouth, who whimpers too, already too far away and beyond any word.

This is who they are, who they have become. A goddess and a mortal, a saint and a devotee, royalty cradled in humility, a swan who´s permission has been granted. Tulips on morning dew and stone kisses by the ocean´s foam. It has been like this since the beginning of time, ever since they saw each other through cold raindrops and stained glass. Lace and ribbons in wrists. Among war and stars and beyond heaven and all the circles of hell.

All the love of a thousand lives falls down over Catra and almost makes her fall, grasping at her chest as if she wasn´t sure her heart was still there. And Adora, who has always seen her and always will, surges forward and reaches her this time, wrapping her inside her sinner and saint's colorful arms and holding her against her chest, letting them both gasp and whimper

and moan and come high and undone together again and once again, lips in mouths and warm breathes and heart´s borrowed in the other´s chest.

They will not be parted ever again.

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—

"Wow"

Catra is usually very well spoken but she thinks she can give herself this minute of speechless wonder.

She has pulled from the sheet that covered the huge mirror, sneezing a few times from the dust that came flying out of it. Now she is standing in front of the silver reflection, staring at herself for the first time in weeks.

She is naked still because why even bother right now, she's been too busy drowning herself into Adora's being to worry about that. The floor is a little bit cold but the room remains warm, scent heavy and sweet as honey. It makes her skin rise in goosebumps and her short hair sticks to her ears. She is covered in a light warm sweat and, for the first time in weeks, her skin is painted with kisses, cradled like secrets on her neck and chest and the inner side of her thighs and then deep within, where she can't see them but she can feel.

Catra runs her fingers over the scars, lifting her eyebrows. They are huge, crooked and covering almost totally her right side, and they are also completely healed now, faster than any wound of this caliber would have under human medicine. Faster than anything but Catra's own miracle could have ever done it. They are healed and Catra is alive.

Instead of the usual scar tissue one would see in a wound - light pink, raised, slightly bumpy, not fleeing tk Catra after living with that woman during her childhood and adolescence - Catra's scars are smooth, soft to the touch and, under the light, she can see the clear pattern of scales, dim golden and turquoise. It's Adora's skin, on *her* skin, like painted glass. One and the same.

It's the same in the other scars, if smaller. On her right shoulder, on the back of her leg, over her upper arms, down her forearms, on the curve on her ribs, on the nape of her neck. On every single piece of skin where hits and stone and water managed to reach her. Instead of blood and jarring violence there is only softness and glimmer like jewels.

Catra had never thought she would ever see this, that she would ever nearly *look* like this. As if someone had taken a string from the stars and knitted her back together with it. It's almost as if someone had managed to find a way to turn diamond and sapphire into powder and had tattooed her skin with it, forever carrying a part of Adora's skin on hers.

Catra lifts her eyes from her body and back to the mirror, looking at Adora through the reflection without bothering to turn around.. Adora is sitting cross legged in the middle of the bed,staring at Catra without shame. Her skin is draped over her shoulders and back like a

blanket, sunlight damp hair in complete disarray falling over her collarbones and shoulders, her pale back covered in twin blooms as Catra's.

In all, both of them look thoroughly, absolutely, fucked, a fair statement after being unable to tear themselves from the other until the dawn have away time to the sunset and the rain stopped all together.

"Am I going to grow gills?" Catra asks, bluntly, and Adora would have laughed if it wasn't because Catra looked dead serious through the mirror

"No– uh, actually I don't know," Adora rubs her hand in the back of her neck, giving Catra an apologetic stare through the mirror.

Catra arches her eyebrow, a sly grin stretching in the corner of her mouth. "You don't know?"

"Well, it's just, I don't think this has ever happened before," Adora tries to explain, stuttering a little in her words. Her voice *and* song is hoarse after so many hours singing sweetly next to Catra's ear. "Our skin heals us, faster than anything. and protects us too, like one of those armor you used to read me about. But that's usually only to the first one it belongs to. I've never heard of a first one using their skin to heal another one. Much less– um–"

"A human" Catra finishes for her, gently. Adora exhales, the little apprehension etched on her body leaving all at once once she sees Catra's soft expression. Catra's smile widens, straightening her back to look at herself better. "Maybe I'll get some ears like yours, dummy, I think I would rock them, no offense"

Adora chuckles at the joke, resting her cheek in her bent knee to look at Catra fully, all of her, before opening the skin wrapped around her, stretching her hand towards Catra.

"Come here"

Catra turns in her ankles without even thinking about it, taking Adora's hand immediately and letting herself be pulled back into the unmade bed. It smells like them again.

Adora cradles her in her lap again, wrapping the skin around Catra's body too. Catra nestles her face on the angle of Adora's neck, smiling. Adora lets a gentle kiss fall over Catra's nose, wrapping her arms tightly around Catra's, bringing her closer.

"All those years in the ocean, I thought I needed to have some kind of purpose for living as endlessly as we do. I mean, humans, they wish for glory, or power, or greed. And First Ones are much of the same sometimes. They want to be the greatest predator, they hunt and greed too and they feel better than humans for being stronger, faster." Adora speaks, muffled between Catra's curls, not wanting to be apart from her for a single second. "I thought I had to wish for something like that and when I didn't, when I couldn't, I just felt empty. And alone." Adora exhales softly, eyes closing. Catra's hold over her collarbones tightens. "I got to thinking that maybe I wasn't even deserving of a mate. That I wasn't worth it."

"Adora, you don't need to have a purpose to deserve to live or to be worthy of happiness. You don't need a purpose to deserve being loved"

"I know that now," Adora assured her sweetly, "But– I did find a purpose in the end, Catra. I found a purpose I wanted, a purpose *I* chose. I want– I just want to love you. I want to be happy with you. That's what I want, that's what I choose. And you might want to be my sword but I'll always be your shield."

Catra says nothing but she allows herself to fuse inside Adora's words, nuzzling into all kinds of her skin without stopping smiling. And maybe a tear or two does slip from her eyes but it's worth it. These are Adora's wedding vows too, whispered against the surface of a braided rope on a finger.

“We are going to have a beautiful, happy life together, Catra. I can promise you that. I will always promise you that."

♡

On the seventh day, the rain stops and they go to the sea. It's Catra's idea.

Catra is fumbling with the edge of her shirt, looking at the waves washing over the shore. The sky is still virulently dark but, beyond the clouds that swirl over the house, there is a clear sky, golden and blue and clean.

Here, however, the wind is still cold and the sand is even colder, swirling around Catra's bare feet, soft and damp. She is wearing leggings but the wind still raises goosebumps on her skin. Or maybe it is the sight of the water, calmer now but just as strong, rolling smooth pebbles on its waves just as it rolled Catra inside of it as if she weighed nothing at all.

Catra gulps, rubbing her upper arm with her hand, staring at the water as someone would stare at a tall building or a fire, the noise inside her head become almost unbearable.

Adora's hands fall over her shoulders gently, rubbing tense knots off her muscles and body. Catra exhales slowly, turning her eyes towards her. Adora is looking at her with a tender expression but she also looks hesitant, worrying her bottom lip against her front teeth.

“Are you sure about this?” Adora asks softly, looking between the sea and Catra.

“Not really” the latter confesses under her breath. Adora's silver eyes narrow, frowning deeply.

“Catra- “

“I want to do this. With you” Catra takes Adora's hands between hers, pulling from them so she can press a kiss on Adora's pale knuckles.

Adora relaxes just a fraction, still looking at Catra wearily from below hooded eyes. Her hair is loose, hanging from below her naked waist, and she is beautiful under the darkness of the early day, wrapping herself around Catra's shivering body like a shield.

“Tell me the truth. Why are you doing this?” Adora asks in a whisper, tilting Catra's chin up so they are looking at each other. Catra presses her lips into a tight line, hesitating before sighing deeply, looking at the sea behind them.

“I don't want to live in fear anymore,” Catra murmurs under her breath. "I'm going to have to face Prime again sooner than later and I don't want to be afraid of my own home when I do" she turns her eyes back to Adora's, resting her hand over Adora's collarbones and chest, where the beating of her heart is stronger. “I don't want you to be afraid either”

Adora's eyes soften completely, shimmering a little with the shade of tears. She hasn't said anything but Catra *knows*. She knows that this is hard for Adora too, that the waters and the ocean are a part of Adora and that what happened was terrible for her too. Catra almost died in a place Adora called home for dozens of years, bleeding out on the water and in Adora's arms. She knows that Adora is afraid Catra is going to sink again and Adora won't be able to reach her this time.

Adora has told her about the nightmares, about the cold sand and the even colder depths of the ocean. About the caverns filled with darkness and the overwhelming silence filled with loneliness. About floating hoping the water would kill her.

Adora has told her all of this, tangled on their sheets and on her skin, confessions made on each other's neck and the low of their backs. Things whispered when they were touching everywhere, from the palms of their hands to the soles of their feet.

And yet, Adora hadn't talked about this fear yet. And yet, Catra knew.

"Alright," Adora accepts, leaning to place a sweet kiss on Catra's mouth.

Catra exhales against her lips, letting her weight fall back into Adora's touch. She doesn't even notice when they start to walk across the sand, with Adora's hands around her waist and her mouth over her face, until the waves start licking her cold feet, covering her ankles quickly.

Catra holds her breath, suddenly overwhelmed, body locking into a single shiver. She can hear the rush of her water inside her ears and feel the cold breeze on her body and suddenly all she can see is water at night and the expansion of the stormy sky above her head as she falls to her death, sea devouring her whole, like nothing at all.

"Cat? Catra? My love– " Catra blinks, back to reality with a heavy exhale. She looks up just to find Adora's eyes in front of her, concern and fear swimming inside the blue and silver that lives there. "Catra?"

"I'm here," Catra gasps, a little bit slurred. She blinks traitor tears away, staring at Adora's beautiful, worried eyes. "It 's alright."

"Let's go home"

"No, Adora," Catra holds herself to Adora's body, wrapping her hands around her neck. They share a heavy look, concern against stubbornness. "I can do this. Let me do this," Catra licks

her bottom lip, breath shuttering. "Just– stay with me while I do it."

Adora is still clearly unsure, shoulders tense. The water keeps lapping gently at their ankles, waiting patiently. Finally she gives up, wrapping Catra's arms tight around her back and walking backwards, further inside the water, supporting Catra's waist with her own hands.

Catra does have a hard time, but she holds on. The water starts to rise around them, from their ankles to their knees and around their hips until reaching both of their waists, soaking the ends of Adora's hair and Catra's clothes.

Catra exhales, closing her eyes for a second. She still can feel the sand below her toes but she knows they are closer to open sea and deeper waters. Adora runs a wet hand through her curls, leaving kisses on Catra's temples.

"Alright?" she asks, eyes soft, ready to pull Catra out of the water immediately if Catra asks her to.

"Alright," Catra opens her eyes, nuzzling on Adora's touch.

Adora's skin is held to her collarbones and back and, surrounded by blue water and the golden of the morning sun beyond their bay, it almost seems to shine with its own light all around her, a virgin's halo or s crown, making her look like an angel, fallen from the very heaven and into Catra's palms.

Adora smiles, all white teeth and red lips, cupping Catra's cheek inside her hand. "Can you hold on here for a second?"

Catra wrinkles her nose for a second but nose, breathing slowly through her mouth until her heartbeat steadies and she doesn't feel like she is going to have a panic attack. "Okay"

Adora, who has been looking at her closely the entire time, smiles brighter. She hesitates when she lets go from Catra but doesn't stop smiling softly at her, brushing her chin with her fingertips before sinking completely down the crystalline water.

Catra holds her breath, looking at the water without even blinking, counting her heart beats and feeling the little grains of sand between her toes.

It doesn't even take Adora ten seconds. Catra is looking at the still water when the soft silk end of a tail peeks out to the surface right in front of her, soft as a dress and as beautiful as coral reef. It shimmers blue and golden and then sinks back again inside the water.

Catra is still recovering her breath when another fin peeks out, this time to her side, a little bit smaller and just as beautiful and then sinks back again. And then another, behind Catra, out and in again, behind, to the sides and in front of her again. Fins like mist turned into ice and gems, strong muscle as a kaleidoscope, sharp but at the same time soft, surrounding Catra's body completely until she realizes Adora is swimming in circles around her, playful and sweet loops.

Adora's tail fins flicker at some moment, splashing a drizzle of seawater on Catra's nose. Catra laughs, out loud and squeaky, cleaning her face with her damp fingers. This time, Adora's head is the one that peeks out of the water, all light hair covered in the tiniest seashells and bright blue eyes inside black escaleras, looking at Catra full of tenderness and mirth.

Water drips from her long ears and down her shoulders in little teardrops like pearls when she gets out of the water further, running down her collarbones and into the curve of her breasts, looking themselves back into the water at her waist. She looks at Catra in all her beauty smiling from ear to ear, all sharp rows of teeth and flickering gills.

Like this she kind of looks like a smiling piranha and Catra's cheeks burn red over the fact that she somehow finds her immediately endearing.

“Do you like what you see?” Adora says, cocky and definitely amused, human voice mixed with her song, so beautiful Catra shivers and the water does it with her. Then Catra's face falls, rolling her eyes before raising her hand, also dripping water everywhere, poking Adora in the middle of her scaled forehead.

“Don’t be so full of yourself” she says between her teeth. Adora just laughs, sweet as a bell that just manages to deepen Catra's flush. Catra nibbles the inside of her cheek between her teeth and looks at Adora's tail instead, still swirling inside the water like a lotus leaf around Catra's waist. She extends her hand, curiosity getting the best of her as she runs her fingers flat across the smooth surface of the tail, marveling at how beautiful it is. “I remember it, from that night”

Adora swims closer to her, until their chests are pressed back together. “How much do you remember?”

“Mostly but not everything," Catra narrows her eyes, looking from Adora's tail to the cliff, yards behind them. Under the clouds it looks gloomy and cold, too tall and too terrifying still to put a foot on it again. “I remember pieces, after I fell. The sea and you”

Adora presses their cheeks together into a siren's kiss, holding Catra's hands between her claws, freckled skin against ink-like. Her tail comes to wrap around Catra's lean legs, holding her in place on the water.

Catra smiles down at this, resting her palms over Adora's shoulders. "You held me like this that day"

"I didn't know what else to do," Adora sings, pretty and dark eyes narrowing sadly. Before Catra can say something else, Adora wraps her hands around Catra's head, also too small below the huge claws. "Is it cold?"

“It’s cold in my palms and feet, but everywhere else is alright” Catra looks down at her own body, blurry under the water. A new thought crosses her mind, making her frown.

“What is it?” Adora asks softly, following her train of thought.

“Do you think I could breathe underwater?” Adora stares at Catra, surprised, a tiny smile appearing in the crook of her siren mouth.

“Do you want to try?”

“Uh-uh, no, one thing at a time” Catra rushes to say, laughing nervously. “I- I don’t want water above my head”

“We can work with that,” Adora reassures her. "Where do you want to go?"

"There," Catra points at the horizon, where the sun is actually shining, her other arm wrapped around Adora's neck keeping her close.

"Okay," Adora nuzzles on the side of Catra's face, taking her arms between her hands as she turns around, resting Catra's front and weight over her back. “Come here, sea monkey”

“Ugh, you know what, let me drown” Catra complains without real meaning to it, nestling her face in the long fin between Adora's shoulder blades.

“Never”

The sand gives away under Catra's feet and Adora swims towards the open sea. Catra can feel the exact moment when gravity gives up on her because her entire weight drops into Adora's back and waist, any kind of ground disappearing completely below them.

Catra holds her breath, closing her eyes for a while, until the lash of the cold wind dies down, waiting for the unmistakable sense of sinking into the water, but it never comes. Instead, after a brief moment of panic, Catra feels herself floating, surrounded by water everywhere but past her chin. And the water doesn't hurt and doesn't push her away, for the first time in weeks, welcoming her back inside its waves.

Catra takes a deep breath before opening her eyes and is met with the bluest water she has ever seen, blue that looks almost unreal, clear and crystalline like mirrors of the now clean sky above their heads. Catra looks back, breath stuck on her throat. She still can make out the shape of their house and the shore but it's just a bright point behind them, still covered in the remains of storm clouds. Here, miles away, the water shines almost gold with the morning sun and it's warm against Catra's body, holding her above the sea foam.

Adora swims really fast but Catra doesn't really feel it above the rush of warm wind against her ears. Adora is carrying her on her back, her powerful and long tail making swirls behind them as she breaks through the strength of the water as if it was nothing at all. Part of her wide back and her head are above the water, strong arms making their way across the tides easily.

On the water, her hair almost looks like pure sunlight, white shimmering in shades of blue and lilac and gold, floating around her shoulders in soft locks sometimes getting stuck with tiny pieces of blue seaweed. Her fin ears are flopping a little with the wind and it makes her look kind of like a flying fish and kind of like a butterfly and Catra won't giggle *she will not* but it's the single most beautiful and endearing thing she has seen.

Catra realces her tight hold over Adora's neck just so she can run her finger below the water, down Adora's collarbones and around her chest, hands resting tightly over Adora's ribcage covered in scales. When Adora moves, Catra swears she can see her skin shimmering as if it was covered in glitter. Adora turns her head towards Catra, just enough to throw her a shit eating grin *the absolute idiot* wiggling her eyebrows – that are not even eyebrows anymore but prices of sea glass above her eyes – smoothly.

Catra tries, she really does, to not pout in annoyance – doesn't really work – because all that Adora doesn is laugh even more, water splashing inside her mouth. Catra pinches her lightly on the ribs, right above the gills, making an indignant sound with her throat.

"Can you go faster?" Catra murmurs over the sound of the water. Adora hears her clearly, a pleased look spreading on her face.

"Aye, aye, captain!"

Catra doesn't even get the time to groan at Adora's complete stupid, endearing, lovely silliness because the latter curls her tail and then she is *speeding* across the water, crossing the sea in second. This time Catra *does* feel it because she bites back a small yell, holding herself to Adora's chest even tighter. By the small vibrations she can feel below her fingertips she knows this is exactly what Adora was expecting. Catra would pinch her again if she wasn't busy trying not to fly away and also laughing like a fucking maniac against Adora's soaked hair.

Adora comes to a stop very slowly, circling the water a few times as she changes position, vertical inside the water instead of horizontal so she can roll on her back, holding Catra on her chest instead.

"What is it?" Catra asks, still breathless and giggling from their run in the water. The house and the cliff are now barely pin points behind them and everything is covered in light, uninterrupted, clear ocean all around where Catra can see.

Adora places a tiny kiss over Catra's temple, nuzzling her cheek with her nose a few times before singing. "There is someone here that wants to meet you"

Catra's thoughts stop in her brain, blank space substituting everything else before she can even begin to form some kind of sentence. "Me?"

"Yes" Adora is smiling against her face so it can't be that bad. Still, Catra squirms a little under the water, apprehension falling over her without being able to stop it.

"Who– ?"

"Wait," Adora whispers, leaning her cheek against Catra's and looking at some point on the huge ocean in front of them, expecting. Catra gulps and waits too, unsure on what is supposed to happen next.

She can feel the change on the water before she sees it. It's heavy, very very heavy, coming from the infinite depth of the water below them and then up and up at a surprising speed,

shaking the entire water and rising little waves around them. Catra holds herself to Adora like a lifeline, curling under the feeling, but Adora doesn't even move, lavishing lazy kisses over her face for some kind of reassurance and calm.

The water breaks in two before them, seafoam and droplets washing all over them in a drizzle and the single most enormous whale Catra has ever seen jumps out of the ocean and falls back again without a joyous swirl. The strength of the jump against the water pushed them back a little but Adora's hold is stronger and she is laughing against Catra's head.

Catra can't help herself either. She gasps in surprise and then sputters a little with the sudden rain of salt water but she smiles all the same, so wide her cheeks are starting to hurt.

The whale swims again towards the surface, not jumping this time, stabilizing herself until her big eyes and half of her body are above the water, staring at both of them gently. Catra inhales sharply, suddenly feeling herself infinity and small all at the same time, surrounded by water and Adora and this beautiful sea creature that has come to greet them. The whale is *huge* , so big Catra is merely a bug next to her. *Adora* is small next to the whale, and her tail could easily fit their room and all the way down their stairs. Catra cackles, apprehension replaced quickly with surprise and bright curiosity, staring at the whale right back with a big smile.

Adora is smiling too but she is looking at Catra and only at Catra, staring at her bright profile with all the love and adoration possible embroidered on her face. This is the first time in so long that Adora has seen Catra smile this big and this honest and it fills her heart with all the love that there can possibly be, overflowing out of her heart and almost bursting her chest open, ready to spill across the entire ocean and miles and miles away.

"Wow," Catra mutters, full of wonder, looking from the whale's eye to her body and back to her eye, unable to say another word.

"This is Mother Whale," Adora presents them without letting go from Catra's waist or her face, grinning from ear to ear. "I've known her for a long time"

Mother whale sings in cheerful greeting and even if Catra can't actually understand it, she gets it.

"Hi," Catra gasps out, though she doesn't make a move to get closer, fingers digging in Adora's neck and back.

"My dear," Mother whale sings to Adora, full of tenderness, words only she can comprehend but that for Catra are deep and wonderful songs echoing across the entire ocean. " *Is this your love?"*

"Yes," Adora sings back, getting a happy trill from mother whale back. Her song is different when she speaks to mother whale, and so, Catra can't understand it either. Even though she is too busy gapping in wonder to even be bothered by it. Instead, Catra nestles her cheek over Adora's shoulder and smiles while she states at her.

"Is she saying something?"

"She says you are precious"

Mother whale sings in agreement, lapping a gentle wave of water towards Catra's face, making her gasp a little in surprise and then dissolve into dumb giggles, too charmed to even be ashamed by it.

The water leaps a little bit inside her eardrum, though, and Catra sinks suddenly inside herself at the feeling, holding Adora even closer to her as she tries to fight back the discomfort of it. The motion doesn't go missing by mother whale.

"She is scared", she sings to Adora, her huge eye motherly full of concern.

"I failed her", Adora sings back, holding Catra unconsciously closer to her chest, dark clouds covering her mind again.

"She is not scared of you". Mother whale seems to see the way Catra's fingers dig in Adora's back, her head nestled over Adora's shoulder above the water, eyes tired but tender. *"I think she is scared of losing you"*

It breaks Adora's heart. Mother whale swims a little closer to them until her fin brushes Adora's fingers, wrapped around Catra's waist.

"You are scared too" she sings and if whales could smile she would be doing it, reassuringly . *"Don't be".*

The movement in the water makes Catra's shirt rise a little under the water, letting see through the silver and pearl scars in her side, wide enough that make Adora's stomach turn in phantom pain.

"Oh, I see" mother whale's eyes narrows in comprehension and sadness. *"Hunters?"*

"She was trying to protect me. She protected me." Adora sings and it's very close to a lament. In her arms, Catra shakes awake again, leaving kisses down Adora *'s* shoulders .

"Are you two talking about me?" she asks, tone halfway witty but also a little bit nervous. Adora tightens their grip around each other, nodding against her head.

"Yes"

"All good things?"

"All of them"

"Good." Catra stretches her arm without losing her hold in Adora, just enough so she can pat the only part of the mother whale's head she can reach, the same way she pets Melog's little head. "Pretty whale "

"Oh, she really is precious," Mother whale marvels pleasantly *, "And tiny."*

"She is". Adora bites back a sob, *"I love her. I really love her so much."*

"I can see that, darling." Mother whale's song echoes in the water, filling Adora's sorrowful chest and limbs with warmth and reassurance. *"Sometimes things don't go as we want them to. Sometimes we make mistakes and it hurts us or hurts who we love. And you need to forgive yourself. For your good and for hers"* Mother whale flaps her fin towards Adora again, gently. " *The important thing is that you came back, darling, you're together again. Just don't leave again, alright? I don't know if she could bear it. I don't think either of you can."*

Adora nods, sniffling. Catra feels the weight in her chest be sure she nuzzles closer to Adora, pressing a siren's kiss on her cheek. Mother whole hums playfully, singing something else to Adora for Catra to hear.

"She says you can ride in her fin if you want," Adora says, pushing Catra's bangs out of her face.

"Oh. *Oh,"* Catra flushes s tender shade of red, looking back at the whale slightly tense. The latter sings at her once more, no words needed to translate. "Okay. Thank you"

Adora helps Catra get there, guiding her with firm but gentle arms until Catra is right next to the fin. Catra stretches her arms around the slippery skin, barely managing to hold herself completely to it. Adora places herself right behind her, arms around her waist, holding her in place safely.

"Little human." Mother whale sings deeply, shaking herself back into motion. *"Tell her to hold on tight"*

The three of them swim slowly, further and further inside the ocean until the very tides change and become warmer. The storm clouds are now far away from them, only bright blue sky and the sunlight all around, reflecting over the ocean like mirrors, making it all look perfectly peaceful and calm.

Riding on a whale's fin is a whole new experience for Catra specially because the whale.is huge and Catra is pretty much just another little fish next to her, but it somehow doesn't feel as scary as it should. In fact, held from slippery skin with Adora's arms around her waist and the water splashing gently on her face, Catra is actually having *fun.*

Adora leans her cheek against Catra's, whispering in her ear gently with her human voice. "Are you good?"

"Yeah," Catra affirms and she can't even bit back the excited squeal she lets out when the whale swims a little bit deeper, soaking even the hollow of her collarbones and her chin. It doesn't bother her.

Catra turns to look at Adora and can see the clear glim inside her very bright blue eyes. She is still looking at Catra, all fondness and tenderness clearly written on her siren factions, but there is also a certain flush on her cheeks, kind of purple and pink honestly, and her tail is lashing wildly inside the water below them, excited to swim. Excited to be here, on her ocean, *with* Catra.

The water is not hurting anymore around Adora's skin and she is not feeling that overwhelming oppression anymore, wearing sorrow and regret over her like another skin. In fact, Adora has never feel as alive as she feels right now, breathing water through her gills and smelling Catra's damp hair against her cheek. This is what was missing, all those days and weeks and even years, the love of her life in her arms giggling at the tiny fishes that come to nibble curiously on her bare feet.

"Go swim a little," Catra says suddenly, resting her shoulder against mother whale's big body. Adora blinks at her, huge as an owl, all third eyelid and big pupils, hesitant. "Go on, sea girl, I'll be alright"

"Sure, sure?"

"Sure, sure," affirms Catra, rolling her eyes again. She leans to press a fluttering kiss over the scaled skin of Adora's jaw before flushing herself flat over mother whale's fin, warm all over under the sun.

Adora beams like a fucking sun, her fin ears flipping like butterfly wings with excitement. She hugs Catra tightly on her chest once more before letting go. She swims around Catra once, twice, into a looping circle, tickling Catra's ribs with the end of her tail before sinking down completely.

She doesn't swim far away, barely a few feet deep in the water and always around Catra. When she looks up, Adora can see the sun pouring inside the ocean in golden ribbons, illuminating everything in a turquoise so similar to Catra's eye it makes Adora's heart swell. She can also she mother whale's huge belly, swimming lazily across the ocean, and her fin extended to the side of Catra to hold onto. Catra's shirt rolls every once in a while over her ribs, the scaled scars that live there shimmering brightly inside the water, so similar now to Adora's own tail.

Adora smiles around the water cradling her completely, sighing deeply as she gives a lazy spin around her own body, upside-down and back on. There are colorful fishes swimming all around them, getting close with curiosity and then quickly away. They are in the open ocean now, the sand floor far away from them, though Adora still can distinguish the shapes of colorful coral reefs and rocks below them.

And Adora is *happy,* she is happy and full of joy for this single moment in the open ocean with the love of her life. There is nothing here that can harm them, nothing at all. There is just the sun above their heads hiding the stars from few during the morning, and the blue sky that makes the water look even bluer, and sea animals swimming around them and mother whale and salt and warmth and Catra, smiling to herself above the water as mother whale sings to her something she can't even begin to understand.

Mother whale was right, that day when she spoke to Adora. Adora will always be a part of the ocean and the ocean of her, it is in her skin and in her blood and in her entire being, but the ocean is not Adora's home anymore. It has always been a safe place, it sheltered and protected her for long decades, but it never was the place where she was meant to be. Neither is the shore or the house or the cliff or the town or the land at all.

Adora's home is near the surface, kicking the water as she tries to learn to swim on her own, stretching her hand to brush the pads of her fingers over the back of a fish that crosses her way. She is covered in iridescent scars and her hair is very short for now, smiling sideways when she catches a glimpse of Adora, swimming in eights below the surface. That is Adora's home and, at least for today, she doesn't smell like fear or sadness anymore.

An errand jellyfish is swimming dangerously close to Catra's bare feet, surrounding her a few times,.barely managing to miss her at all with its stinging tentacles. Adora growls low on her throat, rushing quickly back up. It's pretty easy to catch the jellyfish between her claws and then directly towards her mouth, it quite honestly doesn't present resistance at all. One second it's close to Catra's ankles and ten next is gone.

Adora peeks her head back out of the surface with a low hum, the offended poor jellyfish now hanging limp from her sharp fangs as Adora chews happily on them as if it was a mere sour gummy. Adora can't help a pleased grumble to echo on her throat as she snacks on the jellyfish, turning around to look at Catra's precious face.

Catra is already looking back, wearing the most disgusted expression Adora has ever seen her before, her button nose wrinkled and eyes narrowed as she looks at Adora feast on the little and kind of sticky tentacles. The stinging makes Adora's cheeks and tongue tingle funnily. Mother whale is also looking at her, with something much more like mirth in her eye.

"What?" Adora questions around a mouthful of the jellyfish's bell. Catra looks from the jellyfish to Adora's eyes, an adorable pout stretching in her lips as she grimaces.

"You're not kissing me until you wash your mouth" Catra states, as a matter of fact, turning her head away from Adora without another word. Adora sputters, surprise and offense washing over her. She can feel the way even her fin ears flip with the emotions, flushing her face in a deep shade of purple.

"Wh– why?" Catra looks at her wide eyed as if it was an offense on itself to even ask. Adora gulps the last chew of her jellyfish, looking from Catra to mother whale in silent plea. "But– !"

Mother whale hums a sweet tune, full of motherly scolding and also joking mirth, pointing with her big fin at the pieces of jellyfish still stuck to Adora's face.

"See? She agrees with me" Catra announces proudly, nodding to herself. She is still turning away from Adora but her tone is light and Adora can see right past it, towards the tiny smile etched in the corner of her lips.

Adora's worried face falls, substituted by something much more lighthearted and a thousand times cockier. She runs her forearm against her face, absently cleaning it as she starts swimming slowly closer to where Catra is, grinning, quite literally, from ear to ear.

"It's just jellyfish"

"Nu–uh"

Adora wraps her arms back around Catra's waist, leaning her face towards her without a second thought, every single fin and scale and cell in her body singing pleasantly.

"Come on gimme a kiss"

Catra squirms, pushing Adora's face away from her with her palm as she shakes her head firmly, fake nauseated grapes leaving her mouth. "No! Get off me!"

"Just one!"

"No! Ugh!" Adora kisses her cheek, all salt water and tiny pieces of jellyfish, but it's so sweet Catra just can't resist, melting inside the soaked touch without much resistance at all. Adora giggles against her skin, endearment filling her to the brim.

"Oh, you're so in love with me, it's so cute"

"It 's not cute! Get off." Catra slaps the side of Adora´s face rather strongly but Adora just chuckles the entire time. It's barely a feather against her skin after all. Catra crosses her eyes, cheeks bright red and absolutely frustrated, waving her hand in Adora´s direction. "Go fish or something, but away from me."

“Yeah, yeah,” Adora accepts with a flirtatious swing of her tail against Catra´s butt, basking in the way her entire face and neck flushes almost violet.”I´m also very in love with you, you know”

Catra´s shoulders melt a little with the words, all her frustrations evaporating like nothing immediately. “Yes, I know dumbass”

Adora smiles brightly at her, errand tentacles stuck on her sharp molars. Catra pokes her tongue out to Adora and Adora does the same, which is kind of a sight given her tongue is *long* .

Adora swims around Catra the entire time, in and out of the water, doing loopy loops around the tides and never losing sight of her, helping her hold her breath when the splash of the water gets a little too close to her face and Catra tenses immediately just to relax right after when she feels Adora there, with her.

There is a huge flock of stingrays swimming below them, lazy and without hurry on their journey. Some of them turn to look at Catra in wonder but most don't care, going on with their travel as usual. They cross paths with all kinds of fishes and even one or two turtles but mostly their path is calm and gentle. Adora loves this part of the ocean, she has always loved it, how old and weird and beautiful it is. How peaceful and how chaotic it can be. She loves it and today she feels so happy in it.

After a while, Adora swims quickly from the middle of the ocean to the surface, wrapping her arms strongly around Catra´s middle without warning. She pulls from her gently and spins Catra in a circle around the water, winning a squeaky shriek and a loud giggle against her cheek.

Mother whale looks at them tenderly from her place, taking in the sight of them. They are swaying gently from side to side inside the water, following a tune shared only by them, hummed sweetly in Catra´s throat and echoing in Adora´s song. Adora´s hands rest softly and securely over Catra´s back, carrying her weight and keeping her above the water. Catra just smiles at her, running her finger tips around the edges of the scales that live in her jaw and cheeks.

At some moment, Adora leans towards Catra´s ear, whispering something softly before leaning back with a beaming grin. Catra doesn´t answer but the pink flush that covers her shoulders and the absolutely beautiful smile in her lips is enough testimony of even more tender words. For a second there, they were in their own world, surrounded by water like diamonds and golden sun, and Adora looked at Catra oh so fondly, bright eyes like bluebell flowers and kisses on knuckles.

Mother whale sings a soft tune to them, announcing her departure alongside the morning sun. Adora smiles tenderly, nodding softly as she rests her chin over Catra´s shoulder.

" *Thank you* "

" *Any day, sweethearts* " Mother whale answers, full of honesty. Catra doesn´t understand the exchange but she figures, turning around in Adora´s arms to face mother whale as best as she can.

"Thanks" and she means it, she truly means it. Mother whale hums a smile towards her bumping the side of her huge head against Catra´s palms.

" *Take care of each other"* she sings softly, looking at Adora.

" *We will"*

Mother whale swims away peacefully, heart settled on the calmness of the girls she leaves behind. Adora scatters tiny siren kisses all over Catra´s face and neck and shoulders, content in the moment. Catra hums sweetly but her mind is obviously somewhere else, staring at the place where mother whale had gone through almost without blinking.

"What are you thinking about?" Adora asks in a whisper, following her gaze.

"We could run away," Catra says abruptly, making Adora´s heart skip a beat. She seems to realize what she just said because she gasps a little, hunching on herself inside Adora´s hold. "Or swim I guess– we are already here, we could just– go"

"Catra– " Adora frowns deeply staring at Catra´s profile. All the lighthearted mood between them gets a little bit heavier on the edges. But not unbearable, just enough for Adora's skin to raise goosebumps even if it shouldn't be possible. "What about Melog?" Adora finally asks in a thread of a voice. "And Razz's house? And our friends?"

"I– um" Catra nibbles on her bottom lip, sadness falling over her eyes like a shadow. Adora's belly clenches painfully at the sight, heartbroken to see watch in just any kind of distress.

"Are you still afraid?" Adora asks, softening even more her voice.

"Of the sea?" Catra looks around here at the devastatingly huge expanse of the infinite water that surrounds her, and it should make her panic, it should make her heart throb and memories to flood like a tsunami. They do, but her heart doesn't ache as bad as before and she has new memories on the ocean now too. It's not the same. "I don't think so. It's going to take me a little bit still, but no."

Adora nods, exhaling warm breath over her cheekbones. "Of Prime?"

There.

Catra looks down, at the blue water between them..the water was green the night she fell, green seaweed against rock. "I don't want him to hurt you"

Adora's sharp eyes narrow, thinking about her words before speaking again. "Catra, these waters, that house, these are ours. This it's our home." Adora takes Catra's arms between her long hands and wraps them around her neck, leaning their foreheads together. "If you want us to, I'll go with you. I'll stand between the earth and the sky for you, I'll carry you across the entire ocean for the rest of my life. But I'm not going to let him keep them, keep our home. I'm not going to let him win."

Catra's eyes swell with tears on the corners but she doesn't look away, running her fingers across the strands of hair knotted on Adora's neck. "You are my home"

"And you are mine," Adora assures her, running her fingers down her back. "I– You said it yourself, Cat'. I don't want to live in fear either, I don't want you to be afraid that he is going to hunt us down for the rest of our lives." Adora's eyes harden, not out of anger but for something completely different, a sense of wanting to shelter, of wanting to take care and protect and love. "I want to protect this no matter what. I want to protect you"

"I want to protect you too" Catra whispers, letting all of her weight fall over Adora's front.

"You already did," Adora whispers back, against her nape of her neck, brushing the scar that lives there.

They drift off on the water for a while, just floating alongside the calm water with their arms around the other. The sun moves across the sky calmly, making morning into midday and the very start of the evening.

"Are you tired?" Adora runs her palms down Catra's upper arms.

"A little bit" Catra tightens her hold around Adora's neck, nuzzling closer. "I kind of want to stay here though"

"We can stay as much as you want as long as you don't get cold"

"Okay"

Adora nestles Catra over her chest and floats above the water in her back, facing the sky over their heads, Catra's hands over her chest, her cheek against Adora's neck

It's easy carrying Catra, wrapping her tail around her legs so she doesn't get tired of wanting to keep herself afloat, her arms wrapped around her waist. Catra drows off for a little bit and Adora sings to her, without holding back, echoing in the entire water, running her sharp fingers through the short strands of her hair.

There is nothing but the expanse of the ocean all around them.

It's night time when Adora swims them back to their shore. Catra is mostly asleep the entire trip back so Adora wraps Catra's legs around her waist and steps out of her skin, covering Catra's back with it as they make their way through the sand. It bears deep scars where scales and pearls won't grow anymore but it's almost healed too, a mirror of Catra's wounds. Shared pain, shared healing, shared scars, shared love.

The skin keeps Catra warm when Adora helps her peel off her soaked clothes and into the shower, running a dry towel over her face and neck when they are done scrubbing sand and salt from each other's skin.

They pamper Melog for a while and then walk hand in hand into their bed, and even in there, Adora makes sure Catra is well wrapped inside her skin, a tender blanket and a steel sharp shield. Adora is going to veil for her sleep the entire night still.

Catra nuzzles over the lukewarm pillows, resting her arms around Adora's shoulders. She tangles her fingers between the loops of Adora's golden hair, still damp from the shower, rolling the honey strands and then pulling from them softly, bouncing in Adora's back gently.

"Thank you, for doing that with me," Catra whispers, her warm breath crawling over Adora's cheekbones, surrounding her completely with its sweetness.

"Of course," Adora sighs, a content exhale swift and cool around Catra's ears. Catra's eyes are shimmering as she looks up at Adora, and if Adora wasn't pressed so close to Catra right now, she would have missed the small whisper fluttering out of her mouth, tiny and hesitant.

"Are we going to be alright?"

Adora stares at Catra's unsure face among the dark of their room, all precious nose and dear freckles and her heart swells with so much love she doesn't even know what to do with it, how to express it, how to whisper it among Catra's skin so tenderly it won't scare her but so full of want it will make her feel safe and sure.

"We will," is all Adora manages to murmur back, instead, lips ghosting already over hers, not touching yet, running her knuckles over Catra's cheekbones to lull her in. "You got me, and I got you, and we are together. Whatever happens now we will face it together" Adora cups Catra's face between her falls, heartbeat picking up from where Catra grips the fabric of her shirt too, brushing right where her heart is, so carefully and sweet almost as if she was caressing the real thing between her fingertips. "Gods, I love you so much."

I love you too, is what Catra means to say, but Adora is already leaning her way and Catra is meeting her in the middle. It tastes sweet and warm and all kinds of heavenly, sinking past their skin and deep into their bones.

Adora sighs lazily around Catra's lips, leaning back just enough to take a breath she doesn't really need and dive back in, stars gravitating together. Catra grins between kisses, pressing their mouths together again and again, lips brushing as dove's wings, tasting Adora's smile in her breath and her tongue. Salted as the sweet but so unbelievably tender, like morning dew in a flower.

Adora tears herself away off Catra's mouth just so she can run her lips over her face above the bridge of her nose and across the arch of her eyebrow, catching her scent with the tip of her mouth, her hands pressed flush across Catra's back and the low of her waist, holding her close to her.

Adora twists a little on their embrace, just enough so she can rest on her back, pulling from Catra at the same time so she is nestled up in her chest, never once letting go from her.

Catra grumbles and then giggles at the touch of Adora's lips brushing the shell of her ear, blindly searching for her lips again into a lazy kiss. She wishes she could keep going, her belly turning into knots and toes curling at a particular *something* Adora does with her tongue against her teeth. But she feels slow and drowsy, mind fogged and she knows she is just about to fall asleep again.

Adora must feel the sleeplessness in Catra's mouth too because she grins, nuzzling Catra's face with her nose until she is completely tucked on the angle of her jaw, breathing honeysuckle sweetness on her neck.

"Sleep, my love," Adora mumbles, also heavy and sticky like molasses, sleep starting to crawl into her too.

Catra makes a tiny sound on her throat that sounds kind of like a purr and kind of like an *Te adoro* before relaxing completely inside Adora's embracing, snoring softly under her breath. Adora smiles, tiny and looped, mumbling a quiet reaffirmation too before floating in another kind of sea too.

Outside, the rain completely lifted around the house and the hurricane is over and everything is calm.

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On the morning of the eighth day, Prime Kurr stands in the middle of his ship's chamber, looking at the screens that occupy the front wall. They show the images taken by his drone's cameras, of the Salineas' waters and the reefs and Ports around, scanning the waters like vipers. Rain has been keeping from searching for too long and now that the hurricane has fully passed he is not disposed to wait a second longer.

His suit is perfectly tailored, expensive and heavy white fabric perfectly placed over his body. The shoes are shining white leather too and the small emerald on his green tie shimmers with the light of the screens. Hair perfectly placed, not a single strand out of place, Prime is the vivid image of composure and rectitud, of someone that has everything and wishes for more.

His face throbs where the burn has taken his skin, sticking flesh and bone together, staining him forever in red.

Prime grinds his teeth together at the shearing pain crossing his face and past his skull, covering it all into a painful fog. He tests the flap of his suit jacket open and pulls out a golden container from it, quickly snatching a pill and swallowing it whole dry. It won't take away the pain it never does, but he takes it anyway, rage swirling on his chest with each take.

The door of the ship's chamber slides open behind him just as he composes himself again, one of his men walking in with tight steps. The ship is not nearly as big as the yacht was but it is just as disgustingly expensive so, for now, it will do. As long as he gets what he owns, he will make do.

“Sir?” the man calls, several feet behind as he should. Pathetic, all of them.

“Speak” Prime snaps, sharp and quick, never once taking his sickly green eyes from the calm waters images in front of him.

“The hurricane lifted, sir. The ports are chaotic right now and the lifeguard is too busy with the material damages to keep an eye on the sea. It should help us as cover from the maritime security”

Prime doesn't answer but satisfaction starts to wash over him. He is not far away, not nearly, it won't take any effort at all to go to Grayskull shore unnoticed.

“Hordak and his brothers, have they reported yet?” Prime questions around a sly grin that the man can't see.

He waits but it's only met with silence, uncomfortable and hesitant, heavy with something unspoken. Prime frowns, displeased to even have to repeat himself. He turns to face the man sideways, who has his eyes darted into the ground, sweating profusely from the frown and the upper lip. Pathetic indeed.

“Well?” Prime pressures, lip curling over his front teeth into a scowl. The man jolts into his own body, clearly shaken by whatever that he is quieting down before finally opening his mouth and speaking.

“We´ve heard from them. Our men are bringing them into your property” he manages, words tripping with each other.

Prime turns back to the screens, eyes bright. “Bring them to me as soon as they arrive, I must speak with them immediately" The man sputters behind him, choking with his own saliva and it's enough for Prime to finally snap, turning on his ankles to face the man completely, voice taking a very dangerous tone. “What is it now?”

“They are dead, sir,” the man blurts out, face pale. “Baywatchers found their corpses dragged by the tide near the limits of Salineas with Plumeria. They ruled it as a hurricane causality but the forensics report also signaled an attack by sharks” he crosses his eyes with Prime's, looking down immediately after. “They got mauled”

Prime's clever thoughts come into a stop only to pick up again with much more intensity. He doesn't even care about the dead men, or their butchered bodies or their blood on the water.

"And the woman?"

"Nobody has found her body."

Ah

"I see” Prime turns around again, a grin making its way in his mouth. “Leave”

The door opens and closes again, drowning the chamber into silence. It's mostly empty, his collections and prizes gone by the hand of one single, stupid girl thinking love would fix everything. But Prime does not need them, not as long as he gets what he has hunting for his entire life.

Prime opens his jacket again and pulls a second thing from it, a thing square carefully wrapped on a green silk handkerchief. Prime unwraps it enough to see through the picture, golden hair red under the sun, silver eyes like hellfire, angelic face as deceiving as the devil themself. Too beautiful, too sinful, too perfect to touch, too desirable to not have.

“My dearest Adora,” Prime rolls the name on his tongue like sacred wine. “We finally meet”

He starts running his pale fingers over the sharp edges of Adora's face, down the bridge of her nose and the angle of her jaw.

"Don't you worry, dearest, all of this will be over soon. You'll finally be where you belong." His fingers run down the hollow of the picture's neck, hovering for a second in the golden collarbones, untouched. "If you know what is best for *your* Catra, you'll know the right thing to do."

Prime runs his fingers down the photo's edge, circling the curve of breast barely hiding by the fabric of her red dress. His smile grows and stitches on his face.

"Either way, I *will* possess you tonight. In any way, you'll be mine”

♡

At midnight of the eighth day since the hurricane started, Glimmer is awakened harshly by a hand on her shoulder, shaking her alert.

It's a pity, because Glimmer is having a wonderful dream, fantastic, extraordinary even. It involves Bow and glitter and for some reason also balloons and she is having the time of her

life on this little unconscious space until Dream Bow's voice stops singing karaoke and starts mouthing something much more serious until it finally manages to break Glimmer awake, blinking confusedly at the link room around her.

"What– what is it? Who do I have to kill" she blurts, speech slurred by sleep. It takes her a couple of seconds but she finally manages to make sense of Bow's silhouette hovering above her on the bed.

He is also kind of a sleepy mess, all heart shirts and hot pink crocs with pajama shorts, but she also looks much more awake than her. In fact, he looks way too alert, staring down at Glimmer with something much more like dismay on his face.

Not good.

"Glimmer. Glimmer, it's the sea. There is a fire at sea," he is saying, voice cracking and high pitched from how frantic he is. It's enough to slap Glimmer back into reality.

She shakes herself awake, rising from the bed so swift it almost seems like she teleports from one side to the other of the room, already turning on her computer to connect with the bay's number and the security cameras on the ports. She is wearing a lilac nightgown and has rolls in her hair carefully placed before going to bed, but it doesn't matter, tapping quickly orders as she scans the seas.

"What part of the port is it, Bow? Also, can you go and wake up my mom and dad? I'm trying to get in touch with the night shift at the lifeguard but the connection is still shit after the storm."

"No, Glimmer, no," Bow is saying behind her. This time, when Glimmer turns to look at him she can see he is clearly shaking, looking at the window of the bedroom and back to Glimmer frantically. "It's not the town's port"

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asks, straightening from the desk. She can already feel dread running down her back.

"Come see," Bow mutters, grasping Glimmer's wrist on his hand and guiding her to the huge window, the curtain already pulled all back.

From the Bright-Moon manor Glimmer can see, at the right, the shape of the town, a little bit bruised after the hurricane but intact, drowned in darkness until one by one all the lights of the neighborhoods start to turn on, people walking out to watch too. Beyond them, the ports are quiet and calm, sea lapping softly over dark sand for the first time in days.

At the left, Glimmer can see the far, faraway shapes of the hills and meadows that lead to the limits of Salineas, where the old lighthouse once used to be. And, past them, there it is. Red and green and killer. Unnatural. The tall hellfire, violent and cruel, all things devourer, rising from the shore there. The shore– Catra's shore.

Catra's shore is on fire.

"Fuck. Fuck, fuck, fuck. Fuck!" Glimmer curses, scrambling in her feet to reach back to the bed, searching for her phone between the sheets.

She finds it rather quickly, it is already buzzing to life with dozens of messages from the town, from Memrista and their friends and also even from her dad, somewhere on the other side of the manor they are both in. But Glimmer ignores them all, opening the speed dial and calling the same number that had been haunting her for almost a month now.

Catra's number rings and rings and nobody answers and Glimmer calls again. One, two, five, ten, a dozen times. It rings and it remains silent.

Glimmer is aware things are moving around her right now. Bow turns on the light and glues to his own phone, calling every single rescue team and paramedic he can manage to reach. Angella walks into the room and speaks to Glimmer, who doesn't even answer and then to Bow, both of them getting to work in moving this quickly. Micah walks into the room too, also in pajamas but halfway into a rescue uniform. Neon yellow with purple looks weird, even for Glimmer.

Micah asks for Catra and Glimmer doesn't know what to say to him, speed dialing in loops as she tries to get changed into some leggings without letting go from her phone for a second.

Ambulance sirens and pedestrian cars are already gathering outside the manor, getting organized on how to move right now. For a town that hadn't got out of their homes in a week for the weather, everybody is quickly on their feet right now, all of them getting ready, all of them preparing to go into fire.

Glimmer fishes on the bottom of her purse, looking for her car keys before going outside too. Bow is waiting for her on the frame of the door and she has completely forgotten she still has the rolls on her hair. Nobody has told her either because she is cursing like an angry sailor at her phone, clicking the same button with almost too much fury on her tone.

"Catra, answer the goddamn phone," Glimmer basically yells, dialing again.

As if for some miracle, the call goes through.

There is a bit of static and then a weird cracking sound from the other side of the phone, leaving Glimmer frozen in the middle of her bedroom. She waits, holding her breath, not even daring to make a sound in case the call goes off again.

The cracking becomes a ruffle and then a stronger sound echoes in the speaker. A pant, someone is panting on the other side, heavily and hoarse. Scared.

A shiver runs down Glimmer's body and she is all but about to scream when the pant becomes a dry cough and then a voice, hoarse and tired and recognizable even in hell.

"Glimmer," Catra gasps, breathing hard.

Glimmer. Nor Sparkles. Bad, really really bad.

"Catra?! What the fuck is going on?!" Glimmer howls on the phone, panic taking the wheel for a second. Bow is by her side immediately, hearing the call with nervous eyes.

On the other side, Glimmer hears Catra take a breath, as if she were to say something, but suddenly stops. And then Catra gasps, all the breath leaving her lungs, and yells, loudly. It sounds as if something had hit something else and then a crash and something being dragged over pebbles and another drowned yell. Violent struggle takes over any other sound on the speaker.

Glimmer snaps her eyes towards Bow, paling until she feels like she is going to faint. She is gripping the phone with so much force the thin evide might just break apart on her hold. Bow shoots his hand forwards and grasps her by the elbow but he also looks sick, sweat covering his forehead as both of them listen helplessly.

Catra grunts angrily again against the speaker and then whimpers, terrifyingly close to pain. Glimmer is about to yell on the phone again when everything else is cut deadly short between the noise by another sound.

Something *screams* . It's a shriek, loud and sharp and terrifying as fuck, so strong it makes the bedroom's windows to tremble and the lightbulbs of the chandelier to break into little pieces. It rips through the phone and into Glimmer's ear, making her yelp in surprise and pain, dropping the phone onto the ground.

The call goes off and the room falls into silence, matching the sudden darkness from the broken lights. Glimmer doesn't move and neither does Bow, looking at each other without saying a word, chests heavy and ears ringing.

A long time must pass because outside the sirens go on and then go away, but they don't notice it because, suddenly, Glimmer's phone starts ringing again furiously. Catra's ID photo peeks on the screen with the call – it's a photo of her and Adora, in one of those rare occasions Glimmer managed to catch her off guard, arms around the other and soft – again and again until the call almost goes off.

Glimmer picks up the phone immediately, tripping in her face by how quickly she takes it. She answers and looks at the call going through, voice stuck on her throat. Before any of them can say anything, Catra's voice comes onces again, calmer and lower than the first time.

"Sparkles," she greets Glimmer now with her usual nickname, but her breathing gives her again. She is barely containing herself.

Glimmer has never contained herself though.

"Catra, what the hell was that sound? Are you alright?!" She exclaims, pulling from errand strands of her hair.

"I'm alright, they didn't hurt me. They didn't hurt me," and the way Catra says it is like she wasn't speaking to Glimmer at all. There is more rustle on her side and Glimmer swears she can hear a second murmur, speaking softly below Catra's voice.

"The sea!" Glimmer huffs, "Your side of the sea is burning up! What the fuck?!"

"Sparkles," Catra cuts her short suddenly, voice firm and suddenly strong. Thoughtful. Cold. "Call Micah for me. Tell him to send some lifeguard patrols to the sea down here"

Glimmer blinks at the phone, without understanding at all. "What- what are you-"

"Tell him a shark just attacked a pack of illegal hunters"

Glimmer gapes, looking from the phone to Bow's face. By his expression, Glimmer knows that he is thinking exactly the same thing, a dreadful shiver falling over them.

"Fuck, fuck alright. I'll call dad. And, fuck, I'll tell him to make sure that he brings paramedics for them too, I guess, and the port's security– "

"You don't need to," Catra states, and her tone quivers a little bit at the end. Not afraid anymore but something completely different. Sultry. Something so much more dangerous. As if she was, truly and completely, enjoying it. "They are all dead"

End of chapter VII

I am yours, more truly than I have ever been anyone's. Because when I'm with you, I'm me. Not someone I think I should be. And I'll be with you, however you want, for as long as you'll have me.

— *Husband Material,* **Alexis Hall**

Chapter End Notes

gasps like I didn't know the entire plot already

I hope you liked it and the wait was worth it! I'll see you soon for the next chapter (one more and the epilogue and then this story will be over ;.;)

Be good! ♡

For there will never be something as tender as the sun anchored to her sea

Chapter Summary

"I think there's been a misunderstanding. None of you are leaving this shore alive"

Chapter Notes

Vengeance

Catra and Adora have a very cathartic moment. They might also need a little bit of therapy but who doesn´t? >:]
WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
- Mentions of death
- Descriptions of manslaughter
- Descriptions of guns and weapons
- Descriptions of injuries
- Descriptions of violence
- Mentions of blood and gore
- 18+ rated

I know why are you all here. Grab your popcorns, snacks and gummies!! Time to watch the hunter get hunt!!
I´ve marked the start of the fight with **** so you can be prepared! Please be aware that this is a very charged chapter so take as much time as you need to read. Also, writing action scenes is so hard you guys!!
See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter VIII. For there will never be something as tender as the sun anchored to her sea

I'm in so deep that being with you feels like drowning and floating, all at the same time. You helped me find my way in the dark. And I'm terrified that I might not be everything you want, but I'm ready to dive into the fear if it means chasing every sunrise with you

— *Papillon* **, Sonia Palermo**

✧

Glimmer is aware that she is driving like a psychopath and she is kind of aware that Bow is holding for dear life to his seatbelt on the seat next to her. But, in all honesty, she couldn´t give less of a fuck.

The mud and the grass from the meadows is playing her a bad joke as she makes her way through the round paths that lead to Greyskull Shore and there is a light drizzle dripping over the roof of the pink van and the front window, somehow managing to sour Glimmer´s mood even further.

Beyond their spot on the path, just two miles ahead, the violent swirl of red and green flames is devouring the sand and the pebbles and the wood, rising like a wall on the spot where the house should be. The sky is burning, the very sea is burning, sizzling so violent and cruel Glimmer and Bow can hear it, even inside the van and the closed windows.

Behind Glimmer, the loud sound of ambulance´s sirens and dozens of cars rushing down the same muddy paths is breaking the heavy sound of the fire and the heated wind as they make their way too, as fast as they can, beaten only by Glimmer´s frantic drive.

The fire in front of them shakes alive by the salted wind and then, suddenly, stills like a fragment of time suspended in space where not even the flames seem to move at all. Bow and Glimmer narrow their eyes and hold their breath, staring, now close enough to the shore that they can see the way the burning sea starts to retreat on itself, quickly, chasing its own waves in a sudden frenesi, shimmering blue and purple and lilac from where thousands and thousands of deep water algae have made their way to the surface.

Cold dread starts to wash down Glimmer´s back and everybody driving to the shore right now as they all see the way the sea water starts to *roar* , rising and rising and rising until it rivals the very height of the fire itself, blue and silver against the raging hell. And, like this, it almost seems as if the water was pulled by something, a strand of moonlight chasing the waves, a comet's trail in the middle of the rising waves, shimmering with its own light where the water follows its chase until it and the very sea is hovering above the fire, hesitating for just a second before falling with all its violent might against the flames. A small tsunami drowning the entire shore, covering it all in bioluminescent shimmer

Glimmer lets out a shaky breath, blinking quickly when sudden tears start to cloud her vision. She doesn't even know why, even between all that is happening all the fear and the adrenaline and the anger. She doesn't completely understand but the sight of the sea fighting with all its might the cruel fire has made her terribly sad, sorrow falling over her as if the very rain falling against the car roof over their heads was mourning too. A loss, maybe. A mourning. Maybe. A sigh of relief, like holding your breath for a very long time until your lungs scream and your rib cage hurts and then, when you think the strained air in your throat can't last for much longer and your body and your heart weights too heavy for your soul, there comes a sudden breath of clean air, cold and fresh and full of *life.* That's how it feels, this sudden rain, these waves washing away the burning pain. That is how it feels.

Glimmer grinds her teeth together and steps on the car´s accelerator as far as she possibly can, gaining in return a deep grumble from the motor, a loud high pitched yelp from Bow and

definitely some kind of metaphysical scold from her parents somewhere behind their trail, speeding the last few yards towards the shore. Glimmer gives a dangerous turn to the right, skidding over the slippery ground and barely saving them from turning over the van completely, coming into a complete stop right after, frozen in her seat.

It's bad. It's really, really bad. The house is drowned in red fire.

The entire second floor is ablaze, red flames pouring out of every window, now slightly tamed by the rain the tall waves have brought with them, falling in heavy drizzle everywhere. The porch is on fire too, windows long ago cracked by the heat, outside cushions and wind chimes like torches. Dark smoke rises over the home as a dark omen while the firebird consumes everything it cans before the water tames it back down, huge and virulent clouds swirling around the shore menacingly.

It *smells,* like burnt wood and ashes and salt and something else completely different, heavy on the nose that makes Glimmer cough drily the second she steps out of the still rumbling car. She doesn't even bother to close the door, barely reasoning enough to pull the brakes of the car before she starts marching purposely over the sand, hellfire be damned next to her, Bow glued to her ankles with an equally determined but worried expression etched on his face.

The shore is *hot,* sand burning underneath Glimmer's glittering water boots, but the limit of the land and the sea is not on red fire anymore instead lightened by tiny bioluminescent creatures, and blue and lilac remains of fire, fueled by salt, still clinging to the seafoam. There is a strange sound surrounding the raging fire and the shore, hanging over the sea and the sand like the echo of a distant bell, harmonic and sweet but heavy. Like a song, unearthly. A warning.

Glimmer narrows her eyes between the heavy smoke and the kaleidoscopic lights all around them, trying to make sense of the misshapen shadows. The heat coming from the house is warming her cheek, burning slightly the very tip of the strands of her hair and it won't let her see clearly, numbing her sight completely.

“Catra?!” Glimmer screams at the top of her lungs, barely audible by some wall inside the house giving up and crumbling into grumble. “Catra!”

“Glimm,” Bow seizes her wrist so suddenly it's almost painful, digging his ankles on the sand and stopping Glimmer on her march too, barely managing to keep them from falling flat on their faces as he gulps heavily, staring at so point in front of them with wide eyes. His voice is trembling, cracking on the edges and absolutely terrified. “Glimmer”

“What?! Oh” Glimmer's breath dies on her throat, expelled completely as if she had taken a hammer to the chest, eyes glued to the same spot. “Oh”

There is *someone* standing in the middle of the shore, beyond the blue flames and the black smoke. The water reaches the figure's calves in strong waves, covering it in turquoise light and shimmering like starlight over the darkness that surrounds it. Or at least— at least what it looks like to be calves, because when the algae touches them it looks almost *wrong* . Curves where there shouldn't be, soft membranes like wings and thorns and seaglasses sharp as swords.

The chiseled curves that should make its hands are too long, dark like a virgin's palms drenched in holy blood, as dangerous as crystal brittle against silk. The skin is not smooth butter but black obsidian, reflecting the iridescent colors like mirrors, rising in some places and flat in others like thorns of a rose. The long hair is drenched in rubi ink, heavy and soaked in salt water, fluttering in front of an impossibly beautiful and terrible face.The factions melted against the darkness of the night, not a nose or cheeks or even a mouthon sight, nothing at all but the bright shimmer of two or maybe even a hundred eyes, red and cerulean, golden and silver thawing together in halos of light.

A spirit and an apparition and a demon, made of ink shadows and blue and golden light like a flame that has made itself of flesh and ichor blood, the origin of a myth or a ghost story. An angel fallen from heaven for being too sinful and too beautiful. Too curious and too rageful. Wings stripped from ethereal golden feathers only to leave behind the splendid jade coral and turquoise seashell, heavy and long that drag behind the figure´s back when the waves move forward and back, the trail of a comet from the middle of a starry sky into land. A crownless demon and a foreign´s god.

It is– it's indescribable. It just is. Like looking at what people from old times saw millennia back, when they had another understanding of the world and of the sealand and these sightings became their gods and their muses and their monsters too. Gorgon and nymph and sphinx and goddess and siren. Leda and Helen and Penelope. Circe and Hecate and Persephone. The object and the reason and the origin of poetry and war and death.

The figure is not moving, just standing there, and the full sense and understandment that whatever this is looking at them without even blinking falls over Glimmer, locking her cold in place. As if the shadow was considering them, a predator deciding whether to pounce forward and rip throats or stand still, defending. This is its land, this is its sea and its sand and even the remains of its blue fire, and by the fresh blood that drips from the figure´s hands, it would kill whatever and whoever tries to defile it again.

Glimmer roams her eyes through the figure´s shape, holding herself painfully tight to Bow´s hand. There is something cradled in one of the figure´s dark hands, in a touch almost too gentle compared to the horror of it all. It's delicate and long, the dark copper of someone's fingers laced tenderly with the figure´s, uncaring of being stained by the thick blood and the sweat and the water. And if Glimmer narrows her eyes in just a certain way she thinks she can see another shape tucked behind the figure´s shadow, hidden away and protected from anybody's sight by its tall and somber body. Just the mere glimpse of it makes Glimmer take a sharp breath, echoing across the rageful shore loudly.

The specter moves forward suddenly, among the red and blue flames that surround the shore and the house and with every step the shadows seem to melt away, as if darkness itself was retreating and falling off, dropping back into the sea water like heavy teardrops, splashing dark ink everywhere before dissipating away by bright sparkle,like a fallen star in a river. Like this, less cradled by the darkness, Glimmer and Bow can see it, *her* , completely. Tall and strong and unearthly beautiful in all senses. And absolutely frightful. A thin dress clings on her body, thin straps falling off her shoulders, ripped in places and damp with sea water and blood. Blood. It really is blood. Red like carmesí rivers, like pressed poppies against

marble or spilled wine over silk paper, staining the dress and her skin and the water swirling around her elegant ankles.

Glimmer gulps, holding herself to Bow, unsure if to walk forward or run far away or scream or drop to her knees and beg for mercy or cry. Before she can do any of it, anything at all, even close her eyes or breath, the figure takes the last steps towards them, showered now completely on the golden light of the still raging fire next to them, Bow exhales next to Glimmer, out of his chest almost painfully, his entire body shaking completely. Glimmer bites back a yell, taking a hesitant inhale of smoked air and trying very hard not to cough or faint.

Instead she gives an unsure step to the front, her heart hammering inside her chest and her tongue sticky in her mouth as she searches for the figure´s face, below all the copper stains and the matted straw blonde hair. Glimmer sighs, shaky, chewing on the inside of her cheek as she returns the sight of stormy blue and red eyes, the cold drizzle of rain falling over them in curtains.

“Adora?”

Evening of the eighth day

… five hours earlier …

Adora is— different.

She is still her, kind and full of curiosity for the world around her and wearing her heart on her sleeve. Devastatingly beautiful and immensely sweet. Her touches are tender and deliciously slow, careful on every caress she gives to Catra´s body and heart, kisses on skin and mouth, and songs like bells on ears. But there is something new about her, something she hadn't really let through before and that now is in full strength, untamed and uncontrolled like the sea outside their home.

Losing her skin had stripped her from something important, it had made her sadder, nostalgic from something she had thought she had lost. Mournful for the violence and the cruelty of being attacked on her own body and on her own home. Quiet and selfless and resigned and beautiful among it all.

Losing Catra, *almost* completely and devastatingly and definitely losing Catra, had broken her in pieces and ways she didn't even know someone could break before. Too painful to even bear, too full of sadness and regret and self harming guilt. *Too much.* And for those days where they were nursing each other and recovering, tending from wounds and bruised hearts and mist delicate souls, Adora thought she might actually lose herself. It had almost destroyed her.

But them, but *Catra,* it had saved her again. Over and over again. Sleepless nights on the nest that made their bed, whispering against each other's mouths, crying inside palms and lips, tangled on the other's limbs. It had only been a week, the first week towards healing and it wasn't perfect, they had a long way to go, but after everything – kisses on blue bed sheets and swimming in the sea together – something had settled in Adora, not changed, just bloomed.

She is tender but when is also *more.* She is blunt and territorial. Cocky. Feral. Seducing and fiercely protective. She is confident, strong and smart. She knows what she is, a creature of the sea, a powerful entity capable of bending flesh and blood and the very sea in her fingers if she wants it and she accepts it just as much as she accepts her life on land, with Catra, softer and kinder, dancing between two worlds where she belongs.

It's infuriating, it's mesmerizing, and it is unbelievably *hot* .

“So, let me get this straight,” Catra is sitting on the end of the bed, her elbows over her knees, rubbing her temples with her fingertips. The evening light is pouring inside and over the floor from the window, where Adora had plucked out the nailed curtains to let the fresh air come inside. Adora is standing in front of Catra, slipping inside a light blue dress easily, the beautiful golden skin of her chest and waist and legs cradled by the satin fabric like an embrace. Catra has to quite literally fight down a blush, gulping around a knot on her throat. “Your plan is to ambush them when they come, hunt them back and– eat them?”

“Yep!” Adora affirms, twirling in her toes in front of the mirror once before focusing her entire attention back on Catra. The muscles of her back and arms flex when she scrunches down to Catra’s height and it takes everything on Catra not to lose the grip of the conversation and swoon. "I mean— not really like, *eat* them, eat them but yes. It’s probably not going to be very nice anyway, but I'll manage"

Catra stares back at Adora’s beautiful face, halfway waiting for the moment she is going to break a grin and laugh because it is all a joke, but it never comes. She is serious, stressfully and brilliantly serious. Catra let’s her head fall inside her open palms, groaning in the back of her throat.

“Honestly, what did I expect?” she mutters to herself, biting back the edge of panic from her voice. " 'Dora, you know that I adore you, right?"

Adora's silver eyes soften immediately, tender and soft for Catra only, a loopy smile making its way on her lips as she nods. "I do"

"Okay. Then I can say this plan fucking sucks"

Adora's face falls immediately, tender doe eyes narrowing, a *way too kissable pout for her own good* turning up on her mouth. "Hey"

“Adora, this is— it’s not that easy. It’s not going to be like last time. They won’t just burst inside and ask questions–” Catra starts, voice trembling. She doesn't even realize she might just slightly fucked up until she sees the way Adora's eyes go from warm and open to suddenly cold, fogged by memories of a little bit over a week ago. Prime and his men hadn't just asked questions that time. The scars Catra and Adora bare on their bodies are testimony of that.

Catra gulps, breathing deep a few times to avoid spiraling down inside her own head and memories. Adora is there, too, immediately, taking Catra's hands in hers, rubbing reassuring circles on the back and over her palms, for Catra and for herself too. It helps the hammering

inside Catra's chest to calm down enough to keep talking. “They will definitely have some kind of plan already, Adora. Prime knows– he knows where to aim to hurt us."

"I'll protect you" Adora says in a breath, tightening her hold on Catra's fingers. Her human voice and song overlap gently when she speaks. It's been doing that for a while now, beautiful beyond any kind of measure, and the thought that Catra has the privilege to both hear it and understand it, to be the only receiver and reason of it, makes Catra's heart and lungs all kind of gooey and soft inside, even between the crescent alarm rising on her chest right now. "It's different this time, Cat. I have my skin and you have me"

They look at each other in silence for a second, Adora gentle and soft, a tiny smile on the corner of her lips. Catra tense and hesitant, a deep frown on her forehead, staring at Adora's bright eyes. A hundred and more thoughts are roaming free in her mind, memories and fears and the jarring desperation that she really doesn't know what to do next but to hold on to Adora and hope it will be enough.

Adora runs her fingers over Catra's forehead and across the short strands of her hair, nuzzling her lovingly with her touch. There is a scar on Catra's face, shimmering lilac and golden and healed that crosses the bridge of her nose, her eyebrow and all the way to the root of her hair, tinting with its light a lonely strand of Catra's hair in sunlight gold, a mirror of Adora's own.

Catra stretches her hand, brushing her fingertips over the silver scar that crosses Adora's face like lightning, from the middle of her dark eyebrow down her eyelid and just above her cheekbone, barely missing the eye at all. A long ago healed wound that had made her hurt and bleed.

"That asshole hunter almost slashed your face in two that time. It *did* hurt you," Catra whispers, shaking, and even if she knows that hunter in particular is dead now – mangled into pieces by the same knife he had stabbed Adora with and by the sea – she can't fight back the dreadful feeling that any of Prime's men will be up to be as violent and cruel as they possibly can if he asked them to.

Adora exhales slowly through her nose, resting her hand over Catra's, keeping her in place against the skin of her cheek. "They had already taken my skin from me when he attacked me. It's not the same"

Catra grinds her teeth and slips her hand away from Adora, not fast enough to jolt it, but with enough strength that it is obvious she is not happy about it.

"I don't like it," she says, bringing her legs up until she can hook her arms around her knees, hugging herself, her nails digging in the soft fabric of her strap shirt.

Adora winces at the sight, chest constricting painfully. She can't stand looking at her like this, small and worried, it makes her heart tremble with cold and her body to flare up with anger. Anger and rage, against the people, the men, that had caused them to be weary and paranoid in their own home. Against their actions and their violence and their greed. This is Catra's and Adora's home. It's not fair.

Before she can even begin to explain herself, though, Catra runs a hand across her face, blinking hard before focusing on Adora again. "Let's just– suppose they don't have guns or knives or fucking nets for you. What am I supposed to do on your plan?" Catra's beautiful eyes bore themselves on Adora's and the latter suddenly finds herself out of words, silent as she avoids Catra's sight which is, probably, the worst thing she can do. "Adora?"

"Um"

"Adora," Catra's tone is harder now, firm and snapping and just edging on that dangerous tremble that makes Catra sound like she is about to cry or to scream or both. Adora´s shoulders fall forward, the same kind of weight that hovers over Catra falling against her too.

“Can I convince you to stay home and let me deal with this on my own?” Adora asks, unsure, and she already knows what Catra is going to say before her colorful eyes widen and her pupils shrink into pinpoints and she snaps a very clearly and angry–

“No”

Adora closes her eyes into a firm line and doesn't say anything more, watching as Catra wets her dry lips with the tip of her tongue, snapping her eyes away from Adora´s and towards the ceiling instead, silently battling against the sour tears gathering on her eyes. Adora can smell them but she doesn't try to wipe them away, waiting patiently for Catra´s breathing to serenade and her heartbeat to calm down. She knows better than anyone about respecting Catra's boundaries and respecting her control over her own emotions, so she doesn't press further, drawing invisible swirls with her fingers over her palms quietly.

Finally, after long minutes, Catra looks back down at Adora´s handsome and precious face, a little bit wrinkled from where she is obviously painted in concern and the barely contained need to reassure Catra. Catra bites back a sigh on the back of her throat, balling her hands into fists around her legs ignoring the way her nails dig on the skin of her palms.

“I can fight them, Adora, I *want* to face them. What happened last time doesn't mean that I can't defend myself. And I can protect you too" Catra pushes the last part between a plea and a growl, all of her emotions mixing together and bubbling like boiling water on her throat, barely managing to keep them under control.

Adora kneels, scooting closer to her as she takes the balls of Catra's hands between her fingers, gently freeing them from their tight hold. Adora rubs gentle circles on the skin of Catra´s fingertips, stimulating the blood flow on the cold skin there. Her voice is also pleading when she speaks, barely above a whisper.

"I know, Catra, but– " Adora´s tongue feels stuck, heavy as if she had just eaten a spoonful of molasses. She grunts, clicking her tongue against her teeth, fighting with the fog on her own mind too. Her voice has picked up the tone, high and sharp and quick, stumbling words against each other, almost drowned as she says them. She doesn't know how to put all her worry and fear into actual words, not for the men luring closer and closer back to their home, but for Catra. The idea of more pain falling over her makes Adora, in all her confidence and feral strength, bend into herself, a feather against the wind. There is only one thing that could ever undo Adora completely, and that is Catra.

"Catra– I don't want to lose you," Adora murmurs, low under her voice, so different to this newfound confidence that fits her like a golden halo and so similar to the nights they've spent whispering fears to each other, when the tears and the blood were still fresh inside their home.

Catra´s face softens at the whispered confession, not able to fight it back anymore. She cups Adora´s jaw between her fingers, tilting her chin up so their eyes can meet again, silver and sea blue against golden and turquoise, both of them carrying the same worries and the same feelings, so sweet it aches them.

"I don't want to lose you either," Catra whispers back, narrowing her eyes, "But we agreed to do this together, and that means *together* . You need to let me do it, with you. If we are really going to do this and try to survive it you need to trust me too. Alright?"

Adora sighs, guiding Catra´s arms until they are resting around her shoulders, their skins rising goosebumps from where they brush together. They both know this makeshift and oh so craved peace was a gift, from life or from the sea or from some kind of goddess taking pity on them. And they know that, as beautiful and full of repentance as it was, it has already come to an end. They know their time is counted and whatever happens next will make them or undo them forever and that neither will let the other fall without fighting. Always trying to protect each other, always trying to save the other.

"Alright," Adora accepts, leaning her nose against Catra´s cheekbone, rubbing their faces together tenderly. Her voice is shaking. "Alright. We'll make it work"

"We will," Catra agrees, even if they both can feel how badly the other is shaking and how sweaty their palms are when they lace their fingers together.

They hold onto each other and don´t think about the fact that they really don´t have a real plan prepared. They don't have any strategy or map or any kind of steps sketched out for them to follow. This is not a land war or some kind of intergalactic battle. This is about abuse. An abuse that is, in no way and will never be, their fault.

This is about fighting the abuse of men, of humans, that think of themselves so much more than they are. That think they are worth more than any of what Catra and Adora can ever be. That think that they have some kind of right over their bodies and their homes and their lives. This is about fighting those very same men and their greed and their need of power, their want to possess something that can never be possessed, that should never be touched or greeded or defiled. About facing the violence and the cruelty they lash out with when they can't get what they want. Hurtful words and manipulations and physical pain.

Abuse, Abuse, Abuse.

There will never be a way to prepare or plan ourselves against abuse. It's not normal, it's not alright. How could there ever be a plan against that, when life is completely different. When life is not about fear or hurting or running away. When life is not about lies and malice.

Life is about slow dances on the kitchen floor, about golden sunlight coming from stained glass, about fresh and dry flowers on vases and book pages, about warm sheets in the

bedroom. Life is about both stormy and peaceful seas, about silk-soft sand and smooth pebbles on the ground and about flower blooms at the top of the cliff. Life is about morning markets in autumn, about strawberry cakes at three in the morning, about rain storms during gray days and about nightingales-like songs in ear shells. Life is about day-life problems solved with kindness and sweetness, about crystal tears wiped with tender fingers, about embraces after nightmares and shared dreams. Life is about love not about abuse.

There is not a plan to face abuse but there will always be strength to fight for love, in any way possible, and that must be enough.

And sometimes, most of the time, that abuse must be plucked out from the root.

Adora surges forward and Catra lowers down, lips catching together into their own kind of embrace, dancing around the other as hummingbird wings brushing in the middle of a flight. Adora kisses Catra with purpose, honey sugar on the tip of her tongue, mapping the expanse of each other's mouths and necks and shoulders with their touch. Catra kisses her back with all the blue fire that has always lived inside of her, melting worries and fears and pains away with the whole intensity of its heat.

Adora groans around Catra´s tongue, pressing herself closer to her, rising on her knees by the sheer impulse of sudden desire boiling on the pits of her belly. Catra´s whimper echoes on the roof of Adora´s mouth, arching her back against her strong arms when Adora leans forward over Catra´s body, painting kisses on her cheeks and lips and eyelids with tender care, full of all of the love and tenderness and passion they are capable to have for each other, that they have built on the other.

They hold each other on the edge of the bed, fingers digging on each other's cheeks and waist until they almost paint blooms on the skin there. Catra tangles her fingers on the soft strands on Adora´s golden hair and pulls, a tad too harsh and too strong, nails dragging down Adora ´s neck, rising goosebumps and red lines as river paths. Adora inhales and holds her breath harshly at the lustful touch, a deep rumble replicating on her vocal cords and the back of her tongue, hands shaking violently when she grabs a handful of Catra´s short strands and pulls too, gentler but just as full of ardent love. They are going to crumble under each other's sins and they are going to do it with pleasure, again and again, crawling across hell itself just to embrace each other again.

Adora wraps her hands around Catra´s thighs, over her black leggings, and pulls from them softly but with purpose, guiding them until they are securely wrapped around her own ribcage. Adora feels Catra pulling back, a questioning hum in her mouth, but Adora doesn't let her go far, pressing their mouths back together before taking a firm grasp and bringing Catra up, carrying her inside her arms in one swift swing.

Catra yelps on Adora´s mouth and then swoons, melting on Adora´s embrace completely, body tingling and shaking by Adora´s sheer demonstration of strength, quick and easy and full of fervor. Like this, Catra is hovering above Adora´s face, noses pressed together strongly, kisses sloppy and messy, damp lips and skin covered in flush like petals of roses.

The color of the sky outside is changing again, from the day´s blue and pink as cotton candy to bleeding red like blood oranges. The waves of the water are starting to swirl on each other,

fired up by the intensity of Adora´s kisses against Catra´s mouth. Yet everything is very quiet, silence falling over their shore, static like electricity over the ground, all the seagulls and seafoam quieting down suddenly.

Melog is curled up on a pillow over the bed, napping quietly and characteristically oblivious of Catra and Adora´s endeavors. A wisp of breeze comes from outside and across the window, startling Melog suddenly from their drowsy state. They raise their little head from where it is nestled between their paws, ears perked up and twitching with alertness. Their very blue eyes fix on the window, tail lashing wildly behind them, the fur of their back bristling furiously from one second to the other.

Melog sprints to their paws and hisses loudly at the same time Adora hears it too, loud like a bomb on her fine ears. She parts from Catra´s mouth with an exhale, snapping her head to the window, heart hammering inside her ribcage and her head. She lowers Catra back on the ground gently, always touching her, not parting from her nor a single inch nor a single second, her hands holding Catra´s waist so tightly close against her she almost leaves tender bruises behind.

“What is it?” Catra asks, voice in a thread. She sounds kind of windy, by the embrace or the kisses, but cold dread starts to shower down her spine. Her fingers close around the fabric of Adora´s blue dress. eyes jumping from Adora´s grave face to the window and back to Adora.

“There are cars coming down the pathway,” Adora´s human voice has melted away almost completely, song overlapping all the words, sweet still but adamantine and merciless, so sharp the mere sound almost cuts. “A ship coming this way through the bay too. It´s big”

The understatement of the words wash completely over Catra´s mind and soul, locking her in place. Adrenaline starts to pump inside her veins, kicking on and skyrocketing the rhythm of her heart. She feels herself tremble from head to toe without being able to help it, absently pulling from Adora backwards, closer to the door, mind running free.

“It's him,” Catra says and it's not a question.

“Yes,” Adora, pushes Catra behind her back, still holding their hands together. Her shoulders are thrown back, spine straight with all her powerful muscles on display beyond the straps of her dress. Where Catra is breathing heavily, almost panting, Adora is breathing very slowly, so quiet and gradual she almost looks like she is not breathing at all. Her entire body tenses and black scales start to sprout on her back, covering her like swan swings over her arms and temples and nape. Even her eyes change, the blue bell of her irises bleeding into red.

“Adora– “

“They are already here.”

Just as she says it, the unmistakable sound of wheels skidding over the sand and pebbles rumble across the entire shore and house, so loud they rival the very sound of the sea. One, two, three. Four cars, heavy sounding and expensive, stopping so abruptly and suddenly in front of the house like a fucking action movie that it's almost a miracle that they don't crash with each other or roll over themselves.

Catra can hear the way the car doors open with a swing and immediate rushed steps over the pebbles and yet neither of them, Catra or Adora, can do another thing but hold onto each other and almost count the swift seconds between the wheels and the next sound. Catra waits for a voice, for Prime´s voice, speaking loudly to threaten them with fake sweet and dangerous words. So much like that time when Catra was scared and alone, punched and thrown around by cowardly men and dragged out of her own house violently. She waits for it, holding Adora like a lifeline but also ready to push her away if needed. Adora is holding Catra in exactly the same way, both of them waiting for the next move or sound. There is nowhere to run anyway.

They wait for Prime´s voice but it never comes. Instead, there is a sizzling noise, high pitched and weird, aching on Catra´s ears as it comes closer and closer to them. She barely has time to exhale before the noise is followed by the red trail of a flame, dooming as it is threatening, ripping across the wind and tumbling across the open frame of the bedroom, so quick and dangerous they can't even start to try and stop it. The emerald green bottle attached to the flame crashes into hundreds of pieces on the floor and all hell sets loose.

Fire creeps over the tender wood like a violent bird, inflamed by the gasoline that was inside the bottle and that now spreads across the entire place. Monstrous bites and crawls devour wood floors and the nightstands next to the bed, rising over the bed posts as venomous snakes and incinerating the blue sheets like paper and into nothing. It's not there and the next second it´s virulent red and yellow and green, consuming the space that had become their home without a single thread of mercy.

Melog jumps out of bed just in time, hissing and rushing down the stairs with a loud wail. But Catra and Adora stand in the same place, watching horrified as the violent fire makes its way up to the ceiling, surrounding the chandelier there completely with all the fine crystals and seashells cracking under the heat's pressure. The bed is now completely engulfed by the green fire, eating the cotton and silk and feathers and rising dark smoke inside the bedroom, thick and heavy.

Another sizzling sound comes and crashes again, this time on the bedroom next door, down the corridor, setting the room into melting fire and spreading over the railing of the stairs and reaching the small door that leads to the attic. Below them, the loud smash of something crashes violently against the shut windows, maybe a hammer or a metal pole, breaking down the wood frames that lead to the living room just to throw inside another bottle full of gasoline, crashing and flaming up the first floor too.

It's fast and it's raw, making its way across every single inch of their home, every single corner and wall and picture and book and door. A sick mirror of the yacht Catra had burned down in a similar way weeks ago. Of the skin of a white face melting into bone. A sick revenge from a sick man, seeking to trap them like a Brazen Bull inside their own house.

Catra throws herself to the chair of the vanity before she can even begin to start thinking about what she is doing, grasping Adora´s iridescent skin from where it's resting there and between her hands, bringing it towards her chest. She curls around the soft scales and pearls, nuzzling the soft skin against her collarbones as she protects it as much as she can from the fire around.

Sweat is sticking Catra´s short hair to her head and nape, dripping down her temples and collarbones, and she is quickly covered in dark ashes from head to toe, staining her face and arms. Catra coughs, dry and loud, covering her mouth and nose with her hand and furiously blinking back angry tears falling down her ashed cheeks, brought out by the fire and the rage and the sorrow. No. Nobody is ever prepared for abuse. Nobody is ever prepared to be stripped off their home.

Catra gasps around a mouthful of dark air, straining her narrowed eyes to look around the room. Among the smoke, she has lost sight of Adora and it's making her panic very bad and very quick.

“ -Dora?” Catra tries just to dissolve into a painful fit of coughs. Her lungs are starting to fight the smoke, strained inside her ribcage.

A second bottle comes tumbling across the window and inside the room, this time towards the vanity and directly in front of Catra´s feet, crashing into glass pieces surrounded by flames. A pair or arms wrap tightly around Catra´s waist, yanking her from her place before the fire can even get close to lick her feet, across the door and into the corridor, heated up with the fire coming everywhere around them.

Catra tumbles with her own feet against Adora´s strong hold, holding herself to her arms, grinding her teeth and sniffling violently from the smoke. Adora´s face is next to hers immediately, her sweet breath overcome by the smell of salt and charcoal, the skin of her hand warm when she places a wet cloth over Catra´s mouth and nose, keeping her from breathing more ashes full of smoke.

Catra snaps her eyes back to Adora´s, wide and alarmed, tears gathering and dripping down without being able to stop it. Adora returns her sight, scleras drowned into black, but the bright blue or her irises are shining against the dark, beacons of light returning the same sorrowful gaze full of concern and anger and desperation. They are both scared, unbelievable so.

The rage of the fire is too loud on their ears, drowning any other sound, human voice or not. Adora takes a hold of Catra´s waist pulling both of them into their feet, never once letting go from the damp cloth against her mouth. Catra holds Adora´s other hand on a dead grip, nuzzling her forehead against Adora´s sunlight hair, tinted in black by ash and debris falling from the roof, holding to each other among the green and red flames around them.

They try to make their way down the stairs, stumbling against the wall when a fired up beam from the ceiling falls against the railing, barely missing them at all. The steps of the staircase are crumbling down under their weight, leaving nothing but holes and chipped stakes behind, broken into dozens of pieces by the fire that starts to crawl into the very walls.

The downstairs window is destroyed, bottle pieces everywhere, digging in the soles of their feet when they rush through the corridor and towards the kitchen, somehow still untouched by the fire. Catra tries to look out of the window but all she can see are walls of fire consuming her home, crashing the wind chimes into the ground and darkening her vision from the sight of the shore outside. Still, she thinks she can see the fogged shape of several

figures standing over the sand, just hovering there as they watch the unstoppable fire making its way across the house.

Everything is red and virulent green around them, lighting it all in a sick shimmer. Catra digs her fingers over Adora´s waist in a way it must be painful, but Adora is holding her in exactly the same way. Adora drapes herself over Catra´s back and wraps her arms around her chest, holding her close to her chest, acting almost like a shield between Catra and the flames.

Catra coughs, sniffling as she looks around the fired up living room and kitchen with increased alarm. She doesn't want to think, she can't let herself slip and think about what is happening right now. She can't because if she does, if she sees the burning books and their favorite couch in red flames and the ablaze piano and their pictures still on the wall, she might just break down and start to cry. In all of her nightmares, in all of her fears, she never thought it would come to this, that Prime would do this. She must have known but she didn't think so because there wasn't a single bone inside Catra´s body that was evil. As evil as the man and his men standing outside, watching it all fall down with sickly patience. Waiting for *them* to finally come out.

“Melog?” Catra calls out, voice hoarse and strained in her throat, trembling from head to toes in Adora´s hold. Catra looks all around them but no sound comes to her call. “Melog? Kitty?”

Bile starts to pool on the back of Catra's throat, the sour taste makes her almost puke on the floor. She is just about to start crying when a tiny meowl comes from the kitchen counter, drowned out and scared. Catra rushes from Adora's desperate hold, following another meow until she finally peeks on the counter, relief washing over her so fast it makes her dizzy. Melog is curled up inside the sink, little ears pressed back with their tail tight around their body. They are trembling badly and their fur is matted in places, pupils huge when they turn to look at Catra. For a second there, they are the same stray kitten, barely just a few weeks old, that Catra saved from the alley behind the orphan, young and scared. It makes her heart break.

Catra gathers Melog inside her own trembling arms, right next to Adora's skin, rocking them gently to calm them down as she looks up, towards the single small window that serves as ventilation for the kitchen. It's too small for either Catra or Adora to crawl through but not for Melog, and the fire outside and inside haven't reached its surroundings yet.

Catra rushes a tiny kiss over Melog's matted head and raises them towards the window, stretching her arms as far as she can to try and pull the lock open. It's too high and she is barefoot and the fire's smoke is clinging to her nose like a second skin of itself.

Adora is there, as always, right next to Catra. She stands on her toes and pushes from the glass, and when the lock doesn't give in she straight up punches it, breaking into a clean space, wide enough for Melog to jump through without hurting themself. A rush of salted breeze comes inside swiftly, making the flames on the living room to sizzle dangerously.

“Run, Melog,” Catra says, voice strained, pushing from Melog's little legs to make them move forward. Melog holds themself onto the frame of the window, turning their head to look back at Catra and Adora standing below them, gray faces and bright eyes. Catra bites into her upper lip and nods, encouraging Melog further. “We'll be right behind you. Go!”

Melog gives them one last longing look and then jumps down swiftly, running through the heated wood floor and disappearing into the meadows behind the burning house, just another shadow under the night.

Another wisp of air comes into the house through the window, raising the swirling black smoke violently. It hits both Catra and Adora directly on the mouth, making them stumble back into the corridor that leads to the main door, still closed, rimmed by a red light coming from the outside.

This time, Prime's voice does come. It's loud enough to be heard clearly even through the noise of the cracking wood and the fire, echoing through the walls where the flower wallpaper is being eaten alive by his fire. There is a ring on his voice, unmistakable. The tone of someone that thinks has already won, narcissist and mocking them, condescendingly slow almost as if he was talking to a toddler he considers stupid, and disgustingly sly.

"Adora" he calls, and the way he says Adora's name, rolling the syllables and vowels on his viper tongue makes Catra's inside to recoil, sore eyes hooked to the closed door. "I am so sorry that our first meeting had to go on like this. This needless waste is a pity, truly, but you really didn't leave me another choice."

Somewhere on the second floor a huge piece of the roof crumbles into dust, falling heavily on the ground. It's unbelievably hot inside and the smoke is filling every single corner it can reach. The house won't hold on for much longer. It is old, it has had a long life and it has survived wind and sea water and generations through generations of Catra's family. But never something like this. Never something done with the purpose of hurting.

"You've hidden for too long, Adora. And Catrina has had to take the fall of your cowardice. I know that, *you* know that," Catra can feel the way Adora goes absolutely tense somewhere next to her but the smoke is too dense for Catra to search for her face, blindly searching for her hand to try and reassure her amidst the very fire around them. "Please, come out, there is no need to drag this out. We can negotiate."

Every window is covered with flames now, every door and nook where they can slip through, all of them except the main door, where men are already avidly waiting for them to come out, ready for whatever thing Prime has ordered from them. Catra sputters around a handful of ashes on her nose, breathing hard.

"You know where you belong, you know what you must do. Don't you, Adora?" Prime´s voice is loud but he sounds just far away enough to be safely away from the rage of the fire. Of course, he wouldn't raise a single hand to the flaming bottles if that meant staining himself at all. "Come with me. Come and Catrina can leave this place in peace. Nobody will follow her, none of my man or me, you have my word"

Catra searches for Adora in the darkness, panic flaring in her heart when she can't find her or feel her near. For the split of a second, Catra fears Adora has taken the bait. That she has heard that bastard´s words and decided it was better for Catra if Adora sacrificed herself to that man, even after all the promises whispered on each other's palms, and Catra still has her skin cradled against her own chest like a mocking mirror of that horrible night on the yacht

many nights ago. Catra wheezes against the smoke and cleans the teartracks off her eyes violently with the heel of her hand, smudging the dirt on her face everywhere.

“Adora!” Catra can feel the edge of the wall next to her fingers, stumbling blindly against furniture scattered around. The very same paint of the walls is hot, boiling and melting down over the frames. “Adora!”

“ **Catra** ,” comes an exhale next to her, all melodic notes of a song and no human voice at all. Catra snaps her head towards the origin of the music, finally making sense of the shape of Adora´s body in front of the wall next to the door.

“Adora”

“ **Come here,** ” Adora extends her arm and wraps her long fingers around Catra´s wrist, pulling from her gently but firmly. There are claws on her hands instead of blunt nails, tinted in dark ink from the tip to the waist and all the way to her elbows, scattered in dozens of obsidian bright scales. The fire reflecting on them makes her look almost red under all the smoke, the polished surface of a rubi in the middle of the debris, a carmesí angel standing on green flames.

Catra trips a few times with her own feet, and she isn't even wearing shoes, grasping the fabric of Adora´s dress when Adora catches her in her arms. Her entire face has changed, long ears and black eyes and delicate membranes hiding away rows of shark teeth behind red lips. She is an archer´s cord just about to snap, body boiling hot and trembling as Adora holds herself back just so she can embrace Catra inside her arms, nuzzling her nose in Catra´s short and sweaty hair for the sake of having her scent close.

"She could live! Don't you want her to be safe?" Prime keeps pressuring outside. His voice is starting to slip, his perfectly curated tone drifting into undeniable anger and impatience, every single word cutting as a rusty knife against skin. "The only thing you need to do is give yourself to me"

Catra grabs the ends of Adora´s skin tightly between her hands and places it swiftly and carefully over her head, covering her body completely with it like a veil. The bright and beautiful blues and golden stars that form stardust over the skin start to shimmer and stick to Adora´s hair, her temples, neck, arms, waist and legs, melting into her as liquid mercury. Shifting and changing themselves until the skin and Adora are one and the same. Scales and dark pearls and sea glass cover Adora´s body immediately, sprouting and shimmering and breaking through, turning her into a swan and a demon all the same, sharp and dark and red between Catra´s fingers.

She is different from how she is with Catra. Instead of bright as a coral reef, she is dark. Dark as pools of ink swirling in gold and red, as fresh blood over rose petals and thorns like surfaces of arrows. She looks like the messenger raven of an obscure god, like a subterranean monster crawling from the depth of a maritime cavern, a threat painted in roman mosaics, venerated and feared in pagans shrines. Catra touches her shoulders and she almost thinks she can smell the incense and myrrh from her breath, can almost taste the poured wine and sacrifice mest on fire flames, almost can hear the drums that rumble with the beating of her heart.

Catra looks inside Adora´s eyes, red and sharp as swords, swirling in so many tones around the elongated pupils they are fireworks against night skies and comets breaking into the world's atmosphere. She looks at them and can see how, in the middle of the blackness that has drowned her scleras, her irises blurr and then *part* in the middle, stretching and stretching until there are two sets of irises inside each eye, red and golden and blue and silver, staring back at Catra´s face with all the holy and damned attention of a goddess staring at the mortal she fallen in love with. This is Catra´s saint and god and guardian angel. This is Catra´s Orpheus, crawling through the biting fires in the pits of hell to rip her off the very hands of death, with her damned and blessed song and her thirst for Catra´s mouth and for men´s blood, closing her impossible eyes and trusting Catra will follow her back into the light. She will.

Adora wraps her sharp claws around Catra´s narrow waist, pinching lightly the iridescent scars on her skin. Catra looks at her and she can see herself reflected on her pupils, her bright blue and amber eyes bearing themselves inside Adora´s soul. She is young and beautiful and angry and feral inside Adora´s hold, full of her own kind of flames, unbreakable even when the world is falling over her. She holds Adora´s monstrous body in the same way one would hold a tulip´s bloom or a falling star, pressing it against her lips and her heart. This is Adora´s adoration and soul and humanity. Her very life. She is Adora´s Eurydice and her Penelope, weaving the cords of her heart into Adora´s unearthly skin, making of their love her own tapestry to lay her body in. Adora will live for her and will follow her to death.

“Adora, your skin might just save you from the fire but I'm sure your dear Catra´s lungs won't be as safe as you are” Prime's voice sizzles as the fire in the walls. “Please, be reasonable”

Catra cradles Adora's impossible face between her hands, pushing away the long strands of her hair, heavy and soaked with black ooze. It drips and stains the skin of her hands, pooling on her palms and wrists too. Catra lowers Adora´s head until they are facing each other directly, noses pressing together. There is nothing in the space between them but charged air filled with smoke and magic.

"I need to go first," Catra says between her teeth and it is full of all the courage that lives inside her heart. Her hands don't tremble and her voice remains steady, looking at Adora's eyes – all of them – with all of her fury fueled by passion.

Adora's face falls in a way that rivales the very same fire in the house and the rumbling of the waves crashing against the cliff outside. Her hands twitch and dig further on Catra's hips, song dropping down until it is nothing but a growl tearing off Adora's vocal cords. " **No –**"

"Yes. You said you were going to hunt them down, so *hun. them. down,”* Catra growls pointing every single word under her breath. Adora gasps around Catra´s sweet smell, taking a swift, meaningful look to their home falling down into pieces, at the ceiling above their heads, at the broken windows and then back to Catra´s solemn face, obscured by shadows. Her eyes are hooded but bright, something deadly serious swirling inside of them, mirroring the darkness around Adora´s body. They are one and the same too.

“I am not sacrificing myself, Adora, I'm buying you time. You'll look after me and I'll look after you." Catra presses her palm flat over Adora´s chest, right above her heart, the other one

curling around Adora´s nape, flushing their faces together as close as they possibly can. Cold against warmth, night against stars. "Show them what you are."

What a privilege it is to be loved by something touched by sunlight. What a blessing to be caressed not only in the soft and perfectly crafted parts of ourselves but also in the all terrible, darkness parts of our souls. Who else would pray for Lucifer in hell but a lover cradled in tenderness.

Adora cradles Catra´s face between her black claws and kisses her, hard and deep, all soft lips and teeth clicking against teeth, salty and wet with errand tears. Adora tastes like smoke and like fire, copper and burnt on Catra´s tongue, her sharp teeth brushing dangerously slowly against her upper lip and the edge of her tongue. It is messy and desperate, the kind of kiss of a knight to a princess or a warrior to a lover, given in secrecy before going off to die in war.

Adora kisses Catra as if it was the first and the very last time, closing her divinely monstrous eyes tightly, pressing her nose against Catra´s, breathing her in deeply one last time before tightening her hold on her face firmly between her hands, guiding Catra's eyes back to hers with all the intensity she can.

“I love you, so much. More than anything” Adora says against Catra's mouth. Catra smiles, honest and wet from tender tears, nuzzling into Adora's claws like nuzzling to a soft pillow.

“I love you too, always,” Catra nibbles on the inside of her cheek, staring at Adora's face. There are so many things she still wants to say and so little time. “Adora– “

"Adora, do not mistake my kindness with forgiveness. You've both played a dangerous game and miscalculated your moves. And you've lost," Prime's voice is now edging very clear rage, scratching and hoarse when he raises it. "My patience has a limit and I will not be as generous when I run out of it."

Catra releases a shaky breath, blinking hard as they lean their foreheads together. It hurts to breathe, it hurts to talk and even to see but they won't fall here, not without their permission. This is their home, their land, their sea. These are their bodies and their lives. They are tired of being martyrs and they will not be victims of them anymore.

"Let's fuck them up," Catra whispers against Adora's cheek where she places a small kiss on the scaled arch that lives there, leaving nothing but warmth and sweetness behind. Adora chuckles against her cheek, deep and screeching like a crow laughing but tender, mirth falling swiftly over her, something only Catra is able to do for her, bringing happiness even in the middle of war.

Catra takes a step back, slipping out of their embrace. Adora wraps her hand gently around the delicate bones of her wrist, stopping her in her steps just so she can look at her, heavily and meaningfully.

"Be careful" Adora sings, and it's a warning and a plea and prayer all the same, weighing with all the words they had said to each other, all the reassurances and forgiveness and love they had given to each other. Catra smiles and nods back, kissing Adora's sharp knuckles with trembling lips and letting go of her completely.

"Always am"

They share one last longing look and then turn from each other holding their breaths. Catra hears the way Adora rushes through the fire up the corridors, jumping into the flames without a second thought, so swift and ethereal her steps are completely silent against the cracking wood, leaving nothing but the smell of salt behind her.

The fire has now made its way now completely to the lodge, closing further and further around the walls and the ceiling. Catra coughs on the angle of her elbow and walks until she is right in front of the main door of what once was her home. The wood is slightly inflamed by the heat, not yet reached by the fire, and the blue paint of the surface is falling down in tiny pieces over the ground. There is nothing around it but hungry red light and the lash of the wind outside against the inferno.

There is a horrible headache making its way on her temples and Catra grinds her teeth so hard her jaw hurts shaking her head once and ignoring it as she grabs the copper doorknob between her fingers. It hurts and she hisses painfully when the heated metal comes in touch with the frail skin of her palm. She doesn't let go, though, pulling from it until the heavy door moves further, opening fully from the fired insides to the porch outside.

The sun is sinking into the sea when Catra steps out, barefoot and covered in ashes, pulling back from its last golden rays and leaving nothing but the night sky behind. It doesn’t matter anyway.

Everything is red. The house is a beacon of fire in the middle of the bay. The sand is blackened by ashes and the pebbles reflect the fire in red and greens. The very shore is burning, tall and dangerous and absolutely terrifying. The limit between the sand and the sea has been covered in some kind of fuel, creating a red wall that keeps anything from running and trying to escape into the water, extending from the very rocks at the edge of the cliff to the end of the shore, where the path is closed off by white and heavy cars from where men are patiently waiting already.

It's hell on earth.

Deep into the sea, far away so it's safe from the heat of the fire but close enough that Catra can see it clearly even past the heavy smoke, there is a fishing boat. It is also white and clearly expensive, but considerably smaller than the previous yacht, a clear downgrade from Prime's obvious standards. It is small, yes, but it's also full of men. Illegal hunters, corrupt fishermen, murderers and killers, all of them ready to take down what they've come looking for.

There are five men in the sand in front of her house, placed on a half circle from corner to corner, cutting her path short. They are wearing heavy clothes and gauntlets, guarding them from the bite of the fire and their expressions are terrible, waiting over. The four that are on the corners have long trader poles on their hands, electricity sizzling from the tips menacingly, and nets hanging from their waists, held with heavy looking chains and steel hooks, the tips wide enough to be the size of Catra's thumb.

Catra recognizes the man in the middle, huge and built like a tank, rancid smell and sweat dripping down his forehead. It's the same gorilla that had slammed her against the wall that night in the yacht. If she narrows her eyes just in a certain way she thinks she can make out the shape of a scar on his head, where she had hit him before escaping. And he seems to recognize her too because his thin lips stretch over yellowed teeth, crossing his arms over his chest and poofing out in a way that makes the small gun held to his hip show fully.

Absently, Catra wonders what all of these men think are going to get from this. Money, obviously, but what else? Fame? Pride? Do they think Prime is going to share his prize? That they are all going to get a round with what Catra loves the most? Pigs. Bastards. Catra hates them all and she is going to kill them all.

Prime is in front of the shore, on the only square of land where the flames are small enough to not be a complete danger to him. He is, as always, wearing an expensive white suit, surrounded by two other heavy looking men as bodyguards, though he doesn't seem to pay attention to them at all.

His expression is sour when Catra walks out but it changes majestically the moment his good green eye takes sight of Catra, alone, standing on the steps of the house. It goes from impatience to rage to absolute bile, though he doesn't seem surprised at all, instead looking behind Catra swiftly before returning his gaze to her face. His eyes fall back into his usual condescending stare, even if his anger is obviously barely contained there, speaking clear across the shore.

"Miss Catrina," he says, almost as if he was greeting an old and good acquaintance and not the woman he had tried to murder merely a week ago. "What a pleasure seeing you again. And unharmed." Prime roams his eyes across Catra's body, taking in the healed scars on her face and arms. Her shirt hides away the wide shimmer on her ribs and back. "You know I am naturally curious so please, explain to me, how is that possible?"

Catra bites back the tight knot on her throat and the increasing need to throw up when memories hit her in the chest like a cannonball. She won't show just how terrified she really is, she will not. She will not let through how angry she is at seeing the very sea, Adora's sea, in flames. She will not let him know how the smoke of her house is clinging to her nose and throat. He will never find out the pain she and Adora had to go through because of his cruelty and his greed.

Instead, she smiles, sideways and void of any real kind of mirth. She gives a step forward and then another, walking down the steps of the porch until her feet are digging over warm sand. Four of the men raise their batons and make them sizzle at her but they don't move forward, buffling with a mocking grin on their mouths.

She ignores them, digging her eyes on Prime's as she shrugs with one shoulder, her smile stretching into a full grin clinging on the corners of her mouth.

"A miracle," Catra says, mirroring the same tone as Prime's. Condescending and mocking. It displeases him deeply because he grinds his teeth loudly, hands balling into fists at his sides.

"Yes, of course. And is, by all means, the angel that performed that miracle home?"

Catra's grin doesn't flatter. She doesn't move and she doesn't answer either, just staring at Prime's burned face without shame until he squirms angrily in his place, baring his teeth towards Catra like an animal.

Behind Catra a huge piece of wood breaks down on the second floor and falls loudly, sending a shiver of red sparkles towards the blackened sky. The smoke rising from the burning house trembles above the roof, almost as if it was being pulled against its will by something. The roof tiles bend and crack against a strange weight over them, complaining under the pressure. A low sizzle starts to ring across the house and the fire, echoing inside the now empty house and clinging to the very logs in fire. Sinister. Darkness starts to drip down the blue paint and the outside walls, heavy and oozing like ink, thick as it makes its way past the hissing fire and into the very columns, staining the entire length like blood rain.

Catra doesn't turn back but she can see the way something shifts in the eyes of the men surrounding her when they see it, when their human ears start to pick up the ringing but can't understand it or place it. The hands that hold the batons tremble, just a little, one the end of the handle and it only helps to make Catra's grin grow bigger.

She clicks her tongue against her front teeth and hums, walking purposely in Prime's direction until she is barely a few feet in front of the gorilla-man, blocking her from going forward with his huge chest and his black ire full of ire. Ashes are falling from the house, into the wind and the night sky, sauntering into the ground. Catra's footsteps leave white marks on the sand behind, little spots of white light among all the destruction. The ooze drips into the floor of the porch like ink waterfalls behind.

Catra tilts her head to the side, considering the man in front of her. Her eyebrows rise on her forehead, the grin in her mouth pulling into a firm line and then some more until it's a pout on her lips, considering at the man from head to toe.From the heavy chain on his hip to the gun - barely even secured inside the belt at all - to the huge end of a hunting knife peeking out of the cargo pants.

The men around shake themself out of their stupor and rush towards Catra immediately, closing into a tight circle around her.with their teasers turned on and hovering at inches from her body. Catra can feel the drum of the electricity on the fine hairs on her arms. Up on the roof of the house, the sizzling sound turns deeper, reaching the very foundations of the stones around the cliff, making the pebbles on the ground shake. The preamble of an earthquake that is about to explode. But the attention of everyone on the shore is focused on Catra and her only.

Good.

Catra barely spares a second look to the men and chuckles between her teeth, lifting her chin so she is staring directly at the man's face, the slow grin in her face turning nastier and sourer as the second go by, beautiful and dangerous all at the same time.

"What?” She says, loud enough that everyone can hear her but completely focused on the man. She looks at him between her eyelashes and blinks once, twice, turning her voice until it sounds disappointed, like a teacher to a toddler. “You still can't beat me in a fair fight, big boy?"

Catra knows she has hit the nail because the man´s face crumbles and turns into unfiltered rage, the skin of his face going from pastry white to pink to red to violet, sweat breaking into his face profusely when one or two of the men around them lets out a chuckle. The man steps forward and seizes Catra painfully by the short strands of hair that curl around her nape, pulling from her neck and face towards his. Catra stumbles a little on the sand but makes no other movement otherwise, trusting blindly.

"Little whore– " the man spits on her face, his breath rancid. Catra has to make a physical effort not to recoil back in disgust. Out of the corner of her eye she can see the way the man´s fist starts to level up and towards her face, no doubt about to strike down. Catra sucks a breath before he can even begin to try and spit on his face, saliva dripping down his nose and cheek. The man gasps and lets go of his hold on her by surprise, furiously cleaning his face with the back of his face. He is clearly not used to a woman humiliating him so publicly in front of the rest of the crew. Or at all.

"You are all pathetic fucking little men," Catra growls, falling back on her ankles without dearing to move further away. She knows the rest will strike her down – their laughs at the man have already died down by her insult and they are looking at her in the kind of way that makes every single woman in the world dead cold nervous – and being out of her senses is the last thing she needs right now. Instead she cranes her sore neck and throws her shoulders back, baring her teeth at the man. “Touch me again and you´ll lose more than your hand.”

The man sputters and looks like he is about to really hit her this time but the sound of Prime´s loud cackle behind them stops him. Prime throws his head back and laughs, clapping his hand purposely loud and slowly, one after the other several times until all the attention is back to him. He is *smiling* at Catra, crooked from where the burnt skin of his face doesn´t form a mouth anymore

“Such an admirable display of bravery,” he chants before falling back down from his high, voice full of poison. His teeth shine from where he bares them to Catra, green eye darkened by anger. It is the same stare he gave to Catra when she stole the skin from him. The same stare before he threw her from the cliff. “But I've grown tired of this. I gave you a choice and your Adora chose to send you to die in her place. You have chosen your own bloodshed," Prime turns towards the house, extending his arms to the sides, voice ascending into a bull blown yell. He is still smiling, huge and maniac, splitting his face in two different expressions. He is a psychopath. “Did you hear that, Adora?! I will make her suffer! My men will take turns on her and I´ll make sure you hear every second when she dies– !“

The most inhumane shriek breaks into the air, thundering over the entire shore and sea, across the fire and the smoke and the crumble of wood, shaking the earth to its very core. All of the men cringe with the sound, gasping and clawing at their own heads. The four men with teasers around Catra bend over in pain, screaming at the top of their lungs, dropping down their weapons when it's too much too bear, so much they dig their nails into their faces and scratch down, angry red lines painting on their skins by their own hands.

“What the fuck is that?!” one of Prime's bodyguards yells, slamming his palm against his forehead as if somehow that would be enough to rip out the sound of his head.

Catra stares at them in silence, unbothered, blinking back quiet tears of relief as she finally looks back at the house.

Their home is drowned by the fire but there, on the very roof over the attic, a dark figure rises, ripping itself from the red flames, born from the very same ink that peels off her own body. She is almost too big, as if she didn't fit the house at all, Asif she was made of the very column of smoke, as if, if she were to extend her hand and cradle Catra inside her palm, Catra would be nothing but a flower inside her ocean. At first, Catra thinks she looks like a bird, a phoenix standing up from the ashes of what once had been their only safe spot in the world. When she moves, sly and elegant like a panther over the roof, Catra considers she might look like a sphinx, beautiful and terrifying. When she straightens her back and the smoke and the flames and the skin on her body stretches with her Catra swears she sees fins full of thorns, long and huge and covered in obsidian mirrors. Fins and claws on her hands and her scaled feet so big they curlsñ as knives and sword, tearing down at the concrete and the roof tiles like it was nothing at all, and Catra believes she might be an angel after all, fallen into sulfur, ablazed again for her rage and for her love.

Catra gasps in awe and the dark figure that is her love snaps her head towards her immediately, following the sound like following the sun. In all her magnificent horror, she finds herself undone by a single thread of Catra's breath. She doesn't have a face anymore, no tangible factions for Catra to map with her eyes. There is only darkness there and where there was sunlight hair now there are wings, actual wings, feathered cobalt and golden rimmed, sprouting from where the bridge of a nose should be and it isn't, stretching open and wide until they curl over themselves over the back of the head, drifting with the wind and the blaze around her that doesn't seem to be able to even touch her.

She looks at Catra and, between the feathers and the darkness and the mist and the smoke, two eyes open, star-bright and huge and completely focused on Catra and Catra alone. Those eyes hold a thousand galaxies inside of them, swirling on themselves, supernovas collapsing and dying and being born again, dripping tears like planets over nebulas and then over antimatter. Devourer of stars, slasher of men, lover of the sun. And then, another set of eyes open, on the place where eyebrows and temples should be, shimmering like pearls and peacock feathers found on a goddess dress. And then another, on the height of the forehead, mosaics in floors and tapestries on temples. The very same darkness that makes her whole seems to blink with her where the eyes do not, circling each other like a crow around her head, multicolored and impossible, kaleidoscopic and devastating to even look at. Those eyes look at Catra, and when one of the men lets out a terrified shriek on the ground, they focus back on the men, all of them except the first, weighing Catra's body and movement until Catra smiles gently and tiny at her. A reassurance painted in colors for a deity made of sea salt and seafoam and prayers.

Catra looks at her hovering as a ghoul down the roof tiles and the walls and thinks about how Odysseus' men didn't stand a chance, siren crawling in horror and beauty. And how she was right this evening when she spoke to Catra between kisses, the men around them don't stand a chance either. And Catra wonders inside the depths of her heart if she – her love, her only love – is not something else, something *more* . Catra sees her body made of watercolors and seafoam and how it defies the very rules of physics in all her true form and wonders how is it that this marvel raised in thunder and on rainstorm really, truly decided to turn herself into

something so tender and small just so she fit inside Catra's embrace and in Catra's bed. She is ethereal and mystic beyond measure, she could have the entire world at her feet and yet what she chose, what she wants, is just to be as gentle as possible and have a kind life with Catra, a good life filled with love where they could grow old.

She really is a wish, fire herself, the child of a goddess and the sea.

Her shrieking song is still echoing in the shore, a chapel's bell falling down to hell. All of her eyes move until they finally find what they are looking for, an insignificantly small man quivering on his shoes, thinking he could trap lighting on a glass box. She looks at him, past the cruelty of the fire he had caused and his cowardly men almost kneeling on the floor in fear under the gaze of her divinity, straight into a green eye and a misted one, wide open and shrunken over beneath her. She sucks a breath that sounds like a tornado and speaks, her voice and song like a thousand and a million voices, one over the other, overlapping, melting, mixing, partying again, the melodic and obscure echo of all of her ancestors, on sea and on land. The echo of screams of innocents burnt on stakes, of the mother chained to the bed, of the young woman on the street taken as an object, of the child and the young and the adult and the elder, whores and sluts and witches, queens and warriors and sisters. Sacred gifts of the earth stained by greed. All of their voices overlap in hers, for all of what they've had to endure, ripping through hot air and the sprinkle of salt water turning green flames into blue fire, standing tall and beautiful and untouchable, even after everything, in front of her abuser. She is neither human nor man and this is not her demise but her rebellion and her defiance. This is her vengeance.

" ***Prime,*** **"** she sings and speaks and screams and paints his name, invisible vowels and letters made red lighting against the sky. She is calling for him, telling him she *knows* him and what he did, threatening as he threatened them earlier, warning him. She isn't even using the true reach of her song against him, isn't using it as she could. She is singing to him that she is going to kill him, that she is going to kill all of them, and that she is going to *enjoy* it.

“The earbuds! Use the earbuds you idiots!” The big man in front of Catra is screaming, fumbling with the pocket of his vest as he tries and fails miserably at picking up a pair of small noise canceling earbuds. The bodyguards on the shore and the men on the cars next to them do manage to dig them into their ears, sweating profusely and their faces red even when they haven't moved a single inch.

Adora snaps her nebula eyes towards the four men around Catra, all of them but the gorilla-like one, singing a low tune on her throat, a command and a suggestion only for them to hear and know, piercing as an arrow cleanly crossing the end of twelve axes handles. A death sentence spoken in the sweetest melodies.

The men's pupils wide until they are new moons inside their eyes and then shrink into pinpoints, eyes rolling back on their sockets until they are nothing but white scleras stripped in red veins. Their entire bodies tremble, shivering into an eternal goosebump before locking completely, until their limbs are limp over the sand, cordless puppets for Adora to play with to her desire. She makes a swift trill with her throat and the four men stand up, almost in slow motions, limbs and movements not connecting completely, out of sync between their minds

and their own bodies. Maybe this way they can learn what it is to be mangled in your own body when you don't have the power to say no.

They start walking across the pebbles and around the very fire, uncaring when the flames boil up the skin of their feet, reaching the wide and sharp rocks where Adora had hidden the very first night, stopping in front of them and just hovering there, like a devotee out of their mind, like a possessed sinner, like a killer about to meet its punishment.

Catra looks back from Adora´s ethereal body looming over them and back to Prime, scrunching her eyebrows in almost an apologetic stare. Prime is bleeding from the nose, stuck in place.

"I think there's been a misunderstanding," Catra chants, almost too brightly, raising her hands until they are at either side of her face, grinning when Prime´s good pupil shrinks. "None of you are leaving this shore alive"

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The men stand still for a second that feels like a century and then, all of them together and at the same time, start bashing their own heads against the stone. Again and again and again, rock against skin and muscle and then bone.

Crack, crack. *Crack.*

Blood splatters over the rocks and the sand in heavy drops, fresh and dark, mixed with tiny pieces of flesh and saliva and matter, again and again until bone gives away with a loud snap.

Crack

Somebody screams, maybe one of the men in the cars near the shore. Who knows? It doesn't matter because Adora is going purposely *slow* with this. Bang, bang and then more cracks, her voice and song beautiful melting with the gut wrenching sound of something squeezing and clenching down, mushed flesh and blood and teeth off their holes.

Squelch. Crack.

The four men go on and on until they physically can't do it anymore, until there is no more to crash against the rocks. Their bodies fall limps into the sand, mere inches from the ablaze shore, dark blood pooling around their bodies in silence. There are no more sounds coming out of them, not gasps from air or drowned screams or whimpers of blinding pain. Nothing at all. They are gone. They are dead.

The gorilla man is too distracted looking horrified and frozen at the bloodshed next to them to notice Catra sneaking her hand and taking a hold of the hook from his hip, wrapping the steel chain tightly around her knuckles. By the time he looks back to her, face contorted in ire and teeth bared in fury, it's already too late for him. Catra swings her arms back and punches him straight on the face with the hook, tumbling them both onto the warm sand.

The man lets out a drowned yell of pain, sputtering around a gush of blood from his mouth. The hook has made itself a home on the angle of the man's shoulder, digging its way deep into flesh. He falls flat over his back, head crashing painfully over the pebbles on the ground. Catra falls over him, knees at either side of his wide chest, digging uncomfortably on the too hot pebbles. In the house, something else snaps and breaks, throwing another gush of sparks into the sky. So close to him, Catra can smell the lingering stick of gasoline on his clothes and hands, testimony of fault. It had been him the one that threw the fire into her home.

Something red and obscure starts to bloom inside Catra´s chest, inside her veins and her heart and her entire skin. It's something dangerous, void of any kind of human moral and stripped off the fear that comes with it. It is something that had been rooted inside of her from years of abuse, first from that woman in the orphanage where sharp words and belts on knees and back and slaps on the face had been her childhood and her teenager years and the first days of her adulthood. Something Catra is not but that she will be for her love´s sake. Something that had been festering inside of the marrow of her bones from the moment she saw those hunters ripping Adora from her skin and slashing her body like meat, from the moment she found that very same skin hanging from hooks on a crystal box and the coffin that was behind it. From the moment men crashed on her home and pinched her and hit her and dragged her on the floor and up the hill and then down, down, to a sea that loved her but that couldn´t control almost killing her. Born from Adora´s desperation and the salt of her tears and the tremble of her body on Catra´s hands. It is hate, Catra is made from sunshine live but tonight, with the smoke of her home on her lungs and the lingering stink of blood in the air, she hates and for the first and only time, she is tired of holding it back.

Catra wraps her hand around the handle of the hook on his shoulder and pulls downdrown from it, slowly, dragging the sharp end over his flesh, ripping on her way tendons and ligaments and veins, barely missing arteries at all. The man is screaming next to her ear, trashing over the sand with his fists tightly closed, throwing blind punches towards Catra without really getting to hit her at all.

Catra grinds her teeth and lowers her head towards the man, gripping the back of his neck the same way he had just done to her, merciless and humiliating and painful. A few feet behind them, something heavy falls from the roof of the house and into the sand, sauntering and pulling herself over the pebbles and the flames elegantly, a shadow taking a form, a marble statue covered on ink, darkness taking the shape of arms and hips and legs crawling with feathered scales, limbs maybe too long to be normal. All of her eyes blink at the same time and it is as if the sun disappeared from the sky for the split of a second just to be reborn away in every irises.

The man sees her, slithering directly towards them, leaving a trail of ichor behind her steps. He trashes like a madman on the ground, kicking and lashing at Catra, loud curses spat to her face lost on the swirl of a terrified scream. Catra grabs his arms with both hands and pins them to sides, all of her strength fueled by her own rage. She can smell the scent of salt getting closer to her, a smell as known to her as dear and she doesn't feel afraid or tired or scared anymore. Adora´s impossible face hovers next to her, leaning over her shoulder and staring at the man's face. It's like staring to the end of an exploding volcano, where you know the boiling lava will reach you, where you know you are seconds about to die. Next to her, untouched by Adora´s horror, Catra feels above everyone. She feels like something *else* too.

Catra snaps her eyes up, directly at Prime´s, still meters away from them and shielded by his – shivering – bodyguards. Catra holds his gaze as Adora extends her claws to the man, one of them digging on the front teeth, across the maxilar, the other one gripping his bottom teeth and jaw, sharp claws brushing the back of his throat as she starts to *pull* up and down, forcing his mouth open with her hands as far as it can go and then some more and more and *more.*

Catra licks her front teeth with her tongue and doesn't look down at the man at all, staring at Prime's face when she throws back his own words towards him, acid and boiling skin.

“You miscalculated"

Adora pulls down one more time and rips the man's jaw clean off his face, falling pathetically somewhere on the ground by his feet. The tongue rolls out and he chokes on his own saliva and blood, convulsing swiftly below their combined hold before stilling completely, limp over the sand. He was the bigger one, sheer brute force, and so easily he is gone.

Catra has a split second where bile pools on the back of her throat when the smell of death hits her and the world swims around her with dizziness. She closes her eyes until she sees bright points below her eyelids and she doesn't feel like she is going to throw up anymore, opening them again without daring to lose a second longer.

Adora is already looking at her, all of her eyes focused on her face, huge and unblinking like some kind of unearthly owl, blown wide as new moons in an expression that is almost, *almost,* too endearing. Catra looks at her face that is not a face anymore and wonders just how weird it is that she kind of wants to kiss her right now, with her claws covered in blood and a dead man below them and she doesn't even have a mouth at all.

Adora must be able to read her like an open book because her eyes shimmer almost with mirth and she starts leaning inside Catra's space. Her ethereal body crackers sparkles like tiny fireworks when it comes close to Catra's skin.

It's their fault for being distracted, even the tiniest of seconds, because they don't see the way the three men in the cars take advantage of their distraction and charge at them at full force. A heavy net falls over Adora's body in one practiced swing and then pulls back, ripping her off Catra's side and dragging her several feet over the sand. Catra screams in anger, trying and failing to hold Adora's arm, and Adora screams back, struggling against the net with teeth and claws.

Adora sings loudly and rage fully to the men but it is of no use with the noise canceling earbuds, so she digs her claws on the knots of the net and tries to rip them off in half only to scream again when the net tangles against her body and the wings on her face, turning into vivid red with the mere touch. It's only then that Catra realizes this is not an ordinary net, crawling over the sand to try and reach Adora again. This net is made of raw steel with sharp thorns facing the inner face, and steel burns merfolks and any other fae's skin.

There is chaos on the shore. Fire on the house, fire on the limit of the sea, the lash of the waves more violent with every second, fighting off the flames as best as it can, salt sizzling with the heat. The lights of the ship look brighter the more and more it gets closer to the shore and is still staring from his safe spot, face split in two bright with a maniac laugh when

he sees Adora struggling and screaming in pain. The steel burns angry red lines on the obsidian scales of her arms and legs, falling off from her body in rivulets of dark over the ground.

The sound of her screams rips through Catra's eardrums, making her tear up violently, anger and hate rotting inside her heart. Catra scrambles on her knees over the corpse next to her, taking something from his belt before standing up on a rush, hit wind slashing on her face and the short strands of her hair.

Two of the men hold the net from the ends as the third one wraps his hand around the net that covers the wings of Adora's face, tugging and twisting them from them inside his fist. Adora howls in agony, lashing at him with her claws and sinking on herself when the steel touches her palms. Catra digs her ankles on the sand and stands straight, lifting the gun she had taken from the dead man directly towards the hunter's face, teeth clenching together and voice completely strained when she speaks.

"Let her go" Catra spits the words, narrowing her eyes, flashing with ire. Her hands don't shake when she holds the weapon, as much as she hates the use of them, she doesn't tremble or doubt, clicking off the safe pin from the back.

The hunter pulls from Adora's face painfully again, shaking her as if she was only an object, mocking Catra with a dry laugh. The other two follow his cackles, relaxing their hold on the heavy net just a little, too much confidence slipping on their bones as they stare at Catra with the most condescending expression possible. The first hunter scoffs,looking from the end of the gun to Catra's face with raised eyebrows.

"And what are you going to do with that, pretty?"

Catra shoots him in the face. Blood splatters over the ground and hisses against the fire where it splashes everywhere. The man falls on his back immediately with a muted thud, a surprised expression forever etched to his dead face, a red circle dripping from his forehead, where the bullet had gone through, and into his nose and mouth.

He drops the net when he dies and the two men behind jump back in shock too, also letting go from the ends with the surprise. There are drops of blood staining their entire faces too, from flushed wide to fresh red, marching the red of their eyes as they stare at their dead fellow in horror.

Catra doesn't even flinch **,** dropping the gun to the side as she throws herself to her knees and grasp the heavy metal of the net between her fingers, detangling it as gently and fast as she possibly can from Adora's body, hissing in sorrow when smooth scales and feathers and sea glass pool on her palms in black and golden from the ichor bleeding from them.

Adora hums around a pained whimper and curls around Catra's body, the touch of her wings gentle against the skin of Catra's cheek. Embracing her right now feels like embracing the very fog, the smoke swirling behind them from the devouring fire, flesh and mist at the same time. Catra wraps her inside her arms and even though the seconds are closing around them she doesn't let go, running her hands and fingers through new bleeding wounds slowly stitching themselves together, pressing her lips over smooth scales and fins like feathers,

uncaring of the pinch if Adora's claws when they close around Catra's ribcage, keeping her close.

One of the two men reacts faster than the other, throwing himself over the gun Catra had dropped carelessly into the sand. She wasn't really thinking at the moment, she just wanted Adora *out* of that net. He leans back, lifting it to the height of his eyes and in the direction of Catra's forehead, pointing finger running over the trigger with a characteristically click. Catra's eyes widen in the split of the second where she thinks she is about to die, holding her breath and cradling Adora tightly against her chest, and then she hears the loud bang of the weapon going off. She sees the end of the cannon and then she swears she can even see the bullet, copper and shimmering against the light of the fire, flying off it in almost slow motion. And she can feel the way Adora twists in her arms, too fast for Catra to even catch up on.

The bullet crashes against blue golden skin with a rip and then falls silent again. Catra exhales, trembling from head to toe, her eyes fixed in Adora's extended arms and the end of her hand, balled in a fist around the bullet after she caught it midair. The face of the hunter is absolutely astonished too, looking as if he couldn't believe his eyes. As if the realizations that they are all actually fucking with a god has finally begun to fall down.

Adora makes a displeased sound with her throat and crushes the bullet into pieces between her fingers, hissing just s little when the small steel burns in her palm. She opens her hand and lets the frail pieces fall into the ground, infinite bright eyes ripping their way inside the man's shivering soul when he looks back. The wounds on her limbs shimmer and close completely, leaving nothing but healed scales and sea glass behind.

The hunter gapes, barely managing to make a sound at all before Adora swings that very same hand and slashes his throat open with her nails. He gurgles for a few too long seconds and collapses into the ground next to the first one, unmoving.

The third one of the group is already standing up, looking in horror without making a sound. He shakes himself of his stupor the second Adora and Catra turn their eyes towards him, palming his clothes until he finds what he is looking for, a radio held from the back of his belt that sizzles with static when he turns it on.

“What are you all doing, you fucking idiots?! Get down here right now!” he calls from the radio with a yell, never once taking his eyes off them. Catra roams her eyes towards the sea, staring at the ship as it roars back to life from where it had stopped. They are closer to the line of the fire over the sea too so Catra can see clearly the shape of at least another ten other hunters running around over the ship, tripping with their feet.

Adora stands up in a swirl, deliberately slow, looking at the man below her on her entire height. Catra stands up too but steps a few feet back, looking exclusively at Adora. Half of her eyes are narrowed towards the men, the other half considering him lazily. She tilts her head like ink in water and Catra sees the flash of something familiar to her in the middle of her kaleidoscopic eyes. It's something she saw barely a day before when Adora was swimming perfect circles in the sea and an expression that was always there when Adora used to sit on the window and watch the violent water under electric storms. It's this newfound confidence in Adora that has had Catra's breath and tights seized since yesterday.

It lets Catra know that, for Adora, this little man in front of him isn't a challenge at all. By the way she cranes her neck and tilts her head to the side, waiting for the man to do something else but quiver inside his pants, Catra knows that by this point Adora is hunting him for the sake of *fun* and who is Catra to not step back and enjoy watching her enjoy herself? She is already having kind of a sadistic moment right now anyway.

"You can't control me, bitch" the man says, pointing at the earbuds on his ears. "I can't hear you"

Adora hums, not singing or talking, just thoughtful as if she couldn't quite decide yet exactly how to kill him. She approaches him dangerously slowly, sliding over the sand without stepping on it at all. She walks until she is directly in front of the man, who looks too scared to even begin to think to run or do something at all and Catra has to bite a chuckle because with all those *brave* threatening words, there are tears in his eyes.

Adora finally stops in front of him, hovering there for a long second before surging forward, quick as a serpent, gripping the sides of his face between her claws. Her sharp nails dig on his temples, rivulets of blood washing down his forehead and into Adora's wrists, dripping on her clawed feet. Adora makes an annoyed sound, grips tightly and then pulls down, ripping the man's ears straight off his face. The earbuds fly down and lose themselves on the pebbles below

"Can you hear me now?" Adora asks, voice sizzling and beautiful and brutal.

The man's screams are so loud it makes Adora's eardrums ring uncomfortable. She let's go off him, dropping him into the ground by her feet unceremoniously. He tries to crawl away, slipping over sea water and his own blood but Adora stops him in his tracks, tangling her claws on his hair and pulling up, moving her head like a hunting owl looking at a mouse.

" **Are you afraid?"** Adora howls like a banshee, throwing each word at the man's face and brain and very soul.

He shakes his head up and down as best as he can between her ripping hold, struggling without getting nowhere. "Yes"

The columns that hold the porch up on the house crack in half and crumble down the sand with a loud wail and the entire house seems to whimper with it, engulfed completely in black smoke and unrelenting fire. One of Adora's eyes turns towards it, the others still firmly placed on the man's. As much as he tries to close his eyes, he can't hold on much longer under her gaze. And he doesn't represent a challenge at all under her voice.

"I think you should walk into the fire"

The man wheezes, pathetic and frantic just once before his pupils blow up, black overcoming completely the white. Adora lets go from him but it doesn't matter anymore because he stands up on his own, stepping on his own teared ears as he marches towards the fire that has extended from the house to the start of the cliff's meadow. There is a panicked moment there in his eyes on the second right before he steps into the flames completely and then he is devoured by the same fire they had caused, flesh boiling and life leaving his body.

Cards is breathing hard, clenching and unclenching her hands at her side, looking at the way the wings around Adora's face curl against her nape and the curve of her collarbones and then uncurl against, shaking themselves off drops of blood. She remembers having seen paintings of siren's on old tapestries and vases in museums and books. She was never a stranger to creatures, it was a part of her job as a writer, a part of her as she found herself strangely attracted to their mysterious and dark world since she was a teenager. But seeing it in full display in front of her is another thing completely.

She knows she should feel terrified for what is happening. That she should feel nauseated and dizzy at the sight of torn flesh and fresh blood on Adora's hands. At least, she should feel kind of bad for the bloodshed they are doing, but she can't find it in herself to care. She can't find remorse inside her heart or inside her mind. Maybe that makes her a monster too, but she knows what thoughts were swirling inside the men's minds before they learned they couldn't win this. She knows exactly what they wanted to do with her and, most importantly, with Adora. Catra won't feel bad for their deaths.

Something starts vibrating violently on the back pocket of Catra's legging and only then she realizes she still has her phone with her. She takes it without really thinking about it, looking at the bright profile picture of Glimmer insistently on the screen. It must have been ringing for a while now but between the struggle Catra hadn't noticed it earlier.

She stares at the screen smeared with ashes and blood and runs her finger over the answering button without really thinking about it, blinking slowly once, twice before speaking.

"Glimmer," Catra gasps, breathing hard, flinching at the dry rasp of her own voice. Adora is staring at some point above Catra's head, her song sizzling as static across the hot breeze of the shore, tingling on Catra's ears like bells, tearing off as shrieking screams for anything else. She narrows her multiple eyes, dark chest increasing its rhythm.

" *Catra?! What the fuck is going on* ?!" Glimmer howls on the speaker, clearly out of her marbles.

Catra frowns down at the phone because, quite honestly, she doesn't know how to explain. Catra can see her own reflection on the black screen, eyes sunken and rimmed in lilac and red. There are ashes smeared everywhere, from her forehead to her cheekbones, staining her skin in gray, and the men's blood has splashed little spots of red over her chin and collarbones. Her clothes are soiled and her hair is sticking in short curls everywhere from the sea breeze and the unbearable heat and sweat. Catra looks at herself and thinks she looks a little bit in shock and absolutely manic.

Catra opens her mouth to answer something, anything at all, at the same moment Adora's eyes go wide and her dark shark teeth click together loudly. Catra sees Adora moving forward, throwing herself on all the terrible beauty in Catra's direction, her arms extended as if she was to embrace her or push her out of the way.

Catra hears Adora scream, a shriek so loud and so filled with terror that it stops the beating of her heart inside her ribcage for a second. But she can't even begin to think about it because one of the bodyguards that had been guarding Prime all of this time charges out of the black

smoke at full speed and tackles Catra past the line of the fire and into the burning sea behind.

"Catra!"

Here is the thing. Catra can't, definitely, breathe underwater. Theory discarded.

The ring of Adora's scream still echoes inside of Catra's head when her body hits the water. Water starts filling her mouth, ears and nose immediately, drowning every other sound around her but the rush of the strong water and the fast beating of her own heart hammering inside her brain.

Dread starts washing over her as the memory of *falling* and water on her lungs overtakes her for a moment too long for her own good, locking her body in place. For that moment she feels herself dying again, bleeding inside the water with nothing to hold on but the infinite on the sea around her and the darkness, raw and unfiltered darkness on her gaze, around everything she could look at. She is back into a violent sea on a violent night and she knows nothing but to sink down and let herself be taken away.

Except that, tonight, it is not that night. She *survived* that night as she survived all of the worst nights of her life before. Tonight she isn't falling from the cliff and it's not storming outside. Tonight what is pulling down from Catra aren't rocks or waves but the hands of a man pulling from her shoulders and her hair. Tonight there is a fire in her home and tonight Adora is fighting for her life on the shore, *they* are fighting for their lives, for the peace and freedom they promised to each other. And they promised each other too to not give up. Catra closes her mouth tightly and reminds herself not to breathe and opens her eyes, ready to fight back.

Catra can't breathe underwater but, oh, she can *see.*

Instead of the overwhelming darkness she had expected to see all around them, the world is bright and it is beautiful. The water is turquoise and cobalt around her, tiny specks of bioluminescent algae floating on and around her feet and her face, brought to the surface by the increasing waves fighting off the fire on its limits. Where there was blackness before, now there are colors, dozens of them, colors so bright and so much Catra head spins at the sight of them. She can see multicolored fishes swimming quickly away deep below her feet, scared off by the fight and the fire. And past then, Catra can even see even the floor of the ocean, coral reef and marine rocks and sand. It looks as if the very moon had fallen from the sky and into the sea, illuminating everything in silver light. Everything is and looks beyond beautiful, a watercolor brought to life, a gift from Adora's skin living in Catra's body now.

Catra blinks and then blinks again, taking on the marvel around her before being violent shaking off her daydream by a harsh pull from her shoulder. The bodyguard that had knocked her over is below the water too, face pudgy from where the lack of air and the pressure of the water is making its way inside his lungs too. He is gripping Catra's shoulders so tight it hurts, leaving marks on her collarbones from where he tries to take a grasp of her neck, seeking to asphyxiat her. But he is looking for it clumsily, blind inside of what, for him, is the darkness of the water.

Catra grinds her teeth together and claws him in the face with her nails, pressing her thumbs over his eyes and kicking at his torso and rib cage until he lets out a drowned yell, huge bubbles breaking inside the water from his mouth. Catra takes the impulse inside the water and kicks him again, this time directly in the chin, feeling the way the bone gives away with a satisfied crunch. His left hand shoots immediately towards his jaw, silently yowling around a mouthful of water and blood from where he had bitten his own tongue. But his right hand is still tightly wrapped around Catra's wrist, crushing the frail bones there until Catra whimpers, scratching the skin of his hand to try and break free.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra sees something swimming at full speed towards them, fast as a rocket. She barely has time to register the shimmer of green and golden before the bodyguard is snatched swiftly and violently from her side and all that Catra can see next is red.

The surprise makes Catra sputter, taking an accidental and painful gulp of seawater. She kicks away, finally free, around the reddened water quickly remembering that as beautiful as she might see things now she still doesn't know how to swim. Desperation is starting to make its way under her skin when she feels another grip under her armpits, too tight to be gentle at all. Before she can begin fighting again the grip pulls from her forward, without struggle at all, pulling her face out of the water completely.

Catra coughs around the water, running her hands over her face to clean away the salt from her eyes. There is fire a few feet next to her, still raging over the sand and against the seafoam, reflecting over the lashing waves like a red sun. The surface of the water is hot and it is uncomfortable against Catra's skin where the now dead and mangled man floating somewhere near the shore had scratched her, and her clothes are sticking to her shoulders.

"Adora? Adora" Catra wheezes out, still out of breath and winded from the hit and the water still lingering on her mouth. The grip on her armpits is still harshly tight, steady and there. Catra blinks until her eyes stop burning, searching for Adora's dear face.

Instead, she is met by someone completely different. Green scales crawl over the temples and the forehead instead of blue and golden and dark. The skin of the neck and the shoulders is almost copper under the light of the flames next to them, traveling over strong arms and a wide torso and losing itself on a tail shorter than the one Catra had almost just met. The skin is soft and spotted in places, seal-like but just as strong as sturdy as sea glass and gold. There are no wings or sunlight, long hair on the head, exchanged by long and lilac fins that are born from the bridge of a nose, through the temples and all the way until they curl behind the head almost as horns. The mouth is wide, full of sharp teeth across the very cheeks, covered in thin membranes that flutter with every touch of the water.

The touch on Catra's body is different too, firm and sure yes but unattached, keeping her from sinking down again just for the sake of it. Catra takes a sharp intake of air and stares back at the eyes that are looking intently at her. These eyes, however, these eyes she knows. Silver and blue and so similar to the ones Catra so much loves. Catra sees these eyes and knows immediately who she is looking back at.

"Adam," Catra gasps, unable to say anything else.

Adam frowns at the name but nods, once and dry, looking from her bruised up face to the fire and then back. The gills on his neck shackle when he sings, guttural and raw, feral than the song of his sister but just as enchanting, filling through Catra's mind as every word becomes clearer for her than anything else.

" **Teela and I will get rid of the ship** " he is singing, looking back at the open sea behind them.

There, on the surface of the ship, illuminated by the fire and the lighting above their heads, Catra can see another figure. Violet and orange and blue, as huge as Adora, the sound of her song breaking through the lash of the waves, sizzling and cutting and beyond terrifying too. The wings in her head rival the length of her tail as she throws herself over the ship, ripping the hunters off one by one and dragging them back into the sea with her. Catra can hear the creams and the sounds of the struggle as she butchers every single one of them, easy and without struggle. Unlike Adora, she is feasting and Adam will join her soon enough, sinking sharp teeth on warm flesh and ripping arteries and veins, chewing and biting and chomping away until there are only bones for her to pick on them.

Catra exhales, heavy and shaky, tearing her sight from the butchering to look back at Adam, nodding once at him. Before he can swim away back to his mate, Catra seizes him by the arm, the skin of her palm brushing the smooth scales living there. Catra swears she can feel the way the skin of her own ribs, where her scars are, tingles at the touch, as if recognizing its brothers too. By the way Adam's eyes widen, Catra thinks he can feel it too.

"I am going to protect her," Catra says to him, without shaking or stumbling on her words, sure and steady as a promise, as the bow she carries in her heart and the ring that wraps in the finger of her hand. True as it could ever be and filled with all the conviction that can leave inside of her, that she will not hesitate to cover herself in blood too to keep the one they both love safe.

Adam looks back at her with his black eyes charged in some kind of shared meaning between them and then hums, narrowing his eyes with something that almost looks like approval.

"I know you will . " He pulls his free hand out of the water, placing something on Catra's scratched up palms, cold at the touch and sharp. Cares looks down at it and hisses , running her thumb over the surface. It is the broken end of a harpoon, knife sharpened and lethal, weapon of men passing from a selkie into Catra's hands. Catra wraps her fingers around the handle firmly, pressing her lips into a firm and decided line.

Adam swims her back to the shore, as close as he can without leaving the water once, into an opening between the fire from where Catra can crawl through without burning herself.

" **Go** " Adam growls in her ears and lets her go, sinking back into the water and swimming immediately away, leaving only a trail of green light behind. Catra can hear the loud and terrified screams coming from the ship picking up suddenly and the way the metal seems to start bending on itself by an unknown force, tripping the living rest of the crew into the water and right inside the avid claws of the hungry siren's below.

Catra hears it all the entire time as she makes her way through the wet yet warm sand, searching frantically around the shore until she finds what she is looking for.

To Catra's horror, Prime and the last bodyguard, the only remaining men on the shore, have managed to take a hold of Adora, ambushing her by surprise when the now dead one knocked Catra into the water and Adora was too busy screaming and rushing forward no notice the heavy steel chain coming straight towards the back of her head, knocking her just for enough seconds for them to hold her down.

The bodyguard is holding Adora's clawed feet with his hand, struggling as he tangles the remains of a broken steel net around her ankles, just as he had done across her wrists, keeping her from clawing his heart out of his chest. The metal heats up and burns her skin at the touch, vivid red and boiling hot, scarring skin and burning off feathers and scales. Adora is yowling in pain and in fury, fighting and kicking and struggling back with all her might, but her body is screaming with her by the pain, weakened at the touch of the steel.

Catra looks up and her blood freezes inside her veins at what she sees there, heart coming into almost a stop by the fear and the sheer anger. Prime is holding Adora from the back, his chest pressed flush against her shoulder blades. One of his hands is tightly gripping the end of a hook cruelly embedded on Adora's shoulder, keeping her in place enough for her to yell every time she moves even the smallest of inches, golden ichor dripping heavily down her arm and into the sand from the wound. His other hand is holding up the length of a steel chain, and it is with a turn of her stomach that Catra realizes Prime has *muzzled* Adora with it. The chain digs painfully inside Adora's mouth, gagging her, crossing from cheek to cheek, past her fin ears and across the back of her head where Prime keeps his hold firm, pulling from silk hair until ichor starts dripping from it too. The metal sinks in the frail skin of Adora's mouth and face, burning there too until Adora is narrowing her eyes in blinding pain and her eyes are dripping with crystal tears, unable to hold them back.

There are feathers and scales and sea glass everywhere around where she is, falling in rivers from where the steel is burning them off and where Prime and his man have ripped them off by their own hands. Their hands are stained in gold too, testimony enough of their cruelty. Adora is almost unable to move, being by the shearing hurt or the shock or the anguish running through her entire body, too tired from the pain, limbs and her very skin screaming. Her wings have almost completely fallen off and the remains of her blue dress are soaked in blood, red and tale telling of a night of horror. For the fraction of a second she is the same lonely siren, angry and scared out of her mind at the limits of this very sea, being dragged away in the arms of men against her will.

Prime tightens his hold around the chain even more, purposely dragging from the steel hook when Adora tries to fight him off again. He is soiled from head to toe in ashes and sweat, and he presses his serpent mouth against Adora's cheekbone when he hisses a very low, "Behave" sending a shiver running down her entire body.

Adora's eyes fix on the man tugging from her ankles and doesn't even see her coming when Catra crashes with all her strength against the bodyguard, colliding with him and sending them both Catra and the man stumbling over the sand. Adora gasps, a drowned whimper that barely sounds like the song of Catra's name at all, watching as Catfa rolls over the sand

immediately and turns towards the man, slashing down something sharp to his face without a second thought. The man has barely a few seconds to react, zigzagging over the ground and making Catra lose her stab by mere millimeters, the end of the hook digging on the pebbles and sand instead.

Prime keeps his hold firm and doesn't let go as Catra grunts, low and feral, out of her godforsaken mind. She is soaked from head to toe and her white shirt has turned red from the bloodshed, the colorful eyes Adora so much adores wide and frantic, looking at every single place as she hunts for the man in front of her. She growls under her breath, scrambling over the sand to grab the handle of her weapon again, knuckles white from how hard she holds it, swinging it back to the man with renewed force.

This time, however, the man is ready for her because he rolls to the side and kicks her right between the chest, sending her tumbling to the side with the violent hit. Adora whines and struggles without use, her skin trying and failing to heal her with the steel still over her body, watching uselessly as the man stands up from the ground and turns towards Catra, kicking her in the ribs so hard something cracks loudly. Adora can hear it all the way to her place, wincing and bending on herself as the hit echoes inside her own body like a shadow.

Catra bends over her own body and drowns down a pained yell, crawling at her sand around her fingers as she blinks back tears off her eyes, spitting a gush of blood from where she bit down her own cheek so hard she bled herself. Adora sees as the man goes back and rises his feet to kick her again but Catra jumps at him, pushing away the flaring pain of her rib so she can kick him on the knee, almost cracking clean his patella in two with the hit.

Catra stands up and reaches for her weapon at the same time that the man reaches for something on the back of his belts, wheezing and cringing by the pain on his knees. Catra sees the movement out of the corner of her eye and turns towards him but he is faster than her for the fraction of a second as he takes a hold from the hunting knife hanging on his back and stabs Catra on her right side, swift and painful.

Adora screams around the gag on her mouth, song ringing out of control and drowned out by the burn of the steel against her tongue, a shrieking ***No*** and a ***Catra*** and a blood curdling howl, all of them mixing into the most, singular anguish whimper, ripping through her heart and chest and making the very water shiver, rising in height until it rivals the very fire.

From her place Adora can only see the back of the man hovering over Catra and the way her love's eyes widen with surprise, exhaling heavily, her sight clouded by the sudden pain. Prime is chuckling next to her ears and Adora wants to kill him more than anything but the steel hurts too much and she just can't rip the gaze of her eyes away from Catra's dearest face, not for a single second.

She watches as Catra's breath gets stuck on her throat, her eyes looking swiftly towards Adora, swimming in tears and fogged. She is pale and a cold sweat has made its way in her forehead, all of her freckles like tiny suns over her skin. Adora loves so much and Catra loves her in the same way right back. Her eyes seem to carry all her words and all the love she feels for Adora, overflowing off her heart and into the very sand, reaching Adora even though they are so painfully torn apart. It's and *I love you, I love you, I love you* without words or sounds but loud between them, a language and a song only they know. Adora can see it inside her

eyes when her gaze settles back down and she tears her eyes firmly but painfully from Adora's just so she can wrap her hands around the collar of the man's jacket with newfound anger in her heart.

Catra grinds her teeth so hard they chip and pulls from the man's clothes, who hasn't moved a notch for a few seconds, grunting and tugging and tugging with all her strength and making them stumble both over slippery pebbles and moving sand and the very fire, fighting to her last breath. They fall across the heavy and dark smoke coming from the house, losing themselves from sight completely.

Adora can't see them anymore, can't see Catra anymore. The only sounds coming from the place she and the man had disappeared through are the cracking of woods and the struggle of a body falling heavily on the ground, grunting and whimpering and *gurgling* and then the fire is drowning every other sound away with it, deafening Adora, keeping her away, *away and what if she is suffering, what if she's gone and Adora loves her more than anything, Catra is her entire sould and Adora wasn't there and what if –*

Adora struggles like a wounded animal on Prime's hold, suffering and full of mourn stained with ire, uncaring if the hook drags down her shoulder and arms until the pain flares like lava on her bones, uncaring of the steel chain on her mouth and the protest of the bone of her jaw forced open, spitting saliva and ichor. She lashes and fights and kicks at the nets tangled on her claws, trying and failing to sing, to scream until her lungs are the ones screaming on pain. She feels the way Prime just twists the strands of her hair until strands fall over his fingers ripped off cruelly from Adora's scalp, and brings her even closer to him, flushing the side of his face completely against hers. He smells like sulfur and fire and expensive colony, mirth on his voice when he speaks to her, whispered yet loud enough to be heard clearly. He is enjoying it, he is enjoying sees Adora suffer.

"We could have done this another way, Adora" his breathe is rancid and it smells like charcoal from where the melted flesh in his face never healed properly. It makes Adora recoil. "I warned you, I showed you and your *Catra* my mercy and you spit on it. Have you seen what you've done? *You* made *me* do this! It's your fault!"

He doesn't give a fuck about his mangled men death on the sand or in the sea. They are only tools for him to dispose off and he doesn't care what is to be their fate – he hasn't even realized his ship is gone. *Adora* doesn't even know her brother is *here* – He doesn't care about the burnt house or the shore ablazed by his own fire or losing his face or his possessions because he finally has on his hold the very same thing he had obsessed for since he has a young adult with too much money and too much greed wanting to possess something that couldn't and should never be possessed in the first place and at all. He has the siren, beautiful and deathly and held down against her will and he pleasures himself from that, *proud* , thinking he is right and that he has the right to do this, to take this. To stain this

Prime lets go from the handle of the hook, still holding the chain tight between his knuckles, confident and full of his nasty, sick pride festering in the belief that he has already won. He roams his free hand down Adora's sharp collarbones, past the falling feathers and gills on her neck and the smooth scales and sea glass of her shoulders, down her fluttering ribs and above her abdomen, scratching ivory lines with his nails where the satin fabric of her dress barely

manages to cover her at all. He wraps a handful of the fabric at the height of Adora's hip, gripping so hard the material protests and almost rips in half. That's what he wants.

"I'll make sure you understand that your place is beneath me" Prime rolls out his tongue, locking a line over Adora's cheekbone and the edge of her infinite eyes. The touch with Adora's skin burns his mouth like acid but he doesn't step back, feasting in the way Adora tries to snap her head away and recoils violently on the sand. "I'll have you in my bed, and when I get tired of you I'll have you on my walls. Even if I have to rip that tongue of yours out of your mouth to keep you quiet."

A ruffling sound comes from behind them, just a few feet away to be hidden from his line of sight. Muted steps over damp sand, quick and heavy, purposeful, their sound drowned lightly by the roar of the fire and the lash of the sea. By the time Prime hears them they are already next to him, rushing to the side and the forward, accompanied by a calm breathing, almost told calm. Calm and ready and full of untamed fury.

"Hey Prime"

Prime turns around and sees the way an arm swings down at him, the mirror surface of the hunting knife reflecting the flames when Catra stabs him violently and without mercy straight in the face.

One

The blade digs in cleanly from the side of his cheek, across the mouth, lashing the surface of his sick tongue and out again through the wall of the melted cheek, crossing from one side of the other without a single resistance, easy, as warm wax giving up under the metal. It is a sick mirror of the pain that he is inflicting over Adora washing over him, white hot and humanly unbearable, full of cruel purpose. It fills his mouth with fresh, dark blood, choking him as it gushes down his throat and drips over his chin and suit, turning the spotless white into bright red.

Catra grunts, teeth bared and eyes feral, gripping Prime's nape to keep him in place when he jolts on his own body and tries to slip away. The sudden excruciating pain makes him drop Adora's chain, tumbling her into the sand. Adora sputters, spitting the chain out of her mouth, her entire face numb and tingling with pain, sizzling where her skin starts to heal her but dripping with ichor still. She bites down on the pieces of net on her wrists and rips them off, looking up to stare at Catra fully.

She is covered in blood, from her neck to her arms to her clothes, like a marble statue covered in copper, but it is not hers. Adora roams her eyes over Catra's body frantically but doesn't find wounds, no slashes or stabs or bleeding gashes. Instead, in the place where the man had presumably stabbed, her shirt is slightly torn and the skin of her side is on display, smooth and gentle and porectet by siren skin, by Adora's skin. They are Catra's scars, shimmering like jewels and acting like a shield through which the metal of the knife couldn't pass. Saving her life.

Adora looks past Catra swiftly, where the smoke has cleared slightly by the sea breeze, and catches sight of the last hunter fallen on the ground, body locked in an eternal scream before

dying. There is the end of a harpoon stabbed into his mouth, past the teeth and directly on his throat, eyes bloodshot from where he drowned with his own blood before stilling forever.

Catra grips the handle of the hunting knife tightly between her fingers and *twists,* the blade cutting off skin and muscle on the walls of Prime's cheeks like nothing. Her screams, a gurgling sound as she spits out chunks of blood, staring at Catra, for the first time, with something very much like fear in his eyes.

Catra stands on her toes to lean her face towards his, in a very similar way he had just done to Adora, her breath hot and blood smelling against his face, speaking from in between her grinded teeth, every word charged with so much more hate than the one before.

"Does that hurt, you fucking swine?" She asks him in a vile whisper, twisting and twisting and then pulling off, cutting his mouth into a jarred and bloodied line, from ear to ear, his jaw barely hanging from the joint to keep itself in place.

Prime gags and convulses on his own body by the pakn, giving a stumbling and clumsy step back to try and escape away. Which is, on insight, completely useless because Catra is already swinging back, mind clouded with hate.

"Wait-" Prime barely manages to moan before Catra stabs him in the shoulder, deep and crude.

Two. The hunting knife is sharp enough to slash the heavy fabric of the suit and the flesh below, fueled by Catra's fury pent up inside her ribcage. She twists the handle and drags the blade down, across the deltoids and towards the elbow, mirroring the wound of Adora's shoulder by the hook, until flesh hands in shreds. Except that the blood dripping down now is not golden and holy but rotten and dark.

Catra growls around a scream and pulls back, throwing herself completely against Prime, knocking him into the sand and pebbles, crawling over him like a Fury all of her own, a goddess of vengeance clothed in red, splashing carmesí drops everywhere around them. After that, it's just the blood and her anger and her.

Three. A stab to the ribs, right below the curve towards the abdomen, deep and swift, past skin and into liver. Hatred turned to strength and fear becoming bloodshed.

Four. Into the left lung, barely missing arteries with surgical precision, ripping down and filling the chest with air and blood, lung collapsing on itself and poisoning the arterial blood, spilling down as broken wine.

Swing, swing. Swing. SWING.

Five. Six. Twice to the right arm when he tries to pull from her hair and claw at her face. She is so sick of men touching her, of *him* touching *her.* She saw that disgusting hand roaming down the body of her beloved and so she slashes the tendons into shreds and snaps the ligaments until they are mangled knots.

Seven straight through the palm, when he tries to slap her back. She is covered in blood, her shirt sticking into her skin, freckles sun and shimmering scales. Adora was covered in blood the day she arrived at the shore, from wounds and hits and hands of men ripping her skin off her body. Catra hasn't forgotten about it, she has never forgotten it, always on the back of her mind ready to build up and explode as a furious and deadly volcano, taking and burning everything on its path.

Eight. Nine. Ten. Three more on the chest, one after the other, past the collarbones and pristine silk white shirt now covered in increasing stains of red, soaking the fabric. These aren't as deep as the others but are as full of anger, clinically placed in the middle of the mindless butchering. She is saving the arteries of the neck and the heart of purpose. Those are not for her to drink off. Those belong to someone else to tear from.

Eleven. He is struggling violently against the attack but she has pinned him down with her knees, holding him in place for her to do as she pleases. Catra is aware he is screaming like a bloody banshee below her as she digs the knife fast and relentlessly over his body, into the curve of his armpit where arm meets shoulder and where he is soaked, either by his own blood or by sweat. It rings on her ears and crawls on every single cell of her body, as hot as the flames that have devoured her home and as vile as the greed that almost took away her love. It reminds Catra of the blood curdling screams that had rang across the shore mere seconds ago, frightened and desperate, from the song of an angel herself in the hands of s true monster. It makes Catra lack any kind of guilt, slashing and cutting until she physically can't do it anymore.

Twelve. The last one is deep in the side of his body, across kidney and muscle and all the way across the lower back. This one is for herself too. For her blood spilled on the sea and the intense feeling of falling falling falling down without being able to stop it. For making her afraid of her own home and her own land. For every hit and tease and slap and kick as she was dragged across her house like a ragdoll. This one is for herself, because of herself, for all of that suffering she didn't deserve. She might not be throwing him off a fuckin cliff but she can make him *bleed.* What is done is done but she is the one that gets the last word. She is the one that says when it's enough .

Catra gasps, stumbling back with the inertia of her own body when she pulls out the knife from the last stab wound, spraying blood over her cheek and collarbones. She exhales heavily, cheeks damp from where she hadn't realized tears had begun to run down. She lets them be, pooling on her chin and dripping down her neck in errand paths, cleaning away blood and dirt from her skin. Her heart is thundering inside her chest, pumping frantically with adrenaline and now that she is not moving anymore, not sinking the knife again and again in flesh, her arms are trembling violently making even her teeth click against each other.

She let's go off the knife, tossing it red and bloodied to the side, several feet away from her. She doesn't want to see it ever again. She tries to stand up and step away from Prime's bloodied body, still convulsing and coughing blood everywhere below her. And still very much painfully alive. His white suit and shirt is completely red.

Catra gives a step back on the sand and loses her foot, feeling herself fall back towards the hard pebbles with a huff. A pair of cold arms shot forward from behind her, catching her inside them swiftly, breaking her fall and lowering her gently into sand. Catra wraps her hands immediately around Adora's claws, holding them close to her heart as Adora cradles her gently against her chest, pulling her feet away from the bloodied scene.

The burns around Adora's wrists and ankles are already healed, new scales sprouting quickly there, blue and obsidian and golden, soft under Catra's touch. The sight of it makes the tears in Catra's eyes fall even harder and she *sobs,* loud and cracking, heart wrenching, breaking in millions of pieces as she sinks on Adora's embrace. The tears make her sight blurry, fogged and dizzy even, and she can't quite place the air inside her lungs correctly but she can't slow them or stop them down. She is shaking violently from head to toe and it's a miracle that she hasn't puked already, and she smells terrible, to sweat and the fresh blood she is coated in.

Yet, between all of this, the blood and the tears and the sweat, Adora doesn't let go of her. Quite the contrary, Catra cries and Adora holds her even closer against her feathered soft chest, her long hands wrapped around Catra's rib cage, pressing her ethereal cheeks on hers in gentle and loving kisses. The remaining wings in Adora's body brush Catra's damp face, curling around her temples and obscuring her sight for a second, hiding the burning and bloodied world around them from her gaze even if just for a few seconds. Gifting her the feeling of their touch and their skins together until Catra's ragged breathing starts to calm down and she is not hovering on the edge of panic anymore, her heartbeat matching Adora's inside her chest, drumming and tender.

In front of them, Prime has started to crawl on the sand, bleeding out and yet still trying to find a way to get out of this alive. He looks kind of pathetic, like a worm crawling on clay, whimpering and gurgling with his own spit and tongue. Catra takes a ragged breath and tries to motion Adora upwards, muscles too sore to actually work properly, stumbling back to the sand unceremoniously. Suddenly she feels as if she weighed a thousand pounds, too heavy no move anymore. Adora understands her anyway, wrapping her arms around Catra´s waist and helping her up swiftly, her touch tender everywhere. All of Adora´s eyes are focused on Catra ´s – all of them – full of colors and bright as newborn stars, making sure she is steady on her feet before letting go of her completely, turning back to face Prime fully.

The sharp end of her teeth flash when she opens her mouth, a high pitched sizzle rolling off her tongue and into the very sand, raising goosebumps and shivers at its wake. Prime hears her because he goes hysterical over the sand, nailing at the pebbles and kicking furiously, sputtering something Incomprehensible when he doesn´t make it but a few inches away. His face is terrible, contorted and disfigured by the old burn and Catra´s stab gun, covered in his own blood. He looks just like what he is, a small, greddy man. A grain of dirt, annoying, under the sole of Adora's feet.

Adora walks towards him with muted steps, following him in silence when he makes another sad attempt to escape. She considers him for a few seconds, head tilted to the side, towering above his mangled body. All of her heavy, beautiful hair is coated in black ink and blood, dripping down her back and legs. Something flashes on the back of her starstruck eyes, red, settling in the bright rings around her pupils as she leans down towards him.

Adora wraps her hand around his neck, holding him with a vice grip, not even trying at all. Is easy, pinching her nails on his nape, yanking him off the floor so violently she can feel the way his bones cackle inside his body. She holds him up and away from her body, using only one hand with no effort at all, so far from the ground he is a whole foot above Adora's head. Prime whimpers and trashes inside her hold miserably, looking to impulse himself to something, anything, clawing at the back of Adora's ethereal hand. His face is red, almost violet with the effort and the lack of hair, bleeding out from all his wounds, his eyes so tense they are huge and bloodshot with the pressure of Adora's hand around his neck, holding back of cracking it in half by spite alone.

He held Catra like this, when he threw her from the cliff. Adora hasn't forgotten it. It is carved on the back of her eyes and the cells inside her brain for all of eternity.

" **Do you want me?"** Adora asks, magnificent and beautiful as the very sun covered in blood, voice echoing as a thousand across the shore. " **You'll have me"**

Prime wheezes loudly, panic settling on the marrow of his bones. He struggles without use as Adora starts to walk towards the water, past the flames on the edge that seem to fold down at her pass. The water is rising too, swirling on itself and crashing with strength over the sand, soaking Catra's knees quickly as the tide starts to devour the flames into nothing.

Prime snaps his eyes to Catra's, virulent green surrounded by red meeting jewel turquoise and gold. He opens his mouth and gasps around a fresh mouthful of blood, muttering heavy and thick.

"Help- help me" he begs at Catra. As if she hadn't just stabbed him to death out of rage and hate alone. Catra narrows her eyes, sharp as daggers when she returns his gaze, her voice just as cold. Colder than the deep sea and all of their creatures.

"Why would I do that?" Catra says, loud and clear, spitting his own words, the ones he said to her on the cliff before throwing her into a painful death, back to his face. "After all, we humans are so very emotional"

Adora drags him across the pebbles and deep into the water, crossing the fire like nothing, sinking them both down. Catra can see the shimmer around Adora's legs where bone and muscle and skin fuse together into one, feathers replaced by the smooth and beautiful surface of a long tail, lashing violently on the water and against the tide.

The last thing Catra sees of Prime are his terrified eyes a second before Adora sinks him along her completely. With time, the details of this night will.get a little bit fuzzy in the edges for Catra, fogged and locked away with the years, no place for them in her life anymore. But that memory, of his eyes knowing he is about to die and about to suffer deeply for it, Catra will always remember it. It will be a testimony that they will always fight for each other and for their lives.

Catra won´t see it, hidden away by the depth of the water, but Adora will drag Prime into the very depths of the sea, deep and deep until the pressure starts to become absolutely unbearable for any human being. The water is thick and salty with Prime´s blood, gushing off each of Catra´s knife wounds on his body, calling the attention of predators miles and miles

just to swim away quickly at the sight of the siren, quickly chased away by her hunting smell.

Adora stops just before Prime´s organs blow up by themselves with the pressure, shaking Prime around with all her strength until he is looking at her, fully, completely, all of her horror, all that she truly is in her true form, huge and terrifyingly wonderful. She takes pride in herself, on what she is, on what she can do, on the way Prime's eyes go wide in terror when Adora smiles from ear to ear with all of the rows of her teeth stained in red. Finally after everything, he understands just how small and insignificant he truly is. He understands he was wrong.

Adora shoots forwards like an arrow and sinks her teeth on his jugular, past veins and flesh and into carotids, purposely slow, purposely painful, chewing and ripping and tearing apart, skin and muscle and clots of blood, feasting on limbs and flesh until the only thing left is a floating skull and remains of body and bones, broken in pieces and sinking into the floor of the sea for the rest of the predators living there to feast to.

But Catra doesn't see this, that is not meant for Catra to see. The brutality and bloodshed of it is not meant for Catra to witness, Adora would never allow it. Catra has seen enough horror as it is.

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Instead, Catra watches as the sea tide keeps rising at quick speed, circling past her knees and hips and waist until it is brushing her chest. There is a trail of bioluminescent algae like a fallen comet on the limits of the sea, illuminating everything like a starry night sky around Catra´s body and fingertips. It is beautiful, sticking to the sand and Catra´s clothes and skin, washing away blood lingering in there as best as it can. Catra sighs at the touch of it, running her palms over the fluttering surface, unable to hold back a wet giggle when they tingle on her fingertips like the tiniest of kisses. The waves are frighteningly tall and strong, fighting the vile fire and pulling away corpses and remains of blood from the shore, cleaning the land from their stain, but they don't pull from Catra or drag her into its depths. And they are gentle, lapping on her body calmly, like a lullaby from the sea now that the war is over.

She is so tired, so fucking tired. Her eyes are heavy and her chest *hurts,* pains with the shadow of all that had just happened. Her nose is tickling with the smoke of her house, still burning behind her, and her ears ring with the cracking of the wood. She can't bring herself to turn around and see it, not right now. She doesn't dare to start thinking about it, not when she is standing alone on the shore and in the middle of the water waiting for Adora´s return. Catra will cry about it, a lot, but not right now. Not when she is bruised up and shaken to her core but alive.

Catra takes a step forward, walking deeper into the water, straining her gaze to look better at the beauty of the sea around her. She winces with each step, wrinkling her nose uncomfortably. The last asshole definitely bruised up one or two of her ribs, maybe even cracked it a little bit, if the hammering and hot pain flaring in there has anything to say about it – she might need to go to the hospital after all – But she is still in shock by the fact that the knife that man swung at her actually didn't manage to stab her at all, skin smooth and untouched. The hit had hurt and it had ripped the air from her lungs but it hadn't even

scratched her beyond that. Her scars, where Adora tore apart her own skin to heal her, seemed to be a shield all of their own, diamond strong and just as beautiful. She is still in shock for quite a few things. It's going to take her a while.

Right now, all she cares about is Adora and Adora alone.

" 'dora?" Catra calls, small and hesitant, looking at the cold water surrounding her, parting the waves with her hands where the luminous algae won´t let her see past the blues and purples and pinks. "Adora"

Catra feels panic creeping in the back of her throat, like her soul is about to leave her body and her chest to burst out through her mouth. Her eyes are tearing up – they have probably not stopped since they began – falling down the shimmering water like pearl drops. It's been too long. Just how long is too long? The sky is dark blue and the shore red and the water of colors and it's been too long.

Catra is about to throw herself into the deeper side of the sea, knowing how to swim or not, when she sees small circles forming on the surface, bigger and bigger until the surface of the water breaks and Adora's head peeks out of the water, as beautiful as the first time Catra saw her on this very same shore.

The wings around her face have shrunken out and her face has relaxed, still long fin ears and membranes in cheeks and covered in the most beautiful of scales, bright as the water around them. Her shoulder is not bleeding anymore, hook pulled off and thrown somewhere in the middle of the sea, and her mouth is slightly bruised but mostly healed now, burn marks gone with the chain now pulled away by the waves. Only two eyes are looking at Catra now too, huge as moons and bright, reflecting the luminous life swimming around them with a splendor of their own. She is also kind of completely covered in blood but Catra couldn't care less for that at that moment.

She sprints head forward through the huge tide, splashing water everywhere, tripping several times with her own feet below the surface of the water and against the soft sand, pebbles rolling on the soles. She pays no mind to it, stretching her arms just in time to meet Adora in the middle, wrapping each other in the tightest embrace they can possibly give, almost painful by how close and hard they hold onto each other.

Catra gasps around their embrace, loud and heartbreaking, drowning in a sob as she holds every single inch of Adora's body she can reach. She nuzzles her face on the length of her soaked hair, digging her fingers on her waist, past the gills on her ribcage, on her shoulder blade and nape. Catra can feel the smooth length of Adora's tail as it wraps around her waist and the hold, firm and reassuring, helps settle down her breath, keeping her from slipping and sinking into the water.

Adora holds Catra back with the same ferocity, wrapping her arms around her waist tightly, burying her head on the angle between her neck and her shoulder, where her scent is stronger and she can hear the steady drum of Catra's heart against her fine ears, the run of blood on her veins, the warmth of her chest against Adora's skin. Anything, *anything* at all that helps Adora to convince herself that Catra is alive and well and breathing. That they are here, embracing each other in the middle of colorful water.

And Catra is pulling from her face, insistently, wrapping her fingers around the silk soft girls of her neck and the angle of her jaw and then forward, guiding Adora's face tenderly where it belongs, to the only place Adora has ever belonged, on the sweet embrace of her mouth. Adora is not oozing black ink from her body anymore, and she doesn't look so much like a nightmare as before, still cradled inside her skin, but she still smells like salt and blood and she probably does not taste better. Catra doesn't mind

She presses her mouth against Adora's into a kiss. Her mouth is busted, lip split open against Adora's siren ones, thin and full of teeth. They taste like salt and metal and blood and, honestly, it is a little bit disgusting but they are smiling into the kiss as their mouths part and fall together again, cradling each other's face with the most tender and desperate of touches they possibly can. Their noses smooch together, fin ears against cartilage, glittering eyelashes over sea glass. Catra exhales against Adora's mouth and Adora presses tiny kisses over her entire face, over the upper lip and her chin and the angle of her jaw and her temples. They are here, they are here and they can't believe they are.

Catra leans back slightly, just enough so she can see Adora's face, taking on her presence fully in front of her, with the water lapping waves on their chest. And Adora is looking at her with such tender expression, owl eyes soft and loving reflecting the luminous life on the water. Catra has never seen something as beautiful as what Adora is and the realization that they have each other, actually have each other and even if their home is *gone* they'll have each other from now on and for the rest of their lives, hits Catra on the chest fully, making her voice tremble.

"Hey" Catra greets her love, sniffling. Adora's smile becomes, somehow, even more gentle, melting on the corners. Adora holds both of Catra's hand in one of hers, tracing the arch of her cheekbones with the back of her knuckles.

" **Hey** " Adora whispers back in her song. It's just Adora's voice this time, soft and kind and full of love for Catra.

And then Catra is crying and Adora is following her. Catra hiccups around a sob and breaks down completely, heavy drops and loud and heartbreaking cries whacking her body with the strength of it. It's loud and messy, bubbling a little bit with snot and making Catra´s face and neck flush in red. Catra has never cried like this, not for a long time. Not in the orphanage, six and alone and terrified, not when Adora left, overwhelmed with guilt and sadness, not even last week, in repentance and fear.

Adora had never cried like this either, never in dozens to hundreds of years. Humans would tell in their stories that a siren has no tears to shed but that is far from the truth. Adora had cried, so much too, tears like crystal drops that were washed away invisible among the waves. She had shredded her heart and her skin and her body and had wailed in return by the pain of it. But nothing like this, painting lines of silver on her face, dripping from her chin and into Catra´s palms, splitting her ribcage open in half and letting everything inside of it pour out.

This was the kind of cry that spoke of nothing but the utmost and more overwhelming relief. A breath of cold and fresh air taken after a long time of smoke and the thick scent of fear. A

golden ray of sunlight after days and years of darkness, It was freedom and magic unchained, running free and without anymore free across the land where it was always meant to be.

This shore, this place that once had been a beacon of light for the sea, had always been magic, preparing itself for years and years. Buildings rising, buildings falling, sea against sand and rolling pebbles with sea glass making paths towards meadows. The small house of a big family and then the big house of a smaller one. And as scary as the cliff might still look right now, too full of painful memories to begin to heal, in a few years it will change too, cradled in green grass and blue bells and daisy blooms, washed by the sunlight and the rays of the moon as sweet years go by, turned into a whole watercolor of its own. This place was always meant to guard a story, this story, their story. Through years of myths and tales and folklore, many mortals had been enchanted by the world beyond the shore, by the mystery living under the surface of the water too wide and sometimes too terrifying to be seen and loved as it was. And many if not most had found their demise there, loving something too ethereal and beautiful to be touched, something too proud to love them back. All of those tales, one after the other, always ending the same. But there was only meant to be one story, only one in this life, when an angel born from the depths abyss had stumbled with the land world and seen the midnight sun during a raining night and fallen in love. And the sun had loved her back.

"It 's over, it's over. He is gone" Adora is whispering against Catra´s cheeks, placing siren and human kisses there, warming her with her embrace and holding her so close to her heart they might just fuse into one. "It 's alright now. You were very brave, my love, you were so brave"

Catra inhales deeply against Adora´s neck and nods, watching at the water swirling around their chest with narrowed eyes, gaze blurred. She lets her hands fall from their place over Adora´s shoulder blades and dips them into the water, letting all of her weight fall into Adora ´s arms as she scrubs almost violently the stains of blood from her hands. She doesn't regret it, not a single thing she had just done, not after she saw what that man wanted to do, what he tried to do with them. But she also doesn't want a single trace of them on her skin anymore.

Adora must realize this too because she also dips her claws into the bright water, taking a crystalline handful between her hands before running her damp palms over Catra´s face, down her cheek and forehead and short hair, cleaning off blood and ashes from her skin. Catra lets her be, closing her eyes under her touch and breathing slowly through her nose when the water drops fall down the bridge of her nose and Adora pulls down softly from her. Down until their chins brush the surface and Adora stops for a second, waiting for Catra´s consent. Catra nods, still not opening her eyes, and they both sink under the water.

They don´t go far, barely a few inches below the surface, just enough for Adora to scrape the rest of the blood off Catra´s body even if their clothes are far too gone to save at all. Adora places a tiny siren kiss over Catra´s nose when she is done, tangling the end of her tail around Catra´s ankle so she doesn't feel like she is going to drift away. Catra smiles around the caress, still holding her breath when she opens her eyes, slowly to adjust the new range of her sight.

Looking at Adora under the water is like staring at a star directly on the face, so bright it slips the warmth of her light into Catra´s sore bones. Catra blinks out tears that lose themselves

with the water and grins from ear to ear, feeling herself falling in love all over again when Adora leans towards her and kisses her again. Underwater and cold and completely magical. Sweet as a bloom. Bright as the sun. She thought she would panic with her head underwater – she almost did minutes ago, fighting for her life – but this is completely different. Catra doesn't feel pain or worry or fear she just feels *love,* reaching every single cell of her body. Magic and love. Catra doesn't want to feel anything else for the rest of her life but the warmth and happiness that overflows her body when Adora kisses her like this, tender and full of reassuring love. And suddenly she is not afraid of water on her ears anymore. She has new memories like this, to fight the bad ones when they get to be too much.

Catra still can breath under water, though, so they end up floating back out of the water, Catra´s arms end up resting over Adora´s shoulders, her cheek nestled against Adora´s neck, cradling each other as Adora wraps her own hands on the low of Catra´s waist, drawing invisible swirls on her shivering skin with the back of her hands careful still of her claws.

Catra sniffles and looks up at some moment, staring right back to the most scary pair of bright blue eyes a few feet from them. A shiver runs down Catra´s back – to which Adora starts rubbing circles on the middle of her back chasing the cold from Catra´s muscles away, still too entrailed in Catra and completely unaware that they are accompanied – biting back a curse.

“Jezz– ” Catra hisses, head bumping at Adora´s temple gently, calling for her attention. As if all of what Adora is wasn't already completely attuned to Catra. “I think someone wants to see you, princess” Catra mutters, rolling her eyes when the bright eyed figure blinks slowly in recognition. *Sirens.*

“Uh?” Adora sounds a little bit winded as she spins back, still with Catra in her arms, her eyes widening when she catches sight of the figure drifting on the water behind them. Her breath gets stuck on her throat, lips quivering when she sings. "Brother"

Adam peeks out of the water further, aquamarine and silver body glistening with the light around them, purposely looking back at Adora and making a soft trill sound with his throat in recognition. It's just a little bit creepy but Catra thinks he smiles among the darkness of the night, long rows of teeth dripping red.

Adora´s hands jerk around Catra´s body, visibly excited and eager to meet her brother but also hesitant to tear herself away from Catra´s body even for the tiniest of seconds, drifting over the tide together without moving.

A small flash next to them calls Catra's attention, looking down at the water just to find out her phone, floating screen up and still turned on, the crystal cracked in the middle but functional and still stuck on the dial numbers. Catra's eyebrows skyrocket on the forehead and she detangles one of her hands from around Adora's neck to grab the small square off the water.

"Hey, it's my phone" Catra runs her finger tips over the screen, chuckling when she realizes it actually does work. She even has a signal. "That's a good piece of junk" Catra returns her eyes to Adora's, who is already looking back at her, a silent question etched on every single of her sharp factions. Catra rolls her eyes, fondly, detaching herself from Adora completely

just so she can point at the spot where Adam is still hovering like a radioactive seal in the middle of the sea.

“Go on, sea girl, I'll be here," when Adora still looks unsure, Catra softens her smile, nodding reassuringly. "Promise"

Adora beams and leans down to press one more clumsy kiss over Catra's mouth, sinking into the water to swim fast as an arrow towards her brother. Catra chuckles, winded and shaking her head as she runs her fingers over known numbers, placing the phone on her ear when the call goes through.

Glimmer is howling at her from the other side of the speaker. It's kind of, a lot, of annoying and kind of endearing hearing her verbal puke worrying all over Catra but she is honestly a bit tired.

"Sparkles," Catra cuts her short, voice firm and strong. Thoughtful as she stares at the remains of her burning house. Cold as the sea keeps washing bodies away. "Call Micah for me. Tell him a shark just attacked a pack of illegal hunters– "

Adora makes her way in front of her brother on a heartbeat, tail lashing behind her wildly. Adam looks at her keeping up his unfazed and unimpressed expression, trying to hide just how worried he actually was. Adam might be a siren but he is still her brother. And he also has a reputation to hold on.

" **Sister– Uff** !" Adam's cool greeting song gets cut in half when Adora quite literally throws herself over him, wrapping her long arms around the sharp spikes of his shoulders and holding him so close against her chest Adam huffs. He stays still, frozen with his arms hovering under the water without knowing exactly what to do. He grimaces, song turning into a teasing tone. " **Is this one of your human ways to display affection?"**

" **Yes** " Adora mitters, song muffled from where she has tucked her face between Adam's gills. " **Now shut up and take it"**

Adam grunts, annoyed and infuriated all at the same time but he lets her be, hesitatingly wrapping his own sharp arms around her upper arms. It's very clumsy and much more uncomfortable but they make do, holding each other on the water.

Adam looks down at Adora, narrowing his eyes as he studies her. She is better from the last time he saw her, strong and powerful tail healthier, her cheeks fuller, her skin no longer sickly green and clammy. She is also different, clattered in blue and golden and opals, a piece of treasure from the deep shipwrecks Adora so much liked to swim around when she was younger on her immortality. Adam recognizes the shimmering ring of colors from the eyes of Adora's mortal, he is not dull, and it makes a certain kind of calm wash over him. The knowledge that she is actually going to be alright.

"How did you know?" Adora asks, leaning back, finally taking on the wrecked hunting ship deep into the bay, pieces of metal and spark of electricity shimmering in and around as it sinks down.

" **I have this ability to know when your tail is in trouble, which is pretty much always** " Adam answers, rolling his dark eyes. Adora grunts and pinches him on the nose with her claws, smirking when Adam groans in indignation. Adam takes Adora's hands between his, lowering them back into the water. She might be different right now but they are still the same. " **You are my sister, I wanted to make sure you were alright. And it's obvious I was right** ."

Adora's smile doesn't flatter, the rising of her forehead the only tale at Adam's comment. She narrows her eyes at the bright waters all around them and then mack at Adam, tilting her head to the side with curiosity.

"And Teela? "

" **Enjoying leftovers** ," Adam answers easily, shrugging as he points behind them with a flutter of his claws, " **it's been a while since she got to taste humans, you probably wouldn't want her near yours right now anyway** "

Adora's eyes soften impossibly on the corners, stari g back at her brother with a thousand words not spoken less sung over, some kind of realization falling l er her as she starts to understand what happened after that motherfucker of a hunter knocked Catra into the sea.

" **Thank you"** Adora says, choking slightly with her own breath, still too absolutely soft. " **Thank you for protecting her"**

Adam grumbles, looking past Adora's shoulder to stare at Catra, still floating a good couple of feet away from them. She is still thumbing at the small algae that makes her skin shimmer in colors, haze a little bit unfocused as she looks back at the remains of the house where the fire is not as violent as before but still present. The sight makes Adora's heart clench inside her chest.

"She is alright, I guess, " Adam says between his teeth, finally giving in. He will never admit it outloud but after seeing how much this human loves his sister and how hard she fought to protect her, he kind of, maybe, is starting to actually like her.

Between the pain of looking at the remains of their home, the words make Adora grin, relief watching her as she bumps Adam's side with the end of her tail. " **She is more than alright** "

Adam sizzles something unintelligible between his teeth and turns to look back, where a loud, trilling sound is coming from near the rocks. Teela is calling him home. By the way he sees Adora's human's eyes sparkle when their gazes meet, he understands she is calling Adora home too.

"Don't be a stranger, alright?" He warns his sister. Adora sees past his shit immediately because even though she grins, her eyes are tender, dark and huge and reflecting Adam's own.

" **What, I'm going to start to think you'll miss me** "

" **Absolutely no. You are a pain** "

Adora hums, swimming closer to Adam just so she can wrap her hand on the base of his neck, bringing their foreheads together. Adam wraps his claws around Adora's shoulders, keeping them close as the end of their tails brush with one another, silk soft against gems.

" **You are not getting rid of me that easy, brother** " Adora sings, kind, " **I'll always be a part of the sea and we will always have each other"**

Adam nods into their touch, gills fluttering when he exhales. Maybe this whole tender human thing is rubbing on him after all. "**I'll take your word on that. Sister**"

They hold onto each other for a second longer and then Adam untangles himself completely from Adora, humming a known song between them, one that accompanied them since they were alone and calves and all they had was each other. Then he is swimming away, throwing one last meanful look at Catra, who blinks at him once, a silent thank you shared between them. This won't be the last time they see each other. They will meet again in different circumstances, kinder ones. But for tonight more humans won't take long to show up, attracted by the fire, so Adam must meet Teela again. And Adora must too return to her beloved's arms.

Adora watches him go, unable to contain her own tears dripping down her face and into the sea. The waves seem to feel her too, curling around her skin, smothering scales and sea glass, lapping soft caresses over her as it calls for her attention again.

" **Thank you** ," Adora sings, just between the water and her.

Adora had always felt this, an unspoken connection between her and the ocean, a silent voice in her skin and her head, calming her down when loneliness and the weight of long and endless years became too much, telling her to wait, to be patient just a little more. The same pull that calmed the violent waters during an even more violent storm and that allowed her to reach Catra in the darkness. It's the same kind of shift and pull and ethereal song she felt when she was born, the same when she arrived for the first time to this shore and when she meet Catra's eyes under the cold rain and then now, when the waves raise and crash against the fire and the cliff, creating its own kind of rain to stop down the bite of flames. And it is now asking Adora a gentle yet frightening question. Giving her the right to choose.

She places her palms over the water, barely touching it at all, feeling the way it kisses her skin. And she then lowers down until her forehead and nose is resting against the surface with the tender of touches, not sinking just resting there. Her lips brush against seafoam and stardust, a whisper just between whatever spirits live in there and her own soul, baring it completely. A plea and an answer. Honest and sweet. The voice of a deity devastatingly in love, willing to give everything that makes her holy for it, for her, for this life. For this person floating on her waters just a few feet behind her. A saint, a priestess, an angel guarding Adora's heart.

"I renounce my immortality" Adora whispers in a voice that is not a voice and a song that is not quite a song. Firmly and completely sure, closing her opal eyes into a prayer. A shiver runs down Adora's spine when she says the words, from the roots of her hair to the very fine fins of her tail, feels some kind of invisible and warm light surrounding her body. ***"Please. I choose a life to be with her. That's all I want***"

She doesn't really notice a change. There is no magical transformation, no bright light coming from a god's trident. The sea doesn't rise in tsunami waves and the skies don't fall from the heavens. It's very very quiet. The sea is calm. Adora is still herself, tail and fins and claws and sea glass. Powerful and part of the sea. She is still seafoam in flesh and ichor in blood. For a second, she doesn't know if her plea has been listened to. Only time will tell now.

"Adora" Catra is calling for her, soft, giggling breathless when tiny fish make their way under her feet. The sea loves her too, a shimmering apology for all the pain she had to go through. It'll get better.

There are tears still falling down Catra's eyes, cheeks damp and sweet, and she looks a little bit nervous nibbling on the bottom of her lip as stares at Adora still floating in the middle of the sea. For a minute there she looks almost unsure if Adora is going to come back. The corner of Adora´s eyes wrinkle when she smiles and Catra sighs, silent among the now blue fire and the bright water, stretching her arms forward. A quiet question now from her, tender and nervous. A ¨ *Come*¨ and ¨*Stay with me*¨

Adora exhales, heart leaping on her chest, and swims back home to her.

End of chapter VIII

When my time comes around

Lay me gently in the cold dark earth

No grave can hold my body down

I'll crawl home to her

– **Hozier** , *Work song*

Chapter End Notes

Not gonna lie, that was so hard to write :p
Hope you liked it! Next time I see you it will be for the Epilogue and then our story of the siren and her beloved will be over ;.;
Thank you so much for all of your amazing comments! kudos! and bookmarks! I hope to answer you all soon! See you in a week! Be good!!

The Epilogue of a Love Story

Chapter Summary

They do get to have a beautiful, happy life

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the finale T.T
I am so forever grateful that you all decided to trust me with this story and followed it up to this point, some from the very beginning, some on the time I was gone, some.new, but I love you all the same and I can't thank you enough
Thank you. Thank you. Thank you

Let's dive one last time on the sea of Anchor and close this one life, beautiful and kind.
It's time for my, our, girls to rest

I love you all (◠‿◠)♡

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Epilogue of a Love Story

Loving you made me stronger and I feel braver. My life and my heart are so much fuller now and I'm not afraid of the future anymore. I'm ready for whatever's waiting for us. And I promise that I will love you with every bit of my heart until I take my last breath.

— *The Handy Nanny* **, K. Sterling**

There is a little baby sleeping in a warm room. They are laying over a soft mattress and blue blankets, face and tummy facing the ceiling, their tiny feet stretched, even tinier hands curled up next to their precious face twitching every once in a while as they dream. They are fast asleep.

There is light pouring inside the room, golden sunlight from where it enters through the open window. The curtains are pulled aside, shifting with the wind, letting the sounds of the sea dance inside. Sea foam against sand, small pebbles rolling in the calm waves, blue sky mirroring over the ocean like turquoises, a painting full of light just beyond the glass. A

watercolor page found in a fairytale book. In this part of the sea the weather is always perfect for each season. Hot in summer, perfectly chill in autumn, snow for winter, golden sun in spring. The sun is golden today and the sand is white and the pebbles dark and everything is perfect.

It's a perfectly beautiful day.

The room is a little bit different now, another kind of new, but the heart of it remains as it was so many years ago. The bed still has wood posts in every corner, soft white tulle hanging from it, guarding the inside from any errand bugs. The blankets and sheets are still blue, white and silver pillows gathering in the far end like a fortress. The closet and the vanity are thrifted, fixed up and painted new, dresses like silk and soft jackets and pin pearls still scattered inside and over the surface. The walls are painted a gentle shade of plumbago and there is a small golden chandelier hanging from the seashell colored ceiling, sea glass and tiny shells twinkling from it like the wind chimes singing on the porch outside. There is a huge mirror next to the bed, from floor to ceiling like the window opposite to it, the frame golden and the surface perfectly polished, creating a living portrait of the room it reflects.

There are new things here, though, the warmth of a domestic life slipping into the roots of this home. There is a wicker basket full of baby toys placed over one of the night tables. They are soft as a cloud and clean, all of them, shaped as sea animals from whales to string rays to little crabs and fishes. Most of them are gifts from the town, given in pretty bags and cheerful boxes after the baby was born and the entire town threw a whole party in their name. Others are from their very first birthday and they came with kisses and lemon cake. Usually the basket is in the nursery but they've spent a lot of time here lately, so for now it lays there.

Baby clothes are sitting next to the wardrobe, cotton soft and folded carefully. Shirts and sweaters and socks. Hats and the tiniest of overalls and jackets and boots, colorful and tender. They have pretty drawings and embroideries of sea life on them, done with obvious and tender love. The clothes smell like clean soap and lavender and a little bit like sea salt too.

A music box is playing sweetly from its spot in the vanity, the notes filling the room gently. It is shaped like a seashell, of course, made of porcelain and nacre shell, rimmed in gold dust and beautiful. It has a small porcelain siren in the middle, caught in the middle of a swirl inside a blue painted ocean. It was a gift from the baby's godparents, wrapped in lilac sparkling paper with hearts the day after the baby's birth, when the house was warm and the people living inside of it were even warmer.

A rocking chair has been placed next to the window, of beautiful dark wood with hand made carvings of sea life on the back and the armrests. There is a soft feather pillow on the seat, embroidered with colorful flowers and waves. The chair is well loved, after being passed from family to family in the town and then finally getting here, where it is supposed to be.

There is a siren's skin carefully draped over the back of the rocking chair, shimmering in turquoises and gold, pearls and opal under the sun, scales like gold coins and bright as moonlight dust. Long, light and ethereal. Testimony of a quiet morning lulling a baby to sleep, their tiny body cradled inside the skin, safe and warm and so loved. There is no need to hide this skin away, not anymore, not at their own home. So it just stays there, calm and quiet. Waiting.

The baby's name is Finn. They are one year old - and two months with five days exactly - and already a wonderful devious sunbeam inside their house. Their hair is curly and messy, honey colored under the light, and they have errand freckles scattered around their baby face, like tiny sun kisses marked over their skin. Their eyes are blue, as blue as the sea outside, as the sea glass on a siren´s skin, as the eyes of their mother, two gems on sun kissed skin. They've still got tooth gaps in their mouth, adorable milk teeth adorning their smile as pearls when they laugh. This baby laughs so much, every day, all the time, echoing as tiny and sweet bells and just a little squeaky on the edges. Their laughter fills every single corner of the house, sparkles like stardust and moonlight, a reflection of the love they are surrounded by. They wear mismatched socks with tiny sharks on them and a cream colored onesie with sea horses scattered around the fabric and bows on their sunlight hair.

Finn is in that baby age where the world is bright and beautiful and where sharks and whales are the absolutely best thing in the world and, honestly, who can blame them? Their thoughts are colorful as are their swift but core memories and they can't talk very well right now, mostly adorable babbles and short endearments learnt from the song of those who love them.r

Their mommy – beautiful and soft, cradled in golden light and lavender smell – knitted a little whale toy for their first birthday, sitting for hours to end in the armchair that faces the sea, with her long dark hair messy for the breeze and her freckles so much like Finn's popping under the sun. Their mommy is amazing like that in Finn's mind, just like the sea waves she has painted on her left arm and that she lets Finn color inside the lines with their watercolors. Just like the colorful patches in her body like sea glasses underwater. And like the softness of her hands when Finn falls asleep over her warm chest, right next to her heart, just as when they were just a newborn and all they knew was the tenderness of their mother's shelter. She is amazing and she is beautiful and she loves Finn with all her heart.

Their mamma is incredibly too – beautiful and tall and gentle, skin like gems and voice like bells – She carries Finn all the time, wrapped on her arms and the softness of her skin, always watching over them. She taught them how to walk in the same clumsy but endearing way she learned too, among soft sand and flower blooms. And sometimes, most of the time, she leans down and smothers her face against Finn's belly and the soles of their tiny feet, breathing sweet raspberries there and making them laugh. She knows a lot about the ocean, her hair is kind of blue under the water and sometimes Finn thinks she looks a little bit like a whale herself when she is swimming. Though that's a secret only for their moms and Finn, who is still too little to understand beyond knowing this is who their mom is and how much she loves them.

Finn has spent hours with their moms exploring the beach, splashing around the water with their so, so small plastic water boots the moment Finn learnt how to walk, always held from their moms gentle hands, always just close enough to the water to touch their soles and collecting all kinds of shells and sea glass and sometimes even fosiles. Those are their favorites and always win a delighted little giggle from them because their mamma always finds the good ones, swimming deep, deep inside the bottom of the ocean and bringing back handfuls of curiosities to them with a big grin.

This is mostly how Finn remembers their mothers at this young age. Mommy smells like fresh baked bread, her hair is curly like theirs and her hands are soft and gentle when she

caresses their cheeks and kisses their forehead and palms. Mamma smells like salt, she sings them to sleep every night, without fault, and her skin sometimes sparkles gold and blue, especially when she swims, she swims very well. They held Finn after they were born for endless hours over their chests and Finn learned the sound of their heartbeats before anything else.

And Finn's mommies love each other. Deeply.

They dance in the kitchen and the bedroom and the living room, feet bare, hand in hand, their faces as bright and in love as the first time. They kiss sweetly and they hold each other. Mamma sings, so beautiful the sky seems to sing with her, and mommy smiles. They love each other, Finn knows this even though they are still a baby. And both of them always smile at Finn, always, sweet words and songs and kisses. Finn, who was so wanted and is so cherished, lives surrounded by love every single day and even if they can't understand the full meaning of the word yet, or even pronounce it well, they know they are loved.

For now though, Finn sleeps, tired after a morning playing and then lulled by their mommy singing to them on the rocking chair. They are so asleep they don't even notice when Melog jumps into the bed, nuzzling the side of their old furry face - gray sprinkled over black fur – gently against their cheek. Or when a pair of loving hands roll them over on their back, softly picking them up and into another warm pair of arms. Finn just sighs inside their dreams and nuzzles into the angle of a neck, pale eyelashes fluttering when someone kisses them tenderly on the cheek.

"Let's go get ready, mi amor," a sweet voice whispers, carrying them against her chest and off the room.

The room is filled with the sun.

There is something else that is new here, a framed picture placed on a small table next to the window. Is the only one in the room - the rest are downstairs, over the corridors and the kitchen and the fireplace - with a glass vase full of small blue bell flowers next to it.

In the photograph there are two people, one tall and with honey hair, sun kissed skin and smiling. She has her arms around the waist of someone else, pressing a closed eyed kiss behind her ear. The second person is shorter, with dark curls falling down her back in a ponytail. Her skin is darker and she is smiling cheekily at something beyond the camera, mirth in her eyes and happiness in the corner of her lips. She is also, in the picture, very very pregnant.

They are Finn's moms, holding each other, taken on the town's bay a little before Finn was born. They look happy. They are happy.

They earned it.



They do get to have a beautiful, happy life.

It gets a little bumpy on the edges, but they get there.

The fire on the shore eventually dies down, mostly by the sea itself, drowned by its humongous waves. The green flames consume themselves and disappear, completely gone. They are no match for the sea, they never were. The bright sea washes them away as it washes blood and other unfortunate remains, pulling them to the depths, forgotten and unimportant. Fear and greed will never touch this waters or this shore again.

The people of the town arrive swiftly and quickly, one after the other, none of them caring about anything else but to help save the little that remains of the house. They manage sooner or later to tamper the raging fire into nothing but Catra and Adora's home is gone, for now.

Wood beams give up under the pressure of the heat and fall, curtains and blankets are consumed by the flames, the few windows that remain standing crack under the fire. The books and the piano and the couch get consumed by the fire. The salt baths and the sheets where they slept and made love melt and mix and then they are nothing but sweet breeze on the sea wind. The smell of blood and tears and nail scratches on the floor are reduced to ashes too, glass to sand as rose to thorns.

So many memories, most of them good, some of them too sorrowful to even think about, all of them important, the foundations of their home and of their lives. They don´t lie anymore on the wood floor or the seashell pillars or the tinted windows, but they live inside of them and they will rebuild their shelter from them and they will make it stronger with the seams of the love they have built between themselves.

After all the fear and the hunt and the chase, after all the war they had to overcome, there is nothing else they can´t do as long as they hold onto each other, as long as they have each other. Even if the dark and eventual white smoke makes their eyes burn with warm tears and their hearts to squeeze in each other´s chests. They lace their fingers together like ribbons in wrists and hold the other's breath and they are alive. This too they will survive.

They do manage, however, to save some things. Glimmer marches out of the smoking house covered in ashes and hands them a box, followed by another from Bow and then another from Micah, and then another and another. From Angella and Mermista and Sea Hawk and the women from the bakery and Miss Thaymor – damn be her knees the day she won't jump to help – and someone else followed by another, people from the town gathered together to help them.

They save books, from Catra – most of them crisp on the cover and the edges but there – and from Razz – the fairytale book Razz had left Catra, as if somehow she had known in a certain way what was to become of her granddaughter long after she was gone – and some clothes, including Catra's mom's dress, the fabric dirty and the pearl stained in ashes but intact. Most of their pictures survive, miraculously, glass cracked and edges burnt a little, yes, but they are here, the start of years long of memories that are to come. The only photo Catra has of her mom makes it out too and that's enough.

Glimmer is kind enough to not comment on anything, face settled as she helps them go through the stuff they get to save and *absolutely not letting them stand up anymore, no, sit there and rest and shut the hell up.* Catra knows she knows and Adora knows too. They know

Bow knows too by now. Maybe part of the town that arrived behind them knows too, and maybe even the entire town, who knows. But, even if they do, nobody says anything, nobody comments between themselves or chatters or whispers. If they know then they know and that's it. It changes nothing, love is held above it. So, the town helps.

Melog appears again after the fire dies down, their fur matted with gray ashes and the dawn´s dew after hiding in the meadows behind the shore but completely fine otherwise. They march over the sand and the pebbles and around the myriad of people running around like headless chickens with their little head turned up and a sprint on their step, divinely and olympically ignoring at everyone that calls breathlessly their name until they reach the flat stones that make the start of the cliff beyond.

Adora and Catra are sitting on the open back of Glimmer´s van, arms around each other, foreheads pressed tightly together. Catra is drenched with seawater and sweat, face gray with ashes and dirt, marked with clear tracks from her cheekbones to her chin. Her lip is busted and she feels sore and heavy everywhere but she is alive. Adora, as always, is right next to her. She is, quite honestly, mostly covered in tracks of blood, halfway washed away by the sea waves and halfway dry on the other side. Her hair has gone a strange shade between pink and copper and even though someone has thankfully ran a damp towel to clean her face and shoulders – and mouth – she still looks kind of like a fright, untouched too. Alive too.

Adora has her arms around Catra´s waist, her cheek resting over Catra´s temple, whispering sweet kisses over her face, cleaning tear tracks away with her lips and fingertips. One of Catra´s hands is resting over Adora´s lap, thumbing the fabric of the ruined dress as if she is trying to anchor herself to something tangible, something to convince her Adora is really here, that *they* are really here, together, that they made it. Her other hand is gripping tightly the blanket gently placed around their shoulders, keeping them both warm and sheltered inside of it. When the light hits the surface of the blanket , however, it shimmers in opal and turquoise and golden coral and for anyone really looking it's a tale to tell that this is not a blanket at all. But that's alright now too, even if Glimmer and Bow actually realize, even if the town finds out, even if the entire world knows, it's alright. They won't be afraid.

Melog sees all of this with their colorful eyes until they reach them both, sitting on the sand in front of their bare feets and meowing, *loudly,* to call their attention. Both Catra and Adora ´s head shot immediately towards the sound, tired expressions melting into beaming delight and immeasurable relief when they see Melog there, blinking unimpressed at them. Catra bends over and scoops them into her arms in one swing, cuddling them inside the skin and their embrace. Adora´s hands come into the picture too, ruffling the matted fur on their head and chin and belly, giggling at the immediate purr.

They laugh, wet in the edges and the middle, and smile crooked and covered in ashes and hold each other and their tiny, makeshift family into a hug. Catra kisses Adora´s busted mouth and Adora cries honey tears against her cheeks. Melog purrs like a rumbling storm between them and the people of the town stare at them with soft eyes, covered in gray ashes and sea salt and they know, too, that both of them will be alright.

For a while, they move with Glimmer and Bow, which proves to be a whole challenge of its own. Not only because they are way too independent to live with someone else or because

they miss the sound of the sea beyond their window, but because Catra and Adora are in love and they are completely free now, and so, they are enthusiastically *loud* and Glimmer is pretty much done with them almost immediately.

In Adora and Catra's defense, they move into the Bright-Moon manor which is not exactly Glimmer's but her parents, and they are far away enough through the mazed corridors of the huge property to be blissfully unaware of anything. Also in their defense and as far as everyone knows, Catra and Adora didn't just go through a traumatic event but they are also pretty much married, so the only thing Glimmer manages to do is buy for herself sleep earbuds and ignore Catra every time she makes lighthearted but asshole remarks to the rolls on her hair when she slams on their door to be *fucking quiet already* all while blushing furiously.

Before any of that, however, about a week after they move into the manor and after some deserved rest, which is more consists pretty much on Adora and Catfa nesting into a warm cocoon of blankets and sleeping for most of the day, Glimmer and Bow sit them down and make them talk. The last thing they knew, after all, was picking up the broken pieces of Catra's heart and Adora's absence from the house.

They don't explain everything, obviously. Not even the surface. Catra grumbles about them having a fight, and miscommunication and other stuff Perfuma would be proud of. Adora fills in some details too, lashing out and leaving, and by the way her cheeks paint on rose red and her eyes glass over with memories, it is obvious she is not proud. Mid conversation Catra has the impulse of grabbing Adora's hand and locks herself away with her inside the room, guarding her from the scolding stares of their friends that, even if they are well intentioned, sometimes it can be too much. They, after all, not know the true extent of what happened and they never will. They don't know about the fear or the false feeling of betrayal or the blood on the bathtub. This is all Glimmer and Bow get to know, that for Catra and Adora being apart almost killed them both and that is not happening ever again.

And Adora doesn't *talk* either. Pretty quickly Catra realizes that Adora only uses her human voice with her and her alone, and even then when it is only both of them, it's mostly melted with her song. With anyone else, she just signs, content on the familiarity of it. The unspoken arrangement seems to calm Adora down, making her feel in control of what she wants to say and how she wants to express it, and it seems to make her happy too. And Catra is happy if Adora is happy

The first three weeks Glimmer spends them throwing weary glances at Adora, weighing her in, an unspoken weight on her eyes as she makes sure Adora is, actually, not going to break Catra's heart again. As much as Catra berates her for it and basically threatens Glimmer to leave if she doesn't leave Adora alone, Adora understands. That Glimmer's worry comes from a place of love, love for Catra, and that she doesn't mean ill.

Adora does as best as she can, wrapping her hand around Catra's and never ever leaving her side, giving Glimmer reassuring looks every time she glares at her from under her lilac eyelashes. It takes Catra a while more to understand Glimmer but she gets there in the end, as annoying as it could be.

Bow gets around much faster than Glimmer, he is an angel and he gets the reason Adora had gotten hurt about Catra holding back stiff and not communicating, especially with something as important as the hunters and their own security. He sees the way Adora's eyes mist with unshed tears sometimes when she is looking at Catra laughing from the other side of the room, mind clouded with memories and thoughts still to sour to overcome. Healing is hard. Bow bumps his shoulder with hers and smiles every time when she turns her blue, *blue* , eyes at him, a quiet reassurance that all will be well.

Bow and Adora get along pretty well and pretty easily. Living in the same space – as much as Catra insists they are perfectly capable of renting a place for now thank you very much – helps them become closer friends than they were before. Bow is kind but strong-headed and valiant and Adora admires those qualities from him deeply. He is also very gentle with Catra, which helps enormously.

Bow calls for his brother, one of thirteen, to come help them with the reconstruction of the house. He is an architect and he shares the same dad humor as Bows and as their dads before them. And he gets into the same mind space as Catra when he is planning something, sketching one house plan and another and another, ideas swirling and prepared for anything they may ask for.

After the fire dies down and everything they may possibly save is saved, the firefighting department helps them clean the remains of wood and glass and metal and ashes until there is nothing but sand and the slight burn mark left on the ground. Catra stares at the empty patch of land where the house once before and almost can't believe it is actually gone. It's sad, it's terrible, almost unbearably sad, and Catra cries on Adora's arms that night until her eyes are red and raw she can't possibly cry anymore. Adora holds her through it, curling around her body as a shield, and cries too, mourning the loss of it with her.

Micah and Bow and the Marine Life Center help to scan the sea in front of their shore, making sure that the fire's hadn't actually hurt any sea life or coral reef. They find nothing wrong – except maybe one or two or a few human bones remain on the bottom but they don't make a comment about it, the mortuary doesn't make a comment about it and soon enough they are gone too - Micah gives them the green light to rebuild after it. Adora makes a joke in their room that night about protecting the sea wildlife at his own house and Catra has to bite back a laugh because it's actually funny and it makes her even more in love with Adora, if that is even possible.

The original planes and the scriptures are, fortunately, still with Catra's lawyer. She gives the planes to Bow's brother and within a week they come with a new plan of their own. Catra wants to keep the main spirit of the house intact because even if she is kind of a rule breaker she is also sentimental. The first floor remains pretty much the same but with some changes. Porch facing the sea and the door framed by huge tinted windows from corner to corner of the walls. Adora and Catra decide to keep the small loveseat that leads to the stairs, where they say goodbye and hello on that hard time. It is theirs and they are reclaiming it again.

Catra does change the placement of the kitchen and the living room. Now that they have the chance to start anew, she wants windows and she wants light. She is so tired of darkness in her life, with Adora next to her the only thing she wants to know about is light. So she

changes the planes for living room to be facing the shore with huge picture windows on the wall and the kitchen to be facing the meadows with the biggest glass doors she can afford in there – which is no problem at all because Catra is *loaded* and this is her home – just so she can open them from side to side in the morning, letting the dew and the pinks of the dawn come through. She is also not saying it but at some point Catra is getting Adora a dog. Catra wants for Adora to experience every single thing life has to offer and if that implies a dog she will comply.

For the second floor Catra keeps their room as it was, exactly the same, because that place is holy and full of all the gentleness of their love and she misses it dearly. She decides, however, to make the room next to theirs into a full on bathroom for Adora, filled with white and blue talavera mosaic and the biggest tub she can find. Adora doesn't say it, but the glimmer in her eyes when she sees the planes is clear as day for Catra and it makes her smile, completely pleased with herself. They are building this house again for *themselves* after all. For the first time in Catra´s life, and in Adora´s, neither of them is alone on this.

Catra also adds a third room on the second floor, past the corridor, facing the blooming meadows behind the house with the sight of the sunset directly through the windows and a small balcony meant to be filled by vines and flower blooms. Catra adds it to the plane quietly, without any more explanations. Adora looks at her doing it and presses a silent kiss on the back of her head, quiet on her thoughts but with her heart racing. And in those moments, neither of them can wait for the rest of their lives to begin.

The town helps them rebuild. Everyone that can help, helps. Someone manages to get all the wood and carpenters and other materials they need, somebody else gets a local construction business to handle the heavy stuff. Adora finds out she *likes* constructing and that she is *good* at it. She likes lifting heavy things and sweat and getting her hands dirty. She likes the exhausting work and her calloused fingers and the sore muscles when she nuzzles back in Catra´s arms to sleep. She likes to build up their home.

Catra likes the building too, but she is more for the details and the paint and all the technical stuff And she enjoys, most of it all, looking at Adora work. The flexing of her biceps under the sunlight and the flush on her face when she laughs breathless and silent is always a delight for her. It also makes Catra, to Glimmer´s dismay, really enthusiastic at night. But who can blame her? She has been scared and on edge for so long that now that is over all of Catra´s emotions are overflowing and out of control. Mostly when she gets to see this new version of who Adora is, whole and completely free. It undoes Catra every single time.

After the fire, the merchants take a good look at their thin bodies and sunken cheeks and pretty much the entire people of the market start giving them groceries as gifts. They hand it to them in basket after basket filled to the brim with bread and fruits and vegetables and fish and meat and candies. It comes to a point where Catra quite honestly doesn't know what to do with all of it. Adora is just happy to chew on the fish and feed Catra the sweets during their breaks from the construction.

Catra gives most of it to Angella and the chefs of the manor as a thank you for letting them stay until their house is done. Angella is delighted and Micah gives her the biggest of hugs – once she assures him it's alright for him to touch her – reminding that she doesn't need to

thank them at all. Catra only wrinkles her nose and nods, exhaling around the embrace and saying nothing more.

Truth is, picking up eating after the long weeks between Adora's departure and the end of the war that had lashed against her home, of barely hanging there, too sad and overwhelmed and exhausted with no appetite or want to eat whatsoever, has been difficult for Catra. It has taken a lot from her, tears and endless hours sitting with her psychologist, processing the things that had happened to her, to her home, to Adora who she loves, terrible things that she might be projecting into her eating. It's a work in process and it's not easy, at all, but she has been getting there, little by little and with a lot of patience, held from Adora's hand when it is too much sometimes and she feels like she is going to fall again.

"It's alright," Adora says one night, the day Catra decides to take the first step and return to therapy for the first time after her young adult years.

That day is just a *lot* and Catra breaks down inside their room on the manor, curling over herself next to the bed and over the cold floor. She doesn't regret what she had done to survive and she would do it again time after time, but the journey there and the thought of what could have been of Adora, of herself, of what had almost been done to both of them, still haunts her dreams.

Adora sits in front of her and wraps her inside her skin and her arms, letting her cry over her shoulder with gentle touches and reassuring whispers in her ears.

"It's alright, my love, it's alright. You've been through so much." Adora nuzzles her face over Catra's short hair, curly and brushing the edge of her jaw, cradling her over her chest the entire time. "You can take as much time as you need, Catra. I'll be here with you. I'm here with you."

Catra has done it for Adora, whose worried and tender eyes are always next to her, letting her know that no matter what she will always be by Catra's side and that Catra can take as much time as she needs because she won't be doing any of it alone. Not again, not ever.

But she is also doing it, most important of it all, for herself. She wants to live, she wants to see things and do things and write and laugh and have terrible double dates with her friends. She wants to do it all, all the years that belong to her, she wants them. She wants them next to Adora and she wants to enjoy them. Catra is reclaiming her life back and with it comes her health.

A few months after the fire, in the early hours of the morning after she has woken from a dream she really can´t remember, Catra decides she is definitely not going to be able to fall asleep again. She detangles herself from Adora's octopus embrace and goes for a quick walk through the manor. She tiptoes as she wanders mindlessly for a while through the corridors until she finally finds herself in the kitchen, disgustingly huge and uncharacteristically empty. She roams around the fridge for a while and when can't find anything that might fill the sudden hungry pit on her stomach she just stands there, between the counter and the open fridge, staring at a dozen ingredients waiting for her. It takes her a beat, then another, then Catra is pulling a recipe book from the shelf and starts cooking.

Adora finds her in the kitchen a few hours after, woken up missing the warmth of Catra´s body. Catra´s hands are covered in dough with a batch of burned cookies, a batch of undercooked ones and a last one that must be absolutely perfect because Adora quite literally inhales them after she tastes them. After that, Catra discovers that she is actually good at baking stuff and takes a hobby of it, going from crooked cookies to cakes to pizza and even ice cream at some point. It makes Catra happy, it makes Adora happy seeing Catra happy, and sooner or later it helps Catra make her recovery easier. Kinder.

Catra calls Scorpia at some point, who cries – nothing new – sick of worry after weeks of not hearing from her – it makes Catra feel guilty and she apologizes profusely for it – Scorpia calls Entrapta who is happy and just mildly disappointed Catra didn't took samples from the hurricane, and then Scorpia calls Perfuma, who is as delighted as her girlfriend of hearing about Catra. Scorpia almost faints after Catra tells her about the fire and it takes a good hour for her to get convinced to not get a plane immediately to Salineas. They all accord to go visit some time soon, after the house is done.

Adora visits the sea and sometimes her brother too, if the water is warm, at least thrice a week, when they are sure their shore is completely empty after everyone has gone home to rest and nobody can interrupt them. Adora brings her beautiful skin with her, usually guarded safely alongside Catra´s mother´s dress, and slips inside of it before dipping into the sea, who welcomes her back with open arms. Sometimes Catra goes swimming with her, sometimes she stays back, sitting calmly on a blanket over warm sand as she watches the sunset go down and Adora do shimmering happy loops on the waves. It´s good.

It takes them almost an entire year but the house on Greyskull shore lives again, a fragment of a memory and the dream of a future wish. The house is still seashell white and the main door blue. There are garden couches on the porch and newly done wind chimes hanging from the ceiling beams. The tinted windows now show sea scenarios instead of flowers, whales and waves and other sea life reflecting rainbows on the floor when the sun hits them. The walls inside are colorful, from paint to cheerful wallpaper that Catra would have never chosen by herself but that Adora loved it.

Everything inside is showered in golden light, from the kitchen to the living room with the new fireplace and the gifted piano on the corner, to the stairs with mosaic between the steps, and the bedrooms. Light coming from every single window and door and the dome built on the room, right above the rest of the stairs. Most of their furniture is thrifted from the town or the other small towns around Salineas. They fix them and paint them new together, placing them where they belong until late hours of the night, dangerously barefoot and sharing hot chocolate. Some other things they have to buy so they travel to bigger stores to get them, mostly the stove with a bigger oven for Catra´s baking, and the washing machine and new bedsheets. They have a swift argument about the ugliest carpet Catra has ever seen in her life but that Adora absolutely adores the moment she sees it and after fifteen minutes of banter and carrying the godforsaken thing into the back of the truck, Catra thinks of how fortunate she is that the worst thing she has to worry about nowadays has to be how awful it is going to look on their living room.

Catra places pots full of honeysuckle and lavenders on the windows and Adora opens every door and window during the day to let the salted air come in. Adora brings freshly hunted

fish from the sea and Catra ends up learning how to tend a small garden on the back of their house, getting small tomatoes and species and other vegetables for them to cook at home. They make love in their new bedroom, so much like the old one, and equally as sweet, and Adora spends hours happily floating in the humongous bathtub, whispering kisses on the back of Catra´s damp neck. They spoil Melog rotten and Adora sweeps Catra off her feet every day, guiding them both into a gentle dance across the floor of their home.

Every time Adora thinks she can´t love Catra more she is proved wrong. She sees her heal and sees her face her fear and pain with bravery. She sees her kindness overflowing out of her like sunlight from the sun. Sees her laugh and joke around and also sees her cry and get angry and Adora loves her through it all. Adora sees her love her back, with all the darkness inside Adora, all her weakness and fears too, all her now tampered anger and all her beauty. Catra loves her, raw and vulnerable and completely. There is so much love inside Adora´s heart and chest and bones that sometimes she doesn´t know what to do with the immensity of it all, doesn´t know where to place it but in kisses and caresses with fingertips and embraces and all of her wrapped around all that Catra is. She is engraved on the cords of her heart and on the sea glass paths of her skin and on the palms of her hands.

The twelfth night after they return home, caught in the middle of a slow dance around the living room floor, Adora leans her temple against Catra´s forehead and whispers a tender song into Catra´s ear, pronouncing the words she was meant to say months ago and that she never forgot. She runs her fingers over the tender rope wrapped around Catra´s ring finger and watches as Catra´s eyes widen and then swell with crystal tears, falling down her cheeks in rivers as she nods. She is so beautiful, right now under the warm light of the fireplace and the fairy lights on the ceilings. Her hair has grown, brushing her chin and nape in silk curls and she looks happy, so so happy. Adora loves her so much. She loves her so much that, when Catra whispers the exact same words back to her against her damp lips in her own question, Adora can't do anything else but laugh between even sweeter tears and nod right back.

Micah marries them. They do it next to the bay and the entire town throws a party.

Glimmer is over the moon and she shrieks on Catra's ear when they tell them, but Catra bites back a snarl and only rolls her eyes, much to Glimmer's even more annoying recall. Adora laughs without a sound the entire time, patting Bow's back when he tearfully hugs her back. They manage it as a renewal of vow, a celebration for one they hadn't had the opportunity to do before, but the notice spreads like rain across the entire town and pretty much a few hours after their announcement to the Bright-Moons every single soul in Salineas knows.

Catra and Adora have already said their vows, months ago in their old room, wrapped around each other after hours and days of tears, after long moments of promises and kisses. They are already married in all the ways that matter. For them, this is just an opportunity to share their love and have fun, maybe even get drunk a little.

At some point, however, it starts to become something really important too.

Catra doesn't stress herself with it, Glimmer after all demands to be the one in charge of everything and she makes good use of it because Catra doesn't even notice something is going on until she is sitting in Mermista's shop alongside Adora's cheerful face choosing a

food menu for the day, with Bow and Glimmer making remarks at their sides. Catra makes their cake because Adora loves cake, especially Catra's lemon and salted cookies one. Catra blinks and suddenly there are blue and white paper lamps hanging from ropes on the streets and someone is talking about sweet smelling flowers that make her nose stuffy next to her, and somebody else is placing chairs and flower petals on the sand.

She blinks again and she sees a glimpse of Adora before Glimmer closes the door on her face, cradled in satine white and pearls, with her long sunlight hair curling below her waist and a pink smile on her face when she looks at Catra through the bedroom mirror, beaming as the bright blue sky outside. So, so beautiful it steals the breath from Catra's chest.

Catra blinks once more and sees herself this time, in front of the very same mirror, bright eyes and flushed cheeks. Someone has fixed her mother's dress for her, lace falling off her shoulders as dragonfly wings and the skirt pooling around her ankles in silk. The person standing on the reflection looks like a gardenia's bloom, soft veil sprinkled in stardust held to their short hair with the tiniest of golden pearls and so much like the siren's skin she guards on their home better than her own life. And she doesn't recognize herself but it's good. She likes this version of herself, this person that returns her gaze with bright eyes, this one who is happier and free and soft on all edges. Someone who is not scared, someone who is in love and is being loved back in return, in every single way possible that is to love.

She has flowers pinned on her hair and they match the colorful bouquet on Adora's hands when they stand one in front of the other. Peonies and blue bells and cotton blooms. They are both barefoot over the sand, the waves licking at their soles, blessing them too.

Catra repeats whatever Micah says as wedding vows, she doesn’t really remember what her mouth says. She is too busy getting lost in the silver lapis lazuli of Adora’s eyes, standing in front of her with the most tender of expressions, the corner of her eyes wrinkling when the biggest of smiles stretches on her pink lips. She has never looked more beautiful, except perhaps when she is swimming free and untamed on her sea or when she is sleeping curled around Catra's side or when she just woke up and she is a little bit lazy and a whole lot soft or every single minute of every single day. Doesn't matter, because Catra is in love with her and she cares for her and after so long thinking they wouldn't be able to stay together, they are here.

Adora signs her vows, mirrors of Catra's, hands expressive and elegant and excited. She is also saying the same words as Micah but her eyes are as honest and sweet as the night she pronounced them in their bedroom, as the night she asked Catra to marry her in the only way they were missing. Catra cleans Adora's eyes with her fingertips when tears make her sight blurry and Adora laughs, damp and breathless, and Catra laughs with her. And then they are married.

There are no new rings, they have their own, gentle thread around their skins, sturdy and strong after loving through so much – *but maybe, just maybe, in twenty years or so Adora will gift Catra another ring, opal and silver and seafoam. And maybe Catra will do the same, pearl and gold and sand, because they are completely attuned to each other. Halves of one soul*

Catra eats until she is hiccuping sugar and dances until her feet hurt. Swirls and spins and laughs the entire time, until her lungs hurt and her chest feels filled with gold. She dances with everybody and then with Adora only. Somebody brings popcorn and somebody else brings cotton candy ice cream, which is a wild success for Adora who eats the whole thing in one sitting.

Catra invites Spinerella and her wife, Netossa, and thanks her deeply for all her help when Catra couldn't even stand up from the floor, though they don't know that and Catra doesn´t say it either. Scorpia and Perfuma and even Entrapta come too – and they never leave because this place has something so intrinsically magical about it that it manages to enchant everyone in their own special way – and they spin Catra around and they adore Adora. And it is all that Catra can ask for.

Their party goes on until well into the early hours of the morning, until there are people napping on the chair or still dancing in the sand or chatting lighthearted as they sit on the port and dip their feet into the calm waters, beautiful under the pink morning light. Catra and Adora don't stay for all of it though. They go back to their home and walk hand in hand across their home, on the limit where the waves kiss the sand, watching the sunrise with matching smiles. They leave a trail of petals on their walk.

Inside their bedroom, washed by sunlight and the colors of the tinted windows over the floor, Adora strips Catra off her dress and makes love to her over blue bed sheets and feather pillows, whispering the same vows she had signed into Catra´s hair and neck. And Catra paints promises on the skin of her hands and the low of her back, blissfully happy.

They go to see the world after that. Away from the sea for the first time in Adora´s life but the sea breeze always accompanies them and Adora in a plane is a whole experience for both of them, but they make do. They visit beautiful and old villages, walk up endless stone stairs until Catra makes Adora carry her up all the way to the top and complain about museums and tourists. They dip their toes on the cold surfaces of lakes and hike up mountains until there is nothing around them but the infinite blue sky and the fresh air and the sun. They go down earth caverns – Catra hates it – and up the the roof of the tallest buildings – Adora hates it more – and have picnics on untouched meadows next to foreign seas – all the water seems to love Adora no matter where she goes.

Catra gets a new camera and takes photographs of everything, all of it, pilling inside her journal and her backpack, memories of a life she wants to guard with her entire heart, that she never wants to forget. As if this way she could keep these memories from fading away once their time has passed. What matters right now are the landscapes she prints on a small stationery placed next to a castle, and the instant polaroids tucked on her wallet of Adora´s bright and goofy smile as she feeds a giraffe, and the traditional revealed photography of both of them on their wedding day guarded inside the same bag where she guards Adora´s skin and that she brings with her everywhere.

Catra gathers all of these photos and starts placing them carefully inside an journal she got from an old store, of the hands of an old woman that reminded her so much like Razz it makes her head spin. She clips them to the thick pages with small clips and glues postcards and stamps and dry flowers she presses among the pages from every place she goes to. Adora

starts to draw, beautiful renditions of streets and precious and old buildings and rivers and mountains and sea and maps and Catra´s profile smiling on a coffee shop and Catra places them inside too. Adora writes Catra love letters, actually, tender, romantic love letters and learns them all by heart and then guards them among the very same pages of her journal. In a way, it feels like Catra is writing another kind of book, kinder, full of softness and happiness. A love story, her first one, her only one.

They go back home eventually and they have a perfectly beautiful life. Just like that, seven years pass them by.

The anniversary of the day Adora arrived at the shore, Catra is laying awake on her side, blinking slowly as a thousand thoughts run inside her mind. Adora is sleeping next to her, laying on her back. One of her arms is tightly wrapped around Catra´s waist keeping her close, the other one rests loosely next to her head. She is drooling a little bit and her nose wrinkles as it always does when she dreams. Her face is so relaxed like this, with the strong angles of her jaw and nose and soft curves of her cheeks and lips. There is a clear dimple on her cheek and almost invisible wrinkles on the corners of her eyes from years of laughter and Catra loves them all, from the mole next to her mouth to the silver scar crossing her eye.

Catra runs her fingers over the skin of Adora´s shoulder, dark golden after so many days under the sun, humming under her breath for a few minutes. Adora must feel the change in her breathing pattern because she stirs softly, lazily blinking awake and turning her face down towards Catra. A precious smile stretches on her lips, sweet and completely in love, the face of someone that has just woken up from tender dreams and is watching what they love and cherish the most in the entire world.

"Adora" Catra whispers between their skins, calling her completely from the dreamworld. Adora´s smile grows, lighthearted and winded.

"Hmm," it takes her a little bit to shake completely awake, soft minutes during which Catra draws circles over Adora´s collarbones. Adora giggles at the touch, looking at Catra´s face gently. “Hi, my love”

“Hey” Catra greets her back, wetting her bottom lip with her tongue as she gathers all of her bravery inside her heart, speaking the words she has meant to say for a little while now. "I– I want us to talk about a baby"

Adora is completely awake immediately. She exhales very slowly through her mouth, trying to quiet her speeding heartbeat, but the tender pink flush on her face is obvious and the scales that sprout as blooms on her temples and forehead give her away immediately, shimmering as stars in the golden darkness that still lingers inside the bedroom.

Adora searches for Catra's hand under the blankets, tangling their fingers tightly together, never once taking her sight away from Catra's eyes.

"Are you sure?" She is being careful, it's obvious, weighing her words in a way so they won't overwhelm Catra.

Catra can see this because she has known Adora for years that feel like a lifetime, because she is her soulmate and her mate and her lover and her wife. And the gentle yet completely excited expression that is shimmering inside Adora's eyes right now makes the last of her doubts melt into nothing. Because yes, she is sure, Catra *wants* this and she wants it *with* Adora, and Catra's heart, that is already huge with love, to swell so much more, making way for another kind of love, sweet and kind and *theirs*.

"We've talked about it before" Catra whispers, cheeks blushing pink. It was Adora who brought it up first, a little over eight months ago, hesitant and nervous. They had seen Scorpia and Perfuma taking their baby to her first day of preschool and it had clenched something inside Adora's chest even since then.

Adora had always known that she wanted to live everything life could give her by Catra's side. All of it, good and bad. All of what Catra would want to give her, Adora would cherish and protect always, for the rest of her life and until her last breath. They had lived such a wonderful happy life together those past few years that for a long time Adora didn't even think about a baby, about someone else that was a part of both of them. But then she had seen Catra silently kneeling to tie the undone shoelaces of Scorpia's kids and Adora just *knew*.

"I know," Adora moves closer to Catra, if that is even possible, until their noses are practically smoothed together, staring at each other's eyes with calm. "I want to take care of you, Catra, I want you to feel ready and good for it. I love you and I– I would be so happy to do that journey with you, really. But you need to know I will be just as happy even if you decided to never have kids. It would be alright. I'm here with you, for *you* . Everything else, *everyon* e else, is a gift. You're the only miracle I've ever wished for"

Catra gulps around the thick knot inside her throat, sniffling when tears start to gather on the corners of her eyes at Adora's words. She tries to ignore the throb inside her heart, curling a loose strand of Adora's hair around her finger. It's long, as long as Catra's is right now, a strand of sunlight on the palm of her hand. What would a baby be? The very sun, a shooting star nestling inside Catra's embrace, light and love and hope inside a tiny body, all of their memories and all of their lessons on life placed together to make someone happy.

"Honestly? I'm terrified, Adora" Catra chuckles, a little bit wet but honest. "I'm so scared. My mom- she died so young and I never had– what that woman did to me–" Catra's voice cuts short as she gathers her thoughts back. Adora waits patiently, singing sweetly against her ears. "I don't know how to be a mom, but– " Catra takes a breath "but I want to do it. With you. I want us to do it together. I want to love someone that is a part of us and I want them to be as happy as they deserve. I want that"

"I want that to" Adora's heart shivers and holds Catra with firm hands. There are spots of pink on her cheeks too and she also looks nervous but her voice is honey sweet when she speaks, words slipping into song. "I don't know how to be a mom either. I– you know Adam and I never knew our parents, not really. I can't even remember their faces anymore, just, just the hunt. But–"

Adora tangles on her own words, closing her eyes and breathing deeply a few times just like Catra and then her own therapist taught her how to do – the last one obviously doesn't know everything, just *enough* for her to make Adora understand that she also needed help working

through the thing that had happened to them. But it had been a good call because Adora *needed* it, she needed to accept, inside her heart and mind, that all that had happened wasn't her fault and that they were there, alive and safe. It helped.

"I'm ready to do it, too. I want to do it with you," Adora sniffles, her fin ears fluttering as they always do when Adora is feeling a lot. Catra has tl bite back a smile because she is sure Adora hasn't even noticed she has partially transformed in her hands. "We are going to spoil them rotten, aren't we?"

"I think we will," Catra agrees with a laugh. She doesn't even bother wiping off the warm tears falling off her cheeks. "Would that be so bad?"

"No. Not at all," Adora whispers, soft and tender, catching each sweet tear in Catra's face with her lips before leaning back. She is staring at Catra's face with a whole lot of mirth inside her bright blue eyes, wiggling her sea glass eyebrows in a cheeky expression, full of mirth. "Should we start now?"

Catra chuckles a snort, loud and unceremoniously, pushing Adora's face off her with her palm. "Dumbass"

"I have a good feeling about today." Adora mutters around a laugh, her cheek squished and flushed under Catra's touch.

"Oh yes? *Of course* you do"

"C'mere" Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist and spins her around, rolling on the warm blankets as they laugh in each other's mouths.

It is alright now. They are safe. Their home is safe, the town watches over them. They have been together for almost eight years - still such a short time for the amount of love they have for each other - They are wiser and have seen things beyond anybody's reach, together. It 's alright now.

The evening of Catra's thirty three birthday, a couple of months after their conversation and eight years after their first meeting at the sea, they find out. Adora realizes before Catra does.

They rise late that day and kiss for a long time after, still blissfully oblivious. Adora spends most of the late morning swimming on the sea, collecting pearls from the seafloor and tiny shells, knitting them together into a pretty bracelet for Catra's wrist. Catra stays home and prepares homemade pizza for both, happily kneading the dough and preparing the sauce as she sings along to the music coming from the radio. By the time Adora walks back home the sun is lower on the sky and Catra is wiping ingredients after a sudden urge for ice cream. The entire house smells like home.

Adora sits on the chair of the counter and hums with Catra, looking at her swaying her hips with the music from between her eyelashes and soft eyes. It isn't something Adora sees, something visible or too obvious. It is a shift, a change of something. Maybe Catra smells

sweeter, maybe she is softer around the edges. Maybe her cheeks are a little bit too rosy and her eyes are so much brighter and her smile devastatingly more tender.

Whatever it is, it tugs on the cords of Adora's heart and then expands it impossibly bigger, leaving her lighthearted and winded and absolutely completely enamored. Adora's breath hitches on her throat and she transforms, fluffing up like a popcorn under the sun, all scales and feathers on her face and sea glass and pearls. She is aware that she is weeping now but she can't avoid it, hiding her face between her scaled palms and sobbing silently.

" 'dora? What is it, mi amor?" Catra is in front of her in a heartbeat, wrapping her hands around Adora's wrists and lowering gently back down, resting her palms on Adora's cheeks to keep her close. Her face is soft but lined with worry, eyes shimmering when they lock with Adora's. "Why are you crying?"

Adora tries to speak but fails, hiccuping around a sob. She wraps her hands around Catra's waist and lets herself cry. It's a good cry, warm tears, open chest, flying heart.

Catra's eyes widen and her heart hesitates a beat inside her chest, flaring alive as her body and soul makes a home inside her body for someone else.

"Oh" Catra exhales, blinking tears too, quiet and honey like. "Oh, I see"

They wrap in each other's arms and cry together and welcome this new part of their souls into their lives.

The first three months go by like a stream of water, quick and fresh and sweet clean. They keep it quiet, just between them and their doctor at the town. And Melog, who becomes practically a locomotive by how strong they purr every time they curl around Catra's small belly when she naps.

Catra sleeps a lot those first few months. She curls over the bed, and the comfortable couch in front of the living room, and the loveseat next to the tintes windows and the swinging couch on the porch with the sea in front of her and the breeze on her long hair and sleeps, long and warm and without a single worry. When she doesn't sleep she walks around the house barefoot and full of happiness, cheerful as she steps over the mosaic and the wood. She gets a craving for sliced tomatoes and pistachio ice cream, often together. She sings all the time, loud and in tune, and when she doesn´t she is always laughing about everything, splashing droplets of water everywhere when Adora chases her playfully around the waves.

Adora watches her dance improvised steps with Melog on her arms and sees her become so *bright* . Brighter than the very sky. Glowing as the sun in the sky. There is a kind of light that surrounds her everywhere she goes, as if she was carrying a star inside her body, their light wrapping around her skin as Adora´s skin does for her. And Adora *adores* her, completely and devastatingly. She didn't know there was possibly a way for her heart and soul to love Catra more but there is and it is here and Adora is almost undone with the devotion that lives inside her body for Catra. Catra, who is beautiful and sweet and freely happy, who is carrying their baby, *their baby,* inside of her with grace and bravery and sweet love.

Adora hears the heartbeat of the baby for the first time the morning of the day they are to go for Catra´s next ultrasound, with her fine fin ear pressed next to Catra´s belly. It's a flutter, as swift as a butterfly wing and as strong as the waves of the sea crashing outside. Alive. She doesn't say anything but tears slip as crystals from the corner of her eyes as she hums a wordless song in her mother tongue, hoping it will reach the sleepy baby inside their mother's womb. Catra runs her nails through her golden and blue hair and doesn't try to hide her smile.

Adora loves her so much and she is absolutely protective of her, almost fiercely so. It's nothing new in Adora, ever since that night on the cliff, where neither Adora nor Catra dare still to step foot on. Adora follows Catra around as the shadows of the sun, wrapping her iridescent skin over her shoulders, carrying her around when she gets breathless and flushed and placing so many pillows everyone the entire house looks like a nest or a cloud fortress. Catra complains lightheartedly that she can walk perfectly good on her own and Adora ignores her, smothering her face in kisses and tickling her ribs and pressing her face and lips over the gentle curve that starts to appear on her belly, warm and tender.

Catra´s love is a lighthouse and Adora´s sea will always, always, wrap herself around her light.

By the fourth month they start telling people, who are all overwhelmed by joy. Glimmer and Bows basically demand to be the godparents because they love Catra and Adora deeply, so much they're basically a family already and they are going to love that baby just as much. Scorpia and Perfuma are overjoyed too and Scorpia cries and hugs Catra tightly but just gentle enough to not shake her too much. Entrapta offers to invent a tech pat to keep an eye on the baby crib, Angella and Micah embrace them for about half an hour, the town starts rolling presents again to their door and small knickers for the baby's arrival. It overwhelms Catra a little bit but Adora has her back and all is good.

And then Adora takes Catra to the sea. They buy a sailing boat, pick Melog, pack tightly and go into the open sea. Much to their friends' dismay. But it helps Catra, so much.

Catra complains about the morning sickness and the sea breeze tangling her long hair – brushing her waist on soft curls now – but she is calm, peaceful, sleeping most of the time or writing or humming lullabies and basking under the light of the sun. Slowly getting bigger, softer and more beautiful as the weeks go by.

At some point, it starts to draw down on her that she is actually, really pregnant. It's probably the first time she feels the baby kick, on a very early morning where the sun is perfectly warm and Catra is perfectly drowsy on the pillows placed on the ship's bow. Adora is wrapped around her like a six feet long octopus as Catra reads in silence, nuzzling her golden head against Catra's baby bump. She has gotten clinger too, much more protective, bare from head to toe as she touches every single patch of Catra's skin with hers. And she is singing that day, as she always does in the mornings when she greets their sleepy love, the fragment of a future approaching quickly and yet to come. It is then when Catra feels it, swift and determined and right against her kidney. And then another, right against Adora's cheek. It makes both of them hold their breath and then break into a fit of damp laughter, to which the baby just kicks again, doing their own loops inside their own kind of sea.

They visit all the ports around Etheria, eating ice cream with their feet dipped on the cool water next to the smooth stones of the shore and buying trinkets, mostly for the baby. Small stuffed toys and even smaller rompers and a mobile for the crib Angella gifted them before leaving.

Most of the time, though, they spend it at the sea. There, in the middle of calm waters so blue they rival the very sky. Where there are no other ships or towns and where the only things around them are the clouds and the sea world and the stars. It doesn't storm during the time they spend at the sea. The water keeps perfectly calm, sometimes just a fine drizzle that keeps the warmth at bay but nothing else.

The whales make their companions for a good while, swimming next to them and singing. Mother whale comes for most of the ride, singing loudly and sweet next to their ship, joyed when she understands what is happening. Sometimes other sea creatures come with her, fishes of all colors and shapes, stingrays and dolphins and seals and sharks and even jellyfishes – much to Adora's delight – all of them curious to take a glimpse to Catra and hear the rapid beating of her baby's heart and then to Adora's bright blue siren eyes and beaming shark smile. And Catra's heart swoons because she loves Mother Whale and she loves the fact that the entire ocean seems to already love their child, even before they had ever been born. Catra likes to sit on the edge of the ship and watch Mother whale and Adora swim and sing in loops around her. It makes her smile, and every day Catra smiles it is an omen for a wonderful life.

At night Adora strips off her skin and cradles Catra on their feather soft bed below the deck, making love to each other until they drift into sleep, sweet and caring and also full of all the passion and love that they have for each other that lives inside of them that has only gotten stronger with the pass of the years.

Catra starts writing a story, handwritten in one of her journals. This story is not for her, even though she already knows it by heart. It is for someone else that will still take some years to read it fully and as it should but that will be theirs. A tale of a siren and the human she had fallen in love with, and about the seafoam against sand and pebbles, and the morning star and all of its night siblings, and about flowers in the meadow of a cliff. It's the only love story Catra will ever write and that it will join with the rest of her journals, the memories of a life with the other half of her soul, a gift for each year of her child's life.

Near the seventh month, they have to go back home. Weirdly, Catra would happily spend the entire rest of her pregnancy at the sea, on their little boat with Melog – who is surprisingly good on open sea – and Adora and the breeze and silence around them. She is not afraid of water anymore. But neither Adora, who is increasingly more and more nervous and equally as excited, nor Glimmer and Bow, who somehow call almost every single day to know how Catra and the baby are doing even though there isn't supposed to be a signal on the sea, will let her.

Truth to be told, she is glad too in the end to be at home. She is not nervous or scared anymore. She was, at the beginning, but Adora has been with her every step of the way, every moment where it had been a little too much and Catra got overwhelmed and terrified she would do something wrong for their baby. There is nothing wrong, there is nothing to be

scared about this, this little gift of love. Catra doesn't even know them yet but she already loves them, all that they are and all that they'll decide to be, Catra loves them. Unconditionally.

And Adora, Adora has a *plan*. She has been talking with Catra's doctor every few days now, quick and avid signing that the doctor has answered with patience and care. Adora has read the books and seen the videos – and she even visited the maternity hospital in the town, much to Catra's mirth – and she has a plan. She knows what to do, what to get, who to call if things go south. She has planning charts all over the living room and the kitchen. She spent three hours putting together the nursery furniture while Catra smiled at her wrinkled concentrated face and rested her sore ankles on the loveseat of the room. Adora has baby proofed the entire house and painted the nursery's ceiling with sea life and placed the stuffed whales mobile above the crib. She has embraced and kissed and worshiped and cherished Catra so much she is sure her heart is living inside her warm body now and forever – it is, in a way, in the greatest of ways – She has sat on the shore of the sea and call for her brother and cry tender tears on his arms because she is so happy and so excited and she still can't believe they are here, that this is her life. No more endlessly void and dim purpose. They are here.

Adora is ready. Catra is ready.

Finn is born at home. It's just the two of them, Catra and Adora agree on it. Neither of them wanted to do this somewhere else, not even on the sea. This is their home.

It starts very early in the morning, when the sun is not even up in the sky yet. Catra wakes up and she feels it, a tug in the low of her belly, flaring white pain and then she is breathless. She gasps, once, and Adora is up and on her feet immediately, tumbling into the floor and then up again, disheveled and circling the room and speaking so fast her voice slips into a full song, nervous and on edge and so fucking excited even if they still have hours to go. Catra stares at her from her place on the pillows, gripping the sheets between her fingers and unable to fight the loopy and in love grin in her mouth.

They fix the bed and feed Melog, who rubs their little head against Catra's neck when her breath gets stuck in her throat, holding herself to the counter of the kitchen until her knuckles turn white. Adora tracks the contractions on Catra´s phone and has to clean her eyes from tears every once in a while. They call their doctor to let her know in case they need her, and then to Glimmer and Bow only and Catra threatens to punch Glimmer in the face when Glimmer also threatens to go down to their shore to see them. Family stuff.

Catra stands in front of the open kitchen's window, cradling her belly between gentle hands and breathing the fresh sea breeze slowly through her nose. She is aware that she is trembling from head to toe and that her cheeks are flushed bright red, her entire skin tingling as if a meteor was falling over her. Adora is there for her, she wraps her arms around Catra's chest, resting her palms over the round curve of her belly and breathes with her, practiced motions they know by heart now. Adora braids Catra's hair tight against her head and holds her own into a ponytail to keep it out of the way.

In the end, it's their bath that makes the marvel. Maybe it's because Catra has come so used to the water she feels something is missing if she is not around it, maybe it's because Adora is a siren, maybe it is because this has come to be an important place for them, who knows. Catra

sinks to the warm water and rests her forehead over the cool marble of the edge. She panics for a second, caressing her belly with trembling hands, suddenly scared of her baby leaving the safety that her body brings them and into this world and she gets scared for them, for not being able to protect them as she wants. But then Adora wraps her skin over Catra's bare shoulders and kneels next to her on the cold floor, holding her through it, brushing the sweaty bangs from her face and kissing on her red cheeks, filling the entire room and house with the sweetest of songs. Their baby will not only have Catra, they will have Adora too and Adora is a force of nature and she would destroy the world for them. Catra nor the baby are alone.

Catra sniffles, eyes misted when she turns to look at Adora's face, spots of red painting her cheeks and lips.

"Hey there, angel" Adora greets her, eyes teary too, song sweet as bells. Her body is also out of control, scales crawling over her temples and neck and down the length of her shoulders and arms. Her ears are fins and flopping with emotions every once in a while and her eyes are bright blue, piercing as stars, calming the rising chase of Catra's heart.

"Hey, dummmy," Catra whispers back, tiny and exhausted. She is so beautiful, so absolutely beautiful for Adora and for the entire world.

She looks so tired and her body is shaking but she carries it with a kind of grace that would make Adora tumble on her knees if she wasn't already kneeling in front of her love. A few errand curls have escaped from her braid and bounce gently against her forehead, silk soft. And her eyes are the brightest they have ever been, two beacons of light, golden and turquoise and starlights. Adora has never loved like this and yet she is about love even more. How is Adora's body supposed to hold it? Supposed to hold all of this devotion, that slips out of her like waves against the sand. Adora can hear the baby's heartbeat on her fine ears, synchronized to Catra's, to their mom's, to Adora's own heart and the waves outside.

“You're so brave. You're so strong, my love,” Adora is singing against her cheeks, cradling her warm face between her palms, running her thumbs over the corner of her eyes. “Listen to me, Catra. You are so beautiful, you're so– so holy for this world. You are doing something so amazing and so wonderful and I love you so much"

Catra chuckles around her own tears, wrapping her hand around Adora's neck, the other one holding her hand with an unbelievably strong grip. If Adora wasn't a siren, she would flinch by the fierce hold of it, and still she would bear it because Catra is doing all the hard parts and Adora will always lend herself for Catra to hold onto when she needs it the most.

"I love you too" Catra holds her breath, closing her eyes when another wave takes over her completely. Adora´s sea glass eyebrows scrunch in worry, leaning so she can kiss Catra´s whitened knuckles with gentle touch until she relaxes again against the edge of the tub.

“Are you alright?” Adora asks, tiny and hesitant. There is a pile of freshly clean towels on the table next to them, more warm water and the sterilized instruments the doctor had handed to them. Melog is curled up on the top of the towels, kneading the towels and meowing very softly every time another contraction rolls out.

"I can do this, I can" Catra gasps out, grinding her teeth.

"I know you can, my love.”

Catra nuzzles her face against the angle of Adora´s neck, breathing in the salted smell of her skin Adora tilts her face and places a kiss right above her ear. "Stay with me, okay? Stay with us"

"Of course yes. Always" Adora is not going anywhere, never again.

In the end it's easy, after everything, it's easy. Finn is born under the sunlight, with the breeze slipping inside the house and the sound of the waves outside their window. The ocean sings too, welcoming them to the world.

Adora takes them from Catra´s shaky hands and cleans them, wrapping them inside her skin. She runs the tip of her finger down their tiny nose and their forehead, and the peach nuzzle of light hair across their temples, gentle and loving. They are pink as a peach and as precious as their mother, the same button nose, the same round cheeks. They share their hair with Adora, golden strands that curl over their little ears. Finn is born and, everyone in the months to come will tell them it's not possible, not so young, but they smile, tiny, precious and happy. They have Adora's smile.

For a second there, as Catra cries against Adora´s shoulder when she climbs into the water to cradle both of them on her arms, Catra wishes Razz and her mom could be there, with them too. For a second, when the wind chimes outside jinglee and the breeze ruffles her hair, she thinks they are.

Adora wraps Finn tightly and then places them right back into Catra´s arms, helping her clean and dry and then reach the bed with the utmost care, mind in a haze. The world has suddenly imploded for Adora. All that made her universe suddenly is bigger, brighter, full of colors she hadn't even seen on the depths of the oceans, singing so loud and sweet it was as if the sole sound could carry Adora´s body and soul through life, held inside the tender whimpering of their newborn baby against Catra´s chest.

And then Adora's skin changes again, the blues and the goldens welcome a new shade, pink scales sprouting from them, mixing into their own dawn, opals that reflect the lilacs and tender pinks of the sky the hour Finnie was born, golden thread mirroring Finn´s sunlight hair crossing the everlasting scars that have been on the skin for years, stitching them together. She carries her family on her skin and on her soul and on her heart and Adora cries, she cries and cries, curled around Catra´s warmth, reassuring her sore body with tender touch and staring at the sleepy face of their baby, both of them quiet as the sea outside. Adora runs her fingers down Finn's tiny foot as Catra nurses them – gorgeous and beautiful and wonderful as an angel – and presses a loving kiss on their even tinier sole. Finn giggles, without a sound, and the entire world lights up with them.

"Hello, my baby, hey," Catra welcomes Finn with a sore and sweet whisper, placing gentle kisses on their forehead. She is crying, silent and soft. "We are your moms, darling. We are so happy to meet you"

"We love you so much, Finnie," Adora sings too, smiling through tears too. "You are so, so loved."

And then Finn sneezes out of nowhere, milk on the tip of their little nose, their little hands curled over the skin of Catra's breast and a sprout of lilac scales bloom on their temples and cheeks, soft as feathers that fall out right after and Catra and Adora fall in love all over again.

Adora is a gentle mother, tender, beauty she learned from Catra. The predator is undone again by such a beautiful and small creature, tiny inside her palms. She holds Finn in her arms with such care, cradling their head in the angle of her arm. Finn's hands are so tiny against Adora's hands, barely a whisper, even smaller fingers curling around one of hers, holding her close. She never stops holding them against her, over her chest and over her arms, cradling Catra when she feeds them, brushing their cheeks when they eat. She didn't know she could love more, after Catra. She didn't know there was enough space on her soul and her chest but it's so easy in the end. It is that same feeling that had always lived inside of her, for all those dozens and dozens of years and that had finally guided her to Catra. The feeling that Adora had always been waiting for them, this tiny creature, living long years just so she could see their precious face nestled in the loving hands of the love of her life.

While Finn is a newborn, Adora gets used to sitting in the rocking chain next to their crib the entire night, watching over their sleep. She wraps her iridescent skin around their tiny body — a merfolk habit aimed to keep the newborns warm and safe — her hand placed gently over their chest, feeling them breathe deeply through the night. First Ones used to abandon their children once they were old enough to eat on their own, in human time, probably equivalent to just a few months old. Adora doesn't leave Finn's side for a single second. Catra wakes up at some point of the night and finds Adora there, right next to the crib, eyes soft and tired as she hums Finn to sleep. And Catra smiles and climbs into the rocking chair too, curling around Adora´s side and her strong arms as they watch together at their tiny baby dream. Marveling at the fact that this tiny soul is a part of both of them and that they are so loved already, so much by so many people, and that they will never be alone or know war or pain. That this is the world their baby will get to grow into, with blue sky and golden sun and loving waves and the embrace of the sea and the love of their mothers.

Sometimes there are bad days, days when Finn can't stop crying no matter what and neither of them get to sleep and the sea gets a little bit of turmoil outside. On those days, Adora wraps Finn tightly against her chest with her skin and rocks them gently from side to side, rubbing their back with her hands, reassuring them gently. It is alright, after all. Finn is too small, too tender and too new to the world and they are learning to understand emotions. And emotions can be overwhelming. It's their job as moms to gently guide them through it. On days like that, Catra makes them hot cocoa and wraps her arms around Adora's waist, resting her cheek on her shoulder, exhausted but speaking to Finn softly, holding their tiny hand between her fingers, kissing their temples when they can't cry anymore and just whimper on their mom's hold, soft and heartbreaking. On days like that, sometimes, they go to the sea, walking together until the water reaches their waists, just deep enough so the waves lick the soles of Finn's feet, calming them down almost immediately.

Sometimes too, when Catra is dancing cheerfully around the living room with Finn, singing fairy tales for them and tickling at their ribs, Adora looks at her family. She sees their faces, so precious to her. Catra's vibrant eyes, the size of Finn's feet barely above Adora's palm. Sometimes, she sees them and the thought that she almost lost them, lost them both, hits her like a storm. And it hurts. Truth is, Adora was scared. She was happy, she was so *so* happy.

She had the greatest things she could have ever asked for. And that made her scared that someone would rip them away, that someone would find out what Adora was and that it would put Catra's and their baby's safety in danger.

But then, there are days where Catra and Adora bath Finn together, barely a few days old, in warm water and wrapped in a light blanket as they wash them together. Snd Finn will smile and rub their chubby hands over their face, where the gentlest fins sprouted on their ears under the touch of the water. And Finn giggles and Catra and Adora laugh too because they will have to teach them how to control them and because they flip like wings when Finn gets excited, just as Adora´s. And Adora knows they will be alright.

Healing is a process and it's not easy, but Catra is there. And Adora is there for Catra too, when her eyes mist over and she lays in bed until late hours of the morning, when memories get too heavy for her to move or wake up. When it hurts. And that's alright too, because they are together, and they are healing. Because they love each other enough to be weak and vulnerable with the other, to break a little on the seams and then pick up each other again, golden threads holding them stronger. They have already lived through the worst and the darkness and they have survived it. They have walked through fire and violent sea hand in hand and come on the other side. And on the other side was this, this life, this home. Finn.

What a blessing, what an honor, to have faced death and greed and to be able to cradle this in her hands and protect it and call it hers. Call herself theirs. Adora wouldn't change it for anything. Not for the ocean or the waves or the seafoam. Not for immortality. An angel that had once cursed her endless life renouncing her wings for the greatest form of love.

For something worth living for.



They are going sailing into deep waters again. It's the first time since Catra was pregnant, now that Finn is just a little bit older. They've missed the sea.

They are going to meet the whales on their journey and Finn will get to know another kind of godmother, less pink and sparkling but just as loving. And Finn will get to know their uncle too, who has been picking at Adora's nerves for months now because *this is his nibbling and he wants to meet them and show them what the real ocean is like, noty like you and all of those land creatures,* much to Catra's motherly snarl.

Who would have known Catra and Adam would get along so well, after so many years? The same acid humor and sharp banter. The same respect for the sea. The shared love for Adora. How wonderful, how lovingly frustrating for Adora who has become the object of their pranks.

Everything is packed and well placed inside their ship, clothes, toys and food and soft blankets. Melog is already curled inside their bed in the room under the deck, sleeping peacefully. Age is starting to take a toll on them now, but they are happy and they've lived a happy life and still have years to live by.

Adora is brushing her hair behind her ears in front of the mirror next to their bed, getting herself ready before they leave. She is wearing one of her sunday's dresses, white with golden straps on her shoulders, soft and comfortable. And she is characteristically barefoot, it's not like she needs shoes on the sand and much less on their sea. Her skin is over the bed, shimmering in kaleidoscopic rainbows and gently draped over the blankets by Catra before she went to help their baby get ready for the journey. Their laughter rings in the corridor outside the room, echoing as a jingle bell across the house, bright and beautiful and young.

Adora smiles, laughing softly under her breath, love flaring inside her chest as she absently runs her fingers across the long strands of her hair behind her ears and holds them back with a pearl pin. She smells a little bit like baby powder and lavenders and sea salt and Catra's lemon cake, soft over her skin.

The light of the sun falls suddenly over her hair and Adora goes still, staring at herself, her heartbeat suddenly lowering just to race impossibly stronger on her ribcage.

Adora raises her fingers and picks the thin strand of silver hair on her head, curled around her fingers when she pulls gently from it. It's so silver it almost looks bright white among the dark honey of her hair – long ago obscured by endless I beautiful days under the sun – and when she runs her fingernails eagerly behind her ear, under the sunlight pouring from the window, she can see it's not alone, strands like moonlight living in there, long and bouncing and soft. Carrying a thousand memories and the promise of more.

Adora's hand trembles and she holds her breath, looking back at herself with tender eyes.

After so many years, Adora is growing old

Old, actually old. With laughter wrinkles around her eyes and silver hair. Older alongside the years, immortal as she was and mortal as she chose to be, a plea answered. Older with the love of her life, with Catra. Catra who is her soul and her entire heart, who saved her in so many ways, so many she doesn't even get to understand yet. Catra and the baby they adore. Adora is going to get to see their baby grow up and she is going to get to grow old with Catra too, she will get to see her get older and more beautiful and tender and soft in a completely new way. And when the time comes she is going to die too, with her, many many years into the future and longer than anyone else, peaceful as waves washing over sand, graves of marble on the meadow of a cliff. Hand in hand with the love of her life as they start another kind of journey. Together. And meanwhile she will love her life, she will love every single second of it.

Growing old is a gift

"Adora?" Catra is standing in the open door, looking at Adora with soft eyes, her overall mustard colored and embroidered with daisies on the pockets. There are paint stains on the knees and legs from hours of playing with Finn, and her hair is held back with a red bandana around her head falling perfectly disheveled behind her back.

Finn is nestled in her shoulder and neck, cream colored romper and soft denim overall, with purple socks and a tiny sun hat. They are snuggling to their mom's curly hair as they look at Adora with tender baby eyes, blue bells as the flowers next to the window and as Adora's

silvered eyes, full of wonder and innocent love. They look at Adora and smile, all precious grins and baby giggles, whispering bubbly and lovingly as they stretch their tiny chubby hands towards Adora.

"Mammy," they babble and it sounds like a song. Adora stretches her hand immediately and holds Finnie's tiny fingers between hers, placing a swift kiss on their palm, winning giggles in return. Adora loves them so much.

Catra must feel something in Adora because she smiles, tiny and gentle, the same kind of smile she gave Adora that night at the shore, so many years ago. She extends her hand towards Adora, palm up, the rope ring in her finger as beautiful as the day Adora placed it there. "You coming, my love?"

Adora smiles back, tears gathering in the corner of her eyes without actually falling. Yes, she is going to cherish every single second of this life, drink off the light of it, wrap herself in her love. She extends her arm too and takes Catra's hand, fingers tangling together, always close, never separated. One soul.

The sun is bright and the sky blue and the sea sings. Sings. For the siren that had given up her immortality for the human she loves and the life that awaits for them.

The End

(...) I am full moon howl, I am ocean grief

(...) What a privilege it is to be a war ruined by love

To be battle ruined by grace

My quiet angel, my gentle surrender.

Do you know what emptiness you've killed just by existing?

– **Y.Z** , *You're all Honey and None of the Sting*

Chapter End Notes

This story is for all of those that ever felt lost. For those that lost their homes and those that found it again in peculiar ways. For those that are still searching. For those that are tired and worn out, those that ever felt life was empty. Those that are happy dancing barefoot on the kitchen. Those that are alone. Those that are brave and are broken and are whole. Those that found love those, those that lost it, those that are still waiting. Like

the sun.
It's for you. It's for me.
Thank you ~

And to the next, follow the light

Chapter Summary

... Catra and Adora ...

Chapter Notes

Anchor´s Book PDF is available for FREE now on my Ko-Fi [https://ko-fi.com/s/055b8a793a] !!!

Thank you so much for all the love, for all the patience and for loving my girls so much. I read every comment and bookmark, even if most times I don´t have the opportunity of answer, and I appreciate and adore every single one.

As it is our last time together here with our siren and her beloved, I want to give personal thanks to: Danae, GayPanicForCatra, itsalwaysrainy, nootnella, Lex_7312, randospopfan, Marlolcat_28, coldmushi, alittlerunaway, winterferrars, MPR0703, CanadianBear, Lisra, GayPanicAttack, turtleinahat, BeTheChange10, Cintilantestan, daisyisthehappiestflower, TaliSands, TackyEye, thorn45, imjustasadgirl, bluelizard1, nightsoul13, MedusaStoneGarden, dolphin 2013, SimplyAbsolute, Eviebebeevie, sapphic_moons, Evontelle, amphitrite_6 and every single person that liked, gave kudos, bookmarked, commented and for who this story meant something, anything at all. I hope the love of it accompanies you always.

With nothing else to say, I leave you with the end and the new beginning. Lots of love

See the end of the chapter for more notes

And to the next, follow the light

If I had a flower for every time, I thought of you...

I could walk through my garden forever

– Alfred Tennyson

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Catra is old. Properly old this time.

Her hair has long ago gone silver, bouncing just above her shoulders in everlasting curls, held back with the shell pin Adora gifted her in one of many birthdays. She knows she is old because her face has grown up with time, wrinkling on the corner of her eyes and the curve of her cheekbones, sweet testimonies of a happy life. Her hands are old too, elegant still but thinner.

Catra knows she is old because she knows she turned a hundred years old at some point, though she lost the count after that. She is only aware because Adora made a joke about both of them passing the century now and Catra pinched her in the ribs as if they were still newlyweds dancing across the streets of the old town.

She is also aware that she doesn't look her age. Elderly people over a hundred years old don´t look like her, with her face older but bright and soft as ever. With her back straight and her elegant steps intact after years of dancing and chasing the waves. With her mind clear and her memories intact.

For Catra, who didn't think she would've made it past her twenties, watching herself get old was incredible. A miracle. A small magic gift from the person she loves, cradled in her own kind of magic like the pearlescent scars that still live in her body.

Still, Catra is old.

She has seen Finn grow. From the little baby cradled against her chest, newborn and soft as a bloom; to the sweet and cheeky toddler that couldn't stay away from running among the waves of their home; to the beautiful teenager with eyes still bright for magic, full of the same curiosity for the world as their mother once had. To the precious adult, smart and free and happy.

Catra saw them be as happy as any child could be. She has seen them and their own family grow. Has met their partner and their children, and the children of their children. Grandchildren and great grandchildren even. Catra, who´s family died too fast, who grew up alone, who was always alone, suddenly and unexpectedly and beautifully had a family. A family to call hers. A family that started as two and that now used to fill the house next to the shore on holidays and every other happy memory. So big they had to get used to camping in the living room and add rooms to the second floor and the attic. A family.

She saw them just a few days ago. They were all here. They were here to say goodbye.

It wasn't a big party and neither a mourning reunion. They were here because Catra called for them because she knew. Somehow, she knew that this was it. The journey was coming to an end. And so, Catra held herself to Adora´s sweet hand and, together, they called for their family to say goodbye.

The house was filled with laughter. All the windows were open, sunlight and sea breeze coming inside as the sound of the waves embracing the shore outside. Children were running up and down the stairs; across the living room and the meadows and the shore outside; playing with the waves of a sea that had seen this family be born. Children of Catra and Adora. Children with dark hair and sunlight curls bouncing over their shoulders. Children

with turquoise and golden and silver-opal eyes. Children and younglings and adults, filled with magic, full of happiness. Free.

The shore was warm where the sun touched it, pebbles rolling over themselves polished by the salted water. That shore, that had seen so many things; that had seen rain and storm and tumultuous meetings and heartbreaking goodbyes; that had seen red fires and red nightmares long ago forgotten. That had seen happiness, undying and so big it couldn´t be contained, spilling free across their little spot in the world and the town and the very foundations of the earth.

There was food and music and dancing, so much dancing. In a way, it felt like a celebration all on its own. Catra got to embrace her family and embrace Adora and they were together. They kissed Finn's precious face, now wrinkled and wise too. And they knew their family would be alright.

They've seen friends leave too. It was hard but it was peaceful.

Melog, who lived to be forty years old and who was always by Catra and Adora and Finnie´s side; who was happy and content and helped foster other kittens for years; and maybe that magic that surrounded their entire family had rubbed off on their little old kitty after all. Mr and Mrs Thaymor and then Angella, who went first, and after Micah. Mermista and Seahawk, who everybody knew were going to end up getting married after all and now the *Sea Daughter XIV* is run by their twins and their children. Entrapta, who never had children but they helped open a university in the town that now carries their name on it. Scorpia and Perfuma, whose daughter married Finn and for which they were actually family after. The people of the bread shop and the market. Little by little, their places were taken by their own families. Kind too. Sweet and happy too.

Glimmer and Bow, their best friends. They went one after the other as love sometimes does. They were friends until the end, saw things together, celebrated and laughed next to each other. They were there the day after Finn was born; they carried them on their arms and sung them to sleep and caressed their little fin ears without saying a word. They were there on their first day of school and on sick days. Their grandchild married Finn and Flora's first child, of course, because they couldn't stop not being a family. Glimmer and Bow walked them to the altar and they met their first great grandchildren and then they were gone too.

Adora said goodbye to her brother. They embraced each other and braided the other's hairs; they whispered sea secrets and tender nicknames and remembered times together and apart. Adora is older, Adam remains the same. She asks him to look after her family and then he is gone too, to the ocean that he loves. Adora doesn't know when they'll see each other again, but she hopes he is happy, she hopes he lives and she hopes he remembers her as she is, a siren, his sister, that had finally found her place in the world when she fell in love with the sun.

Catra blinks and sighs tender years away, her reflection returning her own gaze through the mirror of their room. Catra runs her fingers behind her ears and takes off her earrings, leaving the dark pearls inside the box next to the vanity. She is wearing a dress, blue like Adora's eyes; not her wedding one that once had been her mother´s and later went to their grandchildren. Her hair is loose, falling in white loops over her shoulders and back. The

strand of sunlight hair still lives in her, born from the opal scars still etched on her face; mirrors of the rest that live in her body. With time, they have become part of her, a part of the love of her life living on her.

As always, she is barefoot.

The stained glass of the windows paint's shapes of colours on the floor. The windchimes outside sing about sea songs and quiet peace. The door of their room is open and, with it, comes the smell of sea salt and lavenders, soft steps over the wooden floor as Catra´s soul walks inside. Catra smiles, tender and soft, still looking through the mirror with gentle eyes.

"Hey, Adora," and Adora smiles too.

"Hello, my love"

Adora is beautiful, as beautiful as the first time Catra saw her. Her hair is still long and soft, but it has gone white. White as sand and as winter sunlight. There are wrinkles clear in the dimples of her mouth and in her eyes. Her hands are tired and old too. She is tall and graceful but full of wisdom. She has seen the world and lived, *lived.* Lived all that this wonderful world had to give; she has lived every second and every moment, drank from them and surrounded herself on their light.

She couldn't have known, that night she hid on the sharp rocks of what later would be her home, she couldn't have known all that she was meant to become. A siren, yes, a fairytale, a creature of the sea, but also so much more. She has become a friend, a wife, a mother, a grandmother even. She has become a dancer and a scholar and a guide. She has become a deity and a mortal, tender and happy; made of memories. They are embroidered in the marrow of her bones and in the pearls of her skin. She is old and she is beautiful.

Catra looks at Adora´s gentle eyes and her heart grows in size as it does every day she wakes up and lays eyes on her, warm and sleeping next to her. A every night where Adora swims on their sea, with the moon and the sand as company. As this very morning, when the sun made her golden. It is, after all, a perfectly beautiful day.

"It's time, isn't it?" Catra asks in a whisper, exhaling through the treacherous sting of warm tears in her eyes. She can't avoid them, she won´t, she loves this life *so much.* But Catra knows it is their time, she can feel herself fading away.

Adora must feel it too because her song is as gentle as it can possibly be, loving in all its edges, known to Catra as known are the stars and the waves. "Yes, my love"

Catra looks at herself one more time and then around her, at their bedroom. With the blue walls and the carefully made bed. With the open windows and the sound of seafoam and waves coming from outside. With the chandelier of blown out candles and their washed white furniture. With the sea by the window where Finnie´s music box used to be; where the photograph of the three of them, before Finn was even really here, still lingers inside its frame.

Finn knows what to do. Knows that they are to come in a few days and start checking the boxes labelled in the house. Knows about the marble gravestones on the cliff. Knows that they will not find anything else, no bodies and nobody else. Those will go to the sea, as it should, as it was always supposed to be. Those will fall among calm waters and rest over white sand and sea glasses like fallen stars and they will lay there, one next to the other, cradling each other on their last sleep. Always holding each other.

Instead, Finn will go through their mothers' belongings and they will find a book. There have been many books throughout Finn's life. Books of mystery, of terror, of adventures; even a single one of a love story, handwritten by their mother. A story said only in the most marvellous of fairy tales. A story about love and loyalty and tenderness. A story about them, about the two people Finn knowns better in the whole world, two people that taught them what was love.

This one book though, will be older, with the cover craved on the swirls and depths of the ocean and the lingering smell of a perfume that once belonged to their great grandmother, who Finn didn't get to know. The book Razz left for Catra once will be waiting for Finn too, next to the portrait in their room; a secret passed through generations and generations, known by all of them and so dear to the heart of their family. A secret of the siren that had fallen in love. And hopefully, no matter the time that passes, these stories will guide their family and will shelter them.

Catra is going to miss them so much, she hopes with all her heart to meet them again.

“Alright,” Catra turns in her ankles, walking the few steps that separate her from Adora. Her Adora. Her beautiful, beautiful Adora.

Adora, who takes her inside her arms, holding her in an embrace they know as well as the back of each other's hands. Adora, who hums a song like a lullaby and smiles against Catra´s hair, pressing kisses as butterflies on her temples. Adora, who loves Finn with her entire heart; who loves her grandchildren and her great grandchildren and her friends; who also loves this life so much too. Adora, who loves Catra so much more, who could follow her to the end of the world. Adora, who whispers against her ears, “Are you ready?”

Catra closes her eyes and nods against the angle of her neck, where her heart sings. “Yes. Yes, I think I am,” and then, with even a sweeter voice, she asks, “Stay with me?”

"Of course, yes," A promise, sweet as the rings that lay on their fingers, made of old rope and tender words. A promise, pressed in old lips that cradle each other in a kiss. A promise, made as it has always been done, held and protected and fulfilled. A promise, like their vows, made out of love. “Always”

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Little fishes tickle on the soles of Catra's feet, making her laugh.

She is sitting on the swollen wood of the port, perfectly calm. Her dress pulls around her thighs and waist, keeping it from soaking through as she dips her feet on the calm waves

below her. Seafoam crawls to her skin in gentle caresses, warm after a day under the golden sun. There are tiny seashells that hold the strands of her hair, embroidered with silver thread among bluebells and cotton blooms. The wind tangles on the loose curls that have managed to escape from the pins, brushing her jaw and chin where they came undone after hours of dancing.

She is beautiful, she *feels* beautiful. Glimmer was right, after everything, when she finally nagged her enough and managed to convince Catra to fulfil that old dumb but sweet rhyme.

… *Something old* … Catra's mother was beautiful and she loved her daughter deeply. From the moment she was born in that house next to the seashore, there wasn't a single day where her little baby wasn't loved. And Catra´s mom was gone too soon. Now, her mother's dress clings to Catra's body like a second skin, silk and gentle, embroidered in pearls and silver with soft lace falling off her shoulders; almost dawn pink under the light of the evening sun. In a way, it's an embrace. A caress from her mother walking beside her today.

… *Something new* ... Glimmer loved Catra the moment she was able to see her heart. Looking at her falling in love was a privilege; looking at her blooming like a rose, with pink cheeks and bright eyes and a perpetual smile, made Glimmer love her too. And she saw her in sorrow and saw her vulnerable and then saw her overcome pain and grow into this beautiful person and Glimmer thought that maybe life had sent her a sister after all. Neither of them knows yet that they'll be planning other parties in the future, together; for Glimmer and Bow, for their children, for their family. This morning though, Glimmer gifted her pearls earrings, dark and beautiful, and helped her clip them in her ears after doing her hair. Glimmer cried the entire time, softly and happy. Catra would be lying if she said she didn't cry too.

… *Something borrowed* ... After living on their manor for almost a year, Angella and Micah felt as if these were their children too. They had seen them as they were, fragile and vulnerable, stroked by tragedy as they set foot on their marble floors with feet stained by ashes and blood. They had seen them walking side by side through the gardens, hands laced together, quiet. They had seen them at three in the morning, one baking the other looking at her the entire time like she was her entire world – because she was – They had seen them, eyes lined in red; tired and worn out. But they also saw them bright as stars, they had seen them laughing and chasing each other; pulling pranks on each other and camping under blankets in the jasmine gardens. They became their children. And so, Angella clipped the winged pin Micah wore on their own wedding over Adora's cream dress, and Micah placed Angella’s old veil over Catra's head. They fulfilled their promise, to be there for them.

… *Something blue* ... Bow adores them with his entire heart the second he sees them together for the first time. It was easy, to Bow, knowing that this love he was seeing unfold in front of them was the kind of love that lives through ages; through time; through a thousand lives; forever. And his heart broke with them when they almost lost each other; and it broke again, in a better way, when they found their way back to the other again. Today he puts blue bells that match Adora's eyes on the flowers of her hair and walks Catra through the aisle and into Adora's hands.

... I think it's dumb, Sparkles ...

... I think it's sweet ... a hum, still unsure*... maybe it could be a way of carrying your family with you….*

... Oh ... Alright, then ...

There is music coming from the beach next to her. People are dancing across the white sand and smooth pebbles, illuminated by the paper lamps hanging over the venue. Laughter rises from the warm corners where tables have been decorated with sea seashells and blue candles in garlands of laurel; chattering and the echo of singing reaching Catra from where she is sitting, filling her chest with warmth.

She hears her arrive. How could she not, when the very sea seems to sing when she is near. She is barefoot and precious, flushed pink from where she was smiling and laughing until her ribcage hurt. Catra saw her dancing with Bow and Glimmer before coming to sit here, twirling around on their friends´ arms with happiness written all over her face.

"*Can I sit with you, my love?"* Adora signs, looking at Catra like one would look at the very dawn. Her eyes are hooded and her cheeks peach; hair like sunlight tousled everywhere, the little shells Adam has braided in her hair on the sea before the sun even came out twinkling with each other like little bells.

Catra's face splits into a grin, holding her arms up to embrace Adora inside of them. "Come here, princess"

Adora curls inside her arms, dipping her human legs into the water next to hers. The waves seem to shimmer a little at the touch, bioluminescent algae bright against their skins. Catra lingers a sweet kiss against her head, smiling next to Adora's pink ear.

"I love you" she whispers, softly and just between them. She can feel Adora smiling on the angle of her next, leaning back enough so she can sign in front of her.

"*I love you too,"* Adora's eyes roam towards the beach too, melting in the edges at the sight of the town and their friends, joy pouring out of every single one of them like a golden aura. *"Are you happy?"*

Catra feels herself loose and tender all over, running her thumb over the ring rope on Adora's finger. "Yes. I'm so happy Adora"

"*I'm glad."* Adora places a sweet kiss on the back of Catra's knuckles, nuzzling her nose against her forearm. *"Hey"*

"Yes?"

"We are married now"

Catra giggles, actually giggles, fluttering a sweet kiss on the corner of Adora's mouth. "We've been married for a while, dummy"

"*I know,"* Adora's cheeks paint in red, wiggling her eyebrows at her. *"But we are married the human way now"*

“Mmm,” Catra hums a low song, resting her cheek against Adora's, a tender siren kiss between both. “I'd marry you in every single way and life, ‘Dora”

They'll join their friends again in a moment, dance again a second later; laugh and joke and smile around until their sky blends into starry night and then back into lilac dawn. Their dresses will tangle on each other's legs and their hairs will come undone. There will be candies and sweet photographs that will last a lifetime, testimonies for a family that is yet to come.

For now, though, they hold onto each other, letting the flowers on their hair fall into the calm waters that had seen them fall in love with each other, tiny blooms of colour among the turquoise of the seafoam and the waves.

“Hey lovebirds!” Glimmer calls for them from the end of the port, waving her arm full of excitement. Her dress is lilac and full of sparkles in the skirt and she doesn't know it yet but Bow is going to ask her to marry him on the morning of tomorrow. Love brings some kind of magic with it, after all. Especially a kind of love like this. “Come here! I want to take a picture and Catra still owes me a dance!”

Catra rolls her eyes but she is smiling. Adora is smiling too, happiness shining on her like the sun shines on the sky. They hold each other's hands and stand up on the wood, splashing each other with seafoam playfully. Adora twirls Catra under her arm and dips her into a swift kiss, full of meaning and overjoyed laughter; tripping on their feet and caught on each other's skirts as they waltz endearingly clumsy on the port’s edge. And then they are hoping back into the sand to reach their family again.

The sea licks on their soles and waves them goodbye for now.

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Catra and Adora walk inside the water hand in hand.

The sky is pink and golden, scattered in clouds that almost look like cotton candy, rainbow rays scattering the sky from where the sun shines through. The waters are calm, waves like embraces washing over the shore, with its warm sand and shimmering pebbles.

The sharp stones at the edge have long ago gotten covered by moss where sea creatures like to linger around. The cliff is covered in flowers, evergreen grass and blooms of blue and pink and yellow and white, scattered like tapestries of nature; there is no fear or anger or sadness on this place, not anymore, not for a long time.

The house behind them is shell white, with blue wooden windows and the porch filled with wind chimes. Every window is coloured in stained glass, sea life on every corner from the whales to the seals to the hidden sirens giving twirls among the crystal waves. Inside, the fireplaces are quiet today but still warm from endless blue and golden fires. There are blankets folded over the soft couches, over the carpet and saved inside the hidden seats next to the window of the corridor. Dozens of books adorn the bookcases, with beautiful covers and golden letters. There are fruits in baskets inside the kitchen and containers filled with

honey and jelly, brought from their garden, always blooming and full of life. There are so many photographs, over the fireplaces and the walls and the corridors; pictures of a beautiful life and of the beautiful people that lived it. Upstairs, the huge bathroom is quiet, clean and in silence. The room of the east wind is closed, their baby long ago grown and happy. The attic is organized and filled with the light from the sunset, with reminders of their endless travels. Their room is tender, the bed done, the mirror uncovered, dresses in the closed and the windows open.

This house is filled with memories, cradled in love. Dances over the wood floors and caresses in the corners of stained glasses. Whispers of kisses and songs of love words, laughter and sorrow, love as much as it can be. It will live forever, just like them in a way, just like their love.

The water is warm when it touches Catra's skin, welcoming her back home. The day showers them in golden light, night will fall soon. Catra is not afraid, nor sad or nervous. She is calm, leaving footsteps on the sand behind her that get hidden away by the white seafoam and the tide. She can feel the way the tiny grain gives away below her soles, delivering her to the strength of the water holding her afloat.

Adora is beautiful in front of her. She has placed her skin over her head, a mirror of the veil she once wore on an ocean like this, on a white wedding that smelled like lavenders. Catra runs her old fingers over the soft skin, across pearls and golden coins and sea glass, and pinks and blues and golden and strings of silver and old healed scars. A comet, a fallen star shimmering inside her palms. She has lived such a long life around this skin, this skin that protects what she loves the most, this skin that saved her and adorned her own body in opal scars and feather scales. This skin that makes her love, her heart, her Adora, who she is, who she has always been. She is going to miss it too, with all her heart; yet she knows that, no matter what, this skin and this magic will always live inside Adora, in one way or another, and Catra will love it all the same.

The skin shivers and melts around Adora's frame, cradling her in colours. Soft wrinkled human skin changes into feathers and scales; fins as silk in her ears and neck and ribs that flutter at the touch of the breeze; rows of everlasting sharp teeth; white hair damp and floating among the waves like coral and sand; and a strong tail, long and wonderful like a sun of its own, wrapping Catra in safety among an ocean that loves them both. Her eyes shimmer and then change too, silver into bright blue, looking at Catra with so much tenderness and love she can feel her heart shivering under the touch of Adora's clawed hands.

She is old like this too, but not in the way mortals are. She is old in the way the world is old; in the way mountains are hundreds of thousands of years; in the way the tallest trees covered in moss are old; in the way the rivers with stone floors and seas with white sand are old. Old in a way the sky scattered in stars is old. She, who is maybe a deity and maybe an angel; who could bend the world inside her hands or rise the tide up to the sky or touch the sun with her bare palm; she, who could live forever yet has chosen to leave this world with Catra. She has chosen Catra. Old and infinite and beautiful, absolutely beautiful.

They love each other so much. How could they not, when they are halves of the same soul, halves of the same stardust.

Adora rests her palm over Catra's soft and frail cheek, stroking the skin under her forever bright eyes with tenderness. Adora loves her so much, with her entire life, and she loved this life so much too. She is going to miss it with every fibre of her body and skin and soul, but she knows that, no matter what and whatever that may come, it will also be beautiful because Catra will be there.

"I love you" Adora sings, resting her opal forehead against Catra's, skin against skin. Catra smiles around a tearful laugh and hums too, trailing kisses over Adora's cheeks and temples. “Thank you, for everything Cat.”

"I love you too," Catra sings back, lingering a kiss on feather gills, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck and holding her close. “I love you, Adora, so much.”

“You can sleep,” Adora whispers, running her claws and tender hands through Catra's curls, a caress so gentle it is a whisper, memorizing the feeling against her skin. “I’m here, my love. I'll be here when you wake up.”

Catra is feeling sleepy, so very sleepy. It's the kind of heaviness you have after you've lived a wonderful day that you never want to end, yet all of your bones and muscles and heart want some rest. The kind of sleepiness of somebody that lived a wonderful life, full of happiness and never stained by the horrors, and now they knows it's time to go to sleep into another kind of dream. It's the same kind of sleepiness Adora feels too, resting her cheek over the crown of Catra's head, carrying her among the waves as she has done for all the sweet and long years of their life. Catra can feel it in Adora's body because tears like pearls spill from her eyes and she feels happy, achingly happy with nothing but the blue ocean and the golden sky around them. Sun and sea embracing.

"Adora" Catra whispers against Adora's cheek, their last siren kiss.

"Catra" Adora sings back, bells like windchimes and lullabies.

These are the first words they ever said to each other, many lives ago, even if they don't remember it. When they were nothing but handfuls of sunlight among the expanse of the universe. And later, in a hundred more lives; among castles of white bricks and towns surrounded by forests and pink skies clustered in moons and stars; hand in hand no matter what.

There are so many memories on these waters, so many words and songs that were whispered in here. It will fill this little spot of the world with its magic forever.

Adora's song has started to drift off, shimmering still as a sun fallen on water, Catra wrapped inside her arms. And, for a moment there, Catra is bright too, from the siren skin living in her body as scars or for Adora's touch or for the love that lives inside them for each other. They have lived a wonderful life and they have never loved each other as much as they do now.

They are soft on each other's arms. Soft and old and ready. The ocean is calling them back home.

Together, they fall asleep and sink into the water. And then they are also gone.

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Adora has a baby in her arms.

They are asleep, they are so small. Small, small like a pearl's shell inside her palm. Small like a sea glass or a bloom in a meadow. Small like a star, infinite as the sky yet so tiny inside Adora's shivering arms. And they are beautiful, so beautiful.

They look like their mother, like Adora's heart. This baby, *their baby,* looks like the love of her life so much Adora's breath and heart skips a beat, overwhelmed with so much love. They are so wonderful, so beautiful, and who gave Adora the right to have this; this little creature that looks so much like their mother and so much like her too; a little soul to love and nurture and protect forever. Adora has a baby in her arms and she doesn't quite know what she did to deserve them, but she thanks them. Adora has a baby in her arms and they are sleeping and Adora is crying, and she can't stop trembling.

She is aware Catra is looking at them from her place on the bed next to her. She is tired and she is exquisite and she did so beautifully, so wonderful. Her hair is braided and long; her hands are elegant and still; her face is exhausted and peaceful. And Adora loves her with her entire heart. Adora, who has always known Catra is a miracle on earth. Adora, who saw her carry their little baby and then saw her bringing them to these worlds, land and sea, like magic all on its own.

Catra smiles and hums, a lullaby she has learned from Adora's mother tongue. She rests her open palm next to Adora's golden and blue scaled cheek and presses a lingering kiss on her jaw. She is gorgeous, a nymph stepping out of the very sun; and oh, how Adora adores her, all that she is and represents, all that she does; every single change in her body, every new line and wrinkle and patch and freckle. Adora loves her.

Adora cries because she wasn't supposed to have this, this little piece of sunlight that is half of Catra's soul and half of hers. She wasn't supposed to be able to swaddle them inside her pearl and sea glass skin and lean to press a kiss on their warm head. She wasn't supposed to hold their little fingers on her pinkie or rest their small palm inside of hers, so tiny it is barely there at all; so fragile and vulnerable and still pink as a peach after being born from their mother's safety. She wasn't supposed to be able to return them back inside the sweet embrace of the love of her life and curl her own body around them, holding them close to her chest. She wasn't supposed to be a mother, or a wife, or to be anything her heart wanted in a world where she was free.

Adora was supposed to wander across the ocean on her own; she was supposed to swim and float and hunt and never know anything else but endless darkness and void. She was supposed to be content with the thick weight of the water all around her, with the caverns and the floor of the ocean and never wish for anything else. She was supposed to be alone and to be eternal.

But she has seen the stars. She has seen the world and the sky and the sun. She has dipped her toes on the waters of this world and breathed from its air and, even if she wasn't supposed to

be here, she is. She was brought to this point, to this life, to be able to be everything she could and to be *happy*. Truly, absolutely happy and free.

“Te amo,” Adora sings in Catra's mother tongue, pressing her lips against their baby's temple. She can feel the way Catra starts crying above her, sweet and silent, resting her warm cheek over the crown of Adora's sunlight hair. Adora tangles their fingers together, resting her lips over the back of Catra's knuckles. She smells good, like lavenders and sea salt and their baby's skin on hers. “I love you.”

“I love you too,” and Catra's voice is tired but soft, running her fingers through Adora's silk hair as the latter watches their baby stir and yawn on her arms, blindly searching for Adora's warmth. “We love you, Adora, so much. We are together now,” and then, in an even sweeter voice, “Sleep, ‘Dora, I'll be here when you wake up.”

Adora smiles around a wet laugh, closing her eyes. Catra's heart drums like a hummingbird inside her chest and their newborn baby sleeps against Adora's collarbones. Whatever that may come, Adora accepts it with arms wide open. She's got such a beautiful life and she is happy.

They have the rest of their lives ahead of them.

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When Catra opens her eyes again, she is surrounded by light.

The sky above her head is pink; and lilac also; and blue. It is clustered in stars even though it's day time, bright and twinkling and beautiful. There is a moon shining in the sky, and a smaller one next to it, big and close. There are hills and meadows cradled in moss and flower blooms, so bright and colourful they look like watercolours. The sound of rivers reaches her where she is resting, crystalline water making its way on every crevice and corner. She is surrounded by tall grass, evergreen and fresh, dew sticking to her cheeks and hair. Everything is beautiful, so absolutely beautiful Catra's heart trembles inside her chest.

Catra doesn't know this place and yet it looks familiar to her. Familiar in a way that the sun is familiar to us, when we know we've lived our entire lives with its warmth and yet we don't remember the exact moment we learnt it was a star. She knows she hasn't been here in a long time but she doesn't feel nostalgic or sad. Instead, there is only peace inside her heart, quietness and tenderness all around her because, wherever she is right now, it is home. Golden like and welcoming her back.

Warmth spills like spoonful next to her, a softness that is different to the patch of moss she is huddled over. And it takes Catra a second to understand she is not alone here, that there is a second heartbeat right next to her, sleepy and also at peace. Catra looks down and her heart sings, staring at all the lovely angles and softness of Adora's face.

She is sleeping still, breath even and quiet. There is no fear or worry on her face, nothing but softness and tranquillity. She is young again, maybe even younger than the first time Catra saw her on their last journey together. Her hair is free, spilled in golden strands around her

head like a crown. Her cheeks are rose and peach and her lips slightly parted, breath sweet and warm. She is wearing a simple white dress, held to her shoulders in golden straps; and she is barefoot, soles stained by mud and grass. She still smells like sun and water tides but there are no sea glass scales of fins on her skin, not this time, and for a second Catra mourns them, even if she can't quite place her memory right now.

Catra knows she, herself, is different too. She can't quite remember how she is different but she knows she is in a way younger than she just was. Yet, she feels tender, filled with all the wisdom and loveliness of all her past lives. She is barefoot too, matching Adora and maybe they were chasing each other before tumbling asleep in the grass; maybe they were swimming in the bright rivers; maybe they were dancing, arms and lips tangled. Whatever it is, it was beautiful and Catra is content.

She curls herself tighter next to Adora's side and watches with sleepy but bright eyes as tiny sparks of light twinkle over Adora's nose, almost tickling her awake again. Adora huffs around a laugh and opens her eyes, lazily, wrinkling the fabric of Catra's dress between her hands as she holds her close.

Catra can't remember exactly what they were doing before falling asleep, can't phantom how long they've been drowsing off next to each other; but this body, Adora, this Catra knows better than anything else. She knows all the lines of her face and the smell of her skin; she knows the colour of her hair and the drum of her heart beating inside her chest. She knows the secret spot next to the curve of her collarbones; knows the mole that has made its home on her ribs; knows the veins of her hands and the hidden kiss in her lips. Catra knows her, all of her, everything she is and has been, all the brightness and darkness like an ocean of its own.

Catra can see the moment her silver eyes open completely, bright blue and lavender under this light, pupils widening as new moons when she takes on the beauty all around them just as Catra had done too. She can see the way light confusion and remembrance make their way over Adora's lovely face when she blinks slowly towards the pink starry sky. She feels Adora's hand tangle in the curls of her hair, thumb brushing absently against Catra's nape; a gentle reassurance for Adora, that Catra is actually there, with her.

Catra can see it, the way slow realization starts to settle inside Adora's bones, and then she can feel it too, falling over both of them like the sparks of light fluttering around them. It's always like this when they wake up here, in the first place that saw them fall in love. Because they know. They remember.

Adora wiggles on her place over the grass, blinking away warm tears that gather on the corner of her eyes and spill down her cheeks. If she lays very still, she thinks she can still feel the waves and the tide against their skin. She looks to her side, to Catra, who is already looking back patiently waiting for Adora to return back to her. Catra always remembers first and she is patient always, her light guiding Adora back home.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra greets her, smile bright. Adora's face splits like a sun. She raises her hand, the one that is not holding Catra against her chest, running the back of her knuckles against Catra's cheekbones in a gentle caress.

“Hello, my love,” her voice is hoarse, almost as if she hadn't talked in a long time even if it really has just been a second. But then again, it's always the same, between the here and the next, whispers that sound like a breeze. “I missed you”

“I missed you too,” and because Catra *remembers,* and because she was happy every single second of her life with Adora, she whispers back. “Thank you”

... For being here. For living with me. For staying. For everything ...

This is who they are and nothing could ever break them apart. They know they will rise, eventually, walk hand in hand across the meadows and alongside the edges of rivers, staring at stars Adora had hung up from the sky in another time and whispering to each other about kind times. And, who knows? If they walk far enough, maybe, they´ll even find a house next to a shore, a house with blue windows and windchimes by the door, chasing each other among pebbles and waves. A memory of a place where they were the happiest.

This memory, those reminiscences of all these lives, will always live here on this patch of a starry heaven they have made for themselves. In a place that they deserve. And they know that, when they are ready once more, they'll start again. Because there has never been a bigger privilege than falling in love with each other over and over again.

… I can't wait to meet you again ...

… Just don't take so long this time, alright? …

For now, they remain as they just were. A mortal and a siren and everything in between.

Catra and Adora.

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“You´re safe now, you are going to be alright,” Catra closes her own eyes tightly, nestling the siren´s head further on her neck. “Nothing is going to hurt you here.”

“I´m going to get you home, Adora”

“I promise”

… How long would you wait for me?

How long have I been away? …

… Whatever here that's left of me is yours just as it was.

– *As It Was*, **Hozier**

Chapter End Notes

Thank you :)

Extras

Hello! This is Ginny speaking.

Just a heads up for all the lovers of this story and might still be interested that I will be posting short stories post canon events

You can find them inside the series "The sea and the sun" or simply clicking in the box description into "Next story"

Thank you so much for your support these years it means the world to me. I hope to see you in the other stories too :)

End Notes

Hope you like it! Comments, kudos and bookmarks are always deeply appreciated it.

See you next chapter!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!